Indirect Light

Extracted from *Polar Inertia*

Paul Virilio

> Light is the name of the shadow of the living light.
>
> Bernard de Clairvaux

I STILL REMEMBER MY astonishment, ten years ago, when I saw video screens replacing mirrors on Paris Metro platforms.

Soon after 1968, it is true, surveillance cameras had appeared at the entrances to the *grandes écoles* and universities, and this new equipment was also used to keep watch on the boulevards and major junctions of the capital.[1] Today, I am astonished once again when I see the lens of a micro-camera rising above the keypad that gives coded access to a block of flats. Evidently entry phones are no longer enough to do the job of the old concierges.

As an electro-optical substitute, *videoscopy* seems to come into its own with this role of indirectly lighting a domestic environment for which electric light, a direct form analogous to daylight, is no longer sufficient. Rapid miniaturization is indeed making the video camera and its monitor more and more akin to a *warning light* that comes on to let us see who is here or who is there.

Even the old 35 mm cine-camera has had its eyepiece viewfinder replaced to advantage with a screen that actually displays the recorded images.

How can one fail to see here the essential characteristic of video technology: not a more or less up-to-the-minute 'representation' of an event, but *live presentation of a place* or an electro-optical environment – the result, it would seem, of *putting reality on waves* by means of electro-magnetic physics?

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It is logical, then, to find here not any performance space, any 'screening room', but only a *control room*.

In furnishing the image of a place, videography does not itself require any 'space' except for its supporting camera and monitor, themselves integrated – or dissolved, as it were – into other equipment having nothing to do with 'artistic' televisual or cinematic representation.

Just as one is not bothered by the dials and lights on a car dashboard or by the lighting in a shop window, so one is not really troubled by the 'broadcasting' or 'diffusion' area of a video camera. That area is solely *what is lit up*, and not the 'theatre' or site of a cinema performance screened at some distant location.

So great is the difference between video observation, cinema and television that the TV set has itself been overtaken through the incorporation of monitors into the most ordinary domestic equipment – for example, the 'electro-optical porter' that makes people visible as the entry phone only made them audible.

The whole debate on the crisis of cinemas, on the miniaturization of public film theatres, will no doubt soon be repeated in relation to private homes and the 'living room', where the TV set is still often located. For the emancipation of the screen will involve not only its sudden expansion into the giant open-air Jumbotron or Olympic stadium screen, but also its *compression* into a scattered array of ordinary objects unconnected with televisual performance or information.

Who still cares about the electrical wires in domestic appliances? Who tomorrow will care about the optical fibres built into commonly used materials or equipment?

Alongside the *broadcasting* of current political or artistic events, video 'illuminates' us about phenomena instantaneously *transmitted* across varying distances and thus becomes itself a new type of tele-topographic 'site' or location. (Is there not already talk of 'neighbourhood television'?) Just as Edison's invention of the electric light-bulb caused daytime places to appear at night, the new electro-optical lamp causes places to become visible amid generally invisible surroundings. As the site of the non-site of instantaneous transmission (at varying distances), it effects a kind of commutation of perceptible appearances similar to that which occurs in para-optic perception and quite unrelated to ordinary mass-media communication.[2]

Thus, alongside the well-known effects of 'telescopy' and 'microscopy', which have revolutionized our perception of the world since the 17th century, it will not be long before the repercussions of 'videoscopy' make themselves felt through the constitution of an instantaneous, interactive 'space–time' that has nothing in common with the topographical space of geographical or even simply geometrical distance.

Whereas theatrical or cinematic *mise en scène* involves the spatio-temporal organization of stage action or film narrative in an area used for public performances, and whereas, to a lesser degree, production for

television requires a private stage or broadcasting area (the rooms of a private home), this no longer applies to video transmission. For 'cine-videography' solely consists in the *commutation* of more or less distant and disjointed appearances, and also in the commutation of interactive actors at varying distances. Commutation of the emission and reception of the video signal, at the monitoring terminal, indicates the *mutation-commutation* of distances (topology) into *power* (tele-topology), that is, into light energy as the union of relativist cinema and wave optics.

The present crisis of cinemas is not therefore mainly due to an increase in domestic film-viewing; rather, it expresses a crisis in the idea of representation linked to rapid spread of the 'live' dimension. The live 'real-time' spectacle is a result of the development of videoscopy, not only in people's homes, but here, there and everywhere, in the very body of the various pieces of equipment in which it began to be incorporated nearly twenty years ago. (The most striking example is the weaving of optical fibres into composite materials.) The crisis, then, is a crisis of *delayed* broadcasting as such, so that electro-optical imaging techniques now impose the idea – or, to be more precise, the 'ideography' – of a veritable presentation of places and milieux, a 'presentation' which corresponds, on a human scale, to what telescopic presentation meant for astronomy or microscopic presentation for the innermost properties of materials.

Video is no more the eighth art than cinema was the seventh. The crisis affecting cinema box-office, rival TV channels but also what is called art video stems from the fact that, ever since the beginnings of photography and cinema, as well as of radio and television, the showing of *events* or entertainments has been more important than *the lighting up of the places* where they happen. Notwithstanding Edison, Marey, the Lumière Brothers, Vertov and a few others, the fun of the fair nearly always took priority over illumination (and did so more than ever with the coming of television), but the appearance of an *active optics* has suddenly replaced the feats of passive optics (of glass and other transparent lens material) in the organization of perceptible reality. This startling new *presence of tele-reality* transforms the nature of both the object and the subject of traditional representation, so that *pictures of places have now taken over from the 'picture houses'* where performances used to occur. Only the theatre, thanks to its unity of time and place, still escapes the transmutations of electro-optical lighting whose immediacy excludes 'unity of place' for the sole benefit of 'unity of time', albeit of a *real time* which seriously affects the space of real things.

In fact, alongside the 'radio-activity' of emission and reception, with its 'electro-acoustic high fidelity', there is now what might be called the 'opto-activity' of videoscopic commutation, with all the problems of 'electro-optical high definition' that this implies.

When there is talk in Toulouse and elsewhere of the imminent introduction of neighbourhood television (*télé locale*), people do not realize that they are

borrowing a term from videoscopy or, in the case of a cabled city, from a 'videography' that allows the town to *see itself* and to *make itself visible* – that is, to become its own 'production', its own film.

The city of Rennes, for example, has a plan for 'electronic public lighting' to boost the political and economic existence of the urban area – hence the requirement for a municipal tele-noticeboard and the inevitable telesales that will replace the local press with one huge cathode shop-window. But is this not already how things are with the more limited proximity of objects and places in our everyday environment, with the Metro video terminals, the company's closed-circuit television, or the shops that are able to see the faces of window-gazers? And that is nothing compared with 'wall-socket' cameras and 'light-bulb' monitors built into ordinary objects, much as the microphone and loudspeaker were earlier incorporated into alarm-clock, tape recorder or Walkman, or the digital displays of quartz watches were implanted into pen tops, cigarette lighters and all manner of other objects. In the realm of videoscopic display, however, commutation is different. 'Geographically close' television and 'geometrically close' video are *parasitic* upon clear perception of the here and now: they interpenetrate and interchange places *teletopologically*, thanks to sudden 'live' revelation of the 'space-speed' at present supplanting the space–time of our ordinary activities. Merging with para-optical illumination, the upper speed limit of live transmission defines itself as indirect lighting at the speed of the video signal.

It is often claimed in the West that miniaturization, like giant screens, is a Japanese gadget. But this is not true. What is happening in image physics is also happening in astrophysics, where the Hubble space telescope is soon to come into operation with *adaptive optics*, that is, with image correction that depends on the computer's capacity and not just on the properties of the lens.

Screen and picture size therefore have nothing to do with it; the dimensions of the object are no longer what counts. For now the cathode screen displays *spatial distance that changes before our eyes into luminous energy, into illumination power.*

As a new kind of distance – the 'light (zero sign) of the new physics'[3] – suddenly takes the place of the customary distances of time (positive sign) and space (negative sign), every surface of whatever size has an objective existence only in and through the interface of an observation which, instead of just being the visible result of direct solar or electric lighting, is due to indirect lighting by the radio-electrical field of a Hertzian system or an optical fibre cable.

What we see for the *maximal surface* of the globe subjected to constant scrutiny by military, meteorological and other satellites is also true for the *minimal surfaces* of objects and places subjected to the intense lighting of videoscopy. In fact, a mysterious 'tele-bridge' is established between an ever-growing number of surfaces, from the largest to the most minute, in a kind of sound-and-image feedback which triggers for us observers a

(video-geographical or video-geometrical) 'tele-presence' or 'tele-reality' essentially expressed by the concept of real time.

What Einstein's 'point of view theory' taught us in 1905 about the relativity of extension and duration – that is, the inseparable face-to-face meeting of observer and observed surfaces, a relativist interface without which extension has no objective dimension – is *visibly* confirmed by instantaneous video feedback in which the electro-optical environment wins out over the classical 'ecological' environment. A kind of 'electronic meteorology' thereby asserts itself without which the meteorology of the earth's atmosphere would soon become incomprehensible. At a time when the major US television channels ABC, CBS and NBC are faring worse and worse, Ted Turner's live news channel, CNN, is planning a 'News Hound' service for a million subscribers with video equipment. 'That's a million opportunities for us,' Earl Casey, the man in charge of this future interactive system, said recently, '*a million witnesses able to provide us with pictures*; all we'll have to do is select.'

In the military sphere, eminently strategic research into *stealth* aircraft points in the same direction. While a complex environment of electromagnetic detection is established at global level, active research is being pursued into ways of escaping 'radio-electrical sight' through special new materials such as the PBZ super-polymer, which is said to be capable of avoiding detection by radar waves. At the same time, however, aeronautical producers are asked to embed in the same material optical fibres capable of sounding, or permanently illuminating, the dense cells and organs driving the combat aircraft.

For the philosopher Schopenhauer, the world was its representation. For the 'video-maker' or electronics expert, we may say, matter is becoming its presentation – direct and external 'presentation' and, at the same time, internal and indirect presentation, the object or instrument becoming not only present to the naked eye but remotely present or '*tele-present*'.

This *physical non-separability* of outside and inside, near and distant, is also exemplified by the road-haulage industry and by the development of 'star' publicity. Thus the American Geostar company, and soon its European counterpart Locstar, are due in the near future to place the first piece of their 'Radio Determination Satellite Service' in orbit. Thanks to this surveillance system, the headquarters of a haulage company will know at any moment the geographical position of each of its vehicles, a geo-stationary navigation satellite enabling it to monitor and control movements. We can see why the magazine *Match* has just had its logo drawn in the Chott Djerid (dear to Bill Viola) of central Tunisia, suddenly turning the desert into a kind of screen, as all the continental and oceanic surfaces have become for the gaze of orbiting satellites.

But this ceaseless *rapprochement* of above and below would not be complete if, after the nadir, we left out the zenith – that is, the minor miracle of high-orbit billposting which is Coca-Cola's plan to leave its indelible mark on our nightly firmament.[4]

Once again we notice the decline of the sites of representation and projection. Theatre, stage or screen become simply *the sky and the ground*, all the surfaces from the smallest to the largest that are exposed, nay, *overexposed*, to the inquisitive gaze of automatic instant-relay cameras – surfaces or, more exactly, 'interfaces' which have objective existence only as a result of videoscopic examination by live-relay recording material. *This 'real-time' tele-reality is supplanting the reality of the real-space presence* of objects and places, now overridden by electro-magnetic paths.

For Einstein, what distinguished a correct theory from a wrong theory was only the length of time for which it remained valid: a few years or decades for the former, a few moments or days for the latter. Is it not perhaps the same with the duration of images, with the difference between the 'real-time' and the 'delayed-time' image?

In the end, the whole problem of 'tele-reality' (or 'tele-presence', if that seems preferable) hinges on this same question of the validity of a short duration; the real value of the *object* or *subject* instantaneously present at a distance entirely depends upon the *passage*, that is, the speed, of its image, the speed of light of contemporary electro-optics. It is the same with 'remote' or 'tele' action, thanks to the capacity for instantaneous interaction in telemetry. The *opto-activity* of the online image is similar to the *radio-activity* of a device that handles objects at a distance (remote-controlled vehicles, transfer machines, various kinds of instrument).[5]

This advent of the real 'passage' to the detriment of the real object and subject – a phenomenon so indicative of the primacy of image over thing resulting from the new supremacy of real time over real space – clearly reveals the wave character of reality. For the sudden *commutation of perceptible appearances* is ultimately only the herald of a general derealization resulting from the new illumination of perceptible reality – a reality not just 'apparent' as before, but 'transparent' or, to be even more precise, *trans-apparent*.

There is a fusion/confusion of transmitted appearances and immediate appearances, with indirect lighting capable of soon supplanting direct lighting – not only, of course, artificial electric lighting but above all natural lighting, with the revolutionary changes in perception that this implies. The advent of passage as instantaneous and ubiquitous is thus the advent of *time light*, the intensive time of electro-optics which is supplanting for ever traditional passive optics.

We can bet, though, that the status of reality will not long resist this sudden illumination of places, happenings and events. For while improvements in the *spatial* definition of optical camera lenses have made it easier to see contrasts and increased the luminosity of the habitual image, recent improvements in the *temporal* definition of filming and electronic transmission procedures have increased the clarity and resolution of videoscopic images. Thus, audiovisual speed primarily helps us to see and to hear, or, in

other words, *to move forward in the light of real time*, as automobile speed helped us to move forward in the real space of an area of land.

The greater 'transparency' of high-speed communications (TGV, supersonic aircraft, etc.) is thus compounded by the sudden (electro-optical and acoustic) trans-appearance of the means of information and telecommunication. High fidelity and high image definition serve greatly to modify the nature of the (acoustic or visual) relief, which in the end comes down to the greater or lesser reality of the things perceived, a spatio-temporal relief conditioning our apprehension of the world and of present time. Since the eye interprets any change in luminous intensity as a change in form, the light (direct or indirect, natural or artificial) produces not only the colour of objects and places but also their relief. Hence the importance of research into high definition of the image, definition at once spatial and temporal of a video signal capable of achieving for visual space what high fidelity of the radio signal has already done for the stereophony of sound volumes: *a veritable stereo-optics integrated into the domestic environment.*

Thus, just as star-filming techniques continually improve the image resolution of remote detection satellites, so the constant improvement of TV picture definition increases not the electrical transparency of the local environment (as at the beginning of the century, with the electrification of town and country), but the *electro-optical trans-appearance* of the *global* environment. This means the emergence of a new kind of 'relief' or audio-visual volume applying to the totality of transmitted appearances, a 'stereo-videoscopy' whose significance at macroscopic level is similar to that of the sudden breakthrough of electron microscopy in disclosing the infinitely small. In order to see, one is no longer content to dispel the shadows of surrounding darkness; the commutation of appearances can also remove the obstacle of extension, the opacity of great distance, thanks to ruthlessly penetrative videoscopic equipment that is analogous to the most powerful of floodlights. As the electro-optical *faux jour* of indirect public lighting dawns, as the real is put on air as the figurative, a new artificial light now complements electric lighting in much the same way that electric lighting once filled in for daylight.

At 1.32 p.m. local time, on 26 October 1987, a Titan-34D rocket launched a KH11 satellite from Vandenberg air base in California. *From its polar orbit covering the whole planet*, this satellite is able, at any moment of its ceaseless electronic scanning, to zoom in, spin round and transmit pictures in the form of electronic impulses. The average life of this military light is 36 months.

The invention of cinema can no more be separated from the invention of searchlights than it can from that of snapshot photography. Did not Thomas Edison, inventor of the incandescent lamp in 1879, work on the kinetograph a few years later? As to Louis Lumière, at the Universal Exhibition of 1900 the French Navy lent him its most powerful searchlight to project his films on a large screen, in the famous Gallery of Machines. And in 1948, shortly

before his death, the pioneer of the cinema was still working to improve lighthouses for the Navy.

Today, the projection of wide film on to planetarium domes is only possible with a 15 kW xenon lamp initially designed to illuminate NASA's rocket-launching sites.

Finally, in 1969 when the astronauts returned from the Apollo XI lunar mission, the President of the USA ordered all the coastal cities to be lit up, as ordinary lampposts are lit up in the evening along marine boulevards. This was meant as a homage not only to the conquerors of the moon but also to the sudden power of public lighting to reveal man's presence to the farthest reaches of the atmosphere.

If one thinks of the illumination of theatres and palace festivities in the age of Louis XIV or the introduction of electric street lighting at the end of the last century, it is clear that the history of public spectacle has been inseparable from the history of light – from fireworks through the diorama of Daguerre (a decorator at the Paris Opera and the Ambigu Comique) to the *son et lumière* displays of recent times. The birth of the cinema was itself inseparable from the development of artificial light, the famous 'arc lamps' being necessary both for the shooting of films in studios and for their screening in public theatres.

The other revealing aspect of this sudden extension of transparency has more to do with police requirements, for lighting makes the streets safer and so prolongs the time for commercial enrichment. Already in 1667, long before the days of video surveillance, Police Lieutenant La Reynie issued a famous ordinance that led to Paris's world reputation as the *ville lumière*. Then came the electrification of town and country in the early 20th century, an undertaking rather like the present laying of cable to carry video along optical fibres throughout the big conglomerations. But now the shift concerns the very nature of the light, which is no longer just artificial but *indirect*, differing from direct light as much as candlelight once did from the light of the stars.

We should also mention here the *light-intensification* camera (or binoculars) currently used by the Army to see in the middle of the night over considerable distances. Often replacing infrared systems, this 'low-light television' amplifies the surrounding light, however weak, by nearly a hundred thousand times. In a way it is similar to a particle accelerator. Consisting of a tube placed in a powerful and continuous electrical field, the film camera has successive levels of photon acceleration which increase accordingly the luminosity of the final image; the accelerated light particles strike a screen with a phosphorus film at the other end of the tube, causing each particle of the film to glow. Lately this kind of indirect lighting equipment has started to be used by the German and British police, especially for football stadium surveillance.

In fact, where the *real time* of live television broadcasting prevails over the real space of a land actually crossed, the mere distinction between natural and artificial light is no longer enough; one has to add the difference

in kind between *direct light*, natural or artificial, and *indirect light*, for electro-optical lighting now replaces electrical lighting as the latter once did the rising of the day.

And this is while we wait for the active optics of computer graphics to achieve its next feat: that is, the coupling of the passive optics of cameras with a computer capable of rectifying the transmitted image as only glass lenses used to do. *Digital optics* will then succeed analogue optics, as the latter once cleverly complemented the ocular optics of the human gaze.

As the image is the most sophisticated form of information, it is logical to expect that advances in computing will also end in the deployment of this indirect light: *digital light* this time, capable of piercing reality's shadows and of most realistically conveying an unknown transparency, such as fractal geometry already makes possible, with digital zoom effects that are nothing other than computer-generated *synthetic lighting*. The passages and their 'trans-appearance' signal the innermost constituents of the form-image, *shape of that which has no shape, image of that which has no image* (Lao-Tse) – a figure for the dynamic of emptiness, similar to the void of sub-atomic physics for which Oriental thought long ago paved the way.

But let us return to the city, the 'light-city' that has been home to all historical illuminations from the Fire of Rome through the pyrotechnics of the Age of Enlightenment to the laser displays of recent times. Since illumination is synonymous with the unveiling of a 'scene', with revelation of a transparency without which appearances would be nothing, only a narrow conception could still talk of light simply in terms of the lighting of places. For how can one fail to see, behind those dazzling electro-optical displays, that the public image is on the way to replacing public space, and that the political stage will not be able to do without indirect lighting, any more than it has been able to do without direct artificial lighting? With its origins in the city-theatre organized around the public spectacle of agora, forum or parvis, then in the *cinecittà* of Western modernity, the contemporary *'telecittà'* today establishes the *commutation of perceptible appearances* through the feats of satellites, Hertzian networks and optical fibre cables. In its respective time, each of these 'urban representations' has known how to use the spectacle of transparency, of public illumination, to develop its culture and collective imagination.

An exceptional situation may serve to illustrate this point. In the spring of 1989, between May and June, Beijing students decided to demonstrate for 'democracy'. They gathered and gradually took over Tiananmen Square, not setting any time limit to their occupation – an old practice which goes back, not to the sit-ins of the 1960s (as some have suggested), but to the Greek City where the public space of the agora was the guarantee of the citizens' political unity against the threat of a tyrant.

At the time of Gorbachev's arrival on 14 May, they numbered three hundred thousand, and three days later a million. Profiting from the fact that most of the international agencies had sent their cameras and reporters, and

even such top editorial writers as Dan Rather, to cover the reconciliation of the two Communist giants, the Chinese students demanded live coverage of the Tiananmen events so that pictures of the country's most famous public square should be broadcast not only to the world but, above all, to Shanghai, Canton and everywhere else in China.

This demand was rejected by the authorities, and the eventual introduction of martial law was accompanied by a massacre of the population of Beijing by the tanks of the People's Liberation Army. What had already happened in Czechoslovakia after the Prague Spring, or in Poland with the decree establishing an 'internal state of war', was now being reproduced in Asia. The people's army was crushing the people.

But let us return to the 'illumination' of these events by the world's press agencies. Aware that the presence of fifteen hundred journalists in Beijing was of extreme political importance, the students repeatedly showed signs of collusion with their far-off TV 'viewers' by writing banners in French or English, by deploying exotic symbols such as the 'statue of liberty' beneath the portrait of Mao Tse-tung, or by making frequent references to the French Revolution. Formerly, the surface of the agora or the parade ground of a garrison town corresponded to the 'surface area' of the men under arms: citizen-soldiers in Ancient democracy or enlisted troops of fortified towns. 'March separately, strike together': this infantry maxim also fitted the gathering of citizens on the public square; the adjoining streets enabled them to fly to where the public power was identified with the crowd united in the face of external aggression or civil war.

Curiously enough, with the public image of Tiananmen Square broadcast all over the world, we saw both an infinite extension of that surface area (thanks to the real-time interface of the television screen) and a miniaturization of it in the shape of a 51 cm cathode screen that did not seriously convey any depth of field. Hence the importance of the fact that in Hong Kong during that crucial period, not only private television but *the giant screen in the city stadium* was used to unite people collectively with what was taking place at the heart of the Chinese capital.

This was a kind of 'teletopia'[6] in which real-time continuity made up for the absence of real-space contiguity. For a time, the stadium and giant screen in Hong Kong became inseparable from Tiananmen Square, as the square already was from millions of television viewers around the world. However much the forbidden city may ban it, things at one end of the earth are made visible, accessible, at the other end, thanks to the energy of a *living light*, at once electro-optical and acoustic, whose effects on society will be incomparably more important than those of electrification were more than half a century ago.

Real time, delayed time, two times, two 'movements'. On 15 May 1989, the students gathered on Tiananmen Square demanded *live* news coverage – a fruitless effort on their part.

After the tragic events of 7 June in Beijing, Chinese television constantly broadcast *recorded* material, shot by automatic police surveillance

cameras, of certain excesses against isolated vehicles and soldiers – always without showing the peaceful occupation of the square or the massacre of its occupants by the People's Republic of China. The choice of image or, to be more precise, the *time* of the image chosen determined China's current political reality – as if, in the end, the country's vast expanse and the huge numbers living in it counted for less than the instant in time chosen to speak of it, to show what was really happening there; as if the real time and real space of the Tiananmen events disturbed the Chinese leaders so much that they had to temper its effects through a *replay*.

It is a strange politics when public images shown with calculated delay are supposed to staunch the disastrous consequences, as the ramparts of the public space and the laws of the city used to block the threat of subversion or aggression. Not only is the day and hour of *concrete* action chosen as before; now there is a decision to obscure the immediate event *temporally and temporarily*, while the actors, the students on Tiananmen Square, are subjected to physical repression.

The events may well be described as a 'siege', a new kind of 'state of siege': not so much an army encirclement of city-space as a *temporal siege*, a siege of the real time of public information. The key element is no longer the familiar censorship preventing disclosure of things that the state wishes to keep secret; it is *the replaying of recorded material*, the retarded ignition of the living light of events.

This 'war over real time' finally shows how right Louis-Ferdinand Céline was at the end of his life, when he said in disillusion: 'For the moment only the facts count, and not even they for very long.'

That moment has now passed, in China as in the wider world: what is done can be undone by means of interactive telecommunications; a 'tele-topian' reality has the upper hand over the topical reality of the event. On 9 June 1989, Chinese television solemnly announced that the Army would fire without warning upon anyone carrying a camera or other photographic device.

The mutation currently under way is confirmed by another, final aspect: namely the crisis of the household car or, more precisely, its symbolic decline to the advantage of other objects, more eccentric vehicles. 'The car will be the last of your worries' – a slogan placed above the Ford stand at the Paris motor show in 1988 – was a wonderful illustration of this process. For it is a decline which, as always, adorns itself with a maximum of useless accessories, rather as the event itself changed its name to the 'World Motor Show'.

In fact, what is really global today is live television; a particular car, whether for sport or transport, is never more than a local object. This explains the recent success of the all-weather vehicle, the famous 4 × 4 which tries to escape the rut of the beaten track. It is an eccentric trial indeed – an attempt to leave the way, the motorway, at any cost.

As we have seen, the image is now the only high-performance vehicle,

the real-time image which is supplanting the space where the car still moves from one place to another. In the end, the crisis of the household car is rather like the crisis of the neighbourhood cinema. How many of those dark halls found themselves turned into garages or service-stations, before these in turn became supermarkets or, more recently still, recording studios or newspaper headquarters!

As Fellini put it a short time ago: 'I no longer travel, I only have fits of moving around.' For as fever or energy occupies and possesses us, we no longer dwell in the motive energy of any 'means of transport' – hence the major risk posed by the various 'speed' drugs.

The cinema, Alfred Hitchcock used to say, is armchairs with people inside. Even if the saloon-car bucket seats are for the moment less empty than the cinema armchairs, we should not have any illusions. How much longer will we accept the tedium of the motorway journey?

In Japan television has already invaded taxis and high-rise lifts. Just as dogs are banned from garden squares, cars no longer enter pedestrian zones in some central areas; they go into exile on Paris's ring boulevard while awaiting completion of the super-ring boulevard, or the ultra-rapid underground laser system in which cars will think they are the Metro.

How to make a journey without actually moving from one place to another? How to vibrate in unison? These questions should soon lead to different means of transport and transmission, quite unrelated to the domestic contraption that still serves us today.

Let us look more closely. We no longer turn a switch on our radio or television set; we touch a control or press a key on our remote-control pad. Even our quartz watches have a digital display instead of hands that move around.

'This will replace that', wrote old Victor Hugo referring to book and cathedral. Will it not be the same tomorrow with screen and limousine? Until when will we *really* keep moving from place to place?

Was it not again the Japanese who recently invented the *bo-do-kahn*, a vibrating pillow that allows you to listen rhythmically to a Walkman? Even the rising sun no longer casts its moving rays upon Japanese apartments bathed in sunlight by optical fibre.

Moreover, the people in charge tell us that in the Osaka conurbation, with a population of twenty million, cable networks are already being implanted beneath the motorways so that images can travel through the cars' subsoil. Listen to the Formula One world champion Alain Prost: 'Real speed is to approach obstacles with the impression that you are moving in a slow-motion film.' And the former rally-driver Bernard Darniche stated soon after retiring from competition: 'For me, the ideal car is a mobile video-control.'

Why try to hide it? The only way of saving the private car is to fit it with a temporal video-image compressor: a *turbo-compressor of the real-time image*.

The talking car that warns drivers of engine trouble is a mistake, once

road simulators for motoring schools are on sale for a hundred thousand francs (the price of a new vehicle). What is needed is a car that actually sees other vehicles *over the horizon*, so that car speed and audiovisual speed are rendered compatible. Maybe the Prometheus project that unites twelve European companies within the framework of Eureka is actually working on such an idea. After all, the 'travel pilot' devised by the Blaupunkt corporation is already just an obsolete guidance system, given that electronic chips of less than one micron will soon each contain the equivalent of the whole US road network.

At a time when a single videodisc can depict all the different journeys in a town – Aspen, Colorado, as it happens – how can there not be attempts to give motoring a new 'perspective' in which the temporal depth of the electronic image prevails over the spatial depth of the motorway network?

Recent advertising for the Thomson washing-machine described this household object as a 'washing-computer'. So how can one fail to grasp that tomorrow's transport machine will first of all be a 'driving-computer' in which the audiovisual feats of the electronic dashboard will prevail over the optical qualities of the field beyond the windscreen?

Just as parachute exercises are moving more and more in the direction of 'relative flight', so will car travel develop from a means of absolute physical transport to a means of 'relative transport' associated with instantaneous transmission, the kinematic energy of the video-computer image advantageously replacing the kinetic energy of engine capacity.

As higher speeds progressively disentitle all others, the TGV and the ultrasonic aeroplane will not change anything. The *time-reducing machine* is no longer the motor-car but audiovisual and real-time technologies.

A few years ago, the Cartier Foundation for Contemporary Art exhibited a superb collection of Ferraris, a veritable symposium of coupés, saloons and convertibles. But this luxury display in the Jouy-en-Josas park merely illustrated the evolution of 'aerodynamics', a science as antiquated in the age of computer-assisted design and driving as the aesthetics of old antique furniture has long since been.

Translated by Patrick Camiller

Notes

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1. Symbolically enough, this electronic surveillance system is operated from the basements of the Paris City Hall.

2. See Jules Romain, *La Vision extra-rétinienne et le sens paroptique*, Paris: Gallimard, 1964.

3. See Gilles Cohen-Tannoudji and Michel Spiro, *La Matière-espace-temps*, Paris: Fayard, 1986.

4. A harbinger of such eccentricity appeared in the 1930s with the sudden surge of aerial advertising. 'Skywriting' was then quite a common practice.

5. On 19 October 1987, the computerized Wall Street crash gave us a preview of the negative effects of that instantaneous link-up of financial markets which is commonly known as the Big Bang.

6. See in this connection the plan for 'decentralization of the capital of Europe' which I submitted to the Élysée Palace on 14 July 1988.

Virilio and Architecture

Neil Leach

A GROWING NUMBER OF philosophers and cultural theorists of the 20th century have turned their attention to aesthetic questions, and to architectural issues in particular. It is as though there has been an aesthetic turn which parallels and echoes the earlier literary turn. Among these theorists, Paul Virilio stands out as the one who has engaged most comprehensively with the world of architecture. An artist by background and a self-styled urbanist, he has consistently colonized the space of architecture as a platform from which to develop his cultural theory.

Virilio's interest in architecture even led to his involvement in an architectural practice. In 1963 Virilio formed the 'Architecture Principe' group with Claude Parent. The two remained partners until they fell out over differences of opinion on the events of May 1968, in which Virilio took an active part. In the reforms following those events, Virilio became involved with teaching, and in 1972 was appointed co-director (alongside Anatol Kopp) of the École Spéciale d'Architecture in Paris.

Virilio continues to explore architectural ideas, but the focus of his research has now shifted. His research concerns may be divided into two distinct phases. Virilio's early interests lay in questions of space, and his more recent interests relate to the problem of time. It is a shift which he himself describes as being from 'typology' to 'dromology'. With this shift Virilio has gone on to pursue more abstract theoretical enquiries, and to interrogate the way in which we perceive the environment around us. Yet, while this more recent work resists a concrete engagement with architectural form, it always circles around the question of space and spatiality, and remains highly relevant to architecture. This article will attempt to offer an overview of Virilio's engagement with the world of architecture, acknowledging the positive contribution that he has made to that realm, but also exposing the negative aspects of his work.

One of the problems in assessing Virilio's work is that he often comes

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across as a somewhat inconsistent thinker. It is difficult to construct any unified position out of Virilio's thought and, by extension, equally difficult to assess its contribution. Indeed, one of the perverse questions that seems to arise from the work of Virilio, no less that that of Fredric Jameson and Jean Baudrillard, is that it always appears to be double-edged. Even when he appears as an outspoken critic around certain issues, he displays a marked fascination with those issues, which seems to betray an underlying interest in precisely what he is criticizing. His criticism always threatens to falter, and to fold into some form of acquiescent support.

One way to explain this might be to surmise that he has been seduced by his prey, as Baudrillard has suggested is typical of theorists in general through the analogy of Sophie Calle and her *Suite Vénitienne* (1988). Theorists are prone to become trapped by that which they are themselves attempting to stalk. Alternatively one might recognize that every intellectual position is defined by what it is not, and that the positive bears the imprint of the negative. A critical outlook will therefore often reveal the trace of its own repressed other. With Virilio, it is almost as though there is something he recognizes within himself which he wishes to suppress, and which he therefore projects on to some external object in order to criticize it. At certain strategic moments, then, it is profitable to read Virilio against Virilio as a theorist *for* rather than *against* what he is critiquing. This, at any rate, is the strategy adopted here. But it is clear that, however the double-edged nature of Virilio's position might be explained, the inconsistencies in his thought ensure that any attempt to offer an overview of his work must be compromised, and can only constitute a provisional undertaking.

Phase One: Virilio and Typology

The first phase of Virilio's research – his interest in typology – was centred around two principal projects, his archaeological work on wartime bunkers on the Atlantic coast, which was published in *Bunker Archeology* (1975) and his theoretical work on the function of the 'oblique', which was published mainly in the journal *Architecture Principe* (Virilio and Parent, 1996), which he had co-founded with Parent. Virilio was also directly involved in the design process, and co-designed a building with Parent, the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay in Nevers, which, with its bunker-like forms and tilted floors, to some extent fuses these two interests (Virilio, 1996).

Bunker Archeology reads as a very personal exploration of the physical remains of the German Atlantic fortifications abandoned after the Second World War. Virilio had been brought up during the war. Life could not have been easy for a young boy in occupied France, especially one whose surname betrayed an obvious connection with 'fascist' Italy. If the war left a deep impression on Virilio, such that war and the weaponry of war echo throughout his work like some sort of constant refrain, the physical traces of war in the form of these all too concrete remains constitute an architectural version of this obsession. In *Bunker Archeology* Virilio presents an archaeological survey of these forms. Alongside his own exquisite photographs of

these bunkers, he includes drawings, documents and his own written reflections. It is the photographs, however, that catch one's attention. These are hauntingly sublime images of the now silent relics of war, set against the natural beauty of the Atlantic coast. And it is clear that their sublime beauty has captivated Virilio. He quotes Rainer Maria Rilke: 'The beautiful is just the first degree of the terrible' (Virilio, 1975: 139). It is here that we can begin to recognize an obsession with the sublime taking root, an obsession which, we shall see, will emerge as the Achilles' heel of Virilio's thought.

In *Bunker Archeology* there is a curious echo of Le Corbusier. In Virilio's textured images of these massive concrete forms, with their crude imprints from the wooden shuttering, one senses a fascination that parallels Le Corbusier's passion for *baton brut*, the conscious use of these imprints, that became a form of architectural signature. And if the great grain elevators of the American Midwest inspired Le Corbusier in his architectural design, so these pure, functional forms with their simple aesthetic, disappearing into the dunes, seemed to have fired the imagination of Virilio. Certainly, one can see the influence of these forms in the church at Nevers.

Through the 'theory of the oblique', meanwhile, Virilio explored the possibility of a non-orthogonal architecture. In this he rejected the two fundamental principles of Euclidean space, the horizontal and the vertical, and argued for a third alternative, the 'oblique'. His approach was based on Gestalt theory and the phenomenology of perception of Maurice Merleau-Ponty. Space was to be experienced not through the perception of the eyes, but through the movement of the body exploring new modes of habitation suggested by the possibilities of the oblique. In effect Virilio harnessed the work of Merleau-Ponty for a new dynamic model of dwelling. Whereas in traditional building there had been a split between dynamic zones of circulation and static areas of dwelling, Virilio sought to fuse the two to create circulation as a form of dwelling. This was underpinned by a concern to develop forms which would promote a sense of disequilibrium and instability. As he explains:

> The objective of our research was to challenge outright the *anthropometric precepts of the classical era* – the idea that the body is an essentially static entity with an essentially static proprioception – in order to bring the human habitat into a dynamic age of the body in movement. In our work, the *traditional stability* (habitable stasis) of both the rural horizontal order and the urban vertical order gave way to the Metastability of the human body in motion, in tune with the rhythms of life. (Virilio, 1996: 13)

This challenging of a static anthropometric approach to architecture reflected a broader questioning of the social order at a cultural level. Virilio recognized that there had been a change in humanity, 'a metamorphosis of consciousness', and the function of the oblique was to respond to the 'new plane of human consciousness'. In this there are echoes of the Situationist

position, which looked for an architecture to fire the imagination and allowed for a richer ontological experience that broke free of the reified relationships of the society of the spectacle. Indeed, the forms of Virilio and Parent do not differ widely from those of Situationist-inspired architects. Prominent among these was the Dutch architect, Constant, whose New Babylon projects, although not fully embraced by the movement, remained the most comprehensive attempt to translate the Situationists' ideals into architectural forms (Andreotti and Costa, 1996). In these projects Constant pursued themes such as 'disorientation' and 'dynamic space'. Anxious to avoid the limitations of the static spaces of utilitarian society, he promoted the concept of the 'dynamic labyrinth', one that accepted that the liberation of behaviour requires a labyrinthine space, but one which allowed that space to be continually subject to modification, according to the 'ludic' imagination. While Virilio's work on the oblique allowed little scope for modification, he clearly shared a common concern with Constant for the principle of 'dynamic space'.

The theory of the oblique has also been considered influential in the origins of the architectural movement that has been termed 'deconstruction' or 'deconstructivism'. In challenging the authority of ideas such as stability and vertical equilibrium, and by introducing the unstable and the oblique, Virilio's work resonates with that of later architects, such as Bernard Tschumi, who likewise challenged the hegemony of concepts such as rectilinearity, order, symmetry and compositional hierarchy, some of the basic tenets of traditional architectural aesthetics. Tschumi has been concerned to establish a new architecture for a new age. It is, perhaps, in the displaced, fragmented, angular forms of Tschumi's pavilions at the Parc de la Villette in Paris, and in the tilted ground plane of his video pavilion in Groningen, Holland, that we find the logical inheritance of Virilio's ideas.

Phase Two: Virilio and Dromology

With time, however, Virilio himself began to realize the limitations of his theory. Oblique forms were difficult to build and impractical to use. Moreover, Virilio's design collaboration with Parent had come to an end. Increasingly Virilio became preoccupied with more abstract questions of time. His interests began to shift from spatial considerations to spatio-temporal ones. Out of a theory of movement through architecture there began to emerge a theory of architecture in an age of movement. The focus of his research changed from typology to 'dromology', which he defines as 'the study and analysis of the impact of increasing speed of transport and communications on the development of land-use' (Virilio, 1996: 13).

Virilio's interest in dromology can be traced through a number of publications, of which *Speed and Politics* offers the most direct engagement with the subject (1986). Here, Virilio analyses the effect of speed within the contemporary city, which is read as a machine whose streets act as channels for rapid communications. Through these veins of the city course the 'dromomaniacs', the mobile revolutionaries of the modern age. These

dromomaniacs – from *sans culottes* to brown-shirts – reveal how speed is the essence of political change. Beyond this they offer a model for change on an international scale through the medium of war. Modern warfare, Virilio notes, with its emphasis on mobility and surprise, depends on speed. Not only this, but speed becomes an issue of propaganda: 'Speed is the hope of the West, it is speed that supports the armies' morale' (Virilio, 1986: 55). *Speed and Politics* amounts to a panegyric of speed and the possibilities which it affords, written with a certain Futuristic fervour.

Similar themes underpin Virilio's more recent publications, but it is in *Lost Dimension* that Virilio addresses these questions within a more obviously architectural framework (1991). Here Virilio offers a number of takes on a similar theme, the consequences of the collapse of the significance of spatial distance within an era of considerable technological advances. Again speed becomes the key theme, whether it is the speed of instantaneous information transfer or the speed of ballistic missile capabilities. Virilio explores the consequences of this in the context of domestic, urban, national and international scenarios.

From an architectural perspective, one of the key ideas to emerge out of this later work has been that of the erosion of the hegemony of the physical, or, as Virilio calls it, the 'exhaustion' of the physical. Virilio questions whether or not we now exist in a condition of 'post-architecture', whereby the way in which we engage with traditional constraints imposed by architectural elements such as walls has shifted as a result of advances in technology. Emblematic of this has been the change in how the city is entered. It is no longer the port or the railway station, but the airport that is the chief entry to the city. With that the importance of city gates as the symbolic entrance to the city has been replaced by invisible forms of control embodied in electronic surveillance systems. Virilio's message is clear enough. Physical constraints, such as city walls, have been superseded by other, more sophisticated methods of control. This has a marked impact upon the urban. Not only has the development of new technologies reduced the need for physical proximity and therefore precipitated a process of de-urbanization, but these technologies have challenged the very necessity of physical presence. Once personal interaction can be displaced into the realm of the virtual, all that is associated with the world of the physical loses its hegemony. This is the point at which the urban begins to wane, and the post-urban takes over.

Moreover, advances in informational systems and transportational networks have had a significant impact on traditional modes of perception. And it is by engaging with these shifts that Virilio, who is above all a theorist of speed and time, has made so many penetrating observations. For it is by observing how the acceleration of various operations and, in particular, the development of systems of instantaneous information transfer, have come to distort our conception of time, that Virilio highlights the influence of these developments on our perceptions of place. In an age when the window of the cathode ray tube comes to displace the actual window of

the physical enclosure as the site of immediate and instantaneous information transfer, we find ourselves in a location without a location:

> Thanks to satellites, the cathode-ray window brings to each viewer the light of another day and the presence of the antipodal place. If space is that which keeps everything from occupying the same place, this abrupt confinement brings everything precisely to that 'place', that location that has no location. The exhaustion of physical, or natural relief and of temporal distances telescopes all localization and all position. As with live televised events, the places have become interchangeable at will. (Virilio, 1997: 385)

This 'instantaneity of ubiquity' further challenges the hegemony of physical space. We must now understand the world not in terms of spatial dimensions, but in terms of spatio/temporal dimensions: 'Speed distance obliterates the notion of physical dimension' (Virilio, 1997: 385) It is no longer a question of how far away a place is. Now it is simply a question of how long it takes to reach it. With the advent of supersonic transportation, for example, it can take less time to cross the Atlantic by plane than to traverse a single European city by foot. Physical distance gives way to temporal distance as 'the loss of material space leads to the government of nothing but time' (Virilio, 1997: 385).

Evaluating Virilio

What, then, is the significance of Virilio's contribution to a debate about architecture? The significance of his early work is easy enough to appraise. In particular, the stylistic indebtedness of later architects to his work shows the not inconsiderable influence of the 'theory of the oblique' on shifts in architectural expression. Likewise, his *Bunker Archeology* has left its legacy in a more recent publication by Diller and Scofidio (1994) on links between tourism and war on the French Atlantic coast. But it is Virilio's later work, which arguably has the greatest potential impact.

In particular, Virilio points towards a way of theorizing virtual reality. He recognizes that the key to understanding virtual reality is not to grasp the purely instrumental opportunities afforded by new technologies, but to apprehend the ways in which these affect our patterns of consciousness. If technology will never actually replace consciousness, it will at least influence it in ways that are only now becoming apparent. It is as though the concept of the 'tele-' – the 'far' – and all that is associated with the previous, modernist paradigm have to be radically rethought. By adapting Merleau-Ponty's theory of perception, Virilio argues for a tele-perception as a new mode of operation. A theory of cyberspace, such as begins to emerge from Virilio's work, draws upon the notion of telekinesis, of the capacity of the body to operate in any corner of the universe through some form of prosthetic interactive device. The principle of traditional prosthetics, such as the walking stick or the artificial limb, as a mechanism for extending the motility of the body, is itself expanded to include techno-prosthetics, such

as the virtual reality glove, which enlarge the body's sphere of operations indefinitely. As such the paraplegic confined to the wheelchair paradoxically offers a model of how the limitations of the body can be overcome, and how, in a virtual world, human beings may soon be able to access the far corners of the universe. Distance becomes no object. The body can operate as easily using this mechanism on the next planet, as it can in the next room.

Yet while distance is obviated, a new depth is created. Operating through technology introduces a new anonymity already witnessed in telephone conversations. Persons communicating from adjacent VDU consoles correspond as though they are miles apart. Telecommunications, in dissolving the 'here' and 'now', serve both to break down distance, physical distance, and to create psychological 'distance'. While Virilio seems to prophesy the Internet with his observations that the screen has become the city square, 'the crossroads of all mass media', he equally highlights a new *manner* of communication, where technology introduces both a distance and an anonymity (Virilio, 1997: 389). It is in the new telephone dating systems and the frankness and openness that they engender, that the decisiveness of Virilio's comments becomes apparent.

Virilio's work can be understood as an enquiry over the primacy of place in formulating ways of grounding the self. As such it offers a direct riposte to the work of Heidegger, whose concept of 'dwelling' has become something of a dominant paradigm within recent architectural theory amid calls for a regionalist architecture and celebration of the concept of *genius loci*. This concept has been pursued further by those who have developed Heidegger's thought – architectural theorists such as Christian Norberg-Schulz (1980) and philosophers such as Gianni Vattimo (1995: 74–7). It is against Heidegger's static model of 'dwelling' that the potential of a more dynamic model of existence becomes apparent. Even prior to the technological advances that Virilio considers so significant, one might perhaps challenge Heidegger's assumption on other accounts, and question whether such a place-specific mechanism for grounding the self could *ever* have been applied universally. One only has to consider nomadic tribes or, indeed, ethnic or religious groups such as gypsies and Jews, who traditionally – whether voluntary or otherwise – have led the life of the 'wanderer' to understand that, even within traditional societies, Heidegger's concept of 'dwelling' might have had certain shortcomings. But the important point, as Virilio realizes, is that more recent developments in material circumstances have influenced patterns of consciousness, so that even if Heidegger's outlook may once have been valid, its application can be seen as correspondingly less relevant today. Indeed, one might even argue that to a large extent the paradigm of the dynamic 'wanderer' has replaced that of the static 'dweller'.

In an age in which human beings are constantly mobile, the importance of place – place of origin, place of birth, etc. – as a mechanism for grounding the self is diminished. Even the home has been redefined as a 'property' exchangeable within the marketplace. In a world dominated, in

Marc Augé's terms, by 'non-places', individuals now begin to constitute their identity through more transitory phenomena, such as jobs and possessions (Augé, 1995). These possessions may include even technological objects, such as cars and computers. All this has undermined the role of place as a mechanism for constituting one's identity. This is further exacerbated by the reduction in status of the physical and the increased reliance upon the virtual within our contemporary world. In short, the whole thesis of the link between building, dwelling and thinking needs to be revised. This is where Virilio has much to offer. Virilio as a theorist of non-presence and omnipresence, as a theorist of the erosion of physical space and the increasing importance of virtual space, begins to suggest a model of dwelling as virtual dwelling, which feeds off the technological and absorbs it productively, and identifies new imaginative possibilities emerging from this situation. Furthermore, by engaging, seemingly positively, with technology, Virilio transcends the limitations of Heidegger's thought, and opens up the possibility of thinking of new, less place-specific, ways of grounding the self.

It is as though Virilio develops Merleau-Ponty's notion of the primacy of perception into a notion of simulated perception, that echoes in some way Baudrillard's arguments for a notion of hyperreality over traditional notions of reality. Just as in Baudrillard's terms we have come adrift from any sense of referent in the real world, as we now read the world through the image of the world, so too, for Virilio, we have lost touch with 'authentic' perception, and we experience the world increasingly through simulated perceptions. 'It seems that the *reality effect*', Virilio observes, 'replaces immediate reality' (1997: 389). Virilio's vision is therefore a cinematographic one, a vision of the world in which Hollywood provides the model for our contemporary paradigm: 'So, more than Venturi's Las Vegas, it is Hollywood that merits urbanist scholarship' (Virilio, 1997: 389–90).

Problematizing Virilio

Virilio's futuristic outlook must be read, however, with some caution. On occasion his thought appears to lack a sense of the dialectic. Thus, while Virilio appears to identify a shift which undermines the significance of place, and which promotes instead a space of appearances, one might argue that this shift seems to anticipate its opposite in a mechanism of reciprocal presupposition. In other words, the very overcoming of a sense of place seems to invite a renewed interest in the importance of place. The possibilities opened up do not introduce a total placelessness. Indeed, it is precisely because physical space does not constitute such an obstacle for the contemporary office with its faxes, Internet, telephones and so on, that choice of *actual* space becomes a significant concern. No longer is it necessary for offices to be trapped in congested, grimy cities. It is not therefore that physical space is irrelevant. Rather, traditional constraints in the way that physical space is perceived are now becoming less relevant.

For example, the flexibilities introduced by instantaneous information

transfer now allow imaginative use of different time zones – and hence different spaces – for a new generation of technological servicing industries. Information can now be sent from New York at the end of the day to be processed overnight by others, say in Africa, operating during the day of their own time zone, so as to deliver the fully processed product back to New York for the following morning. Such strategies have the potential of exploiting not only differential time zones, but also differential labour markets. While the world becomes the potential office, the specific site of the individual workstation emerges as an increasingly important consideration.

Equally, one might introduce a sense of the dialectic to the opposition between the body and the virtual. The condition of cyberspace has the effect of obviating the body, while at the same time privileging the body. Not only is it that such conditions make one aware of the corporeality of one's own body by way of compensating for the erosion of the importance of the physical, but they also seem to highlight the body itself as a means of grounding these new perceptions. For it is only against the actual body in actual space that perceptions of the virtual body in virtual space can be gauged. To be fair, this is a conclusion that Virilio himself hints at. For while the notion of some ecstatic experience – an experience, that is, which is 'outside' the body – might provide some sense of temporary escape from the body, this can only be a provisional move. 'While spatial escape may be possible', notes Virilio, 'temporal escape is not' (Virilio, 1997: 386). Just as, for Virilio, there can be no escaping time, ultimately, one might surmise, there can be no escaping the body, since the body, like time, operates as a form of datum point, the baseline against which to measure all experiences. One might lose track of time, but one is always in time. One might lose sense of the body, but one is always in the body. To this extent virtual reality must always remain virtual.

Another way to reflect on the limitations of Virilio's thought is to contrast it with that of Michel Foucault and Gilles Deleuze on the progressive erosion of the importance of physical constraints. Foucault had first commented on the capacity for architectural form to condition behaviour in his essay 'Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias' (1997a). Here architecture was employed as a form of institutionalized demarcation of structures of power. In *Discipline and Punish*, Foucault develops this thesis within a more fluid, post-structuralist framework. He becomes concerned with the relationship between architectural form and more diffuse ways in which power is exercised (Foucault, 1997b). The panopticon provides a model which encapsulates the characteristics of a society founded on discipline. It embodies a system in which surveillance plays a crucial role, and in which knowledge is inseparably bound to power. The very architectural layout of the panopticon affords various techniques of control, which, Foucault thought, would in themselves assure almost automatically the subjection and the subjectification of the inmates.

In his 'Postscript on the Societies of Control', however, Deleuze

observes that disciplinary societies have now given way to societies of control (1997: 313). There has been a shift in mechanisms of control as visible constraints are superseded by invisible ones. This is reflected in the development from factories to corporations, and from machines to computers. Physical discipline has been replaced by more gaseous systems of control, where the credit card has supplanted the gaze of the foreman. This leads to a situation in which humankind is no longer constrained by physical space, but forever trapped by debt, ensnared in a system of limitless postponement. 'The burrows of the molehill' have been replaced by the complex 'coils of the serpent' (Deleuze, 1997: 309–13). For Deleuze, then, we must step beyond the Foucault of panopticism. Power is no longer linked to space, and architectural forms have little control over human behaviour.

This thesis echoes that of the 'exhaustion' of the physical in Virilio. But whereas Virilio looks at this condition invariably as an abstract consequence of technological developments, Foucault and Deleuze consider the question within a specifically political context. Space is always seen as political space, as the space of political agency. Their concern throughout is for the politics of use of a space, and how that use might affect the freedom of the individual. No such concern appears in Virilio, who offers little comment on the control of the technological world of which he speaks. Nor indeed does he ever seem to engage fully at any point with the social and economic problems posed by late capitalism. In short, the political – in both the specific and the most general senses – is seldom addressed. This is all the more surprising, given the purportedly political focus of Virilio's writings, and his own political activities.

How might we begin to explain this? One way would be to consider the extent to which Virilio's critique remains essentially an aesthetic one. The problem, it would appear, is that in any aesthetic discussion of form, the question of political content is all too easily elided, and while we might wish to refrain from a simplistic understanding of the relationship between aesthetics and politics, we might recognize that within the aestheticization of politics a certain complex restructuring of the relationship between the two occurs, whereby the political comes to collude with the aesthetic (Hewitt, 1993). But whatever the precise mechanism of interaction between the aesthetic and the political, it is clear that aestheticization leads if not to a rinsing of the political, then at least to a form of camouflaging. This is the guilty secret that haunts all engagements with the aesthetic.

Virilio, one might suppose, ought to be especially cautious when he deals with issues that touch upon such terrain. Given his own background against the events of May '68, and his undoubted familiarity with debates which served to fuel those events, such as Guy Debord's critique of the 'Society of the Spectacle', one would imagine that Virilio should have been only too aware of the issues at stake with the question of aestheticization. Yet the problem seems to be deeply ingrained in Virilio's whole project, and is evident in two early works, the publication, *Bunker Archeology* and the design for the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay in Nevers. From these

we can trace the emergence of a problem that is to haunt Virilio throughout his work.

It is precisely in his handling of architectural form in *Bunker Archeology,* where Virilio charts the German Second World War fortifications on the Atlantic coast, that the problem first appears. It is questionable enough – despite the accompanying text which is dressed up in the language of concern – for Virilio to publish a book full of exquisite photographs of bunkers, photographs that themselves fall prey to the trap of turning emblems of war into haunting, seductive images. But the problem becomes more deep-rooted when – with Parent – Virilio reproduces these forms in his design for the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay. It is at this point when forms borne of war are reproduced in churches and other buildings, that the principle that Walter Benjamin had so incisively recognized in Marinetti's aesthetic celebration of war are replayed within an architectural forum (Benjamin, 1973: 234–5). And if Marinetti is to be criticized for proclaiming that war is beautiful, is not Virilio to be reprimanded for celebrating the aesthetic images of war, rinsed of their original meaning and recycled as abstract architectural forms? And even if Virilio had been attempting, however unsuccessfully, to reclaim these forms and harness them towards a Christian agenda, is it appropriate to attempt this in the first place?

All this hints at the Achilles' heel of Virilio's thought. His outlook remains essentially an aesthetic one, abstracted from political or any form of social concerns. While he addresses shifts in patterns of consciousness that arise from the implementation of new technologies, unlike Foucault or Deleuze he fails to interrogate the full political ramifications of these developments. It is this that allows him to distance himself from the sinister potential of these technologies, and to claim so seemingly naïvely, as he does with the Tactical Mapping Systems, that the functions of eyesight and weaponry 'melt into each other' (Virilio, 1997: 390). It is this that allows him to celebrate the 'dromomaniac' as a type, without distinguishing adequately the *sans culottes* of the French revolution from Hitler's brown-shirts, and without addressing the political ends to which his subject matter tends (Virilio, 1986: 20). And it is this that allows him to dwell so extensively and seemingly uncritically on themes such as 'war' and 'speed'.

It is through the figure of Marinetti, perhaps, that we might best understand the trajectory of Virilio's thought. Virilio is above all a champion of speed as an *aesthetic* gesture, and with that the same problems that afflicted Marinetti's celebration of speed echo throughout his work. It is speed and the machinery of speed that Virilio promotes. And it is against the backdrop of his own questionable obsession with war and the paraphernalia of war that we see further traces of this recurrent problem. *Speed and Politics* is less a manifesto for a general political agenda, than an enquiry as to how speed might facilitate one all too obvious particular agenda. 'Speed is the essence of war', notes Virilio, citing Sun Tzu. But in failing to distance himself from the problem, Virilio appears to condone this

position, and to accept war as an almost necessary corollary of greater speed and mobility in contemporary society.

Virilio and Parent were once greeted with a phalanx of Nazi salutes when they gave a paper at a conference on avant-garde architecture at Folkestone in 1966. It has been suggested that this was a response to the monumental scale of their designs, that also led them to be branded 'Prix de Romists of cosmic thought' by left-wing students at the Ecole des Beaux-Arts (Ockman, 1993: 409). But perhaps those who offered the Nazi salute recognized only too clearly that there is more than a little of the Futurist mentality in their work, and that the whole criticism of the aestheticization of politics, raised by Benjamin, might equally be levelled at them. 'All efforts to render politics aesthetic', noted Benjamin, 'culminate in one thing: war' (Benjamin, 1973: 234). In this context it is perhaps no coincidence that Virilio himself should be so obsessed by war.

How might this obsession with war be manifested within an architectural scenario? An obvious example lies in the work of Lebbeus Woods. In his book, *War and Architecture*, Woods clearly finds the death and destruction in Sarajevo a deeply aesthetic experience. 'War is architecture, and architecture is war!' he proclaims (Woods, 1993: 1). What is most alarming about this equation of architecture with war is not the attempt to see architecture as a form of war, for inevitably architecture will involve some war-like destruction, in that the very process of construction presupposes the destruction of whatever had previously belonged to the site. It is, rather, the tendency to see war as a form of architecture. The destruction of the physical fabric of Sarajevo provides the aesthetic impulse for new forms of architecture. These forms are generated in response to the destruction of the buildings but, more importantly, in their jagged, torn aesthetic, they complement and draw inspiration from the mutilated buildings. As such they constitute an aesthetic celebration of destruction. The work of Woods therefore provides an obvious example of the potential consequences of Virilio's aestheticization of politics.

If we are to find fault with Virilio, we should look beyond the pseudo-scientific language which Alan Sokal and Jean Bricmont criticize so simplistically, failing to recognize the essentially romantic nature of his futuristic vision (Sokal and Bricmont, 1998). Rather, we should focus on the problem of aestheticization. With the aesthetic bias of Virilio's project, the political is too often elided. There is a form of anaesthesia at work which 'numbs' the concern for the political. Just as Albert Speer's sublime stage-sets for Nazi rallies recast a highly unsavoury political agenda as an intoxicating spectacle, so too Virilio's celebration of the exhilaration of 'speed' seems to overlook the political consequences of what is being celebrated. While 'speed' may offer many positive advantages, it may equally have negative ones. All this is lost in Virilio's empty, aphoristic slogans, such as, 'The speed of violence becomes the violence of unsurpassed speed' (Virilio, 1997: 138). And the intoxication of Speer's sublime stage-sets is matched by the intoxication of speed – the 'high' of high speed,

as Virilio describes it (Virilio, 1986: 27). And it is perhaps no coincidence that the term 'speed' is also used for various drugs. Virilio's celebration of the exhilaration of 'speed' and 'war' seems to appeal to a culture dominated by a desire for the sublime and for ecstatic escapism.

In the aesthetics of disappearance, it would seem, it is not the aesthetic which disappears, but the political. Yet in reality the political never fully disappears. For what lurks beneath the veneer of the aesthetic is a more insidious, reactionary form of politics: a politics of acquiescence.

All this points to a deeper underlying problem. If Virilio's work is so popular today, what does this say about contemporary culture? In an age in which, according to Baudrillard, everything has become aestheticized, is it surprising that a writer who holds such a viewpoint should prove so appealing? For it is in a culture where politics is reduced largely to a matter of mere images that Benjamin's formulation of the link between aesthetics and politics is replayed within a specifically postmodern constellation. Perhaps, then, rather than worry about the sinister implications of Virilio's work, we should be concerned about the culture in which it seems to command such appeal. For in a culture where 'speed' and 'war' become fashionable slogans, violence will always threaten to reappear.

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Paul Virilio's Bunker Theorizing

Mike Gane

> If man has no need for the machine to live in his natural environment, he needs the machine to live in a hostile one. (Virilio, 1994 [1975]: 41)

> We must get inside pure war, we must cover ourselves in blood and tears. We mustn't turn away. (Virilio, in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997 [1983]: 108)

Introduction

PAUL VIRILIO'S WORK has a curious status today. On the one hand his name is still absent from leading social theory commentaries. On the other he is widely cited – I note even in today's *Guardian*, Adrian Searle writes that Seurat's painting *The Bathers* has a 'kind of stillness we have nearly lost. And with its loss, we ourselves are in danger of disappearing. This is the kind of dark thought Paul Virilio warms his hands over of an evening' (*Guardian*, G2 30 Dec. 1997: 13). This is precisely the kind of reference Jean Baudrillard's work was receiving ten years ago (*Guardian*, 21 Sept. 1988: 27). The two writers are often associated as the pre-eminent French postmodern theorists (see Kroker, 1992; Ritzer, 1997).[1] Both writers refer to the other in friendly terms, but admit some profound differences. Virilio: 'I have a friendly relationship with Baudrillard, even if I don't always agree with him' (in Rötzer, 1995: 98); Baudrillard:

> We have worked together ... without any problem... His analysis of the cyberworld is intransigent, inexorable, fatal I might dare say, and I find it beautiful and remarkable ... [but] he puts himself in the position of the anti-apocalypse prophet, having been persuaded that the worst can come about. On this point we have ended up going our separate ways. I do not believe in

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> his real apocalypse ... it is the coming of the virtual itself which is our apocalypse, and this deprives us of the real apocalypse. (1997b: 46–7).

Virilio:

> There's a neonihilism in him that I don't like. (in Rötzer, 1995: 98)

Baudrillard:

> Virilio takes a position which is very clearly moral.... Ultimately his analysis is more radical than mine. (1997b: 80)

These cryptic remarks refer in fact to something of a major divergence, and it is highly instructive to follow through the logic of this particular difference of opinion. In this article I attempt to do this by examining Virilio's part in the exchange by tracing the theme of the bunker through his writings, and the way his thinking seems to be caught in an unresolved dilemma.

Bunker Archaeology

> My relation to the war machine has always had a kind of mythic dimension. (Virilio, in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997 [1983]: 7)

A selection of Virilio's earliest writings has recently been re-published (in Parent and Virilio, 1996), including material which makes it possible to reconstruct to some extent the first phase of Virilio's work. Born in 1932, he was brought up in war-time Nantes in France. He was educated at the École des Metiers, Paris, and trained to become an artist in stained glass, working eventually with Braque and Matisse. He followed courses by Jankelevitch, Merleau-Ponty, Wahl and Aron at the Sorbonne. He has been close to Abbé Pierre, and the worker priest movement, having joined the Catholic movement in 1950 (Petit, in Virilio, 1996). In 1958 he was on vacation at Saint-Guenole (Virilio, 1994: 10) when he noticed a German-built war bunker. He wrote up his reflections in a short piece called 'Bunker Achaeology' (1958, included in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 71). In this essay he reported: 'Using the techniques of archaeology, I have explored the subterranean world of one of the esoteric forms of times: the blockhouse. The plan of the blockhouse is strangely reminiscent of that of an Aztec temple' (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 71). From 1958 to 1965 he made a study of the bunkers around the western and northern coasts of France. An exhibition of his photos with explanatory text was later presented by Virilio in 1975–6 at the Museum of Decorative Arts in Paris and published in translation as *Bunker Archeology* (1994). The first period of Virilio's thought goes through to about 1978 and we can trace this through texts collected in *L'Insecurité du territoire* (1993 [1976]).

In the decade 1958–68 Virilio passed from being an artist specializing in stained glass, to architect under the guidance of Claude Parent, though

apparently Virilio had no technical qualification in architecture (who needed this in 1968?). Virilio became a teacher at the École Speciale d'Architecture (ESA) in 1969, a co-director with Anatole Kopp in 1972 (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 13) its General Director, 1975, and President in 1990 (Virilio, 1994: 213). His relationship with Parent, 1963–8 was thus pivotal. Parent was an experimentally minded architect using concrete. Virilio's studies of the bunkers formed a natural point of convergence of ideas and interest. But Virilio was also interested in the structural characteristics and philosophy of space, what he called topotonics. Having investigated bunkers that had toppled over in the sand, he had become fascinated with the potentialities of inclined planes as a resource. In what appears today as a frighteningly naïve vision, he sought to combine bunker style with oblique planes in order to revolutionize the habitable space of cities. The revolution would involve a rejection of conventional room design – he stigmatized such spaces as 'micro-ghettoes' – to continuous 'habitable circulation' on slopes made possible by the technology of reinforced concrete. Curiously, Virilio and Parent wore smart black suits at this time in contrast to the 'psychedelic ensembles favoured by most architects' and when they presented their ideas for 'oblique cities unfolding across the landscape' at a conference at Folkstone in 1966, 'the audience rose up *en masse* and gave them a Hitlerian salute' (Crompton, cited by Migayrou, in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 63). Others, according to Claude Parent, compared the oblique spaces proposed by Virilio 'to the prisons of the Bolshevik police, which had skewed cells and ceilings so low that it was impossible to stand' (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 55).

Transforming the Bunker

> ... to say that the positive phenomenon of technology came in large part from the arsenal and war is.. hard for people to accept. (Virilio, in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 24)

Though no large-scale project of this kind was ever realized, Virilio was able to win a commision through his Catholic contacts for a new church in Nevers, the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay. The church indeed looks like a concrete bunker and has inclined floors. It also has stained-glass windows (see Parent and Virilio, 1996: 20–31), though Parent detested them 'they weren't my idea, and I never show them in photographs' (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 52). Clearly Virilio's radical architecture was transformative: to make military architecture, as it condensed social energy and revealed new functions, serve other functions, a theme he was to develop at some length in essays on critical space. But in the mid-1960s Virilio seemed to be fascinated by the idea of a 'repellent' brutal architectural style which would force users to question conventions in a mode similar to that adopted in Situationism (see Migayrou, in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 62), adding alienation to alienation. At this juncture he promoted a revolutionary and expansive conception of space, a style of intervention

within critical modernism. In the journal which functioned as their manifesto, *Architecture Principe*, Virilio wrote 'we have never before witnessed a change in humanity itself. We are now on the brink of such a metamorphosis – a metamorphosis of our consciousness ... a radical transformation of the notion of dimensions' (1966, in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 65). In a radical but obscure utopianism, Virilio wrote:

> ... urbanism will in future have much more to do with ballistics than with the partition of territories. In effect, the static vertical and horizontal no longer correspond to the dynamics of human life. In future, architecture must be built on the oblique, so as to accord with the new plane of human consciousness. (1966, in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 65)

Virilio stressed the importance of bodies in circulation or, as he called it, 'habitable circulation', indeed the 'conditions are ripe for the emergence of a civil architecture, for this spatial art to pass from the private to the public realm and, in so doing, to accede to its true role – the invention of society' (1996: 68). His vision was precise, the new oblique architecture would change the nature of the city, which now would become 'an enormous projector, a torrent of every kind of activity, every kind of fluidity' (1996: 68). The emphasis was insistent: conventional architecture had condemned humanity to horizontality and therefore to stasis. The vision was one of transforming 'static space' into a habitat 'mobilized by the function of the oblique' and liquid technology (1996: 45, 68). The new structures of urban development would not grow in static concentric rings, but would be 'mediated structures' and 'would form interlinked assemblages that would develop and spread out over regions, along the vital arteries of a territory'. Virilio saw this use of the incline, and the curve, as necessary 'when alienation has become commonplace' (1996: 71).

In the seventh issue of *Architecture Principe* (1967), he republished the article he had written on 'Bunker Archaeology' in 1958 in which he noted that the geometry of these bunkers 'is no longer affirmatory, but eroded, worn. The right angle is reduced, suppressed, in order to make the structure resistant to capture.' The effect of ballistics on structure was clear, the oblique had been invented for essential, practical not aesthetic reasons. These monuments also had a different relation to the earth for 'the mass is no longer grounded ... but centred upon itself, independent, capable of movement and articulation' (1958, in Parent and Virilio 1996: 71). As Migayrou has pointed out, this meant for Virilio that the 'bunker expressed fluidity, building without foundation – the Corbusian ideal of the ocean liner' (1996: 62). Life in these bunkers, in Virilio's view, was 'an exercise in becoming more subtle' (1996: 71). Bunkers heralded he argued, without irony, 'a new architecture that is founded no longer on man's bodily proportions, but on his capacity for thought' (1996: 71).

Claude Parent, crucial agent for the transformation of Virilio from master painter on glass to novice architect of the oblique, was interviewed in

1995 about his early relation with Virilio. Parent met Virilio in 1963. Parent's background – decisively influenced by Andre Bloc (see Migayrou, in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 59f), neo-plasticism and geometric abstractionism – naturally aligned itself with Virilio's study of bunkers (1996: 51). 'After a while, he began coming to the office for a few hours each day', and he:

> ... brought a couple of jobs into the office: the church of Sainte-Bernadette and the Thompson-Houston Aerospace Centre. I was responsible for drawing up the initial designs and plans (he lacked the technical know-how), but then ... [we would] discuss how the project should evolve... (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 51)

Thus in the project for the church 'it was Virilio who said that we should put a slope on the floor planes ... the challenge of working together on a real, concrete project inspired a fundamental breakthrough – the first application of the function of the oblique' (1996: 51). The military aspects of the project was seen in a purely technical light, for what interested Virilio was not simply the war functioning in terms of a system of antagonistic blocs, but that the 'D-Day landings consolidated the whole of the industrial might of the United States' (1996: 51). Virilio 'admired that in the same way that he admired the super-organized Panzer divisions and the autobahn system' (1996: 52). There was considerable opposition to these ideas: 'Virilio insisted that the general resistance to the oblique derived from a resistance to anything new. In the early days of the automobile, people were afraid that they would suffocate if they went above thirty kilometres an hour' (Parent, in Parent and Virilio, 1996: 55).

Virilio's theoretical ambitions were restated in a retrospective essay of 1996:

> The objective of our research was to challenge outright the anthropometric precepts of the classical era – the idea of the body as an essentially static entity ... In our work, the traditional stability (habitable stasis) ... gave way to the metastability (habitable circulation) of the human body in motion... The space of the body became mobile. (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 13)

The project was not a success however and 'after a few years the overwhelming difficulties of building an oblique habitat led us to abandon this work' Virilio admitted (1996: 13).

In 1975–6 Virilio was able to stage his photos of the bunkers in an exhibition at the Museum for Decorative Arts in Paris. His text for the exhibition (orig. 1975) has been republished with a new preface and afterword (Virilio, 1994). The preface recounts the moment of discovery of the bunkers and the way in which they exercised their fascination: passing under a tympanum a 'companion piece to the porch of a religious building' and through this entrance to a 'low, small room, round or hexagonal ... and

having, at its centre, a socle quite similar to a sacrificial altar. Trap doors open in the cement floor, through which access to the crypt is gained.' Virilio talks of 'the crushing feeling' experienced within this monumental structure, 'the visitor in this perilous place is beset with a singular heaviness' (1994: 15–16). The text suggests that it is war, or the war machine which is at the origin of industry and industrialization, indeed Virilio argues that it is war which is at the origin of civil and religious social forms (1994: 43–4). The bunker is the precursor of the survival machine, where the crypt is a form 'that prefigures resurrection', a 'vehicle that puts one out of danger' an 'ark that saves' (1994: 46). The 'Afterword' gives a concise overview of the changes in the character of the world's military situation from 1945 to 1990 and it is clear that for Virilio a remarkable reversal has taken place, a reversal which his writings through the 1970s and 1980s charted in detail. He sums this up in the following way: 'the supremacy of arms of communication ... over arms of massive destruction ... became a reality, bringing about a mutation in real warfare as important as the mutation brought long ago by the supremacy of light arms of destruction' (1994: 202). It seems clear that even by the time the *Bunker Archeology* exhibition was held in Paris in 1975–6, Virilio had already reorganized his own position well beyond abandoning the idea of 'habitable circulation' for purely technical reasons.

Out of the Bunker, Briefly

> May '68... the place was packed. I heard a guy ... say '..."imagination comes to power" that's not true, it's the working class!' I answered: 'so comrade, you deny the working class imagination...' (Virilio in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 82)

Something else had also happened: the events of May '68 in Paris. As Claude Parent recounts, it was the dramatic politicization of Virilio in those events which was to lead to the break-up of their relationship. In the early part of 1968 Parent and Virilio were preparing to build a structure at the University of Nanterre called 'The Pendular Destabilizer'. This was a purely experimental double oblique structure (rather like two bunkers joined together side by side in the form of an X) elevated 12 metres above the ground and isolated from the rest of the world : 'there was no telephone, no post, no means of communication – except for a little hole in the wall that we could talk to each other through' (Parent and Virilio, 1996: 55). The events of May '68 ended the experiment. Virilio joined the student occupation of the Odéon. Parent remained convinced that the oblique was aesthetic not political, Virilio regarded it as essentially aesthetic and political; the friendship and the partnership came to an end in 1970. What Virilio encountered and explored through 1968 is developed through the idea of 'critical space' which can be read as a very specific recasting of his idea of 'habitable circulation'.

Virilio's new ideas emerge over the period 1969–75 in journals *Esprit*, *Cause Commune* and *Critique*, essays collected together in *L'Insecurité du territoire* (1993 [1976]).Virilio reports the joy of having been able to sleep in a lecture theatre at the Sorbonne (after making the intervention in the Richelieu Amphitheatre reported in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 80) have breakfast in a box at the Opéra, eat lunch in a director's office, find a nursery in the library, find a games room in the Renault showroom, indeed of having been able to find France, its stations, airports, schools, shops, as a space to be occupied, thereby reversing the alienated state of everyday life (Virilio, 1993: 86–7): just as there is a need for freedom of speech so there is also a need for freedom of movement. A barricade, he wrote, is not simply a territorial limit but a construction of a new kind of liberated space, a 'new mode of the appropriation of space and time' (1993: 89). Although Virilio uses the experience of May '68, in these years, he does not adopt Marxist language or ideas (with the possible rare exception of an observation that his work concerns the primacy of a revolution in the 'means of destruction' rather than 'means of production' [Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 105]). What interests him is the experience of space in the changing character of the overall strategic situation in its military aspect, and increasingly the logic of mass communications which he sees as its inevitable counterpart.

Volte Face: Back to the Bunker

> We're in a system in which military order dominates ... no matter if that order is socialist, capitalist or anything else. (Virilio, in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 96)

Virilio's reflections on the failure of May '68 are now worked through the theme of speed, not of economics or politics. The leading body of capitalist civilization has become a 'jet set' which no longer resides in traditional and expected locations in time and space. This counter-revolution succeeds through an escalation to 'hyper-communication' transforming the terrain of struggle. Fundamental innovations and technical revolutions put an end to any hope of a genuine revolution in 'habitable circulation'. Indeed, his former position which depended on a critique of the stasis of bourgeois society is inverted. He charts the emergence of nuclear deterrence, 'total peace', not as stasis but as absolute war (1993 [1976]: 71), another reversal in the logistical order. He concludes his study in *L'Insecurité du territoire* by outlining the unexpected consequences brought in the wake of this new order (1993: 243–70). The old communism equated progress with speed but speed is no longer the sign of progress, quite the opposite, since speed is where the enemy to progress resides (1993: 266–70).

Speed and Politics (1986 [1977]) and *Popular Defense* (1990 [1978]) register the scope of the vast change in Virilio's position. The problematic shifts from space to time, and from an expansive politics of mobilization

and liberalization, to a defensive and conservative politics of resistance to acceleration and to a defence of the social. Responding to the appeals of theologians like Bonhoeffer, Virilio begins to warn of the dangers implied in the new state of the world, dangers to the experience of space of the city and of democracy, and of the new possibility of apocalypse brought about by new technologies and strategies available to and adopted by the military elite. In a sense the essay *Speed and Politics*, with its theory of power through control of movement a 'dromocracy' (1986: 70), was the culmination of an analysis applicable to a world already passing away. If the proletariat still thinks in terms of the control of streets and physical movement (1986: 103), the military thinks otherwise: it thinks logistically in relation to new meeting points such as airports, highways and telecommunications (1986: 104). Communism died, fascism survives (1986: 117) and has adapted. In this world, available in instantaneous communication and immediate information, a new permanent state of emergency is created which brings a sharp end to struggles in relative speed (1986: 149).

Virilio draws out these conclusions more dramatically in his book *Popular Defense*:

> If... civilians could have resisted the assault of the war machine, gotten ahead of it, by creating a defence without a body, condensed nowhere, it is quite evident that today they don't even realize that technology has surpassed this kind of defence. (1990: 71)

This is because: 'There is no need for an armed body to attack civilians, so long as the latter have been properly trained to turn on their radios or plug in their television sets' (1990: 71). In these conditions the political state declines, and where 'hyper-communicability' exists there grows totalitarian power (1990: 64–6). The right of armed defence by citizens is lost, while on the other hand 'from now on' the military power is so 'shapeless' it can no longer be identified as it installs itself in a regime of generalized security: an important and irreversible shift from a state of political and civil justice, to a state of logistical and military discipline (1990: 75). This is achieved through the systematic destruction of all the major forms of social solidarity which previously offered real resistance to the state: particularly the family, conceived by Virilio as essentially a combat unit. The liberation of women effectively weakens the solidarity of the family as a defensive form against the state. The resort to terrorism by ultra-left-wing groups again only serves to strengthen, not weaken, the war machine (1990: 88). This creates a paradox: the possibility that the revolution can succeed through control of the streets has been lost yet 'there is no more revolution except in resistance' (1997: 82). Virilio returns to his bunker.

Symbolic Exchange and Death

> As soon as the civil detaches itself from death, denies it ... we fall body and soul into the militaristic interpretation. (Virilio, in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 129)

It is instructive at this point to compare Virilio's experience with that of Baudrillard, with whom he began to collaborate on the journal *Traverses* from 1976. Both Virilio and Baudrillard reversed their positions on the meaning of the events of May 1968, coming in the mid-1970s to a common point of view that the political situation had rendered a simple commitment to revolution and progress untenable. The points of departure were, however, very different. Baudrillard's background in literature, anthropology and sociology was in marked contrast with Virilio's background in craftwork, theology and military architecture, but the convergence was strong and condensed around the acceptance of a new social condition marked by the success of material consumerism, the dominance of mass communication in a condition of political stasis (theorized by Virilio as a paradoxical situation of pure war). There were, however, clear differences of opinion. As Virilio was later to remark (in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 125), Baudrillard's key text, *Symbolic Exchange and Death* (1993) developed no discussion of the war machine (for take-up of this idea one has to go to Deleuze and Guattari); Baudrillard, if anything, moved to a pagan position of symbolic exchange which saw the Christian forms adhered to by Virilio as the very source of modern simulacra. And while Virilio sought a base in the social for retrenchment of resistance to ongoing technological transformations, Baudrillard notoriously announced the 'end of the social'. Baudrillard's essay on the architecture of the Pompidou Centre ('L'Effet Beaubourg: implosion et dissuasion', 1994a [1977]) stands in remarkable contrast with Virilio's *Bunker Archeology* (1994 [1975]). Just as Virilio had described the bunker as a dead animal, so Baudrillard began his essay on the Beaubourg by defining it as a 'carcass of flux and signs' (1994a: 61) and 'an imperial compression – figure of a culture already crushed by its own weight – like moving automobiles suddenly frozen in a geometric solid' (1994a: 63). Instead of celebrating the idea of polyvalent space in the interior of the new building, Baudrillard is scathing in his contempt for the idea of 'circulation' in this space, with its 'immense to-and-fro movement similar to that of suburban commuters'. The paradox is, he said, people search for a 'corner which is precisely not one, (and so) exhaust themselves secreting an artificial solitude ... the ideology of visibility, transparency, of polyvalency' (1994a: 62). It leads Baudrillard to a famous formulation: from now on the vision of a possible revolutionary explosion has to be replaced by that of implosion; and the same is true of the city itself: 'fires, war, revolutions, criminal marginality, catastrophes: the whole problematic of the anticity, of the negativity internal or external to the city, has some archaic relation to its true mode of annihilation' (1994a: 70–1). Baudrillard reflects that the events of 1968 have to be rethought: 'something else began ... the violent involution of the social' (1994a: 73).

Baudrillard's position in the mid-1970s is to pit 'culture', in the anthropological sense, against the regimes of simulacra. Baudrillard's critical essay only works, in fact, on the basis that he can say what this opposition between them is. Culture is at this moment in his thought an

ordered structure, 'a site of the secret, of seduction, of initiation, of a restrained and highly ritualized symbolic exchange' (1994a: 64). While the Beaubourg Centre is 'nothing but a huge effort to transmute [the] famous traditional culture of meaning into the aleatory order of signs, into an order of simulacra (the third) that is completely homogeneous with the flux and pipes of the facade' (1994a: 65). But what about a concrete bunker? It is strange that Virilio sought to find, and did find in his concrete bunkers, a sacred altar, a place of initiation, a crypt. But the very fact that concrete is a liquid medium is for Baudrillard, against Virilio, important in its own right. In *Symbolic Exchange and Death* Baudrillard refers to the 'old cook' who lived in the Ardennes who sculptured everything in that 'single polymorphous material: reinforced concrete' (1993: 52). Everything modelled in concrete, and Baudrillard lists them: chairs, sewing machines, an entire orchestra. Baudrillard notes, that this project is:

> ... not so far removed from the stucco builders of Baroque art, nor very different from projecting an urban community onto the terrain of a large contemporary group ... it is already aiming at control of a pacified society, cast in a synthetic substance ... a project which aims at political and mental hegemony, the fantasy of a closed mental substance. (1993: 53)

In this analysis concrete plays the same role as stucco, a primitive medium for simulacra (of the first order), but Baudrillard already notes its second-order industrial potentialities. The essential nature of this project is identified as belonging to the counter-reformation, conceived in detail by the Jesuits in a new type of reactionary elite and state organized around a homogeneous theology (1993: 52). Stucco is 'an apparatus of the same order' and the concrete of the Ardennes cook is a 'mental substance' (1993: 52–3).

Baudrillard's analysis here was developed as part of what he called a theory of 'orders of simulacra' (1993: 50–88), a topic taken up as the feature of a special issue of the journal *Traverses* (no. 10, *Le Simulacre*) in February 1978. Baudrillard's contribution was the essay 'La Precession des simulacres' (orig. 1978: 3–37, trans. in 1994: 1–42), and Virilio wrote 'La Dromoscopie ou l'ivresse des grandeurs' (orig. 1978: 65–72) which was also published in an expanded version in the journal *Critique* (vol. 34: 324–37, as 'La Dromoscopie ou la lumière de la vitesse', this version reproduced as chapter 6 of *L'Horizon negatif* [1984: 143–55]). It is not surprising to find that Virilio's discussion starts with the statement that 'movement commands the event' (1984: 143) which we find later is derived from Napoleon (1984: 161). Virilio's idea sees simulacra as phenomena closely linked to those of command posts, control consoles, cockpits. He develops the idea that with moving vehicles like cars the travellers see the world in a new way, a double reduction: of the time-distance of the voyage and the new screen vision of the world. He calls this the dromoscopic simulation (1984: 146). Thus Virilio's idea of simulation is quite different from that of Baudrillard and

closer to that of McLuhan (who theorized the new vision of the world produced by the speed of trains). Virilio's thesis is that the driver in such a position of simulation in the dromocratic order maintains the dictatorship of movement (1984: 148).Virilio traces the idea of the 'conductors' of peoples behind the 'dromoscopic screen of absolute power' before passing to the motorcyclist and 'conductors of families who reproduce in their little everyday movements (*evasions*) the dromocratic order of great invasions'(1984: 154–5). The discussion suggests that now it is the earth itself which is the vehicle, and all perception of the movement of the sun, moon and stars is equivalent to perception of 'the real' through a panoramic screen (1984: 159). The way is open for new means of teleguidance or what he calls 'dromovisual apparatuses' (1984: 160). But against McLuhan he argues that the significant developments here cannot adequately be seen as or reduced to the technological, the crucial effects concern the new levels of rapidity of communication between interlocutors: the violence of speed is not a simple technological phenomenon. Here the motor has been war, with industrial civilization its transformed effect, and the new acceleration producing the condition of pure war (1984: 161).

Virilio's 'simulations' are representations of the real world, representations which are substituted for one another as technology develops. Baudrillard's conception of these relations is more complex: the real is not a brute given, but a historically and socially evolved form of appropriation of the world (and replaces other forms through their constant and systematic destruction). For Baudrillard, then, '[r]epresentation stems from the principle of the equivalence of the sign and the real' whereas simulation, 'on the contrary, stems... from the radical negation of the sign as value, from the sign as reversion ... of every reference.' In this new situation 'there is no longer a Last Judgement to separate the false from the true' (Baudrillard, 1994a: 6). As Baudrillard had noted in his essay on the Pompidou Centre in Paris the 'Beaubourg illustrates very well that an order of simulacra only establishes itself on the alibi of the previous order' (1994a: 64).[2] What separates Baudrillard and Virilio at this point in time, is not just Christianity (where Baudrillard takes a Nietzschean position which is anathema to Virilio, (see Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 133), but essentially a dispute about the theory of the real as a referent for simulation, and particularly the social as referent. The different emphasis given by Virilio to the theory of war could be seen as providing a relatively specialized zone which ensures that theoretical topics do not come into direct contact, and which allows theoretical exchanges between him and Baudrillard to occur.

Both Virilio and Baudrillard follow McLuhan in their own way: the medium is the message. The development of the mass media, tele-technologies, brings about the ecstasy of communication and the hegemony of the screen, the vision machine. As I have noted, Virilio made this transition in his writings over the period 1969–75 (in *L'Insecurité*) with his thesis that acceleration is generalized through communication. This becomes a

decisive new step in his account of dromocracy: at the end of *Speed and Politics* Virilio concludes with the observation that with the advent of nuclear war and the new means of communication 'the war-machine becomes (thanks to the reflexes of the strategic calculator) the very decision for war' (1986 [1977]: 139–40). Preparation for war is part of war itself, and creates 'extreme proximity of parties in which the immediacy of information immediately creates the crisis' (1986: 143). Virilio suggests this realizes what was most feared by Clausewitz, the 'full discharge' of total war (1986: 151). The Red Brigades in Italy called in February 1978 for all militants to 'act militarily in order to act politically against the "bunkers in which the agents of counter-revolution hide"' (Virilio, 1990: 42). Virilio, stung to reply wrote a resolute critique of this aim: it is too late for any assault, only popular defence is possible. But it is clear this creates a crisis at the heart of Virilio's position: there are three kinds of resistance – first, to struggle against the war-machine by declaring war on it or, second, to enter its body and divert its effect or, third, simply to act defensively where possible forms of solidarity arise and to build up these solidarities where possible. The former seems outmoded by the 1970s, but the question which haunts Virilio's project of popular resistance is what forms it would take and whether they are effective. Even more pressing is the question of what happened to the work of transforming the technological developments brought about by the military machine?

Bunker Visions

> I believe in the peace of Christ. (Virilio, in Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 122)

Virilio's most mystical text, *The Aesthetics of Disappearance* (1991a [1980]), followed on from Baudrillard's own rather strange text *Seduction* (1990 [1979]). Virilio's work might well be considered an attempt to counter Baudrillard's Nietzschean fatal theory with a statement of Christian meditation on seduction and evil. Virilio's argument relies heavily on a range of bizarre mystical texts and positions including that of Saint Bernadette of Lourdes. He has no hesitation in claiming that her witness to the Virgin is as valuable as any work of the German romantics and idealist philosophers. Indeed, he sees a profound unity between the 'simple story' of a young seer, and the 'elaborate tales of the transcendental poets' (1991a: 42). One finds here he says a 'sort of para-optic aesthetics of the real world, an unusual activity of the senses, usurping their function by chance' (1991a: 42). Bernadette's visionary experience is cited as primary evidence of the experience of time:

> I saw poplars beside the torrent and brambles in front of the cave quiver as if the wind was shaking them, but all around nothing moved and suddenly I saw something white ... a white girl no bigger than me. She greeted me, bowing... (1991a: 38)

Virilio is bitterly critical of the way children are now deprived of their apparitions. Bernadette said of her experience 'for that moment you'd give a whole lifetime', and Virilio records 'this is exactly what she does by hiding in a convent at Nevers where she dies at age 35' (1991a: 39). Nevers is now marked by Virilio's Bunker church. Virilio has subsequently noted the similarity of the experience of being in the grotto at Lourdes and being in a bunker (Virilio and Brausch, 1997: 35).

At the end of this book Virilio muses on the mystery of the bunker. 'As a young man I wondered about the aesthetics of war machines ... I found myself often contemplating a bunker or the silhouette of some submarine seen at a distance, wondering why their polished forms were so inscrutable', he writes. His first reflections related these forms to:

> ... zoomorphism, to metamorphism, but all of that was comparison, imitation and could not satisfy me. Then I believed these forms were inscrutable because they all related to speeds that were different, excessive... But the over-production of movement implied by war changed the way things looked; the motor, since it relates directly to the state of paradoxical wakefulness replaced the causal idea – that was its revolution; the motor proceeds from the soul. (1991a: 103)

The deepest threat is the systematic elimination of genuine religious consciousness (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 124). In his *L'Horizon negatif* (1984) Virilio specifies the nature of this threat and the military as false priesthood. It is a struggle between two temporalities: the 'instant' is the warrior, the 'eternal' the priest (1991a: 291). The condition of nuclear pure war sees the emergence of the cult of military-scientistic objects, a millenarianism founded as a cargo cult of the arsenal. It is the evocation of a mystical apocalypse through the 'adoration of vehicles'. It is 'the nuclear faith' (1991a: 305), a pure parody of religion. Virilio is fighting the war of a new virtual Christian priesthood.

Bunkers in the Desert

> ... the apocalypse is here. It could happen at any moment ... [it] is hidden in development itself, in the development of arms – that is, *in the non-development of society.* (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 139)

What happens to the bunker in the 1980s? In the key essay of *L'Horizon negatif* he suggests pure speed and pure war are desert forms, devoid of human life and historical events. The desert as the negative horizon; the desert as 'the last figure of the bunker' (1984: 210). It is one of the effects of a series of important transformations: capital accumulation is to be understood as the accumulation of wealth and wealth as condensation of speed. But speed is above all transport and as transportation structures accelerate it becomes clear that what occurs is above all a revolution in the transportation of messages, to the radical dematerialization of carriers: pure

communication and the dramatic disappearance of man, cities, citizens. This radical situation makes even more significant the new value of the simple act of presence: in the Latin American case, a visible protest, a witness to the disappearance of individuals. With the emergence of the speed of the new media all peoples are exposed to a similar process, and also tend to disappear, 'as if by magic' (in Rötzer, 1995 [1986]: 101–2).

When pure war changed gear and the Gulf War broke out in 1991, Virilio was keen to locate and analyse, just like Baudrillard, its new logic, in the light of theorizing over 25 years. Virilio's analysis, in *L'Ecran du desert* (1991b) concluded that a shift had indeed taken place and this was the first 'post-modern war' (1991b: 177) in the sense that it was now clear, as had been foreseen, many of the temporal and spatial aspects of war had been completely transformed by communication and other technologies (see the commentary on this transition in Bogard, 1996: 78–97). This war was, for Virilio, a world war 'in *miniature*', and deserved to be known as World War III 'in reduction' (1991b: 162), where the military vision machine proved itself sovereign. The instantaneity of decision-making through information produced at an unprecedented speed meant that space–time relations were fused in a total 'electromagnetic environment' (1991b: 165). Much has been made of the apparent difference between Baudrillard and Virilio on the Gulf War, indeed the difference appeared sharp at the time. Yet Virilio introduced the spectre of the '4th front': the speed of communication and information is so rapid and decisive it rules out at a stroke effective responsibility and democratic control. It creates the paradoxical elimination of the distinction between true and false, the fusion of object and image, even of defence and attack (1991b: 182). And Baudrillard wrote at the time:

> ... in confronting our opinions on the war with the diametrically opposed opinions of Paul Virilio, one of us betting on apocalyptic escalation and the other on deterrence and the indefinite virtuality of war, we concluded that this decidedly strange war went in both directions at once. (Baudrillard, 1995: 49)

But this conclusion is superficial. For Baudrillard the crucial point was that the separation between war and peace was dissolved into virtual transpolitical forms. Virilio, on the other hand requires the separation of the two terms in order to perform his critique. We can say, therefore, that Virilio noted something Baudrillard did not: a new situation of the bunker. Unlike the bunkers on the Atlantic Wall, Saddam's bunkers were hidden and disguised, resembling other 'furtive' phenomena of this new type of war (1991b: 119). These bunkers were hidden in the desert, a modern Atlantis. Thus Virilio, from a Baudrillardian point of view, seems to have taken at face value the war machine's own propaganda (see Keeble, 1997: 166–87, esp. 180), a further absolute reversal had taken place. The destructive arms were now exposed, but the defensive infrastructures were

disguised (1991b: 121). The new bunkers were proof against nuclear attack and designed to maintain hundreds of soldiers in a new kind of hostile environment with sophisticated air filtration systems (1991b: 121). On the other hand one of the great 'errors' of the allies was to have bombed a civilian bunker less well disguised than others (1991b: 189, 185–6), compounded, paradoxically, by the problem of an inability to assess accurately the effect of its attacks, even with all the immense panoply of sophisticated spying apparatuses. These seemed able only to give precise information about position, not to be able to play any significant qualitative role in the verification of damage inflicted.

Grey (Bunker) Ecology

> ... a pollution no longer atmospheric or hydrospheric but dromospheric. (Virilio, 1997: 64)

Virilio has often complained that people do not understand his position, that: 'war and not commerce is the source of the city, as they don't accept the negativity of technology' (1997: 24). Thus we must be clear: war and peace are not simply opposite states. They do not figure as unique categories, but are transformed into each other: the priest transforms war into peace, the warrior transforms peace into war. Virilio models himself, however, not on a Christian example, but on a pagan example: the Greeks brought politics and citizenship into existence out of war. In the Agon the individual dies for the city. He exchanges this death for a new life. But in the new situation the 'military man is a false priest because the question of death doesn't interest him. He's an executioner, not a priest. A new inquisitor' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 49).

Virilio is also fascinated by the emergence of a new type of inertial mode of being, and in particular Howard Hughes, who 'ended up a technological monk in the desert of Las Vegas, without getting out of bed' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 73). All he did was to watch films. He saw *Ice Station Zebra* 164 times: 'he never stopped watching a film that represented exactly that same inertia in a polar city...' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 73). 'What fascinated me about Howard Hughes ... was the fact that he managed to foreshadow a mass situation' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 74). But, asks Virilio: 'Who are these people fascinated by their electronic windows?' This interests him since here 'we have a phenomenon of inertia and death on the spot ... a sedentariness in dead time' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 74). So: pure war which is infinite in its preparation (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 92), has an ineluctable but paradoxical logic. The increase in the rate of acceleration of communication leads to the elimination of the world's dimensions: point, line, surface, volume. For Virilio this is the supreme pollution, the pollution of space–time: 'there is no longer any "here", everything is "now"' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 144).

Conclusion

> Virilio ... the last and best of all the saints. (Kroker, 1992: 44)

Virilio conceives the bunker occupant in this new situation as being 'encapsulated in the arrow of cosmic time, cut off from local time by his very travels, the extra-worldly navigator (or worldly televiewer) is the victim of an unprecedented inertia' (1997: 128). The cybernaut is an atrophied body 'whose safety takes precedence over all activity, to the point where, for him, the concrete environment has only a single point left, the point' (1997: 128). But it is clear that Virilio is unable to find any way he can enter and divert this machine (unlike Baudrillard's analyses of the virus, etc.). Virilio does not seek to introduce a pathology, the problem for Virilio is that pathology, in the shape of an accident, is all too likely to become general (1997: 69ff). The earnest and humourless logic of Virilio's position is quite different therefore from that of Baudrillard. Virilio in essence has a theory of the relentless and accumulative dromocracy, while if Baudrillard's 'orders of simulacra' appear accumulative (since they abolish previous orders) in the end they occupy a curved space and are subject to reversibility, for the last judgement has already occurred ('might it not perhaps be necessary to replace Paul Virilio's dromology with a palindromology?' asks Baudrillard wickedly [1994b: 122]). Virilio tries to specify a 'grey ecology' a new kind of resistance (it has no means) to a new pollution (it is 'omnipolitan') (Virilio, 1997:143). For Baudrillard, Virilio's 'attempt to escape the apocalypse of the virtual, is... the last of our utopian desires' (1994b: 117).

We should return, finally, to the basic dilemma Virilio finds himself facing. If 'we must get inside pure war ... cover ourselves in blood and tears' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 108), he has failed to discover from his high-tech bunker window any mode of entry to the machine. If he fights a battle for the real against the virtual, presenting a resisting distance, even from a low-tech bunker (no television or computer screen, no fixed or – horror! – mobile telephone, fax, a kind of Non-pendular Stabilizer) he remains a prophet of the last utopia arising on the lost horizon of the social. But in the new situation pure war brings a new obstacle to exchange: polar inertia, so that eventually every 'city will be in the same place – in time' (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 61). Every Bunker will be in the same place. Virilio now outlines his strategy:

> Proximity, the single interface between all bodies, all places, all points of the world – that's the tendency. And I push this tendency to extremes. It's not science fiction. Science and technology develop the unknown, not knowledge. Science develops what is not rational. That's what fiction is. (Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: 62)

To pass from fiction into the 'real', however, he must at some point, come out of his bunker. He is profoundly furtive about his capabilities on this front: 'I

have no solution to offer', and he adds: 'if there's a salvation it lies in the humility of philosophical, scientific and political thinking ... a radical scientific and philosophical humility. We are nothing' (in Rötzer, 1995: 103–4). The perfect disguise.

Notes

Versions of this article were read at the Universities of Nottingham and Warwick. Many thanks to those who took part in the discussions and to the two anonymous referees who read the article.

1. It is not uncommon to find their names associated with the same publications (e.g. at one time on the French journal *Traverses*, through numerous Semiotext(e) publications), at the same conferences (e.g. the *Looking Back on the End of the World* collection, Kamper and Wulf, 1989), interviewed for the same publication series by Sylvère Lotringer for Semiotexte (see Baudrillard, 1987, and Virilio's discussions with Lotringer in *Pure War*, 1997), by Rötzer – a chapter each for Boer Verlag (Rötzer, 1995 [1986]), and both interviewed at book length by Philippe Petit for Grasset: Virilio in *Cybermonde, la politique du pire* (1996) and Baudrillard in *Le Paroxyste indifferent* (1997a).

2. It is interesting to note that in a recent interview Virilio remarks that the Beaubourg was 'already a symptom of the mobilization of architecture' in a way which paralleled the acceleration of the real (Virilio and Brausch, 1997: 74).

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Virilio and New Media

Sean Cubitt

IT IS ALWAYS FLATTERING to read that you inhabit the ultimate moment in history, and that your own time witnesses the definitive crisis of your civilization. Much of the interest and attraction of Virilio's writings comes from his belief that we inhabit today a crisis of perception, precipitated through the militarization of perceptual technologies and the embedding of these technologies in the familiar environs of the street, the home and the architecture of daily life. This crisis of architecture, in which the solid geometry of buildings gives way to the fluid transparencies of media, he sees inaugurated in the time-lapse chrono-photographic experiments of Etienne Jules Marey (for example Virilio, 1994: 60–1; see also Ceram, 1965; Dagognet, 1992), precursors to cinema, and in any given text of Virilio's is seen as culminating in the latest upgraded and accelerated medium of transmission or recording. If much of his assertive and allusive, elliptical and epigrammatic writings are crowded with hyperbole and unsubstantiated assertions, yet the work seems to capture key elements of our awe before the new constellation of communicative technologies, our belittlement under the regime of contemporary mediated and networked societies. Yet Virilio's is a deeply liberal critique, formed not only in his Christian faith (see Virilio and Lotringer, 1997: passim) but in the centrality he affords to individuals. Faced with the collapse of the values he holds dearest, Virilio must recount the classical liberal scenario of Armageddon. Virilio's liberalism is in the lineage neither of Stirner's right-wing libertarianism, the deep subtext of much North American neo-liberal techno-utopianism, nor of Kropotkin and the agrarian utopianism that occasionally surfaces in contemporary writings critical of technological rationalism. Instead, it forms an anarchist mirror to the pessimistic Marxism of Adorno. But where Adorno is concerned to discover in the European past the roots of Nazism and authoritarianism, for Virilio the burning issue is a contemporary apocalypse. That catastrophe is ultimately ethical, since the progress of

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media technologies leads to the destruction of the properly human will, the ground for ethical choice.

Virilio's epigrammatic, even ideogrammatic prose traces a media history, deeply informed by current media and communications scholarship, in the attempt to trace not so much the genesis as the trajectory of a historical process under whose wheels we are even now being crushed. According to his central thesis, the militarization of society at large, and the media in particular, produces an acceleration of communication which demands of us an accommodation to rapidly shrinking technological time-scales. This is the point in mediated perception into which Virilio inserts his concept of picnolepsia, the momentary lapse in consciousness which facilitates the invention of cinema, since it acclimatizes us to the production of continuities where there are none, and which ultimately will lead to 'the authority of electronic automatism, reducing our will to zero' (Virilio, 1991a: 104). Virilio spends little time analysing the films of the Lumière brothers, often seen as the originals of the documentary and realist traditions of cinema, and instead repeatedly returns to the illusionistic magical tableaux of Georges Méliès. Marey's chronophotography, Virilio argues, established a science of the invisible, revealing what the eye is too slow too catch. In the trick films of the 1890s:

> What science attempts to illuminate, 'the non-seen of the lost moments', becomes with Méliès *the very basis of the production of appearance* of his invention, what he shows of reality is what reacts continually to the absences of the reality which has passed. (Virilio, 1991a: 17)

The problem addressed here, of the ability of the eye to establish continuity between frames ('persistence of vision') and even more so the ability to effect the transition from shot to shot, have been central to the discussion of cinema since the earliest times. It forms the nub of the famous Kuleshov effect, an experiment in montage in which the audience reinterpret a single shot of the actor Mosjoukin according to whether the following shot is of a plate of soup, a coffin or a pretty girl (Kuleshov, 1973).

Film theory addresses this retrospective Gestalt in a number of ways, one of the most influential being the theory of suture advanced by Lacanian film analysts of the 1970s, according to which the closure of the film text depended on the responsibility assumed by the spectator to become the subject of that text, so completing its absences (marked by framing and editing) by becoming present as spectator (see Dayan, 1976; Heath, 1977/8; Oudart, 1977/8). As Rothman puts it, this view of film can be read as 'intrinsically tyrannical' (Rothman, 1976: 453); the question remains as to whether it is, as Rothman believes, the theory that is tyrannical, or the media. Suture played a crucial role in restoring a temporal dimension to screen-theoretical accounts of cinematic subjectivity, a major crux of structural analysis. Effectively, what the theory of suture argued is almost exactly the opposite of Virilio: that the viewer is constituted as a presence by the

absences of the filmic text. Where the suture theory scores, contra Rothman, is in giving to this newly constituted subject in return an active role in the construction of the film. If, in the post-'68 fervour of film theory in France, Oudart sees this as a complicity in the oppression operated by Hollywood, it can also give us the grounds for a more mature understanding of the interactivity between audiences and texts now that media studies is more forgiving of popular pleasures and more interested in the audience's active participation in the construction of meaning.

Virilio's picnoleptic theory, by contrast, assumes the subordination of the viewer not to the textual production of the film, but to the apparatus of the cinema. Though this view too had its place in 1970s screen theory (see Baudry, 1975, 1985; Heath and de Lauretis, 1980), the specificity of the individual film was always a retardant on generalization about the medium as such. In Virilio's case, we come into contact with a media theoretical tradition for which, on the McLuhan principle, the medium rather than its individual instances is the message. This creates a crux in Virilio's thought, since to some extent, especially in *The Aesthetics of Disappearance* (1991a), he offers not only a sociological account of the powers of the militarized media, but the elements of a phenomenology of mediated experience. Where screen theory gave itself the task of understanding the production of subjectivity in the textual production of the reality effect, picnoleptic theory attempts to understand the abolition of subjectivity in the disappearance of reality. In a lucid summary of his earlier work, Virilio argues a distinction between the 'small' or 'passive optics' he associates with the geometries of our immediate environs and the 'big' or 'active' optics of wave-particle physics and the weapons and transmission media that operate at the speed of light. The former puns on '*grandeur nature*', translatable as both 'life-sized' and 'natural grandeur', an experiential category of vision based on unmediated, immediate vision. The latter, 'big optics', is the optics of lasers, radar, television, to which materiality is transparent, and which reduces the human world at first to a tiny globe spinning in empty space and finally to a point disappearing into unreality. Founded in the irreality of quantum mechanics and technologically sourced outside the human perspective in satellites and aircraft, 'the *active* big optics of the speed of light are unleashed (from beyond any horizon) onto the intermittent perception of the SMALL WORLD made transparent by waves carrying their various signals' (Virilio, 1992: 88). The problem of intermittence still haunts perception, the more so, according to Virilio, as the photo-mechanical media, with their quasi-physiological pulse of 24 frames per second, are replaced by opto-electronic circuits of pure information. Where analogue media still claim at least a resemblance to actual objects and actual vision, the digital image is now entirely abstracted, converted into signal and number, circulated at speeds that defy the human sensorium. The picnoleptic moment becomes then an ontological quality of the mediation of appearances, which in their most recent manifestations as satellite observations or immersive virtual reality systems reveal the destiny which all mechanical mediation has

pursued under the governance of militaristic modernity: the eradication of distance: 'how can you not', he asks, 'as of now dread the advent of a deep feeling of confinement of man locked in an environment at once deprived of horizon and of *optical depth*?' (Virilio, 1992: 88).

The governing theme of this discourse is clearly one of loss, summarized most apothegmatically as 'the more speed increases, the faster freedom decreases' (Virilio, 1986: 142) and, in a paraphrase of Kipling: 'the concept of reality is always the first victim of war' (Virilio, 1989a: 33). The implication – that freedom and reality are mutually dependent – of course begs the question of where such an innocent state of real freedom and free reality has ever existed. There seems to be some suggestion that this state exists in a divine time outside of human history, as an Ideal. Virilio rarely addresses the issue directly or positively, but by indirections amid the grim warnings concerning the accelerating degradation of human and material reality. Claiming his position as 'realist' (Oliveira, 1996: np), he nonetheless occupies an exclusively critical stance towards the technologies of transport and transmission which have, in his analysis, reformulated what it means to be human. In this way, as Kellner has proposed (Kellner, 1998: np), he follows in the phenomenological footsteps of Martin Heidegger (1977) and Jacques Ellul (1964) in offering an account of mass media as totalitarian, adding a specific spin concerning the loss of the local: as he expresses it to Oliveira, 'Globalization – and don't we have a paradox here? – also means the end of one entire world: the world of the particular and of the localized' (Oliveira, 1996: np). The human scale of perception is inundated by the sheer speed of communication, and in its place there arrives a fierce, inhuman view whose motive is assault and destruction, and whose mechanical delivery systems not only carry into daily life the imperatives of warfare but, replacing the human scale of face-to-face perception, deprive us of the bases from which we might resist its domination.

The position is summed in an essay dating from the mid-1980s:

> The will-to-power of those industrial nations who, at the turn of the century, practised the techniques of total war, has now been replaced by the theoretical operations of a totally involuntary war, on the part of post-industrial nations investing increasingly in informatics, automation, and cybernetics. In these societies, the use of human labor-force and the direct responsibility of people has been displaced by the powers of 'anticipated' and 'deferred' substitution, the power of the system of auto-directed armaments, self-programmed detection networks, and automatic respondents who lead humanity to the confinement of a hopeless waiting. (Virilio, 1991b: 136)

Like Baudrillard in the same period (Baudrillard, 1994: 32–3), Virilio reads the armed stand-off of the Cold War as a mutual pact between the antagonists to guarantee that both can extend their power over their own territories, a process Virilio describes as 'endo-colonization'. But in the period since the fall of the Berlin Wall and the effective end of global

bipartisan politics, the motive force of cultural change has shifted towards the imagined enemy, now dematerialized as potential or virtual, whose fictive character we had learned to delineate in the harshest years of nuclear deterrence.

In one sense, the Gulf War of 1991 was the last gasp of Cold War-fare, a war based on the attempt to deter the enemy from striking. But in another it foreshadowed what has occupied Virilio throughout the subsequent years, the nature, dimensions and impact of information war. Again like Baudrillard (1995), Virilio understands Desert Storm as a derealization of warfare, not only in terms of the news coverage (his book on the subject is called *Desert Screen*), nor exclusively in terms of the abstraction of the combatants from the results of their actions (an effect he traces back at least to 'the pressurized cockpits of US Superfortress bombers' which 'had become artificial synthesisers that shut out the world of the senses' at the end of the Second World War [Virilio, 1989a: 24]). Much more than either, the accumulated data on the battlefield had allowed US pilots and technicians to simulate battle in the Iraqi desert in computer models and ground-based flight-simulators for several years prior to the actual events. The upshot of this dematerialized mode of information warfare was the terrifying effectiveness of the US military machine in the Gulf. Moreover, the enemy in this instance occupied effectively a different historical period to the US, fighting for a territory in which they still believed, and in which they had a stake. For the information warrior, territory, according to Virilio, has no meaning whatsoever. It has been assimilated into the datastreams of battle computers, and has become immaterial.

Ironically, the automobile and the cinema alike produce an immobile spectator of action, not a mobile participant. From the first pan shot of 1896 to the broadcasting technologies of the post-war period, he argues in 'The Last Vehicle', travelling has been diminished, losing first the transit in the acceleration of trains, cars and planes, then the act of departure, substituting 'the primacy of arrival (which is momentary)' (Virilio, 1989b: 118). With the diminution of journeys, there arrives the possibility of the elimination of space. Global electronic information and transmission systems now provide the technological infrastructure not only for the destruction of space, but for its replacement with the 'time of light', the instantaneous transmission of data at the limit speed of the universal constant. But while Virilio, consistently and inaccurately describing transmission rates as 'instantaneous', argues for the triumph of time (speed) over space, he is also able to offer an insight into the changing nature of time. 'Today', he notes in *The Vision Machine*, ' "extensive" time has given way to "intensive" time. This deepens the infinitely small of duration, of microscopic time, the final figure of eternity rediscovered outside the imaginary of the extensive eternity of bygone centuries' (Virilio, 1994: 72). Clearly for Virilio technology and science are barely distinguishable, science acting as the discursive expression of technology's historical imperative. The advanced dematerialization he sees in quantum physics, as indeed in the fractal mathematics of

emergence, is intrinsic to the opto-electronic technologies which are busily substituting for first-hand experience. Equally clearly, he goes against the flow of Anglo-Saxon postmodernism, with its emphasis on spatialization and the diffusion of history and temporality. Instead, he sees the inhabiting of the moment as the end of historical experience, an experience itself premised on spatial and especially local awareness. The picnoleptic moment has ceased to function as the motive inattention that permits the illusion of cinema, and instead has become the goal of new data-streaming technologies whose speed exceeds that of perception, and which therefore promote a permanent state of unawareness, of null experience, with all activity delivered over to the optical machine, and all passivity delivered to the immobilized passenger aboard Concorde or immersed in virtual reality.

One might forgive Virilio his typical use of 'final' and 'ultimate', the constant rhetorical companions of a certain journalistic urgency, were it not for the apocalypse which they so certainly announce. This vision, I would argue, derives from Virilio's misunderstanding of the nature of mediation in general and network communications in particular, a misunderstanding that limits his analysis to the existential position of the individual. 'The thing described takes over from the real thing' (Virilio, 1995a: 43) in the politics of disinformation, indeed the 'essential culture of disinformation' (Virilio, 1995a: 61). This substitution or commutation of virtual for physical proximity reduces to zero that distance which, for Virilio, is constitutive of human identity: the distance between observer and observed, subject and object. Disinformation is then the creation of a fiction in which the world is no longer object over against the subject, but simply a malleable and consumable entity, almost a Heideggerian 'standing-reserve'. But this analysis, once again like Baudrillard's, derives from a sense that the business of mediation is representation. When, as he believes, representation ceases to evoke a real world of immediate perception, the representational media also curtail the possibility of democratic representation.

Liberalism is a philosophy founded in individual identity. In Virilio's pessimistic liberal anarchism, the crisis of representation occurs in the essential subject–object relation though which identity marks itself off from the world and the others. But mediation is not representation: media serve to mediate, not between subjects and objects, but between subjects. This conclusion, already adumbrated in the theory of suture, provides us with the grounds for a social theory of mediation. Screen-theoretical work argues that identity, individuality and subjectivity are constructed, in a mediated society, through mediation. Individuality is then an end product of the mediation process, not its foundation. It is Virilio's imaginary embattled individual, clinging to identity in the face of technology, that grounds his more paranoid Jeremiads, and blinds him to the mutuality involved in media productivity. Where Virilio sees only the diminution and vanishing of subjectivity, the theory of suture allows us to understand subject formation as always already ephemeral, the always temporary and contingent structure of the self in the experience of media. What is being lost in the acceleration

of communications media is only a historically specific mode of subjectivity, not subjectivity as such. It is only the individual – along with such perquisites as freedom and privacy – which disappears, faced with the new necessity for a blurred boundary between the public and, for lack of the private, the intimate sphere of what perhaps we can still refer to as the unconscious. This unconscious, however, is framed less by the individuation process of the bourgeois family, and more by the interactive, fluid subjectivities of online communities. In a rare moment of positivity, Virilio concludes a 1995 article by suggesting that:

> We have to acknowledge that the new communication technologies will only further democracy if, and only if, we oppose from the beginning the caricature of global society being hatched for us by big multinational corporations throwing themselves at a breakneck pace on the information superhighways. (Virilio, 1995b: np)

It is an unusual moment in which the possibility of political action is entertained,[1] and the opening up of this possibility comes from the equally unusual suggestion of a 'we': a community of the like-minded. It is also surprising to find Virilio recognizing that there are other agencies beyond self-activating technological change, and that the capitalization of online communications is, at least in the short-term, the major threat to the democratic capabilities of the net. The lack of such hopeful eschatologies among his major statements is a direct consequence of the grounding of his philosophical liberalism in the theory of representation.

I cited earlier Virilio's rewriting of Kipling, equating war's first casualty, truth, with the casualty reality. The slippage is effected, once again, by dependence on representation theory, in which the key function of signification is to establish referential links between subject and object. This surely sits well with the definitions of communication offered by contemporary cognitive science and information theory, for which the mathematics of communication systems and the metaphor of mind as computer both rely on the concept of signal as datum, byte or unit of information. But from the point of view of media theory, emphasis on reference ignores the centrality to mediated communication of the phatic, the establishment of social and cultural solidarity in dialogue, as when we ask almost content-free questions like 'How are you?' From the standpoint of a mediation theory, the history of the phatic mode includes the history of exclusions from communicative solidarity, the denial of their presence and the turn towards re-presenting them as objects external to the world of communication. In fact, I believe it is quite possible to argue that the phatic is the central function of communication, to the point that even the exchange of orders or information are modes of phatic solidarity. Emphasizing the phatic suggests that the truth-content of messages is not necessarily restricted to their content but to their address. It is curious in this context that Virilio, normally so attentive to shifting technologies, centres so much of his attention on production and

transmission technologies, and so little on the structure of distribution. It is distribution which holds the key to the massification of the media, from the film exchanges that gave rise to the Hollywood studios (see Gomery, 1992) to the global ambitions of the Microsoft Channel. Distribution not only focuses on the address to audiences, both in marketing and in such day-to-day rhetorical truisms as 'We bring you live pictures' or 'Thank you for welcoming us into your home', with their implicit announcement of power relations, and also in the address characteristic of specific technologies like the Internet browser window or the layout of newspaper pages. It also draws us back to the relationships between people which appear, from Virilio's liberal point of view, as the magical relation between objects, specifically the vanishing world and the ever-more present media.

Virilio's theory of representation appears to rest rather specifically on a concept of truth as total and complete, and completely identified with the existence of a pre-existing world, a unity only ruptured by its communication. Virilio's position is not only liberal but humanist, a humanism arising from a Christian phenomenology curiously akin to that of realist film critic André Bazin. In *The Vision Machine*, Virilio addresses the intersection of militarization and representation in terms of 'the logistics of perception':

> It is a war of images and sounds, rather than objects and things, in which winning is simply a matter of not losing sight of the opposition. The will to see all, to know all, at every moment, everywhere, the will to universalised illumination: a scientific permutation on the eye of God which would forever rule out the surprise, the accident, the irruption of the unforeseen. (Virilio, 1994: 70)

War has changed, in the era of Stealth bombers and smart weapons, by a process of absolute acceleration, from the face-to-face struggle for occupation of physical space to a thoroughly mediated struggle for absolute surveillance. This absolute surveillance and its counter, camouflage and deception, are extended to the politics of the militarized state. In the meantime, visual media accelerated to the point of instantaneity have altered the terms of perception, through the ambition to emulate God, in the erasure of the contingent which marks the perception of reality.

In Virilio's terms, mediation eradicates first the substance, the immutable essence of objects and later, in a second movement from mechanical to electronic media, obliterates even the *accidence*, the material form in which substance presents itself to perception. The reality of an object's image is thus displacing the virtuality of its presence (Virilio, 1994: 64); that is, in transmission, even the materiality of the image is substituted in a process of virtualization in some ways the offspring of military dissimulation. We are then faced with the 'fusion of the object with its equivalent image' (Virilio, 1994: 68) tending towards 'an artificial reality involving digital simulation

that would oppose the "natural reality" of classical experience' (Virilio, 1994: 76).

Here, as throughout his work, Virilio depends upon a belief in the wholeness of perception independent of cognition. This depends upon (1) a whole event or state of affairs in the world which is (2) simultaneous with (3) a whole perception of that state of affairs. This phenomenology of perception, which appears to derive from Husserl, shares Husserl's dilemma over the relation between perception, memory (retentions) and expectation (protensions). Immediate perception is allied, in both Husserl and Virilio, with temporal and spatial contiguity and with instantaneous and mutual wholeness of both perception and perceived. Yet the duration introduced by cognitive functions of retention and protension shatters the wholeness of both. Virilio correctly notes that mediated perception does not share this immediacy. However, since he does not believe that perception is in every case mediated, both by the phenomenal aspect that the perceived takes on in the moment of perception, and by the retentions and protensions of the perceiver, he understands mediation as a fall from grace, from a natural perception which, in its integration of human and world, provided the basis of human identity. He is therefore free to declare that higher degrees and velocities of mechanical perception are the phenomenal form of a collapse of both humanity and reality, 'as though our society were sinking into the darkness of a voluntary blindness' (Virilio, 1994: 76).

To turn Virilio on his head, it is sufficient to point out, as Derrida does in his critique of Husserlian phenomenology of perception (1973: 60–9), that consciousness has no present. Moreover, since the world itself is never self-present either, perception is already mediation. This is not to say that we should therefore embrace uncritically the loss of human identity, or that we should abandon the Bazinian project for a cinema in which 'life might ... be the self into which film finally changes it' (Bazin, 1971: 82) . It does suggest, however, that we proceed beyond a state in which social relations appear in 'the fantastical form of relations between things' (Marx, 1976: 165). As Linda Brigham argued in the excellent Special Issue of the online journal *Speed* devoted to his work, like Habermas Virilio interrogates 'the social effects of media in terms of their relation to a prior social and perceptual condition' (Brigham, 1995: np). But communication is not about the recuperation of some prior truth of things, but rather a perpetual and mutual building and negotiation of truth, reality and subjectivity. Virilio's representation theory understands truth as an impossibly total content of communication: that is why it is perpetually disappointed, or forced to confront the human impossibility of rendering in mediated form the totality of truth associated with an object. But if instead we were to direct attention towards the distributive moment, with its extended labour performed on the materials of mediation, we find instead that truth is always partial, always postponed and always negotiated, while offering also an understanding of the strategic structural domination practised by the mega-corporations of the infotainment industries over the distributive media. If it seems niggling

to correct Virilio's description of new computer-mediated communication as 'instantaneous', it is an important detail, most of all because the time needed to download a file is the temporal intervention into the mediation process of the labour time necessary to compose, store and decode its content. If it is a key job of commercial media to disguise the processes of their production, the very delay of distribution channels nonetheless bring back to us the labour involved in their making.

Without an understanding of the control structures of the media industries, Virilio is cast back on the meagre resources of the isolated individual, unsurprisingly now envisioned as the stunned receiver of a vast, unintelligible, real-time data-stream. At such a juncture, '*Vision, once substantial, becomes accidental*' (Virilio, 1994: 13; original emphasis). This slogan carries with it the double meanings of substance and accident, read in the light of Nicholas de Cusa (Virilio, 1997: 17). If, as appears here, the substance is the truth of the object, then the truth lost in digital representations is that ideal form that precedes and exceeds the limits of the mundane, while *accidence*, which is all that can be captured in photo-mechanical or opto-electronic media, is the merely ephemeral and worldly. Yet this ephemerality and worldliness are surely the most significantly material aspects of the object, not least because they give the lie to the thing-in-itself, and require us to speak of its appearance to some other, that is, its dependence on its subject or, in a mediated world, its dependence on its mediation. In this sense objects exist, as objects, only as mediations, only as they signify in relations between people

For Virilio, on the contrary, the triumph of ephemeral appearance is a sign of the abolition of the weight, mass, bulk and depth of truth. Their obdurate otherness, their truth, gave objects a position relative to subjects that they have lost in the instantaneity of transmission. Without that relative position, accident takes on its second meaning, of catastrophe. Ungoverned now by truth, rendered into the quantum fluctuations of hypermedia, appearances circulating at unheard-of speeds bring us to the brink of info-war and data-crash. Such is Virilio's account of the 1989 Black Friday crash, which he reads as the uncontrolled acceleration of machine-driven trading in derealized stocks and shares, rather than as a function of anarchic capital. Likewise, hacker hits on power supplies and databanks appear to him as the disaster which is always invented at the same moment as the vehicle, in the same way that derailments and wrecks are the necessary accompaniment of trains and cars. The 'general accident' (Virilio, 1997: 132) will prove Virilio right in the moment that it makes all statements of truth or probability impossible. The insubstantial will, in that moment of wreckage, ruin the substance of the world, homogenizing all differences previously guaranteed by the distance between objects and subjects.

If, however, we deny to Virilio his philosophical liberalism and his ontological substance, what can we draw from his poetics of transmission? Reversing his evaluation of the changing nature of mediation, we can take a conception of the new centrality of the ephemeral in human affairs. The true

difference between computer-mediated communications and the older forms of print and photo-mechanical media is that the heart of computer media lies in distribution, not recording. The storage media associated with computers are notoriously liable to corruption and infection. The only hope for permanence is in proliferation of copies, that is, in the distribution of texts across a variety of media and machines. But even this belies the capacity of computer files to be overwritten: corrected, discussed, amended or erased. Like the death of privacy, the end of permanence is a frightening effect of new media, one that drives Virilio to distraction. Yet in that vertiginous impossibility of archiving the world's Internet traffic, we confront not the desecration of the temple of learning, but the avenue of escape from the Foucauldian archive. It is that archive, as much as the phenomenological *Umwelt*, that constitutes the horizon of the self, whose loss Virilio so greatly mourns, but which from a different viewpoint becomes a crucial act of emancipation.

We can also, I believe, abstract from his description of the collapsing gap between subject and object a vision of the increasing integration of subject with subject in the mediation of objects. Neither cognitive science nor phenomenology allows for the socialization of subjectivity in a mediated world: the challenge remains to provide such a social psychology and social phenomenology in the pursuit of a sociology of communication that recognizes its centrality, as Virilio does, but also permits intervention and creativity. The old liberal-anarchist tirades against state and technology cannot bring us a politics adequate to the new media formations. That task remains to be undertaken. But here again Virilio does give us some avenues to explore, most of all in his work on memory. Noting the movement from older theories of retinal retention to the theory of cognitive schemata in the formation of memory, he insists on 'the role of memorisation in immediate perception' (Virilio, 1994: 61). Such instantaneous memorization, demanded by the flicker of images at 24 or 25 frames per second, allows both for subliminal effects – a theory to which Virilio is almost alone in clinging – and an editing of vision in the breaks between frames, producing a virtual memory of virtual objects. On the one hand, this will lead Virilio to worry at the emergence of prospective simulations, computer models devised in order to foresee, such as Geographical Information Systems (GIS). This is a genuine fear: the purpose of computer simulations is an extension of business plans and Soviet 5-year plans: the administration of the future according to the dictates of the present. But Virilio also recognizes, on the other hand, that 'The weak light that allows us to apprehend the real, to see and understand our present environment, itself comes from a distant visual memory without which there would be no act of looking' (Virilio, 1994: 62). What now guides his anxiety is not the fact of memorization, which in any case shapes even direct perception, but the transfer of visual memory from the human sensorium to mechanical perception.

The loss of a guiding 'distant visual memory' might be likened to a process in which we lost the ability to recognize the picturesque,

painting-like quality of a landscape. One of the guiding themes of modernist art, indeed, is the elaboration of visual and verbal strategies to provoke a renewal of habituated vision. One of the most important single works of modernism, Duchamp's *Large Glass* (also known as *The Bride Stripped Bare by her Bachelors, Even*) of 1917–22, works along this fault-line of modernist mediated vision in a particularly fascinating way, eroticizing the gaze between the bachelors in the lower half and the bride in the upper, mechanizing the look through the intervention of fantastic machineries of desire, and capturing the whole fantastical narration in a variety of media which, in their physical materials and their dependence on chance techniques, vividly capture the aporias of photography. One of the work's titles, *Delay in Glass*, can surely be read as a direct reference to glass-plate photography and the capture not only of light but of time, postponing its emergence back into the world. What Duchamp manages that Virilio does not, apart from his profound understanding of the implication of gender in visual technologies, is his readiness to surrender rational control. What, after all, is the purpose of GIS simulations if not rational control over the future environment? Duchamp, by contrast, demonstrates in a practical way the impossibility of exercising control even over the past. The apparatus for Duchamp as for Virilio takes on a life of its own. But in Duchamp's version, that life is one which can be respected as an authentic contribution to dialogue, the active participation of the machineries of mediation in the mediative process between humans. Where Virilio lives in terror of the mechanical take-over of human activities, Duchamp points us towards the necessary realization that we are already in dialogue with our devices.

Our machines, now more than ever, constitute our environment. Where Virilio imagines a pre-media innocence of perception, always already lost to mediated humanity, he projects a curiously passive relation into the monologue of self and object, in which the object addresses the self, throwing itself before it, seeking in the self a completion of its truth. The Duchamp perspective suggests instead that there is a partnership between us and our technologies, an assimilation of our conventions into the technologies, and of their conventions into us, but in a dialogue in which both are subject to constant negotiation and change. This is not to say that the military and commercial applications of technological research have not had immense repercussions on the nature and functioning of such familiar gadgets as the desktop computer: the crushing individualism of the design of the typewriter keyboard, mouse and graphical user interface in the interests of office automation rather than commonality of communication is a case in point. But it is also true that our relations with technologies are as complexly negotiated as our relationships with films, novels or philosophies; that we jury-rig our sense of minute-by-minute existence and our world-views out of the interactions we have with a world constituted as much by the materiality of the media as by the physical environment of which they form so salient a characteristic.

The spectacular eradication of distance is exactly that: spectacular.

And as with a Hollywood special effects blockbuster, our attention is split between the illusion and the spectacular craft that makes the illusion possible. That divorce is typical of our dialogue with the uncanny intelligence of machines (and of course their equally uncanny ability to go wrong). For Virilio, there is no dialogue, only resistance to media technologies that have become forces of history: 'How', he asks, 'can we resist this deluge of visual and audiovisual sequences, the sudden *motorization of appearances* that endlessly bombard our imagination?' (Virilio, 1997: 96). Subjectivity, once formed in relation to objectivity, is now constituted in relation to mediation. The process appears to him one-sided, with the techno-logic of militarization and endo-colonialism enforcing the ongoing, yet final process of dehumanization. The only alternative is to turn away from mediation, 'out of a concern to preserve one's integrity, one's *freedom of conscience*' (Virilio, 1997: 96), a term which in French means both moral standards and consciousness. One warms to his dogged refusal of cybertopian optimism, to his crying out against the abuse of power in the design and delivery of technologically mediated perception. But it is inadequate to refuse technologization, to appeal to a pre-technological 'ethics of immediate perception' (Virilio, 1997: 102), or to refuse that mediation which, in the contemporary world, is the material form taken by our solidarity with others in the interests of an imaginary free consciousness. For all its perversion in the interests of transnational capital and the imperialism of finance, mediation is the condition in which we live, and which in many respects has forced us, in the globalization as well as the mediation process, away from the philosophy of individual will into deeper mutual dependency, and a consequent surrender of individual freedom in the interests of a human ecology. In order to understand the processes through which we are living, and to develop tactical means for intervening in the macro-scale organization of communications in a critical moment of their evolution, more is required than philosophical nihilism.

To take an example where Virilio's analysis is extremely informative, the private automobile is without doubt the single most deleterious innovation of the last century, even more so than the military technologies deployed in wars too often begun to secure supplies of fuel for them. Motorists are careless of the ecological effect of the noxious fumes expelled by their vehicles, despite the fact that their own children suffer from the respiratory diseases they cause, just as they claim innocence for the oil spills attendant on the trade in petrol. The car instils in its driver and passengers that sense of right and invulnerability that is responsible for so many deaths. It inscribes in the motorist the expectation of surveillance. It travels far faster than the human sensorium can cope with. Few people would batter an animal to death in cold blood, but roadkill is considered an acceptable by-product of the right to speed. It is a device which isolates the driver from the world, transforming it into pure trajectory and removing all but the most rudimentary communication with others, consisting solely of signals concerning direction and velocity. The motorway, not the

mediasphere, is the scene of picnolepsia, the suspended consciousness of auto-pilot driving. The non-space of the car's interior, underwritten by its isolating soundtrack of radio and recorded music, abstracts from the unplan-able environment of populations and weather. Inscribed in discourses as various as marketing campaigns and Chuck Berry songs as the individualist icon of freedom and mastery, the motor is in fact quite the opposite: a device for immobilization and subjection. Its reality is neither the open road nor the moment of arrival but the horizonless no-man's-land of the traffic jam. Yet it would be absurd to accept this nightmare as either historical necessity or unchallengably hegemonic. From Greenpeace to Reclaim the Streets, the incompetent ugliness of private cars is challenged globally. One can hope for its eventual demise.

Perhaps this ecological catastrophe is easier to fight than the process of mediation: more obvious, more dangerous, more tangible. In transport there is a single technology against which to rail: we are so interwoven in mediation that no act of sabotage can break our need to communicate. To develop beyond pessimism, we need not only the essayistic media theory of Virilio's vibrant gloom: we need the meticulous scholarship on which he draws, that analyses the detailed history of the new technologies as well as the old, work now being undertaken in the histories of radio, television and cinema but still in its infancy in terms of networked and digital media (though see Edwards, 1996, on Internet historiography and Curry, 1998: 59–86 for a critical history of an extremely germane digital technology). We need to understand the economic rationales and design philosophies that enter into the construction of new technologies. But most of all we need to grasp the nettle of principled analysis: that as the world changes, nostalgia for a lost innocence is no grounds for critique or politics. Virilio at the very least offers us the opportunity, indeed demands that we reflect upon the urgent necessity, for an ethical grounding of our coming to terms with the new media.

I have tried to show that Virilio's liberal humanism, his reliance on theories of representation and, most of all, his philosophical individualism, have hampered his ability to provide a telling analysis and prognosis in the new media field. But I hope that I have also shown that re-reading his scenarios of disempowerment and indifferentiation in the light of concepts of dialogue, communication and mediation can provide us with a way of drawing from his works a sense of the ethical demands placed on us by the technologization of community. Apocalypse is not the only possible future. Even if it were, we are ethically bound to act as if it were not. As the old revolutionary has it, pessimism of the intellect; optimism of the will.

Note

1. Virilio has been an active participant in anti-racist and homeless struggles in France: it is his writing which tends towards political quietism. Like many of his contemporaries, notably Deleuze and Guattari and Jean Baudrillard, Virilio tends to see the state as the villain of the piece, a view that normally denies him access to

analysis of the globalized capitalist enterprise as central player in new media technologies.

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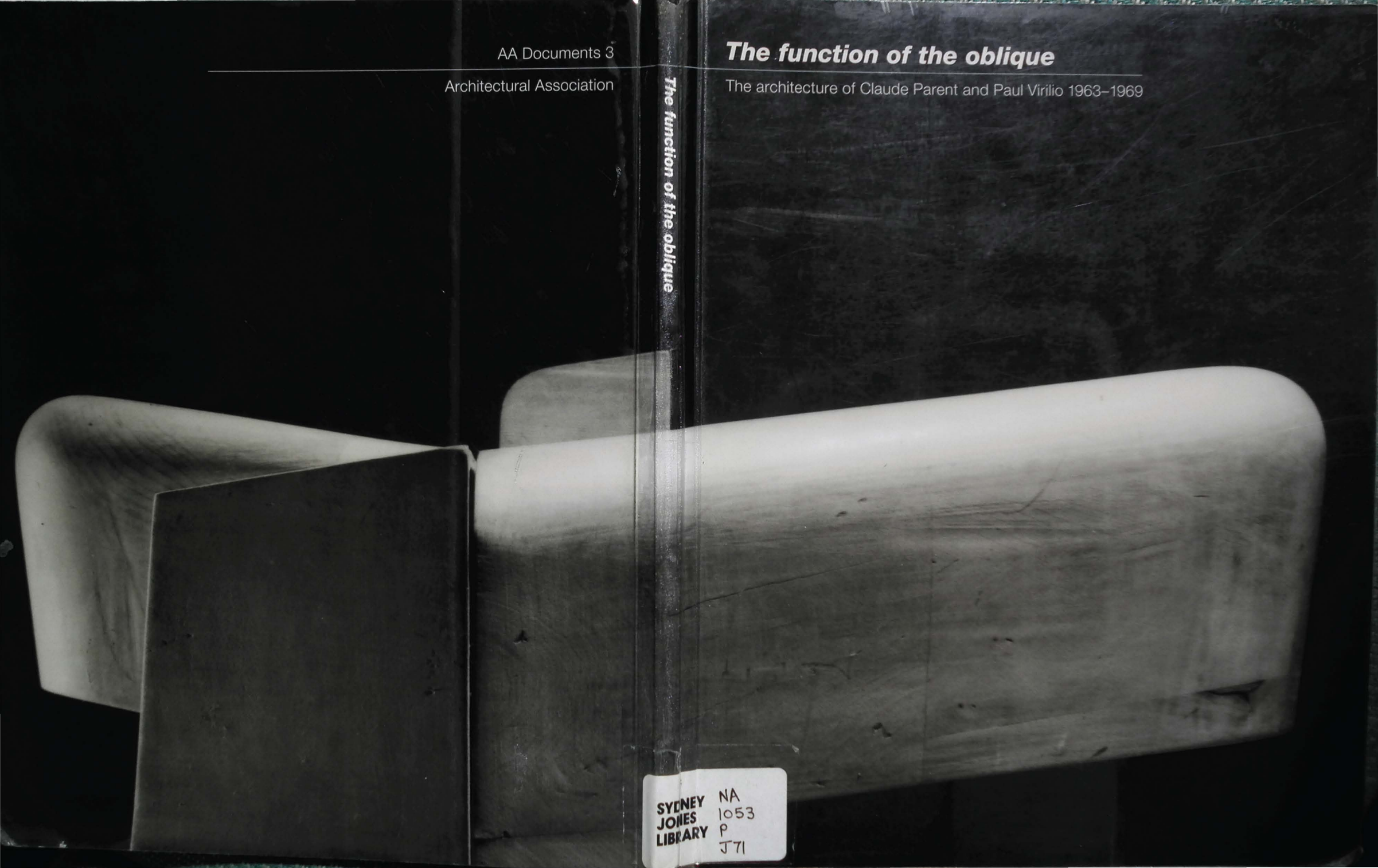
AA Documents 3

Architectural Association

The function of the oblique

The architecture of Claude Parent and Paul Virilio 1963–1969



The function of the oblique

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Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1964–6.
Photograph: Pierre Bérenger.

Contents

5 Introduction
Jacques Lucan

11 Architecture Principe
Paul Virilio

14 A critical modernity
Claude Parent

Projects

16 *Church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay, Nevers*

32 *Charleville Cultural Centre*

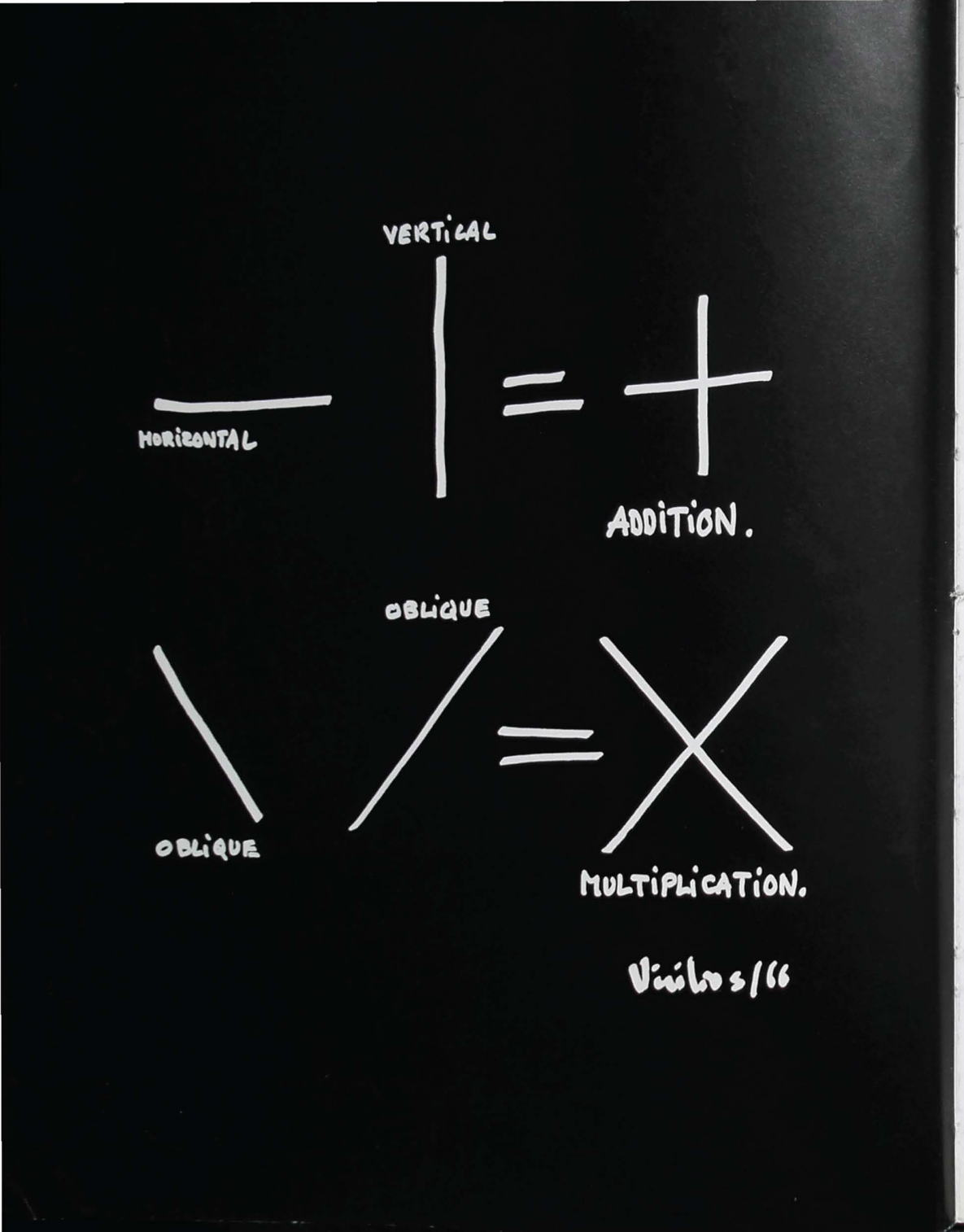
36 *Oblique houses: Drusch, Mariotti and Woog*

49 Interview with Claude Parent
Irénée Scalbert and Mohsen Mostafavi

59 The definition of a critical architecture
Frédéric Migayrou

64 Architecture Principe
Texts from the manifesto-magazine

72 Selected bibliography



Introduction

Jacques Lucan

In 1963 Claude Parent and Paul Virilio formed the Architecture Principe group[1] with the aim of investigating a new kind of architectural and urban order. Rejecting the two fundamental directions of Euclidean space, they proclaimed 'the end of the vertical as the axis of elevation'[2] and 'the end of the horizontal as the permanent plane'[3]: Out With Manhattan, Out With Old Villages. In place of the right angle, they adopted 'the function of the oblique', which they believed would have the benefit of multiplying usable space. Their explication of this principle, with its accompanying ideogram, frequently provoked a smile: the crossing of horizontal and vertical results in an addition sign; the crossing of two obliques results in a multiplication sign.

But what exactly was 'the function of the oblique'? For the Architecture Principe group, it was a new means of appropriating space, very much inspired by a *Gestalt* psychology of form, which promoted continuous, fluid movement and forced the body to adapt to instability: 'While the enclosed and the cryptic lie at the origins of this new era of architecture … we must also recognize within the sense of disequilibrium, of vertigo, the second archetype of this art of space.'[4]

Parent and Virilio's experimental and provocative research, which was not without its obscure points, found concrete form in the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay at Nevers (1964–6).

As Paul Virilio himself acknowledges, the church is more an 'engineered structure' than a 'work of art'.[5] Inward-looking, with rough concrete walls and rounded-off corners, it was inspired by the German bunkers of the Atlantic Wall, which were a source of fascination for Virilio.[6] Its massive cantilevers induce a sense of disequilibrium which is exaggerated by the tilting of its floors – a tangible sign of 'the function of the oblique': '…we wanted above all to create an "ordinary place" where experimentation replaces contemplation, where the architecture is experienced through movement and the quality of that movement.'[7]

The purpose of the oblique was to encourage a constant awareness of gravity, bringing the body into a tactile relationship with the building. The qualities of the architecture were to be perceived in a sensitive, sensual manner, as people became free to move beyond conventional spatial situations. Oblique planes were used in a prototype for a luxury apartment, to create ideal surfaces for repose of a nonchalant, sophisticated nature – something which, in 1968, was very much in keeping with the mood of the times. But the approach was developed further with the idea of 'interlacing the oblique'.

Left: Paul Virilio's ideogram of the function of the oblique, from *Architecture Principe* magazine, 3, April 1966.

Above: Fortification on the Atlantic Wall, from Paul Virilio's *Bunker Archéologie*, 1991.

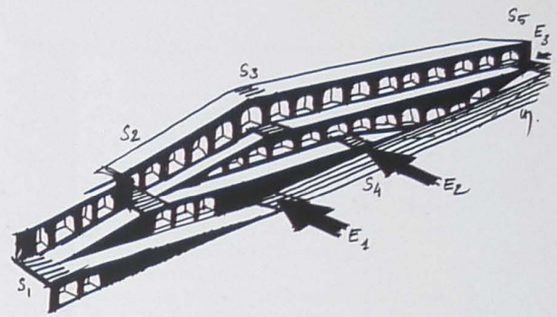
Right: Church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay, Nevers. Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1964–6.

This engendered, most significantly, the shopping centre in Sens (1970), in which the shops open onto ramps almost 120 metres long, and the French Pavilion for the 1970 Venice Biennale, an 'oblique space' created by Claude Parent in collaboration with a number of artists. By this time Parent was no longer working with Virilio: the month of May 1968 had exposed political differences which spelled the end of the Architecture Principe group. Virilio actively participated in the 'events'; Parent reproached him for this.

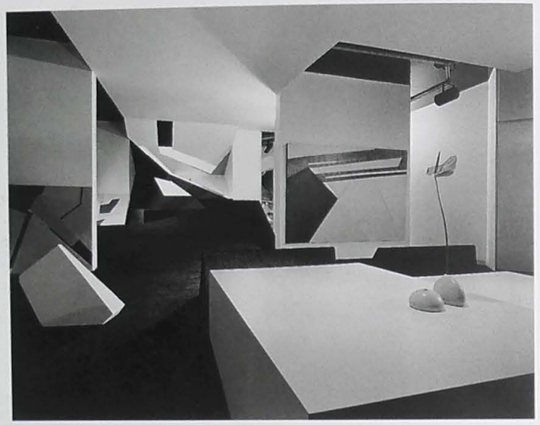
The collaboration lasted, in effect, five years. How far did its influence extend? Let us note, first, that Bruno Zevi followed the group's activities throughout its existence, and in 1973 devoted a special issue of *L'Architettura* to Claude Parent.[9] It also found favour in Spain, and several major features on its work were published in the Madrid magazine *Nueva Forma*, edited by Daniel Fullaondo.[10] In France the influence of the group may be traced through its members' subsequent careers.

While Paul Virilio, since 1968, has focused exclusively on theory and teaching, Claude Parent has pursued the practice of architecture, and has produced numerous buildings that go beyond the exploitation of the principles of the oblique. His architecture is typically wilful and assertive, and at times violent and provocative. The forms are dense, often sculpturally full, stretching the enclosing volumes to the point where an indivisible continuity of elements is achieved. Parent is a virtuoso in the use not only of metal, as in his 'structurally brutalist'[11] student housing in Paris (Maison de l'Iran, 1961–9, with Mohsen Foroughi, Heydar Ghiai and André Bloc), but also of reinforced concrete, which he shapes into massive walls and surfaces that enhance the building's unity and the closure of its form.

At a time when there is much talk of flexibility, openness and mobility, Claude Parent appears to be swimming against the tide in proposing fixed, monumental, almost immutable structures which



Shopping centre, Sens. Claude Parent, 1970.



Right: Bellaguet apartment, Neuilly. Claude Parent, 1970.

Below: The French Pavilion at the 1970 Venice Biennale. Claude Parent, architect/curator, with Andrée Bellaguet, painter; Gérard Mannoni, sculptor; Jean-Pierre Cousin and Gilles Ehrmann, photographers.

resolutely maintain a distance from their surroundings. Such aloofness is ill suited to the realities of large-scale urban development. Indeed, Parent has never built a major housing project, and he has offered little more than utopian visions of the city of the future: 'The only worthwhile method is ... to incite residents to "abandon" existing villages by offering them nodes of urban facilities set at distant intervals from each other."[12]

Yet it is undeniable that he has influenced certain architects, among them Jean Nouvel, who worked for a long time in his office during the late 1960s. In 1973 Nouvel designed a building according to 'the function of the oblique': the Delbigot house at Villeneuve-sur-Lot (with François Seigneur and Roland Baltera). More significantly, however, he has adopted Parent's idea of the architectural form as a closed entity – a disturbing and singular object folding back on itself. This conception is reflected in projects such as his competition entry for the Tokyo National Theatre (1986).[13] As with the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay, the exterior of Nouvel's theatre reveals little about what is unfolding inside; the massive building envelope seems to contain, almost to constrain, spaces that are on the point of eruption.

Parent and Virilio's church and Nouvel's theatre are being exhibited together in the French Pavilion at the 1996 Venice Biennale of Architecture, which takes as its theme 'the fractured monolith', and explores the impact of the architecture-sculpture movement in France.

Notes

1 The painter Michel Carrade and sculptor Morice Lipsi were also members of the Architecture Principe group, but only Claude Parent and Paul Virilio put their signatures to the articles in the magazine which constituted its 'permanent manifesto'.

2 Paul Virilio, 'La fonction oblique', in *Architecture Principe*, 1, February 1966.

3 Ibid.

4 Paul Virilio, 'Instabilisation', in *Architecture Principe*, 3, April 1966.

5 Paul Virilio, 'Nevers chantier', in *Architecture Principe*, 4, May–June 1966. Virilio wrote that the church was 'un ouvrage d'art' rather than 'un œuvre d'art': the French has a ring which is lost in translation.

6 Virilio has devoted two books and an exhibition to the subject of German bunkers. See, in particular, *Bunker Archéologie* (Demi-Cercle, 1991). English edition: *Bunker Archeology* (Princeton Architectural Press, 1994).

7 Paul Virilio, 'Nevers chantier'.

8 'The interlacing of the oblique' – *Entrelacs de l'oblique* – was also the title of a book which coupled Parent's most important projects with his futuristic drawings (Editions du Moniteur, 1981).

9 *L'Architettura*, 208, February 1973, 'Claude Parent', with an article by Ionel Schein: 'Claude Parent ou la nécessité d'être architecte'.

10 See *Nueva Forma*, 25, February 1968; 26, March 1968; 28, May 1968. The projects featured in these issues were republished in July 1968 in a single volume: 'Claude Parent, Paul Virilio, 1955–1968'. *Nueva Forma* devoted further articles to André Bloc and Claude Parent: 50, March 1970; and to Claude Parent alone, 78–79, July–August 1972.

11 The term is borrowed from *Nueva Forma*, 28, May 1968, which described the work as *'brutalismo estructural'*.

12 In *Architecture d'Aujourd'hui*, 138, June–July 1968.

13 For more on the Charleville project, see 'Charleville étude', in *Architecture Principe*, 9, dated December 1966, but not published till December 1977. For the Tokyo National Theatre project, see Jean Nouvel et Associés, Philippe Starck, *Nouveau théâtre national de Tokyo* (Champ Vallon/Seyssel, 1987).

Architecture Principe

Paul Virilio

Claude Parent (left) and Paul Virilio (right) in the 1960s.

I formed the Architecture Principe group in 1963, along with the architect Claude Parent, the painter Michel Carrade and the sculptor Morice Lipsi. Such multidisciplinary groups were in vogue at the beginning of the 1960s, and Claude Parent himself collaborated in several, including the Espace group founded by André Bloc.

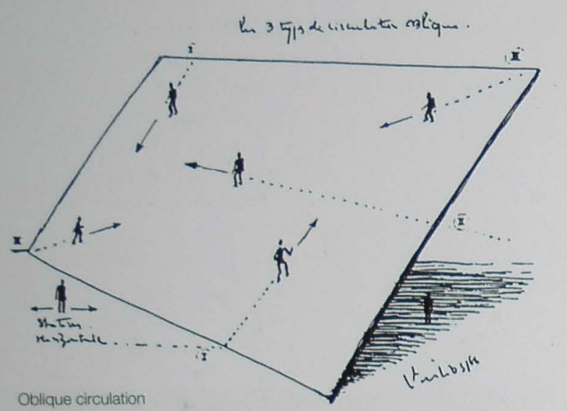
My own research at the time was devoted to the architecture of Second World War bunkers. Since 1958 I had been studying not only the blockhouses of the Atlantic Wall and the Siegfried and Maginot lines, but also the military spaces of what was known as 'Fortress Europe', with its rocket-launching sites, air-defence systems, autobahns and radar stations.[1] This was an archaeological study, and a personal one, motivated by the desire to uncover the geostrategic and geopolitical foundations of the total war I had lived through as a young boy in Nantes, not far from the submarine base of Saint-Nazaire.[2] For me, the architecture of war made palpable the power of technology – and the now infinite power of destruction.

In my efforts to understand the spaces of conflict, I drew on *Gestalt* theory – the psychology of form and the phenomenology of perception. This approach revealed the extreme importance of the LOGISTICS (and fluxes) of circulation during the Blitzkrieg, and enabled me to realize the effect of the BALLISTICS of different projectiles on the configuration of contemporary military architecture.[3]

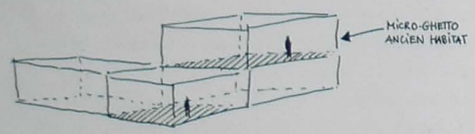
Already during that time, I was exploring in a number of experimental designs the possibility of a TOPOLOGICAL or at least non-orthogonal architecture. I was also working as a painter. I had made some stained-glass windows for churches, helping to execute Matisse's designs for Saint-Paul de Vence and those of Braque for Varengeville. It was through these connections in the domain of sacred art that I obtained the commission for the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay in Nevers, which was built between 1964 and 1966 by Claude Parent and myself.

The Nevers church was followed by projects for the cultural centre in Charleville and the Mariotti house in Saint-Germain-en-Laye, which unfortunately were never built. The Thomson-Houston Aerospace Centre in Vélizy-Villacoublay, however, was successfully completed at the very end of our collaboration, in 1968/9, thanks to the good working relationship that I had with the engineer, Rami-Méziane.

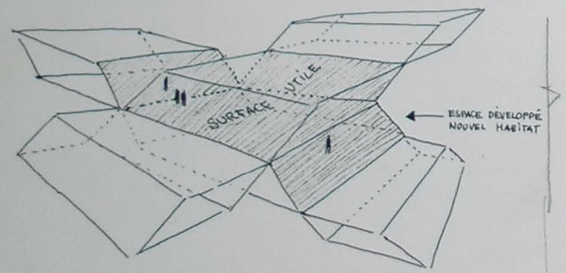
In addition to these projects, it is important to mention the full-scale experimental model of an elevated oblique structure, 'The Pendular Destabilizer no. 1', that we set up at the University of Nanterre. It was our intention to live for several weeks within



Oblique circulation



Habitable stasis



Habitable circulation

this structure, in an attempt to test the equilibrium and habitability of inclined slopes and to determine the best choice of angles for the different living spaces. But the 'events' of May 1968 – which began, as everyone knows, on the campus of Nanterre – effectively put a stop to our *psycho-physiological* experiment.

However, the most important work of the group is to be found elsewhere, in the development of the theory known as THE FUNCTION OF THE OBLIQUE... To elaborate the theory, it was absolutely essential to have a publication, a 'manifesto' – hence *Architecture Principe*, nine issues in total, edited jointly by me and Claude Parent, from 1966 on. That was thirty years ago.[4]

'The function of the oblique' had its origins in the concepts of disequilibrium and motive instability. The idea of using the earth's gravity as a motor for movement inspired a very Galilean utilization of the INCLINED PLANE – a building form in which the horizontal was used only as a means of establishing a 'threshold' between two slopes.

After the HORIZONTAL order of the rural habitat in the agricultural era, and the VERTICAL order of the urban habitat in the industrial era, the next logical (or, rather, topological) step was for us the OBLIQUE order of the post-industrial era.

To achieve this, it was necessary to discard the notion of the *vertical enclosure*, whose walls are made inaccessible by gravity, and to *define habitable space by means of wholly accessible inclined planes*, thereby increasing the usable surface areas. This was, in essence, the principle of HABITABLE CIRCULATION.

In contrast to partitions or vertical walls, which provoke an opposition between *in front* and *behind*, a combination of oblique and horizontal planes would result only in *above* and *below*; surface and soffit. Thus the artificial ground of the dwelling would become a LIVING GROUND enclosing all the various articles that are required for domestic life.[5]

By setting the structure on an incline, and by making every part of the built surface (except for the underside) habitable and accessible, *the range of truly habitable spaces would be considerably increased*, at the scale of both the individual dwelling and the building as a whole, since the vertical facade would also cease to exist.

The objective of our research was to challenge outright the *anthropometric precepts of the classical era* – the idea of the body as an essentially static entity with an essentially static proprioception – in order to bring the human habitat into a dynamic age of the body in movement. In our work, the *traditional stability* (habitable stasis) of both the rural horizontal order and the urban vertical order gave way to the METASTABILITY (habitable circulation) of the human body in motion, in tune with the rhythms of life. The space of the body became MOBILE. The limbs of the individual became MOTIVE. And the inhabitant effectively became LOCOMOTIVE, propelled by the (relative) disequilibrium created by the gravity of planet earth, the habitat of our species.

Oblique architecture thus became a *generator of activity* which used physiological principles to make buildings more habitable. 'It is not the eye which sees', according to the philosopher Maurice Merleau-Ponty, but *'the body as a receptive totality'*.

The typology of the inclined plane, by increasing usable surface space, also preserved that rare and extremely precious commodity: real space, as distinct from the space of the atmosphere or the liquid element of the hydrosphere.

In the work of the group, the 'making of the architectural OBJECT' was superseded by the 'making of the JOURNEY'; the classical building finally gave way to the *bridging structure*, which, through the non-Euclidean geometry of its large inclined arches, allowed the full expanse of the landscape to unfold.[6]

In this regard, I should indicate that the illustrations in the *Architecture Principe* magazine were obviously not of architectural or even urbanistic projects, but were simply statements of PRINCIPLE – concepts intended to outline the theory of 'habitable circulation' (with theory, in this instance, remaining true to its origins in the Greek *theoria*, which means both 'procession' (parade) and 'process').

In conclusion, I would like to mention that my interest in the oblique extended beyond the limits of my collaboration with Claude Parent. After I became co-director (with Anatole Kopp) of the Ecole Spéciale d'Architecture in Paris in 1972, my teaching concentrated on the development of technical research into the organization and the precise morphology of oblique volumes. Several student theses were devoted to this theme, but after a few years the overwhelming difficulties of building an oblique habitat led us to abandon this work, which seemed to offer no practical benefit to young architects starting out in the working world.

Since being forced to abandon the SPACE of the oblique, I have devoted myself to TIME – or more precisely to the diverse phenomena of acceleration in this era of the 'global village'. The focus of my research has shifted from TOPOLOGY to DROMOLOGY, i.e. the study and analysis of the impact of the increasing speed of transport and communications on the development of land-use. But that, as they say, is another story.

Notes

1 See *Bunker Archéologie* (Centre de Création Industrielle, 1975; second revised and expanded edition Demi-Cercle, 1991). This second edition has been published in English as *Bunker Archeology* (Princeton Architectural Press, 1994).

2 See *L'Insécurité du territoire* (Stock, 1976; revised edition Galilée, 1992).

3 See *Vitesse et politique* (Galilée, 1977), p. 16. Published in English as *Speed and Politics* (Semiotexte, 1986).

4 See *Architecture Principe* (L'Imprimeur, 1996), a new compilation of the nine issues of the manifesto magazine.

A critical modernity

Claude Parent

The Modern Movement has left us with two legacies which are of dubious value:

- a proliferation of satellite towns, new towns, dormitory suburbs and large-scale housing schemes that do not fit into the frame of the traditional city
- a cavalier approach to our built heritage.

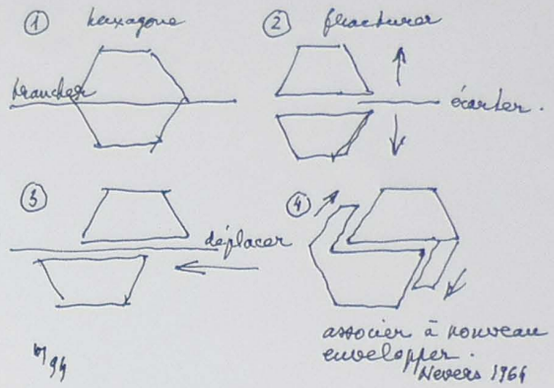
These problems continue to haunt us, prompting us to rethink our ideas and to question whether the architectural ideals of the 1920s and 1930s can continue to serve as our inspiration.

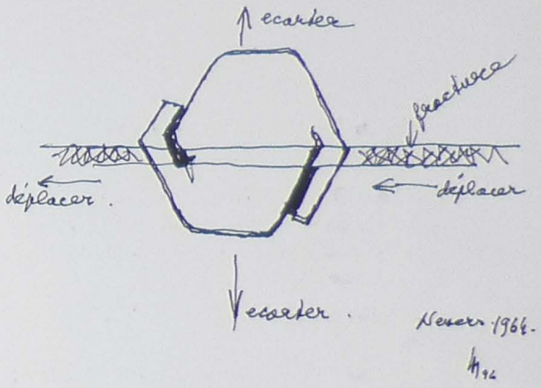
The failure of the Modern Movement can be attributed to its claims to absolute legitimacy, its unbending control over both urban sites and the countryside, its inability to broach self-criticism. Modernism's policy of beginning from the *tabula rasa* – its unrepentant desire for a complete break with the past – has led to the foundering of its entire theoretical basis. Equally, its taste for systematization has corrupted a way of thinking that once was generous and universalist.

There is no longer a coherent basis for architecture. Lines of investigation have diverged; the exchange of ideas has been curtailed. In the absence of any global discussion, the only recourse is to invent anew – or to recover propositions that were rejected in the past. Within this context, architecture is experiencing a cultural revolution which is manifested in:

- the questioning of form as an aesthetic absolute; the rejection of its unchallenged, unchallengeable universal application
- the introduction into projects of an element of contradiction
- the willingness to be self-critical
- the exploration of 'faults' within the continuity of forms
- the appearance in architectural thinking of an element of doubt
- the overcoming of this potentially destructive doubt by a return to coherence.

This strategy of positive questioning is the only means of moving towards a new modernity – a CRITICAL MODERNITY – that will free us from everything which is obsolete and allow us to consider anew the modern architecture of the 1920s and 1930s. In this respect, my work in the 1960s with Paul Virilio, both theoretical and practical, gave some clear signals for contemporary practice in advocating:

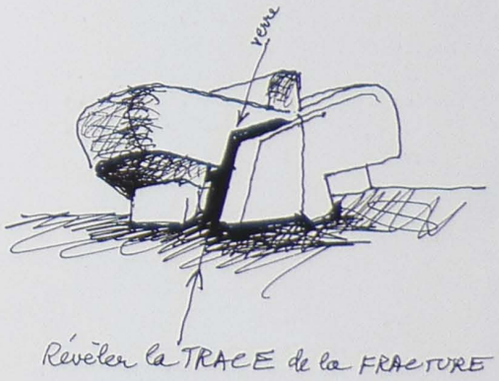




- the mobilization of form
- the use of the fracture
- the expression of disequilibrium in cantilevered masses
- the recurrent sensation of instability
- the use of inclined planes to disrupt the classic orthogonal system.

These elements can be seen as precursors of a critical modernity whose aims are:

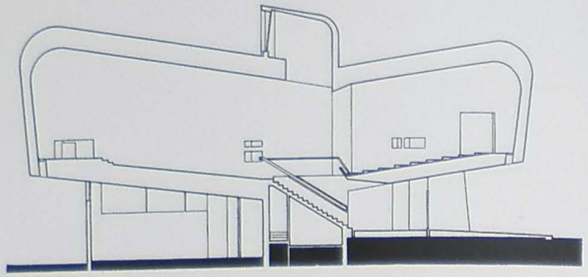
- to avoid an unquestioning recourse to the formal vocabulary of the past
- to maintain significantly better relations with the historical built fabric than Modernism has achieved to date
- to expand the frontiers of memory.

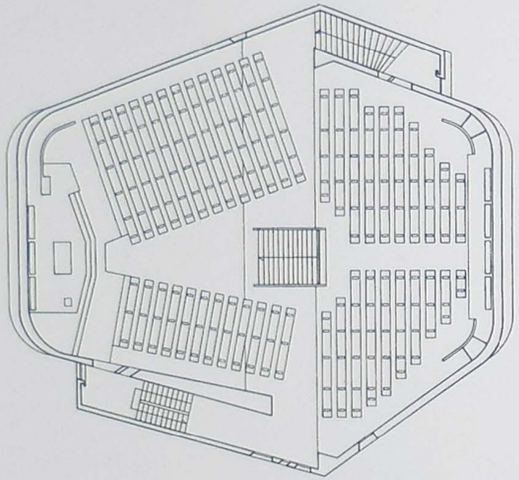


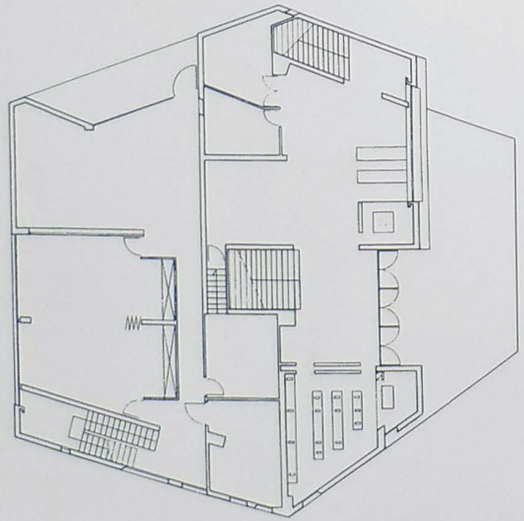
Above: The fracturing of the plan and form of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay, from Claude Parent's sketchbooks.

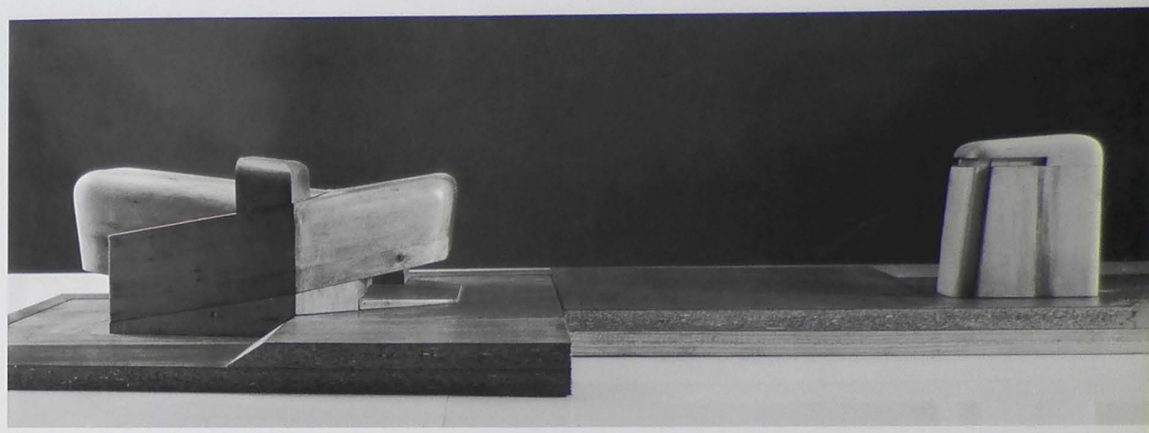
Projects

Church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay, Nevers









The church of Sainte-Bernadette was our first venture into the function of the oblique. Curiously, its construction preceded the development of our experimental theories in *Architecture Principe* magazine.

The church has a menacing appearance: its opaque concrete carapace is defensive, even deliberately 'repulsive' in its relation to the surroundings, but at the same time it forms a protective enclosure for the interior, which has been conceived as a grotto, in homage to the life of the church's patron saint.

The sense of rupture from the surrounding context is reinforced by the use of a military vocabulary of architecture inspired by German bunkers. Our decision to apply this language to the form of the church came at a late stage of the project's development, long after we had defined the fractured hexagonal plan, the double inverse slope of the nave, the light slots in the walls, and the side and central entrances.

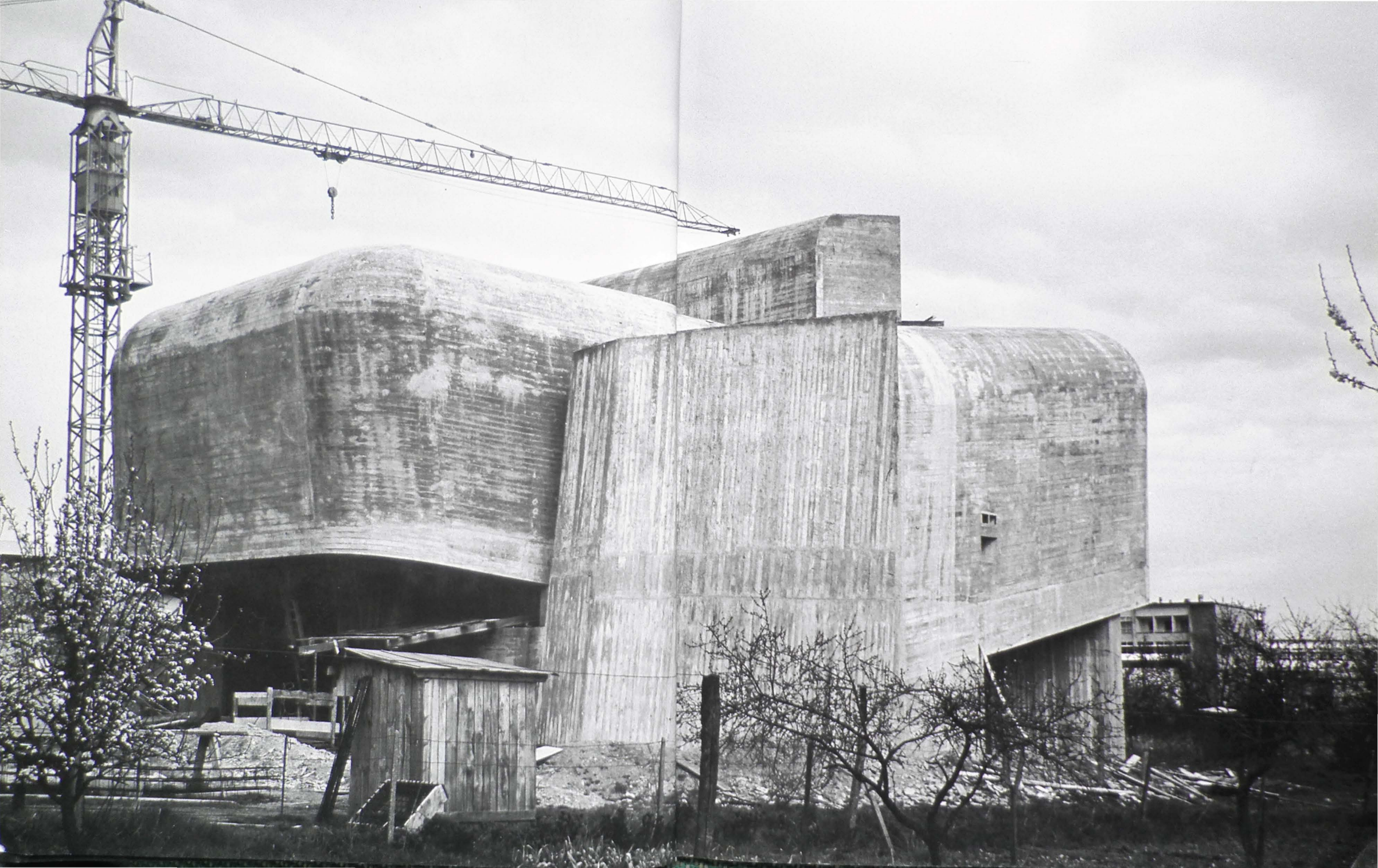
The formal references to bunkers should therefore be seen as a secondary element. In annexing a military vocabulary and stripping it of its lethal functions we were making a conscious effort to play up the drama of the exterior while playing down the connotations of war.

But perhaps this explanation is somewhat over-intellectualized: the result of our approach was a building with a forceful presence eliciting the dual sense of fear and wonder that is often deemed a fitting attribute of religious spaces.

The appearance of the church has provoked strong reactions, but in analysis it has more to do with a sculptural coquettishness than with a considered application of the principle of the oblique. The two ideas are unconnected: the oblique structure is quite independent of the formal vocabulary of the bunker. They simply coincided in this single instance because Virilio and I each came to the project with a set of design ideas that we wanted to develop to the full.

The church is important in the history of the oblique because it expresses in sculptural form three key elements: the function of the oblique; our anger with the architecture and society of the time; and the liturgical openness desired by the parish priest, Monseigneur Bourgoin. That is no mean achievement for a project with a budget of 130 million old francs on a pocket-sized site. *CP*

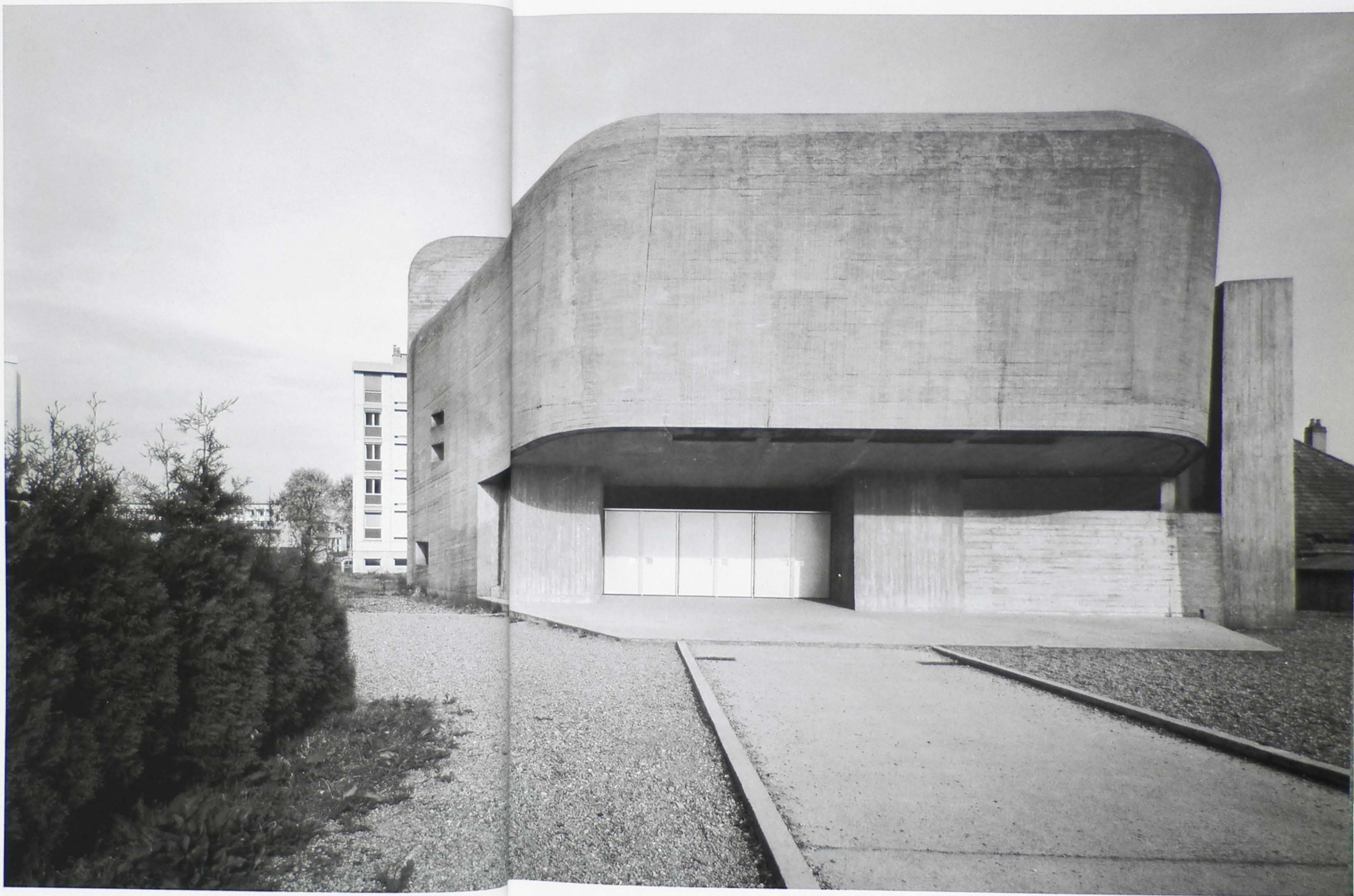
Above and pp. 17–18: Model of the proposed parochial centre of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay, showing both the church and the (unbuilt) presbytery. Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1964–6.

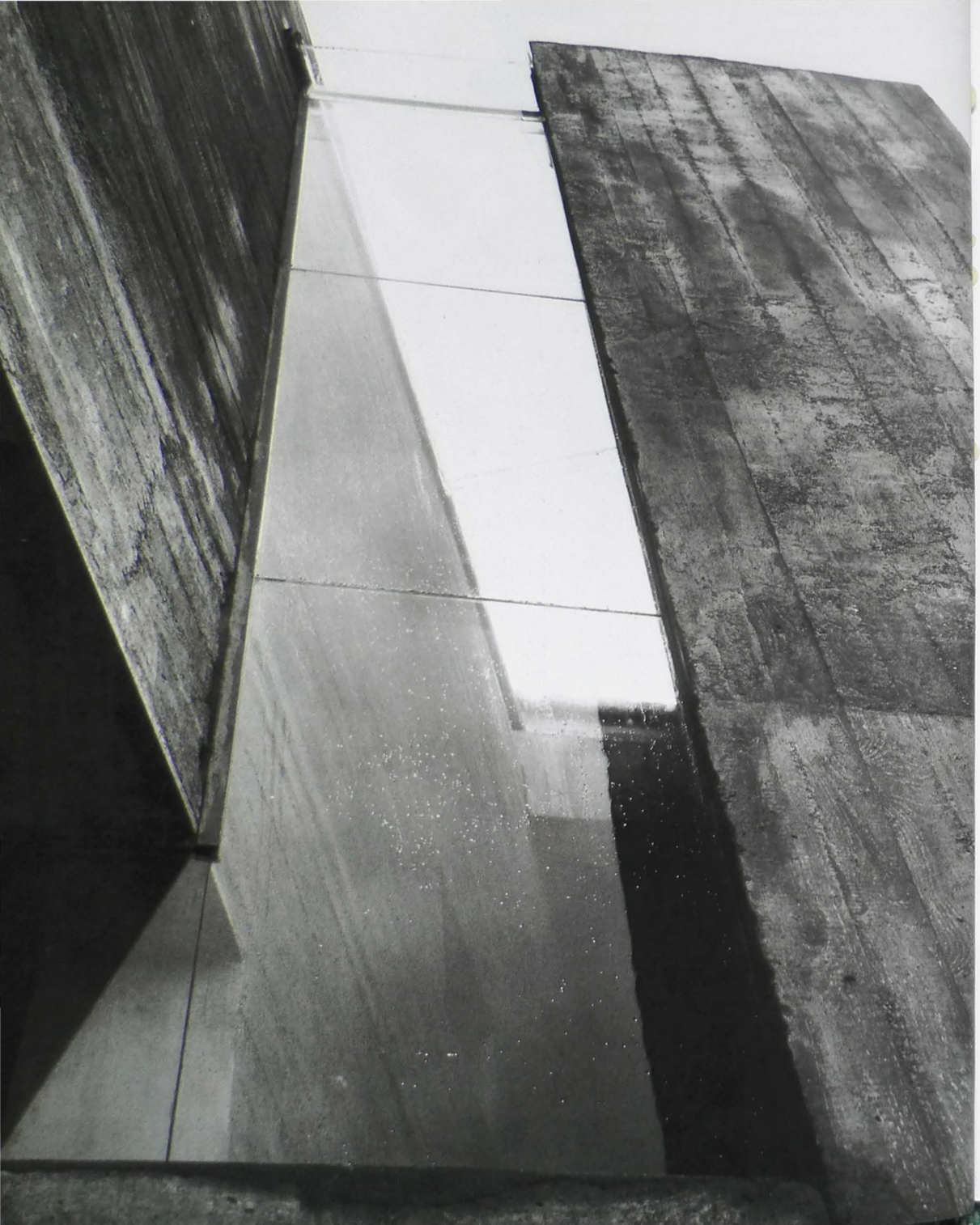


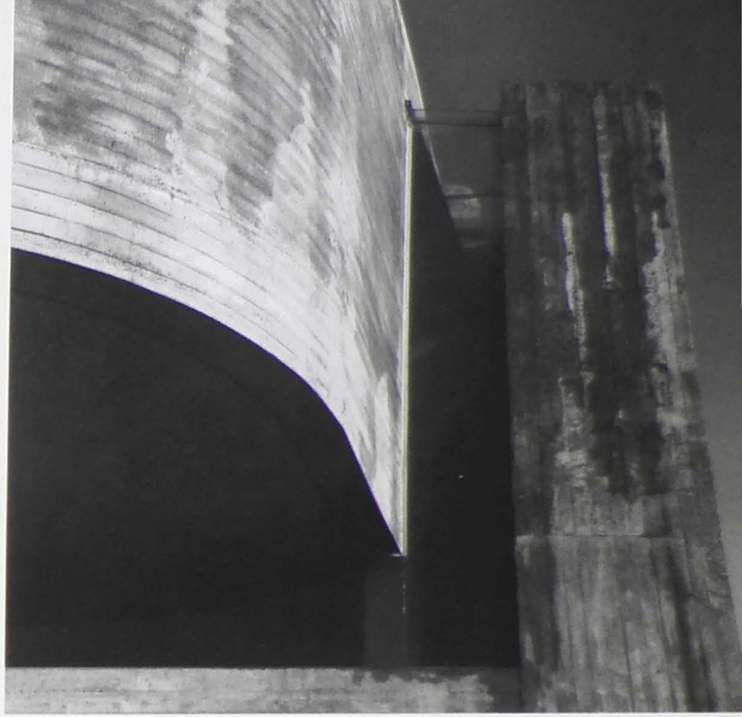
The plan of the church is based upon the interpenetration of two shells, one containing the altar, the other the confessionals. The shells overlap obliquely, creating an ascending central aisle at their juncture. The cantilevered forms are supported by plinths: to the east, below the altar, there is a block containing the meeting and instruction rooms; to the west, below the confessionals, are the baptistery and day chapel.

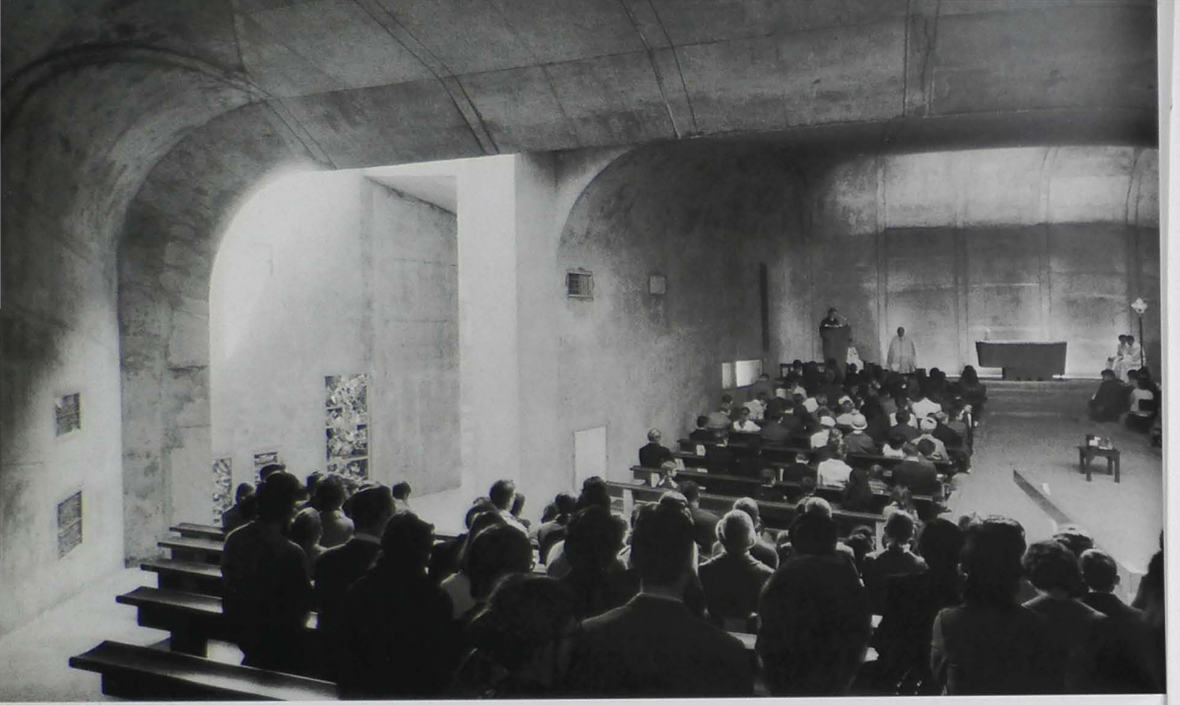
Secondary entrances are located beneath the overhang at the juncture of the two shells. To the north a double stairway leads down to the meeting and instruction rooms, while to the south a single stair leads to the sacristy and baptistery. In the centre, the principal access stair rises up into the middle of the nave, along the east–west axis leading to the altar.

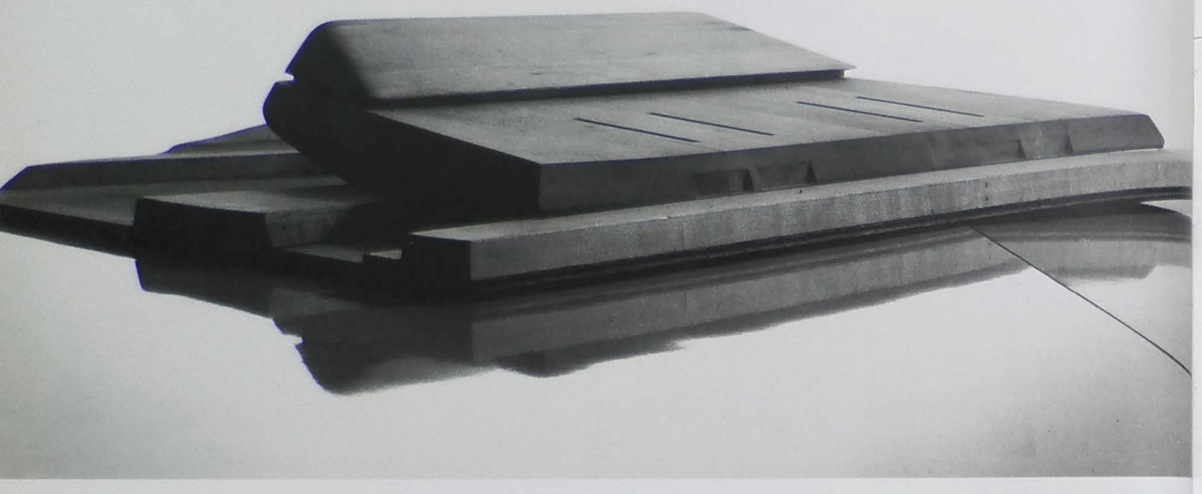
Narrow slots are cut into the floor of the main space and some of the walls to provide a form of backlighting, illuminating the vaults above. Complementary lighting is obtained through continuous vertical fissures between the two detached and overlapping lateral volumes which enclose the nave. A transverse lantern skylight articulates the inversely pitched roofs, emphasizing the ruptured effect. The reinforced concrete is left bare inside and out.

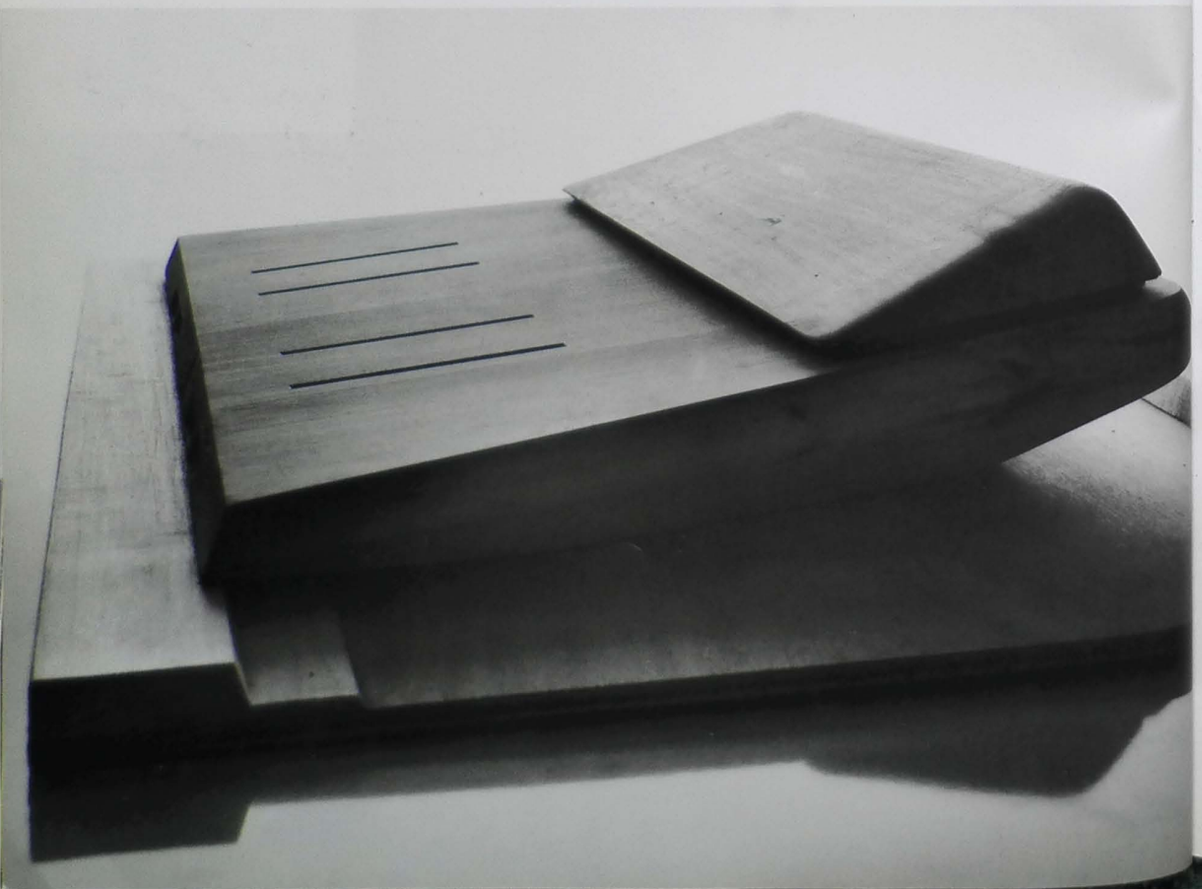










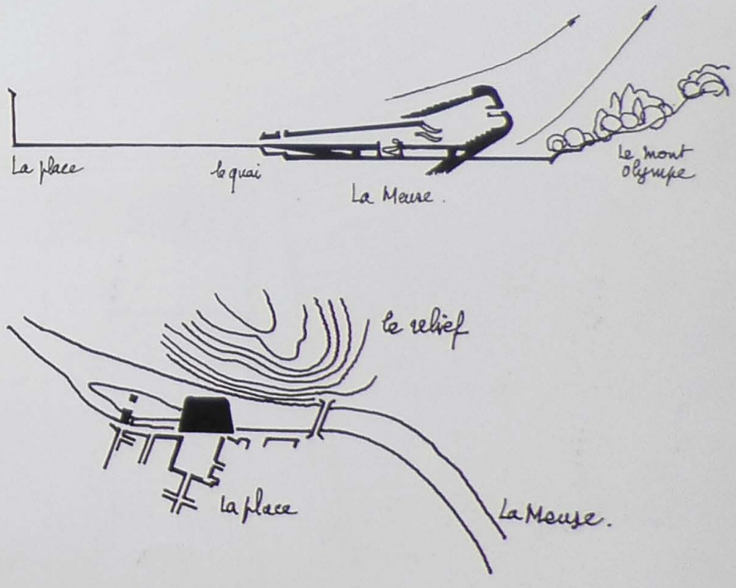


Projects

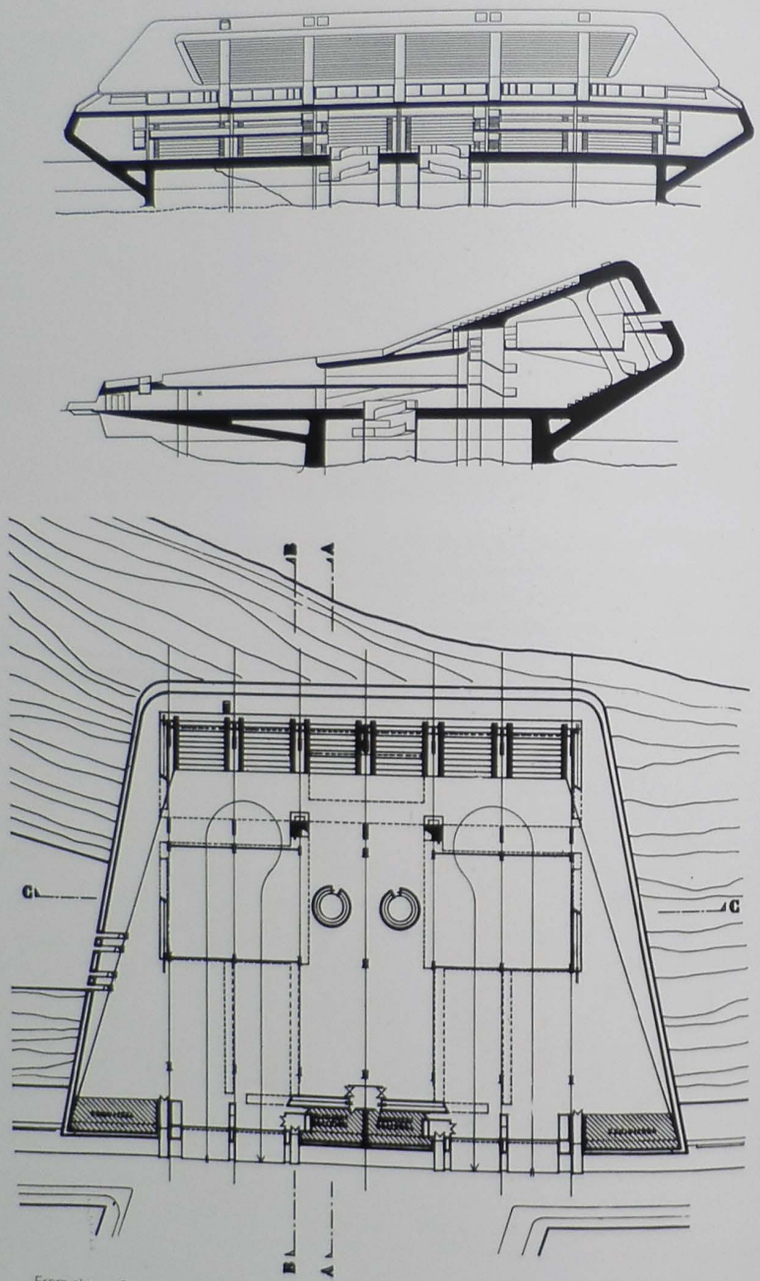
Charleville cultural centre

The Charleville cultural centre is an obliquely sliced concrete shell enclosing more than 10,000 square metres of usable surface space. The facilities are arranged over several levels that are tied together by a system of ramps and stairs. The roof of the main enclosure – a continuous sloping ramp – slides into the base of the oblique upper terraces, and serves as a stage for open-air spectacles and informal gatherings. An urban square extends down the slope from the terraces, forming a backdrop for larger events.

Below the outdoor terraces, a sheltered upper deck overlooks the restaurant level, which is itself suspended within the internal volume. A series of steep stairs link the restaurant to the exhibition spaces below, and open onto two levels of performance space that can be tied together or isolated as required. The reinforced concrete casing, the outer edge of the restaurant and the upper bridge are all punctured with inlets and fissures which provide natural light or points of access. Openings cut into the base of the structure allow barges on the River Meuse to sail right up to quays which are connected with the building by a pair of spiral ramps. The creation of such an uninterrupted flow between exterior and interior is a key advantage of the principle of inclined planes. *CP*



Above: Site plan and sketch showing the relation of the cultural centre to the river Meuse and the form of the urban square. Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1966.

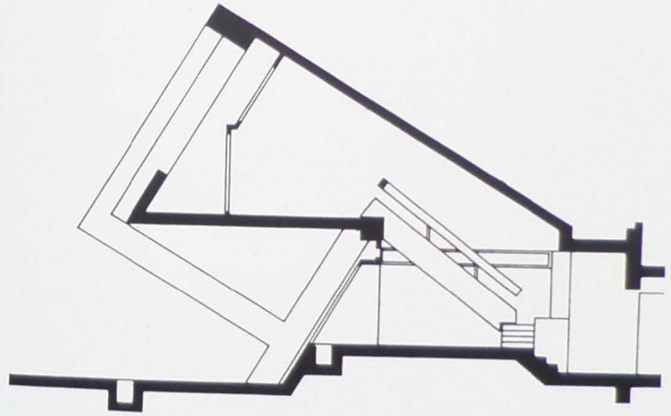


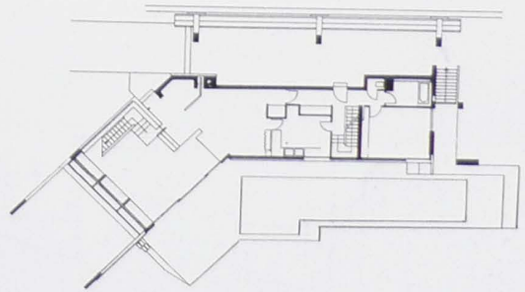
From above: Section B–B, section C–C, ground-floor plan (quay level).

The overall form of the Charleville project is in no way 'figurative'. It is not nautical, despite its setting, nor aerodynamic, despite its profile. Rather, it is carved out of the capacity of the interior.

Until now, capacity has played a minor role in determining architectural form except, of course, on the general level of scale. The importance assigned to the protective role of the external envelope has totally overshadowed the CAPACITY EFFECT. The resulting emphasis on the purely technical aspects of architecture (load-bearing, support) means that in essence buildings are merely the 'scaffolding' of their contents. Technical concerns have been raised to the level of poetics – a tendency that has been encouraged by engineers and extended by the development of the steel structure. Thus the framework and the materials attached to it – whether stone, wood or metal – have been unduly emphasized. The use of poured materials, concrete or plastic, will completely alter this situation, transferring to the exterior a positive imprint of the volume inside. By doing this, and by making all surfaces continuously usable, the long-standing opposition between interior and exterior will be largely neutralized...

The general form of the building has been developed concurrently with a stratification of the levels of use. Abandoning the convention of the facade as a barrier, we have inverted the floors, and occasionally even rolled them back on themselves, in order both to refine the spaces and to exploit their full height. Out of this strategy there has emerged a wing-like section of leading and trailing edges. *PV*





Drusch house, Versailles

The morphology of the function of the oblique can be traced back to the Drusch house. The main element of the house,a cube turned on its edge, contains a living space on three levels. The cube seems to be toppling off its base, giving a palpable sensation of movement, although it is in fact secured by a concrete footing. *CP*

Drusch house, Versailles. Claude Parent, 1962–3. Ground-floor plan and section through living space.

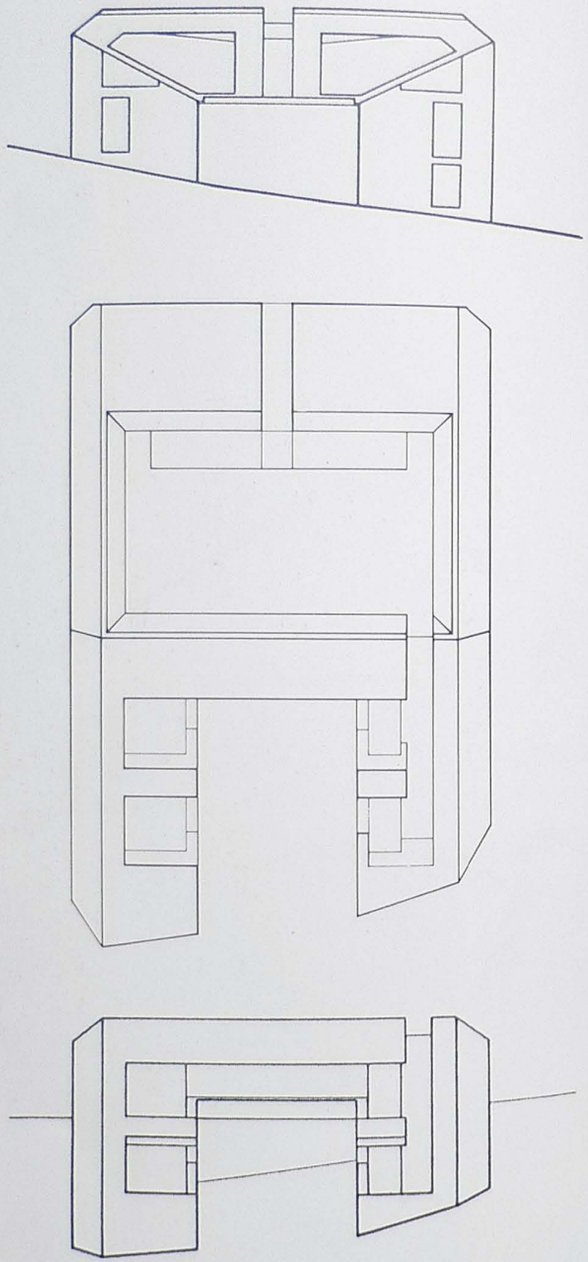
Mariotti house, Saint-Germain

We undertook this study for a house on a site in Saint-Germain at the request of the owner of a small building firm, a man named Mariotti. The project got as far as the building permit stage.

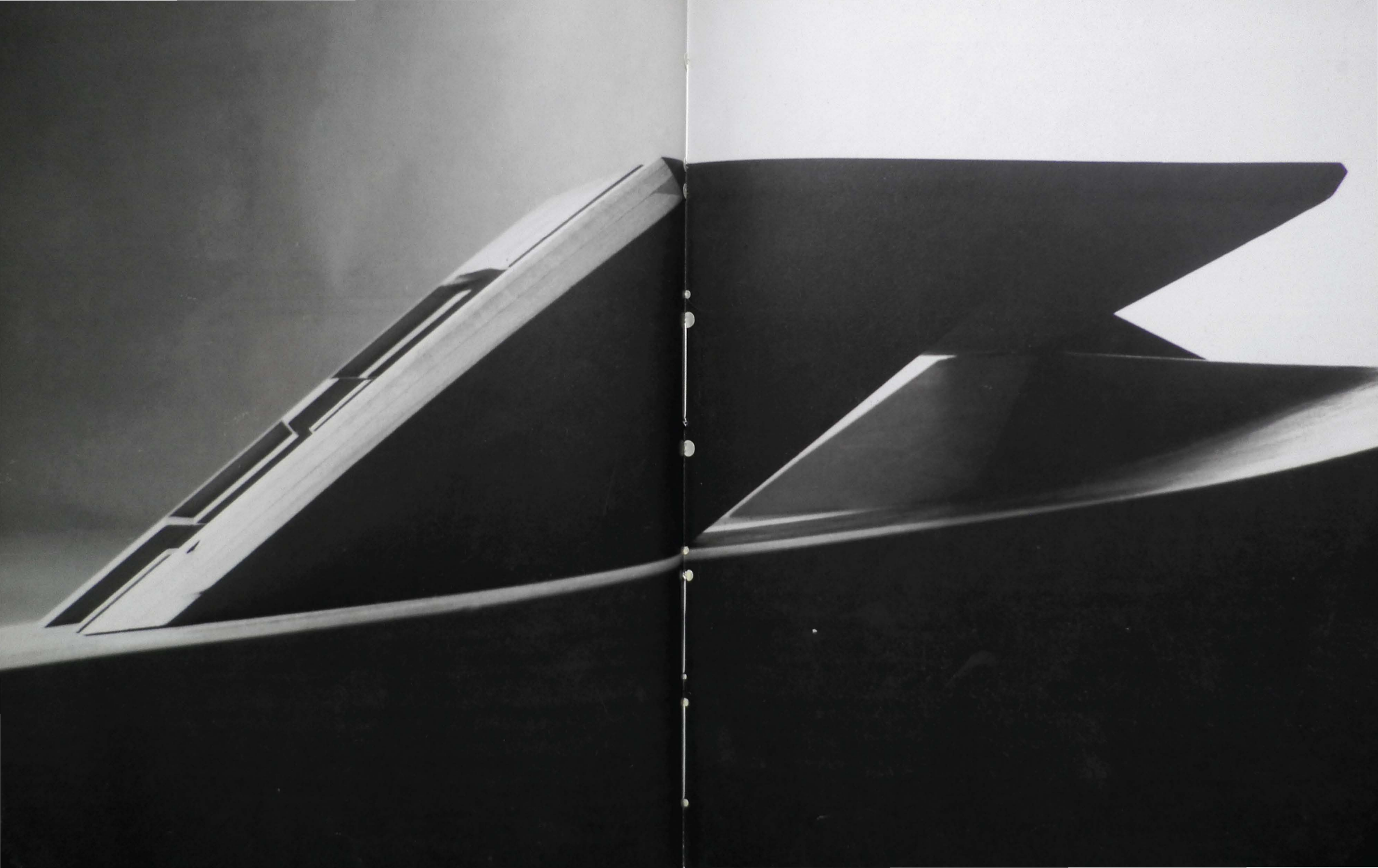
The house straddles the small, sloping site like a bridge. It is possible to walk across the entire expanse of its inclined facades, as well as along its terrace and its third point of contact with the ground (the access ramp to the rear). Mariotti was the first house to be designed on the oblique. *CP*

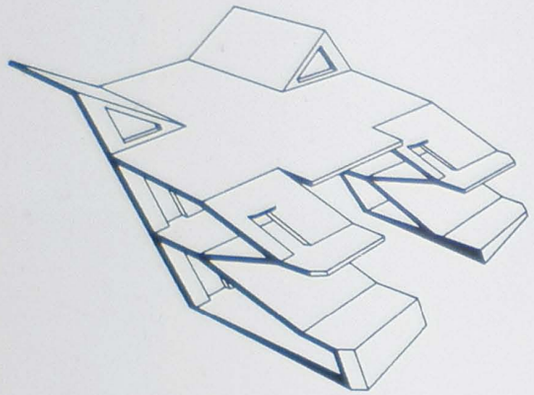
The micro-ghetto of the traditional habitat is transformed into a freely accessible interior landscape by the mobilizing function of the oblique, which removes all impediments to movement – the fixed partitions and the random clutter of furniture. The underside of the oblique forms an isolating screen which fully serves the needs of privacy, allowing the whole of the upper surface – the living part – to be devoted to the activities of the inhabitants. The sense of dynamics is heightened by the diversity of the forms, materials and colours of the household equipment, which is always practicable, and incorporated into the built structure. The wing-like floor plane integrates different supply and equipment circuits at each stage of its elevation.

The Mariotti house expresses the principle of habitable circulation. *PV*



Mariotti house, Saint-Germain. Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1966. From above: Front elevation, roof view, rear elevation. Opposite: Access ramp to the terrace.



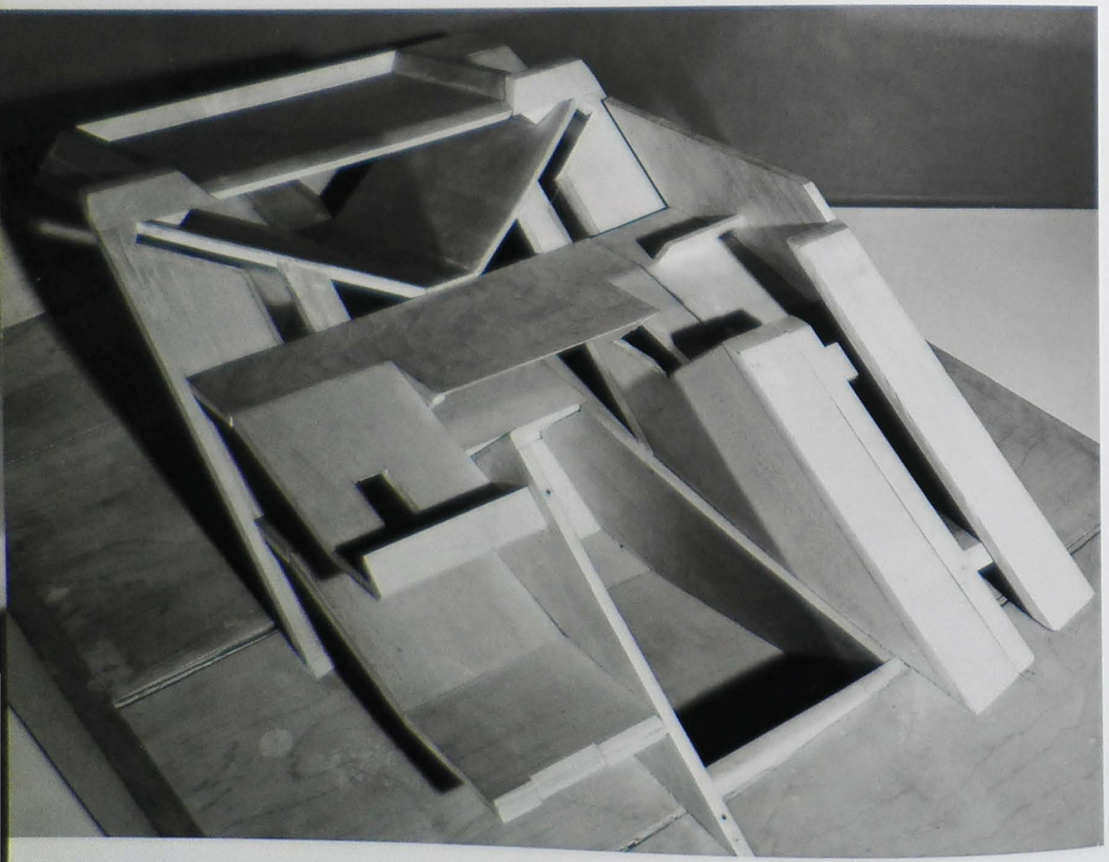


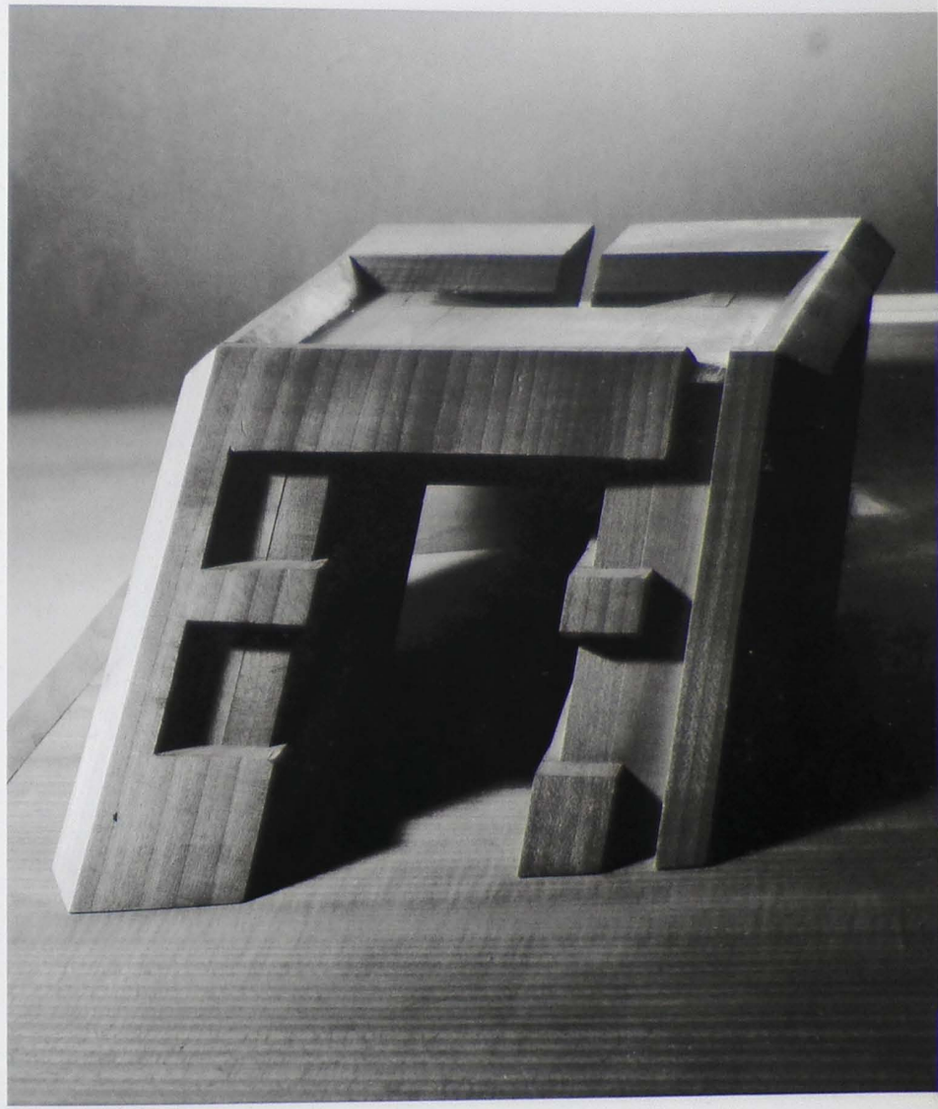
Mariotti house, Saint-Germain.
Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1966.

Opposite page: Model view of front elevation: the central portion of the facade is glazed.

Right: Interior perspective illustrating the principle of habitable circulation.

Below: Study model showing how the structure straddles the sloping site.





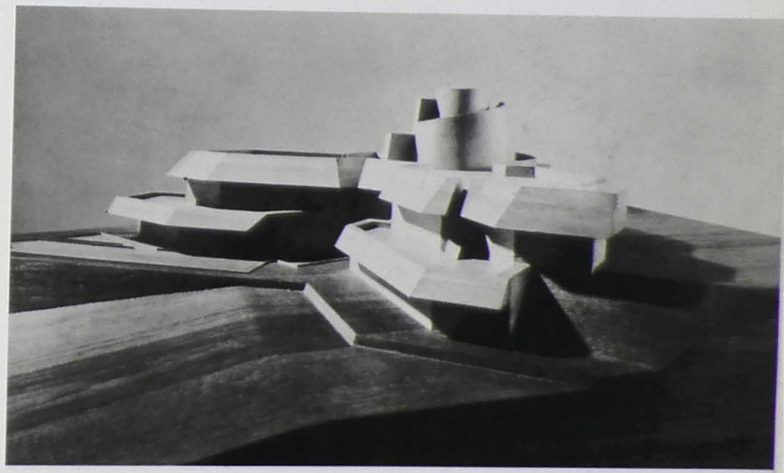
Woog houses

Monsieur Woog, a young, capricious and indecisive Swiss millionaire, the king of the electric toothbrush, came up with the idea of building for himself the house of the century. He devised a programme for a magnificent site on the shores of Lake Geneva, and consulted a minimum of ten architects. Woog didn't see any point in limiting himself. He *invented* the age of consultation: since then the State has quite happily carried on with the process.

The submitted projects were all quite beautiful. Ionel Schein devised a transparent glass cage that displayed the organic guts of the interior. Jacquemain proposed a splendid tower that curved outwards at its summit. Another architect, from Los Angeles, created an underground structure with observation bubbles peeking out of the hillside...

For my part, I produced three studies exploring the spatial possibilities of the oblique, which perfectly suited the theme of the house. Woog wanted to have a single sweeping vista of the whole of Lake Geneva (a familiar possessive impulse), but at the same time to remain down to earth (in the bucolic sense). His brief stipulated that the house had to rise upward in a series of terraces from ground level up to a height of fifteen metres. This apparently impossible requirement was an inspiration to me as well as the other architects. *CP*

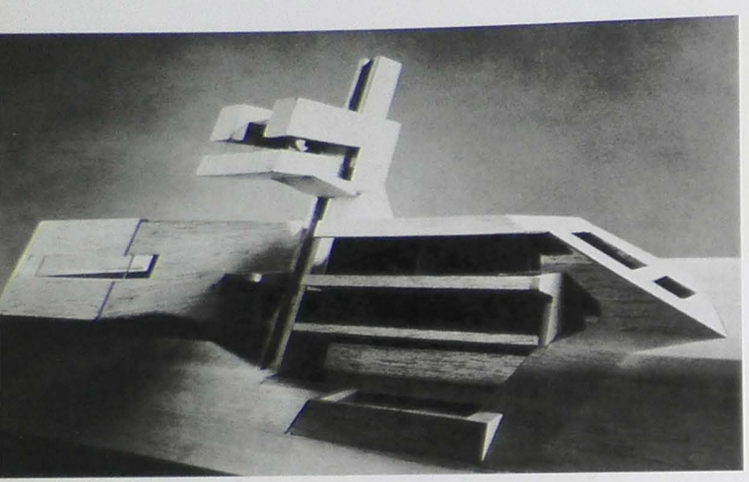
Left: Woog no. 2. Claude Parent, 1966–8.

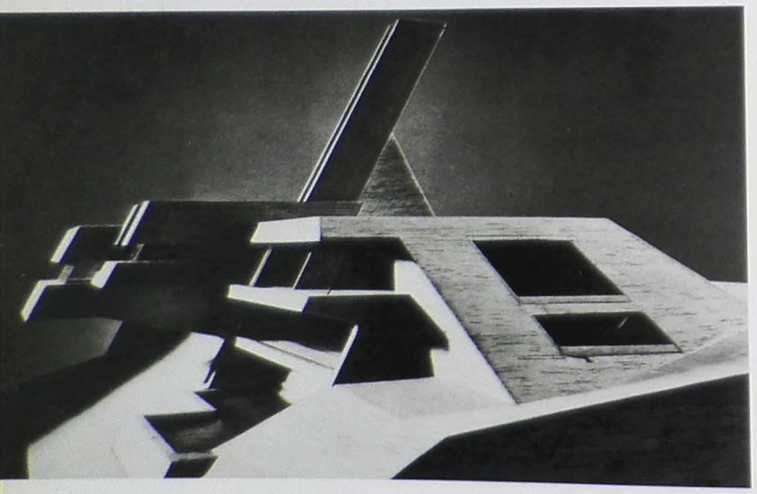


Woog no. 1

Woog no. 1
Traditional

A central (spiral) ziggurat containing the owner's art collection and living spaces rises to the full maximum height of fifteen metres. Around this pivotal oblique are arranged two horizontal planes of living space. The architecture expresses respect, tradition, calm...



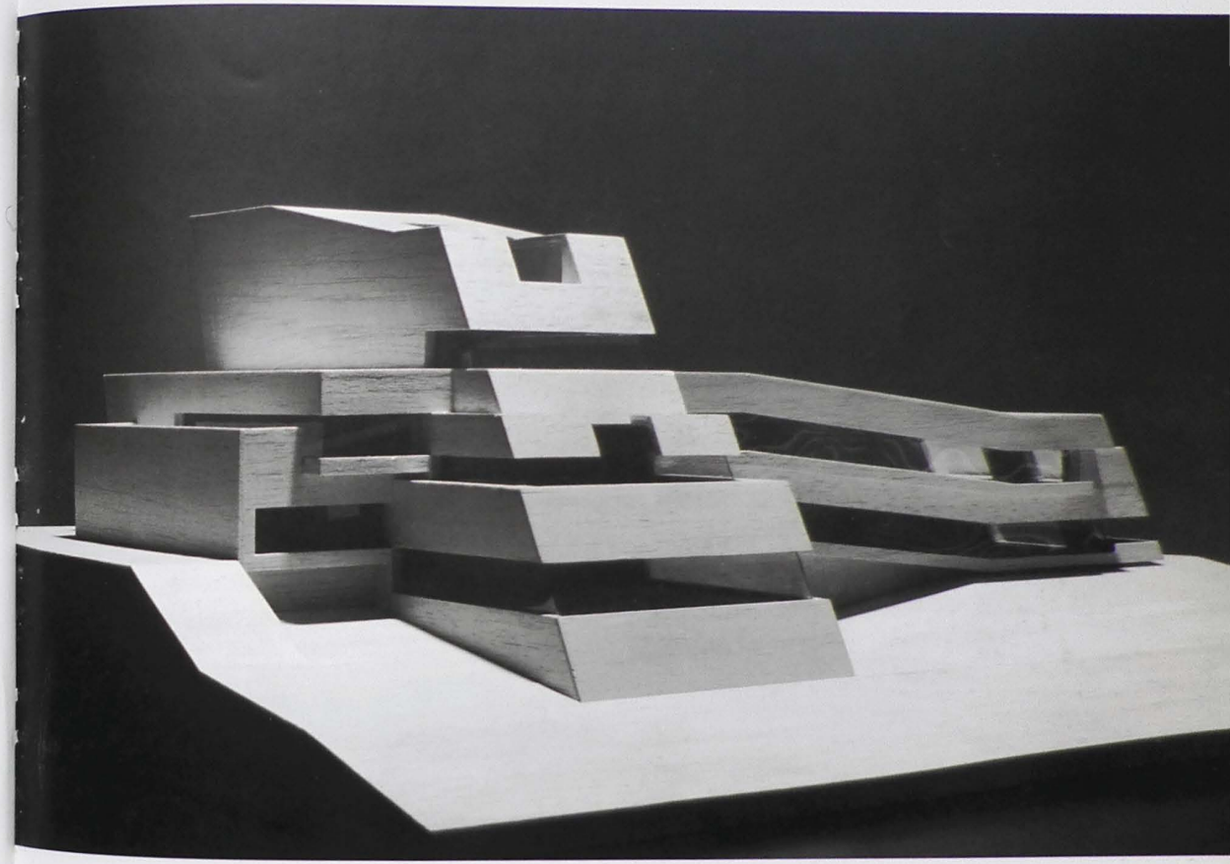


Woog no. 2

Mobile

One part of the house, made up of two ramps, detaches itself from the base of the construction and ascends a track along a huge sloping ramp of concrete. When fixed at the top, it provides 100 square metres of suspended, isolated space.

A slow, almost imperceptible movement animates this enormous block of concrete. A crazy arrangement. The poetry of defiance.



Woog no. 3

Double ascension

This is my favourite of the three schemes – a helmet, or mask, with black holes gaping on to the countryside.

Two sets of ramps, placed at right angles to each other, converge at the core of the house. In one wing are the bedrooms, set on gentle eight degree slopes between two galleries. In the other wing is the living room, on a steeper, twenty degree slope. At the junction of the two wings there is a marvellous space, rich and complex.

Of course, the dream had to come to an end. Monsieur Woog, after all this fuss, wisely settled back into his old place.

Interview with Claude Parent

Irénée Scalbert and Mohsen Mostafavi

We would like to learn more about your collaboration with Paul Virilio. How did it come about?

We had a mutual friend, the painter Michel Carrade, who was always saying that we should meet, but somehow we never got around to it – until 1963, when Virilio came to buy an apartment in Paris. He had found one, and even signed a contract on it, when he saw a building going up on the nearby avenue du Maine and decided, in an instant: '*That's* where I'm going to live.' This was strange, because at that stage the building consisted of two storeys of concrete, nothing more. It was my first big project. Up to then I'd done only individual homes, exhibitions, little things like that. Virilio found out from Michel that I was the architect, and he asked to meet me. Our collaboration was set in motion by a shared passion for architecture.

Yet Virilio did not have any architectural training.

When I first knew Virilio, he was a painter of stained glass. He knew an extraordinary amount about his craft, but he also had a real instinct for architecture – an instinct reflected in his impulsive decision to buy that apartment.

Left: The architect's sister, Nicole Parent, demonstrating movement on an oblique plane.

Our decision to work together was sealed when I took Virilio to see two other projects then under construction: the Drusch house in Versailles, and the Bordeaux-le-Pecq house in Bois-le-Roi. The Drusch house had a particularly dynamic form – a cube turned on its edge, to create a visual disequilibrium. I hadn't conceived of it in intellectual or philosophical terms. I simply wanted to make a house that appeared to be on the point of toppling over. The other house, with its curved forms, also had a sense of movement, and in it Virilio sensed the idea of 'emergence'. There is a French word, 'surrection', which describes this exactly: the architecture seems no longer to be rooted in the ground, but rather to be erupting out of it – almost as if the ground itself was lifting up to make the form.

These two buildings represented the culmination of an interest in the dynamics of form that had developed during my ten-year collaboration with André Bloc. It was Bloc who instigated my true education as an architect. When we met, I was a young malcontent at the Ecole des Beaux-Arts; he was the editor of *Architecture d'Aujourd'hui*, with contacts all over the world. Bloc introduced me to the painters and sculptors in the Groupe Espace. I met Del Marle, Léger, Delaunay, Baertling, Hartung, Pol Bury and many others who were involved in Neo-plasticism and Geometric Abstraction. They

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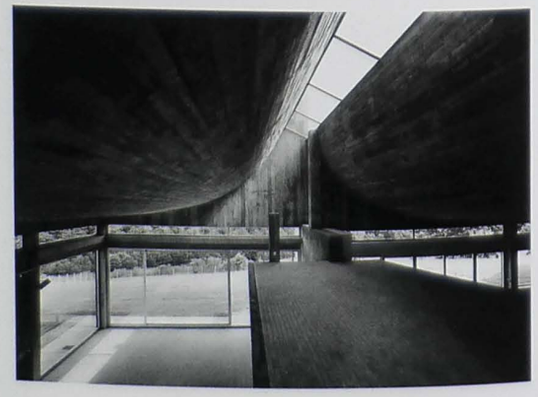
Bordeaux-le-Pecq house, Bois-le-Roi. Claude Parent, 1963.



had an enormous influence on my work, as they opened my eyes to the idea of a dynamic geometry.

At the same time, Virilio had discovered another version of the architecture of disequilibrium through his study of the bunkers and fortifications of the Atlantic Wall.

Thus our collaboration fused two independent approaches to the same theme.

Once you'd established this common theoretical ground, how did you proceed to work together in practice?

To begin with, Virilio was a discussion partner. He used to accompany me when I was invited to take part in a debate: we'd give a joint response to questions. After a while, he began coming to the office for a few hours each day.

As a pupil?

No, as an equal, though he was almost ten years younger than me. He brought a couple of jobs into the office: the church of Sainte-Bernadette and the Thomson-Houston Aerospace Centre. We worked on these projects together. I was responsible for drawing up the initial designs and plans (he lacked the technical know-how), but then we'd have frequent meetings to discuss how the project should evolve, what revisions should be made, and so on. That's how we did it.

So would you say that you were propelled into a marriage of convenience by the commissions that Virilio brought into the office? He wasn't an architect. He needed you to complete the projects.

Virilio had an admirable, and legitimate, ambition to make architecture, and he contributed to the projects in a very real way. It was Virilio who said that we should put a slope on the floor planes of the church. When he made this suggestion, I realized to my dismay that I had succeeded in disrupting the internal spaces and structure of the Drusch house, but not the primary plane of reference – the floor. The challenge of working together on a real, concrete project inspired a fundamental breakthrough – the first application of the function of the oblique.

It seems that the church of Sainte-Bernadette allowed you to synthesize the experience that you'd gained at the Drusch house with the vertiginous qualities of the tilted war bunkers that Virilio had studied.

The military vocabulary of the bunkers dominated our early projects – the church, as well as the cultural centre in Charleville. Virilio saw the bunker as the apotheosis of twentieth-century architecture. He was the bunker specialist; he had photographed thousands of them, up and down the Atlantic Wall. And his enthusiasm was infectious. I began to realize that this was a splendid form of architecture. I liked the continuity of the forms, the sheer size of the concrete shells, the way they responded to the landscape. Some bunkers also have a sense of movement. If you look at them for long enough, they seem to be advancing towards you – like tanks. Together, we decided to use the military vocabulary of the bunkers to initiate a formal dialectic.

What exactly were your attitudes towards the military and the war?

I was anti-militarist, though that was more part of my nature than a considered ideological position. Virilio was also anti-militarist, but he did have a certain respect for the power of a collective organization to achieve extraordinary, almost magical results that are beyond the power of an individual. The D-Day landings were for him a remarkable event, not only because they brought liberation, but because they consolidated the whole of the industrial might of the United States in pursuit of a common goal.

He admired that, in the same way that he admired the super-organized Panzer divisions and autobahn system of the Germans.

Many would think it inappropriate to apply a military vocabulary to the design of a church.

For me, designing a church is no different from designing a single-family house, a cinema, or a supermarket: in each case, you have to find the best spatial solution to a problem posed in terms of human activity. I'm not a practising Christian, so I didn't get involved in the metaphysical issues of the church.

But isn't Virilio religious?

Very much so. We got the commission for Sainte-Bernadette through his connections with the church. He had worked on a number of religious art projects, and became acquainted with Le Corbusier during the construction of Ronchamp.

One could make a comparison between the inclined planes of Sainte-Bernadette and those of Le Corbusier's church in Firminy, which was designed around the same time.

It's true that the French architectural press labelled us as 'post-Corbusians', but that is not how we saw ourselves. I think Firminy was a fine, mature work, perhaps Corb's best building, but it did not express the function of the oblique. Corb created the effect of a cantilevered mass, which is not the same thing as physically cantilevering the floor plane.

One element of the Nevers church is very Corbusian – the tiny holes punched through the walls to bring in light. But I really don't like those holes. They weren't my idea, and I never show them in photographs.

You applied the idea of the oblique not just to the church, but to house designs as well. How practical do you think the idea was on a domestic level?

Charles de Gaulle once said that the French were like cattle, meaning that we're content to remain neutral towards our surroundings because we want nothing more than a tranquil home-life. All apartments here tend to look alike. The poor don't have much choice in the matter: they are given a minimum space, with a standard layout. But, for the rich, it's a conscious decision, and they all choose the same set-up, even the same curtains. Our use of the oblique was intended as an assault on this general coziness, this overwhelming neutrality.

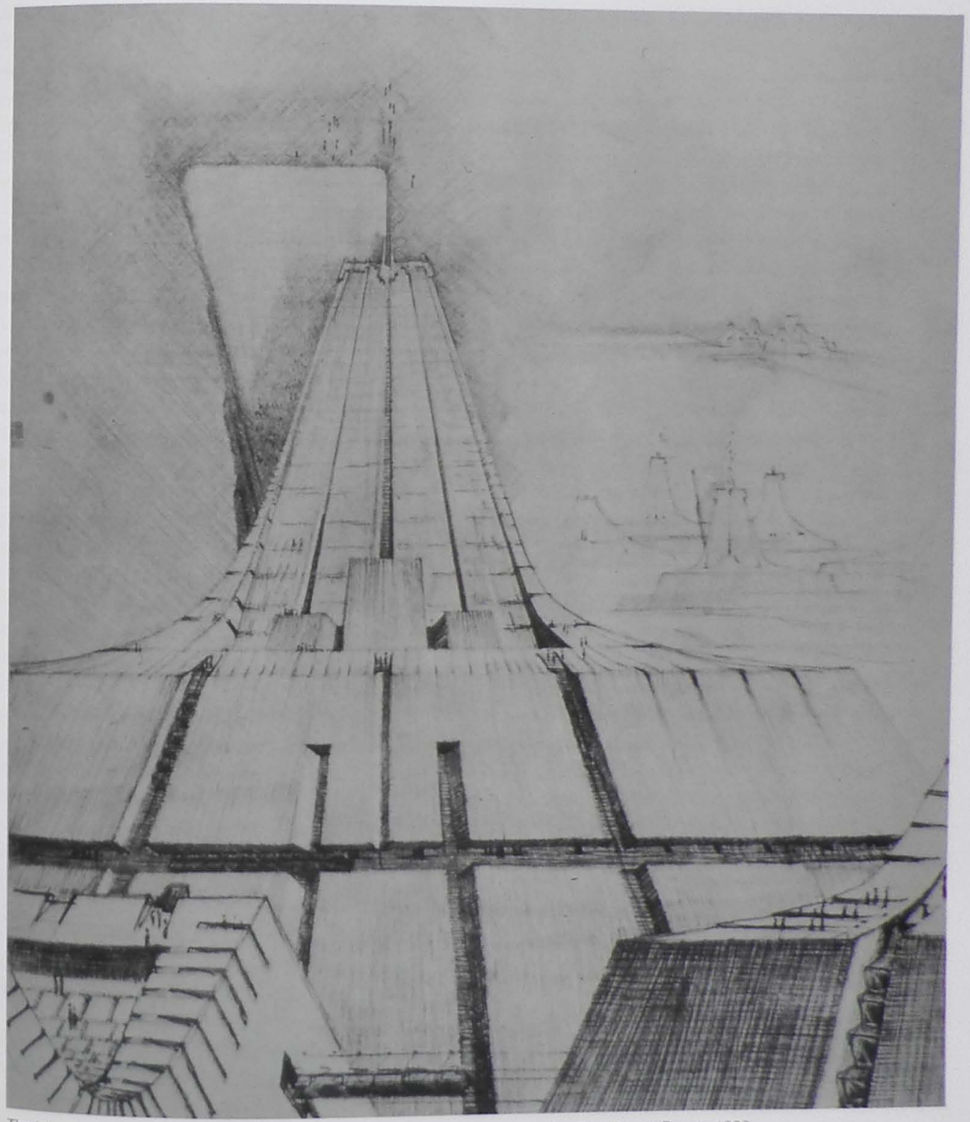
You've also referred to the oblique as part of a 'third order of urbanism'. How might the notion of the oblique transform the city?

In our conception of urbanism, the oblique made it possible to achieve a fluidity of movement, ensuring that the building was no longer a barrier to communication. The surface of the oblique structure was continuously accessible, belonging not to an individual but to the community as a whole.

There's a distinctly utopian flavour to many of your urban projects.

I became interested in architectural utopias around 1954, when I met the sculptor Nicolas Schöffer and learned about his 'spatio-dynamic architecture'. I'm aware now that this work was directly inspired by Moholy-Nagy and the Russian Constructivists, but at the time nobody in France knew anything about those people. In terms of architecture, the country was a closed system.

I got to know other utopists later on, in 1965, when I organized an exhibition at the Salines d'Arc et Senans which included Paolo Soleri and all the Japanese Metabolists, amongst others.



The Waves project – a series of oblique urban structures unfolding like the incoming tide. Claude Parent, 1966.

To me, your approach towards the utopian projects seems rather inconsistent. You were more or less part of a movement in architecture-sculpture which protested against the standardization imposed by industry. But, conversely, your cities were conceived on a huge scale, and seemed to require a vast amount of industry to sustain them. Were the projects mere excursions into science-fiction, or did they have a more serious intent?

Until around 1962, I saw them as a means of making a statement about the way urbanism was being practised. I was searching for an alternative to the relentless advance of the amorphous urban agglomeration. I was saying, 'If it has to be big, it should at least look good.' But at that stage, I didn't take it much further than defining a modern form for these cities.

With the introduction of our notion of the oblique, things became more complicated. I began to be concerned with making proposals that related in some way to the existing city. And I began to find myself in disagreement with my fellow utopists. The final break came with the debate on a project which proposed a huge urban expressway – the grand avenue Charles de Gaulle – slicing through Paris, blocking pedestrian movement. I thought that was crazy, but my alternative proposal – an accessible, sloping structure – found no support among the utopists. So I finished with them, and refused to join the GIAP group (Groupement International d'Architecture Prospective) created by Michel Ragon.

There's one historical point that we haven't yet covered: your collaboration with Virilio on the magazine Architecture Principe. *What motivated you to become publishers?*

When we set up the magazine, we'd been working together for three years on the church at Nevers. We had very clear ideas about what we wanted to achieve – but the architectural press wasn't much interested in them. So we decided to finance our own magazine and send it out free to everyone. It created an uproar. Maymont, for example, came up to me and said, 'You're mad, Parent. You've gone too far this time.' This was rich, coming from the man who had proposed to put floating cities in the Bay of Tokyo.

What was it that upset these people so?

It was the oblique, the idea of putting everything on inclined planes. We might have been forgiven if we had just called the things 'slopes'. As it was, we encountered absolute opposition. The magazine was our counter-attack. I published theoretical projects and wrote articles. Virilio did the same, though his work had a different tone and definite pet themes. Anything on 'habitable circulation' is bound to be by him. His writing took a radical theoretical stance, whereas I was probably more concerned with concrete issues – and more confrontational.

What were the roles of Lipsi and Carrade? They were listed on the masthead of the magazine as consultants in the 'plastic arts'.

Their involvement was minimal. Lipsi made a sculpture for Sainte-Bernadette, and Carrade was supposed to do the church decorations, though he never finished them. They took part in our discussions at the beginning, and were sympathetic to our ideas, but the inclined plane was purely the work of Virilio and myself.

You've described the reaction of your contemporaries to the idea of the oblique. What did younger people think?

As we got closer to '68, we found that the younger, more intellectual students began to see use as belonging to the same camp as the Situationists. The first time this became apparent, I didn't even know what 'Situationist' meant, so I asked Virilio, who lent me a magnificent metallic gold volume printed on sumptuous paper – unlikely packaging for a virulent critique of society. I was impressed, and I suspect that Virilio, who was a great reader, was at the time much influenced by the Situationists as well as other writers such as J. K. Galbraith. Virilio has always had a talent for tuning in to current trends and events and interpreting them in his own distinctive way to give them a new dimension. That, I believe, is the basis of his approach.

Virilio insisted that the general resistance to the oblique derived from a resistance to anything new. In the early days of the automobile, people were afraid that they would suffocate if they went above thirty kilometres an hour. Similarly, it was felt that sloping floors were inimical to mental stability. Our oblique spaces were compared to the prisons of the Bolshevik secret police, which had skewed cells and ceilings so low that it was impossible to stand.

To prove that it was possible to inhabit the oblique, we designed 'The Pendular Destabilizer' – an experimental structure that was raised twelve metres above the ground to isolate it from the outside world. There was no telephone, no post, no means of communication – except for a little hole in the wall that we could talk to each other through. It was a bit like those followers of Saint Simon who used to climb up columns and never come down again.

When did this experiment take place?

It didn't. We'd set aside a month of the vacation to test the structure at the University of Nanterre, but then May '68 came along.

'68 was not at all as I'd hoped. I had expected the movement to go beyond its blanket targetting of established systems and propose a new way of thinking, a new order. I don't think it's fascist to talk about 'order'. To my mind, the word implies a coherence, a system of thinking embraced by the majority of the population. But those involved in the 'events' merely tore everything apart without proposing any realistic alternative.

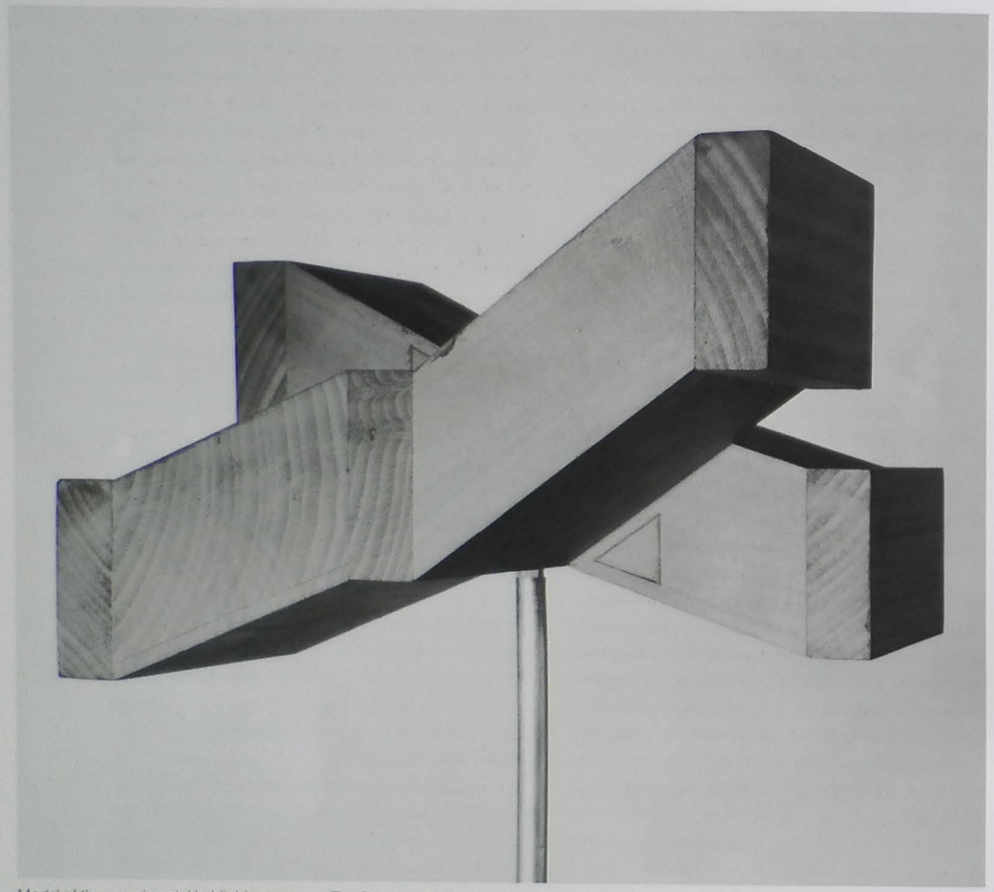
Virilio's experience of the time was very different. He was close to the hub of things. He wrote an article for a special issue of *L'Express* magazine, and he joined the group occupying the Odéon. When I went to see him, I was told that he was now calling himself 'Comrade Paul'. Those people all took themselves very seriously, forming 'revolutionary committees' and 'sub-committees'.

I have no stomach for that kind of thing. It reminded me of the aftermath of the Liberation in the south of France, when bands of fifteen-year-olds got hold of guns and went out looking for revenge. I don't like that mob mentality. It's the same thing in churches: when people come together in large groups, all individual will is lost.

Did Virilio join any particular group?

No, though he was very much involved in the movement as a whole. He said it was something he'd been dreaming of all his life – 1789 revisited. All the same, he was no fool. The day the police stormed the Odéon and drove everyone out with their batons, he wasn't there. He'd gone home to take a bath.

A couple of years later, around 1970, there was a special issue of *Architecture d'Aujourd'hui* covering trends in contemporary architecture. The editor was then Marc Emery; Bloc had been dead for a while. Virilio and I each contributed an article – but we didn't consult each other on the content. I wrote that the function of the oblique was not a political movement; it had no political agenda. Virilio was furious when he read this and he called me up: 'How can you say that?', he said, 'You know how involved I was in '68, how I risked my life, etc., etc.' And I replied, 'There are two of us in Architecture Principe, two of us in the oblique. You can question society



Model of the experimental habitable structure, 'The Pendular Destabilizer no. 2'. Claude Parent and Paul Virilio, 1968.

and challenge the processes of architecture, but I don't see that as politics – not in the sense of the politics of May '68, which were idiotic.'

After that, we could no longer work together. I was upset that the political climate had so corrupted a friend of six years.

What lessons do you think the 1960s hold for contemporary architectural practice in France? Do you think the ideas of the time have had an enduring influence?

The 1960s were a euphoric time for most architects. Suddenly they had the freedom to construct pretty much what they wanted, how they wanted. Yet it seems to me that almost everyone was too busy building to stop and think, particularly about the relation of architecture to the city. The widespread euphoria stifled the ability to respond critically to work. The architectural press described everything as wonderful. Paradoxically there were fewer ideas bubbling around than in the 1950s, when there was very little money but no shortage of enthusiasm or critical reflection.

The 1960s also did little to improve the relation between architecture and the landscape or society. Perhaps the only significant 'advance' was in technology. As the best-known architects were given ever more commissions, they had to find ways of dealing with their burgeoning workload. They soon developed a taste for new technologies, which they applied to the organization of the site and to the industrialization and rationalization of building components. Our best architects today are technocrats.

One final question. After more than forty years of practice as an architect, is there something that you'd still like to achieve?

My hostility to the kind of mass construction that I've just been describing has meant that I have missed out on the opportunity to work on a large-scale urban project. I was excluded from the post-war rebuilding progamme simply because I once said in a magazine article that I would have no part in a social housing movement that was social in name only, and anti-social in reality. I've always been ready to take up the challenge, but have never been given the opportunity – all because of my big mouth.

I would love it if one day some bureaucrat said, 'Let's give Parent a chance to show what he can do with a piece of the city.'

This interview took place in Neuilly in December 1995.

The definition of a critical architecture

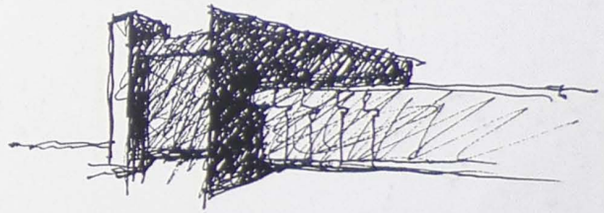
Frédéric Migayrou

Claude Parent is one of the compelling figures of post-war French architecture, yet curiously few critical texts have been devoted to him.[1] Whether there is a 'Parentian' aesthetic remains open to question. The work is characterized not by any style or mode of expression, but by a negation of form, a relentless reviewing of methods and processes, a continual reinvention of vocabulary. It is an architecture of rupture, in which the construction has to respond to the specificity of the event.

Parent came early to practice. He and Ionel Schein were still students at the Ecole des Beaux-Arts in Paris when they were given the opportunity to build their winning entry in the 1953 Maison Française competition. The result was the Gosselin house at Ville d'Avray, whose plan was split in two by a wall.

This distinctive gesture of incision, or fracture, is to be found in all of Claude Parent's work. In early buildings, it served as a device for disrupting Neoplasticist compositional grids: in the Soultrait house (1957) and Mauriange house (1961), parts of the floor plan were rotated 120 degrees from the vertical to create an internal redistribution of space. In later houses, the diagonal was introduced in order to increase the fractures of the plan and add complexity

Bloc house, Antibes. André Bloc and Claude Parent, 1959.

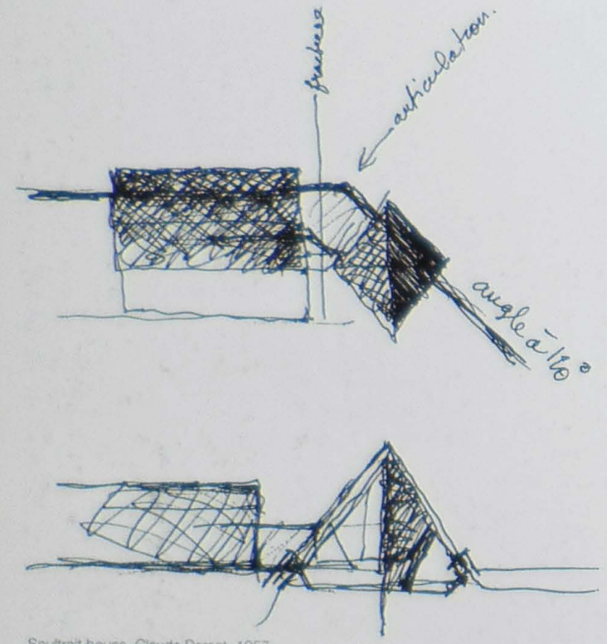


The fracturing wall of the Gosselin house, Ville d'Avray. Claude Parent and Ionel Schein, 1953.

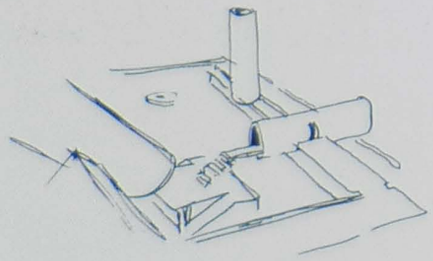
to the relation between programme, concept and built space. Parent cast aside the strictures of functionalism and rationalism in favour of a liberating spatial principle.

Parent's questioning of Modernism was a response to the intellectual climate of the post-war era, and to the ideas of the artist and publisher André Bloc in particular. In the 1930s Bloc had championed the International Style in his magazine, *Architecture d'Aujourd'hui*, but following the war he changed direction, turning first to painting and then to sculpture. In the 1950s he set up a new magazine, *L'Art d'Aujourd'hui*, to promote the idea of a synthesis of the arts, and with Del Marle he founded the Groupe Espace, which explored an abstraction inspired by De Stijl. During this period the language of architecture was redefined by a continual dialogue with sculpture; a new aesthetic was born.

The influence of André Bloc and the Groupe Espace may be seen in the presence of shifted grid compositions of facades and profiles (Pedrizet house,



Soultrait house. Claude Parent, 1957.



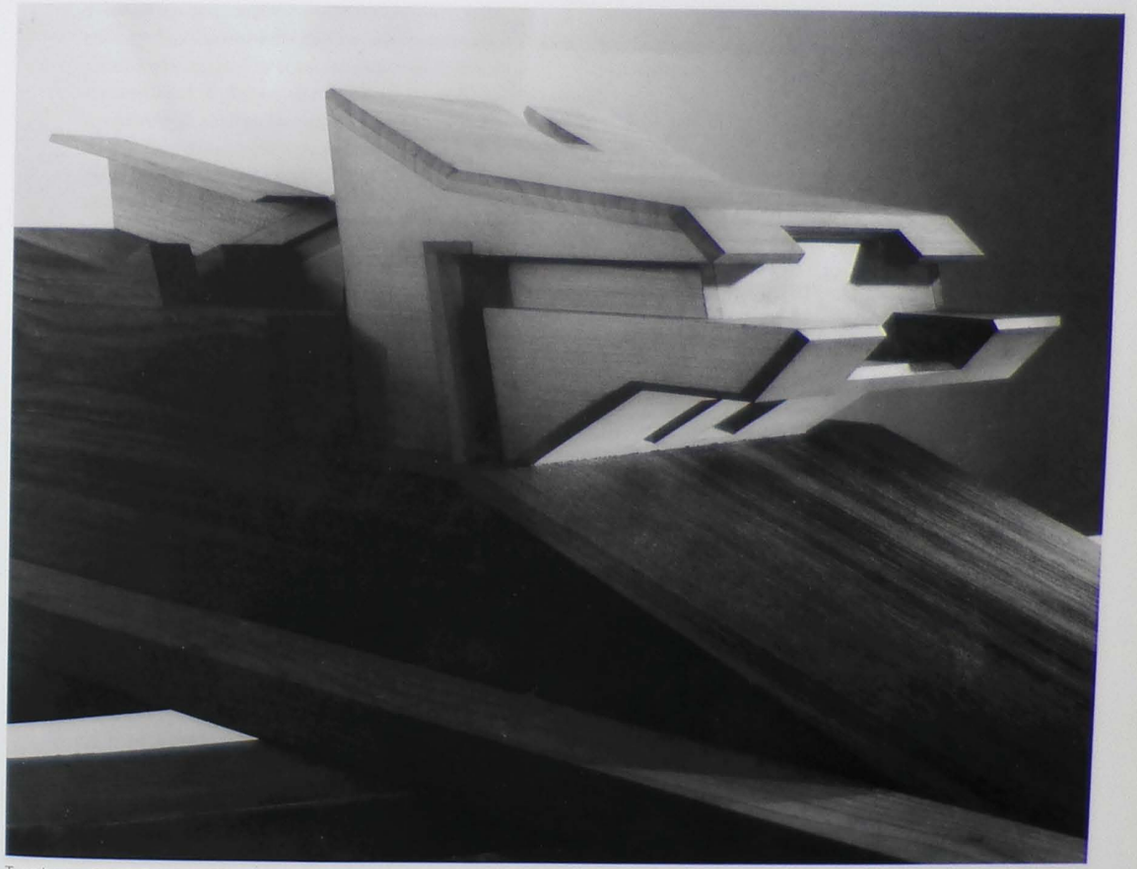
Yves Klein memorial. Claude Parent, 1962.

1955), and the use of superimposed or intersecting concrete frames (Neyret house, 1955, and Parent's own house, 1957). Parent acted as architect for Bloc on three chapels which are characterized by a fragmentation of form, and Bloc in turn painted murals for a number of his houses. However, the limits of their collaboration became clear with the design of Bloc's own house in Antibes (1959). Parent discerned an opportunity to push the dislocation of the modern grid to an extreme, and he proposed to carry the roof structure beyond the mass of the villa, a glass volume set on *pilotis*; Bloc demurred, and asked for the plans to be put back into alignment.

Yet Parent's move towards an architecture of disequilibrium is apparent in an earlier building, the Soultrait house (1957), which has a vast triangular roof structure that seems to rise up, fracture, and then tumble back down to the ground. Parent had progressed from a criticism of internalized geometric space to a dynamic understanding of form.

The impetus for this transition was provided by a member of the Groupe Espace, the sculptor Nicolas Schöffer, who introduced Parent to Neo-plasticism, the Bauhaus and Russian Constructivism, and collaborated with him on a number of projects, culminating in the Spatio-Dynamic City (1954). Schöffer was then investigating ways of translating the concept of spatial dynamism into form. His sculptures, like those of Constant during the same period, incorporated an architecture of motion into a phenomenological understanding of space. Along with Ipoustéguy, Gilioli, Szekely and Di Teana, he was part of a movement in art which explored monolithic spatial volumes.[2]

Parent himself used the sculptures of Mannoni as the starting-point for two architectural projects in 1960, and he undertook further collaborations with artists in an attempt to develop a new approach to the placing of objects in space. He worked with Yves Klein (Architectures of the air, 1958), Georges Patrix (Troyes cultural centre, 1964), Jacques Polieri, Yacov



Tueg house. Claude Parent, 1969.

Agam and Jean Tinguely, among others. But once again it was André Bloc who opened up a new direction for him.

In 1959 Parent assisted André Bloc and Edouard Albert on the Total City project, which was defined by opposing orthogonals (Bloc's contribution) and diagonals (the work of Albert) – an opposition resolved only in a 1963 sculpture by Bloc, which crossed a cube with diagonals. The concept of a cube turned on its edge was subsequently used by Parent as a means of achieving a radical displacement that freed space from the metaphor of the foundation, from the ground itself. The cube was an integral part of two projects of 1963: the Experimental Evolutionary house, which required the participation of its inhabitants, and the Drusch house.

The Drusch house consists of an elongated concrete frame that is split in plan and in volume by a cube (the living space) turned on its edge: the notion of the fracture assumes a truly dynamic quality, as it touches the construction as a whole. In this work Paul Virilio recognized an approach to space that was in sympathy with his own study of political topology – an extensive survey of the German bunkers of the Atlantic Wall that had led him to question whether territory could still be controlled by force.

Through their work together in the Architecture Principe group, Parent and Virilio continued to subvert Modernism's quest for stable foundations. In promoting the oblique – a plane lacking both stability and external references – they were making a radical stand against an architectural culture of geometrical volumes firmly inscribed in space.

In this context, the project for the church of Sainte-Bernadette du Banlay in Nevers (1964–6) may be seen as a built manifesto, for it brought to fruition Parent's investigations into space, and gave concrete, sculptural form to Virilio's idea of a negative, critical aesthetic. The vocabulary of the bunker was intended to create a 'repellent' architecture that would overturn established perceptions and provoke a response from the user, in the same spirit as the work of the Situationists. For Virilio, the bunker expressed fluidity, building without foundation – the Corbusian ideal of the ocean liner. In the church in Nevers, the concrete monolith was combined with the theory of the oblique to reinforce the idea of a dynamic architecture appropriate to modern times. Virilio wrote: 'Each era has its own definition of space relating to the system of geometric references by which a society operates. This fundamental structure determines the basis of "law" and of the different types of appropriation, at the level of both the individual and the population as a whole; social relations being in effect determined by this definition of space.'[3]

Parent and Virilio explored the architectural applications of the oblique in further projects, most notably the Charleville cultural centre (1967) and the Mariotti house (1967). In addition, they used the nine issues of their manifesto-magazine, *Architecture Principe*, to formalize a theoretical position. None the less, their ideas were difficult for many European architects to assimilate – as their polemical reception at the Folkestone IDEA congress of 1966 made clear.[4]

The events of May 1968 signalled the end of the Architecture Principe collaboration, but not of Claude Parent's exploration of the oblique. He designed the oblique Tueg house in 1969, curated an 'oblique' pavilion at the Venice Biennale of 1970, and developed urban projects such as the Inclipan (1974). At the same time he explored ways of using the negating form of the oblique as a tool for social comment: the shopping centres in Reims (1969), Sens (1970) and especially Epernay (1971) may be seen in this light as uncompromising manifestos of a critical architecture. Parent's later designs for nuclear power stations (e.g. Cattenom, 1978) may similarly be understood as an attempt to move towards an irreversible architecture expressive of a society's ability to accept its own contradictions.

However, this somewhat destructive approach has done little to enhance the place in history of a man who has his whole life defended the creative role of the architect within an expanded sphere of participation; who has fought against preconceptions and conformity in order to define – through the act of building – a critical, negating architecture, which embraces risks in the pursuit of its goals.

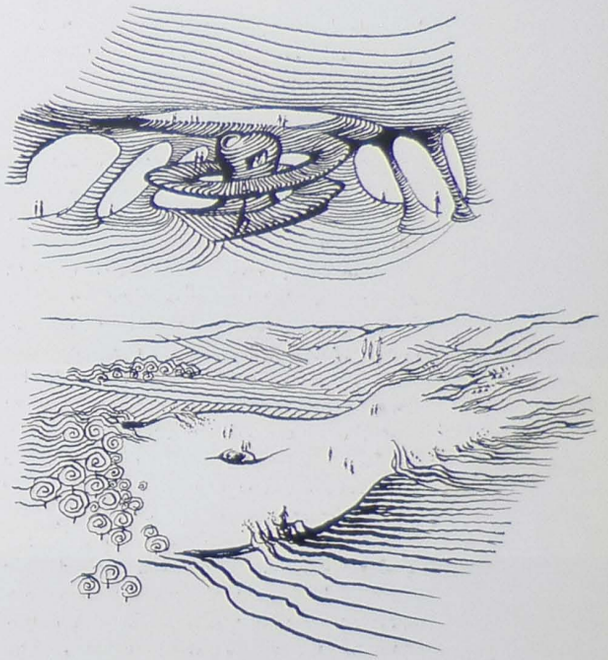
Notes

1 One notable exception is Michel Ragon's critical study of Claude Parent, *Monographie Critique d'un architecte* (Dunod, 1982).

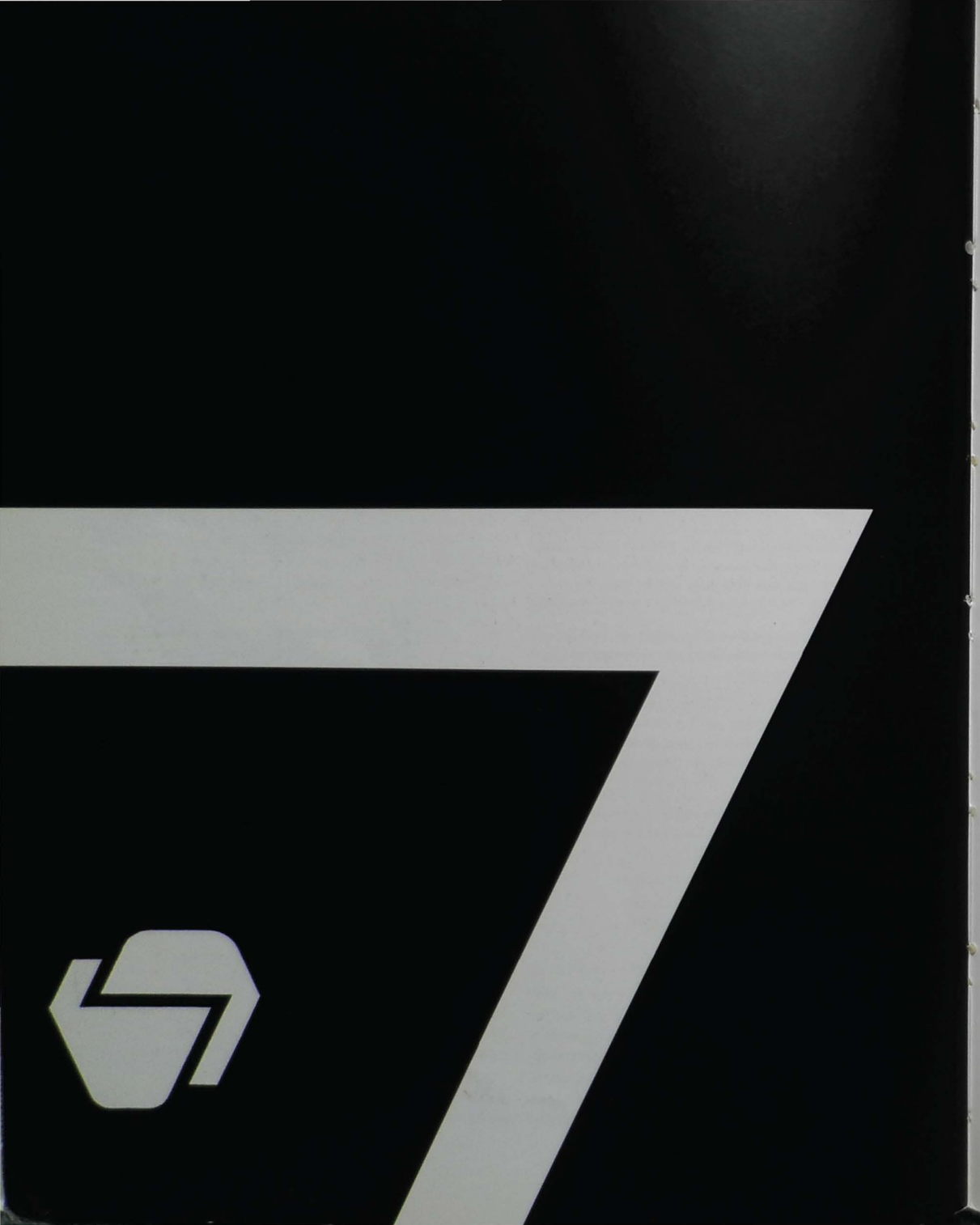
2 Nicolas Schöffer pinpointed the diverging tendencies in sculpture in an article entitled 'L'Art et les mathématiques' (*L'Art d'Aujourd'hui*, 7, 1956), in which he wrote that there were two spatial solutions to a differential proposition containing more than three variables – volumes made of ellipses, similar to those of Pevsner, or monolithic sculptural volumes.

3 Paul Virilio, *Architecture d'Aujourd'hui*, 139, September 1968.

4 'IDEA' stands for the 'International Dialogue of Experimental Architecture'.
[A more detailed account of this 'polemical' reception has been given by a fellow participant in the congress, Dennis Crompton of Archigram:
Parent and Virilio immediately stood out on account of their garb – black suits, in contrast to the psychedelic ensembles favoured by most architects there. They got up on stage, in their black suits, and presented a series of drawings for oblique cities unfolding across the landscape. When they were done, the audience rose up *en masse* and gave them a Hitlerian salute.]



Sacred spiral project. Claude Parent and Ben Jakober, 1984.



Architecture Principe

Texts from the manifesto-magazine

Warning

The state of crisis unfolding in every sphere of human activity, the loss of distinct categories and divisions in the return to a unifying principle, the massive decline in common values and conventions; these are signals of a perhaps unprecedented event.

Throughout history, there have been numerous changes in society, but we have never before witnessed a change in humanity itself. We are now on the brink of such a metamorphosis – a metamorphosis of our consciousness, a disruption of shared perceptions, a radical transformation of the notion of dimensions.

This will be an earth-shaking upheaval – not just the 'change of scale' that was promulgated by early-twentieth-century rationalists, but a complete reversal of meaning. All human activities will be thrown into disarray, and the resulting shock wave will topple, one after the other, the established principles of aesthetics, philosophy and economics.

The transformation of human consciousness is already evident in our behaviour towards the environment, in the growing pressures being exerted on the environment by the tendency towards global uniformity, in the gradual erosion of the pleasures to be derived from the great variety of different kingdoms, species and genera of nature, as these yield to the overwhelming standardizing power of the principal elements: land, space and sea.

Such advanced, definitive totalization necessarily implies a reversal in the hierarchy of dimensions; height becoming length, top becoming edge.

Once the notion of the vertical has been abandoned, a true embodiment of space-time will at last be possible. This crucial act will radically alter the founding principles of the spatial art that is architecture, and singularly amplify its aims and power. The criteria for evaluating a site – the preference for sunlight, the importance of orientation, the requirement for vegetation, etc. – will be stripped of both their traditional bucolic and their newer 'hygienic' terms of reference. The promiscuous concern with the details of a landscape will give way to a cursory awareness of Place. Just as all of man's so-called 'natural environments' have shown themselves to be merely a reflection of primitive superstitions, so too the taste for rusticity will ultimately be revealed as a relic of antiquity.

Urbanism can no longer be solely concerned with the organization of the district and the administration of the city; in future, its only limits will be the elements: continental, marine, spatial. The configuration of these thresholds – the morphology of their relations – will govern all operations. In this respect, present studies of the laws governing space are of considerable interest, because they appear to indicate that urbanism will in future have much more to do with ballistics than with the partition of territories.

In effect, the static vertical and horizontal no longer correspond to the dynamics of human life. In future, architecture must be built on the oblique, so as to accord with the new plane of human consciousness. Any architectural programme that fails to do so will rapidly become useless.

In responding to this direct, ineluctable

psychological force, architecture will be transformed into a truly physiological material, intimately adapted to the needs of the individual. When this happens, it is conceivable that notions of art will coalesce with notions of reality.

The enormity of this phenomenon calls for an immediate renovation of our conceptions of architecture. If this art is to become the great civilizing agent of future societies, it must throw off the passivity that has characterized it until now and take up its role as society's most important tool. If it fails to do so, our familiar troubles will turn into inextricable confusion, and fundamental misery.

Paul Virilio, AP 1, February 1966

Dominate the site

Architecture is not organic; it is designed.

Architecture cannot be assimilated to the object; it is anti-object.

Architecture assembles; it is the very essence of social groupings.

Architecture is not integrated with the site; it remains autonomous, and its relation to the landscape is based upon its quality and size.

In this time of crisis, architecture needs to offer a solution: it has to protect people, help them to survive.

To answer needs, deal with constraints, fight the impossible, architecture has to:

– leave behind existing towns and promote the creation of new urban communities

– dominate the site, become the equivalent of a natural relief

– change its dimensions, become an artificial relief, landscape...

In face of the present uncertainties – in face of anxiety, anguish, collective fear, the rise in violence – architecture has to establish an entirely new way of thinking. It can achieve this by means of two key devices:

– inclined planes, applied to both the formation and the utilization of space

– oblique, cantilevered forms, in which the interior is used for habitation, the exterior for circulation.

Architecture must never be neutral or indeterminate. It must be active; it must continually engage people, draw them into action, involve them in public events. People are essential to the life of the architectural environment (buildings are there to be climbed, conquered).

The basis for the formation of buildings must not be the accumulation, juxtaposition or addition of simple cellular elements. A building's form must be distinguished from the processes of modular agglomeration – as must the study of form. Architecture has to return to the phase of the concept, the principle. Then, by virtue of its dimensions, it will once more achieve monumentality, within a new conception of space.

Communal life will then be integrated with the city, becoming a positive life-force, and no longer the threatening, unpredictable determinant of architectural form.

Architecture will reassert itself. It will become indisputable, undisputed. It will no longer inhabit the domain of the avant-garde. It will *be*. People will recognize it as their own. Other arts will discover in it coherence and reality.

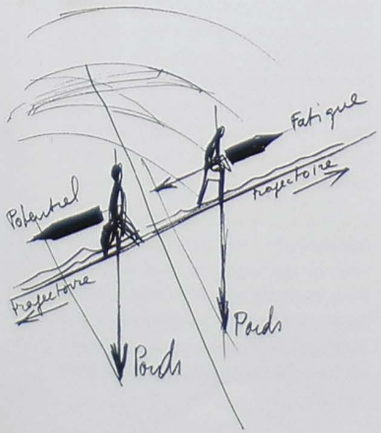
Claude Parent, AP 1, February 1966

Potentialism

Within the built environment there exists an oft-invoked state of crisis. Mankind's indifference to architecture is well known. There have been attempts to remedy this. The method chosen is to 'shock' people by proposing an architecture that is incompatible with their tastes or habits. This jolts them out of their general apathy, but it fails to win them over.

Such are the battles that the various movements in contemporary architecture have engaged in – futile battles, because formal tools very quickly lose their edge in a world that is driven by insatiable consumerism. Thus all theories based upon the invention and application of a particular architectural form have failed.

In order to open up communication, to engage people and ultimately to win them over, it is necessary to draw them into an environment, to make them feel, deep down, that they are becoming part of a universal architecture. 'Potentialism' entails the use of specifically architectural methods to bring about this state of mind, which is characterised initially by receptiveness, then by participation, and ultimately by a sense of belonging.



The first step is therefore simply to promote awareness. The only means of doing so is to elicit such intense 'displeasure' that people are forced into a state of refusal – of REPULSION.

The second step is to supply the means of overcoming this initial response, that is to say, of moving beyond refusal. The newly freed potential of architecture, POTENTIALISM, activates an unconscious mechanism that absorbs people, integrates them into a movement which is of an architectural character.

These two strategies, carried out in tandem, precipitate a second state in which people – unconsciously, without prejudice, without the shackles of a received culture, without scepticism – rediscover the freedom of autonomous behaviour. Thus liberated, they will be able to evolve unconventional means of communicating with and consciously PARTICIPATING in architecture. They will have before them the EVIDENCE of the UNITY of man and architecture.

Claude Parent, AP 3, April 1966

Habitable circulation

We do not yet know how to combine the property of solidity and the property of fluidity. While other disciplines resolved the problem of fluidity long ago, architecture seems to have been paralysed by human movement, powerless to prevent the incompatible forces of motion and immobility from destroying the modern metropolis.

The social phenomenon of mass migrations, the variety of energy sources required by an industrial society or advanced scientific enterprises, even the forces of nature – all are fluid, none has been absorbed by the modern city. In all its manifestations, movement has become the agent of our cities' destruction.

In a world in which everything is transformed – the element into energy, the point into route – it is no longer feasible to separate habitation from circulation. From now on, there will be a confrontation between two fundamental forces: 'MOBILE ARCHITECTURE' and 'HABITABLE CIRCULATION'.

The first of these, while opportunistically incorporating the word 'architecture', in fact shares the aims of industry – and consequently its methods and effects. The second, though it perhaps seems a contradiction in terms, simply returns to the roots of architecture to find a solution to the problems of fluidity.

Civil architecture has been considered for too long solely in terms of its protective role, and its present stagnation is undoubtedly the result of an imperfect understanding of its true nature.

It is no accident that real architecture has often sought refuge in the stairway, the bridge, the barricade or the highway

interchange: these tasks have presented it with a challenge, whereas the dwelling condemns it to a total passivity.

Through the ages, architecture has realized its full potential, its full power, only when confronted by another force – spiritual or material. At the beginning of this century society was not powerful enough to stimulate a civil architecture of true value. And today, weighted down by the mass of the population, civil architecture has become unutterably inert.

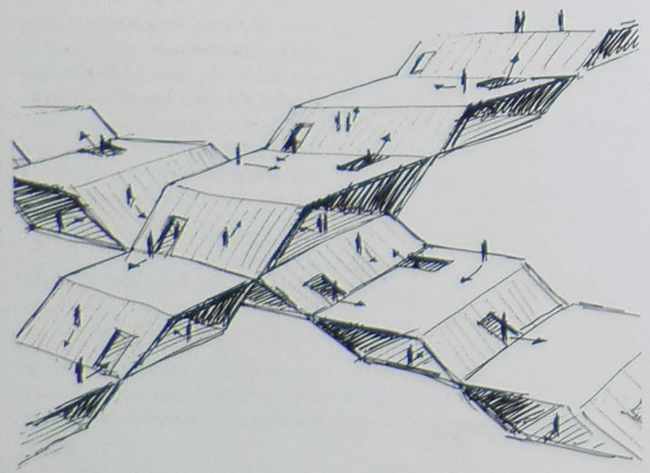
But finally the conditions are ripe for the emergence of a civil architecture, for this spatial art to pass from the private to the public realm and, in so doing, to accede to its true role – the invention of society.

Architecture must no longer be content to accompany, or even worse, to define itself in terms of circulation, for this dissipates its specific character. To bring about change, it is necessary to devise an urbanism in which circulation becomes habitable – an architecture in which an animating oblique function supplants the neutralizing one of the fixed horizontal plane, an architecture in which mankind is propelled by the very profile of its habitat, in which the city becomes an enormous projector, a torrent of every kind of activity, every kind of fluidity.

The problem is one of conflating the two central roles of architecture without getting them confused, as is the case with mobile architecture. For too long we have separated structure and circulation and, while the vertical order has given rise to facadism and has emphasized the visual at the expense of the effective, the horizontal order long ago corrupted architecture by limiting its role to the provision of stability and shelter.

Tomorrow's architecture will essentially be one of circulation: static space will yield to spaces of transfer – the habitat, like the city as a whole, will be mobilized by the function of the oblique.

Paul Virilio, AP 3, April 1966



Mankind uprooted

In this second half of the twentieth century weapons are being massed for an implacable campaign against architecture. This time, the aim is to crush it for ever.

The 'ORGANIZERS' are uprooting people in order to make them malleable, quantifiable, cataloguable, analysable – mere units in a well-meaning statistical exercise that leaves nothing to chance. The intention: to construct, for this uprooted species, a space that has no future because it is founded upon an analysis of the present – a world of easy comfort and consumption extrapolated from the insatiable demands of today. This is the future proposed (and indeed desired) by a defunct power which has abrogated its responsiblities towards the individual, choosing instead to pander to the urges of the masses, who have become mere consumers.

Careers officers, planners, engineers, technical experts, administrators, legal and financial advisers, insurers, sociologists, psycho-sociologists, ethnologists, climatologists, geographers, demographers, decorators and designers – all are carrying out the necessary work of levelling, with a serenity that derives from the certainty that they are acting in the best interests of mankind. These professions are diminishing the role of architects, the last brachycephalics of the species.

But this attack on a discipline whose function is to root – to position – mankind is not being carried out in a straightforward fashion. Rather than line up for a head-on confrontation, the 'organizers' have chosen a more efficient solution – betrayal. They have enlisted the aid of certain key figures, among them architects who, consciously or not, have embarked upon the systematic destruction of their art at the very moment when its practice has sunk to its lowest ever level. By choosing to complain rather than to celebrate the unique role of architecture, such 'spokesmen' are outdoing even the 'organizers'. Under the pretext of revitalizing the discipline, they are injecting it with the lethal (i.e. non-specific) germs of other disciplines.

But we would like to say to:

- those who have been trying for several years to submit architecture to the ends of industry
- those who are standardizing
- those who are demolishing the mass and working furiously against it
- those who advocate the undiscriminating use of purely mathematical structures which are erected under the guise of 'architecture'
- those who want to conflate the roles of architect and engineer
- those who argue for economy in the current narrow, short-sighted sense of the term, who argue for a reduction in the cost price of each element without considering the implications of such an approach for the economy as a whole
- those who submit architecture to the profit notion prevailing in industry
- those who, in order to achieve all this, reduce architecture to being merely the sum of its elements – ideally, a sum comprising industrial elements, in keeping with their admiration for mass production
- those who go on and on about 'human scale'
- those who subjugate both the scale and the intentions of architecture to man, and who see in the provision of 'comfort' the supreme function, the ultimate aim
- those who are so frightened by the responsibilities attendant upon true creativity that they try to be as flexible, mobile, supple and adaptable as possible, which results in an architecture that is neutral, indeterminate
- those who are pushing mankind towards NOMADISM
- those who believe that architecture and urbanism are not so much the preserve of the architect as the product of a concerted study carried out by a multidisciplinary group or team with no creative hierarchy
- those who do not believe in the autonomy of architecture
- those who demand humility of architecture
- those who BETRAY architecture

We would like to say, to all those people: we are MOBILIZING, and declaring a state of war.

Claude Parent, AP 3, April 1966

Structure

A structure is a physical framework that gives support to the mind. Architecture is the structure that links the elements of the universe: land, air, sea and man. Within its physical forms, it sustains the potential to serve as a bridge, as a means of transfer between the mind and the perceived world. This transfer is made possible by the materialization of the notion of Space.

It is the very materiality of architecture which makes it ineluctable. Without an architecture–structure, we would be incapable of establishing terms of reference for the things around us. Without this skill of transfer, we would be cut off from the world. At a time when space exploration is 'abstracting' us from our traditional framework of support, we need architecture more than ever. At present it is the essential condition, the fundamental base that will provide our species with some chance of success in tackling the next stage of our existence: survival.

However, this transfer can only be achieved if there is a conscious engagement with architecture. People have to become more aware, more receptive. The 'POTENTIALITY' of architecture must be revealed, made palpable. The function of the oblique is our only hope of achieving this. The introduction of the VECTORS of tiredness (ascent) and euphoria (descent) combats the neutrality of the users of a place and gives 'direction' to its occupation. The inclined plane ensures that this 'direction' is no longer of necessity restricted to the vertical – i.e. a line perpendicular to the reference-plane of the earth – but is rather a more complex projection combining mass and intention. The com-

manding presence of 'intention' ensures that the mind is engaged by the architecture. People will no longer be able to maintain their neutrality or indifference by erecting barriers of inertia or of familiarity.

The function of the oblique forces a conscious participation by drawing out the 'POTENTIAL CHARGE' that resides within each individual. The elements of this charge will be speculated upon and then analysed and studied through a series of experiments conducted according to rigorous scientific methods.

With regard to the inclined plane, the following conditions can already be adduced:

ACTIVATION / The exercise of choice with regard to a place according to the potential of gravity, with the chosen direction either supplying or consuming energy.

VERTIGO / The condition induced by the loss of the traditional reference-system of the vertical and the horizontal.

CONFINEMENT / A psychological reaction to 'cryptic' interior spaces that offer no direct views of the outside.

DEPOLARIZATION / A modification of behaviour with regard to solar orientation.

CANALIZATION / An exploration of means of visualization through views from above or below, overhanging views, vistas, panoramic views from elevated places.

CONTINUUM / A growing awareness of belonging to a continuous, permanently unfolding architectural environment.

The search for new human elements to the function of occupying a place will always remain open.

Claude Parent, AP 3, April 1966

The mediated city

The function of urbanism is to create mediated structures that establish a link between a portion of the lithosphere and a layer of the atmosphere.

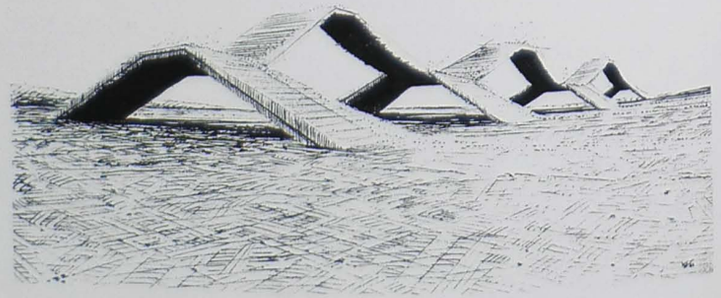
Unfortunately, for the majority of urbanists the word 'elevation' does not seem to suggest anything more than a means of increasing occupation density. To consider a spatial dimension solely as a means of 'stacking' is clearly a scandal. This attitude, perhaps a legacy of archaic rural society, has given rise to an extraordinary situation: dwellings tend to uniformity, regardless of whether they are above or below ground. Remarkably, in the transition from the solid and opaque earth to the transparent and gaseous atmosphere, the standard unit gains no more than window openings.

It therefore seems that we must acknowledge the paradox of a three-dimensional art which up to now has failed to take advantage of its spatial possibilities. The inability of architects to work both above and below the horizon line, two distinct spheres of operation, is undeniable: the proof is all around us.

The ground is still thought of as absolute and anchoring. This conception must be set aside to make way for one in which it is solely the boundary or threshold between two specific spaces, two particular natural states. From now on the ground must be regarded, not as the 'plinth of verticality', but as the 'axis line' of the architectonic operation.

Whereas there are only three options for a building organized along the vertical – 1 rise up, 2 move outwards, 3 shift forward/back – an oblique *surrection* can form a wide variety of configurations, depending on the angles of its slopes and all their possible combinations.

Urbanism should no longer be about setting out on the ground 'bull's-eyes' of urban concentration or conglomeration (the former achieved by an immediate centrality, the latter by an equally immediate verticality). Instead, we need to devise mediated structures that incorporate both habitation and circulation. These would form interlinked assemblages that would develop and spread out over regions, along the vital arteries of a territory, providing a hier-



archy of uses in response to the needs of the time and the populace. Thus ENFRANCHISEMENT would be revealed as the fundamental term of the new urbanization.

At a time when physical constraints are multiplying, when alienation has become commonplace, we must, for the sake of society, use the incline, the curve, and topological or rather TOPOTONIC means to exploit the full potential of space.

Paul Virilio, AP 6, August 1966

Bunker archaeology

The physical evidence of a dramatic moment in modern history is disappearing. Six thousand monuments, stripped of their purpose and cut off from the present, seem now to suggest a mysterious presence.

Using the techniques of archaeology, I have explored the subterranean world of one of the esoteric forms of our times: the blockhouse. The plan of the blockhouse is strangely reminiscent of that of an Aztec temple, while its concealed siting relates it also to ancient Egyptian and Etruscan tombs. But, whereas the pyramidal or circular form of those ancient monuments was a conscious evocation of a sacred symbol, a cosmic image, any such figure in the blockhouse is both implicit and involuntary.

Moreover, the geometry is no longer affirmatory, but eroded, worn. The right angle is reduced, suppressed, in order to make the structure resistant to capture. The mass is no longer grounded in the earth, but centred upon itself, independent, capable of movement and articulation. The architecture floats on the surface of an earth that has lost its materiality.

When I approached one of these monoliths on a beach, it seemed to assume an almost animal form, like a carcass abandoned, kicked over in the sand – the sloughed-off skin of a long-extinct species. And when I went inside I felt a peculiar oppressiveness; the thickness of the walls was palpable. Here was a second envelope, a psychological one that served to heighten certain senses, to shelter certain activities. There were no windows to illuminate the interior, the opening presented only a view of the exterior, precisely defined, as if by a searchlight.

In this survival machine, life was not a neutral force but an exercise in becoming more subtle, more essential.

These primitive structures, an astonishing example of an era's blindness towards itself, have taken on the banal appearance of a mere residue – of a talus which survives only because of the difficulty of demolishing it. Yet they herald a new architecture that is founded no longer on man's bodily proportions, but on his capacity for thought; an urbanism in which the simplified analyses of social conditions are finally transcended, allowing the habitat to be intimately joined with the hidden possibilities contained within the individual being.

Paul Virilio, AP 7, March 1967
(Reprint of an article written in 1958)

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6

THE SPLIT BETWEEN THE EYE AND THE GAZE

The split of the subject · The facticity of the trauma · Maurice Merleau-Ponty · The philosophical tradition · Mimicry · The all-seer · In the dream, it shows

To continue.

Wiederholung—let me remind you once again of the etymological reference that I gave you, *holen* (to haul), of its connotation of something tiring, exhausting.

To haul, to draw. To draw what? Perhaps, playing on the ambiguity of the word in French, to draw lots (*tirer au sort*). This *Zwang*, this compulsion, would then direct us towards the obligatory card—if there is only one card in the pack, I can't draw another.

The character of a set, in the mathematical sense of the term, possessed by the play of signifiers, and which opposes it for example to the indefiniteness of the whole number, enables us to conceive a schema in which the function of the obligatory card is immediately applicable. If the subject is the subject of the signifier—determined by it—one may imagine the synchronic network as it appears in the diachrony of preferential effects. This is not a question, you understand, of unpredictable statistical effects—it is the very structure of the network that implies the returns. Through the elucidation of what we call strategies, this is the figure that Aristotle's *automaton* assumes for us. Furthermore, it is by *automatisme* that we sometimes translate into French the *Zwang* of the *Wiederholungszwang*, the compulsion to repeat.

I

Later, I shall give you the facts that suggest that at certain moments of that infantile monologue, imprudently termed

egocentric, there are strictly syntactical games to be observed. These games belong to the field that we call pre-conscious, but make, one might say, the bed of the unconscious reserve—to be understood in the sense of an Indian reserve—within the social network.

Syntax, of course, is pre-conscious. But what eludes the subject is the fact that his syntax is in relation with the unconscious reserve. When the subject tells his story, something acts, in a latent way, that governs this syntax and makes it more and more condensed. Condensed in relation to what? In relation to what Freud, at the beginning of his description of psychical resistance, calls a nucleus.

To say that this nucleus refers to something traumatic is no more than an approximation. We must distinguish between the resistance of the subject and that first resistance of discourse, when the discourse proceeds towards the condensation around the nucleus. For the expression *resistance of the subject* too much implies the existence of a supposed ego and it is not certain whether—at the approach of this nucleus—it is something that we can justifiably call an ego.

The nucleus must be designated as belonging to the real—the real in so far as the identity of perception is its rule. At most, it is grounded on what Freud indicates as a sort of deduction, which assures us that we are in perception by means of the sense of reality that authenticates it. What does this mean, if not that, as far as the subject is concerned, this is called awakening?

Although, last time, it was around the dream in chapter seven of *The Interpretation of Dreams* that I approached the whole question of repetition, it was because the choice of this dream —so enclosed, so doubly and triply enclosed as it is, since it is not analysed—is very revealing here, occurring as it does at the moment when Freud is dealing with the process of the dream in its last resort. Is the reality that determines the awakening the slight noise against which the empire of the dream and of desire is maintained? Is it not rather something else? Is it not that which is expressed in the depths of the anxiety of this dream—namely, the most intimate aspects of the relation between the father and the son, which emerges, not so much in that death as in the fact that it is beyond, in the sense of destiny?

Between what occurs as if by chance, when everybody is asleep—the candle that overturns and the sheets that catch fire, the meaningless event, the accident, the piece of bad luck—and the element of poignancy, however veiled, in the words *Father, can't you see I'm burning*—there is the same relation to what we were dealing with in repetition. It is what, for us, is represented in the term neurosis of destiny or neurosis of failure. What is missed is not adaptation, but *tuché*, the encounter.

Aristotle's formula—that the *tuché* is defined by being able to come to us only from a being capable of choice, *proairesis*, that the *tuché*, good or bad fortune, cannot come to us from an inanimate object, a child or an animal—is controverted here. The very accident of this exemplary dream depicts this. Certainly, Aristotle marks the extreme limit of that point that stops it on the edge of the extravagant forms of sexual behaviour, which he can only describe as *teriotes*, monstrosities.

The enclosed aspect of the relation between the accident, which is repeated, and the veiled meaning, which is the true reality and leads us towards the drive—confirms for us that the demystification of that artefact of treatment known as the transference does not consist in reducing it to what is called the actuality of the situation. The direction indicated in this reduction to the actuality of the session, or the series of sessions, is not even of propedeutic value. The correct concept of repetition must be obtained in another direction, which we cannot confuse with the effects of the transference taken as a whole. Our next problem, when we approach the function of the transference, will be to grasp how the transference may lead us to the heart of repetition.

That is why it is necessary to ground this repetition first of all in the very split that occurs in the subject in relation to the encounter. This split constitutes the characteristic dimension of analytic discovery and experience; it enables us to apprehend the real, in its dialectical effects, as originally unwelcome. It is precisely through this that the real finds itself, in the subject, to a very great degree the accomplice of the drive—which we shall come to last, because only by following this way will we be able to conceive from what it returns.

For, after all, why is the primal scene so traumatic? Why is it always too early or too late? Why does the subject take

either too much pleasure in it—at least, this is how at first we conceived the traumatizing causality of the obsessional neurotic —or too little, as in the case of the hysteric? Why doesn't it arouse the subject immediately, if it is true that he is so profoundly libidinal? Why is the fact here *dustuchia*? Why is the supposed maturation of the pseudo-instincts shot through, transfixed with the *tychic*, I would say—from the word *tuché*?

For the moment, it is our horizon that seems factitious in the fundamental relation to sexuality. In analytic experience, it is a question of setting out from the fact that the primal scene is traumatic; it is not sexual empathy that sustains the modulations of the analysable, but a factitious fact. A factitious fact, like that which appears in the scene so fiercely tracked down in the experience of the Wolf Man—the strangeness of the disappearance and reappearance of the penis.

Last time, I wanted to point out where the split in the subject lay. This split, after awakening, persists—between the return to the real, the representation of the world that has at last fallen back on its feet, arms raised, *what a terrible thing, what has happened, how horrible, how stupid, what an idiot he was to fall asleep* —and the consciousness re-weaving itself, which knows it is living through all this as through a nightmare, but which, all the same, keeps a grip on itself, *it is I who am living through all this, I have no need to pinch myself to known that I am not dreaming.* The fact remains that this split is still there only as representing the more profound split, which is situated between that which refers to the subject in the machinery of the dream, the image of the approaching child, his face full of reproach and, on the other hand, that which causes it and into which he sinks, the invocation, the voice of the child, the solicitation of the gaze —*Father can't you see . . .*

2

It is there that—free as I am to pursue, in the path in which I am leading you, the way that seems best to me—threading my curved needle through the tapestry, I jump on to the side on which is posed the question that offers itself as a crossroads, between us and all those who try to conceive of the way of the subject.

In so far as it is a search for truth, is this way to be forged in

our style of adventure, with its trauma seen as a reflection of facticity? Or is it to be located where tradition has always placed it, at the level of the dialectic of truth and appearance, grasped at the outset of perception in its fundamentally ideic, in a way aesthetic, and accentuated character as visual centring?

It is not mere chance—belonging to the order of the pure *tychic*—if this very week I have received a copy of the newly published, posthumous work of my friend Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Le Visible et l'invisible.*

Here is expressed, embodied, what made the alternation of our dialogue, and I remember so clearly the Congrès de Bonneval where his intervention revealed the nature of his path, a path that had broken off at one point of the *oeuvre*, which left it nevertheless in a state of completion, prefigured in the work of piety that we owe to Claude Lefort, to whom I would like to pay homage here for the kind of perfection which, in a long and difficult transcription, he seems to me to have achieved.

This work, *Le Visible et l'invisible*, may indicate for us the moment of arrival of the philosophical tradition—the tradition that begins with Plato with the promulgation of the idea, of which one may say that, setting out from an aesthetic world, it is determined by an end given to being as sovereign good, thus attaining a beauty that is also its limit. And it is not by chance that Maurice Merleau-Ponty recognized its guide in the eye.

In this work, which is both an end and a beginning, you will find both a recapitulation and a step forward in the path of what had first been formulated in Merleau-Ponty's *La Phénoménologie de la perception.* In this work, one finds a recapitulation of the regulatory function of form, invoked in opposition to that which, as philosophical thinking progressed, had been taken to that extreme of vertigo expressed in the term idealism—how could the 'lining' that representation then became be joined to that which it is supposed to cover? *La Phénoménologie* brings us back, then, to the regulation of form, which is governed, not only by the subject's eye, but by his expectations, his movement, his grip, his muscular and visceral emotion—in short, his constitutive presence, directed in what is called his total intentionality.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty now makes the next step by forcing

the limits of this very phenomenology. You will see that the ways through which he will lead you are not only of the order of visual phenomenology, since they set out to rediscover—this is the essential point—the dependence of the visible on that which places us under the eye of the seer. But this is going too far, for that eye is only the metaphor of something that I would prefer to call the seer's 'shoot' (*pousse*)—something prior to his eye. What we have to circumscribe, by means of the path he indicates for us, is the pre-existence of a gaze—I see only from one point, but in my existence I am looked at from all sides.

It is no doubt this *seeing*, to which I am subjected in an original way, that must lead us to the aims of this work, to that ontological turning back, the bases of which are no doubt to be found in a more primitive institution of form.

Precisely this gives me an opportunity to reply to someone that, of course, I have my ontology—why not?—like everyone else, however naïve or elaborate it may be. But, certainly, what I try to outline in my discourse—which, although it reinterprets that of Freud, is nevertheless centred essentially on the particularity of the experience it describes—makes no claim to cover the entire field of experience. Even this between-the-two that opens up for us the apprehension of the unconscious is of concern to us only in as much as it is designated for us, through the instructions Freud left us, as that of which the subject has to take possession. I will only add that the maintenance of this aspect of Freudianism, which is often described as naturalism, seems to be indispensable, for it is one of the few attempts, if not the only one, to embody psychical reality without substantifying it.

In the field offered us by Maurice Merleau-Ponty, more or less polarized indeed by the threads of our experience, the scopic field, the ontological status, is presented by its most factitious, not to say most outworn, effects. But it is not between the invisible and the visible that we have to pass. The split that concerns us is not the distance that derives from the fact that there are forms imposed by the world towards which the intentionality of phenomenological experience directs us—hence the limits that we encounter in the experience of the visible. The gaze is presented to us only in the form of a strange contingency, symbolic of what we find on the horizon, as the thrust

of our experience, namely, the lack that constitutes castration anxiety.

The eye and the gaze—this is for us the split in which the drive is manifested at the level of the scopic field.

3

In our relation to things, in so far as this relation is constituted by the way of vision, and ordered in the figures of representation, something slips, passes, is transmitted, from stage to stage, and is always to some degree eluded in it—that is what we call the gaze.

You can be made aware of this in more than one way. Let me describe it, at its extreme point, by one of the enigmas that the reference to nature presents us with. It is a question of nothing less than the phenomenon known as mimicry.

A lot has been said about this subject and a great deal that is absurd—for example, that the phenomenon of mimicry can be explained in terms of adaptation. I do not think this is the case. I need only refer you, among others, to a short work that many of you may already know, Roger Caillois' *Méduse et compagnie*, in which the reference to adaptation is criticized in a particularly perspicacious way. On the one hand, in order to be effective, the determining mutation of mimicry, in the insect, for example, may take place only at once and at the outset. On the other hand, its supposed selective effects are annihilated by the observation that one finds in the stomach of birds, predators in particular, as many insects supposedly protected by mimicry as insects that are not.

But, in any case, the problem does not lie there. The most radical problem of mimicry is to know whether we must attribute it to some formative power of the very organism that shows us its manifestations. For this to be legitimate, we would have to be able to conceive by what circuits this force might find itself in a position to control, not only the very form of the imitated body, but its relation to the environment, from which is has to be distinguished or, on the contrary, in which it has to merge. In short, as Caillois reminds us very pertinently, on the subject of such mimetic manifestations, and especially of the manifestation that may remind us of the function of the eyes, that is, the *ocelli*, it is a question of understanding whether they

impress—it is a fact that they have this effect on the predator or on the supposed victim that looks at them—whether they impress by their resemblance to eyes, or whether, on the contrary, the eyes are fascinating only by virtue of their relation to the form of the *ocelli*. In other words, must we not distinguish between the function of the eye and that of the gaze?

This distinctive example, chosen as such—for its location, for its facticity, for its exceptional character—is for us simply a small manifestation of the function to be isolated, the function, let us say the word, of *the stain*. This example is valuable in marking the pre-existence to the seen of a given-to-be-seen.

There is no need for us to refer to some supposition of the existence of a universal seer. If the function of the stain is recognized in its autonomy and identified with that of the gaze, we can seek its track, its thread, its trace, at every stage of the constitution of the world, in the scopic field. We will then realize that the function of the stain and of the gaze is both that which governs the gaze most secretly and that which always escapes from the grasp of that form of vision that is satisfied with itself in imagining itself as consciousness.

That in which the consciousness may turn back upon itself —grasp itself, like Valéry's Young Parque, *as seeing oneself seeing oneself*—represents mere sleight of hand. An avoidance of the function of the gaze is at work there.

This much we can map of this topology, which last time we worked out for ourselves on the basis of that which appears from the position of the subject when he accedes to the imaginary forms offered him by the dream, as opposed to those of the waking state.

Similarly, in that order, which is particularly satisfying for the subject, connoted in psycho-analytic experience by the term narcissism—in which I have striven to reintroduce the essential structure it derives from its reference to the specular image—in the satisfaction, not to say self-satisfaction, that diffuses from it, which gives the subject a pretext for such a profound *méconnaissance*—and does its empire not extend as far as this reference of the philosophical tradition represented by plenitude encountered by the subject in the mode of contemplation—can we not also grasp that which has been eluded, namely, the function of the gaze? I mean, and Maurice

Merleau-Ponty points this out, that we are beings who are looked at, in the spectacle of the world. That which makes us consciousness institutes us by the same token as *speculum mundi*. Is there no satisfaction in being under that gaze of which, following Merleau-Ponty, I spoke just now, that gaze that circumscribes us, and which in the first instance makes us beings who are looked at, but without showing this?

The spectacle of the world, in this sense, appears to us as all-seeing. This is the phantasy to be found in the Platonic perspective of an absolute being to whom is transferred the quality of being all-seeing. At the very level of the phenomenal experience of contemplation, this all-seeing aspect is to be found in the satisfaction of a woman who knows that she is being looked at, on condition that one does not show her that one knows that she knows.

The world is all-seeing, but it is not exhibitionistic—it does not provoke our gaze. When it begins to provoke it, the feeling of strangeness begins too.

What does this mean, if not that, in the so-called waking state, there is an elision of the gaze, and an elision of the fact that not only does it look, *it* also *shows*. In the field of the dream, on the other hand, what characterizes the images is that *it shows*.

It shows—but here, too, some form of 'sliding away' of the subject is apparent. Look up some description of a dream, any one—not only the one I referred to last time, in which, after all, what I am going to say may remain enigmatic, but any dream—place it in its co-ordinates, and you will see that this *it shows* is well to the fore. So much is it to the fore, with the characteristics in which it is co-ordinated—namely, the absence of horizon, the enclosure, of that which is contemplated in the waking state, and, also, the character of emergence, of contrast, of stain, of its images, the intensification of their colours—that, in the final resort, our position in the dream is profoundly that of someone who does not see. The subject does not see where it is leading, he follows. He may even on occasion detach himself, tell himself that it is a dream, but in no case will he be able to apprehend himself in the dream in the way in which, in the Cartesian *cogito*, he apprehends himself as thought. He may say to himself, *It's only a dream*. But he does

not apprehend himself as someone who says to himself—*After all, I am the consciousness of this dream.*

In a dream, he is a butterfly. What does this mean? It means that he sees the butterfly in his reality as gaze. What are so many figures, so many shapes, so many colours, if not this gratuitous *showing*, in which is marked for us the primal nature of the essence of the gaze. Good heavens, it is a butterfly that is not very different from the one that terrorized the Wolf Man —and Maurice Merleau-Ponty is well aware of the importance of it and refers us to it in a footnote to his text. When Choang-tsu wakes up, he may ask himself whether it is not the butterfly who dreams that he is Choang-tsu. Indeed, he is right, and doubly so, first because it proves he is not mad, he does not regard himself as absolutely identical with Choang-tsu and, secondly, because he does not fully understand how right he is. In fact, it is when he was the butterfly that he apprehended one of the roots of his identity—that he was, and is, in his essence, that butterfly who paints himself with his own colours —and it is because of this that, in the last resort, he is Choang-tsu.

This is proved by the fact that, when he is the butterfly, the idea does not occur to him to wonder whether, when he is Choang-tsu awake, he is not the butterfly that he is dreaming of being. This is because, when dreaming of being the butterfly, he will no doubt have to bear witness later that he represented himself as a butterfly. But this does not mean that he is captivated by the butterfly—he is a captive butterfly, but captured by nothing, for, in the dream, he is a butterfly for nobody. It is when he is awake that he is Choang-tsu for others, and is caught in their butterfly net.

This is why the butterfly may—if the subject is not Choang-tsu, but the Wolf Man—inspire in him the phobic terror of recognizing that the beating of little wings is not so very far from the beating of causation, of the primal stripe marking his being for the first time with the grid of desire.

Next time, I propose to introduce you to the essence of scopic satisfaction. The gaze may contain in itself the *objet a* of the Lacanian algebra where the subject falls, and what specifies the scopic field and engenders the satisfaction proper to it is the fact that, for structural reasons, the fall of the subject always

remains unperceived, for it is reduced to zero. In so far as the gaze, *qua objet a*, may come to symbolize this central lack expressed in the phenomenon of castration, and in so far as it is an *objet a* reduced, of its nature, to a punctiform, evanescent function, it leaves the subject in ignorance as to what there is beyond the appearance, an ignorance so characteristic of all progress in thought that occurs in the way constituted by philosophical research.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

X. AUDOUARD: *To what extent is it necessary, in analysis, to let the subject know that one is looking at him, that is to say, that one is situated as the person who is observing in the subject the process of looking at oneself?*

LACAN: I shall take up again what I have said above, adding that my discourse here has two aims, one of concern to analysts, the other to those who have come here in order to discover whether psycho-analysis is a science.

Psycho-analysis is neither a *Weltanschauung*, nor a philosophy that claims to provide the key to the universe. It is governed by a particular aim, which is historically defined by the elaboration of the notion of the subject. It poses this notion in a new way, by leading the subject back to his signifying dependence.

To go from perception to science is a perspective that seems to be self-evident, in so far as the subject has no better testing ground for the apprehension of being. This way is the same one that Aristotle follows, taking as his starting-point the pre-Socratics. But it is a way that analytic experience must rectify, because it avoids the abyss of castration. We see this, for example, in the fact that the *tuché* does not enter, except in a punctiform way, into theogony and genesis.

I am trying here to grasp how the *tuché* is represented in visual apprehension. I shall show that it is at the level that I call the stain that the *tychic* point in the scopic function is found. This means that the level of reciprocity between the gaze and the gazed at is, for the subject, more open than any other to alibi. That is why we should try to avoid, by our interventions in the session, allowing the subject to establish himself on this level. On the contrary, we should cut him off from this point of ultimate gaze, which is illusory.

The obstacle you point out is certainly there to illustrate the fact that we take a great deal of care. We do not say to the patient, at every end and turn, *Now, now! What a face you're making!*, or, *The top button of your waistcoat is undone.* It is not, after all, for nothing that analysis is not carried out face to face. The split between gaze and vision will enable us, you will see, to add the scopic drive to the list of the drives. If we know how to read it, we shall see that Freud already places this drive to the fore in *Triebe und Triebschicksale* ('Instincts and their Vicissitudes'), and shows that it is not homologous with the others. Indeed, it is this drive that most completely eludes the term castration.

19 February 1964

7

ANAMORPHOSIS

Of the foundation of consciousness · The privilege of the gaze as objet a · *The optics of the blind · The phallus in the picture*

Vainement ton image arrive à ma rencontre
Et ne m'entre où je suis qui seulement la montre
Toi te tournant vers moi tu ne saurais trouver
Au mur de mon regard que ton ombre rêvée

Je suis ce malheureux comparable aux miroirs
Qui peuvent réfléchir mais ne peuvent pas voir
Comme eux mon oeil est vide et comme eux habité
De l'absence de toi qui fait sa cécité[1]

You may remember that, in one of my earlier lectures, I began by quoting the poem, *Contrechant*, from Aragon's *Le Fou d'Elsa*. I did not realize at the time that I would be developing the subject of the gaze to such an extent. I was diverted into doing so by the way in which I presented the concept of repetition in Freud.

We cannot deny that it is within the explanation of repetition that this digression on the scopic function is situated — no doubt by Maurice Merleau-Ponty's recently published work, *Le Visible et l'invisible*. Moreover, it seemed to me that, if an encounter were to be found there, it was a happy one, one destined to stress, as I shall try to do today, how, in the perspective of the unconscious, we can situate consciousness.

You know that some shadow, or, to use another term, some 'resist' — in the sense one speaks of 'resist' in the dying of material — marks the fact of consciousness in Freud's very discourse.

But, before taking things up again at the point we left them last time, I must first clear up a misunderstanding that appears

[1] For a translation of the poem, see page 17.

to have arisen in the minds of certain members of the audience concerning a term I used last time. Some of you seem to have been perplexed by a word that is simple enough, and which I commented on, namely, the *tychic*. Apparently, it sounded to some of you like a sneeze. Yet I made it quite clear that it was the adjective formed from *tuché* just as *psychique* (psychical) is the adjective corresponding to *psuché* (psyche). I used this analogy at the heart of the experience of repetition quite intentionally, because for any conception of the psychical development as elucidated by psycho-analysis, the fact of the tychic is central. It is in relation to the eye, in relation to the *eutuchia* or the *dustuchia*, the happy encounter and the unhappy encounter, that my lecture today will be ordered.

I

I saw myself seeing myself, young Parque says somewhere. Certainly, this statement has rich and complex implications in relation to the theme developed in *La Jeune Parque*, that of femininity—but we haven't got there yet. We are dealing with the philosopher, who apprehends something that is one of the essential correlates of consciousness in its relation to representation, and which is designated as *I see myself seeing myself*. What evidence can we really attach to this formula? How is it that it remains, in fact, correlative with that fundamental mode to which we referred in the Cartesian *cogito*, by which the subject apprehends himself as thought?

What isolates this apprehension of thought by itself is a sort of doubt, which has been called methodological doubt, which concerns whatever might give support to thought in representation. How is it, then, that the *I see myself seeing myself* remains its envelope and base, and, perhaps more than one thinks, grounds its certainty? For, *I warm myself by warming myself* is a reference to the body as body—I feel that sensation of warmth which, from some point inside me, is diffused and locates me as body. Whereas in the *I see myself seeing myself*, there is no such sensation of being absorbed by vision.

Furthermore, the phenomenologists have succeeded in articulating with precision, and in the most disconcerting way, that it is quite clear that I see *outside*, that perception is not in me, that it is on the objects that it apprehends. And yet I

apprehend the world in a perception that seems to concern the immanence of the *I see myself seeing myself*. The privilege of the subject seems to be established here from that bipolar reflexive relation by which, as soon as I perceive, my representations belong to me.

This is how the world is struck with a presumption of idealization, of the suspicion of yielding me only my representations. Serious practice does not really weigh very heavy, but, on the other hand, the philosopher, the idealist, is placed there, as much in confrontation with himself as in confrontation with those who are listening to him, in an embarrassing position. How can one deny that nothing of the world appears to me except in my representations? This is the irreducible method of Bishop Berkeley, about whose subjective position much might be said—including something that may have eluded you in passing, namely, this *belong to me* aspect of representations, so reminiscent of property. When carried to the limit, the process of this meditation, of this reflecting reflection, goes so far as to reduce the subject apprehended by the Cartesian meditation to a power of annihilation.

The mode of my presence in the world is the subject in so far as by reducing itself solely to this certainty of being a subject, it becomes active annihilation. In fact, the process of the philosophical meditation throws the subject towards the transforming historical action, and, around this point, orders the configured modes of active self-consciousness through its metamorphoses in history. As for the meditation on being that reaches its culmination in the thought of Heidegger, it restores to being itself that power of annihilation—or at least poses the question of how it may be related to it.

This is also the point to which Maurice Merleau-Ponty leads us. But, if you refer to his text, you will see that it is at this point that he chooses to withdraw, in order to propose a return to the sources of intuition concerning the visible and the invisible, to come back to that which is prior to all reflection, thetic or non-thetic, in order to locate the emergence of vision itself. For him, it is a question of restoring—for, he tells us, it can only be a question of a reconstruction or a restoration, not of a path traversed in the opposite direction—of reconstituting the way by which, not from the body, but from something

that he calls the flesh of the world, the original point of vision was able to emerge. It would seem that in this way one sees, in this unfinished work, the emergence of something like the search for an unnamed substance from which I, the seer, extract myself. From the toils (*rets*), or rays (*rais*), if you prefer, of an iridescence of which I am at first a part, I emerge as eye, assuming, in a way, emergence from what I would like to call the function of *seeingness* (*voyure*).

A wild odour emanates from it, providing a glimpse on the horizon of the hunt of Artemis—whose touch seems to be associated at this moment of tragic failure in which we lost him who speaks.

Yet is this really the way he wished to take? The traces that remain of the part to come from his meditation permits us to doubt it. The reference-points that are provided in it, more particularly for the strictly psycho-analytic unconscious, allow us to perceive that he may have been directed towards some search, original in relation to the philosophical tradition, towards that new dimension of meditation on the subject that analysis enables us to trace.

Personally, I cannot but be struck by certain of these notes, which are for me less enigmatic than they may seem to other readers, because they correspond very exactly to the schemata —with one of them, in particular—that I shall be dealing with here. Read, for example, the note concerning what he calls the turning inside-out of the finger of a glove, in as much as it seems to appear there—note the way in which the leather envelops the fur in a winter glove—that consciousness, in its illusion of *seeing itself seeing itself*, finds its basis in the inside-out structure of the gaze.

2

But what is the gaze?

I shall set out from this first point of annihilation in which is marked, in the field of the reduction of the subject, a break—which warns us of the need to introduce another reference, that which analysis assumes in reducing the privileges of the consciousness.

Psycho-analysis regards the consciousness as irremediably limited, and institutes it as a principle, not only of idealization,

but of *méconnaissance*, as—using a term that takes on new value by being referred to a visible domain—*scotoma*. The term was introduced into the psycho-analytic vocabulary by the French School. Is it simply a metaphor? We find here once again the ambiguity that affects anything that is inscribed in the register of the scopic drive.

For us, consciousness matters only in its relation to what, for propaedeutic reasons, I have tried to show you in the fiction of the incomplete text—on the basis of which it is a question of recentring the subject as speaking in the very lacunae of that in which, at first sight, it presents itself as speaking. But I am stating here only the relation of the pre-conscious to the unconscious. The dynamic that is attached to the consciousness as such, the attention the subject brings to his own text, remains up to this point, as Freud has stressed, outside theory and, strictly speaking, not yet articulated.

It is here that I propose that the interest the subject takes in his own split is bound up with that which determines it —namely, a privileged object, which has emerged from some primal separation, from some self-mutilation induced by the very approach of the real, whose name, in our algebra, is the *objet a*.

In the scopic relation, the object on which depends the phantasy from which the subject is suspended in an essential vacillation is the gaze. Its privilege—and also that by which the subject for so long has been misunderstood as being in its dependence—derives from its very structure.

Let us schematize at once what we mean. From the moment that this gaze appears, the subject tries to adapt himself to it, he becomes that punctiform object, that point of vanishing being with which the subject confuses his own failure. Furthermore, of all the objects in which the subject may recognize his dependence in the register of desire, the gaze is specified as unapprehensible. That is why it is, more than any other object, misunderstood (*méconnu*), and it is perhaps for this reason, too, that the subject manages, fortunately, to symbolize his own vanishing and punctiform bar (*trait*) in the illusion of the consciousness of *seeing oneself see oneself*, in which the gaze is elided.

If, then, the gaze is that underside of consciousness, how shall we try to imagine it?

The expression is not inapt, for we can give body to the gaze. Sartre, in one of the most brilliant passages of *L'Être et le Néant*, brings it into function in the dimension of the existence of others. Others would remain suspended in the same, partially de-realizing, conditions that are, in Sartre's definition, those of objectivity, were it not for the gaze. The gaze, as conceived by Sartre, is the gaze by which I am surprised—surprised in so far as it changes all the perspectives, the lines of force, of my world, orders it, from the point of nothingness where I am, in a sort of radiated reticulation of the organisms. As the locus of the relation between me, the annihilating subject, and that which surrounds me, the gaze seems to possess such a privilege that it goes so far as to have me scotomized, I who look, the eye of him who sees me as object. In so far as I am under the gaze, Sartre writes, I no longer see the eye that looks at me and, if I see the eye, the gaze disappears.

Is this a correct phenomenological analysis? No. It is not true that, when I am under the gaze, when I solicit a gaze, when I obtain it, I do not see it as a gaze. Painters, above all, have grasped this gaze as such in the mask and I have only to remind you of Goya, for example, for you to realize this.

The gaze sees itself—to be precise, the gaze of which Sartre speaks, the gaze that surprises me and reduces me to shame, since this is the feeling he regards as the most dominant. The gaze I encounter—you can find this in Sartre's own writing—is, not a seen gaze, but a gaze imagined by me in the field of the Other.

If you turn to Sartre's own text, you will see that, far from speaking of the emergence of this gaze as of something that concerns the organ of sight, he refers to the sound of rustling leaves, suddenly heard while out hunting, to a footstep heard in a corridor. And when are these sounds heard? At the moment when he has presented himself in the action of looking through a keyhole. A gaze surprises him in the function of voyeur, disturbs him, overwhelms him and reduces him to a feeling of shame. The gaze in question is certainly the presence of others as such. But does this mean that originally it is in the relation of subject to subject, in the function of the existence of others as looking at me, that we apprehend what the gaze really is? Is it not clear that the gaze intervenes here only in as much as it is

not the annihilating subject, correlative of the world of objectivity, who feels himself surprised, but the subject sustaining himself in a function of desire?

Is it not precisely because desire is established here in the domain of seeing that we can make it vanish?

3

We can apprehend this privilege of the gaze in the function of desire, by pouring ourselves, as it were, along the veins through which the domain of vision has been integrated into the field of desire.

It is not for nothing that it was at the very period when the Cartesian meditation inaugurated in all its purity the function of the subject that the dimension of optics that I shall distinguish here by calling 'geometral' or 'flat' (as opposed to perspective) optics was developed.

I shall illustrate for you, by one object among others, what seems to me exemplary in a function that so curiously attracted so much reflection at the time.

One reference, for those who would like to carry further what I tried to convey to you today, is Baltrusaïtis' book, *Anamorphoses*.

In my seminar, I have made great use of the function of anamorphosis, in so far as it is an exemplary structure. What does a simple, non-cylindrical anamorphosis consist of? Suppose there is a portrait on this flat piece of paper that I am holding. By chance, you see the blackboard, in an oblique position in relation to the piece of paper. Suppose that, by means of a series of ideal threads or lines, I reproduce on the oblique surface each point of the image drawn on my sheet of paper. You can easily imagine what the result would be—you would obtain a figure enlarged and distorted according to the lines of what may be called a perspective. One supposes that —if I take away that which has helped in the construction, namely, the image placed in my own visual field—the impression I will retain, while remaining in that place, will be more or less the same. At least, I will recognize the general outlines of the image—at best, I will have an identical impression.

I will now pass around something that dates from a hundred years earlier, from 1533, a reproduction of a painting that, I

think, you all know—Hans Holbein's *The Ambassadors*. It will serve to refresh the memories of those who know the picture well. Those who do not should examine it attentively. I shall come back to it shortly.

Vision is ordered according to a mode that may generally be called the function of images. This function is defined by a point-by-point correspondence of two unities in space. Whatever optical intermediaries may be used to establish their relation, whether their image is virtual, or real, the point-by-point correspondence is essential. That which is of the mode of the image in the field of vision is therefore reducible to the simple schema that enables us to establish anamorphosis, that is to say, to the relation of an image, in so far as it is linked to a surface, with a certain point that we shall call the 'geometral' point. Anything that is determined by this method, in which the straight line plays its role of being the path of light, can be called an image.

Art is mingled with science here. Leonardo da Vinci is both a scientist, on account of his dioptric constructions, and an artist. Vitruvius's treatise on architecture is not far away. It is in Vignola and in Alberti that we find the progressive interrogation of the geometral laws of perspective, and it is around research on perspective that is centred a privileged interest for the domain of vision—whose relation with the institution of the Cartesian subject, which is itself a sort of geometral point, a point of perspective, we cannot fail to see. And, around the geometral perspective, the picture—this is a very important function to which we shall return—is organized in a way that is quite new in the history of painting.

I should now like to refer you to Diderot. The *Lettre sur les aveugles à l'usage de ceux qui voient* (Letter on the Blind for the use of those who see) will show you that this construction allows that which concerns vision to escape totally. For the geometral space of vision—even if we include those imaginary parts in the virtual space of the mirror, of which, as you know, I have spoken at length—is perfectly reconstructible, imaginable, by a blind man.

What is at issue in geometral perspective is simply the mapping of space, not sight. The blind man may perfectly well conceive that the field of space that he knows, and which he

knows as real, may be perceived at a distance, and as a simultaneous act. For him, it is a question of apprehending a temporal function, instantaneity. In Descartes, dioptrics, the action of the eyes, is represented as the conjugated action of two sticks. The geometral dimension of vision does not exhaust, therefore, far from it, what the field of vision as such offers us as the original subjectifying relation.

This is why it is so important to acknowledge the inverted use of perspective in the structure of anamorphosis.

It was Dürer himself who invented the apparatus to establish perspective. Dürer's 'lucinda' is comparable to what, a little while ago, I placed between that blackboard and myself, namely, a certain image, or more exactly a canvas, a treliss that will be traversed by straight lines—which are not necessarily rays, but also threads—which will link each point that I have to see in the world to a point at which the canvas will, by this line, be traversed.

It was to establish a correct perspective image, therefore, that the *lucinda* was introduced. If I reverse its use, I will have the pleasure of obtaining not the restoration of the world that lies at the end, but the distortion, on another surface, of the image that I would have obtained on the first, and I will dwell, as on some delicious game, on this method that makes anything appear at will in a particular stretching.

I would ask you to believe that such an enchantment took place in its time. Baltrusaïtis' book will tell you of the furious polemics that these practices gave rise to, and which culminated in works of considerable length. The convent of the Minims, now destroyed, which once stood near the rue des Tournelles, carried on the very long wall of one of its galleries and representing as if by chance St John at Patmos a picture that had to be looked at through a hole, so that its distorting value could be appreciated to its full extent.

Distortion may lend itself—this was not the case for this particular fresco—to all the paranoiac ambiguities, and every possible use has been made of it, from Arcimboldi to Salvador Dali. I will go so far as to say that this fascination complements what geometral researches into perspective allow to escape from vision.

How is it that nobody has ever thought of connecting this

with . . . the effect of an erection? Imagine a tattoo traced on the sexual organ *ad hoc* in the state of repose and assuming its, if I may say so, developed form in another state.

How can we not see here, immanent in the geometral dimension—a partial dimension in the field of the gaze, a dimension that has nothing to do with vision as such—something symbolic of the function of the lack, of the appearance of the phallic ghost?

Now, in *The Ambassadors*—I hope everyone has had time now to look at the reproduction—what do you see? What is this strange, suspended, oblique object in the foreground in front of these two figures?

The two figures are frozen, stiffened in their showy adornments. Between them is a series of objects that represent in the painting of the period the symbols of *vanitas*. At the same period, Cornelius Agrippa wrote his *De Vanitate scientiarum*, aimed as much at the arts as the sciences, and these objects are all symbolic of the sciences and arts as they were grouped at the time in the *trivium* and *quadrivium*. What, then, before this display of the domain of appearance in all its most fascinating forms, is this object, which from some angles appears to be flying through the air, at others to be tilted? You cannot know—for you turn away, thus escaping the fascination of the picture.

Begin by walking out of the room in which no doubt it has long held your attention. It is then that, turning round as you leave—as the author of the *Anamorphoses* describes it—you apprehend in this form . . . What? A skull.

This is not how it is presented at first—that figure, which the author compares to a cuttlebone and which for me suggests rather that loaf composed of two books which Dali was once pleased to place on the head of an old woman, chosen deliberately for her wretched, filthy appearance and, indeed, because she seems to be unaware of the fact, or, again, Dali's soft watches, whose signification is obviously less phallic than that of the object depicted in a flying position in the foreground of this picture.

All this shows that at the very heart of the period in which the subject emerged and geometral optics was an object of research, Holbein makes visible for us here something that is simply the subject as annihilated—annihilated in the form

that is, strictly speaking, the imaged embodiment of the *minus-phi* [$(-\phi)$] of castration, which for us, centres the whole organization of the desires through the framework of the fundamental drives.

But it is further still that we must seek the function of vision. We shall then see emerging on the basis of vision, not the phallic symbol, the anamorphic ghost, but the gaze as such, in its pulsatile, dazzling and spread out function, as it is in this picture.

This picture is simply what any picture is, a trap for the gaze. In any picture, it is precisely in seeking the gaze in each of its points that you will see it disappear. I shall try to develop this further next time.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

F. WAHL: *You have explained that the original apprehension of the gaze in the gaze of others, as described by Sartre, was not the fundamental experience of the gaze. I would like you to explain in greater detail what you have already sketched for us, the apprehension of the gaze in the direction of desire.*

LACAN: If one does not stress the dialectic of desire one does not understand why the gaze of others should disorganize the field of perception. It is because the subject in question is not that of the reflexive consciousness, but that of desire. One thinks it is a question of the geometral eye-point, whereas it is a question of a quite different eye—that which flies in the foreground of *The Ambassadors*.

WAHL: *But I don't understand how others will reappear in your discourse . . .*

LACAN: Look, the main thing is that I don't come a cropper!

WAHL: *I would also like to say that, when you speak of the subject and of the real, one is tempted, on first hearing, to consider the terms in themselves. But gradually one realizes that they are to be understood in their relation to one another, and that they have a topological definition —subject and real are to be situated on either side of the split, in the resistance of the phantasy. The real is, in a way, an experience of resistance.*

LACAN: My discourse proceeds, in the following way: each term is sustained only in its topological relation with the others, and the subject of the *cogito* is treated in exactly the same way.

WAHL: *Is topology for you a method of discovery or of exposition?*

LACAN: It is the mapping of the topology proper to our experience as analysts, which may later be taken in a metaphysical perspective. I think Merleau-Ponty was moving in this direction—see the second part of the book, his reference to the *Wolf Man* and to the finger of a glove.

P. KAUFMANN: *You have provided us with a typical structure of the gaze, but you have said nothing of the dilation of light.*

LACAN: I said that the gaze was not the eye, except in that flying form in which Holbein has the cheek to show me my own soft watch . . . Next time, I will talk about embodied light.

26 February 1964

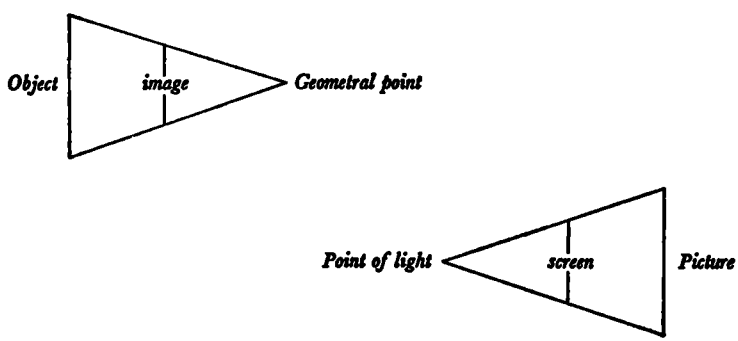
8

THE LINE AND LIGHT

Desire and the picture · The story of a sardine can · The screen · Mimicry · The organ · You never look at me from the place I see you

The function of the eye may lead someone who is trying to enlighten you to distant explorations. When, for example, did the function of the organ and, to begin with, its very presence, appear in the evolution of living beings?

The relation of the subject with the organ is at the heart of our experience. Among all the organs with which we deal, the



breast, the faeces, etc., there is the eye, and it is striking to see that it goes back as far as the species that represent the appearance of life. You no doubt eat oysters, innocently enough, without knowing that at this level in the animal kingdom the eye has already appeared. Such discoveries teach us, it should be said, all manner of things. Yet we must choose from among these things those that are most relative to our search.

Last time, I think I said enough to enable you to grasp the interest of this small, very simple triangular schema that I have reproduced at the top of the blackboard.

It is there simply to remind you in three terms of the optics

used in this operational montage that bears witness to the inverted use of perspective, which came to dominate the technique of painting, in particular, between the end of the fifteenth and the end of the seventeenth centuries. Anamorphosis shows us that it is not a question in painting of a realistic reproduction of the things of space—a term about which one could have many reservations.

The little schema also allows me to remark that certain optics allow that which concerns vision to escape. Such optics are within the grasp of the blind. I have already referred you to Diderot's *Lettre*, which shows to what extent the blind man is capable of taking account of, reconstructing, imagining, speaking about everything that vision yields to us of space. No doubt, on this possibility, Diderot constructs a permanent equivocation with metaphysical implications, but this ambiguity animates his text and gives it its mordant character.

For us, the geometral dimension enables us to glimpse how the subject who concerns us is caught, manipulated, captured, in the field of vision.

In Holbein's picture I showed you at once—without hiding any more than usual—the singular object floating in the foreground, which is there to be looked at, in order to catch, I would almost say, *to catch in its trap*, the observer, that is to say, us. It is, in short, an obvious way, no doubt an exceptional one, and one due to some moment of reflection on the part of the painter, of showing us that, as subjects, we are literally called into the picture, and represented here as caught. For the secret of this picture, whose implications I have pointed out to you, the kinships with the *vanitas*, the way this fascinating picture presents, between the two splendidly dressed and immobile figures, everything that recalls, in the perspective of the period, the vanity of the arts and sciences—the secret of this picture is given at the moment when, moving slightly away, little by little, to the left, then turning around, we see what the magical floating object signifies. It reflects our own nothingness, in the figure of the death's head. It is a use, therefore, of the geometral dimension of vision in order to capture the subject, an obvious relation with desire which, nevertheless, remains enigmatic.

What is the desire which is caught, fixed in the picture, but

which also urges the artist to put something into operation? And what is that something? This is the path along which we shall try to move today.

I

In this matter of the visible, everything is a trap, and in a strange way—as is very well shown by Maurice Merleau-Ponty in the title of one of the chapters of *Le Visible et l'invisible*—*entrelacs* (interlacing, intertwining). There is not a single one of the divisions, a single one of the double sides that the function of vision presents, that is not manifested to us as a labyrinth. As we begin to distinguish its various fields, we always perceive more and more the extent to which they intersect.

In the domain that I have called that of the geometral, it seems at first that it is light that gives us, as it were, the thread. In effect, you saw this thread last time linking us to each point of the object and, in the place where it crosses the network in the form of a screen on which we are going to map the image, functioning quite definitely as a thread. Now, the light is propagated, as one says, in a straight line, this much is certain. It would seem, then, that it is light that gives us the thread.

Yet, reflect that this thread has no need of light—all that is needed is a stretched thread. This is why the blind man would be able to follow all our demonstrations, providing we took some trouble in their presentation. We would get him, for example, to finger an object of a certain height, then follow the stretched thread. We would teach him to distinguish, by the sense of touch in his finger-ends, on a surface, a certain configuration that reproduces the mapping of the images—in the same way that we imagine, in pure optics, the variously proportioned and fundamentally homological relations, the correspondences from one point to another in space, which always, in the end, amounts to situating two points on a single thread. This construction does not, therefore, particularly enable us to apprehend what is provided by light.

How can we try to apprehend that which seems to elude us in this way in the optical structuring of space? It is always on this question that the traditional argument bears. Philosophers, going back from Alain, the last to have concerned himself with it, and quite brilliantly, to Kant, and even to Plato, all expatiate

on the supposed deceptiveness of perception—and, at the same time, they all find themselves once again masters of the exercise, by stressing the fact that perception finds the object where it is, and that the appearance of the cube as a parallelogram is precisely, owing to the rupture of space that underlies our very perception, what makes us perceive it as a cube. The whole trick, the hey presto!, of the classic dialectic around perception, derives from the fact that it deals with geometral vision, that is to say, with vision in so far as it is situated in a space that is not in its essence the visual.

The essence of the relation between appearance and being, which the philosopher, conquering the field of vision, so easily masters, lies elsewhere. It is not in the straight line, but in the point of light—the point of irradiation, the play of light, fire, the source from which reflections pour forth. Light may travel in a straight line, but it is refracted, diffused, it floods, it fills—the eye is a sort of bowl—it flows over, too, it necessitates, around the ocular bowl, a whole series of organs, mechanisms, defences. The iris reacts not only to distance, but also to light, and it has to protect what takes place at the bottom of the bowl, which might, in certain circumstances, be damaged by it. The eyelid, too, when confronted with too bright a light, first blinks, that is, it screws itself up in a well-known grimace.

Furthermore, it is not that the eye has to be photo-sensitive—we know this. The whole surface of the tegument—no doubt for various reasons that are not visual—may be photo-sensitive, and this dimension can in no way be reduced to the functioning of vision. There is a certain adumbration of photo-sensitive organs in the pigmentary spots. In the eye, the pigment functions fully, in a way, of course, that the phenomenon shows to be infinitely complex. It functions within the cones, for example, in the form of a rhodopsin. It also functions inside the various layers of the retina. This pigment comes and goes in functions that are not all, nor always immediately discoverable and clear, but which suggest the depth, the complexity and, at the same time, the unity of the mechanisms concerned with light.

The relation of the subject with that which is strictly concerned with light seems, then, to be already somewhat ambiguous. Indeed, you see this on the schema of the two triangles,

which are inverted at the same time as they must be placed one upon the other. What you have here is the first example of this functioning of interlacing, intersection, chiasma, which I pointed out above, and which structures the whole of this domain.

In order to give you some idea of the question posed by this relation between the subject and light, in order to show you that its place is something other than the place of the geometral point defined by geometric optics, I will now tell you a little story.

It's a true story. I was in my early twenties or thereabouts—and at that time, of course, being a young intellectual, I wanted desperately to get away, see something different, throw myself into something practical, something physical, in the country say, or at the sea. One day, I was on a small boat, with a few people from a family of fishermen in a small port. At that time, Brittany was not industrialized as it is now. There were no trawlers. The fisherman went out in his frail craft at his own risk. It was this risk, this danger, that I loved to share. But it wasn't all danger and excitement—there were also fine days. One day, then, as we were waiting for the moment to pull in the nets, an individual known as Petit-Jean, that's what we called him—like all his family, he died very young from tuberculosis, which at that time was a constant threat to the whole of that social class—this Petit-Jean pointed out to me something floating on the surface of the waves. It was a small can, a sardine can. It floated there in the sun, a witness to the canning industry, which we, in fact, were supposed to supply. It glittered in the sun. And Petit-Jean said to me—*You see that can? Do you see it? Well, it doesn't see you!*

He found this incident highly amusing—I less so. I thought about it. Why did I find it less amusing than he? It's an interesting question.

To begin with, if what Petit-Jean said to me, namely, that the can did not see me, had any meaning, it was because in a sense, it was looking at me, all the same. It was looking at me at the level of the point of light, the point at which everything that looks at me is situated—and I am not speaking metaphorically.

The point of this little story, as it had occurred to my partner,

the fact that he found it so funny and I less so, derives from the fact that, if I am told a story like that one, it is because I, at that moment—as I appeared to those fellows who were earning their livings with great difficulty, in the struggle with what for them was a pitiless nature—looked like nothing on earth. In short, I was rather out of place in the picture. And it was because I felt this that I was not terribly amused at hearing myself addressed in this humorous, ironical way.

I am taking the structure at the level of the subject here, and it reflects something that is already to be found in the natural relation that the eye inscribes with regard to light. I am not simply that punctiform being located at the geometral point from which the perspective is grasped. No doubt, in the depths of my eye, the picture is painted. The picture, certainly, is in my eye. But I am not in the picture.

That which is light looks at me, and by means of that light in the depths of my eye, something is painted—something that is not simply a constructed relation, the object on which the philosopher lingers—but something that is an impression, the shimmering of a surface that is not, in advance, situated for me in its distance. This is something that introduces what was elided in the geometral relation—the depth of field, with all its ambiguity and variability, which is in no way mastered by me. It is rather it that grasps me, solicits me at every moment, and makes of the landscape something other than a landscape, something other than what I have called the picture.

The correlative of the picture, to be situated in the same place as it, that is to say, outside, is the point of gaze, while that which forms the mediation from the one to the other, that which is between the two, is something of another nature than geometral, optical space, something that plays an exactly reverse role, which operates, not because it can be traversed, but on the contrary because it is opaque—I mean the screen.

In what is presented to me as space of light, that which is gaze is always a play of light and opacity. It is always that gleam of light—it lay at the heart of my little story—it is always this which prevents me, at each point, from being a screen, from making the light appear as an iridescence that overflows it. In short, the point of gaze always participates in the ambiguity of the jewel.

And if I am anything in the picture, it is always in the form of the screen, which I earlier called the stain, the spot.

2

This is the relation of the subject with the domain of vision. The word subject must not be understood here in the usual sense of the word, in the subjective sense—this relation is not an idealist relation. This overview, which I call the subject, and which I regard as giving consistency to the picture, is not simply a representative overview.

There are many ways of being wrong about this function of the subject in the domain of the spectacle.

Certainly, there are plenty of examples in *La Phénoménologie de la perception* of what happens behind the retina. Merleau-Ponty cleverly extracts from a mass of writing some very remarkable facts, showing, for example, that simply the fact of masking, by means of a screen, part of a field functioning as a source of composite colours—produced, for example, by two wheels, two screens, which, one revolving behind the other, must compose a certain tone of light—that this intervention alone reveals in a quite different way the composition in question. Indeed, here we grasp the purely subjective function, in the ordinary sense of the word, the note of central mechanism that intervenes, for the play of light arranged in the experiment, all the elements of which we know, is distinct from what is perceived by the subject.

Perceiving the effects of reflection of a field or a colour is quite different—it does have a subjective side to it, but one arranged quite differently. Let us, for example, place a yellow field beside a blue field—by receiving the light reflected on the yellow field, the blue field will undergo some change. But, certainly, everything that is colour is merely subjective—there is no objective correlative in the spectrum to enable us to attach the quality of colour to the wavelength, or to the relevant frequency at this level of light vibration. There is something objective here, but it is situated differently.

Is that all there is to it? Is that what I am talking about when I speak of the relation between the subject and what I have called the picture? Certainly not.

The relation between the subject and the picture has been

approached by certain philosophers, but they have, if I may say so, missed the point. Read the book by Raymond Ruyer called *Néo-finalisme*, and see how, in order to situate perception in a teleological perspective, he is forced to situate the subject in an absolute overview. There is no need, except in the most abstract way, to posit the subject in absolute overview, when, in the example he gives, it is merely a question of getting us to grasp what the perception of a draught-board is—a draught-board belongs essentially to that geometral optics that I was careful to distinguish at the outset. We are here in space *partes extra partes*, which always provides such an objection to the apprehension to the object. In this direction, the thing is irreducible.

Yet there is a phenomenal domain—infinitely more extended than the privileged points at which it appears—that enables us to apprehend, in its true nature, the subject in absolute overview. Even if we cannot give it being, it is nonetheless necessary. There are facts that can be articulated only in the phenomenal dimension of the overview by which I situate myself in the picture as stain—these are the facts of mimicry.

This is not the place to go into all the more or less complex problems posed by the question of mimicry. I would refer you to the specialized works on the subject—they are not only fascinating in themselves, but they provide ample material for reflexion. I shall content myself with stressing what has not, perhaps, been sufficiently brought out. To begin with, I shall ask a question—how important is the function of adaptation in mimicry?

In certain phenomena of mimicry one may speak perhaps of an adaptive or adapted coloration and realize, for example—as Cuénot has shown, probably with some relevance in certain cases—that coloration, in so far as it is adapted completely, is simply a way of defending oneself against light. In an environment in which, because of what is immediately around, the colour green predominates, as at the bottom of a pool containing green plants, an animalcule—there are innumerable ones that might serve as examples—becomes green for as long as the light may do it harm. It becomes green, therefore, in order to reflect the light *qua* green, thus protecting itself, by adaptation, from its effects.

But, in mimicry, we are dealing with something quite different. Let us take an example chosen almost at random—it is not a privileged case—that of the small crustacean known as *caprella*, to which is added the adjective *acanthifera*. When such a crustacean settles in the midst of those animals, scarcely animals, known as briozoaires, what does it imitate? It imitates what, in that quasi-plant animal known as the briozoaires, is a stain—at a particular phase of the briozoaires, an intestinal loop forms a stain, at another phase, there functions something like a coloured centre. It is to this stain shape that the crustacean adapts itself. It becomes a stain, it becomes a picture, it is inscribed in the picture. This, strictly speaking, is the origin of mimicry. And, on this basis, the fundamental dimensions of the inscription of the subject in the picture appear infinitely more justified than a more hesitant guess might suggest at first sight.

I have already referred to what Caillois says about this in his little book *Méduse et compagnie*, with that unquestionable penetration that is sometimes found in the non-specialist—his very distance may enable him to grasp certain implications in what the specialist has merely stated.

Certain scientists claim to see in the register of coloration merely more or less successful facts of adaptation. But the facts show that practically nothing that can be called adaptation—in the sense in which the term is usually understood, that is to say, as behaviour bound up with the needs of survival—practically nothing of this is to be found in mimicry, which, in most cases, proves to be inoperant, or operating strictly in the opposite direction from that which the adaptive result might be presumed to demand. On the other hand, Caillois brings out the three headings that are in effect the major dimensions in which the mimetic activity is deployed—travesty, camouflage, intimidation.

Indeed, it is in this domain that the dimension by which the subject is to be inserted in the picture is presented. Mimicry reveals something in so far as it is distinct from what might be called an *itself* that is behind. The effect of mimicry is camouflage, in the strictly technical sense. It is not a question of harmonizing with the background but, against a mottled background, of becoming mottled—exactly like the technique of camouflage practised in human warfare.

In the case of travesty, a certain sexual finality is intended. Nature shows us that this sexual aim is produced by all kinds of effects that are essentially disguise, masquerade. A level is constituted here quite distinct from the sexual aim itself, which is found to play an essential role in it, and which must not be distinguished too hastily as being that of deception. The function of the lure, in this instance, is something else, something before which we should suspend judgement before we have properly measured its effects.

Finally, the phenomenon known as intimidation also involves this over-valuation that the subject always tries to attain in his appearance. Here too, we should not be too hasty in introducing some kind of inter-subjectivity. Whenever we are dealing with imitation, we should be very careful not to think too quickly of the other who is being imitated. To imitate is no doubt to reproduce an image. But at bottom, it is, for the subject, to be inserted in a function whose exercise grasps it. It is here that we should pause for a moment.

Let us now see what the unconscious function as such tells us, in so far as it is the field which, for us, offers itself to the conquest of the subject.

3

In this direction, a remark of Caillois' should guide us. Caillois assures us that the facts of mimicry are similar, at the animal level, to what, in the human being is manifested as art, or painting. The only objection one might make to this is that it seems to indicate, for René Caillois, that the notion of painting is itself so clear that one can refer to it in order to explain something else.

What is painting? It is obviously not for nothing that we have referred to as picture the function in which the subject has to map himself as such. But when a human subject is engaged in making a picture of himself, in putting into operation that something that has as its centre the gaze, what is taking place? In the picture, the artist, we are told by some, wishes to be a subject, and the art of painting is to be distinguished from all others in that, in the work, it is as subject, as gaze, that the artist intends to impose himself on us. To this, others reply by stressing the object-like side of the art product. In both

these directions, something more or less appropriate is manifested, which certainly does not exhaust the question.

I shall advance the following thesis—certainly, in the picture, something of the gaze is always manifested. The painter knows this very well—his morality, his search, his quest, his practice is that he should sustain and vary the selection of a certain kind of gaze. Looking at pictures, even those most lacking in what is usually called the gaze, and which is constituted by a pair of eyes, pictures in which any representation of the human figure is absent, like a landscape by a Dutch or a Flemish painter, you will see in the end, as in filigree, something so specific to each of the painters that you will feel the presence of the gaze. But this is merely an object of research, and perhaps merely illusion.

The function of the picture—in relation to the person to whom the painter, literally, offers his picture to be seen—has a relation with the gaze. This relation is not, as it might at first seem, that of being a trap for the gaze. It might be thought that, like the actor, the painter wishes to be looked at. I do not think so. I think there is a relation with the gaze of the spectator, but that it is more complex. The painter gives something to the person who must stand in front of his painting which, in part, at least, of the painting, might be summed up thus—*You want to see? Well, take a look at this!* He gives something for the eye to feed on, but he invites the person to whom this picture is presented to lay down his gaze there as one lays down one's weapons. This is the pacifying, Apollonian effect of painting. Something is given not so much to the gaze as to the eye, something that involves the abandonment, the *laying down*, of the gaze.

The problem is that a whole side of painting—expressionism—is separated from this field. Expressionist painting, and this is its distinguishing feature, provides something by way of a certain satisfaction—in the sense in which Freud uses the term in relation to the drive—of a certain satisfaction of what is demanded by the gaze.

In other words, we must now pose the question as to the exact status of the eye as organ. The function, it is said, creates the organ. This is quite absurd—function does not even explain the organ. Whatever appears in the organism as an

organ is always presented with a large multiplicity of functions. In the eye, it is clear that various functions come together. The discriminatory function is isolated to the maximum degree at the level of the *fovea*, the chosen point of distinct vision. Something quite different occurs over the rest of the surface of the retina, incorrectly distinguished by specialists as the locus of the scotopic function. But here, too, chiasma is to be found, since it is this last field, supposedly created to perceive things in diminished lighting, which provides the maximum possibility of perceiving the effects of light. If you wish to see a star of the fifth or six size, do not look straight at it—this is known as the Arago phenomenon. You will be able to see it only if you fix your eye to one side.

These functions of the eye do not exhaust the character of the organ in so far as it emerges on the couch, and in so far as the eye determines there what every organ determines, namely, duties. What is wrong about the reference to instinct, a reference that is so confused, is that one does not realize that instinct is the way in which an organism has of extricating itself in the best possible way from an organ. There are many examples, in the animal kingdom, of cases in which the organism succumbs to an excess, a hyper-development of an organ. The supposed function of instinct in the relation between organism and organ certainly seems to have been defined as a kind of morality. We are astonished by the so-called pre-adaptations of instinct. The extraordinary thing is that the organism can do anything with its organ at all.

In my reference to the unconscious, I am dealing with the relation to the organ. It is not a question of the relation to sexuality, or even to the sex, if it is possible to give any specific reference to this term. It is a question rather of the relation to the phallus, in as much as it is lacking in the real that might be attained in the sexual goal.

It is in as much as, at the heart of the experience of the unconscious, we are dealing with that organ—determined in the subject by the inadequacy organized in the castration complex —that we can grasp to what extent the eye is caught up in a similar dialectic.

From the outset, we see, in the dialectic of the eye and the gaze, that there is no coincidence, but, on the contrary, a lure.

When, in love, I solicit a look, what is profoundly unsatisfying and always missing is that—*You never look at me from the place from which I see you.*

Conversely, *what I look at is never what I wish to see.* And the relation that I mentioned earlier, between the painter and the spectator, is a play, a play of *trompe-l'œil*, whatever one says. There is no reference here to what is incorrectly called figurative, if by this you mean some reference or other to a subjacent reality.

In the classical tale of Zeuxis and Parrhasios, Zeuxis has the advantage of having made grapes that attracted the birds. The stress is placed not on the fact that these grapes were in any way perfect grapes, but on the fact that even the eye of the birds was taken in by them. This is proved by the fact that his friend Parrhasios triumphs over him for having painted on the wall a veil, a veil so lifelike that Zeuxis, turning towards him said, *Well, and now show us what you have painted behind it.* By this he showed that what was at issue was certainly deceiving the eye (*tromper l'œil*). A triumph of the gaze over the eye.

Next time, we shall return to this function of the eye and the gaze.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

M. SAFOUAN: *In the contemplation of the picture, if I have understood you correctly, the eye seeks relaxation from the gaze?*

LACAN: I shall take up here the dialectic of appearance and its beyond, in saying that, if beyond appearance there is nothing in itself, there is the gaze. It is in this relation that the eye as organ is situated.

SAFOUAN: *Beyond the appearance, is there a lack, or the gaze?*

LACAN: At the level of the scopic dimension, in so far as the drive operates there, is to be found the same function of the *objet a* as can be mapped in all the other dimensions.

The *objet a* is something from which the subject, in order to constitute itself, has separated itself off as organ. This serves as a symbol of the lack, that is to say, of the phallus, not as such, but in so far as it is lacking. It must, therefore, be an object that is, firstly, separable and, secondly, that has some relation to the lack. I'll explain at once what I mean.

At the oral level, it is the nothing, in so far as that from which

the subject was weaned is no longer anything for him. In anorexia nervosa, what the child eats is the nothing. This will enable you to grasp obliquely how the object of weaning may come to function at the level of castration, as privation.

The anal level is the locus of metaphor—one object for another, give the faeces in place of the phallus. This shows you why the anal drive is the domain of oblativity, of the gift. Where one is caught short, where one cannot, as a result of the lack, give what is to be given, one can always give something else. That is why, in his morality, man is inscribed at the anal level. And this is especially true of the materialist.

At the scopic level, we are no longer at the level of demand, but of desire, of the desire of the Other. It is the same at the level of the invocatory drive, which is the closest to the experience of the unconscious.

Generally speaking, the relation between the gaze and what one wishes to see involves a lure. The subject is presented as other than he is, and what one shows him is not what he wishes to see. It is in this way that the eye may function as *objet a*, that is to say, at the level of the lack $(-\phi)$.

4 March 1964

9

WHAT IS A PICTURE?

Being and its semblance · *The lure of the screen* · Dompte-regard *and* trompe-l'œil[1] · *The backward glance* · *Gesture and touch* · Le donner-à-voir *and* invidia[2]

Today, then, I must keep to the wager to which I committed myself in choosing the terrain in which the *objet a* is most evanescent in its function of symbolizing the central lack of desire, which I have always indicated in a univocal way by the algorithm $(-\phi)$.

I don't know whether you can see the blackboard, but as usual I have marked out a few reference-points. *The* objet a *in the field of the visible is the gaze.* After which, enclosed in a chain bracket, I have written:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \textit{in nature} \\ \textit{as} = (-\phi) \end{array} \right.$$

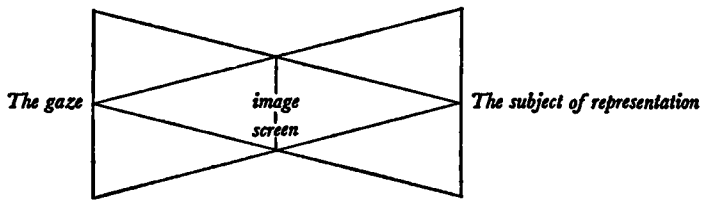
We can grasp in effect something which, already in nature, appropriates the gaze to the function to which it may be put in the symbolic relation in man.

Below this, I have drawn the two triangular systems that I have already introduced—the first is that which, in the geometral field, puts in our place the subject of the representation, and the second is that which turns *me* into a picture. On the right-hand line is situated, then, the apex of the first triangle, the point of the geometral subject, and it is on that line that I,

[1] The sense of the verb *dompter* is 'to tame', 'to subdue'. The reference, then, is to a situation in which the gaze is tamed by some object, such as a picture. Lacan has invented the phrase *dompte-regard* as a counterpart to the notion of *trompe-l'œil*, which has of course passed into the English language [Tr.].

[2] *Donner-à-voir* means literally 'to give to be seen' and, therefore, 'to offer to the view'. The Latin *invidia*, translated as 'envy', derives, as Lacan points out, from *videre*, to see.

too, turn myself into a picture under the gaze, which is inscribed at the apex of the second triangle. The two triangles are here superimposed, as in fact they are in the functioning of the scopic register.



I

I must, to begin with, insist on the following: in the scopic field, the gaze is outside, I am looked at, that is to say, I am a picture.

This is the function that is found at the heart of the institution of the subject in the visible. What determines me, at the most profound level, in the visible, is the gaze that is outside. It is through the gaze that I enter light and it is from the gaze that I receive its effects. Hence it comes about that the gaze is the instrument through which light is embodied and through which—if you will allow me to use a word, as I often do, in a fragmented form—I am *photo-graphed.*

What is at issue here is not the philosophical problem of representation. From that point of view, when I am presented with a representation, I assure myself that I know quite a lot about it, I assure myself as a consciousness that knows that it is only representation, and that there is, beyond, the thing, the thing itself. Behind the phenomenon, there is the noumenon, for example. I may not be able to do anything about it, because my *transcendental categories,* as Kant would say, do just as they please and force me to take the thing in their way. But, then, that's all right, really—everything works out for the best.

In my opinion, it is not in this dialectic between the surface and that which is beyond that things are suspended. For my part, I set out from the fact that there is something that establishes a fracture, a bi-partition, a splitting of the being to which the being accommodates itself, even in the natural world.

This fact is observable in the variously modulated scale of what may be included, ultimately, under the general heading of mimicry. It is this that comes into play, quite obviously, both in sexual union and in the struggle to the death. In both situations, the being breaks up, in an extraordinary way, between its being and its semblance, between itself and that paper tiger it shows to the other. In the case of display, usually on the part of the male animal, or in the case of grimacing swelling by which the animal enters the play of combat in the form of intimidation, the being gives of himself, or receives from the other, something that is like a mask, a double, an envelope, a thrown-off skin, thrown off in order to cover the frame of a shield. It is through this separated form of himself that the being comes into play in his effects of life and death, and it might be said that it is with the help of this doubling of the other, or of oneself, that is realized the conjunction from which proceeds the renewal of beings in reproduction.

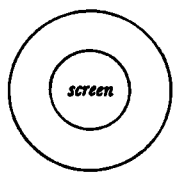
The lure plays an essential function therefore. It is not something else that seizes us at the very level of clinical experience, when, in relation to what one might imagine of the attraction to the other pole as conjoining masculine and feminine, we apprehend the prevalence of that which is presented as *travesty*. It is no doubt through the mediation of masks that the masculine and the feminine meet in the most acute, most intense way.

Only the subject—the human subject, the subject of the desire that is the essence of man—is not, unlike the animal, entirely caught up in this imaginary capture. He maps himself in it. How? In so far as he isolates the function of the screen and plays with it. Man, in effect, knows how to play with the mask as that beyond which there is the gaze. The screen is here the locus of mediation.

Last time, I alluded to the reference given by Maurice Merleau-Ponty in *La Phénoménologie de la perception* in which, from well-chosen examples based on the experiments of Gelb and Goldstein, one can already see, simply at the perceptual level, how the screen re-establishes things, in their status as real. If, by being isolated, an effect of lighting dominates us, if, for example, a beam of light directing our gaze so captivates us that it appears as a milky cone and prevents us from seeing

what it illuminates, the mere fact of introducing into this field a small screen, which cuts into that which is illuminated without being seen, makes the milky light retreat, as it were, into the shadow, and allows the object it concealed to emerge.

At the perceptual level, this is the phenomenon of a relation that is to be taken in a more essential function, namely, that in its relation to desire, reality appears only as marginal.



reality is marginal

This is certainly one of the features that scarcely seems to have been noticed in pictorial creation. Yet rediscovering in the picture what is, strictly speaking, composition, the lines dividing the surfaces created by the painter, vanishing traces, lines of force, frames (*bâtis*) in which the image finds its status is a fascinating game—but I am astonished that in one very remarkable book they are called *frameworks* (*charpentes*). For this term eliminates their principal effect. By a sort of irony, on the back of this book, there nevertheless figures, as being more exemplary than any other, a picture by Rouault on which is traced a circular line to enable us to grasp the main point.

Indeed, there is something whose absence can always be observed in a picture—which is not the case in perception. This is the central field, where the separating power of the eye is exercised to the maximum in vision. In every picture, this central field cannot but be absent, and replaced by a hole—a reflection, in short, of the pupil behind which is situated the gaze. Consequently, and in as much as the picture enters into a relation to desire, the place of a central screen is always marked, which is precisely that by which, in front of the picture, I am elided as subject of the geometral plane.

This is why the picture does not come into play in the field of representation. Its end and effect are elsewhere.

2

In the scopic field, everything is articulated between two terms that act in an antinomic way—on the side of things, there is the gaze, that is to say, things look at me, and yet I see them. This is how one should understand those words, so strongly stressed, in the Gospel, *They have eyes that they might not see.* That they might not see what? Precisely, that things are looking at them.

This is why I have introduced painting into our field of exploration by the narrow door offered by us by Roger Caillois —everyone noticed last time that I made a slip of the tongue in calling him René, heaven knows why—in observing that mimicry is no doubt the equivalent of the function which, in man, is exercised in painting.

This is not the occasion to begin a psycho-analysis of the painter, which is always such a tricky matter, and which always produces a shocked reaction on the part of the listener. Nor is it a question of art criticism, and yet someone who is close to me, and whose views count for a great deal with me, told me that he was very troubled when I embarked on something very like art criticism. Of course, that is the danger, and I shall try to avoid any such confusion.

If one considers all the modulations imposed on painting by the variations of the subjectifying structure that have occurred in history, it is clear that no formula can possibly embrace those aims, those ruses, those infinitely varied tricks. Indeed, you saw clearly enough last time that after declaring that there is in painting a certain *dompte-regard*, a taming of the gaze, that is to say, that he who looks is always led by the painting to lay down his gaze, I immediately introduced the corrective that it is nevertheless in a quite direct appeal to the gaze that expressionism is situated. For those who remain unconvinced, I will explain what I mean. I am thinking of the work of such painters as Munch, James Ensor, Kubin, or even of that painting which, curiously enough, one might situate in a geographical way as laying siege to that which in our time is concentrated in painting in Paris. When will we see the limits of this siege lifted? That, if I am to believe the painter André Masson, with whom I was talking recently, is the most immediate question. Well!

To point out references like these, is not to enter into the shifting, historical game of criticism, which tries to grasp what is the function of painting at a particular moment, for a particular author at a particular time. For me, it is at the radical principle of the function of this fine art that I am trying to place myself.

To begin with, I would stress that it is in setting out from painting that Maurice Merleau-Ponty was particularly led to overthrow the relation, which has always been made by thought, between the eye and the mind. What he has shown in a quite admirable way, beginning with what he calls, with Cézanne himself, *those little blues, those little browns, those little whites*, those touches that fall like rain from the painter's brush, is that the function of the painter is something quite different from the organization of the field of representation in which the philosopher held us in our status as subjects.

And what is that? Where does that get us? It already gives form and embodiment to the field in which the psycho-analyst has advanced since Freud, with what, in Freud, is crazy daring, and what, in those who follow him, soon becomes imprudence.

Freud always stressed with infinite respect that he did not intend to settle the question of what it was in artistic creation that gave it its true value. When he is dealing with painters and poets, there is a point at which his appreciation stops. He cannot say, he does not know, what, for everybody, for those who look or hear, is the value of artistic creation. Nevertheless, when he studies Leonardo, let us say, roughly speaking, that he tries to find the function that the artist's original phantasy played in his creation—his relation to those two mothers Freud sees represented in the painting in the Louvre or in the cartoon in London, by that double body, branching at the level of the waist, which seems to blossom from the entwined legs at the base. Is it in this direction that we must look?

Or should we see the principle of artistic creation in the fact that it seems to extract—remember how I translated *Vorstellungsrepräsentanz*—that something that stands for representation? Was it to this that I was leading you when I made a distinction between the picture and representation?

Certainly not—except in very rare works, except in a painting that sometimes emerges, a dream painting, so rare that it

can scarcely be situated in the function of painting. Indeed, perhaps this is the limit at which we would have to designate what is called psychopathological art.

That which is the creation of the painter is structured in a quite different way. Precisely to the extent that we restore the point of view of structure in the libidinal relation, perhaps the time has come when we may question to advantage—because our new algorithms allow us to articulate the answer better—what is involved in artistic creation. For me, it is a question of creation as Freud designated it, that is to say, as sublimation, and of the value it assumes in a social field.

In a way that is at once vague and precise, and which concerns only the success of the work, Freud declares that if a creation of desire, which is pure at the level of the painter, takes on commercial value—a gratification that may, all the same, be termed secondary—it is because its effect has something profitable for society, for that part of society that comes under its influence. Broadly speaking, one can say that the work calms people, comforts them, by showing them that at least some of them can live from the exploitation of their desire. But for this to satisfy them so much, there must also be that other effect, namely, that *their* desire to contemplate finds some satisfaction in it. It elevates the mind, as one says, that is to say, it encourages renunciation. Don't you see that there is something here that indicates the function I called *dompte-regard*?

As I said last time, *dompte-regard* is also presented in the form of *trompe-l'œil*. In this sense, I appear to be moving in the opposite direction from tradition, which situates its function as being very distinct from that of painting. Yet I did not hesitate to end my last talk by observing, in the opposition of the works of Zeuxis and Parrhasios, the ambiguity of two levels, that of the natural function of the lure and that of *trompe-l'œil*.

If the birds rushed to the surface on which Zeuxis had deposited his dabs of colour, taking the picture for edible grapes, let us observe that the success of such an undertaking does not imply in the least that the grapes were admirably reproduced, like those we can see in the basket held by Caravaggio's *Bacchus* in the Uffizi. If the grapes had been painted in this way, it is not very likely that the birds would have been deceived, for why should the birds see grapes portrayed with

such extraordinary verisimilitude? There would have to be something more reduced, something closer to the sign, in something representing grapes for the birds. But the opposite example of Parrhasios makes it clear that if one wishes to deceive a man, what one presents to him is the painting of a veil, that is to say, something that incites him to ask what is behind it.

It is here that this little story becomes useful in showing us why Plato protests against the illusion of painting. The point is not that painting gives an illusory equivalence to the object, even if Plato seems to be saying this. The point is that the *trompe-l'œil* of painting pretends to be something other than what it is.

What is it that attracts and satisfies us in *trompe-l'œil*? When is it that it captures our attention and delights us? At the moment when, by a mere shift of our gaze, we are able to realize that the representation does not move with the gaze and that it is merely a *trompe-l'œil*. For it appears at that moment as something other than it seemed, or rather it now seems to be that something else. The picture does not compete with appearance, it competes with what Plato designates for us beyond appearance as being the Idea. It is because the picture is the appearance that says it is that which gives the appearance that Plato attacks painting, as if it were an activity competing with his own.

This other thing is the *petit a*, around which there revolves a combat of which *trompe-l'œil* is the soul.

If one tries to represent the position of the painter concretely in history, one realizes that he is the source of something that may pass into the real and on which, at all times, one might say, one takes a lease. The painter, it is said, no longer depends on aristocratic patrons. But the situation is not fundamentally changed with the advent of the picture dealer. He, too, is a patron, and a patron of the same stamp. Before the aristocratic patron, it was the religious institution, with the holy image, that gave artists a living. The artist always has some financial body behind him and it is always a question of the *objet a*, or rather a question of reducing it—which may, at a certain level, strike you as being rather mythical—to an *a* with which—this is true in the last resort—it is the painter as creator who sets up a dialogue.

But it is much more instructive to see how the *a* functions in its social repercussions.

Icons—the Christ in triumph in the vault at Daphnis or the admirable Byzantine mosaics—undoubtedly have the effect of holding us under their gaze. We might stop there, but were we to do so we would not really grasp the motive that made the painter set about making this icon, or the motive it satisfies in being presented to us. It is something to do with the gaze, of of course, but there is more to it than that. What makes the value of the icon is that the god it represents is also looking at it. It is intended to please God. At this level, the artist is operating on the sacrificial plane—he is playing with those things, in this case images, that may arouse the desire of God.

Indeed, God is the creator of certain images—we see this in *Genesis*, with the *Zelem Elohim*. And iconoclastic thought itself still preserves this when it declares there is a god that does not care for this. He is certainly alone in this. But I do not want to go too far today in a direction that would take us right to the heart of one of the most essential elements of the province of the Names-of-the-Father: a certain pact may be signed beyond every image. Where we are, the image remains a go-between with the divinity—if Javeh forbids the Jews to make idols, it is because they give pleasure to the other gods. In a certain register it is not God who is not anthropomorphic, it is man who is begged not to be so. But that's enough of that.

Let us pass now to the next stage, which I shall call *communal*. Let us go to the great hall of the Doges' Palace in which are painted all kinds of battles, such as the battle of Lepanto, etc. The social function, which was already emerging at the religious level, is now becoming clear. Who comes here? Those who form what Retz calls '*les peuples*', the audiences. And what do the audiences see in these vast compositions. They see the gaze of those persons who, when the audience are not there, deliberate in this hall. Behind the picture, it is their gaze that is there.

You see, one can say that there are always lots of gazes behind. Nothing new is introduced in this respect by the epoch that André Malraux distinguishes as the modern, that which comes to be dominated by what he calls '*the incomparable monster*', namely, the gaze of the painter, which claims to impose itself as being the only gaze. There always was a gaze behind. But

—this is the most subtle point—where does this gaze come from?

3

We now come back to the *little blues, little whites, little browns* of Cézanne, or again to the delightful example that Maurice Merleau-Ponty gives in passing in his *Signes*, namely, that strange slow-motion film in which one sees Matisse painting. The important point is that Matisse himself was overwhelmed by the film. Maurice Merleau-Ponty draws attention to the paradox of this gesture which, enlarged by the distension of time, enables us to imagine the most perfect deliberation in each of these brush strokes. This is an illusion, he says. What occurs as these strokes, which go to make up the miracle of the picture, fall like rain from the painter's brush is not choice, but something else. Can we not try to formulate what this something else is?

Should not the question be brought closer to what I called the rain of the brush? If a bird were to paint would it not be by letting fall its feathers, a snake by casting off its scales, a tree by letting fall its leaves? What it amounts to is the first act in the laying down of the gaze. A sovereign act, no doubt, since it passes into something that is materialized and which, from this sovereignty, will render obsolete, excluded, inoperant, whatever, coming from elsewhere, will be presented before this product.

Let us not forget that the painter's brushstroke is something in which a movement is terminated. We are faced here with something that gives a new and different meaning to the term regression—we are faced with the element of motive in the sense of response, in so far as it produces, behind it, its own stimulus.

There, that by which the original temporality in which the relation to the other is situated as distinct is here, in the scopic dimension, that of the terminal moment. That which in the identificatory dialectic of the signifier and the spoken will be projected forward as haste, is here, on the contrary, the end, that which, at the outset of any new intelligence, will be called the moment of seeing.

This terminal moment is that which enables us to distinguish between a gesture and an act. It is by means of the gesture that

the brushstroke is applied to the canvas. And so true is it that the gesture is always present there that there can be no doubt that the picture is first felt by us, as the terms *impression* or *impressionism* imply, as having more affinity with the gesture than with any other type of movement. All action represented in a picture appears to us as a battle scene, that is to say, as something theatrical, necessarily created for the gesture. And, again, it is this insertion in the gesture that means that one cannot turn it upside down—whether or not it is figurative. If you turn a transparency around, you realize at once if it is being shown to you with the left in the place of the right. The direction of the gesture of the hand indicates sufficiently this lateral symmetry.

What we see here, then, is that the gaze operates in a certain descent, a descent of desire, no doubt. But how can we express this? The subject is not completely aware of it—he operates by remote control. Modifying the formula I have of desire as unconscious—*man's desire is the desire of the Other*—I would say that it is a question of a sort of desire *on the part of* the Other, at the end of which is the *showing* (*le donner-à-voir*).

How could this *showing* satisfy something, if there is not some appetite of the eye on the part of the person looking? This appetite of the eye that must be fed produces the hypnotic value of painting. For me, this value is to be sought on a much less elevated plane than might be supposed, namely, in that which is the true function of the organ of the eye, the eye filled with voracity, the evil eye.

It is striking, when one thinks of the universality of the function of the evil eye, that there is no trace anywhere of a good eye, of an eye that blesses. What can this mean, except that the eye carries with it the fatal function of being in itself endowed—if you will allow me to play on several registers at once—with a power to separate. But this power to separate goes much further than distinct vision. The powers that are attributed to it, of drying up the milk of an animal on which it falls—a belief as widespread in our time as in any other, and in the most civilized countries—of bringing with it disease or misfortune—where can we better picture this power than in *invidia*?

Invidia comes from *videre*. The most exemplary *invidia*, for us

analysts, is the one I found long ago in Augustine, in which he sums up his entire fate, namely, that of the little child seeing his brother at his mother's breast, looking at him *amare conspectu*, with a bitter look, which seems to tear him to pieces and has on himself the effect of a poison.

In order to understand what *invidia* is in its function as gaze it must not be confused with jealousy. What the small child, or whoever, *envies* is not at all necessarily what he might want —*avoir envie*, as one improperly puts it. Who can say that the child who looks at his younger brother still needs to be at the breast? Everyone knows that envy is usually aroused by the possession of goods which would be of no use to the person who is envious of them, and about the true nature of which he does not have the least idea.

Such is true envy—the envy that makes the subject pale before the image of a completeness closed upon itself, before the idea that the *petit a*, the separated *a* from which he is hanging, may be for another the possession that gives satisfaction, *Befriedigung*.

It is to this register of the eye as made desperate by the gaze that we must go if we are to grasp the taming, civilizing and fascinating power of the function of the picture. The profound relation between the *a* and desire will serve as an example when I introduce the subject of the transference.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

M. TORT: *Could you say more about the relation you posited between gesture and the moment of seeing?*

LACAN: What is a gesture? A threatening gesture, for example? It is not a blow that is interrupted. It is certainly something that is done in order to be arrested and suspended.

I may carry it to its logical conclusion later, but, as a threatening gesture it is inscribed behind.

It is this very special temporality, which I have defined by the term arrest and which creates its signification behind it, that makes the distinction between the gesture and the act.

What is very remarkable in the Peking Opera—I don't know whether you saw them on their recent visit—is the way fighting is depicted. One fights as one has always fought since time immemorial, much more with gestures than with blows.

Of course, the spectacle itself is content with an absolute dominance of gestures. In these ballets, no two people ever touch one another, they move in different spaces in which are spread out whole series of gestures, which, in traditional combat, nevertheless have the value of weapons, in the sense that they may well be effective as instruments of intimidation. Everyone knows that primitive peoples go into battle with grimacing, horrible masks and terrifying gestures. You mustn't imagine that this is over and done with! When fighting the Japanese, the American marines were taught to make as many grimaces as they. Our more recent weapons might also be regarded as gestures. Let us hope that they will remain such!

The authenticity of what emerges in painting is diminished in us human beings by the fact that we have to get our colours where they're to be found, that is to say, in the shit. If I referred to birds who might let fall their feathers, it is because *we* do not have these feathers. The creator will never participate in anything other than the creation of a small dirty deposit, a succession of small dirty deposits juxtaposed. It is through this dimension that we are in scopic creation—the gesture as displayed movement.

Does this explanation satisfy you? Was that the question you asked me?

TORT: *No, I wanted you to say more about that temporality to which you already referred once, and which presupposes, it seems to me, references that you have made elsewhere to logical time.*

LACAN: Look, what I noticed there was the suture, the pseudo-identification, that exists between what I called the time of terminal arrest of the gesture and what, in another dialectic that I called the dialectic of identificatory haste, I put as the first time, namely, the moment of seeing. The two overlap, but they are certainly not identical, since one is initial and the other is terminal.

I would like to say more about something for which I was not able, for lack of time, to give you the necessary indications.

This terminal time of the gaze, which completes the gesture, I place strictly in relation to what I later say about the evil eye. The gaze in itself not only terminates the movement, it freezes it. Take those dances I mentioned—they are always punctuated by a series of times of arrest in which the actors pause in a

frozen attitude. What is that thrust, that time of arrest of the movement? It is simply the fascinatory effect, in that it is a question of dispossessing the evil eye of the gaze, in order to ward it off. The evil eye is the *fascinum*, it is that which has the effect of arresting movement and, literally, of killing life. At the moment the subject stops, suspending his gesture, he is mortified. The anti-life, anti-movement function of this terminal point is the *fascinum*, and it is precisely one of the dimensions in which the power of the gaze is exercised directly. The moment of seeing can intervene here only as a suture, a conjunction of the imaginary and the symbolic, and it is taken up again in a dialectic, that sort of temporal progress that is called haste, thrust, forward movement, which is concluded in the *fascinum*.

What I wish to emphasize is the total distinction between the scopic register and the invocatory, vocatory, vocational field. In the scopic field, the subject is not essentially indeterminate. The subject is strictly speaking determined by the very separation that determines the break of the *a*, that is to say, the fascinatory element introduced by the gaze. Does that satisfy you more? Completely?

TORT: *Almost.*

F. WAHL: *You have left to one side a phenomenon that is situated, like the evil eye, in the Mediterranean civilizations, and which is the prophylactic eye. It has a protective function that lasts for the duration of a journey, and which is linked, not to an arrest, but to a movement.*

LACAN: What is prophylactic about such things is, one might say, allopathic, whether it is a question of a horn, whether or not made of coral, or innumerable other things whose appearance is clearer, like the *turpicula res*, described by Varro, I think, which is quite simply a phallus. For it is in so far as all human desire is based on castration that the eye assumes its virulent, aggressive function, and not simply its luring function as in nature. One can find among these amulets forms in which a counter-eye emerges—this is homeopathic. Thus, obliquely, the so-called prophylactic function is introduced.

I was thinking that in the Bible, for example, there must be passages in which the eye confers the *baraka* or blessing. There are a few small places where I hesitated—but no. The eye may

be prophylactic, but it cannot be beneficent—it is maleficent. In the Bible and even in the New Testament, there is no good eye, but there are evil eyes all over the place.

J.-A. MILLER: *On several occasions recently, you have explained that the subject cannot be located in the dimension of quantity or measure, in a Cartesian space. On the other hand, you have said that Merleau-Ponty's research converged with your own. You have even maintained that he laid down the reference-points of the unconscious . . .*

LACAN: I did not say that. I suggested that the few whiffs of the unconscious to be detected in his notes might have led him to pass, let us say, into my field. I'm not at all sure.

MILLER: *To continue. Now, if Merleau-Ponty is seeking to subvert Cartesian space, is it in order to open up the transcendental space of the relation to the Other? No, it is in order to accede either to the so-called dimension of inter-subjectivity, or to that so-called pre-objective, savage, primordial world. This leads me to ask you if* Le Visible et l'invisible *has led you to change anything in the article that you published on Merleau-Ponty in a number of* Les Temps Modernes?

LACAN: Absolutely nothing.

11 March 1964

Photography

In the days of cock-a-doodle I went and saw Rome and the Lateran hanging from a silk thread. I saw a man without feet outrunning a swift horse and a sharp, sharp sword cutting a bridge in two.
—The Brothers Grimm, "The Tale of a Cock-a-Doodle"

1

This is what the film diva looks like. She is twenty-four years old, featured on the cover of an illustrated magazine, standing in front of the Hotel Excelsior on the Lido. The date is September. If one were to look through a magnifying glass one could make out the grain, the millions of little dots that constitute the diva, the waves, and the hotel. The picture, however, refers not to the dot matrix but to the living diva on the Lido. Time: the present. The caption calls her demonic: our demonic diva. Still, she does not lack a certain allure. The bangs, the seductive position of the head, and the twelve eyelashes right and left—all these details, diligently recorded by the camera, are in their proper place, a flawless appearance. Everyone recognizes her with delight, since everyone has already seen the original on the screen. It is such a good likeness that she cannot be confused with anyone else, even if she is perhaps only one-twelfth of a dozen Tiller girls.[1] Dreamily she stands in front of the Hotel Excelsior, which basks in her fame—a being of flesh and blood, our demonic diva, twenty-four years old, on the l -ido. The date is September.

Is this what *grandmother* looked like? The photograph, more than sixty years old and already a photograph in the modern sense, depicts her as a young girl of twenty-four. Since photographs are likenesses, this one must have been a likeness as well. It was carefully produced in the studio of a court photographer. But were it not for the oral tradition, the image alone would not have sufficed to reconstruct the grandmother. The grandchildren know that in her later years she lived in a narrow little room with a view onto the old part of town and that, to amuse the children, she would make toy soldiers dance on a glass plate;[2] they also know a nasty story about her life, and two confirmed utterances which change a bit from generation to generation. One has to believe the parents—who claim to have gotten it from grandmother herself—that this photograph depicts the very same grandmother about whom one has retained these few details that may also in time be forgotten. Yet eyewitness accounts are unreliable. It might turn out after all that the photograph depicts not the grandmother but a friend who resembled her. None of her contemporaries are still alive. And the question of likeness? The ur-image has long since decayed. But the now-darkened appearance has so little in common with the traits still remembered that the grandchildren submit in amazement to the imperative of encountering in the photograph their fragmentarily recorded ancestor. All right, so it's grandmother; but in reality it's any young girl in 1864. The girl smiles continuously, always the same smile. The smile is arrested yet no longer refers to the life from which it has been taken. Likeness has ceased to be of any help. The smiles of plastic mannequins in beauty parlors are just as rigid and perpetual. This mannequin does not belong to our time; it could be standing with others of its kind in a museum, in a glass case labeled "Traditional Costumes, 1864." There the mannequins are displayed solely for the historical costumes, and the grandmother in the photograph, too, is an archaeological mannequin which serves to illustrate the costumes of the period. So that's how women dressed back then: chignons, cinched waists, crinolines, and Zouave jackets.[3] The grandmother dissolves into fashionably old-fashioned details before the very eyes of the grandchildren. They are amused by the traditional costume, which, following the disappearance of its bearer,

remains alone on the battlefield—an external decoration that has become autonomous. They are irreverent, and today young girls dress differently. They laugh, and at the same time they shudder. For through the ornamentation of the costume from which the grandmother has disappeared, they think they glimpse a moment of time past, a time that passes without return. Although time is not part of the photograph like the smile or the chignon, the photograph itself, so it seems to them, is a representation of time. Were it the photograph alone that endowed these details with duration, they would not at all outlast mere time; rather, time would create images for itself out of them.

2

"From the early days of the friendship between Goethe and Karl August."—"Karl August and the 1787 coadjutor election in Erfurt."—"A visit of a Bohemian in Jena and Weimar" (1818).—"Recollections of a Weimar high school student" (1825 to 1830).—"A contemporary account of the Weimar Goethe celebration on November 7, 1825."—"A rediscovered bust of Wieland by Ludwig Klauer."—"Plan for a national monument to Goethe in Weimar."—The herbarium for these and other investigations is provided by the Goethe Society yearbooks, a series that in principle can never come to an end. It would be superfluous to ridicule the Goethe philology which deposits its specimens in these volumes, all the more so since it is as ephemeral as the items it processes. In contrast, the pseudo-luster of the numerous monumental works on Goethe's stature, being, personality, and so on has hardly begun to be questioned. The principle of Goethe philology is that of *historicist* thinking, which emerged at about the same time as modern photographic technology. On the whole, advocates of such historicist thinking[4] believe they can explain any phenomenon purely in terms of its genesis. That is, they believe in any case that they can grasp historical reality by reconstructing the course of events in their temporal succession without any gaps. Photography presents a spatial continuum; historicism seeks to provide the temporal continuum. According to historicism, the complete mirroring of an intratemporal sequence simultaneously contains the meaning of all that

occurred within that time. Thus, if the connecting links of the Erfurt coadjutor election or the recollections of the Weimar high school student were missing in the presentation of Goethe, such an account would lack reality for the historicist. Historicism is concerned with the photography of time. The equivalent of its temporal photography would be a giant film depicting the temporally interconnected events from every vantage point.[5]

3

Memory **encompasses neither the entire spatial appearance of a state of affairs nor its entire temporal course. Compared to photography, memory's records are full of gaps. The fact that the grandmother was at one time involved in a nasty story that is recounted time and again because people really do not like to talk about her—this does not mean much from the photographer's perspective. He knows every little wrinkle on her face and has noted every date. Memory does not pay much attention to dates—it skips years or stretches temporal distance. The selection of traits that it assembles must strike the photographer as arbitrary. The selection may have been made this way rather than another because dispositions and purposes required the repression, falsification, and emphasis of certain parts of the object; a virtually endless number of reasons determines the remains to be filtered. No matter which scenes an individual remembers, they all mean something relevant to that person, though he or she might not necessarily know what they mean. An individual retains memories because they are personally significant. Thus, they are organized according to a principle which is essentially different from the organizing principle of photography. Photography grasps what is given as a spatial (or temporal) continuum; memory images retain what is given only insofar as it has significance. Since what is significant is not reducible to either merely spatial or merely temporal terms, memory images are at odds with photographic representation. From the latter's perspective, memory images appear to be fragments—but only because photography does not encompass the meaning to which they refer and in relation to which they cease to be fragments.**

Similarly, from the perspective of memory, photography appears as a jumble that consists partly of garbage.

The meaning of memory images is linked to their truth content. So long as they are embedded in the uncontrolled life of the drives, they are inhabited by a demonic ambiguity; they are opaque, like frosted glass which scarcely a ray of light can penetrate. Their transparency increases to the extent that insights thin out the vegetation of the soul and limit the compulsion of nature. Truth can be found only by a liberated consciousness which assesses the demonic nature of the drives. The traits that consciousness recollects stand in a relationship to what has been perceived as true, the latter being either manifest in these traits or excluded by them. The image in which these traits appear is distinguished from all other memory images, for unlike the latter it preserves not a multitude of opaque recollections but elements that touch upon what has been recognized as true. All memory images are bound to be reduced to this type of image, which may rightly be called the last image, since it alone preserves the unforgettable. The last image of a person is that person's actual *history.* This history omits all characteristics and determinations that do not relate in a significant sense to the truth intended by a liberated consciousness. How a person represents this history does not depend purely on his or her natural constitution or on the pseudo-coherence of his or her individuality; thus, only fragments of these assets are included in his or her history. This history is like a *monogram* that condenses the name into a single graphic figure which is meaningful as an ornament. Eckart's monogram is fidelity.[6] Great historical figures survive in legends that, however naive they may be, strive to preserve their actual history. In authentic fairy tales, the imagination has intuitively deposited typical monograms. In a photograph, a person's history is buried as if under a layer of snow.

In his description of a Rubens landscape presented to him by Goethe, Eckermann notices to his surprise that the light in the painting comes from two opposing directions, "which is quite contrary to nature."[7]

Goethe responds: "This is how Rubens proves his greatness, and shows to the world that he stands *above* nature with a free spirit, fashioning it according to his higher purposes. The double light is indeed violent, and you could even say that it is contrary to nature. But if it is contrary to nature, I also say that it is *higher* than nature; I say that it is the bold hand of the master, whereby he demonstrates in a brilliant way that art is not entirely subject to natural necessity but rather has laws of its own." A *portrait painter* who submitted entirely to "natural necessity" would at best create photographs. During a particular period, which began with the Renaissance and may now be approaching its end, the "artwork" has indeed been faithful to nature, whose specificity has revealed itself more and more during this period. But by penetrating this nature, the artwork orients itself toward "higher ends." There is cognition in the material of colors and contours; and the greater the artwork, the more it approaches the transparency of the final memory image, in which the features of "history" converge. A man who had his portrait painted by Triibner asked the artist not to forget the wrinkles and folds on his face. Triibner pointed out the window and said, "Across the way, there's a photographer. If you want to have wrinkles and folds, then you'd better hire him—he'll put 'em all in. Me, I paint history."[8] In order for history to present itself, the mere surface coherence offered by photography must be destroyed. For in the artwork the meaning of the object takes on spatial appearance, whereas in photography the spatial appearance of an object is its meaning. The two spatial appearances—the "natural" one and that of the object permeated by cognition—are not identical. By sacrificing the former for the sake of the latter, the artwork also negates the *likeness* achieved by photography. This likeness refers to the look of the object, which does not immediately divulge how it reveals itself to cognition; the artwork, however, conveys nothing but the transparency of the object. In so doing, it resembles a magic mirror which reflects those who consult it not as they appear but rather as they wish to be or as they fundamentally are. The artwork, too, disintegrates over time; but its meaning arises out of its crumbled elements, whereas photography merely stockpiles the elements.

Until well into the second half of the nineteenth century, the practice of photography was often in the hands of former painters. The not yet entirely depersonalized technology of this transition period corresponded to a spatial environment in which traces of meaning could still be trapped. With the increasing independence of the technology and the simultaneous evacuation of meaning from the objects, *artistic photography* **loses its justification: it grows not into an artwork but into its imitation. Images of children are Zumbusches,[9] and the godfather of photographic landscape impressions was Monet. These pictorial arrangements—which do not go beyond a skillful emulation of familiar styles—fail to represent the very remnants of nature which, to a certain extent, advanced technology is capable of capturing. Modern painters have composed their images out of photographic fragments in order to highlight the side-by-side existence of reified appearances as they manifest themselves in spatial relations. This artistic intention is diametrically opposed to that of artistic photography. The latter does not explore the object assigned to photographic technology but rather wants to hide the technological essence by means of style. The artistic photographer is a dilettante artist who apes an artistic manner minus its substance, instead of capturing the very lack of substance. Similarly, rhythmic gymnastics wants to incorporate the soul about which it knows nothing. It shares with artistic photography the ambition to lay claim to a higher life in order to elevate an activity which is actually at its most elevated when it finds the object appropriate to its technology. The artistic photographers function like those social forces which are interested in the semblance of the spiritual because they fear the real spirit: it might explode the material base which the spiritual illusion serves to disguise. It would be well worth the effort to expose the close ties between the prevailing social order and artistic photography.**

5

The photograph does not preserve the transparent aspects of an object but instead captures it as a spatial continuum from any one of a number of positions. The last memory image outlasts time because it is unfor-

gettable; the photograph, which neither refers to nor encompasses such a memory image, must be essentially associated with the moment in time at which it came into existence. Referring to the average film whose subject matter is the normal photographable environment, E. A. Dupont remarked in his book on film that "the essence of film is, to some degree, the essence of time."[10] If photography is a *function of the flow of time,* **then its substantive meaning will change depending upon whether it belongs to the domain of the present or to some phase of the past.**

Current-event photography, which portrays phenomena familiar to *contemporary* **consciousness, provides access of a limited sort to the life of the original. In each case it registers an exteriority which, at the time of its reign, is a means of expression as generally intelligible as language. The contemporaneous viewer believes that he or she sees the film diva herself in the photograph, and not just her bangs or the pose of her head. Naturally, the viewer cannot gauge her on the basis of the photograph alone. But luckily the diva numbers among the living, and the cover of the illustrated magazine functions as a reminder of her corporeal reality. This means that present-day photography performs a mediating function: it is an optical sign for the diva, who is meant to be recognized. One may have doubts in the end as to whether her decisive trait is really the demonic. But even the demonic is not so much something conveyed by the photograph as it is the impression of the moviegoers who experience the original on the screen. They recognize it as the representation of the demonic—so be it. The image denounces the demonic not because of, but rather** *despite* **its likeness. For the time being, the demonic belongs to the still-vacillating memory image of the diva to which the photographic likeness does not refer. But the memory image drawn from the viewing of our celebrated diva breaks through the wall of likeness into the photograph and thereby lends the latter a modicum of transparency.**

Once a photograph ages, the immediate reference to the original is no longer possible. The body of a deceased person appears smaller than the living figure. Likewise, an *old* **photograph presents itself as the reduction of a contemporaneous one. The old photograph has been emptied of the life whose physical presence overlay its merely spatial**

configuration. In inverse proportion to photographs, memory images enlarge themselves into monograms of remembered life. The photograph is the sediment which has settled from the monogram, and from year to year its semiotic value decreases. The truth content of the original is left behind in its history; the photograph captures only the residuum that history has discharged.

If one can no longer encounter the grandmother in the photograph, the image taken from the family album necessarily disintegrates into its particulars. In the case of the diva, one's gaze may wander from her bangs to her demonic quality; from the nothingness of the grandmother, the gaze is thrown back onto the chignons. It is the fashion details that hold the gaze tight. Photography is bound to time in precisely the same way as *fashion.* Since the latter has no significance other than as current human garb, it is translucent when modern and abandoned when old. The tightly corseted dress in the photograph protrudes into our time like a mansion from earlier days that is destined for destruction because the city center has been moved to another part of town. Usually members of the lower class settle in such buildings. It is only the very old traditional dress, a dress which has lost all contact with the present, that can attain the beauty of a ruin. The effect of an outfit which was still worn only recently is *comical.* The grandchildren are amused by the grandmotherly crinoline of 1864, which provokes the thought that it might hide the legs of a modern girl. The recent past which claims to be alive is more outdated than the past that existed long ago and whose meaning has changed. The comic quality of the crinoline results from the powerlessness of its claim. In the photograph, the grandmother's costume is recognized as a cast-off remnant that wants to continue to hold its ground. It dissolves into the sum of its details, like a corpse, yet stands tall as if full of life. Even the landscape and all other concrete objects become costumes in an old photograph. For what is retained in the image are not the features envisaged by a liberated consciousness. The representation captures contexts from which such consciousness has departed—that is, it encompasses orders of existence that have shriveled without wanting to admit it. The more consciousness withdraws from natural bonds, the more nature diminishes. In old etchings

whose fidelity is photographic, the hills of the Rhine look like mountains. As a result of technological development, they have in the meantime been reduced to tiny slopes, and the grandiosity of those aged views seems a bit ridiculous.

Ghosts are simultaneously comical and terrifying. Laughter is not the only response provoked by antiquated photography. It represents what is utterly past, and yet this detritus was once the present. Grandmother was once a person, and to this person belonged the chignon and the corset as well as the high-Renaissance chair with its turned spindles, ballast that did not weigh her down but was just carried along as a matter of course. Now the image wanders ghost-like through the present, like the lady of the haunted castle. Spooky apparitions occur only in places where a terrible deed has been committed. The photograph becomes a ghost because the costumed mannequin was once alive. The image proves that the alien trappings were incorporated into life as accessories. These trappings, whose lack of transparency one experiences in the old photograph, used to be inseparably meshed with the transparent aspects. This terrible association which persists in the photograph evokes a shudder. Such a shudder is evoked in drastic fashion by the pre-World War I films screened in the avant-garde "Studio des Ursulines" in Paris—film images that show how the features stored in the memory image are embedded in a reality which has long since disappeared. Like the photographic image, the playing of an old hit song or the reading of letters written long ago also conjures up anew a disintegrated unity. This ghost-like reality is *unredeemed.* **It consists of elements in space whose configuration is so far from necessary that one could just as well imagine a different organization of these elements. Those things once clung to us like our skin, and this is how our property still clings to us today. Nothing of these contains us, and the photograph gathers fragments around a nothing. When the grandmother stood in front of the lens, she was present for one second in the spatial continuum that presented itself to the lens. But it was this aspect and not the grandmother that was eternalized. A shudder runs through the viewer of old photographs. For they make visible not the knowledge of the original but the spatial configuration of a moment; what appears in**

the photograph is not the person but the sum of what can be subtracted from him or her. The photograph annihilates the person by portraying him or her, and were person and portrayal to converge, the person would cease to exist. An illustrated newspaper recently put together photographs of famous personalities as children and as grown-ups and published them under the heading "The Faces of Famous People: This Is How They Once Were—and This Is How They Are Today!" Marx as a youth and Marx as leader of the Center party, Hindenburg as a lieutenant and as our Hindenburg. The photographs are set side by side like statistical reports, and one can neither guess the later image from the earlier one nor reconstruct the earlier image from the later. One has to take it on faith that the optical inventory lists belong together. The features of human beings are retained only in their "history."

The daily papers are illustrating their texts more and more. And what would a magazine be without pictures? The most striking proof of photography's extraordinary validity today is the increase in the number of *illustrated newspapers.* **In them one finds assembled everything from the film diva to whatever is within reach of the camera and the audience. Infants are of interest to mothers, and young gentlemen are captivated by the legs of beautiful girls. Beautiful girls like to see sports and stage celebrities standing on gangways of ocean liners, embarking on voyages to distant lands. In distant lands there are battles of conflicting interests. Yet the focus of attention is not on them but on the cities, the natural catastrophes, the cultural heroes, and the politicians. In Geneva, the League of Nations is meeting; it serves as a pretext for showing Mr. Stresemann and Mr. Briand conversing in front of the entrance of the hotel. The new fashions also must be disseminated, or else in the summer the beautiful girls will not know who they are. Fashion beauties attend chic events accompanied by young gentlemen; earthquakes take place in distant lands; Mr. Stresemann is seated on a terrace with potted palms; and for the mothers we have the little tots.**

The aim of the illustrated newspapers is the complete reproduction

of the world accessible to the photographic apparatus. They record the spatial impressions of people, conditions, and events from every possible perspective. Their method corresponds to that of the weekly newsreel, which is nothing but a collection of photographs, whereas an authentic film employs photography merely as a means. Never before has an age been so informed about itself, if being informed means having an image of objects that resembles them in a photographic sense. Most of the images in the illustrated magazines are topical photographs, which refer to existing objects. The reproductions are thus basically signs which may remind us of the original object that was supposed to be understood. The demonic diva. In reality, however, the weekly photographic ration does not at all mean to refer to these objects or ur-images. If it were offering itself as an aid to memory, then memory would have to determine the selection. But the flood of photos sweeps away the dams of memory. The assault of this mass of images is so powerful that it threatens to destroy the potentially existing awareness of crucial traits. Artworks suffer this fate through their reproductions. The phrase "lie together, die together" applies to the multiply reproduced original; rather than coming into view through the reproductions, it tends to disappear in its multiplicity and to live on as art photography. In the illustrated magazines, people see the very world that the illustrated magazines prevent them from perceiving. The spatial continuum from the camera's perspective dominates the spatial appearance of the perceived object; the resemblance between the image and the object effaces the contours of the object's "history." Never before has a period known so little about itself. In the hands of the ruling society, the invention of illustrated magazines is one of the most powerful means of organizing a strike against understanding. Even the colorful arrangement of the images provides a not insignificant means for successfully implementing such a strike. The *contiguity* of these images systematically excludes their contextual framework available to consciousness. The "image-idea" drives away the idea. The blizzard of photographs betrays an indifference toward what the things mean. It does not have to be this way; but in any case the American illustrated magazines—which the publications of other countries emulate to a large degree—

equate the world with the quintessence of the photographs. This equation is not made without good reason. For the world itself has taken on a "photographic face"; it can be photographed because it strives to be absorbed into the spatial continuum which yields to snapshots. Sometimes it is the fraction of a second required for the exposure of an object that determines whether or not a sportsman will become famous to the point where illustrated magazines commission photographers to give him exposure. The camera can also capture the figures of beautiful girls and young gentlemen. That the world devours them is a sign of the *fear of death.* **What the photographs by their sheer accumulation attempt to banish is the recollection of death, which is part and parcel of every memory image. In the illustrated magazines the world has become a photographable present, and the photographed present has been entirely eternalized. Seemingly ripped from the clutch of death, in reality it has succumbed to it.**

7

The series of pictorial representations of which photography is the last historical stage begins with the *symbol.* **The symbol, in turn, arises out of the "natural community," in which man's consciousness was still entirely embedded in nature.**

> **Just as the history of individual words always begins with the sensuous, natural meaning and only progresses to abstract, figurative uses in the later stages of its development, one can observe the same progression from substance and matter to the spiritual and the intellectual in religion, in the development of the human individual and of mankind in general. Likewise the fundamental meaning of the symbols in which the earliest human beings customarily deposited their views of the nature of the world surrounding them is purely physical and material. Symbolism, like language, sat in nature's lap.**[12]

This statement, by Bachofen, comes from his study of the rope-twisting Ocnus in which he shows that the spinning and weaving depicted in the image originally referred to the activity of the creative

power of nature. As consciousness becomes more and more aware of itself and in the process the originary "identity of nature and man"[13] dissolves, the meaning of the image becomes increasingly abstract and immaterial. But even if, as Bachofen puts it, the image progresses to the point of designating "the spiritual and the intellectual," the meaning is nevertheless so much a part of the image that it cannot be separated from it. For long stretches of history, imagistic representations have remained symbols. So long as human beings need them, they continue, in practice, to be dependent on natural conditions, a dependence that determines the visible and corporeal expression of consciousness. It is only with the increasing domination of nature that the image loses its symbolic power. Consciousness, which disengages itself from nature and stands against it, is no longer naively enveloped in its mythological cocoon: it thinks in concepts which, of course, can still be used in an altogether mythological way. In certain epochs the image retains its power; the symbolic presentation becomes *allegory.* "The latter signifies merely a general concept or an idea which is distinct from it; the former is the sensuous form, the incorporation of the idea itself." This is how old Creuzer defines the difference between the two types of images.[14] At the level of the symbol, what is thought is contained in the image; at the level of allegory, thought maintains and employs the image as if consciousness were hesitating to throw off its cocoon. This schematization is crude. Yet it suffices to illustrate the transformation of representations which is the sign that consciousness has departed from its natural contingency. The more decisively consciousness frees itself from this contingency in the course of the historical process, the more purely does its natural foundation present itself to consciousness. What is meant no longer appears to consciousness in images; rather, this meaning goes toward and through nature. To an ever-increasing degree, European painting during the last few centuries has represented nature stripped of symbolic and allegorical meanings. This certainly does not imply that the human features it depicts are bereft of meaning. Even as recently as the days of the old daguerreotypes, consciousness was so imbricated in nature that the faces bring to mind meanings which cannot be separated from natural life. Since nature changes in exact correspondence with the

particular state of consciousness of a period, the foundation of nature devoid of meaning arises with modern photography. No different from earlier modes of representation, photography, too, is assigned to a particular developmental stage of practical and material life. It is a secretion of the capitalist mode of production. The same mere nature which appears in photography flourishes in the reality of the society produced by this capitalist mode of production. One can certainly imagine a society that has fallen prey to a mute nature which has no meaning no matter how abstract its silence. The contours of such a society emerge in the illustrated journals. Were it to endure, the emancipation of consciousness would result in the eradication of consciousness; the nature that it failed to penetrate would sit down at the very table that consciousness had abandoned. If this society failed to endure, however, then liberated consciousness would be given an incomparable opportunity. Less enmeshed in the natural bonds than ever before, it could prove its power in dealing with them. The turn to photography is the *go-for-broke game* of history.

8

Although the grandmother has disappeared, the crinoline has nonetheless remained. The totality of all photographs must be understood as the *general inventory* of a nature that cannot be further reduced—as the comprehensive catalogue of all manifestations which present themselves in space, to the extent that they are constructed not out of the monogram of the object but from a natural perspective which the monogram does not capture. Corresponding to this spatial inventory is historicism's temporal inventory. Instead of preserving the "history" that consciousness reads out of the temporal succession of events, historicism records the temporal succession of events whose linkage does not contain the transparency of history. The barren self-presentation of spatial and temporal elements belongs to a social order which regulates itself according to economic laws of nature.

A consciousness caught up in nature is unable to see its own material base. It is the task of photography to disclose this previously

unexamined *foundation of nature.* **For the first time in history, photography brings to light the entire natural cocoon; for the first time, the inert world presents itself in its independence from human beings. Photography shows cities in aerial shots, brings crockets and figures down from the Gothic cathedrals. All spatial configurations are incorporated into the central archive in unusual combinations which distance them from human proximity. Once the grandmother's costume has lost its relationship to the present, it will no longer be funny; it will be peculiar, like an ocean-dwelling octopus. One day the diva will lose her demonic quality and her bangs will go the same way as the chignons. This is how the elements crumble, since they are not held together. The photographic archive assembles in effigy the last elements of a nature alienated from meaning.**

This warehousing of nature promotes the confrontation of consciousness with nature. Just as consciousness finds itself confronting the unabashedly displayed mechanics of industrial society, it also faces, thanks to photographic technology, the reflection of the reality that has slipped away from it. To have provoked the decisive confrontation in every field: this is precisely the go-for-broke game of the historical process. The images of the stock of nature disintegrated into its elements are offered up to consciousness to deal with as it pleases. Their original order is lost; they no longer cling to the spatial context that linked them with an original out of which the memory image was selected. But if the remnants of nature are not oriented toward the memory image, then the order they assume through the image is necessarily provisional. It is therefore incumbent on consciousness to establish the *provisional status of* **all given configurations, and perhaps even to awaken an inkling of the right order of the inventory of nature. In the works of Franz Kafka, a liberated consciousness absolves itself of this responsibility by destroying natural reality and scrambling the fragments. The disorder of the detritus reflected in photography cannot be elucidated more clearly than through the suspension of every habitual relationship among the elements of nature. The capacity to stir up the elements of nature is one of the possibilities of film. This possibility is realized whenever film combines parts and segments to create strange**

constructs. If the disarray of the illustrated newspapers is simply confusion, the game that film plays with the pieces of disjointed nature is reminiscent of *dreams* **in which the fragments of daily life become jumbled. This game shows that the valid organization of things remains unknown—an organization which would designate the position that the remains of the grandmother and the diva stored in the general inventory will some day have to occupy.**

Spaces of Passage

The Architecture of Estrangement: Simmel, Kracauer, Benjamin

A common and often explicit theme underlying the different responses of writers and social critics to the big cities of the nineteenth century might be found in the general concept of "estrangement": the estrangement of the inhabitant of a city too rapidly changing and enlarging to comprehend in traditional terms; the estrangement of classes from each other, of individual from individual, of individual from self, of workers from work. These refrains are constant from Rousseau to Marx, Baudelaire to Benjamin. The theme, a commonplace of romantic irony and self-enquiry and the leitmotiv of the Marxist critique of capital, was understood in both psychological and spatial terms. From Baudelaire's laments over the disappearance of old Paris ("the form of a city changes, alas, more rapidly than a man's heart") to Engels's wholesale critique of what he called "Haussmannization," the physical fabric of the city was identified as the instrument of a systematized and enforced alienation. The political critique of urban redevelopment forced by the growth of cities came together with the nostalgia of cultural conservatives lamenting the loss of their familiar quarters, creating a generalized sense of distantiation, of individual isolation, from the mechanical, mass-oriented, rapidly moving and crowded metropolis. Massimo Cacciari has written the history of this intellectual and "negative" critique of Metropolis as it emerged in the sociology of Max Weber, Georg Simmel, and their more conservative contemporaries Ferdinand Tönnies and Werner Sombart.[1]

Here I am concerned with only one aspect of this discourse of estrangement, the spatial and architectural in the writings of Simmel, Siegfried Kracauer, and Walter Benjamin as they searched for physical clues to the understanding of the social conditions of modernity. It will be my argument that, starting with the spatial sociology of Simmel, developing in the paradigmatic

spaces identified and described by his student Kracauer, thence to be applied as a criterion of historical-critical analysis by Benjamin, a unique sensibility of urban space was worked out, one that was neither used as a simple illustration of social history nor seen as a mechanical cause of social change, but rather a conception of space as reciprocally interdependent with society. This sensibility was, by its very nature, attached to certain kinds of urban spaces that were, for social critics, constitutionally related to the social estrangement that seemed to permeate the metropolitan realm. In this sense, the critical strength of spatial paradigms was derived from their intimate association, if not complicity, with the material and psychological conditions of what Georg Lukács dubbed the "transcendental homelessness" of the modern world. For these writers, indeed, they existed as the tangible and residual forms of such alienation.

On one level, of course, it is already a commonplace of intellectual history to note the fundamental role of spatial form in the cultural analyses of social critics like Adorno, Kracauer, and Benjamin. The *intérieur* of Adorno, the site of his critique of Kierkegaard; the *Hotelhalle* of Kracauer, key to his reading of the detective novel as itself a "reading" of modern society; Benjamin's Parisian *passage,* the central figure of his interpretation of the nineteenth century as the prehistory of the twentieth: these emblematic spaces haunt their texts, symbolizing every aspect of the nomadism, the consumer fetishism, and the displaced individualism of modern life in the great cities. Kracauer's often-cited observation, "Spatial images [*Raumbilder*] are the dreams of society. Wherever the hieroglyphics of these images can be deciphered, one finds the basis of social reality,"[2] accurately captures the special nature of these spatial evocations: like hieroglyphs, and their modern counterparts, dreams, these spaces stand ready to be deciphered. Neither simple illustrations nor fully analyzed examples, they seem to hover in a deliberately maintained state of half-reality, now glimpsed clearly, now lost in a cloud of metaphor.

And yet it is true that the central position of these spatial paradigms in the development of critical theory has more often than not been obscured by the equal and sometimes opposite role of temporality, of their concern with historical dialectics. Thus, Adorno's own critique of Benjamin's tendencies toward spatial reification, together with a tendency on the part of critics to follow Benjamin's preoccupation with memory and post-Bergsonian philosophy,

has itself worked against the nuanced interpretation of any dominant spatial images. Perhaps, also, these images are themselves almost too self-evident, too overdetermined, to be noticed as particular "constructions" in their own right. When Benjamin refers to arcades, or Kracauer to a hotel lobby, we tend to associate these forms immediately to their historical and physical referents, ignoring the degree of artifice and careful articulation that distinguishes Benjamin's "passage" or Kracauer's "lobby" from any that we might ourselves have known. For in a real sense these are purely textual spaces, designed, so to speak, by their authors; they possess an architectonics of their own, all the more special for its ambiguous status between textual and social domains; they are, so to speak, buildings that themselves serve as analytical instruments. Here the professional formation of Kracauer as an architect takes on a significant role that far surpasses, while at the same time being informed by, his actual career as a designer.

Estrangement: Georg Simmel

> Objects remain spellbound in the unmerciful separation of space, no material part can commonly share its space with another, a real unity of diverse elements does not exist in space.
>
> Georg Simmel, "Bridge and Door"

As we have seen, agoraphobia had emerged by the end of the century as a specific instance of that generalized estrangement identified by social critics as the principal effect of life in metropolis. It was, indeed, a central metaphor for the more generalized psychological interpretation of modern space undertaken by sociologists who, starting with Georg Simmel, sought to establish a science of social form and structure that treated space as a central category for modeling social relations, a point of reference for the study of individuals and groups. In the face of the crowded disorder of the modern metropolis, argued Simmel, the "sensitive and nervous modern person" required a degree of spatial isolation as a kind of prophylactic against psychological intrusion.[3] If such a personal boundary were to be transgressed, a "pathological deformation" might be observed in the individual, who would present all the symptoms of what Simmel called "fear of touching," or *Berührungsangst*. This fear of coming into too

close a contact with objects was, he argued, "a consequence of hyperaesthesia, for which every direct and energetic contact causes pain."[4] Simmel's diagnosis was at once spatial and mental: the real cause of the neurosis was not, as Westphal and Sitte had implied, solely spatial. Rather, he argued, it was a product of the rapid oscillation between two characteristic moods of urban life: the over-close identification with things and too great distance from them. In both cases, as with the symptoms of agoraphobia, the question was spatial at root, the result of the open spaces of the city, those very large expanses in which the crowds of metropolis found their "impulsiveness and enthusiasm."[5]

Out of this understanding of the spatial dimensions of social order, Simmel went on to construct a theory of estrangement that was once and for all tied to the space of metropolis.[6] Defining the place and role of individuals in society by their spatial relations of proximity and distance, he added the psychological dimension to the spatial, asserting, "It is not the form of spatial proximity or distance that creates the special phenomena of neighbourliness or foreignness, no matter how irrefutable this might seem. Rather, these two are facts caused purely by psychological contents." Space as the *expression* of social conditions would then be open to the sociological gaze: "Spatial relations are only the condition, on the one hand, and the symbol, on the other, of human relations."[7] As effects of human activities, spaces were important indications of social processes, of the interaction between human beings conceived of and experienced as *space-filling*. The "empty space" between individuals, filled and animated by their reciprocal relations, was, in these terms, both a spatial and a functional concept.[8] Viewed in this way, space might allow for the study of the social boundaries that defined the limits of territorial groupings; spatial unities might be identified, within borders coincident with the locations of particular social groups. Such borders, the spatial expression of sociological and functional unity alike, intersected social space like a network of imaginary lines, articulating the activity of society as a frame isolates a picture from its background.

The metropolis presented the most exacerbated condition of these psychological boundaries. In his essay "Metropolis and Mental Life," of 1903, Simmel characterized the "psychological foundation, upon which the metropolitan individuality is erected, . . . the intensification of emotional life due to the swift and continuous shift of external and internal stimuli," as spatial by

definition: "To the extent that the metropolis creates these psychological conditions—with every crossing of the street, with the tempo and multiplicity of economic, occupational and social life—it creates in the sensory foundations of mental life, and in the degree of awareness necessitated by our organization as creatures dependent on differences, a deep contrast with the slower, more habitual, more smoothly flowing rhythm of the sensory-mental phase of small town and rural existence."[9]

The social relations of the metropolitan inhabitant would then be intellectual rather than oral and emotional; the conscious would dominate the unconscious; habits would be adaptable and shifting, rather than rooted and apparently eternal; the impersonal would overcome the personal; objective distance would replace subjective empathy. The fundamental cause of these differences was the nature of metropolitan temporality, the speeded-up tempo of life itself and its regulation according to the standards of "punctuality, calculability, and exactness." For Simmel,

> the metropolis is the proper arena for this type of culture which has outgrown every personal element. Here in buildings and educational institutions, in the wonders and comforts of space-conquering technique, in the formations of social life and in the concrete institutions of the State is to be found such a tremendous richness of crystallizing, depersonalized cultural accomplishments that the personality can, so to speak, scarcely maintain itself in the face of it.[10]

It was the very nature of social relations in the big city that forced distance and thus alienation, for self-defense and for functional reasons. And distance was first and foremost a product of the omnipotence of sight; as opposed to the knowledge of individuals based on intimacy and oral communication in a small community, metropolitan connections were rapid, glancing, and ocular:

> Social life in the large city as compared with the towns shows a great preponderance of occasions to *see* rather than to *hear* people. . . . Before the appearance of omnibuses, railroads, and streetcars in the nineteenth century, men were not in a situation where for periods of minutes or hours they could or must look at each other without talking to one another.

> The greater perplexity which characterizes the person who only sees, as contrasted with the one who only hears, brings us to problems of the emotions of modern life; the lack of orientation in the collective life, the sense of utter lonesomeness, and the feeling that the individual is surrounded on all sides by closed doors.[11]

This distance was necessarily reinforced by the very character of daily life itself. In *The Philosophy of Money,* Simmel wrote,

> For the jostling crowdedness and the motley disorder of metropolitan communication would simply be unbearable without such psychological distance. Since contemporary urban culture, with its commercial, professional and social intercourse, forces us to be physically close to an enormous number of people, sensitive and nervous modern people would sink completely into despair if the objectification of social relationships did not bring with it an inner boundary and reserve. The peculiar character of relationships, either openly or concealed in a thousand forms, places an invisible functional distance between people that is an interior protection and neutralization against the overcrowded proximity and friction of our cultural life.[12]

In his series of excursuses to his essay on social space, Simmel treated a number of characteristic types—the poor, the adventurer, the stranger—as indicative of the power of space to determine role. The last of these, the stranger, was most exemplary. If, Simmel stated, wandering was equivalent to the *liberation* from every given point in space and was the conceptual opposite to *fixation* at such a point, then the sociological form of the stranger combined these two characteristics in one. That is, the stranger was not the "wanderer who comes today and goes tomorrow but the person who comes today and stays tomorrow." Fixed within a particular spatial group, the stranger was one who has not belonged from the beginning. "In the stranger," Simmel concluded, "are organized the unity of nearness and remoteness of every human relation," in such a way that in relationship to the stranger "distance means that he who is close by is far, and strangeness means that he who also is far is actually near."[13] Here Simmel anticipated Freud's reflections on that form of estrangement

known as the uncanny, where relations of the familiar and the unfamiliar—*das Heimliche* and *das Unheimliche*—become ambiguous and merge with one another. Simmel, himself the epitome of the stranger, cultivated, urban, Jewish, and excluded from the normal academic career of his contemporaries Weber and Dilthey, thus defined the role of a being at once strange and estranged in the money economy of capitalism.

Hotelhalle: Siegfried Kracauer

Of all Simmel's students and followers, it was Siegfried Kracauer who, trained as an architect, most profoundly absorbed these lessons of spatial sociology, and especially of the analysis of spatial formations applied to the understanding of estrangement.[14] From his student experience in Berlin in 1907, when he had taken detailed notes at Simmel's lecture on "The Problem of Style in Art," to the completion of his still unpublished monograph on Simmel in 1917, Kracauer found in Simmel a methodological guide to the present. And while his early architectural designs between 1916 and 1918 were by no means infused with a direct sociological "distance," when redescribed in his later autobiographical novel *Ginster,* they took on the character of moments in a slow development toward what Ernst Bloch would recognize as the personality of "the detached hero concerned about nothing and entirely without pathos."[15]

Thus, his project for the Military Memorial Cemetery, designed in Frankfurt in 1916, was, in Kracauer's recollection, a moment of transition between a reliance on traditional models—the cemetery of Genoa and the cathedral of Milan—with their implications of mystery and the labyrinthine picturesque, toward an ironic and distanced vision of the character appropriate to modernity, and a modernity deeply implicated in the forms of war: "To hide the tombs like Easter eggs, this project seemed too soft for these times of general war. Such times called for a cemetery where their horror would be reflected. In place of using the sketches he had developed until then, Ginster . . . elaborated a system of a cemetery that was similar to a project of military organization." Thence the "scientifically lined up," rectilinear tombs set at right angles along allées lined by geometrically cut foliage, surrounding a funerary monument that took the form of an elevated cube with a stepped-back quasi-pyramidal top that served to

display the names of the dead: "During these years of war, the key word for the ruling classes," Kracauer observed, "was simplicity."[16]

Even the "prettiness" of his design for a *Siedlung* at Osnabrück, drawn up in November 1918, with its "little detached houses and gardens with pitched roofs," seemed to "Ginster-Kracauer" to be premature at the very least: in the present conditions of war, "they would," he observed, "inevitably be destroyed," and if not, these pretty houses would become the objects of destruction in a new war, attaching the workers to their defense. "Certainly," concluded Kracauer, "one could not house workers in holes, but it would be perhaps more suitable to place tombstones in the gardens."[17] Similar transformations from symbolism to rationalism were to be traced in the projects of the Swiss architect Hannes Meyer for *Siedlungen* and cemeteries between 1919 and 1923: the Freidorf housing estate near Basel, 1919–1921, with its "Palladian," almost neoclassical layout, but with pitched roofs, and the project for the central cemetery in Basel, 1923, which seems to echo the contemporary interest in the revolutionary architecture of the late eighteenth century, seem to mirror the projects of Kracauer, even though Meyer's later move toward the new objectivity would doubtless have been condemned by Kracauer.

Kracauer's account of his self-distancing from architectural practice seems to have been accompanied by a growing awareness of the distancing powers of architectural space itself, or, rather, the potential of space to act as a powerful emblem of social estrangement. Kracauer characterized his 1917 essay on Simmel as an "existential topography," comparing it to those developed by Simmel himself. In his subsequent writings, the concept of an inhabited topography was extended literally with the aid of Simmel's sociology to the spaces of modern life: the hotel lobby, which became the focus of an unpublished essay on the detective novel in 1922–1925; the "pleasure barracks" of the cafés and music halls, together with their despondent counterparts, the unemployment exchanges, described in his study of white collar workers in 1930; the boulevards or "homes for the homeless" that form the setting of his life of Offenbach published in 1936.

Of these, the hotel lobby (*Hotelhalle*), seen by Kracauer as the paradigmatic space of the modern detective novel, and thus as epitomizing the conditions of modern life in their anonymity and fragmentation, was perhaps the most Simmelian in its formulation.[18] Kracauer compared the modern hotel

lobby to the traditional church; the one a shelter for the transient and disconnected, the other for the community of the faithful. Using Simmel's categories of spatial description, Kracauer elaborated the distinction between what he termed *erfüllter Raum,* or the "inhabited space" of *Verknüpfung,* or "communion," and the void or empty space of physics and the abstract sciences—what he characterized as the *ratio* of modern life. Shut out of the religiously bonded community, the modern urban dweller could rely only on spaces, like that of the hotel lobby, "that bear witness to his nonexistence." Detached from everyday life, individual atoms with no connection save their absolute anonymity, the hotel guests were scattered like atoms in a void, confronted with "nothing" (*vis-à-vis de rien*); stranded in their armchairs, the guests could do little more than find a "disinterested pleasure in contemplating the world."[19] In this way, "the civilization that tends toward rationalization loses itself in the elegant club chair," in the ultimate space of indifference. Even the conventional silence of the setting parodied that of the church. Kracauer quoted Thomas Mann in *Death in Venice:* "In this room there reigned a religious silence which is one of the distinctive marks of grand hotels. The waiters serve with muffled steps. One hardly hears the noise of a cup or tea-pot, or a whispered word."[20] In Kracauer's vision of spatial alienation,

> Rudiments of individuals slide in the nirvana of relaxation, faces are lost behind the newspaper, and the uninterrupted artificial light illumines only manikins. It is a coming and going of unknowns who are changed into empty forms by forgetting their passwords, and who parade, imperceptible, like Chinese shadows. If they had an interiority, it would have no windows.[21]

The mystery of the lobby, proper site of the detective novel, was no longer religious but base, a mystery among the masks; Kracauer cited the detective novel by Sven Elvestad, *Death Enters the Hotel:* "One sees thus once again that a grand hotel is a world apart, and this world resembles the rest of the big world. The clients wander here in their light and carefree summer life, without suspecting what strange mysteries evolve among them."[22] Here, the "pseudo-individuals," or guests, spread themselves like molecules in "a spatial desert without limits," never destined to come together, even when compressed within the *Grossstadt.*

Their only link, Kracauer concluded, was indifferent enough: what he called, suggestively, the strategic grand routes of convention.[23]

Vagabondage

> Would it be the case that vagabondage leads to hysterical neurasthenia, or rather the reverse, that neurasthenia leads to vagabondage?
>
> Jean-Martin Charcot, *Leçons du mardi*

It was the analysis of these "strategic routes" that formed the basis of Walter Benjamin's study of the big city, research that under the title of *Passagen-Werk*—work on the "passages" or covered shopping arcades of Paris—took up the last ten years of his life. Evoking the urban flâneur, Benjamin extolled the art of "slow walking" as the instrument of modern urban mapping. Franz Hessel, whose *Promenades in Berlin* he reviewed with special interest, seemed, for Benjamin, to take this art to its highest form. At once recording the streets and spaces of modern Berlin, with an irony that exposed the shallow propositions of architect-planners, and searching to record the rapidly vanishing old city with minute observations, Hessel bore witness to a moment of transition that would, for Benjamin, never be repeated: "The flâneur is the priest of the *genius loci.* This discreet passerby with his priesthood and his detective's flair, there surrounds his erudition something like that around Chesterton's Father Brown, that master of criminalistics."[24] But the dandified figure of the stroller was complemented in Benjamin by another, more subversive image: that of the vagabond who alone, criminal and exiled, possessed the marginal vision that transgressed boundaries and turned them into thresholds, a way of looking that engendered what Benjamin called the "peddling [*colportage*] of space."[25] Writing of the Place du Maroc in Belleville, Benjamin noted this strange power of names, spaces, and allegorical signification to construct, as if under the influence of hashish, a complex and shifting image beyond that of their material existence. Entering the deserted square on a Sunday afternoon, Benjamin found himself not only in the Moroccan desert but also in a colonial monument: "the topographic vision intersected in it with an allegorical signification, and it did not for all that lose its place at the heart of Belleville. But it is ordinarily reserved for drugs to be able to arouse such a vision. In fact, the names

of streets, in these cases, are inebriating substances that render our perception richer in strata and in spheres. One could call the force with which they plunge us into this state an 'evocative virtue.'"[26] Referring to the many cases of "ambulatory automatism" examined by Charcot and his followers, Benjamin compared this perception to that of the vagabond amnesiac: "It is not the association of images that is here decisive, but their interpenetration. This fact should also be remembered in order to understand certain pathological phenomena: the sick man who wanders the city during the hours of night and forgets the way back has perhaps felt the ascendency of this power."[27]

In using the metaphor of the amnesiac, Benjamin was evoking a tradition of medical cases in which from the 1880s doctors had attempted to link the incidence of certain neurasthenias to social class and even race. For if agoraphobia and claustrophobia were, at least in the majority of cases studied, spatial afflictions of the middle class, another variety of urban disorder, named by Charcot "ambulatory automatism," seemed more prevalent among the working class and especially the out-of-work. For Charcot and his followers ambulatory diseases were inevitably associated with the criminal activity of vagabondage, seemingly differentiated only in terms of degree. They were most evident, Charcot wrote, among those "without avowed profession, without fixed domicile, in a word vagabonds, those who often sleep under bridges, in quarries or lime kilns and who are exposed at any instant to the blows of the police."[28]

Charcot presented two kinds of cases to the audience of his Tuesday lessons. The first were those of vagabonds properly speaking, the second those of workers who were evidently suffering attacks of hysterical of epileptic amnesia. In the first category, the case of a Hungarian Jew who suffered from a "manie des voyages" was of especial interest, as perhaps indicating to Charcot the hereditary nature of what he called this "Israelite" disease: "He is Israelite, you see it well, and the sole fact of his bizarre peregrinations presents itself to us as mentally submitted to the regime of instincts."[29] In the second classification, Charcot concentrated on the case of a young delivery man whose periodic loss of memory led to his wandering through and outside Paris for days on end.

> Here is a man walking the streets of Paris for 14 hours. It goes without saying that he must have looked appropriate; if not, he would have been

> stopped by the police. He must have had his eyes open, or else he would have brought attention to himself. . . . So he must have acted as you or I would on the street, but he was unconscious.[30]

In the light of the repeated nature of these excursions, Charcot diagnosed ambulatory automatism caused by epilepsy. In a nice literary touch, the doctor noted that he was fascinated by the apparent coincidence between his patient's amnesia or somnambulism and that depicted by Shakespeare in *Macbeth:* "If I wanted to define this patient's mental state, I would, like both the poet and physician, say that here is a patient who appears asleep but who behaves like you and me, and we, of course, are awake."[31]

In transposing what for Charcot was an attempt to demonstrate the heredity or racial aspects of vagabondage (the case of his "wandering Jew" was celebrated) into a metaphor for pathological vision, Benjamin was privileging a particular point of view: not that of the doctor-observer, but that of the patient. Such a pathological reading of the city now took on a critical aspect, to be emulated by the writer/flâneur as he sought to recapture the primal resonances of natural paths in the urban labyrinth. Only a dreamlike state of suspension might enable the wanderer to cross between physical surroundings and their mental contents.

Viewed through these lenses, the urban street regained something of the original terror of the nomadic route. Where, Benjamin noted, the original track or road had always carried with it associations of the "terrors of wandering," embedded in the mythical consciousness of the tribes, the street engendered a new form of terror, that of the boredom inspired by its "monotonous ribbon of asphalt." Drawing these two terrors together, and still to be found buried in the subterranean ways of the modern city, was the figure of the labyrinth, site of endless wandering—the Métro.[32]

This underground, which was for Benjamin in some way an equivalent to the unconscious of the city, was to be explored with all the techniques of the geographer. Reading the city "topographically," Benjamin tried to recapture its strange, landscape character. He cited Hofmannsthal's vision of Paris as a "landscape composed of pure life," and added that if this was so, it would be a veritable "volcanic landscape": "Paris is, in the social order, the pendant to Vesuvius in the geographical order." In his imagination, Paris was transformed

into the semblance of an antique excavation, with its ruins, its sacred places, and even its entrances to the underworld. In this sense, it was also like a dream; hence his fascination with those "passages, architectures where we live once again oneirically the life of our parents and our grandparents, as the embryo in the womb of its mother repeats phylogenesis. Existence flows in these places without particular accentuation, as in the episodes of dreams. Flânerie gives its rhythm to this somnolence."[33] Like the troglodyte inhabitants of Gabriel Tarde's vision of a future underground society, Benjamin's flâneurs were tracing the final paths through the traditional city. The development of the boulevards represented only the first stage in the process of the eventual dissolution of the urban fabric.

Implicitly, through the accumulated citations of the *Passagen-Werk,* Benjamin traces a history of modern vision in which the rise of deeper and more public perspectives in the public realm was accomplished at the expense of individual interiority. In the Biedermeier interiors of the 1830s, with their windows shaded by layers of drapery out of urban sight, the point of view was entirely from the inside: "It is thus something like a perspective which opens from the interior toward the window." In the panoramas and arcades, perspective is partially exteriorized but still shut in, a "suffocating perspective." In the broad open vistas of Haussmann, the development was sustained with all the inexorable logic of modern spatialization: from claustrophobia to agoraphobia. It remained only for the project of modernist transparency to complete the process. Describing the peregrinations of Hessel, the modern wanderer, Benjamin saw him as the witness to the very "last monuments of an ancient art of dwelling":

> The last: because in the imprint of the turning point of the epoch, it is written that the knell has sounded for the dwelling in its old sense, dwelling in which security prevailed. Giedion, Mendelsohn, Le Corbusier have transformed the place of abode of men into the transitory space of all the imaginable forces and waves of air and light. What is being prepared is found under the sign of transparency.[34]

The ideology of transparency, the battle cry of modernism, was, as Benjamin recognized, the agent of a spatial dissolution to which only the flâneur was

privy: "the sensation of the entirely new, of the absolutely modern, is a form of becoming as oneiric as the eternal return itself. The perception of space that corresponds to this conception of time is the transparency of the world of the flâneur."[35]

What for Le Corbusier represented a liberation from the closed and infected Balzacian quarters of the nineteenth-century city was, in the historically nuanced terms of Benjamin, the substitution of the void for the home. Without comment Benjamin copied a passage from Sigfried Giedion's *Bauen in Frankreich* of 1928: "The houses of Le Corbusier define themselves neither by space nor by forms: the air passes right through them! The air becomes a constitutive factor! For this, one should count neither on space nor forms, but uniquely on relation and interpenetration! There is only a single, indivisible space. The separations between interior and exterior fall."[36] These "new spatial conditions of modernity," as Benjamin elsewhere observes, were as present in the city as in the house: "The 'ville contemporaine' of Le Corbusier is an old village on a major road. Except for the fact that it is now taken over by cars and airplanes that land in the middle of this village, nothing has changed."[37] The ironic assertion of timeless space here gave force to Benjamin's belief that, finally, space had been destroyed by time. That this process had begun in the late eighteenth century only made the nineteenth the more hallucinatory in retrospect, suspended as it were between a past of walls and doors and a future of voids.

Benjamin wrote his review of Hessel's book in 1929. Some ten years later, the art of flânerie had been banished from Berlin and Paris, Benjamin himself had been forced into exile, thence to suicide, and Kracauer was in New York, writing his analysis of the filmic history that, in technique and substance, had in his eyes given rise to the birth of the Nazi propaganda film. One of these films, depicting the visit of Hitler and his architect Speer to the conquered city of Paris, seemed uncannily to fulfill Sitte's original prophecy that agoraphobia would become the modern disease par excellence. Describing the vision of a vast, empty Paris, the image of the "void" behind the propaganda, Kracauer wrote:

> The Führer is visiting the conquered European capital—but is he really its guest? Paris is as quiet as a grave. . . . While he inspects Paris, Paris it-

self shuts its eyes and withdraws. The touching sight of this deserted ghost city that once pulsed with feverish life mirrors the vacuum at the core of the Nazi system. Nazi propaganda built up a pseudo-reality iridescent with many colors, but at the same time it emptied Paris, the sanctuary of civilization. These colors scarcely veiled its own emptiness.[38]

What Benjamin and Hessel, Kracauer and Simmel were able to comprehend with their meticulous readings of the modern city, that "mnemotechnical auxiliary of the solitary walker," was that in the face of modern planning and its supporting politics, what the nineteenth-century was pleased to call "city" was rapidly in the process of disappearing. Nothing we have seen during a century of urban redevelopment seems to contradict these observations from the first quarter of our era, which lead us to the conclusion that a certain strain of modernist architecture, at least, was intent on transforming the world into Kracauer's nightmare of rationalism triumphant, a gigantic hotel atrium.

Dead End Street

Walter Benjamin and the Space of Distraction

> Vision seems to adapt itself to its object like the images that one has of a town when one contemplates it from the height of a tower; hearing is analogous to a view taken from outside and on the same level as the town; touch, finally, relates to (the understanding) of whoever comes in contact with a town from close up by wandering through its streets.
>
> G. W. Leibniz[1]

We seldom look at our surroundings. Streets and buildings, even those considered major monuments, are in everyday life little more than backgrounds for introverted thought, passages through which our bodies pass "on the way to work." In this sense cities are "invisible" to us, felt rather than seen, moved through rather than visually taken in. A city might be hidden by landscape, distance, darkness, or atmosphere, or then again there may be some hidden influence at work in the observing subject to render it unseen or unseeable. This influence, which we might call, following Walter Benjamin, an optical unconscious, has been much discussed in recent theory, a discussion generally revolving around the nature of modern opticality, its technical, institutional, and psychological construction in the context of mass, metropolitan, postindustrial society and subjecthood. In this chapter I want briefly to look at one particular aspect of this debate, one that returns to Benjamin's own formulation of why cities are not seen, his celebrated remark, in the essay "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," that "architecture has always represented the prototype of a work of art the reception of which is consummated by a collectivity in a state of distraction,"[2] a comment that has been much taken up by critics interrogating the idea of "distraction," but little studied in terms of its spatial implications.[3]

Here, rather than survey its place in the study of technology and visual technique, I want to look more closely at the "space" implied by, and projected from, such a formulation: the space of distraction, so to speak. I will try to show that what Benjamin meant by this tantalizing aphorism is set in a more complex argument about the character of modern space and modern subjects, one that stems from his study of the German baroque mourning play, or *Trauerspiel,* and that in turn situates distraction and its spatial character firmly in the domain of the "modern baroque" as delineated by art and architectural historians from Wölfflin and Riegl to Giedion. I will argue that the tropes of interpretation initially developed to understand the exaggerated and indeterminate spatial forms of the baroque—a space that was seen to represent if not hasten the collapse of Renaissance humanism—were a consistent influence on Benjamin's interpretation of the city, and ones that allowed him to frame the question in terms that went beyond the "visuality" of Riegl to imply the complete collapse of perspectival space in modernity.

Blind Alleys

Benjamin's remark about distraction, usually joined to a discussion of his concept of the "loss of aura," is generally understood to refer to the distracted state of mind of the urban dweller, jaded, bored, or swamped by the flood of visual and social stimuli of the modern city, along the lines of Georg Simmel's reworking of nineteenth-century neurasthenic pathology applied to metropolis. Benjamin himself employs the concept more precisely, however, linking it to the opposition he is drawing between a traditional spectator of a work of art in a state of concentration, and a mass audience lacking concentration and thus "absorbing" the work of art. In the case of buildings, only a tourist will evince that "attentive concentration" characteristic of the art lover. In this Benjamin would seem to be echoing his friend Siegfried Kracauer, whose influential essay of 1926 on Berlin's "picture palaces" was titled "Cult of Distraction." But here, in the apparent genealogy of distraction Simmel-Kracauer-Benjamin, we have to pause in the face of what seem to be serious differences in the use of this word. The German *Zerstreuung* might mean, at one and the same time, distraction, diversion, amusement, diffusion, preoccupation, absentmindedness,

scattering, dispersion, and so on. To take just one example of such differentiation: Kracauer clearly uses the word to delineate the "need for entertainment," the "addiction to distraction" of the Berlin masses, seeking relief from the conditions of their workday lives; he is concerned to describe the movie houses of Berlin as palaces of distraction, optical fairylands, "shrines to the cultivation of pleasure." "The Gloria Palast," he remarks, with implications Benjamin would have appreciated, "presents itself as a baroque theater."[4] Benjamin, however, while his reference to the movies, stars in the context of his statement "the masses seek distraction [*die Massen Zerstreuung suchen*]" implies a general adherence to Kracauer's arguments, immediately moves beyond Kracauer's interest in "surface" to investigate the phenomenological conditions comprised by "distraction," within which buildings and the city are experienced.[5] Building on Riegl's historical analysis of visual cultures as developing from the tactile to the optical, Benjamin emphasizes the twofold nature of architectural appropriation in the city: "by use and by perception—or rather by touch and sight [*taktil und optisch*]." Tactile as opposed to optical perception is, Benjamin claims, following Simmel, accomplished by habit, custom, or usage (*Gewohnheit*). But for Benjamin this is not, as Simmel implied, a kind of appropriation lost to modern cities, rendered subservient to the visual; rather habit and use determine the optical reception of buildings: "As regards architecture, habit determines to a large extent even optical reception." Through habit and use, the rapt attention of an individual observer of a work of art is dispersed, so to speak, in the custom of "noticing the object in an incidental [*beiläufig,* casual] fashion." Distraction here, rather than an active search for over-the-top pleasures, represents an absentmindedness common to a subject in a state of habitual activity: in front of the film, even, "the public is an examiner but an absent-minded one [*ein zerstreuter*]."

That his discussion of the tensions between the tactile and the optical does not necessarily imply a negative judgment of the former is made clear in earlier writings that imply a more positive role for "distraction" in the face of architecture and the city, one that will activate a deeper understanding of urban topography than simple visual inspection. Thus, writing to Gershom Scholem from Assisi in November 1924, Benjamin describes a visit, which took place appropriately enough in a "dense autumn fog," in which he says he

> looked at too many paintings yet did not have enough time to be able to concentrate on architecture. For my inductive way of getting to know the topography of different places and seeking out every great structure in its own labyrinthine environment of banal, beautiful, or wretched houses, takes up too much time and thus prevents me from studying the relevant books. Since I must dispense with that, I am left only with impressions of the architecture. The first and most important thing you have to do, is to feel your way through a city.[6]

Here tactile knowledge of the urban labyrinth is seen as an important precondition to true urban knowledge, a view to be repeated in different ways throughout his exploration of the Parisian underground during his years working on the arcades project. A first metaphor for describing the space of distraction might then be the labyrinth, a Nietzschean metaphor for modernity that would certainly embrace the "art of losing one's way" beloved of Benjamin's city walks. The invisible city would here be the underground, the realm of the dead, the dreamscape across the threshold, all domains treasured by Benjamin in his Berlin and Parisian explorations.

But what of visual as opposed to tactile space? In what respects might we begin to qualify the notion of the visual apperception and appropriation of the city in the context of our expanding understanding of distraction? If we are to believe Hubert Damisch, the question of the visibility of the city (its "readability" if not its "figurability") was posed initially in the context of the modern metropolis, its confused "image" and the breakup of communal bonds with the rise of the masses.[7] Damisch posits that the models of such visibility were engendered, framed so to speak, by the conventional perspective device of the "view through a window," a view that had the theoretical nicety of combining Alberti's transparent surface and the outside (urban) context. Damisch contrasts two scenes through a window: the one sketched by Descartes, as he interrogated the conditions for visual judgment,[8] and the other described by Edgar Allan Poe in "The Man of the Crowd" in which the narrator, sitting in the corner of a London café, deciphered the "labyrinth" of the crowd. This last scene, of course, is a direct reference to Benjamin's own citation of Poe's corner in his Baudelaire study. The implications of Damisch's contrast are clear: Descartes's rational city provided a space for

judgment, Poe's labyrinthine metropolis presented nothing but apparent confusion.

Benjamin himself implies something of the same contrast. In his essay on the collector Eduard Fuchs, he alludes to the nature of Renaissance space as constructed through perspective: "The painters of the early Renaissance," he says in a footnote, "were the first to depict interior space in which the figures represented have *room to move* [Innenräume ins Bild gesetzt, in denen dargestellten Figuren *Spielraum* haben]." Here *Spielraum* has all the connotations of its literal meaning—"space for drama" or "play space," with the additional senses of "room to play," "play room," "figures in play," "elbow room."[9] Such a space, emblem of a historico-visual relationship between perspective painting and the new architecture of the Renaissance, was for Benjamin, as for Wölfflin (who is the principal source for this reference), the very space of existence "architecturally framed and founded."

Elsewhere Benjamin will qualify this space as characterized principally by its depth, where "perspectives" also meant infinite prospects, virtual rooms to move. Writing, again to Scholem, of the title of his newly completed book *One-Way Street,* he notes, "It has turned out to be a remarkable arrangement or construction of some of my 'aphorisms,' a street that is meant to reveal a prospect of such precipitous depth—the word is not meant to be understood metaphorically!—like, perhaps, Palladio's famous stage design in Vicenza, *The Street.*"[10]

But if the book itself was conceived as an essay in the clarity of Renaissance perspective, a study in depth, or at least staged depth, the themes of *One-Way Street*'s aphorisms resonate with post-Renaissance anxiety. For it is precisely this depth which has, in Benjamin's view, been put into question by habit. Under the heading "Articles Lost" in the section "Lost Property Office," he reflects on the difference between "the first glimpse of a village, a town, in the landscape" and the subsequent effacement of this first picture by routine and habit. For Benjamin, as for Riegl, the crucial visual connection is that "between foreground and distance," that shifting relationship between foreground and background (figure and ground) which makes the bas-reliefs and monuments of the late Roman period so ambiguous to interpret. In the case of a landscape, the first shock of the new is erased by habit, which collapses the distance between foreground and background—or, in scenographic terms, front

stage and backstage—so that in some way the prospect vanishes. Benjamin's analogy is telling: "As soon as we begin to find our bearings, the landscape vanishes at a stroke like the facade of a house as we enter it. It has not yet gained preponderance through a constant exploration that has become habit. Once we begin to find our way about, that earliest picture can never be restored." The only resistance to such a disappearing trick would be, as Benjamin notes, that special kind of "blue distance" that "never gives way to foreground or dissolves at our approach," but rather, like a painted backdrop in the theater, simply "looms more compact and threatening" the closer it gets: "It is what gives stage sets their incomparable atmosphere."[11]

The collapse of perspective distance is perhaps the most dominant visual theme of *One-Way Street.* Even as Aby Warburg had viewed with phobic horror the implosion that had destroyed the space of judgment or reflection, the reduction of the *Denkraum* under the assault of rapid communications and technological invention, so Benjamin sees the erosion of the space for criticism: indeed, its space, he advertises, "is for rent":

> Criticism . . . was at home in a world where perspectives and prospects counted and where it was still possible to take a standpoint (point of view). Now things press too closely on human society. The advertisement . . . abolishes the space where contemplation moved and all but hits us between the eyes with things as a car, growing to gigantic proportions, careens at us out of a film screen. And just as the film does not present furniture and facades in completed forms for critical inspection, their insistent, jerky nearness alone being sensational, the genuine advertisement hurtles things at us with the tempo of a good film.[12]

Similarly, the intrusion of large-scale urban construction projects into the heart of the traditional city has removed the distance that once separated the center and the periphery, a distance confirmed by the sight of the horizon—the view of nature beyond the walls—from inside the city to outside, and that was reassuring to the dweller enclosed "in the peace of the fortress" as the elemental forces of nature were held back from contact but revealed to view. Now, a modern process of "mingling and contamination" has produced ambiguities where clarity once reigned:

7. Sasha Stone, "One-Way Street," photomontage for the cover of Walter Benjamin, *Einbahnstrasse* (Berlin, 1928).

> Great cities . . . are seen to be breached at all points by the invading countryside. Not by the landscape, but by what in untrammeled nature is the most bitter: ploughed land, highways, night sky that the veil of vibrant redness no longer conceals. The insecurity of even the busy areas puts the city-dweller in the opaque and truly dreadful situation in which he must assimilate, along with isolated monstrosities from the open country, the abortions of urban architectonics.[13]

Between the clarity of the Renaissance *Spielraum,* that space of free play for both bodies and thoughts, and the ambiguity and mingling of modern urban space, between deep perspectives and prospects and the opaque, flat, impacted surfaces where the subject is rendered blind, so to speak, dependent on habit and custom to feel its way around and through "dark space," there has occurred a fundamental transformation, and one precisely of the same order that Benjamin was indeed describing in his characterization of the Renaissance invention of *Spielraum:* a historical change, calculated according to Riegl's theory of the *Kunstwollen,* in the process of vision itself.

Most commentators, reading Benjamin's Baudelaire essays or taking their cue from the message of the late "Work of Art" essay, have assumed that Benjamin construed this change as both cause and effect of the growth of industrial metropolis. And certainly all the characteristics of modernity are to be found exacerbated in the sites of the *Passagen-Werk.* But in a recent rereading, Samuel Weber has discovered intriguing intimations of modern visuality and the notion of the distracted subject in Benjamin's earlier work on baroque tragedy. Developing the statement by Benjamin that *The Confused Court* (the title of a Spanish *Trauerspiel*) could be taken as a model for allegory, as "subject to the law of 'dispersal' and 'collectedness'" (translated by Weber "dispersion" [*Zerstreuung*] and "collection" [*Sammlung*]), Weber extends Benjamin's statement that "things are brought together according to their meaning; indifference to their being-there [*Dasein*] disperses them once again." Weber posits that

> the tendency toward dispersion that Benjamin discerns in the collective structures specific to the 19th century metropolis no longer appears to originate with the emergence of urban masses but to go back at least as far as the 17th century in Germany. Second, the dispersed, centrifugal

> structure of mass phenomena shows itself to be bound up with articulatory processes at work long before Baudelaire began to "fence" with "the ghostly crowd of words."[14]

Weber further develops the notion of "distraction," or "dispersion" (picking up on Benjamin's tell-tale use of the word *Dasein*), in terms of a comparative axis that might see a more Heideggerian connotation in the word *Zerstreuung* than hitherto allowed by a strict late Marxist reading of Benjamin. Weber points to Derrida's examination of the notion of dispersion in Heidegger, and to its intimate, almost bodily, connection to the spatiality of *Dasein.* Here we might simply note in passing that a cursory examination of Heidegger's own deployment of the term in *Being and Time* points to two major and related meanings: the one linked to the "existential spatiality" of Dasein, and its characteristic form of Being-in-the-World as *zerstreut,* dispersed; the other employing "distraction" as an attribute of curiosity and its propensity to "not tarrying": "curiosity is everywhere and nowhere" and therefore "never dwells anywhere." Both these senses of dispersion and distraction would here intersect more or less seamlessly with the Benjaminian usages of *Zerstreuung* already discussed; or if not intersect, for Benjamin was resistant to any comparison between his thought and that of Heidegger, then certainly alert us to the constantly shifting meaning of "distraction" in 1920s discourse.

If, however, picking up on Weber's implication, we take up the *spatial* dimension of the dispersion/distraction nexus in the context of Benjamin's baroque study, we find that "distraction" takes on a more precise formulation, and this precisely in relation to Benjamin's reworking of the idea of "baroque space" as he had inherited it from Wölfflin and Riegl.

The Baroque Effect

> The momentary impact of baroque is powerful, but soon leaves us with a certain sense of desolation. It does not convey a state of present happiness, but a feeling of anticipation, of something yet to come, of dissatisfaction and restlessness rather than fulfillment. We have no sense of release, but rather of having been drawn into the tension of an emotional condition.
>
> Heinrich Wölfflin, *Renaissance und Barock,* 1888[15]

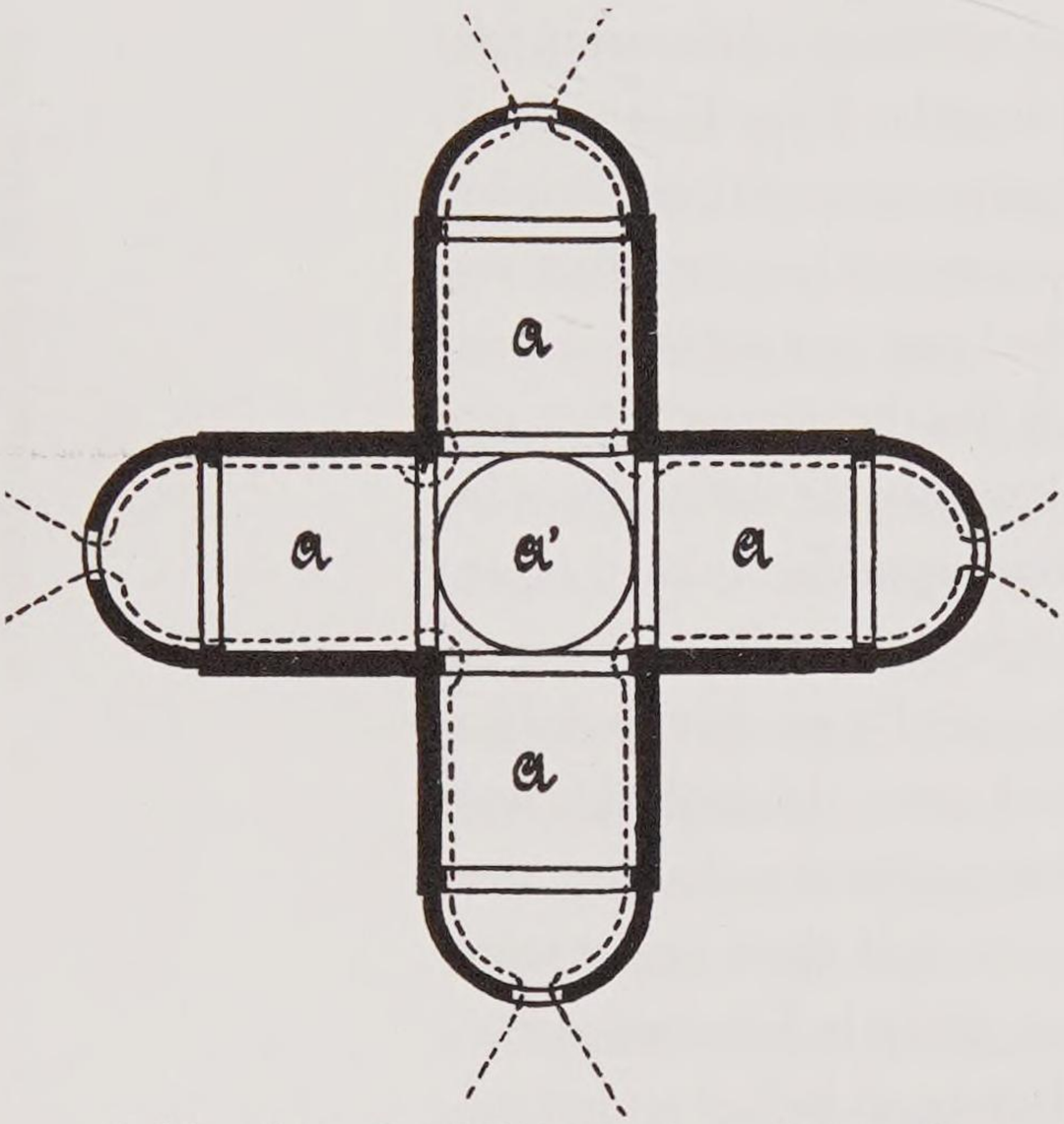
It was symptomatic of the ambiguous nature of "space" as a psychological and material concept that the initial art historical interpretation of architectural space was first worked out precisely in response to an uncertainty about the limits of architecture: that uncertainty which arose in the face of the difficulty of comprehending the nature of architectural "space" after the Renaissance—the so-called baroque space that seemed altogether to break the bounds of architectural stability and three-dimensional harmony. For Wölfflin, student of the "psychology of architecture," this was a pathological condition, reflected in the mental state of its artists: "all the most prominent baroque artists suffered from headaches," he noted, citing Milizia on Bernini and Borromini, and "there were also cases of melancholia."[16]

Thus, for Wölfflin, the baroque (which he dated from the Council of Trent) pushed the limits of (classical, Renaissance) architecture to their potential destruction. An architecture of depth and obscurity had, in his view, replaced an architecture of surface and clarity. The baroque, according to Wölfflin, introduced "an entirely new feeling of space, tending toward infinity." "Space," he wrote, "which in the Renaissance was regularly lit and which can be represented only as tectonically closed, here [in the baroque] seems to be lost in the unlimited and undefined." No longer faced with a clear, external form, "the gaze is led toward infinity."[17] Such a dissolution of space into incommensurability was explained from a psychological point of view that understood every object to be judged according to its relation to the body. Wölfflin had already espoused such a view in his thesis, *Prolegomena zu einer Psychologie der Architectur,* two years before. Noting that "a historical psychology—or rather, a psychological history of art—should be able to measure with great accuracy the acceleration of linear movement," Wölfflin spoke of what he called "the breathless haste of Arab decorative lines" and compared different arch styles to the impressions they give of slow or quick breathing. In the margins of his personal copy of the *Psychologie,* he wrote: "Baroque: irregular breathing."[18] In the baroque, that is, the capacity of the human body to empathize with the building was stretched to deformity. Such a psychological interpretation was to influence that of Jacques Lacan, whose summation of the "baroque"—"the regulation of the soul by the scopic regulation of the body"—seems to extend Wölfflin's critique.[19]

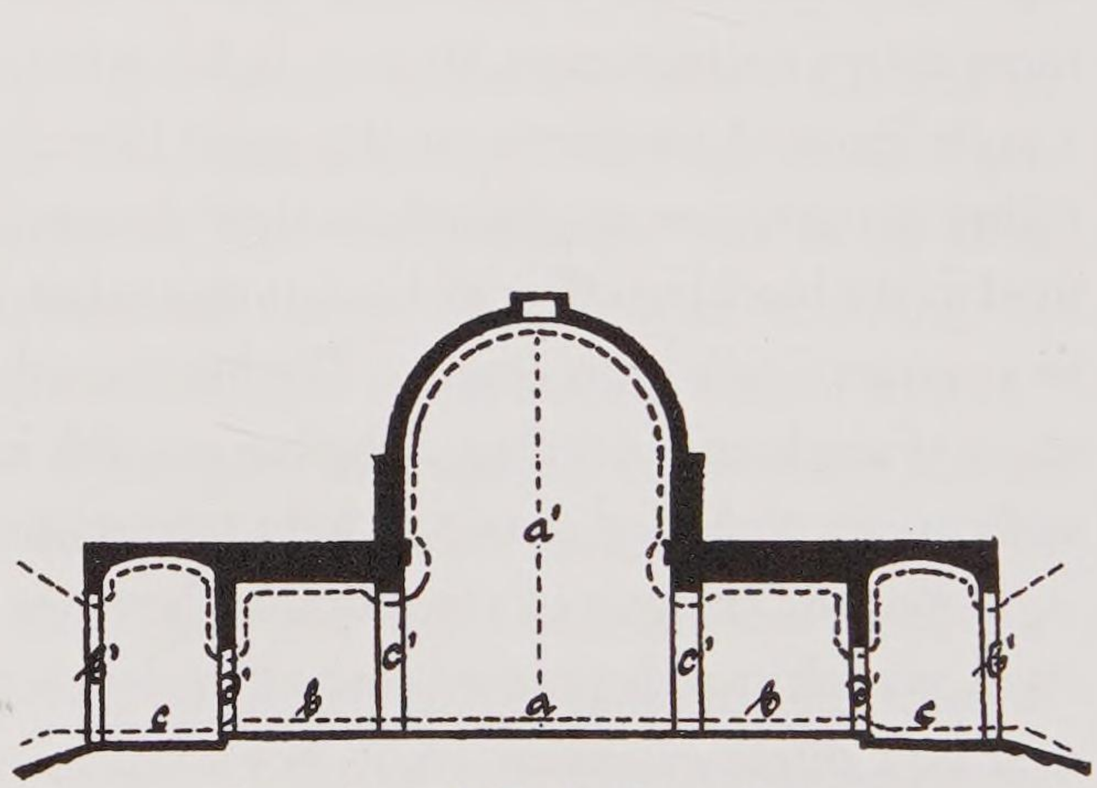
If the baroque represented a breakdown of form, it was easy to associate its characteristics with the new nervous illnesses; the baroque in architecture

and painting was after all filled with rifts, breaks, and openings representing the relations between the material and metaphysical worlds. Thus Daniel Paul Schreber, writing his memoirs in the asylum of Sonnenstein, insisted that he might prove the "extraordinary experiences and observations he controlled" by reference to a baroque painting by Pradilla that he had seen in a publication on modern art. "This picture," he wrote, "is surprisingly like the picture I often see in my head: the rays (nerves) of the upper God, when they are thrust down in consequence of my nerves' power of attraction, often appear in my head *in the image of a human shape.*" Schreber, ignoring the central ascending figures of this painting of "Liebersreigen," indicated a faint image of a woman, in the far top left, in his terms "descending" with outstretched arms, although this was more than a projection on his part. In his mind, the woman was changed into a male figure of the nerves of the upper God, "almost as if these nerves were trying to overcome an obstacle to their descent," an obstacle Schreber attributed to the blocking effect of his former analyst, Flechsig, as he had attempted to counter God's omnipotence. Within the ethereal and potentially infinite space of the baroque ceiling, Schreber was able to figure his struggle for power and contact with God as rays of light representing nerves.[20]

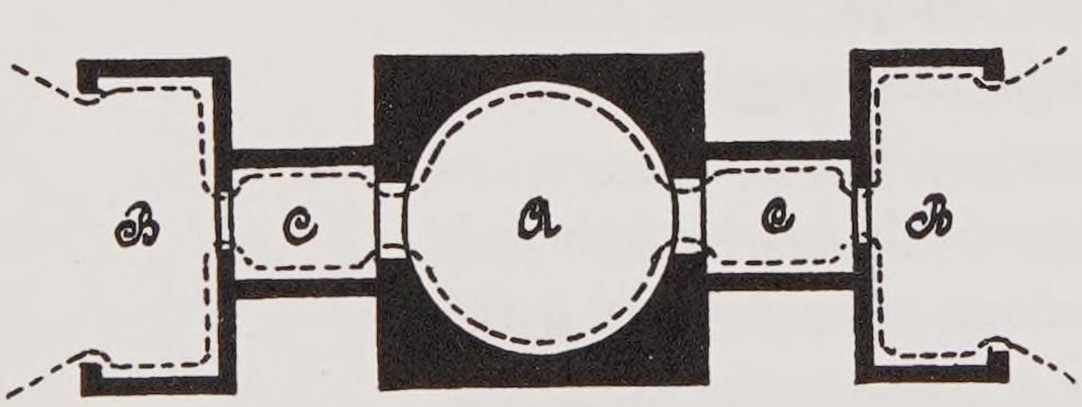
But the critique of the baroque, however historically and formally derived, was ultimately pointed toward the larger problem of modern art, itself seen as a direct extension of, if not a pathological development from, the baroque. Wölfflin's celebrated remark of 1888, "One can hardly fail to recognize the affinity that our own age in particular bears to the Italian Baroque,"[21] underlines the extent to which these ascriptions of decline and dissolution were deliberately aimed at the modern. Wölfflin cited Carl Justi's characterization of Piranesi as having "a nature entirely modern in its passion," embodied in "the mystery of the sublime—of space and of power," and he compared this to the "same emotions which a Richard Wagner evokes to act on us."[22] The baroque was also, of course, a contemporary style; a baroque revival in German-speaking countries—the final phase of eclecticism—had already started in the 1870s, partly inspired by Semper's Opera House in Vienna. A. E. Brinckmann, writing a historical survey of architectural space in 1924 under the title *Plastik und Raum,* spoke of this "neubarock" style that emerged in the late nineteenth-century and culminated, in his terms, with the sculpture of Rodin.[23] In the late 1880s the style was supported by writers like Hans Auer who, as Mallgrave and



6. Schematischer Grundriß der Renaissance-Raumgruppe



8. Schematischer Aufriß der Renaissance-Raumgruppe



7. Schematischer Grundriß der Barock-Raumgruppe.

9. Schematischer Aufriß der Barock-Raumgruppe

Ikonomou recall, saw the baroque style "as offering spatial and formal possibilities for personal and artistic expression, but also as having some special spiritual affinity with the age of Leibniz, Voltaire, and Newton."[24]

Trying to account for the continuing force of the baroque in the present, Adolf Göller in 1887 developed a theory of increasingly rapid style change, each more jaded than the next, so that, in the context of nineteenth-century revivalism, the baroque was simply the natural follower of a Gothic and Renaissance revival.

> With the progressive impoverishment of the architectural style, the charm of form also suffers and disturbing ideas intensify. In addition to the charm of form there is another achievement of the flowering of a

8. A. E. Brinckmann, "Schematic Plans of Renaissance and Baroque Spatial Groups," *Plastik und Raum als Grundformen künstlerischer Gestaltung* (Munich: Piper Verlag, 1924).

style that dissipates only slowly: this is the feeling for high, wide *space,* which is not much subject to jading; like the feeling for masses, it is largely a product of imagination. . . . The baroque style with all of its relatives worked itself out and exhausted its potential. Like a conflagration, it consumed all imaginable combinations of its own elements of form before it was extinguished. Thus it left the sense of form utterly devastated. Since there was no longer anything capable of germinating at the scene of the fire, nothing baroque could grow again in the garden of the reawakening of architecture. . . . One architectural style arises from the ruins of another.[25]

Göller was here echoing the diagnosis of Nietzsche, who had characterized the baroque style in such terms in *Human, All Too Human* some ten years before. For Nietzsche, the baroque style was equally an art of decadence: it "appears whenever a great age of art enters its decline," when "the demands of the art of classical expression have grown too great." Its appearance, he noted, is to be "greeted with sadness—because it heralds nightfall."[26] But in his subtle analysis the baroque took on characteristics that were to influence Walter Benjamin, who, despite his sense of its melancholia, was to see in its forms and subjects a profoundly modern sensibility, one that, as Nietzsche emphasized, should not be presumptuously "dismissed out of hand." Despite its lack of "innocent, unconscious, victorious perfection," the baroque displayed, for Nietzsche, two major aesthetic strengths: those of expression and of narration. Out of the "eloquence of strong feelings and pleasures" was forged "an ugly sublime," one of "great masses, of quantity for its own sake," which reveled in "the light of twilight, of transformation, or of conflagration." Such expressions, "forbidden fruits" for preclassical and classical art, were splendidly displayed in the baroque. Equally, its narrations chose topics and themes full of "dramatic tension: those that cause the heart to quicken even in the absence of art, so close do they bring us to the heaven and hell of emotion." An art of extremes, then, and one that presses the very limits of art to excess, even disappearance.

Nietzsche's remarks haunted Benjamin's melancholic baroque of allegory, ruins, and fragments. Echoing Wölfflin's characterization of the baroque in architecture as representing the decline and decadence of the Renaissance, Benjamin wrote of the period of baroque tragic drama as one of the "Verfalls

der Kunst," an epoch of decadence.[27] Against the "exact mean between excess and deficiency" achieved by Renaissance harmony, the baroque signaled "dissolution" of all forms and boundaries; the call for "unlimited space and the elusive magic of light" led to the transgression of all of architecture's "natural limits." For Benjamin, writing in the 1920s, the analogy between the baroque and the modern was more poignant still; the baroque style joined two periods of decadence by means of a symptomatic analysis of forms in tumult, disrupted forms that were emblematic of the conflicted forces of their respective epochs. Benjamin spoke of the "striking analogies with the present state of German literature" and noted the common themes between baroque tragic drama and expressionist drama, beginning with the presentation of Hans Werfels's *Trojans* in 1915.[28] As with many myths surrounding the emergence of modernism, the baroque effect was seen in terms of light and dark, rather as modernity itself was construed as poised between reason and the abyss of expressionist exaggeration. In this way, taking his cue from Nietzsche, Benjamin construed a baroque that was, as an art of expression and narration, the first modern style, allegorical and overstated, exemplified in the *Trauerspiel.*

Benjamin's subtle transformation of Wölfflin's by-then-commonplace characterization of subject and object relations relies on his critical reading of Riegl's posthumously published *The Origin of Roman Baroque Art,* and intimates that special kind of "modernity" later to be tracked down in the arcades. From Wölfflin to Riegl, as we have seen, baroque space had been essentially treated as a question of depth, of freedom from limits, but thus equally of anxiety, ambiguity and disturbance, distortion and conflict. Riegl's analysis of Michelangelo's proto-baroque Medici Chapel in San Lorenzo, published in 1907 and closely read by Benjamin, speaks of the "introduction of depth replacing the absolutely flat surface," "the tactile surface intersected/crossed by optical depth," a "resolute movement toward the optical, because space in depth, the space of the air, cannot be touched by the finger, can only be estimated in relation to that which is seen."[29] Here baroque space already holds qualities of modern space—as, in Riegl's formulation, the "optical" supersedes the "tactile."

Benjamin, following this law of optical progression, similarly identified three stages through which the concept of "play" (*Spiel*) passed before its modern manifestation: the first the baroque, the second classicism, and the third ro-

manticism (or in his terms, modernity). The first stage Benjamin characterized as fundamentally preoccupied with the "product," the second with "production," and the third with "both."[30] These stages were characterized by different paradigmatic "settings" or "scenes," each one spatially distinct from the next, but in a kind of Hegelian development in which each carried the traces of its previous genesis.

All three periods were similar in that history was finally spatialized. In the paradigmatic and, for modernity, the primal scene of the baroque, Benjamin saw the invention of the "panorama" not so much in technical terms (this would have to wait until the end of the eighteenth century) but in its conceptual form as the spatial form of history in nature. The panorama was, in the *Trauerspiel,* exemplified in the pastoral, the diverse landscapes of which served as the settings for so much ruined monumental history. "History merges into the setting," Benjamin notes; "in the pastoral plays . . . history is scattered like seeds over the ground," and literally so, in the form of columns raised to the memory of heroes.[31] Here Benjamin draws on the study of the baroque by his conservative contemporary Herbert Cysarz, who had coined the term "panoramic" to describe history in the seventeenth century: "'In this picturesque period the whole conception of history is determined by such a collection of everything memorable.'"[32] The setting thus secularizes history, in such a way that, emulating the development of the calculus in science, "chronological movement is grasped and analyzed in a spatial image."[33]

This panoramic space of history, indeed, affected the entire form of the *Trauerspiel.* Where classical tragedy had been characterized by "spasmodic chronological progression," *Trauerspiel* "takes place in a spatial continuum, which one might describe as choreographic."[34] For Benjamin this was where the baroque revealed itself as essentially modern; as the moment when, finally, time becomes spatially measurable. He recounts an image of the moving hand of the clock in a *Trauerspiel* by Geulincx, a "celebrated clock-metaphor, in which the parallelism of the psychological and physical worlds is presented schematically in terms of two accurate and synchronized clocks; the second hand, so to speak, determines the rhythm of events in both."[35] In this double timekeeping Benjamin sees the intimation of a union between the mechanical nature of "clock time" and the aesthetic forms of modern music, as if, he imagines, the cantatas of Johann Sebastian Bach joined the philosophy of Bergson,

testifying to the relations between the regular and harmonious sequence of the historical process and the "the non-qualitative, repeatable time of the mathematical sciences."[36] History would be in this metaphor both spatially and temporally measurable.

Such a mechanistic spatial-historical play that transposes "*what is vital . . . of the originally temporal data into a figurative spatial simultaneity*"[37] cannot be effected, however, without a deep distortion of space itself. From the point of view of the perceiving subject, the very effort to turn time into space turns space into a kind of reflected anamorphosis: "The creature is the mirror within whose frame alone the moral world was revealed to the baroque. A concave mirror; for this was not possible without distortion."[38]

And this distorting mirror reflected, in the *Trauerspiel,* an effectively modern subject, the worried, anxious, cunning and scheming courtier, in the spatial setting of high tragedy—the "tragic scene" prescribed by Vitruvius and illustrated by Serlio. For Benjamin, it is precisely the space of the baroque court, set within "'stately palaces and princely pavilions,'" that, in its spatialization of history on stage, allows history to be interpreted.[39] "The image of the setting, or more precisely of the court [*Hof*]," Benjamin writes, "becomes the key to historical understanding."[40]

This court setting, described in Daniel Casper von Lohenstein's preface to *Sophonisbe* as the intersection between play and scene—"Nowhere are action and setting [*Spiel und Schauplatz*] richer than in the life of those whose element is the court," Lohenstein had written[41]—becomes for Benjamin the paradigmatic space of modern action. For even when the heroes are fallen, when "the court is reduced to a scaffold," "and that which is mortal will enter the setting," the court of the *Trauerspiel* represents the timeless, natural decor of the historical process—a process that inevitably leads toward modernity.[42]

But this courtly space, however grandly represented or ostentatiously displayed, is reduced in both depth and height from that of Greek or even Renaissance tragedy. Where, as Nietzsche imagined it in *The Birth of Tragedy,* the space of the Greek theater is defined only by the skies that hover above it, where "the architecture of the scene appears like a luminous cloud formation" providing an upper stage from which the Bacchante observe the action of the play,[43] for Benjamin, the stage of the *Trauerspiel* is surmounted by lowering clouds and a disturbed sky: "For the dominant spiritual disposition, however

eccentrically it might elevate individual acts of ecstasy, did not so much transfigure the world in them as cast a cloudy sky over its surface. Whereas the painters of the Renaissance know how to keep their skies high, in the paintings of the baroque the cloud moves, darkly or radiantly, down towards the earth."[44] Where the stage of Greek tragedy is a "cosmic *topos*" that reflects the communal will for "the scene" as it becomes a veritable tribunal before which the audience is assembled to witness and judge, "the *Trauerspiel,* in contrast, has to be understood from the point of view of the onlooker."[45] Communality is transformed into individuality, the space of the stage becomes an "inner world of feeling [*Innenraum des Gefühls*]" with no cosmic relationship to redeem its audience. Such concentration on inner space, on individual emotional life, is typical of the society of the court, even as the disillusioned insight of the courtier is typical of the *Trauerspiel.* Forced to play and scheme in the flattened space of an anamorphic mirror, Benjamin's baroque courtier is revealed as a dispersed subject bodily projecting itself in the ruined landscape of historical destiny, measured by the relentless ticking and turning of clocks at ever-increasing tempos, soulless in the wasteland of humanism's detritus, picking its way among the bones of fallen heroes. In this sense, in Simmelian terms, the "courtier" would be one who finds "the tempo of emotional life accelerated to such an extent that calm actions, considered decisions occur more and more infrequently."[46] For Benjamin this subject would resemble nothing more than the alienated modern metropolitan citizen.

The Explosion of Space

Architecture and the Filmic Imaginary

> I am kino-eye. I am a builder. I have placed you, whom I've created today, in an extraordinary room which did not exist until just now when I also created it. In this room there are twelve walls shot by me in various parts of the world. In bringing together shots of walls and details, I've managed to arrange them in an order that is pleasing and to construct with intervals, correctly, a film-phrase which is the room.
>
> Dziga Vertov, 1923[1]

The architecture of film has acted, from the beginning of this century, as a laboratory, so to speak, for the exploration of the built world—of architecture and the city. The examples of such experimentation are well known, and they include the entire roster of filmic genres: science fiction, adventure, film noir, action films, documentaries. Film has even been seen to anticipate the built forms of architecture and the city: we have only to think of the commonplace icons of expressionist utopias to find examples, from *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* to *Metropolis,* that apparently succeeded, where architecture failed, to build the future in the present. Thus the recent installation of the exhibition "Expressionist Utopias" at the Los Angeles County Museum of Art, by the Viennese architectural firm Coop Himmelblau, even suggested a kind of contemporary completion, where at last architecture might be seen to catch up with the imaginary space of film. In recent years, other designers, searching for ways to represent movement and temporal succession in architecture, have similarly turned to the images forged by the first, constructivist and expressionist avant-gardes, images themselves deeply marked by the impact of the new filmic techniques. From the literal evocations of Bernard Tschumi in his *Manhattan Transcripts* and projects for the urban park of La Villette in Paris to the more

theoretical and critical work on the relations of space to visual representation in the projects of Elizabeth Diller and Ricardo Scofidio, the complex question of film's architectural role is again on the agenda. In their new incarnation, such neoconstructivist, dadaist, and expressionist images seem to reframe many earlier questions about the proper place for images of space and time in architecture, questions that resonate for contemporary critique of the "image" and the "spectacle" in architecture and society.

And yet the simple alignment of architecture and film has always posed difficulties, both theoretically and in practice. On the one hand, it is obvious that film has been the site of envy and even imitation for those more static arts concerned to produce effects or techniques of movement and space-time interpenetration. Painting, from Duchamp's *Nude Descending a Staircase;* literature, from Virginia Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway;* poetry, from Marinetti's *Parole in libertà;* architecture, from Sant'Elia to Le Corbusier, have all sought to reproduce movement and the collapse of time in space; and montage, or its equivalent, has been a preoccupation in all the arts since its appearance, in primitive form, with rapid-sequence photography. On the other hand, it is equally true that the Enlightenment roots of modernism ensured that film, as well as all the other arts, were bound, à la Lessing, to draw precise theoretical boundaries around the centers of their conceptually different practices—practices understood as distinct precisely because of their distinct media; each one, like Lessing's own poetry and painting, more or less appropriate to the representation of time *or* space. Thus, despite the aspirations of avant-garde groups, from dada to Esprit Nouveau, to syncretism and synesthesia, the relations of the arts still could not be conceived without their particular essences being defined: as if the arts were so many nations, romantically rooted in soil and race, each with characteristics of their own to be asserted before any treaties might be negotiated. Thus, since the late nineteenth century, film has provided a test case for the definition of modernism in theory and technique. It has also served as a point of departure for the redefinition of the other arts, a paradigm by which the different practices of theater, photography, literature, and painting might be distinguished from each other. Of all the arts, however, it is architecture that has had the most privileged and difficult relationship to film. An obvious role model for spatial experimentation, film has also been criticized for its deleterious effects on the architectural image.

Thus, when in 1933 Le Corbusier called for a film aesthetics that embodied the "spirit of truth," he was only asserting what many architects in the twenties, and more recently in the eighties, have seen to be the mutually informative but properly separate realms of architecture and film. While admitting that "everything is Architecture" in its architectonic dimensions of proportion and order, Le Corbusier nevertheless insisted on the specificity of film, which "from now on is positioning itself on its own terrain . . . becoming a form of art in and of itself, a kind of genre, just as painting, sculpture, literature, music, and theater are genres."[2] In the present context, debates as to the nature of "architecture in film," "filmic architecture," or filmic theory in architectural theory are interesting less as a guide to the writing of some new *Laocoön* that would rigidly redraw the boundaries of the technological arts, than as establishing the possibilities of interpretation for projects that increasingly seem caught in the hallucinatory realm of a filmic or screened imaginary; somewhere, that is, in the problematic realm of hyperspace.

Cineplastics

The obvious role of architecture in the construction of sets (and the eager participation of architects themselves in this enterprise), and the equally obvious ability of film to "construct" its own architecture in light and shade, scale and movement, from the outset allowed for a mutual intersection of these two "spatial arts." Certainly many modernist filmmakers had little doubt of the cinema's architectonic properties. From Georges Méliès's careful description of the proper spatial organization of the studio in 1907 to Eric Rohmer's reassertion of film as "the spatial art" some forty years later, the architectural metaphor, if not its material reality, was deemed essential to the filmic imagination.[3] Equally, architects like Hans Poelzig (who together with his wife, the sculptor Marlene Poelzig, sketched and modeled the sets for Paul Wegener's *Der Golem—Wie er in die Welt kam* of 1920) and Andrei Andreiev (who designed the sets for Robert Weine's *Raskolnikoff* of 1923) had no hesitation in collaborating with filmmakers in the same way as they had previously served theater producers.[4] As the architect Robert Mallet-Stevens observed in 1925: "It is undeniable that the cinema has a marked influence on modern architecture; in turn, modern architecture brings its artistic side to the cinema.

> Modern architecture does not only serve the cinematographic set [*décor*], but imprints its stamp on the staging [*mise-en-scène*], it breaks out of its frame; architecture 'plays.'"[5] And, of course, for filmmakers (like Sergei Eisenstein) originally trained as architects, the filmic art offered the potential to develop a new architecture of time and space unfettered by the material constraints of gravity and daily life.

Out of this intersection of the two arts, a theoretical apparatus was developed that saw architecture as the fundamental site of film practice, the indispensable real and ideal matrix of the filmic imaginary, and at the same time posited film as the modernist art of space par excellence—a vision of the fusion of space and time. The potential of film to explore this new realm, seen as the basis of modernist architectural aesthetics by Sigfried Giedion, was recognized early on. Abel Gance, writing in 1912, was already hoping for a new "sixth art" that would provide "that admirable synthesis of the movement of space and time."[6] But it was the art historian Elie Faure, influenced by Fernand Léger, who first coined a term for the cinematic aesthetic that brought together the two dimensions: "cineplastics." "The cinema," he wrote in 1922, "is first of all plastic. It represents, in some way, an architecture in movement that should be in constant accord, in dynamically pursued equilibrium, with the setting and the landscapes within which it rises and falls."[7] In Faure's terms, "plastic" art was that which "expresses form at rest and in movement," a mode common to the arts of sculpture, bas-relief, drawing, painting, fresco, and especially the dance, but which perhaps achieved its highest expression in the cinema.[8] For "the cinema incorporates time to space. Better, time, through this, really becomes a dimension of space . . . unrolling under our eyes its successive volumes ceaselessly returned to us in dimensions that allow us to grasp their extent in surface and depth."[9] The "hitherto unknown plastic pleasures" thereby discovered would, finally, have the effect of creating a new kind of architectural space, akin to that imaginary space "within the walls of the brain":

> The notion of duration entering as a constitutive element into the notion of space, we will easily imagine an art of cineplastics blossoming that would be no more than an ideal architecture, and where the "cinemimic" will . . . disappear, because only a great artist could build edifices that constitute themselves, collapse, and reconstitute themselves again

ceaselessly by imperceptible passages of tones and modeling which will themselves be architecture at every instant, without our being able to grasp the thousandth part of a second in which the transition takes place.[10]

Such an art, Faure predicts, will propel the world into a new stage of civilization, one where architecture will be the principal form of expression, based on the appearance of mobile industrial constructions, ships, trains, cars, and airplanes together with their stable ports and harbors. Cinema will then operate, he concludes, as a kind of privileged "spiritual ornament" to this machine civilization: "the most useful social play for the development of confidence, harmony, and cohesion in the masses."[11]

Spaces of Horror

Critics of the first generation of German expressionist films had already experienced such a "cineplastic" revolution in practice: the spate of immediate postwar productions in 1919 and 1920, including Paul Wegener's *Der Golem,* Karl Heinz Martin's *Von Morgens bis Mitternacht,* and, of course, Robert Weine's *Das Kabinett des Dr. Caligari,* demonstrated that, in the words of the German art critic and *New York Times* correspondent Herman G. Scheffauer, a new "stereoscopic universe" was in the making. In an analysis published at the end of 1920 that unabashedly paraphrased an earlier article by the Berlin critic Heinrich de Fries, Scheffauer hailed the end of the "crude phantasmagoria" of earlier films and the birth of a new space: "Space—hitherto considered and treated as something dead and static, a mere inert screen or frame, often of no more significance than the painted balustrade-background at the village photographer's—has been smitten into life, into movement and conscious expression. A fourth dimension has begun to evolve out of this photographic cosmos."[12] Thus the film began to extend what Scheffauer called "the sixth sense of man, his feeling for space or room—his *Raumgefühl,*" in such a way as to transform reality itself. No longer an inert background, architecture now participates in the very emotions of the film—the surroundings no longer surround but enter the experience as presence: "The frown of a tower, the scowl of a sinister alley, the pride and serenity of a white peak, the hypnotic draught of a straight

road vanishing to a point—these exert their influences and express their natures; their essences flow over the scene and blend with the action."[13] An advance on the two-dimensional world of the picture, the "scenic architect" of films such as *Caligari* has the ability to dominate "furniture, room, house, street, city, landscape, universe!" The "fourth dimension" of time extends space in depth, "the plastic is amalgamated with the painted, bulk and form with the simulacra of bulk and form, false perspective and violent foreshadowing are introduced, real light and shadow combat or reinforce painted shadow and light. Einstein's invasion of the law of gravity is made visible in the treatment of walls and supports."[14]

9. Walter Reimann, sketch for *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*, 1919.

Scheffauer provides a veritable phenomenology of the spaces of *Caligari*—a corridor in an office building, a street at night, an attic room, a prison cell, a white and spectral bridge, the marketplace; all constructed out of walls

that are at once solid and transparent, fissured and veiled, camouflaged and endlessly disappearing, and presented in a forced and distorted perspective that presses space both backward and forward, finally overwhelming the spectator's own space, incorporating it into the vortex of the whole movie. In his description of the film's environments, Scheffauer anticipates all the later commonplaces of expressionist criticism from Siegfried Kracauer to Rudolf Kurtz:

> A corridor in an office building: Wall veering outward from the floor, traversed by sharply-defined parallel strips, emphasizing the perspective and broken violently by pyramidal openings, streaming with light, marking the doors; the shadows between them vibrating as dark cones of contrast, the further end of the corridor murky, giving vast distance. In the foreground a section of wall violently tilted over the heads of the audience, as it were. The floor cryptically painted with errant lines of direction, the floor in front of the doors shows crosslines, indicating a going to and fro, in and out. The impression is one of formal coldness, of bureaucratic regularity, of semipublic traffic.
>
> A street at night: Yawning blackness in the background—empty, starless, abstract space, against it a square, lopsided lantern hung between lurching walls. Doors and windows constructed or painted in wrenched perspective. Dark segments on the pavement accentuate diminishing effect. The slinking of a brutal figure pressed against the walls and evil spots and shadings on the pavement give a sinister expression to the street. Adroit diagonals lead and rivet the eye.
>
> An attic: It speaks of sordidness, want and crime. The whole composition a vivid intersection of cones of light and dark, of roof-lines, shafts of light and slanting walls. A projection of white and black patterns on the floor, the whole geometrically felt, cubistically conceived. This attic is out of time, but in space. The roof chimneys of another world arise and scowl through the splintered window-pane.
>
> A room; or rather a room that has precipitated itself in cavern-like lines, in inverted hollows of frozen waves. Here space becomes cloistral and encompasses the human—a man reads at a desk. A triangular window glares and permits the living day a voice in this composition. A prison-cell: A criminal, ironed to a huge chain attached to an immense

trapezoidal "ball." The posture of the prisoner sitting on his folded legs is almost Buddha-like. Here space turns upon itself, encloses and focuses a human destiny. A small window high up and crazily-barred, is like an eye. The walls, sloping like a tent's to an invisible point, are blazoned with black and white wedge-shaped rays. These blend when they reach the floor and unite in a kind of huge cross, in the center of which the prisoner sits, scowling, unshaven. The tragedy of the repression of the human in space—in trinity of space, fate and man.

A white and spectral bridge yawning and rushing out of the foreground: It is an erratic, irregular causeway, such as blond ghouls might have built. It climbs and struggles upward almost out of the picture. In the middle distance it rises into a hump and reveals arches staggering over nothingness. The perspective pierces into vacuity. This bridge is the scene of a wild pursuit. . . .

Several aspects of the market place of a small town: . . . the town cries out its will through its mouth, this market place.[15]

Caligari, then, has produced an entirely new space, one that is both all-embracing and all-absorbing in depth and movement. But the filmic medium allowed the exploration of other kinds of space than the totalizing plasticity modeled by Walter Röhrig, Walter Reimann, and Hermann Warm for Weine's film. Scheffauer identifies the "flat space" of Martin's *Von Morgens bis Mitternacht* (1920), designed by Robert Neppach, where rather than being artificially constructed in the round as in *Caligari,* it was suggested in tones of black and white as "a background, vague, inchoate, nebulous."[16] Above and around this inactive space that makes the universe into a flat plane, there is only "primeval darkness"; all perspective is rendered in contrasts of white planes against blackness. There is also the "geometrical space" found in Reimann's film fantasy of Paul Scheerbart's *Algol;* in this meditation on the space of the stars, "the forms are broken up expressionistically, but space acts and speaks geometrically, in great vistas, in grandiose architectural culminations. Space or room is divided into formal diapers, patterns, squares, spots, and circles, of cube imposed upon cube, of apartment opening into apartment."[17] Finally, there is what Scheffauer terms "sculptural" or "solid" space, such as that modeled by the Poelzigs for Wegener's *Der Golem.*

> Professor Poelzig conceives of space in plastic terms, in solid concretions congealing under the artist's hand to expressive and organic forms. He works, therefore, in the solid masses of the sculptor and not with the planes of the painter. Under his caressing hands a weird but spontaneous internal architecture, shell-like, cavernous, somber, has been evolved in simple, flowing lines, instinct with the bizarre spirit of the tale. . . . The gray soul of medieval Prague has been molded into these eccentric and errant crypts. . . . Poelzig seeks to give an eerie and grotesque suggestiveness to the flights of houses and streets that are to furnish the external setting of this film-play. The will of this master-architect animating facades into faces, insists that these houses are to speak in jargon—and gesticulate![18]

Pan-Geometries

In assimilating filmic space to the theoretical types of *Raum* adumbrated in German philosophy and psychology since Theodor Vischer, and in proposing the relativity of spatial forms in the face of continuous optical movement, in a way that reminds us of the historical relativity of optical forms demonstrated by Alois Riegl, Scheffauer anticipates the more scholarly account of perspectival history developed between 1923 and 1925 by Erwin Panofsky. Panofsky's essay "Perspective as Symbolic Form" set out to show that the various perspective systems from Roman times to the present were not simply "incorrect" instances of representing reality, but rather endowed with distinct and symbolic meaning of their own, as powerful and as open to reading as iconographical types and genres. Panofsky even took note of the modernist will to break with the conventions of perspective, and saw it as yet another stage of perspective vision itself. He cites expressionism's resistance to perspective as the last remnant of the will to capture "real, three-dimensional space," and El Lissitzky in his desire to overcome the bounds of finite space:

> Older perspective is supposed to have "limited space, made it finite, closed it off," conceived of space "according to Euclidean geometry as rigid three-dimensionality," and it is these very bonds which the most recent art has attempted to break. Either it has in a sense exploded the

entire space by "dispersing the center of vision" ("Futurism"), or it has sought no longer to represent depth intervals "extensively" by means of foreshortenings, but rather, in accord with the most modern insights of psychology, only to create an illusion "intensively" by playing color surfaces off against each other, each differently placed, differently shaded, and only in this way furnished with different spatial values (Mondrian and in particular Malevich's "Suprematism"). The author believes he can suggest a third solution: the conquest of an "imaginary space" by means of mechanically motivated bodies, which by this very movement, by their rotation or oscillation, produce precise figures (for example, a rotating stick produces an apparent circle, or in another position, an apparent cylinder, and so forth). In this way, in the opinion of El Lissitzky, art is elevated to the standpoint of a non-Euclidean pan-geometry (whereas in fact the space of those "imaginary" rotating bodies is no less "Euclidean" than any other empirical space).[19]

Despite Panofsky's skepticism, it was, of course, such a "pan-geometric" space that architecture hoped to construct through abstraction and technologically induced movement. Architects from El Lissitzky to Bruno Taut were to experiment with this new "pan-geometry" as if, in Ernst Bloch's words, it would enable them finally "to depict empirically an imaginary space." For Bloch, the underlying Euclidean nature of all space offered the potential for architecture to approach "pan-geometry" in reality; basing his argument on Panofsky's essay, he commended expressionists for having generated rotating and turning bodies that produced "stereometric figures . . . which at least have nothing in common with the perspective visual space (*Sehraum*)." Out of this procedure emerged "an architecture of the abstract, which wants to be quasi-meta-cubic." For Bloch this potential allowed modern architecture to achieve its own "symbolic allusions," even if these were founded on the "so-called Euclidian pan-geometry," criticized by Panofsky.[20] In this illusion the architects were encouraged by the cinematographers themselves, who, at least in the twenties, and led by Fritz Lang and F. W. Murnau, accepted the practical rulings of the Universum Film A.G. or Ufa, whose proscription against exterior filming supported the extraordinary experimentation in set design of the Weimar period.

But the attempt to construct these imaginary new worlds was, as Panofsky had noted, not simply formalistic and decorative; its premise was from the outset psychological, based on what Rudolf Kurtz defined as the "simple law of psychological aesthetics that when we feel our way into certain forms, exact psychic correspondences are set up."[21] Hugo Münsterberg, in his 1916 work *Film: A Psychological Study,* had already set out the terms of the equation film = psychological form.[22] For Münsterberg, film differed from drama by its appeal to the "inner movements of the mind":

> To be sure, the events in the photoplay happen in the real space with its depth. But the spectator feels that they are not presented in the three dimensions of the outer world, that they are flat pictures which only the mind molds into plastic things. Again the events are seen in continuous movement; and yet the pictures break up the movement into a rapid succession of instantaneous impressions. . . . The photoplay tells us the human story by overcoming the forms of the outer world, namely space, time, and causality, and by adjusting the events to the forms of the inner world, namely, attention, memory, imagination, and emotion.[23]

Only two years later, in one of his first critical essays, Louis Aragon was to note this property of the film to focus attention and reformulate the real into the imaginary, the ability to fuse the physical and the mental, later to become a surrealist obsession. Seemingly anticipating the mental states of Breton's *Nadja* or of his own *Paysan de Paris,* but as revealed in film, Aragon meditated on the way "the door of a bar that swings and on the window the capital letters of unreadable and marvelous words, or the vertiginous, thousand-eye facade of the thirty-story house . . . ". The possibility of disclosing the inner "menacing or enigmatic meanings" of everyday objects by simple close-up techniques and camera angles, light, shade, and space established, for Aragon, the poetic potential of the art: "To endow with a poetic value that which does not possess it, to willfully restrict the field of vision so as to intensify expression: these are two properties that help make cinematic decor the adequate setting of modern beauty."[24]

For this, however, film had no need of an artificially constructed "decor" that simulated the foreshortening of perspective or the phobic characteristics of space; the framings and movements of the camera itself would serve to construct reality far more freely. In his later 1934 essay on "Style and Medium in the Motion Pictures," Panofsky himself argued against any attempt to subject the world to "aesthetic prestylization, as in the expressionist settings of *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari,*" as "no more than an exciting experiment." "To prestylize reality prior to tackling it amounts to dodging the problem," he concluded: "The problem is to manipulate and shoot unstylized reality in such a way that the result has style."[25]

Unhomely Houses

Some languages in use today can only render the German expression "an *unheimlich* house" by "a *haunted* house."

Sigmund Freud, "The Uncanny"

By far the most popular topos of the nineteenth-century uncanny was the haunted house. A pervasive leitmotiv of literary fantasy and architectural revival alike, its depiction in fairy tales, horror stories, and Gothic novels gave rise to a unique genre of writing that, by the end of the century, stood for romanticism itself. The house provided an especially favored site for uncanny disturbances: its apparent domesticity, its residue of family history and nostalgia, its role as the last and most intimate shelter of private comfort sharpened by contrast the terror of invasion by alien spirits. Edgar Allan Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" was paradigmatic: "With the first glimpse of the building, a sense of insufferable gloom pervaded my spirit. . . . The feeling was unrelieved by any of that half-pleasurable, because poetic, sentiment with which the mind usually receives even the sternest natural images of the desolate or terrible."[1]

And yet the House of Usher, in Poe's description, while evoking premonitions of "shadowy fancies," exhibited nothing untoward in its outer appearance. Its "bleak walls" and "vacant eye-like windows" were stark, but any sentiments of doom were more easily attributed to the fantasies of the narrator than to any striking detail in the house itself. Indeed, when looked at objectively, its ancient stones, carvings, tapestries, and trophies were all familiar enough. The "atmosphere" that surrounded the house, its smell of the grave that "had reeked

up from the decayed trees, and the grey wall and the silent tarn," was difficult to account for: "vague sentiments," seemingly the products of a *dream*. The slow realization that these were properties of the house, embedded in the very stones that possessed a fatality in themselves, that the house was itself an uncanny power, came unwillingly, against all reason, the more disquieting for the absolute normality of the setting, its veritable *absence* of overt terror. The effect was one of the disturbing unfamiliarity of the evidently familiar: "While the objects around me . . . were but matters to which, or to such as which, I had been accustomed from my infancy—while I hesitated not to acknowledge how familiar was all this—I still wondered to find how unfamiliar were the fancies which ordinary images were stirring up."[2]

But in Poe's paradigmatic haunted house, all the tell-tale signs of haunting were present, systematically culled from his romantic predecessors. The site was desolate; the walls were blank and almost literally "faceless," its windows "eye-like" but without life—"vacant." It was, besides, a repository of centuries of memory and tradition, embodied in its walls and objects; the walls were marked by the "discoloration of ages" and crumbling stones; the furnishings were dark, the rooms vaulted and gloomy; it was, in fact, already a museum, a collection such as that assembled by Alexandre du Sommerard in the Hôtel de Cluny, here preserved in memory of a family. Finally, the family itself was almost extinct, doomed by a history that lent the air of the tomb, the family vault, to this once-living abode; its fabric was reminiscent of "old wood-work which has rotted for some years in some neglected vault, with no disturbance from the breath of the external air."[3]

The house was then a crypt, predestined to be buried in its turn, an event prefigured in the "barely perceptible fissure" that ran vertically from roof to foundations. Inside, painted by Usher himself, was what seemed to be the image of its own tomb, a scene that in its character seemed to his narrator the most uncanny of all in its "abstraction":

> One of the phantasmagoric conceptions of my friend, partaking not so rigidly of the spirit of abstraction, may be shadowed forth, although feebly, in words. A small picture presented the interior of an immensely long and rectangular vault or tunnel, with low walls, smooth white, and without interruption or device. Certain accessory points of the design served well to convey the idea

that this excavation lay at an exceeding depth below the surface of the earth. No outlet was observed in any portion of its vast extent, and no torch or other artificial source of light was discernible; yet a flood of intense rays rolled throughout, and bathed the whole in a ghastly and inappropriate splendor.[4]

Abandoned houses, real or imaginary, had a similar effect on the viewer. Those described by Victor Hugo on the islands of Jersey and Guernsey, veritable figures of his own unhomely exile, shared characteristics with the House of Usher, with the difference that they were "haunted" not by some imaginary family spirit but by virtue of the superstitions of the islanders.

It sometimes happens, in Jersey or Guernsey, that in the countryside, or even in the town, when passing through some deserted spot or a street filled with people, you will see a house with a barricaded entrance; holly obstructs the door; one knows not what hideous layers of nailed planks fill the windows of the ground floor; the windows of the upper floors are at once closed and open, all the casements are barred but all the window-panes are broken.

Such a house, killed by its very emptiness and the superstitions that have built up in the region, "is a haunted house [*une maison visionée*]. The devil comes there in the night."[5]

Among these "dead houses" one in particular fascinated Hugo, an empty house in the Guernsey village of Pleinmont. He returned three times in seven years to sketch it from various angles and used it as a central motif in *Les Travailleurs de la mer.* Drawn in brown ink and wash, this small, two-story stone cottage seemed to have little out of the ordinary about it. With its four windows, walled up on the ground floor, its single door, pitched roof, and chimney, it seems no more than the archetypical "child's house," a commonplace compilation of the fundamental elements of dwelling. As Hugo himself noted, "the site is fine, the house is good. This house, built in granite and two stories high, is surrounded by grass. It is in no way ruined. It is perfectly habitable. The walls are thick and the roof solid. Not a stone is lacking in the walls, not a tile from the roof." Nevertheless, it had the reputation of being haunted, and despite its simplicity, "its aspect was strange." Firstly, the deserted site, almost entirely surrounded by the sea, was perhaps too beautiful: "The site is magnificent, and consequently sinister." Then the contrast between the walled-up windows on the ground floor and the open, empty windows on the upper

floor, "opening onto the shadows of the interior," gave a quasi-anthropomorphic air to the structure: "One would say that the empty holes were two gouged-out eyes." An enigmatic inscription over the closed-up door added to the mystery and told of a building and abandonment before the Revolution: "ELM-PBILG 1780." Finally, the silence and emptiness contributed the aura of a tomb; "one thought one saw a sepulcher with windows allowing the specters to look out." It is by such mysteries, adding to local lore, that Hugo explains the haunting. Who were the original inhabitants? Why the abandonment? Why no present owner? Why no one to cultivate the field? These questions, all inexplicable without some unknown and metaphysical cause, added to the atmosphere: "This house is uncanny at midday; what is it at midnight? Looking at it one looks at a secret. . . . Enigmas. Sacred horror is in these stones. This shadow inhabiting these walled-up rooms is more than a shadow; it is the unknown."[6] Thus guarded by terror, the house, as Hugo develops the narrative, becomes paradoxically secure for those unaffected by the haunting; it is the home of smugglers and renegades, exiles and fugitives. Only those on the margin would feel at home in so disquieting an abode. The legend of a crime committed in the house, an indelible act from which it has never recovered, thus rejoined the present it sheltered, and the circle of a home killed by memories was completed in this image of a tomb inhabited by its robbers: "The house, like man, can become a skeleton. A superstition is enough to kill it. Then it is terrible."[7]

Such "terror," however, was not exactly equivalent to that prescribed by Edmund Burke; in the hierarchy of romantic genres, the uncanny was intimately bound up with, but strangely different from, the grander and more serious "sublime," the master category of aspiration, nostalgia, and the unattainable. Thus Poe, attempting to define the peculiar feeling evoked by the House of Usher, had distinguished it sharply from the more terrifying sensations normally attendant on the sublime: "There was an iciness, a sinking, a sickening of the heart—an unredeemed dreariness of thought which no goading of the imagination could torture into aught of the sublime."[8]

Traditionally, of course, all the subgenres of the sublime—the grotesque, the caricature, the fairy story, the melodrama, the ghostly romance, and the horror story—were considered to be subversive of its overarching premises and its transcendent ambitions. While Burke

had traced the sublime to its fundamental source in terror, he readily admitted that not everything that induced terror was sublime.[9] By the same token, Kant's description of a sublimity residing entirely in the mind, as it was drawn to "think the unattainability of nature," did not apply to all ideas of things unattainable. Lurking behind all attempts to achieve sublime expression were a host of pitfalls that ranged from the bathetic to the nonsensical; rhetoricians from Longinus to Jean Paul Richter had understood this tendency of the sublime to fall into the ridiculous, an opposite, moreover, that shared many characteristics with its more serious antecedent. "Ugliness," stated Burke, "I imagine to be consistent enough with an idea of the sublime. But I would by no means insinuate that ugliness of itself is a sublime idea unless united with such qualities that excite a strong terror."[10]

The uncanny, however, was perhaps the most subversive of all, not only because it was easily trivialized but also because it seemed at times indistinguishable from the sublime. Burke himself had included this ill-defined but increasingly popular sensation among those associated with the obscurity that provoked terror, along with the night and absolute darkness: "How greatly the night adds to our dread in all cases of danger," he observed, "and how much the notions of ghosts and goblins, of which none can form clear ideas, affect minds."[11] Such was the threat of the uncanny throughout the romantic period that Hegel, in his vain effort to preserve the memory of an authentic sublime in the Hebrew texts, tried to close the door on this province of "magic, magnetism, demons, the superior apparitions of clairvoyance, the disease of somnambulism," banishing these dark powers from the clear and transparent realm of art. But he was nevertheless forced to admit the general preoccupation of his contemporaries with those "unknown forces" wherein "there is supposed to lie an indecipherable truth of dreadfullness which cannot be grasped or understood."[12]

More than eighty years later, Freud recognized that the uncanny was, at least in its received connotations, an aesthetic category that lay directly within the boundaries of "all that is terrible," that is, within the traditional sublime (U 339). But he set himself the task of identifying "what this particular quality is which allows us to distinguish as 'uncanny' certain things within the boundary of what is 'fearful.'" It was almost with delight that he undertook to explore,

against those "elaborate treatises on aesthetics which . . . prefer to concern themselves with what is beautiful, attractive and sublime," feelings of an apparently opposite kind, those of unpleasantness and repulsion (U 339–340). To explore, that is, the margins of the sublime against its acknowledged center. For Freud, the uncanny evidently presented itself as an especially useful instrument with which to deflate an empty aesthetics on behalf of psychoanalytical knowledge, a skirmish that mirrored his more general attack on metaphysical psychology:

> The subject of the uncanny . . . is undoubtedly related to what is frightening—to what arouses dread and horror; equally certainly, too, the word is not always used in a clearly definable sense, so that it tends to coincide with what excites fear in general. Yet we may expect that a special core of feeling is present which justifies the use of a special conceptual term. One is curious to know what this common core is which allows us to distinguish as "uncanny" certain things which lie within the field of what is frightening. (U 339)

The sensation of "uncanniness" was, then, an especially difficult feeling to define precisely. Neither absolute terror nor mild anxiety, the uncanny seemed easier to describe in terms of what it was not than in any essential sense of its own. Thus it might readily be distinguished from horror and all strong feelings of fear; it was not uniquely identified with the parapsychological—the magical, the hallucinatory, the mystical, and the supernatural did not necessarily imply "uncanniness"; nor was it present in everything that appeared strange, weird, grotesque, or fantastic; it was the direct opposite, finally, of the caricatural and the distorted, which, by their exaggeration, refused to provoke fear. Sharing qualities with all these allied genres of fear, the uncanny reveled in its nonspecificity, one reinforced by the multiplicity of untranslatable words that served to indicate its presence in different languages.

Indeed, Freud's initial attempt at comparative lingustic definition foundered immediately in the face of *unheimlich, inquiétant, sinistre, lugubre, étrange, mal à son aise, sospechoso, de mal aguëro, siniestro,* and of course "uncanny," itself untranslatable. Greek offered simply ξένος (strange, foreign), and Latin only *locus suspectus,* or "uncanny place" (U 341–342). And yet, despite Freud's irritation, the total effect of this assemblage of words certainly delimits, if not the word, at least a field of connotation, a set of attributes. Thus the uncanny

would be sinister, disturbing, suspect, strange; it would be characterized better as "dread" than terror, deriving its force from its very inexplicability, its sense of lurking unease, rather than from any clearly defined source of fear—an uncomfortable sense of haunting rather than a present apparition. Here the English word is perhaps more helpful than Freud was willing to admit: literally "beyond ken"—beyond knowledge—from "canny," meaning possessing knowledge or skill.[13]

The psychologist Ernst Jentsch, in an essay of 1906 that Freud used as a starting point for his own investigation, had already pointed to the intimate relations between psychology and language: "Our German language seems to have created a fairly happy construction with the word *unheimlich.* Without doubt it seems to express that somebody who has an uncanny experience is not quite *zu Hause* [at home] in the matter, that he is not *heimisch* [homely], that the affair is foreign to him."[14] Jentsch attributed the feeling of uncanniness to a fundamental insecurity brought about by a "lack of orientation," a sense of something new, foreign, and hostile invading an old, familiar, customary world. As summarized by Freud, he

> ascribes the central factor in the production of the feeling of uncanniness to intellectual uncertainty; so that the uncanny would always, as it were, be something one does not know one's way about in. The better oriented in his environment a person is, the less readily will he get the impression of something uncanny in regard to the objects and events in it. (U 341)

Despite Freud's reluctance to accept the limits of this explanation—Jentsch's definition was, he concluded, "incomplete"—it nonetheless underlined a first relation of the uncanny to the spatial and environmental, that of "orientation," of "knowing one's way about."

For Freud's purposes, the multiple significations and affiliations of the German word *unheimlich* were more promising. They served at once to clarify the operations of the uncanny as a systematic principle as well as to situate its domain firmly in the domestic and the homely, thence to permit its decipherment in individual experience as the unconscious product of a family romance. To this end, Freud deliberately approached the definition of *unheimlich* by way of that of its apparent opposite, *heimlich,* thereby exposing the disturbing affiliations between the two and constituting the one as a direct outgrowth of the other.

Drawing on two nineteenth-century dictionaries with lengthy citations, Freud allowed his argument, so to speak, to unfold by itself (U 342–347).[15] Thus in Daniel Sanders's *Wörterbuch* of 1860, *heimlich* is first defined as "belonging to the house or family," as "not strange, familiar." It is associated with the intimate, the "friendlily comfortable," "the enjoyment of quiet content, etc., arousing a sense of agreeable restfulness and security as in one within the four walls of his house." Sanders evokes a host of examples: "'To destroy the *Heimlichkeit* of the home.' 'I could not readily find another spot so intimate and *heimlich* as this.' 'We pictured it so comfortable, so nice, so cozy and *heimlich.*' 'In quiet *Heimlichkeit,* surrounded by close walls.'" Swabian and Swiss authors seemed especially susceptible to such notions, as Sanders localized the term in its regional and picturesque spelling: "'How *heimelich* it seemed to Ivo again of an evening, when he was at home.' 'It was so *heimelig* in the house.' 'The warm room and the *heimelig* afternoon.' . . . 'The cottage where he had once sat so often among his own people, so *heimelig,* so happy.'" The word *heimlich* is thereby linked to domesticity (*Häuslichkeit*), to being at home (*heimatlich*) or being neighborly (*freundnachbarlich*).[16]

And yet, lurking behind such images of happiness and erupting through Sanders's own examples, there is the burden of what is definitely not *heimlich:* "The man who till recently had been so strange to him"; "the Protestant landowners [who] do not feel . . . *heimlich* among their Catholic inferiors"; "that which comes from afar [which] assuredly does not live quite *heimelig* among the people." Already conscious of the intrusion of the stranger, Sanders himself seems worried that, as he warns, the original "form of the word deserves to become general in order to protect this perfectly good sense of the word from becoming obsolete"; he fears that *heimlich* will turn on itself and take on the sole meaning of its second major acceptation, that of "concealed, kept from sight, so that others do not get to know of or about it," as in "To do something *heimlich,* i.e., behind someone's back . . . *heimlich* places (which good manners oblige us to conceal)." From home, to private, to privy ("the *heimlich* chamber"), to secret and thereby magic ("the *heimlich* art"), was an all-too-easy slippage. Thence, Sanders noted, it was a small step to *unheimlich*: "Note especially the negative '*un*': eerie, weird, arousing gruesome fear: 'Seeming quite *unheimlich* and ghostly. . . . 'Feels like an *unheimlich*

horror.' '*Unheimlich* and motionless like a stone image.' 'The *unheimlich* mist called hill-fog,'"[17]

Similarly, the brothers Grimm, indefatigable collectors of folklore and myth, defining the word *heimlich* in their own *Deutsches Wörterbuch* (1877), traced the idea of the homely, that which belongs to house and home, a sentiment of security and freedom from fear, as it gradually took on the ominous dimensions of its apparent opposite, the unhomely:

> 4. *From the idea of "homelike," belonging to the house, the further idea is developed of something withdrawn from the eyes of strangers, something concealed, secret. . . .* "Heimlich" is used in conjunction with a verb expressing the act of concealing. . . .
>
> Officials who give important advice which has to be kept secret in matters of state are called *heimlich* councilors; the adjective, according to modern usage, has been replaced by *geheim* [secret]. . . .
>
> *Heimlich*, as used of knowledge—mystic, allegorical: a *heimlich* meaning, *mysticus, divinus, occultus, figuratus. Heimlich* in a different sense, as withdrawn from knowledge, unconscious. . . . *Heimlich* also has the meaning of that which is obscure, inaccessible to knowledge.
>
> *The notion of something hidden and dangerous . . . is still further developed, so that "heimlich" comes to have the meaning usually ascribed to "unheimlich."* Thus: "At times I feel like a man who walks in the night and believes in ghosts; every corner is *heimlich* and full of terrors for him."[18]

Freud was taken with this slow unfolding of the homely into the unhomely, pleased to discover that "*heimlich* is a word the meaning of which develops in the direction of ambivalence, until it finally coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich*" (U 347). Sanders had even produced a citation that demonstrated "that among its different shades of meaning the word *heimlich* exhibits one which is identical with its opposite, *unheimlich.*" This excerpt, from the dramatist Karl Ferdinand Gutzkow, included the phrase "We call it *unheimlich;* you call it *heimlich.*" But Freud the psychoanalyst was even more intrigued by the first part of the passage:

> "The Zecks are all *heimlich.*" . . . "*Heimlich*? . . . What do you understand by *heimlich*?" "Well . . . , they are like a buried spring or a dried-up pond. One cannot walk over it without always having the feeling that the water might come up there again." "Oh, we call it *unheimlich;* you call it *heimlich.*"[19]

This sense of a once-buried spring bursting forth unexpectedly, of the *unheimlich* compared to a disquieting return, was confirmed by

other examples in Sanders that joined the notion of *heimlich* as "concealed" to the sense of something "buried." Thus if sleep was in some way "*heim'lig,*" so cemeteries were "quiet, lovely, and *heimlich*, no place more fitted for their rest," and burial was no more than "To throw into pits or *Heimlichkeiten.*" "I have roots that are most *heimlich,*" cried an author cited by Sanders, "I am grown in the deep earth."[20] In this sense, the *unheimlich* seemed to emerge beneath the *heimlich,* so to speak, to rise up again when seemingly put to rest, to escape from the bounds of home.

Such an ascription was confirmed for Freud by an aphorism again quoted in Sanders and taken from the philosopher Schelling: "*Unheimlich* is the name for everything that ought to have remained . . . secret and hidden but has come to light."[21] It was this phrase that Freud seized upon as the vital clue to his investigation; recurring as a leitmotiv throughout the essay, it offered a veritable "principle" that, intimating a prepsychoanalytic version of "the return of the repressed," permitted him to go beyond the simple "intellectual uncertainty" posited by Jentsch. Indeed the entire argument of "The Uncanny" was to devolve around this apparently simple statement, finally only understandable, according to Freud, by the concept of repression.

Schelling's felicitous "definition" of the uncanny had in fact been extracted by Sanders from the *Philosophie der Mythologie* of 1835, Schelling's late attempt to synthesize the history of religion with the anthropology of cults. Here Schelling had proposed an origin for the uncanny that was itself joined to the origins of religion, philosophy, and poetry. His formulation, anticipating Nietzsche, asserted the necessary existence of the uncanny as a force to be overcome, a first step toward the birth of poetry. Speaking of the Homeric songs, for him among the purest examples of the sublime, Schelling proposed that they were precisely the result of an initial suppression, the civilized subjugation of mystery, myth, and the occult. Like the birth of the Apollonian out of the Dionysian, and with similar effects, the Homeric sublime was founded on the repression of the uncanny:

> Greece had a Homer precisely because it had mysteries, that is because it succeeded in completely subduing that principle of the past, which was still dominant and outwardly manifest in the Oriental systems, and in pushing it back into the interior, that is, into secrecy, into the Mystery (out of which it had, after all, originally emerged). That clear sky which hovers above the

> Homeric poems, that ether which arches over Homer's world, could not have spread itself over Greece until the dark and obscure power of that uncanny principle which dominated earlier religions had been reduced to the Mysteries (all things are called uncanny which should have remained secret, hidden, latent, but which have come to light); the Homeric age could not contemplate fashioning its purely poetic mythology until the genuine religious principle had been secured in the interior, thereby granting the mind complete outward freedom.[22]

This account of the "uncanny principle," besides providing a convenient starting point for Freud—as based on a primal repression, a slaying of the father ("Homer," stated Schelling, "is not the father of mythology, mythology is the father of Homer")[23]—summarized the idea of *unheimlich* as evoked by the romantics. At once a psychological and an aesthetic phenomenon, it both established and destabilized at the same time. Its effects were guaranteed by an original authenticity, a first burial, and made all the more potent by virtue of a return that, in civilization, was in a real sense out of place. Something was not, then, merely haunted, but rather revisited by a power that was thought long dead. To such a force the romantic psyche and the romantic aesthetic sensibility were profoundly open; at any moment what seemed on the surface homely and comforting, secure and clear of superstition, might be reappropriated by something that should have remained secret but that nevertheless, through some chink in the shutters of progress, had returned.[24]

Among the foremost practitioners of the uncanny—what Hegel called that genre of "visionary notions," where "nothing is expressed except a sickness of the spirit," where "poetry runs over into nebulousness, insubstantiality, and emptiness"—Hegel cited the writer E. T. A. Hoffmann, who had for all intents and purposes made the uncanny a genre of his own. It was precisely this aura of indecipherability that attracted Freud to Hoffmann. Hoffmann's stories, further, seemed to present themselves as completely worked examples of Schelling's "theory of the uncanny" in all its possible permutations.

It was in no way accidental that Hoffmann's almost systematic exploration of the relations between the homely and the unhomely, the familiar and the strange, extended to an equally subtle examination of the role of architecture in staging the sensation and in acting as an instrument for its narrative and spatial manifestations. Hoffmann was himself an amateur architect, stageset designer, and

"collector" of strange houses; as a writer and musician the architect he most admired was Karl Friedrich Schinkel, whom he commissioned to design the sets for his opera *Undine*.[25] But the place of architecture in Hoffmann's idea of the uncanny was secured by more than simple allegiance to a talented designer. For romantics of Hoffmann's generation, architecture was central to the task of representing nature, a veritable microcosm of the social and natural world. Kant, after all, had turned it into a metaphor for his entire philosophy, explaining by means of the architectonic the structural relations of thought; for the Young Germans, after Goethe, architecture was, in its Gothic or classical incarnations, a vision of aesthetic perfection—classical as a norm, Gothic as witness to the birth of the nation. Schiller, Schelling, the brothers Schlegel, and later Hegel made architecture a central concern of their aesthetics. Hölderlin, Novalis, and Clemens Brentano found material for their Orphic visions in the temples and fora of an antique Golden Age. Caspar David Friedrich depicted the ruins and traces of a symbolic perfection destroyed by time and the elements. Hoffmann, despite his accentuated irony, found in architecture the tangible sign of a musical harmony unattainable in sound. He also "designed" with meticulous care the settings of his stories, delineating spaces that, sympathetically as it were, resonated to the psychological dimensions of his characters, not simply the illustrations of primitive Gothic terror but the constructed equivalents of the psychological uncanny in architecture.

There are numerous haunted houses in the tales of Hoffmann. The house of the archivist Lindhorst in "The Golden Pot" ("Der Goldne Topf"), for example, is to all intents and purposes a house like any other on its street. Only its door knocker displays signs of the uncanny within. But inside, what might seem to be the familiar spaces of libraries, greenhouses, and studies might turn at any moment into fantastic, semiorganic environments: rooms formed of palms, their gilded leaves covering the ceiling, their bronze trunks standing like organic columns; tropical gardens lit by no outside source of light. Less fantastic but more uncanny, the uninhabited dwelling described in "The Deserted House" ("Das öde Haus") presents itself to the street, like Hugo's ruin, with its openings blocked; its dilapidation strange in comparison with its magnificent boulevard setting, the house was like "a square block of stone pierced by four windows, forming two stories only, a ground floor and a first floor;

. . . cracked and decayed. . . . The four windows were fast shut. Those belonging to the ground floor had been walled up."[26] Finally, Rossitten Castle in "The Deed of Entail" ("Das Majorat") seems only romantic from the outside, a gloomy ruin cursed by the fate of its owners; inside, the rapid transitions from comfortable and secure to uncomfortable and insecure produce a semi–dream effect similar to that of the familiar turned strange.

None of these houses exhibits the structure of the uncanny as well as that described in the tale of "Councillor Krespel" ("Rat Krespel"), however. First published in 1818, then included in the first volume of the *Serapion Brethren (Die Serapions Brüder)* the following year, this story sets out the relationship between the uncanny and architecture without relying on the apparatus of dream, of haunting, or of mystery.[27]

The story opens with an apparently incidental description of the building of a house; on the surface, indeed, as the narrator notes, this is no more than an illustration of one of "the craziest schemes" of this Councillor, himself "one of the most eccentric men" (K 80). The house, described as having been the gift of a local lord in payment for legal services, was built at the bottom of the Councillor's garden according to his own somewhat peculiar specifications. Having bought and assembled all the building materials, stacked and cut the stones, mixed the lime, and sifted the sand, the Councillor had proceeded to amaze the neighbors by refusing all architectural help, directly employing a master mason, journeymen, and apprentices on the work. What was more extraordinary, he had neither commissioned nor drawn up a plan for the house, but had simply excavated a perfectly square foundation for the four walls. These, following his instructions, were built up by the masons, without windows or doors, just as high as the Councillor indicated. Despite the evident madness of this procedure, the builders seemed happy enough, plentifully supplied with food and drink. One day Krespel shouted "Stop!" and the walls were complete (K 80–81).

Then the Councillor began a most strange activity, pacing up and down the garden, moving toward the house in every direction, until, by means of this complex triangulation, he "found" the right place for the door and ordered it cut in the stone; similarly, walking into the house, he performed the same method to determine each window and partition, deciding, seemingly spontaneously, their position and

size. The house was then finished. To celebrate his new home, Krespel invited the builders and their families, but no friends, to a feast at which he played the violin. The result of his maneuvers was a home "presenting a most unusual appearance from the outside—no two windows being alike and so on—but whose interior arrangements aroused a very special feeling of ease" (K 82).

This short, anecdotal introduction serves in Hoffmann's story to present the peculiar character of the musician, lawyer, and violin-maker Krespel, whose beautiful but ill-fated daughter Antonia, blest with an uncannily harmonious singing voice, is trapped within the house, unable to sing lest she die of the effort. In the light of the tale that follows, which recounts the story of Antonia's seduction and final death song, the description of Krespel's crazy house might seem to be one more nonsensical trait of its owner, or at best a literary conceit. The crazy house would then be merely a picturesque fragment, a lively introduction to the tale.

On another level, however, the very eccentricity of Krespel in refusing an architect, the disastrous effects of whose professional drive had been demonstrated in Goethe's own "architectural" novel *Elective Affinities,* might lead us to read Hoffmann's preface as in itself carrying a moral. Perhaps, in the antics of the Councillor, Hoffmann is gently satirizing the myth of the "natural architect," a myth common to the Enlightenment and romantic period alike. In this fable, the architect would be depicted as a Rousseauesque figure, who, left alone in the primeval woods, knew immediately how to build, establishing indeed the very laws of architecture in the raising of the first columns and the framing of the first beams. Krespel as the "antinatural" designer, then, would only make a mess out of his primitive and clumsy gestures, demonstrating, as Hoffmann loved to demonstrate, the negative values of sentimental myths. Following this line of reading, we might also suppose that by refusing the help of an architect (a modern professional) and by employing masons (traditional builders and geometers), Krespel would be a paradigm of the romantic patron, returning to the "roots" of a truly German building by restoring the wisdom of the craft guilds.

Or perhaps Krespel's house should be taken as a kind of paradigm of the beautiful in architecture. Its foundation was erected, after all, on a perfect square; remembering that Krespel was a musician, we might think of the relations, endlessly drawn in classical theory, be-

tween architecture and music, whereby architecture is said in its geometrical harmonies to echo those of music. This too was a favorite romantic analogy: Schelling had announced that "architecture is in general frozen [congealed] music," and had cited the myth of Amphion, who had with his lyre caused the stones to join together to form the walls of Thebes.[28] This idea of architecture as concrete music was widely commented on. In his *Maxims and Reflections* Goethe turned the phrase into "petrified music," and, recalling the myth of Orpheus, qualified his understanding of architecture by finding it a sort of "expired harmony": "the sounds fade away but the harmony lives on."[29] In this sense, Krespel's house might be seen as a large music box, singing on behalf of its occupant, Antonia, who is held mute, save for the first time she was heard to sing, when, finally, the house shone with reflected radiance: "the windows lighted up more brightly than usual." There is little in the crazy exterior of the house to recall the petrified harmonies of Orpheus, those "rhythmic walls" evoked by Goethe, but then Krespel was an extremely unorthodox musician.[30]

Here, along the lines of this synaesthetic analogy, the house might be interpreted as a direct replication in stone of the musical personality of Krespel, replicating not just his outer eccentricity but also his inner soul. We are told that his outer behavior, indeed, is a direct reflection of his inner emotions:

> There are men from whom nature or some peculiar destiny has removed the cover beneath which we hide our own madness. They are like thin-skinned insects whose visible play of muscles seems to make them deformed, though, in fact, everything soon returns to its normal shape again. Everything which remains within us becomes action in Krespel. (K 92)

Thus the apparently "mad" gestures and "irrational" leaps of the Councillor are no more than the external expressions of his spirit, which remains healthy, despite, or maybe because of, the madness on the surface. The chaos of the outer facades of his house, compared to the sense of order within, would be an analogue to this condition of reversed repression. Such a pattern of reversals runs through the whole story, which on every level throws into opposition the terms of apparent madness or evil and revealed sanity or good. The *mise-en-abîme* of upside down and inside out finds its crystallization and prefiguration in the house.

This characterization leads us to a final observation that condemns us no longer to circulate, so to speak, around the house as a metaphor, but permits us to cross over the threshold of an edifice whose structure coincides with the mood of the story and proposes thereby a method for its interpretation. The house, we remember, was described as a house "unusual" from the outside, and homely inside,

> presenting a most unusual [*tollsten,* "mad" or "crazy"] appearance from the outside—no two windows being alike, and so on—but whose interior arrangements aroused a very special feeling of ease [*Wohlbehaglichkeit,* "coziness," "well-being"]. Everyone who went there bore testimony to this. (K 82)

That is, in the terms we have been using, the house was homely inside but most unhomely outside, illustrating Freud's intuition that from the homely house to the haunted house there is a single passage, where what is contained and safe is therefore secret, obscure, and inaccessible, dangerous and full of terrors; that "*heimlich* is a word, the meaning of which develops toward an ambivalence until it finally coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich.*"

But Krespel's house, viewed in these terms, is a structure that in fact reverses the general drift of the uncanny movement from homely to unhomely, a movement in most ghost stories where an apparently homely house turns gradually into a site of horror. Krespel's house makes no attempt to hide its uncanniness on the exterior. In this context, it should be remembered that in fabricating the house Krespel's activities were themselves decidedly *unheimlich*:

> "Make way!" cried Krespel, who then ran to one end of the garden and paced slowly toward his square building. When he came close to the wall, he shook his head in dissatisfaction, ran to the other end of the garden and again paced toward the wall with the same result. He repeated this tactic several times, until finally, *running his hard nose against the wall,* he cried, "Come here, come here men. Make me a door right here." (K 82, my emphasis)

Like a blind man with only his cane and his nose to guide him, Krespel did not, like normal men, see something and then point to it, but rather ran toward something and then touched it. If he saw at all it was with a very "close up," almost haptic, vision. This impression is confirmed in the story when he is described the next day as moving like a drunken or blind man: "He looked as if he would bump into or damage something at any moment," but by some un-

canny sense he avoided breaking the cups on the table and was able to maneuver around a full-length mirror that he initially thought was a void.

Only a partially blind man would be tricked by such a mirror into thinking it was a void. Again, after dinner, fabricating miniature bone objects out of the remains of the rabbit, he is described as operating like a nearsighted jeweler whose eyes enlarge small things, but to whom large things are out of focus. And yet, in literal terms, Krespel can obviously see; it is rather as if he consciously represses the full faculties of sight in order to exercise others, deeper and more potent. This repression of the eye will find its explanation in other uncanny stories by Hoffmann, notably that selected by Freud as the locus of the uncanny itself, "The Sandman" ("Der Sandmann"), a story where the "lust of the eye," as Walter Pater would call it, is played out in every conceivable combination.[31]

In "Der Sandmann," Hoffmann, as Freud observed, privileges the power of the eye; indeed a quantitative reader would estimate more than sixty pairs of eyes described, not to mention the sack of eyes carried by the legendary Sandman, or the "myriad" eyes figured by the flashing eyeglasses of the barometer dealer Coppola, or the incessant repetition of veiled references to eyes in gazes, glances, and visions. The roles of all these oculi might be seen as dividing into two. On the one hand there are the eyes that see everything clearly as it is in the world, like the eyes of Klara, "bright" and "childlike," which see "only the bright surface of the world" (S 287). These are eyes that stop in front of appearance. On the other, there are the more powerful eyes, those of the Sandman, and perhaps of Nathanael, however clouded with sand, eyes that see beyond appearances. The former, clear-sighted eyes are described as mirrors: they reflect the outside world, even as Klara's eyes are "like a lake by Ruïsdael, in which the pure azure of a cloudless sky, the woodlands and flower bedecked fields, and the whole bright and varied life of a lush landscape are reflected" (S 290). The latter, dark-sighted eyes are described as flashing with inner light, with fire; they project rather than reflect, thrusting inner forces onto the outside world, working on it to change and distort it. To the possessors of such potentially lethal intruments, simple mirrors seem lifeless: "'Look at me,' says Klara to Nathanael, 'I have still got my own eyes'; Nathanael looked into Klara's eyes; but it was death that, with Klara's eyes, looked on him

kindly" (S 293). Those who possess only mirrors, those of the homely eyes, however, are not afraid of losing them: the Sandman will not, Klara affirmed, "harm my eyes" (S 287).

But those with inner, uncanny eyes are always fearful of losing their powers of sight; disconnected from the physical eye, the mental eye can all too easily be extinguished, or even vanquished by stronger eyes. Thus Freud will interpret the fear of losing sight as a substitute for the dread of castration, citing "the substitutive relation between the eye and the male organ which is seen to exist in dreams and myths and fantasies" (U 352). In this way, after the father's death, the Sandman appears as destroyer, divider, castrator, impelling Nathanael toward a destructive anxiety of (visual) influence.

There is in *Der Sandmann,* however, a third category of eyes, those mechanical copies that, fabricated either to imitate real eyes, as in the doll Olympia, or to extend the powers of real eyes, as glasses or telescopes, all seem to take on uncanny roles. The spyglass sold by Coppola to Nathanael thus possesses the ability to bring Olympia's artiticial eyes to life: "As he continued to look more and more intently through the glass it seemed . . . as if the power of vision were only now starting to be kindled; her glances were inflamed with ever-increasing life" (S 297). The spyglass has the further power to reduce real eyes to dead ones, as when, casually taking out the glass from his pocket to focus on a strange bush pointed out by Klara, Nathanael looks through it accidentally into Klara's own eyes and is immediately transported to his final vision of the dismembered Olympia, the wooden doll. These mechanical eyes, then, are doubles, the products of art embellishing nature. They add to the already formidable powers of the natural eye, and more often than not they trick it. They are the veritable instruments of trompe l'oeil.

Art as the double of nature, doubling the frightening double existence of man himself, an existence divided between the ego and the ego that observes itself, was a familiar theme in Hoffmann and in romantic literature as a whole. Hoffmann's story entitled "The Doubles" ("Die Doppelltgänger") plays between a painter and his own double, and the double life that is in his art. In another tale, *The Devil's Elixirs (Die Elixiere des Teufels),* art's doubling of nature is referred to the story of Pygmalion who, through desire, brought his statue of Galatea to life. In this case, Hoffmann rewrites this Ovidian story, turning the statue into a painting that uncannily comes to life

for its painter Francesko. In both instances the doubling of art, which succeeds in tricking the eye, is viewed as inherently dangerous. Thus at the end of "The Doubles," Haberland the painter renounces the real Nathalie in favor of a pure ideal that remains in his mind, while in *The Devil's Elixirs,* Francesko's living Venus is a force of the Devil. Art, first invented to ward off the threat of extinction, as in the tracing of a lover's shadow on the wall, is transformed into the demonic sign of death; in this way, as Freud demonstrated, art itself takes on the aspect of the uncanny.

Art is then uncanny because it veils reality, and also because it tricks. But it does not trick because of what is in itself; rather it possesses the power to deceive because of the projected desire of the observer. As Jacques Lacan has noted, the fable of Zeuxis painting grapes that were mistaken by the birds for real fruit implies not that the painter had painted perfect grapes but simply that the eyes of the birds were deceived: "a triumph of the gaze over the eye." Conversely, when the painter Parrhasios triumphed over Zeuxis by depicting a veil on the wall, so lifelike that Zeuxis observed, "well, now show us what you have painted behind it," what was at stake was the *relation* between the gaze of the observer, full of desire to possess, and the trick of the painting.[32] Hence the sinister relation between the double, which is both mask and presentation, and the evil, voracious eye, which demands to be deceived by itself.

No wonder then that Councillor Krespel repressed the power of his eye, deliberately forcing himself to be shortsighted. Krespel was no doublt privileging touch and hearing, the primary senses of the musician; he was also, in the context of a romantic mythology that endowed sight with the sinister properties of destruction—the evil eye—and dissimulation—masking—achieving a kind of willed innocence, through a childlike perception of the world of objects. Only by so doing could he fabricate a house that was not an evil "double," a willed projection of his worst passions, but that was, rather, a house that contained his inner self, whole and untroubled within. And this would be why the outside of the house seemed *unheimlich* and the inside *heimlich;* as a blind transcription, an automatic writing of his undivided soul, it operated as a return route, a passage back from the uncanny to the homely. Even as the Councillor's strange behavior is read by the Professor as an indication that "tomorrow he'll be jogging along at his donkey-trot as usual," so the unfamiliar outside

of the house is a sure indication of familiarity within. "What comes from the earth," the Professor observes, "Krespel returns to the earth, but he knows how to preserve the Divine" (K 92). His crazy house, before the age of analysis, was a mechanism of self-preservation.

In this respect, the house was a therapeutic instrument: Krespel found in this mask of madness a way to rebuff the world and achieve inner composure. This was, after all, a canny way to follow what Hoffmann called his "Serapions Prinzip," which brought together the secular brotherhood in his series of tales of the same name. In this ideal, the outer world was used as a lever to set the inner world of the artist in motion by means of a clear sense of the boundaries between poetry and life. For this the artist had to cultivate a special kind of composure, a *Besonnenheit* or mental state that controlled the release of images and translated stimuli from the outer world into the spiritual domain. As Maria Tatar has concluded, "without this gift, the painter's canvas remains empty, the writer's manuscript consists of blank pages, the composer's score contains not a single note and the artist in general is branded a madman by society."[33] Krespel, before the age of analysis, had preserved his poetic self by means of an artificial boundary, a house that was, in a special sense, a mirror of his soul.

Krespel's house, in its peculiar relationships between exterior and interior, takes its place among many uncanny houses throughout the nineteenth century. Through them, inside and outside, like *heimlich* and *unheimlich,* became the privileged topoi of the uncanny. Thus the typical context for the telling of ghost stories, the apparently homely interior that gradually turns into a vehicle of horror, was described in numerous versions: a cheerful household, generally following dinner, the men smoking pipes before the blazing fire, the women sewing, the children allowed to stay up late. This was the nostalgic evocation of the *veillée,* a "cottage" vision of house and home especially relished in the age of rural displacement and urban emigration. In such a secure setting, stories of terror might be tasted with delight; many writers insisted on the need for a storm outside, to reinforce by contrast the snugness within. Thus the setting of Hoffmann's "Uncanny Guest" ("Der unheimliche Gast"), where "the four ingredients, autumn, a stormy wind, a good fire, and a jorum of punch" engendered a strange sense of the awesome, provoked a fear of the

supernatural, that was then deliciously prolonged by stories that reminded the listeners of the spirit world surrounding them.[34]

Similarly, Thomas De Quincey, an adept in the art of evoking dreams of terror, sometimes with the artificial help of opium, was equally convinced of the need for a secure vantage point from which to start the interior journey. The site of his reveries, stimulated by laudanum, was a simple white cottage, formerly owned by Wordsworth, in the valley of Grasmere. "Embowered by flowering shrubs," this was a homely house, in a sheltered valley, with its simple rooms lined with books and warmed by cheerful hearths.[35] De Quincey, too, insisted on the need for winter and a storm outside for his adventures of the mind, as, almost innocently, he sipped from the ordinary decanter containing the deceptive liquid, an instrument of those fantasies of the architectural sublime that he remembers being described by Coleridge, himself inspired by faulty recollection of Piranesi's *Carceri* etchings.[36]

Building on an already rich tradition of Piranesi "misreading" from Horace Walpole through Loutherbourg to William Beckford, De Quincey adumbrated the first romantic meditation on what might be called the spatial uncanny, one no longer entirely dependent on the temporal dislocations of suppression and return, or the invisible slippages between a sense of the homely and the unhomely, but displayed in the abyssal repetitions of the imaginary void.[37] The vertical labyrinth traced by De Quincey images the artist, Piranesi, caught in a vertigo *en abîme* of his own making, forever climbing the unfinished stairs in the labyrinth of carceral spaces. The passage is celebrated:

> Creeping along the sides of the walls, you perceived a staircase; and upon it, groping his way upwards, was Piranesi himself: follow the stairs a little further, and you perceive it come to a sudden abrupt termination, without any balustrade, and allowing no step onwards to him who had reached the extremity, except into the depths below. Whatever is to become of poor Piranesi, you suppose, at least, that his labors must in some way terminate here. But raise your eyes, and behold a second flight of stairs still higher: on which again Piranesi is perceived, by this time standing on the very brink of the abyss. Again elevate your eye, and a still more aerial flight of stairs is beheld; and again is poor Piranesi busy on his aspiring labors: and so on, until the unfinished stairs and Piranesi both are lost in the upper gloom of the hall.[38]

De Quincey goes beyond a simple Burkean delight in the indeterminacy of ruins, in the sublime, to intimate a fully developed spatial

uncanny. Arden Reed has noted the relations to the Freudian uncanny both in the "omnipotence of thought" displayed by De Quincey's hypnagogic visions and in the space of endless repetition constructed by a reading that conflates all the *Carceri* into a single chain of mental-spatial associations.[39] Such repetition, as Derrida has observed in connection to Freud's own repetition of Neitzsche's affirmation of the "eternal return of the same," has a devilish quality to it; thus, speaking of Freud's own text *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, Derrida notes: "The entire text has a diabolical movement, it mimes walking, it walks without ceasing, but does not advance; it regularly traces out one more step but does not allow the gain of an inch of ground."[40] This endless drive to repeat is then uncanny, both for its association with the death drive and by virtue of the "doubling" inherent in the incessant movement without movement.

Piranesi's drawings, indeed, served many romantics as (always misread) tropes of spatial instability signifying an abyssal drive toward nothingness. De Quincey's report of his conversation with Coleridge gave rise to a long tradition of Piranesi (mis-)interpretation, in which the prison etchings, variously described as dreams, drug-induced deliria, and prisons of the mind, take on the aspect of labyrinths through which the artist wanders, metaphors of the romantic mind.

In this way, Charles Nodier, without acknowledgment but evidently creatively rereading De Quincey, develops the theme with relish in a short story he entitles, significantly enough, "Piranèse," published in 1836, a fable of proto-Borgesian dimensions that evokes the space of interior reflection as a symbol of the endless growth of libraries, the repetition of Babel, the doubling without original of the world in the book.[41] Characterizing a kind of illness that he calls "monomania of reflection" (*monomanie réflective*), Nodier finds its spatial analogue in the vagaries of what he calls Piranesi's "castles in Spain." Here the romantic bibliophile drew a striking distinction between the conventions of the sublime as exhibited in the paintings of John Martin and the strange interior "nightmares" of Piranesi:

> The ruins of Piranesi are about to collapse. They groan, they cry. . . . The effect of his great buildings is no less extraordinary. They produce vertigo, as if one were measuring them from on high, and when you search for the cause of the emotion that inspires you, you are surprised to tremble in fear on one of their cornices, or to see all the objects turn beneath your eyes from the capital of one of their columns.

But *Piranesi's nightmare did not consist in this. I am sure that Martyn* [*sic*] *had the nightmare of space and multitude. Piranesi certainly had the nightmare of solitude and constraint, of the prison and the coffin, of he who lacks air to breathe, voice to cry out and place to struggle.*[42]

In this way Nodier distinguishes the general space of the sublime—that of height, depth, and extension, as characterized by Burke—from that of the uncanny—that of silence, solitude, of internal confinement and suffocation, that mental space where temporality and spatiality collapse. The vertigo of the sublime is placed side by side with the claustrophobia of the uncanny. Thus, imagining a palace built by Piranesi, perhaps the "Ampio magnifico collegio," Nodier contrasts the "imposing grandeur" and "overwhelming magnificence" of the exterior with the interior, still encumbered by the wood and masonry of construction. Nothing is finished, nothing is complete or clear:

The great stair that twists and turns, and the deep vestibule, and the long gallery that leads far off to an even narrower stair, are so obstructed with temporary constructions that it is almost impossible to conceive that the workers can make their way out, and in the imagination one thinks to hear them lament, cry, shout with exhaustion, famine, and despair.

Within this construction, Nodier, like De Quincey, places Piranesi himself, with one foot on the first step, his gaze fixed on the interior whence "an invincible destiny" forces him to climb to the topmost level. This "strange obsession," brought to his spirit by sleep, is both dream and an emblem of the more general fate of the romantic genius: "He must climb, amidst obstacles and dangers, either triumphing or dying." The abyssal space of this ascent is similar to that described by De Quincey, but highly elaborated as a scene of repetitive stages toward infinity.

Oh, how will he make his way, the poor Piranesi, between these close-pressing beams and fragile scaffolds that bend and creak? How will he advance across these unstable posts that are joined to each other by narrow and shaky joists? . . . across this mass of ill-laid stones that overhang and beneath these low and perilous vaults . . . ? One would follow with unease the subtle path of the lightest lizard!

Piranesi climbs nevertheless, and, even though the mind can hardly imagine it, Piranesi arrives.—He arrives, alas, at the foot of a building similar to the first, access to which presents the same difficulties, menacing him with the same perils, demanding the same effort, in yet greater proportion, mag-

nified by his tiredness, exhaustion, and also his old age. . . . Nevertheless, Piranesi climbs again; he must climb and climb and arrive.—And he arrives.

He arrives, overburdened, decrepit, broken, feeble as a shadow; he has arrived at the bottom level of a building similar to the first buildings. . . .

In this way, Piranesi climbs on forever through a space that, still pictorially controlled by the laws of perspective, diminishes while repeating, "until the moment when [the buildings] are lost at a distance hardly measurable by the imagination." At this point, even Piranesi himself, "Piranesi who regards each new building with terror, who climbs, who walks, who arrives, near to ceding to the inexpressible sadness of never arriving the end of his suffering," becomes "imperceptible . . . like a black point on a fading level almost lost in the depth of the skies." Beyond this, Nodier asserts with some relief, "there is nothing but space."[43]

This long and deliberately exhausting *promenade architecturale* has, for Nodier, the function of delineating the space of "morbid sleep," of the "intolerable torture" involved in the monomania of internal reflection, where "all impressions are prolonged without end, where every minute becomes a century." It serves as the prelude to an equally uncanny exploration of the mental space of Count G., a rich bachelor, who, having determined to retire from the world, planned the restoration of the interior of his chateau according to the "fantastic plan of a Piranesian palace." The literal construction of such a space, a "labyrinth of stones," hides the solitary retreat of the proprietor, who, like some character from De Sade's *120 Jours,* defends himself from the world by an almost impassable network of broken connections: "galleries which were only to be circumnavigated with patience and courage; narrow stairs, alternatively mounting and descending, cut by dark and confusing corridors which led nowhere. . . ." Only the narrowest passerelle, to be crossed with terror, led to the Count's apartment, an almost impenetrable asylum, where for three years the proprietor lived in solitary meditation "like the stylite on his column." Found peacefully in death on his bed, at the heart of this interiorization of Babel, he had succeeded in attaining a degree of "alienation" that was not, Nodier stresses, the madness described by the doctors. Like that distantiation (also described by Nodier) achieved by a scholar who, desiring solitude, retreated from the world in an apartment strung with cables on which he balanced further and further from the door, this was a "strange alienation that leaves free

all the other faculties of high intelligence . . . the fanaticism of perfectibility.[44] Such interiority was, in Nodier's terms, the true site of the uncanny, the final place of resistance against "the progress of progress."[45]

The passage from homely to unhomely, now operating wholly in the mind, reinforced the ambiguty between real world and dream, real world and spirit world, so as to undermine even the sense of security demanded by professional dreamers. Following Kant's prescription for the achievement of delight through terror through certain knowledge of safety—"provided our own position is secure, [the aspect of terrifying natural phenomena] is all the more attractive for its fearfulness"—the aesthete of terror succeeded in barricading the walls against nature in order to indulge a taste for fear. But with the locus of the uncanny now shifted to the mind, such barriers were difficult to maintain, dissolving readily into the fabric of the dream, haunting the site of its own dread.

Thus the *veillée*, or "stay-up-late evening" as Michael Riffaterre translates the title of Rimbaud's poem,[46] becomes itself uncanny, its security belied and clouded by its anticipated end, from the nights when, as in Hoffmann's story, Nathanael's father awaits the arrival of the Sandman, sitting silently in his armchair "blowing out billows of smoke till we all seemed to be swimming in clouds" (S 278), to that evening described by Rimbaud when mantle shelf and wallpaper merge with the dream of a voyage, only to return as the sign of normalcy and thereby of death.

> The light returns to the roof post. From the two sides of the room, commonplace scenes, harmonious elevations merge. The wall facing the watchman is a psychological succession of fragments of friezes, atmospheric bands, geological faults.—Intense and rapid dream of sentimental groups with beings of all characters among all appearances.[47]

It is out of the meeting of such a *veillée* and the modern city that Rimbaud would develop his own vision of the Piranesian abyss—the "Villes" of *Illuminations*.

From Hoffmann to Rimbaud, in short stories and in many *veillées*, smoke is thus an agent of dissolution by which the fabric of the house is turned into the depth of the dream; in the same way, as an instrument of the sublime, smoke has always made obscure what otherwise would have seemed too clear.

Nothing seemed to be more settled, more at home, than the life of the narrator of Melville's short story "I and My Chimney" as he sat contentedly puffing his pipe beside an equally puffing chimney stack.[48] Resisting modernization and determined to maintain an amicable pact between himself and his old, silent friend, the chimney, this narrator has indeed captured the imagination of those who have seen something pragmatic and sturdily "American" in finding the center of the home in the fire: a tradition of settler origins, rooted in the anthropology of Semper and finding its architectural expression in the Prairie homesteading of Frank Lloyd Wright.[49]

Certainly the narrator loved his chimney; it provided warmth and stability for the entire house, as structure and function; it did not, like his wife, "talk back," and it represented, symbolically enough, a last bastion of the good past against the intrusions of a bad present. And yet the chimney, as he readily admitted, was something of a tyrant. Twelve feet square at the base, four feet wide at the top, it completely usurped the center of the house, permitting no passage from one side to another, forcing the inhabitants into continual peripheral movement. So strong was its presence, indeed, that the narrator had become its slave. The chimney was master of the house; its "owner" stood behind it, deferring to it on every count, finally protecting it from destruction by withdrawing from the outer world and mounting a continuous vigil lest it be demolished while his back was turned. Fear pervades this story: fear of being deprived of a "backbone" with the removal of the chimney; fear of losing the "one permanence" of the dwelling; fear of confrontation with the wife; fear, given the chimney's shape and vertical power, of loss of manhood.

The chimney provided another kind of support also. It was the central object of the narrator's fantasy life; at once a reminder of the distant pyramids of Egypt and the dark Druidical ritual standing stones, it stood for the entire romantic history of origins, an urmonument, both life-giving and life-taking, harbinger of the eternal fire and tomb of kings. It was further an instrument of knowledge, an observatory pointed toward the heavens. In its bulk almost incommensurable, irreducible to the mathematical calculations of the architect (contemptuously called "Scribe"), it could not be cut down to size. Its inner recesses hiding unknown mysteries and its external walls impermeable and silent, it was, as Hegel would have character-

ized it, the perfect type of *symbolic* architecture, an object not yet separated from the magical world of demons or the projected fantasies of men. Around this pyramid-tomb the house deployed itself, depending on the chimney for sustenance and support; because of its position, it was a kind of labyrinth protecting the inner center from profane intrusion. The resulting confusion of rooms, each forced to act as a passage to the next, one with as many as nine doors, generated a complex network of relations: "almost every room like a philosophical system, was in itself an entry, or passageway to other rooms and systems of rooms, a whole suite of entries in fact." Like the daydreamer whose mental map these rooms seemed to emulate, "going through the house you seem to be forever going somewhere and getting nowhere." Indeed, one might entirely lose one's way: "it is like losing oneself in the woods; round and round the chimney you go, and if you arrive at all it is just where you started and so you begin again and get nowhere."[50]

We are reminded of the similar pattern of uncanny repetition in Freud's description of his strange experience of a particular quarter in a provincial town, "the character of which could not long remain in doubt," as painted women filled the windows of the small houses.

> I hastened to leave the narrow street at the next turning. But after having wandered about for a time without inquiring my way, I suddenly found myself back in the same street, where my presence was now beginning to excite attention. I hurried away once more, only to arrive by another *detour* at the same place yet a third time. Now however a feeling overcame me which I can only describe as uncanny. (U 359)

Freud compared this "involuntary repetition" that transformed a peaceful Italian town (Genoa) into a site of Piranesian claustrophobia to being lost in the mist in a mountain forest, where "every attempt to find the marked or familiar path may bring one back again and again to one and the same spot," or to the experience of being lost in "a dark, strange room," "looking for the door or the electric switch," colliding time after time with the same piece of furniture (U 359). Melville's narrator had a similar sense of helplessness before the uncanny might of his chimney, and he seemed equally unwilling to track down the unconscious motivations of his "involuntary" acts.

This need to veil the source of dependency was mirrored in the narrator's resistance to deciphering or interpreting his hermetic

chimney. It was as if his own body were threatened with extinction. He preferred the pyramid to remain a primal force, before writing, resisting all explanation, like the hieroglyphs before Champollion. Even when, as a last resort to persuade the owner to demolish the chimney, the architect invented the fiction of a "reserved space hermetically closed . . . a secret chamber . . . hid in darkness," the narrator refused to search. Not because he did not believe in its existence, but rather the opposite: he believed too much in mysteries. What the chimney concealed, its and his nether world, should remain concealed. "Infinite and sad mischief," he held, "has resulted from the profane bursting open of secret recesses," thus precisely repeating Schelling's principle. By this means, a kind of tacit treaty was reached between the subversive and comforting powers of the house, allowing it, during the life of its owner at least, to remain a home.

Homes for Cyborgs

The cyborg is resolutely committed to partiality, irony, intimacy, and perversity. It is oppositional, utopian, and completely without innocence. No longer structured by the polarity of public and private, the cyborg defines a technological polis based partly on a revolution of social relations in the *oikos*, the household. Nature and culture are reworked; the one can no longer be the resource for appropriation or incorporation by the other.

Donna Haraway, "A Manifesto for Cyborgs"

If, for the first machine age, the preferred metaphor for the house was industrial, a "machine for living in," the second machine age would perhaps privilege the medical: the house as at once prosthesis and prophylactic. In the Corbusian "home of man" technology took the form of more or less benign "object-types" and perfectly controlled environments that allowed for the full play of the natural body in nature. The line between nature and the machine, between the organic and the inorganic, seemed crystal clear; organicism was a metaphor, not a reality. Now, the boundaries between organic and inorganic, blurred by cybernetic and bio-technologies, seem less sharp; the body, itself invaded and reshaped by technology, invades and permeates the space outside, even as this space takes on dimensions that themselves confuse the inner and the outer, visually, mentally, and physically. "L'homme-type," the modulor muscleman, has through a combination of prosthetic devices, drugs, and body sculpture emerged as Cyborg, a potentially gender-free mutant, and its home is no longer a house. As Walter Benjamin presciently observed, "The work of Le Corbusier seems to arise when the 'house' as mythological configuration approaches its end."[1]

In the terms introduced by Donna Haraway, cyborg culture, a product of late capitalist technology, is at once an all-embracing and controlling reality and a utopia full of promise. The totalizing and hegemonic power of "modern production seems," in Haraway's words, "like a dream of cyborg colonization of work, a dream that makes the nightmare of Taylorism seem idyllic." But it also, she argues, opens up the possibility of a political struggle over the different boundaries it cuts through: the boundaries between the human and the animal, the animal-human organism and the machine, the physical and the nonphysical. "Late twentieth-century machines have made thoroughly ambiguous the difference between natural and artificial, mind and body, self-developing and externally designed. . . . Our machines are disturbingly lively, and we ourselves frighteningly inert."[2] For Haraway, it is precisely in the interstices of these differences, in "the simultaneity of breakdowns," that the "matrices of domination" might be cracked open and, in the "pollution" that results, a new political and social practice opened up. Such a practice, she hopes, will create the conditions of a gender independence through the construction of what Alice Jardine has dubbed "Technobodies" by means of medicotechnologies of reproduction, transplants, and the like.[3]

The implications of this metamorphosis for architecture are more radical than even Reyner Banham would have envisaged. No longer are we fooled by the promise of the house as a bubble-container that frees its human contents from the vicissitudes of external environment: neither the Dymaxion dome nor the spacesuit reflects the infinite permeability assumed by the contemporary skin, the interchangeability of body part and technical replacement, or the spatio-mental reconstruction implied by the cyberspace. This complex and impure system of existence, indeed, offers neither the luminous promise of technological utopia nor the dark hell of its opposite. The sleeper in *When the Sleeper Wakes,* H. G. Wells's turn-of-the-century dystopia, was faced with a clear confrontation between the scientific and the social; the hacker in William Gibson's *Neuromancer* no longer knows the difference between waking and sleeping.

In such a context, architectural exploration, as Elizabeth Diller and Ricardo Scofidio have understood it, might best be limited to the precise dimensions of a controlled experiment. In a world of infinitely disseminated power—of surveillance, of the image, of the technolog-

ical—the stylistic metaphor is as suspect as the functional solution. In their place, the minute and exactly calibrated interrelations of body and machine are subjected to a dispassionate scrutiny, transcribed as the automatic writing of a generation of readymades. These calculations take as their starting point the clearly distinguished systems identified by modernist technique: the system of the object, of the body, of the optical, and finally of the home. Each of these is carefully unwrapped, disassembled, and confronted, as it were, defenseless, to the next. The sites of these strategic deployments emerge as so many battlefields, strewn with the disemboweled residues of yesterday's biotechnical encounters: "no-man's-lands" or homes for cyborgs.

Cyborgs and their homes, of course, have a respectable prehistory in the modern period, in the monstrous merging of animal and human so characteristic of surrealist imagery. As Haraway writes, "The cyborg appears in myth precisely where the boundary between human and animal is transgressed. Far from signalling a walling off of people from other living beings, cyborgs signal a disturbingly tight coupling."[4]

Such coupling has its own history. Thus the gentle horse-headed women and boys that populate Leonora Carrington's *House of Fear* and its illustrations by Max Ernst seem deliberately to transpose the attributes of the centaur and the unicorn in gender and implication. As Carrington herself remarked, "A horse gets mixed up with one's body . . . it gives energy and power. I used to think I could turn myself into a horse."[5] From the figure of Fear, in the Castle of Fear, who "looked slightly like a horse," in Carrington's text and Ernst's collage, through the Oval Lady, who holds the secret of turning herself into a living version of her rocking horse, to little Francis, a mask for Carrington herself, who grows a horse's head, these equine presences play on the register of sexual and mental ambiguities with evident autobiographical reference. It was, after all, Father who burned the rocking horse to punish the Oval Lady for even desiring to be a horse, and Francis whose horse's shape at once displayed his shame at failing to be woman and his androgynous desire. Carrington's horse-people seem to prefigure Haraway's separatist cyborgs.

Carrington's homes for androgynes are equally filled with a mixture of organic and inorganic objects: thus Uncle Ubriaco's workroom in "Little Francis" was "a spacious apartment on the ground floor filled with half-constructed constructions and wholly demolished bicycles. The walls were lined with bookshelves that held books, spare

tires, bottles of oil, chipped figureheads, spanners, hammers, and reels of thread."[6] A series of books—*Man and Bicycle, Intricacies of Pedals, Tobson's Essays on Spokes and Bells, Free Wheels and Ball Bearings*—was piled beside a heterogeneous collection that included starved cockroaches in a small cage, a string of artificial onions, a spinning wheel, ladies' corsets of a complicated pattern, and a great many cogwheels.

For Carrington and the surrealists in general, these semiorganic and dream objects were arrayed to counter the implacable rationalism of purely technological modernism, epitomized in the shape of the Father, who, in the "Oval Lady," seemed "more like a geometric figure than anything else," and who achieved grotesque proportions in the character of Egres Lepereff, "The Great Architect," in "Little Francis." Based on Serge Chermayeff, appointed a surrogate parent during Carrington's stay in London, this designer of guillotines for the execution of boys like Francis espoused "good machinery and efficient planning," which "are always artistically moving." "My platform . . . was pleasing," purred the Architect, "though utterly devoid of anything save the merest mechanical necessities. It was a symphony of pure form." Francis himself was less certain that "architecture . . . in modern art is the nearest form to pure abstraction," observing innocently, "But if you build abstract houses, the more abstract you make them the less there'll be there, and if you get abstraction itself there won't be anything at all."[7]

Surrealism's antipathy to modernism, reflected in the well-known quarrels between André Breton and Le Corbusier, was, on the surface, based on this suspicion of abstraction. For Breton, modernist functionalism was "the most unhappy dream of the collective unconscious," a "solidification of desire in a most violent and cruel automatism." The argument was elaborated by other surrealists: Dalí in his exaltation of the art nouveau, with its "terrifying and edible beauty"; Hans Arp's championing of the "elephant style" against the "bidet style"; Tristan Tzara's indictment of modern architecture as "the complete negation of the image of the dwelling." All posed a volatile and elusive sensibility of mental-physical life against what was seen as a sterile and overrationalized technological realism: the life of the interior psyche against the externalizing ratio.

Le Corbusier himself summarized the opposing positions succinctly in his only contribution to a quasi-surrealist journal—a note on the

work of the psychologically troubled artist Louis Soutter, in an article published in *Minotaure* in 1936. To Soutter's remark, "The minimum house or future cell should be in translucent glass. No more windows, these useless eyes. Why look outside?," Corbusier replied,"This affirmation of Louis Soutter . . . is the very antithesis of my own ideas, but it manifests the intense interior life of the thinker."[8] For Le Corbusier, looking always, as Beatriz Colomina has observed, toward a universally transparent exteriority, the attempt to reenvision the objects of daily life metaphorically was misguided, leading to a dangerous imbalance in the human "technico-cerebral-emotional equation," the creation of a "sentiment-object" rather than an object of use. As Benjamin noted, it was in this debate that the essence of modernity might be summarized: "To embrace Breton and Le Corbusier—that would be to draw the spirit of contemporary France like a bow which strikes with knowledge to the heart of the present."[9]

Against the cold rationalism of the modernists, the surrealists called for an architecture more responsive to psychological needs: what Tristan Tzara termed an "intrauterine architecture" was thus conceived as a radical criticism of the house of Corbusian and Miesian rationalism. "Modern architecture," Tzara argued, "as hygienic and stripped of ornaments as it wants to appear, has no chance of living." Against the horizontal extensions and the dissolution of the barriers between public and private implied by the Domino model, Tzara posed the maternal and sheltering images of "uterine" constructions which, from the cave to the grotto and the tent, comprised the fundamental forms of human habitation:

> From the cave (for man inhabits the earth, "the mother"), through the Eskimo yurt, the intermediary form between the grotto and the tent (remarkable example of uterine construction which one enters through cavities with vaginal forms), through to the conical or half-spherical hut furnished at its entrance with a post of sacred character, the dwelling symbolizes prenatal comfort.

> Entered through "cavities of vaginal form," these conical or half-spherical houses were dark, tactile, and soft. They imitated the play-constructed shelters of childhood.

> When one returns what was torn away during adolescence and childhood, *man* could possess those realms of "luxe, calme et volupté" that he constructed for himself beneath the bed covers, under tables, crouching in

cavities of earth, above all at the narrow entry; when it is seen that well-being resides in the *clair-obscur* of the tactile and soft depths of the only hygiene possible, that of prenatal desires, it will be possible to reconstruct the circular, spherical, and irregular houses that mankind has conserved from the time of the caves to the cradle and the grave, in his vision of intrauterine life which knows nothing of that aesthetics of castration called modern. This will not, in valorizing these arrangements with the acquisitions of actual life, be a return to the past, but a real progress, based on the potentiality of our most strong desires, strong because latent and eternal, the possibility of being liberated normally. The intensity of these desires has not changed much since the stage of man's savagery; only the forms and satisfactions have been broken up and dispersed over a larger mass, and, enfeebled to the point of being lost, with their acuity, the sense of true reality and quietude, they have, by their very degeneration, prepared the way for that autopunitive aggressivity that characterizes modern times.[10]

In Tzara's mingling of popular psychology and primitivism—his observations on architecture were published in *Minotaure* following Michel Leiris's illustrations of Dogon huts in 1933—we can identify a double nostalgia. On the one hand, the return to archetypal forms marks an identification with the origins of civilization and an explicit critique of its technological results, human and material; on the other, the notion of womb *as* origin displays a familiarity with Freudian explanations of desire and the repressed or displaced routes of homesickness: "There is a joking saying that 'Love is homesickness,'" Freud had written in 1919, "and whenever a man dreams of a place or a country and says to himself while he is still dreaming: 'This place is familiar to me, I've been there before,' we may interpret the place as being his mother's genitals or her body" (U 368). It is no doubt in this light that we may interpret Tzara's desire that "the architecture of the future will be intrauterine if it has resolved the problems of comfort and material and sentimental well-being, if it renounces its role of interpreter-servant of the bourgeoisie whose coercive will can only separate mankind from the ways of its destiny."[11]

Such nostalgia, however, hardly evoked the comforting images of hearth and home that were, during the same period, being raised by philosophers of the *Heimat* from Tessenow to Heidegger. For the apparently warm and all-enclosing interiors of intrauterine existence were, as Freud pointed out, at the same time the very centers of the uncanny. At once the refuge of inevitably unfulfilled desire and the

potential crypt of living burial, the womb-house offered little solace to daily life.[12]

Thus, Matta Echaurren's "intrauterine" design for an apartment dedicated to the senses, published in *Minotaure* 11, in 1938, was a deliberate attack on the commonplaces of the bourgeois home. The perspective view shows materials and forms that merge nature and the inorganic, the mathematical and the tactile. It was, Matta noted, "a space that will bring into consciousness human verticality." A true vertigo machine, composed of "different levels, a stair without a handrail to overcome the void," it was also a space of psychological interaction. Its columns were "psychological Ionic"; its furnishings "supple, pneumatic." Matta specified inflatable rubber, cork, paper, and plaster for the soft areas, all for better contrast, framed in an "armature of rational architecture." The whole space simulated a kind of artificial womb.

> Man looks back at the dark pulsions of his origin which enveloped him with humid/dank walls where the blood pulsed close to the eye with the noise of the mother . . . we must have walls like damp sheets which deform themselves and join with our psychological fears . . . the body insinuated as into a mold, as into a matrix based on our movements.[13]

It was the task of the architect, Matta concluded, "to find for each individual those umbilical cords that put us in communication with other suns, objects in total freedom that would be like plastic psychoanalytical mirrors." Frederick Kiesler's "Endless House," designed in multiple versions between 1924 and 1965, was similarly conceived. Hans Arp spoke of this "egg"-like form as if it were the egg of Columbus: "In his egg, in these spheroid egg-shaped structures, a human being can now take shelter and live as in his mother's womb."[14]

This blurring of lines between the mental and physical, the organic and inorganic, was, for the surrealists, one of the characteristic pleasures of art nouveau. Dalí's celebrated eulogy to Gaudi's "edible" architecture had stressed its images of metamorphosis, of all historical styles merging into each other, of the intersection of the biological and the constructional, building and psychoanalysis, architecture and hysteria, in order to produce the ultimate object of desire, or at least its reification. Characterized by its mimesis of the digestible—gates with panels like pieces of calves' liver, columns with bases that seemed

to say "eat me!," buildings that as a whole might be assimilated to cakes—it was an architecture that, in Dalí's words "verified that urgent 'function,' so necessary for the amorous imagination: to be able in the most literal way possible to eat the object of desire."[15] Opposed to modern functionalism in every way, the Style 1900 discovered its real functions in the appetites and desires.

A "traumatism" for art, this style equally modeled itself on the postures of human trauma and psychosis. Using Charcot's photographs of female hysterics at the Salpêtrière, Dalí drew a "psychopathological parallel" between these images of "ecstasy" and the carving of the art nouveau.

> Invention of "hysterical sculpture."—Continuous erotic ecstasy.—Contractions and attitudes without antecedents in the history of statuary (I refer to the women discovered and understood after Charcot and the School of the Salpêtrière).—Confusion and ornamental exacerbation in relation to pathological communications; precocious dementia.—Close relations to the dream; reveries, day dreams.—Presence of characteristic oneiric elements: condensation, displacement, etc.—Blossoming of the sado-anal complex.—Flagrant ornamental coprophagy. Very slow, exhausting onanism, accompanied by a huge feeling of guilt.[16]

The well-known theory of surrealist-inspired ecstasy that followed, summarized in Dalí's collage "Le phénomène de l'exstase," with its focalization of ears ("always in ecstasy") and juxtaposition of Charcot's photographs with art nouveau sculpture, also included a telling image of a tipped chair, empty as if having thrown its contents out of the picture.

This uncanny property of objects to adopt the characteristic behavior of their owners, thence to take revenge, the habit of the inanimate to take on the characteristics of the animate, and vice versa, had already been recognized by Freud. In a passage that seems to anticipate Ernst's collages, he speaks of the naive story of the haunted table from the *Strand Magazine*:

> I read a story about a young married couple who move into a furnished house in which there is a curiously shaped table with carvings of crocodiles on it. Towards evening an intolerable and very specific smell begins to pervade the house; they stumble over something in the dark; they seem to see a vague form gliding over the stairs—in short, we are given to understand that the presence of the table causes ghostly crocodiles to haunt the place, or that the wooden monsters come to life in the dark, or something of the

sort. It was a naive enough story, but the uncanny feeling it produced was quite remarkable. (U 367)

This sensation, evoked, Freud explains, by an "over-accentuation of physical reality in comparison with material reality," was the precise equivalent of Dalí's architecture of "hyper-materialism." Le Corbusier characterized the sensibility, accurately enough, as a disturbance in the balance of "our tehnico-cerebro-emotional equation," an overinvestment of "sentiment" in objects, to the extent that "the feeling for cause and effect falters. We are seized by disquiet because we no longer feel well-adapted; we revolt against our enforced servitude to the *abnormal.*"[17]

And yet, of course, modernism's own object imaginary was hardly less disquieting. Walter Benjamin, indeed, went beyond Dalí's simple opposition to make the conceptual link between the technical visions of modernism and the apparent antitechnical stance of art noveau. Benjamin, who cited Dalí on the "delirious and cold buildings" of art nouveau, formulated a vision of the Jugendstil that was, in reality, an "attempt of art to take the measure of technique."[18] Precisely because, Benjamin argued, the Jugendstil considered itself no longer "menaced" by technique, it could identify itself with technique. Thus he noted the correspondence between the curving lines of art nouveau and their modern counterparts, electric wires, which in turn paralleled the nerves of the modern city dweller: "In the characteristic line of the art nouveau are brought together—united in a montage of imagination—the nerve and the electric wire (and which in particular brings into contact the world of organism and of technique by means of the intermediary form of the neurovegetal system)."[19] For Benjamin, this intersection of technology and nature was represented by the displacement of symbols from romanticism to modernism.

Here we may begin to trace the affiliations of surrealism and modernism on the level of technique, affinities that were announced by Benjamin himself in the aphorism: "The reactionary attempt that seeks to detach the forms imposed by technique from their functional context and to make natural constants out of them—that is to say, to stylize them—is found sometime after art nouveau, in a similar form, in futurism." The structure that united the two, in Benjamin's terms, was fetishism. For it was fetishism that, in its multiple displacements,

"suppresses the barriers that separate the organic from the inorganic world," that is "at home in the world of the inert as in the world of the flesh."[20] Such confusions of identity were, as Sigfried Giedion noted, the inevitable product of the modern mechanization of the dwelling in its mission of repression against the bric-a-brac of the nineteenth century.[21] Giedion observes of the interiors of Ernst's *Une semaine de bonté*,

> Of the billowing drapes, of the murky atmosphere, Ernst's scissors make a submarine cave. Are these living creatures, plaster statues or models of the academic brush found reclining here or rotting? To this question no answer can or should be given. The room, as nearly always, is oppressive with assassination and non-escape.[22]

Surrealism and purism, indeed, fetishized precisely the same *types* of objects: what for surrealists were "objets trouvés" or vehicles of oneiric desire and for Le Corbusier were "objets-membres-humains," or the physical extensions of the body. As Le Corbusier himself recognized,

> The new "Surrealists" (formerly Dadaists) claim to lift themselves above the brute nature of the object and are ready to recognize only relationships which belong to the invisible and subconscious world of the dream. Nevertheless they compare themselves to radio antennae; thus they raise radio onto their own pedestal . . . the supremely elegant relationships of their metaphors . . . are all the time very clearly dependent on the products of straightforward conscious effort . . . the finality necessary to polished steel.

To prove the point Le Corbusier cited De Chirico, writing in the first number of *La Révolution Surréaliste,* December 1924: "They are like levers, as irresistible as those all-powerful machines, those gigantic cranes which raise high over the teeming building sites sections of floating fortresses with heavy towers like the breasts of ante-diluvian mammals."[23]

In this dependency of surrealist fantasy on the real objects of the machine world, "type objects" and "sentiment objects" met in their common aim to overcome technique in its banal manifestations in favor of a technological imaginary that would transform technology into the human and vice versa, into the prosthetic and potentially critical devices of the cyborg. It was not by chance that Walter Benjamin identified Olympia, the automat doll of E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Sandman" and subject of Freud's analysis of the uncanny, as the

ideal woman of the art nouveau. "The extreme point of the technical organization of the world," concluded Benjamin, "consists in the liquidation of fertility."

The modern cyborg was, in this way, anticipated by the automat, with its long tradition in romantic thought, from Hoffmann's Olympia to Mary Shelley's monster, from Villiers de L'Isle-Adam's *Eve future* to Duchamp's "Bride." These "celibate machines" were, as Lyotard has observed, all ruses, fabricated to obscure the essential impossibility of mechanically dominating nature, to blur the distinctions between the biological and the technical; the first such contraption was constructed by Hephaistos for Zeus and named Pandora.[24] Indeed, following Diller and Scofidio's experiments with the staging of Duchamp's Large Glass, we might hazard that their project includes a careful opening of the box belonging to that first "automate," as Alice Jardine has redubbed her, in order to expose the ruse of modernism.[25]

Conceived of in these terms, the objects of architecture become so many prostheses, extensions of the body tied to it in almost organic ways; instruments that, as Michel de Certeau has characterized them, might be defined according to their functions:

> Two main operations characterize their activities. The first seeks primarily to *remove* something excessive, diseased, or unaesthetic from the body, or else to *add* to the body what it lacks. Instruments are thus distinguished by the action they perform: cutting, tearing out, extracting, removing, etc., or else inserting, installing, attaching, covering up, assembling, sewing together, articulating etc.—without mentioning those substituted for missing or deteriorated organs, such as heart valves and regulators, prosthetic joints, pins implanted in the femur, artificial irises, substitute ear bones, etc.[26]

Of course, most of the object types conceived by modernism were prosthetic to one degree or another: Le Corbusier never tired of vaunting the claims of "objets-membres-humains," those type objects responding to type needs and type functions and operating as liberating extensions of our limbs—"chairs to sit on, tables to work at, devices to give light, machines to write with (ah! yes), racks to file things in." a "human limb object," properly designed to harmonize with the body, would act for all the world like "a docile servant. A good servant is discreet and self-effacing in order to leave his master free."[27]

The modernist prosthetic object was equally a master: the etiquette machines fabricated by Schreber for his children—to construct correct posture while lying, sitting, and standing—as well as the taylorized furniture of the Gilbreths were all so many devices to control the body for its own good, chastity belts for the machine age, bringing the organic into line with the social and economic systems of industrial production.

Against this, the object types of Diller and Scofidio neither serve nor dictate; they simply reveal. Peeling back the layers of consumer coverings, Bauhaus black or suburban veneer, they show the form of the guts inside. Televisions are transformed into biological analog through disemboweling, their tubes, wires, and connections left bare, as if to demonstrate their temporary, makeshift nature. On the one hand enfeebled and weak, cut open and wounded, these machines are at the same time threatening, as they parade the enormous power of the technologically constructed microorganism invading the house.

But these operations are not entirely neutral: beginning as a ready-made, the unmade object is itself subjected to a subtle transformation and mutation that points not only to its internal nature but also to its expanded field of operation, its relation to the body. Thus the television screen, shifted from vertical to horizontal, is no longer the focus of a conventional view but now reflected in a mirror that takes its place. The screen, simulacrum of the real, is literally displaced through a simulacrum of itself, at the same time as its controlling (picture-frame) position has been unfixed and refracted through the action of the mirror. Similarly, chairs, which normally would image as well as serve comfort, are cut through in order to threaten the (sitting) body at its most vulnerable point.

Such objects are no longer subject to subjects; they counterattack. As in the collages of Max Ernst, they unionize in revolt, but now in the form of critical machines that pose new identities for their subjects. As apparatuses that both work on and fuse with once-separate bodies, they, like the cyborgs that "use" them, scramble all the recognized codes. Such objects fight back, they machine us as much as we machine them. Indeed, the only resistance, as many of the visitors to Diller and Scofidio's 1990 installation at the Museum of Modern Art realized, was to fall back on the commonplace reading of the objects, using the mirror for making up and envisioning the chair in

the air as a misplaced seat. The network of relations established among objects becomes itself a phenomenal prosthetic for the body, to be refused by normalcy.

If, at one level, the body can be interpreted as a construction determined by the discursive practices of its surveillance and punishment, in the literal constructions of Diller and Scofidio the body both transcribes itself and is written on. The chair that leaves a message impressed on the buttocks—the right way round for another to read—is a machine for transcription. But, unlike Kafka's writing machine that inscribed the name of the punishment in the flesh of the victim, these architectural "magic writing pads" leave only temporary marks. In this way, the states of the modern body are mirrored in reactive structures. Cybernetic and biotechnical operations—hacking, probing—are given material life through the physical exploration of inside and out and the optical scanning of a myriad blind eyes that observe without knowing.

Here the optical networks set up by screen and camera, observer and observed, stage a voyeuristic space in which objects and subjects alike are trapped *en abîme*. But while the apparent trajectories of the eye, marked by the intersecting visual cones of so many lenses, seem to replicate the laws of true vision, in fact the space is traversed by the lines of a "pseudo-optics" established not so much by the geometries of real optical systems as by the psychology of the viewers. And viewers are equally absent in this simulated science where objects take their place, describing an optical scene that both includes and excludes subjects, or rather includes them in the form of a system of virtual signs. In this way an empty chair will "stand in" for its user, closing the system from the outside, as if obligingly supplying itself in the position of the hypothetical spectator of Goya's *Las Meninas,* no longer a technical instrument but a psychological contrivance.

No-body, then, can place itself at the central projection point in this optical system, which operates as a kind of literalization of post-Lacanian space. We who have become used to the diagram of our historically relative, rapidly changing perceptual structures, from Alberti's perspectival window to Nietzsche's labyrinth, are now presented with their archaeological reconstructions, each in conflict with the next, literalized by means of objects that project each system's sinister implications.

The gaze intimated by these layered and fractured cones of vision is, of course, no longer panoptical. In Alice Jardine's words, "We are no longer in the system of the panopticon described so accurately by Foucault . . . we are rather in a mode of self-surveillance: we watch ourselves as someone else."[28] From panoptical gaze to cyborgian gaze, Diller and Scofidio's intricately intersecting watchers shift attention from the written inscription of surveillance to the disseminated, three-dimensional network of glances and reflections. The carefully calibrated glances of the Dutch group portrait as described by Alois Riegl, the culturally precise meanings of perspective as symbolic form explicated by Panofsky, give way to three-dimensional hyperspatial constructions, in which fault lines figure as importantly as any completed sight lines. Where, in a pure cybernetic system as modeled by de Certeau, the privilege is given to writing, now boundaries are broken down and confused by their very inspection in three dimensions.

By the simple but critical act of "realizing" the model in practice, Diller and Scofidio establish a host of half-completed, half-broken refracted lines between mechanical objects and organic subjects; this network *is* in a real sense the cyborgian construction. Emulating at the same time as provoking both inner "hacker" or "cyber" space and outer or body space, the apparatus acts for all intents and purposes as a complicated and imaginary prophylactic among its subjects. The machine-age bachelor mechanism was forced to construct a real barrier, as in the hymenal wall of Alfred Jarry's "island of lubricious glass," which took on the form of any sexual organ when touched.[29] The contemporary cyborg, in contrast, is already insulated by a deflected gaze of a constructed gender and needs no traditional home.

But the home of a cyborg is by no means a site of technological utopia. Describing "home" as a social location, Donna Haraway confronts the breakdown of the bourgeois domestic myth in the face of cybernetic industry:

> *Home*: Women-headed households, serial monogamy, flight of men, old women alone, technology of domestic work, paid homework, reemergence of home sweat shops, home-based businesses and telecommuting, electronic cottage, urban homelessness, migration, module architecture, reinforced (simulated) nuclear family, intense domestic violence.[30]

What for the postwar generation of architectural technotopias, from Archigram to high tech, simply signified burgeoning social oppor-

tunity—the unlikely communitarianism of the "global village"—emerges in reality as a suburban battlefield strewn with the dismembered nuclei of imaginary families and the wreckage of their "homes." In such settings, for better or for worse, there is, Haraway claims, "no 'place' for women." In their place, there are "only geometrics of difference and contradiction crucial to women's cyborg identities." Where, in the taylorized settings of the twenties and thirties, the home was to be retooled to produce a generation of engineers and technocrats, the woman smoothly integrating time and motion into the carefully calculated spaces of a "kitchen-house-factory," now the space of technological competency is reduced to the flat surface of the monitor, the breadth of two hands on the keyboard. In this context the spatial order of the home carries less and less meaning, and its traditional "rooms" and their furnishings even less. A "machine for living in" has been transformed into a potentially dangerous psychopathological space populated by half-natural, half-prosthetic individuals, where walls reflect the sight of their viewers, where the house surveys its occupants with silent menace.

In the Capp Street project constructed by Diller and Scofidio, all these dimensions are explored: the space of each object is remapped as dining table and chairs are lifted in the air, beds and chairs are split in two, all following the vectors established by their (traditional) uses exaggerated to cutting effect. Objects now act out beyond their proper domains: chairs are attached to tables by locks and swings that emulate the presence of human arms; chairs are bisected by the locks of doors—all connected in ways they should not be, in order to reveal their sinister interdependence in the domestic system. Domestic objects are now set free to map their own space of instrumentality; human agency is supplied by surrogate objects, themselves prostheses of objects in their dangerous extensions.[31] Like the dust traces falling on Duchamp's Large Glass, the phantom operations of absent inhabitants and living objects are also mapped in their deposits. The moving bed is tracked by films of dust beneath it; the presence of former drinkers marked by the rings of glasses on the table. The house is left as if an obsolete and already abandoned technological space—like the inside of an old radio—a readymade, found again to be reused at will, dust and all; the traces of nonoccupation as well as of occupation seem to provide a schematic archaeology by which to begin again.

Such an assemblage no longer prefigures a robotic future of unified and gleaming technology; rather it is composed in a present of uneven development, filled with the detritus of past systems of technical order. As described by Michel de Certeau, this present takes on the characteristics of an open-cast mine, still operative in a terrain layered by the fragments of already obsolescent systems:

> Epistemological configurations are never replaced by the appearance of new orders; they compose strata that form the bedrock of a present. Relics and pockets of the instrumental systems continue to exist everywhere. . . . Tools take on a folkloric appearance. They nevertheless make up a discharged corps left behind by the defunct empire of mechanics. These populations of instruments oscillate between the status of memorable ruins and an intense everyday activity.[32]

Despite the apparent homogeneity of the cybernetic system, it operates in the interstices, and with the help of every previous system of bodily and textual inscription. Thus the readymades found by Diller and Scofidio are neither pure types, as imagined by Le Corbusier, nor ironic countertypes, as re-represented by Marcel Duchamp. They are nothing more than junk, throw-away objects found in the street or at the local dump. Already useless to the system of technological utopia, they nevertheless have been recuperated by precise operations for another system, the cyborgian.

In this way, Diller and Scofidio construct environments that have all the air of those transitional wastelands described in contemporary science fiction: the "Night city" of William Gibson's *Neuromancer,* at once "a kind of historical park: reminding the most advanced Japanese technology of its humbler origins," and an "outlaw zone," "a deliberately unsupervised playground for technology itself."[33] More specifically, Diller and Scofidio's Capp Street project resembles in microcosm that other "Nighttown" depicted by Gibson in the short story "Johnny Mnemonic":

> The mall runs forty kilometers from end to end, a ragged overlap of Fuller domes roofing what was once a suburban artery. If they turn off the arcs on a clear day, a gray approximation of sunlight filters through layers of acrylic, a view like the prison sketches of Giovanni Piranesi. The three southernmost kilometers roof Nighttown. . . . The neon arcs are dead, and the geodesics have been smoked black by decades of cooking fires.[34]

In the trusses of these abandoned domes lives a community of LO TEKS, dedicated to a reversal of progress into primitivism, trans-

formed biologically into cyborgs of Darwinian regression, half-dog, half-human. Their city is a bricolage of junk held together by rough epoxy joints, taped to the rafters of this technotropia, "jury-rigged and jerry-built from scraps that even Nighttown didn't want." But where Gibson seems to celebrate, however savagely, a "neuromanticism" that points to a cybernetic sublime in these technological ruinscapes, Diller and Scofidio remain analytical and dedicated to the didactic dissection of the processes that construct this new world.

In this project, the selection of the everyday and well-used object—the old chair, the worn-out television—is deliberately calculated to lull suspicion. Old friends, thrown away after years of service, these objects are nothing but familiar—so familiar indeed as to become banal. But in their recuperation and necessary deconstruction they take on more sinister overtones. Returned from their proper burial, discovered in the wrong place, invested with an uncanny life of their own, they break the long process of deterioration and degradation that leads from the familiar, the ordinary, to the banal, returning once more to the status of the unhomely.[35] In the event, their effect is neither uncanny nor familiar, but rather a demonstration of the potential uncanny, an unveiling of the secret but ever-present reciprocities that bind people to objects in posttechnological domesticity.

What Gibson calls "the consensual hallucination" of cyberspace, occupied by the disembodied consciousness of a hacker jacked into a matrix of spatially represented information—the public realm of the cybernetic—is now brought home. What Adorno epitomized as the dilemma of homesickness—the result of "distancing"—is now solved. The illusionistic virtuosity needed in order, as Adorno dreamed, to experience homesickness at the same time as staying at home is now technologically supplied.[36]

Private space is revealed as infinitely public, private rituals publicized to their subjects and these in turn connected to the public matrix. No longer sheltered from public surveillance by a well-defended private realm, the space of the domestic will now become, as Alice Jardine has hazarded, an agent of self-surveillance: "A lot of these ethical and political regimes will come together in self-surveillance; not all of it will be imposed from the outside . . . self tests . . . in the privacy of your own home . . . soon no-one will be able to touch anyone else, and I think it's going to be everyone."[37]

In this sense, Haraway's cyborgian myth operates as much on the level of dystopia as of utopia; it is, as she explains, built out of irony, "the attempt to build an ironic political myth faithful to feminism, socialism, materialism."

> Irony is about contradictions that do not resolve into larger wholes, even dialectically, about the tension of holding incompatible things together because both or all are necessary and true. Irony is about humor and serious play. It is also a rhetorical strategy and a political method.[38]

Her attempt to pose the cyborg as "a creature of social reality as well as of fiction" that emblematizes the contemporary state of "lived social relations, our most important political construction," is a valiant effort to hold the unthinkable and the possible in the same frame, a counter to the gender divisions and relations that construct the (traditional) present.[39] Such irony, of course, can only be sustained in the active play of political and social experience; its difficult dialectic can rarely be incorporated in the positive spaces and aesthetic constructions of a material shelter. Thus the "house" implied by Diller and Scofidio demands continuous consciousness of physical and psychological discomfort from its para-inhabitants; it converts the pabulum of Heideggerian nostalgia into a *Hausangst* that reveals the banal and everyday nature of the *unheimlich;* the dream of *Heimat* founders on the reality of the coffin-hotel in the zone.

III

Spaces

Dark Space

A whole history remains to be written of *spaces*—which would at the same time be the history of *powers* (both these terms in the plural)—from the great strategies of geo-politics to the little tactics of the habitat, institutional architecture from the classroom to the design of hospitals, passing via economic and political installations.

Michel Foucault, "The Eye of Power"

Space, in contemporary discourse, as in lived experience, has taken on an almost palpable existence. Its contours, boundaries, and geographies are called upon to stand in for all the contested realms of identity, from the national to the ethnic; its hollows and voids are occupied by bodies that replicate internally the external conditions of political and social struggle, and are likewise assumed to stand for, and identify, the sites of such struggle. Techniques of spatial occupation, of territorial mapping, of invasion and surveillance are seen as the instruments of social and individual control.

Equally, space is assumed to hide, in its darkest recesses and forgotten margins, all the objects of fear and phobia that have returned with such insistency to haunt the imaginations of those who have tried to stake out spaces to protect their health and happiness. Indeed, space as threat, as harbinger of the unseen, operates as medical and psychical metaphor for all the possible erosions of bourgeois bodily and social well being. The body, indeed, has become its own exterior, as its cell structure has become the object of spatial modeling that maps its own sites of immunological battle and describes the forms of its antibodies. "Outside," even as the spaces of exile, asylum, confinement, and quarantine of the early modern period were con-

tinuously spilling over into the "normal" space of the city, so the "pathological" spaces of today menace the clearly marked out limits of the social order. In every case "light space" is invaded by the figure of "dark space," on the level of the body in the form of epidemic and uncontrollable disease, and on the level of the city in the person of the homeless. In other words, the realms of the organic space of the body and the social space in which that body lives and works, domains clearly enough distinguished in the nineteenth century, as François Delaporte has shown, no longer can be identified as separate.[1]

In what follows I want to examine only one aspect of this new condition, one that touches on its implications for monumental architecture and more generally on the theorization of spatial conditions after Foucault. I will, that is, analyze the visual construction of images and objects that refer to this dark side of space in the modern period, as a way of approaching a more complex and (I hope) more politically subtle interpretation of subject-space relations than that offered by the conventional wisdom of modern urbanism (flood dark space with light) or architecture (open up all space to vision and occupation).

In the elaboration of the complex history of modern space following the initiatives of Foucault, historians and theorists have largely concentrated their attention on the overtly political role of *transparent* space—that paradigm of total control championed by Jeremy Bentham and recuperated under the guise of "hygienic space" by modernists led by Le Corbusier in the twentieth century. Transparency, it was thought, would eradicate the domain of myth, suspicion, tyranny, and above all the irrational. The rational grids and hermetic enclosures of institutions from hospitals to prisons; the surgical opening up of cities to circulation, light, and air; the therapeutic design of dwellings and settlements; these have all been subjected to analysis for their hidden contents, their capacity to instrumentalize the politics of surveillance through what Bentham termed "universal transparency." Historians have preferred to study this myth of "power through transparency," especially in its evident complicity with the technologies of the modern movement and their "utopian" applications to architecture and urbanism.

Yet such a spatial paradigm was, as Foucault pointed out, constructed out of an initial fear, the fear of Enlightenment in the face

of "darkened spaces, of the pall of gloom which prevents the full visibility of things, men and truths." It was this very fear of the dark that led, in the late eighteenth century, to the fascination with those same shadowy areas—the "fantasy-world of stone walls, darkness, hideouts and dungeons"—the precise "negative of the transparency and visibility which it is aimed to establish."[2] The moment that saw the creation of the first "considered politics of spaces" based on scientific concepts of light and infinity also saw, and within the same epistemology, the invention of a spatial phenomenology of darkness.

Late eighteenth-century architects were entirely aware of this double vision. Etienne-Louis Boullée, who was among the first to apply the newly outlined precepts of the Burkean sublime to the design of public institutions, exploited all the visual and sensational powers of what Burke had called "absolute light" to characterize his projects for metropolitan cathedrals and halls of justice. He was equally obsessed with absolute darkness as the most powerful instrument to induce that state of fundamental terror claimed by Burke as the instigator of the sublime. His design for a Palace of Justice confronted the two worlds, light and dark, in a telling allegory of enlightenment; the cubiform justice halls, lit from above, are set on top of a half-buried podium containing the prisons. "It seemed to me," Boullée wrote, "that in presenting this august palace raised on the shadowy lair of crime, I would not only be able to ennoble architecture by means of the oppositions that resulted, but further present in a metaphorical way the imposing picture of vice crushed beneath the feet of justice."[3]

It was perhaps not by chance that Boullée's reflections on the dark were elaborated during the period of his enforced withdrawal from public life under the real Terror—one that Robespierre himself had described as predicated on the necessities of the "political sublime." During this internal exile, sometime in the mid-1790s, Boullée recounted his "experiments" in light and shade as he walked by night in the woods surrounding his home:

> Finding myself in the countryside, I skirted a wood by the light of the moon. My effigy produced by its light excited my attention (assuredly this was not a novelty for me). By a particular disposition of the mind, the effect of this simulacrum seemed to me to be of an extreme sadness. The trees drawn on the ground by their shadows made the most profound impression on me. This picture grew in my imagination. I then saw everything that was the

most somber in nature. What did I see? The mass of objects detached in black against a light of extreme pallor. Nature seemed to offer itself, in mourning, to my sight. Struck by the sentiments I felt, I occupied myself, from this moment on, in making its particular application to architecture.

Out of his experiences, Boullée formed a notion of an architecture that would speak of death. It should be low and compressed in proportions—a "buried architecture" that literally embodied the burial it symbolized. It should express the extreme melancholy of mourning by means of its stripped and naked walls, "deprived of all ornament." It should, finally, following the model of the architect's shadow, be articulated to the sight by means of shadows:

> One must, as I have tried to do in funerary monuments, present the skeleton of architecture by means of an absolutely naked wall, presenting the image of buried architecture by employing only low and compressed proportions, sinking into the earth, forming, finally, by means of materials absorbent to the light, the black picture of an architecture of shadows depicted by the effect of even blacker shadows.

Boullée gave the example of a Temple of Death, a temple front etched, so to speak, in shadow form on a flat plane of light-absorbent material—a virtual architecture of negativity. Boullée was proud of his "invention": "This genre of architecture formed by shadows is a discovery of the art that belongs to me. It is a new career that I have opened up. Either I fool myself, or artists will not disdain to follow it."[4] Certainly his younger contemporaries were quick to seize on the sublime potentials of this abyssal vision of mortuary form. Claude-Nicolas Ledoux, in particular, made the architecture of death a point of departure for a reverie on the infinite scale of the universe and the absolute "nothingness" of the void after life.

And yet, in retrospect, what is fascinating about Boullée's account is not so much its commonplace references to darkness, nor its fashionable appeal to Egyptian motifs on the eve of Napoleon's expedition, but rather its projection of a "skeleton" of architecture from the basis of the human shadow. This shadow, or "effigy" as Boullée called it, prefiguring the disappearance of the body into darkness, was both a haunting "double" for Boullée himself and a model for imitation in architecture. On one level, Boullée was following the traditional idea of architecture "imitating" the perfection of the human body in massing and proportions, inverting the theory in order to make an

architecture based on the "death form" of the body, shadowed on the ground. But beyond this Boullée created a veritable "simulacrum" of the buried body in architecture: the building, already half sunken, compressed in its proportions as if by a great weight from above, imitated not a standing figure (as classical Vitruvian theory would have demanded) but a form that was already recumbent, itself depicted on the ground as a negative space. This prone figure was then raised up, so to speak, in order to mark the facade of Boullée's temple, now become an image of a specter: a monument to death that represented an ambiguous moment, somewhere between life and death, or, rather, a shadow of the living dead. In this way, Boullée prefigured the nineteenth-century preoccupation with the double as the harbinger of death, or as the shadow of the unburied dead.

In this doubling of the double, Boullée was thus setting up a play between architecture (art of imitation, of doubling) and death (imaged in the double) in a way that gave tangible force to Enlightenment fears. As Sarah Kofman has argued in her analysis of Freud's essay on "The Uncanny," "erected to conquer death, art, as a 'double', like any double, itself turns into an image of death. The game of art is a game of death, which already implies death in life, as a force of saving and inhibition." Boullée's death image, with its shadow inscription mirroring the shape of its dark facade or "ground," plays insistently on this theme that, as Freud pointed out, has to do with "the constant recurrence of the same thing," or repetition. Kofman comments,

> [Freud's] "The Uncanny" indicates this transformation of the algebraic sign of the double, its link with narcissism and death as the punishment for having sought immortality, for having wanted to "kill" the father. It is perhaps no accident that the model of the "double," erected for the first time by the Egyptians, is found in the figuration of castration in dreams, the doubling of the genital organ.[5]

Boullée, in these terms, might well have invented, if not the first architectural figuration of death, certainly the first self-conscious architecture of the uncanny, a prescient experiment in the projection of "dark space." For by flattening his shadow, so to speak, on the surface of a building that was itself nothing but (negative) surface, Boullée had created an image of an architecture not only without real depth, but one that deliberately played on the ambiguities be-

tween absolute flatness and infinite depth, between his own shadow and the void. The building, as the double of the death of the subject, translated this disappearance into experienced spatial uncertainty.

Here the limits of Foucault's interpretation of Enlightenment space become evident. Still tied to the Enlightenment's own phenomenology of light and dark, clear and obscure, his insistence on the operation of power through *transparency,* the panoptic principle, resists exploration of the extent to which the pairing of transparency and obscurity is essential for power to operate. For it is in the intimate associations of the two, their uncanny ability to slip from one to the other, that the sublime as instrument of fear retains its hold—in that ambiguity that stages the presence of death in life, dark space in bright space. In this sense, all the radiant spaces of modernism, from the first Panopticon to the Ville Radieuse, should be seen as calculated not on the final triumph of light over dark but precisely on the insistent presence of the one in the other.

Indeed, on another level, Boullée's design puts into question the generally assumed identity of the spatial and the monumental in Foucault's system. Foucault posited a virtual homology between the institutional politics of panopticism and their monumental crystallizations in the form of building types from the hospital to the prison and beyond, thus setting in motion the critique of modernist typologies that began in the late 1960s; the *spatial* dimension here seems to act as a universal flux bonding political and architectural or monumental. But our analysis of Boullée might suggest that the spatial is rather a dimension that incipiently opposes the monumental: not only does it work to contextualize the individual monument into a general map of spatial forces that stretch from the building to the city and thence to entire territories—something recognized by the situationists, and, in another context, by Henri Lefebvre—but it also operates, by way of the negative bodily projection we have described, to absorb the monument altogether.

Boullée's relentless desire to mimic the "engulfing" of the subject into the void of death, a desire itself mimicked by Ledoux when he speaks of composing "an image of nothingness" in his Cemetery project of 1785, thus ends in the engulfing of monumentality itself. For the rational grids and spatial orders that mark the laying out of the panoptical system in the late eighteenth century are, in the Temple of Death, nowhere present; there is literally no *plan* for this

monument to nothingness. Its sole mark is a facade as infinitely thin and insubstantial as the idea of redoubled darkness—a facade moreover that is precariously balanced between above and below, vertical and horizontal. Here the bodily substantiality of the traditional monument and the palpable spatial identity of the controlling institution dissolve into a mirror of the projection of a disappearing subject. Space, that is, has operated as an instrument of monumental dissolution.

The homology thus established between subject and space seems, on the subjective as well as on the monumental level, to emulate what Roger Caillois referred to as "legendary psychasthenia," that "temptation by space" that seemed to operate in the realm of insect mimicry and that offered so many analogies to human experience. Caillois was fascinated by the loss of any distinction between the insect and its surroundings during the process of camouflaging identity, its tendency to assimilate to its milieu; he pointed out that this did not always correspond to the best possible defense against death. The insect that looked like the leaf on which it was seated could equally be destroyed or eaten along with the leaf. Such loss of identity, he argued, would be a kind of pathological luxury, even "a dangerous luxury." As in imitation in the arts, such mimicry depended on the distortion of spatial vision, on the breaking down of the normal process by which spatial perception situates the subject clearly in space and in opposition to it:

> There can be no doubt that the perception of space is a complex phenomenon: space is indissolubly perceived and represented. From this standpoint it is a double dihedral changing at every moment in size and position: a *dihedral of action* whose horizontal plane is formed by the ground and the vertical plane by the man himself who walks and who, by this fact, carries the dihedral along with him; and a *dihedral of representation* determined by the same horizontal plane as the previous one (but represented and not perceived) intersected vertically at the distance where the object appears. It is with represented space that the drama becomes specific, since the living creature, the organism, is no longer the origin of the coordinates, but one point among others; it is dispossessed of its privilege and literally *no longer knows where to place itself*. One can already recognize the characteristic scientific attitude and, indeed, it is remarkable that represented spaces are just what is multiplied by contemporary science: Finsler's spaces, Fermat's spaces, Riemann-Christoffel's hyper-space, abstract, generalized, open, and closed spaces, spaces dense in themselves, thinned out, and so on. The feeling of

personality, considered as the organism's feeling of distinction from its surroundings, of the connection between consciousness and a particular point in space, cannot fail under these conditions to be seriously undermined; one then enters into the psychology of psychasthenia, and more specifically of *legendary psychasthenia,* if we agree to use this name for the disturbance in the above relations between personality and space.[6]

Following the psychological studies of Pierre Janet, Caillois compared such a disturbance to that experienced by certain schizophrenics when, in response to the question "where are you?," they invariably responded "I know where I am, but I do not feel as though I'm at the spot where I find myself." Caillois seemed to be relating such spatial disorientation to the pathology of derealization discussed by Freud, and beyond this to the host of spatial phobias, from agoraphobia to acrophobia and claustrophobia, identified in the late nineteenth century. Like sufferers from agoraphobia, described by Carl Otto Westphal in 1871, Caillois saw the schizophrenic literally eaten up by space:

> To these dispossessed souls, space seems to be a devouring force. Space pursues them, encircles them, digests them in a gigantic phagocytosis. It ends by replacing them. Then the body separates itself from thought, the individual breaks the boundary of his skin and occupies the other side of his senses. He tries to look at *himself from* any point whatever in space. He feels himself becoming space, *dark space where things cannot be put.* He is similar, not similar to something, but just *similar.* And he invents spaces of which he is "the convulsive possession."[7]

This spatial condition of the devoured subject Caillois assimilated to the experience, described by Eugène Minkowski, of "dark space," a space that is lived under the conditions of depersonalization and assumed absorption. Minkowski, distinguishing between "light space" and "dark space," saw dark space as a living entity, experienced, despite its lack of visual depth and visible extension, as deep: "an opaque and unlimited sphere wherein all the radii are the same, black and mysterious."[8] For Caillois, Minkowski's formulation approximated his own self-induced experience of psychasthenia, explaining among other symptoms his (much intensified) "fear of the dark," rooted once more in "the peril in which it puts the opposition between the organism and the milieu." In Minkowski and Caillois, darkness is not the simple absence of light:

There is something positive about it. While light space is eliminated by the materiality of objects, darkness is "filled," it touches the individual directly, envelops him, penetrates him, and even passes through him: hence "the ego is *permeable* for darkness while it is not so for light"; the feeling of mystery that one experiences at night would not come from anything else. Minkowski likewise comes to speak of *dark space* and almost of a lack of distinction between the milieu and the organism: "Dark space envelops me on all sides and penetrates me much deeper than light space; the distinction between inside and outside and consequently the sense organs as well, insofar as they are designed for external perception, here play only a totally modest role."[9]

The notion of an impulsion toward a loss of the subject into dark space, linked directly by Caillois both to the death drive and to certain forms of aesthetic mimicry, thus returns us to Boullée's experience of impending death in the forest outside Paris, and more directly to its monumental mimicry. We might now say that the Temple of Death, as monument, mimics the subject's own impulsion to be tempted by space, a monument that suffers, so to speak, from legendary psychasthenia.

7

THE LOCATION OF CULTURAL EXPERIENCE[1]

On the seashore of endless worlds, children play.

Tagore

In this chapter I wish to develop the theme that I stated briefly on the occasion of the Banquet organized by the British Psycho-Analytical Society to mark the completion of the *Standard Edition* of Freud's Works (London, 8 October 1966). In my attempt to pay tribute to James Strachey I said:

> 'Freud did not have a place in his topography of the mind for the experience of things cultural. He gave new value to inner psychic reality, and from this came a new value for things that are actual and truly external. Freud used the word "sublimation" to point the way to a place where cultural experience is

[1] Published in the *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis*, Vol. 48, Part 3 (1967).

> meaningful, but perhaps he did not get so far as to tell us where in the mind cultural experience is.'

Now I want to enlarge this idea and make an attempt at a positive statement which can be critically examined. I shall use my own language.

The quotation from Tagore has always intrigued me. In my adolescence I had no idea what it could mean, but it found a place in me, and its imprint has not faded.

When I first became a Freudian I *knew* what it meant. The sea and the shore represented endless intercourse between man and woman, and the child emerged from this union to have a brief moment before becoming in turn adult or parent. Then, as a student of unconscious symbolism, I *knew* (one always *knows*) that the sea is the mother, and onto the seashore the child is born. Babies come up out of the sea and are spewed out upon the land, like Jonah from the whale. So now the seashore was the mother's body, after the child is born and the mother and the now viable baby are getting to know each other.

Then I began to see that this employs a sophisticated concept of the parent-infant relationship and that there could be an unsophisticated infantile point of view, a different one from that of the mother or the observer, and that this infant's viewpoint could be profitably examined. For a long time my mind remained in a state of not-knowing, this state crystallizing into my formulation of the transitional phenomena. In the interim I played about with the concept of 'mental representations' and with the description of these in terms of objects and phenomena located in the personal psychic reality, felt to be inside; also, I followed the effects of the operation of the mental mechanisms of projection and introjection. I realized, however, that *play is in fact neither a matter of inner psychic reality nor a matter of external reality.*

Now I have come to the subject-matter of this chapter, and to the question: *if play is neither inside nor outside, where is it?* I was near to

the idea that I express here in my paper 'The Capacity to be Alone' (1958b), in which I said that, at first, the child is alone only in the presence of someone. In that paper I did not develop the idea of the common ground in this relationship between the child and the someone.

My patients (especially when regressive and dependent in the transference or transference dreams) have taught me how to find an answer to the question: where is play? I wish to condense what I have learned in my psychoanalytic work into a theoretical statement.

I have claimed that when we witness an infant's employment of a transitional object, the first not-me possession, we are witnessing both the child's first use of a symbol and the first experience of play. An essential part of my formulation of transitional phenomena is that we agree never to make the challenge to the baby: did you create this object, or did you find it conveniently lying around? That is to say, an essential feature of transitional phenomena and objects is a quality in our attitude when we observe them.

The object is a symbol of the union of the baby and the mother (or part of the mother). This symbol can be located. It is at the place in space and time where and when the mother is in transition from being (in the baby's mind) merged in with the infant and alternatively being experienced as an object to be perceived rather than conceived of. The use of an object symbolizes the union of two now separate things, baby and mother, *at the point in time and space of the initiation of their state of separateness.*[2]

A complication exists right from the very beginning of any consideration of this idea, in that it is necessary to postulate that if the use of the object by the baby builds up into anything (i.e. is

[2] It is necessary to simplify matters by referring to the use of objects, but the title of my original paper was 'Transitional Objects and Transitional Phenomena' (1951).

more than an activity that might be found even in a baby born with no brain), then there must be the beginning of the setting up in the infant's mind or personal psychic reality of an image of the object. But the mental representation in the inner world is kept significant, or the imago in the inner world is kept alive, by the reinforcement given through the availability of the external separated-off and actual mother, along with her technique of child care.

It is perhaps worth while trying to formulate this in a way that gives the time factor due weight. The feeling of the mother's existence lasts *x* minutes. If the mother is away more than *x* minutes, then the imago fades, and along with this the baby's capacity to use the symbol of the union ceases. The baby is distressed, but this distress is soon *mended* because the mother returns in *x+y* minutes. In *x+y* minutes the baby has not become altered. But in *x+y+z* minutes the baby has become *traumatized*. In *x+y+z* minutes the mother's return does not mend the baby's altered state. Trauma implies that the baby has experienced a break in life's continuity, so that primitive defences now become organized to defend against a repetition of 'unthinkable anxiety' or a return of the acute confusional state that belongs to disintegration of nascent ego structure.

We must assume that the vast majority of babies never experience the *x+y+z* quantity of deprivation. This means that the majority of children do not carry around with them for life the knowledge from experience of having been mad. Madness here simply means a *break-up* of whatever may exist at the time of *a personal continuity of existence*. After 'recovery' from *x+y+z* deprivation a baby has to start again permanently deprived of the root which could provide *continuity with the personal beginning*. This implies the existence of a memory system and an organization of memories.

By contrast, from the effects of *x+y+z* degree of deprivation, babies are constantly being *cured* by the mother's localized

spoiling that mends the ego structure. This mending of the ego structure re-establishes the baby's capacity to use a symbol of union; the baby then comes once more to allow and even to benefit from separation. *This is the place that I have set out to examine,* the separation that is not a separation but a form of union.[3]

It was at an important point in the phase of development of these ideas in me in the early forties that Marion Milner (in conversation) was able to convey to me the tremendous significance that there can be in the interplay of the edges of two curtains, or of the surface of a jug that is placed in front of another jug (cf. Milner, 1969).

It is to be noted that the phenomena that I am describing have no climax. This distinguishes them from phenomena that have instinctual backing, where the orgiastic element plays an essential part, and where satisfactions are closely linked with climax.

But these phenomena that have reality in the area whose existence I am postulating belong to *the experience* of relating to objects. One can think of the 'electricity' that seems to generate in meaningful or intimate contact, that is a feature, for instance, when two people are in love. These phenomena of the play area have infinite variability, contrasting with the relative stereotypy of phenomena that relate either to personal body functioning or to environmental actuality.

Psychoanalysts who have rightly emphasized the significance of instinctual experience and of reactions to frustration have failed to state with comparable clearness or conviction the tre-

[3] Merrell Middlemore (1941) saw the infinite richness in the intertwined techniques of the nursing couple. She was near what I am attempting to state here. Rich material exists for us to observe and enjoy in this field of the bodily relationship that may (though it may not) exist between baby and mother, especially if in making our observations (whether direct or in psychoanalysis) we are not simply thinking in terms of oral erotism with satisfaction or frustration, etc.

See also Hoffer (1949, 1950).

mendous intensity of these non-climactic experiences that are called playing. Starting as we do from psychoneurotic illness and with ego defences related to anxiety that arises out of the instinctual life, we tend to think of health in terms of the state of ego defences. We say it is healthy when these defences are not rigid, etc. But we seldom reach the point at which we can start to describe what life is like apart from illness or absence of illness.

That is to say, we have yet to tackle the question of *what life itself is about*. Our psychotic patients force us to give attention to this sort of basic problem. We now see that it is not instinctual satisfaction that makes a baby begin to be, to feel that life is real, to find life worth living. In fact, instinctual gratifications start off as part-functions and they become *seductions* unless based on a well-established capacity in the individual person for total experience, and for experience in the area of transitional phenomena. It is the self that must precede the self's use of instinct; the rider must ride the horse, not be run away with. I could use Buffon's saying: 'Le style est l'homme même.' When one speaks of a man one speaks of him *along with* the summation of his cultural experiences. The whole forms a unit.

I have used the term 'cultural experience' as an extension of the idea of transitional phenomena and of play without being certain that I can define the word 'culture'. The accent indeed is on experience. In using the 'word culture' I am thinking of the inherited tradition. I am thinking of something that is in the common pool of humanity, into which individuals and groups of people may contribute, and from which we may all draw if *we have somewhere to put what we find*.

There is a dependence here on some kind of recording method. No doubt a very great deal was lost of the early civilizations, but in the myths that were a product of oral tradition there could be said to be a cultural pool giving the history of human culture spanning six thousand years. This history through myth

persists to the present time in spite of the efforts of historians to be objective, which they can never be, though they must try.

Perhaps I have said enough to show both what I know and what I do not know about the meaning of the word 'culture'. It interests me, however, as a side issue, that in any cultural field *it is not possible to be original except on a basis of tradition*. Conversely, no one in the line of cultural contributors repeats except as a deliberate quotation, and the unforgivable sin in the cultural field is plagiarism. The interplay between originality and the acceptance of tradition as the basis for inventiveness seems to me to be just one more example, and a very exciting one, of the interplay between separateness and union.

I must pursue a little further the topic in terms of the baby's very early experiences, when the various capacities are being initiated, made ontogenetically possible because of the mother's extremely sensitive adaptation to the needs of her baby, based on her identification with the baby. (I refer to the stages of growth before the baby has acquired mental mechanisms that do soon become available for the organizing of complex defences. I repeat here: a human infant must travel some distance from early experiences in order to have the maturity to be deep.)

This theory does not affect what we have come to believe in respect of the aetiology of psychoneurosis, or the treatment of patients who are psychoneurotic; nor does it clash with Freud's structural theory of the mind in terms of ego, id, superego. What I say does affect our view of the question: what is life about? You may cure your patient and not know what it is that makes him or her go on living. It is of first importance for us to acknowledge openly that absence of psychoneurotic illness may be health, but it is not life. Psychotic patients who are all the time hovering between living and not living force us to look at this problem, one that really belongs *not to psychoneurotics but to all human beings*. I am claiming that these same phenomena that are life and death to our schizoid or borderline patients appear in our cultural

experiences. It is these cultural experiences that provide the continuity in the human race that transcends personal existence. I am assuming that cultural experiences are in direct continuity with play, the play of those who have not yet heard of games.

Main thesis

Here, then, is my main statement. I am claiming:

1. The place where cultural experience is located is in the *potential space* between the individual and the environment (originally the object). The same can be said of playing. Cultural experience begins with creative living first manifested in play.
2. For every individual the use of this space is determined by *life experiences* that take place at the early stages of the individual's existence.
3. From the beginning the baby has maximally intense experiences *in the potential space between the subjective object and the object objectively perceived*, between me-extensions and the not-me. This potential space is at the interplay between there being nothing but me and there being objects and phenomena outside omnipotent control.
4. Every baby has his or her own favourable or unfavourable experience here. Dependence is maximal. The potential space happens only *in relation to a feeling of confidence* on the part of the baby, that is, confidence related to the dependability of the mother-figure or environmental elements, confidence being the evidence of dependability that is becoming introjected.
5. In order to study the play and then the cultural life of the individual one must study the fate of the potential space between any one baby and the human (and therefore fallible) mother-figure who is essentially adaptive because of love.

It will be seen that if this area is to be thought of as part of the ego organization, here is a part of the ego that is not a body-ego,

that is not founded on the pattern of body *functioning* but is founded on body *experiences*. These experiences belong to object-relating of a non-orgiastic kind, or to what can be called ego-relatedness, at the place where it can be said that *continuity* is giving place to *contiguity*.

Continuing argument

This statement makes necessary an examination of the fate of this potential space, which may or may not come into prominence as a vital area in the mental life of the developing person.

What happens if the mother is able to start on a graduated failure of adaptation from a position of adapting fully? This is the crux of the matter, and the problem needs study because it affects our technique as analysts when we have patients who are regressed in the sense of being dependent. In the average good experience in this field of management (that starts so early, and that starts and starts again) the baby finds intense, even agonizing, pleasure associated with imaginative play. There is no set game, so everything is creative, and although playing is part of object-relating, whatever happens is personal to the baby. Everything physical is imaginatively elaborated, is invested with a first-time-ever quality. Can I say that this is the meaning intended for the word 'cathect'?

I can see that I am in the territory of Fairbairn's (1941) concept of 'object-seeking' (as opposed to 'satisfaction-seeking').

As observers we note that everything in the play has been done before, has been felt before, has been smelt before, and where there appear specific symbols of the union of baby and mother (transitional objects) these very objects have been adopted, not created. Yet *for the baby* (if the mother can supply the right conditions) every detail of the baby's life is an example of creative living. Every object is a 'found' object. Given the chance, the baby begins to live creatively, and to use actual objects to be

creative into and with. If the baby is not given this chance then there is no area in which the baby may have play, or may have cultural experience; then it follows that there is no link with the cultural inheritance, and there will be no contribution to the cultural pool.

The 'deprived child' is notoriously restless and unable to play, and has an impoverishment of capacity to experience in the cultural field. This observation leads to a study of the effect of deprivation at the time of the loss of what has become accepted as reliable. A study of the effects of loss at any early stage involves us in looking at this intermediate area, or potential space between subject and object. Failure of dependability or loss of object means to the child a loss of the play area, and loss of meaningful symbol. In favourable circumstances the potential space becomes filled with the products of the baby's own creative imagination. In unfavourable circumstances the creative use of objects is missing or relatively uncertain. I have described elsewhere (Winnicott, 1960a) the way in which the defence of the compliant false self appears, with the hiding of the true self that has the potential for creative use of objects.

There is, in cases of premature failure of environmental reliability, an alternative danger, which is that this potential space may become filled with what is injected into it from someone other than the baby. It seems that whatever is in this space that comes from someone else is persecutory material, and the baby has no means of rejecting it. Analysts need to beware lest they create a feeling of confidence and an intermediate area in which play can take place and then inject into this area or inflate it with interpretations which in effect are from their own creative imaginations.

Fred Plaut, a Jungian analyst, has written a paper (1966) from which I quote:

> 'The capacity to form images and to use these constructively

> by recombination into new patterns is – unlike dreams or fantasies – dependent on the individual's ability to trust.'

The word 'trust' in this context shows an understanding of what I mean by the building up of confidence based on experience, at the time of maximal dependence, before the enjoyment and employment of separation and independence.

I suggest that the time has come for psychoanalytic theory to pay tribute to this *third area*, that of cultural experience which is a derivative of play. Psychotics insist on our knowing about it, and it is of great importance in our assessment of the lives rather than the health of human beings. (The other two areas are inner or personal psychic reality and the actual world with the individual living in it.)

Summary

I have tried to draw attention to the importance both in theory and in practice of a third area, that of play, which expands into creative living and into the whole cultural life of man. This third area has been contrasted with inner or personal psychic reality and with the actual world in which the individual lives, which can be objectively perceived. I have located this important area of *experience* in the potential space between the individual and the environment, that which initially both joins and separates the baby and the mother when the mother's love, displayed or made manifest as human reliability, does in fact give the baby a sense of trust or of confidence in the environmental factor.

Attention is drawn to the fact that this potential space is a highly variable factor (from individual to individual), whereas the two other locations – personal or psychic reality and the actual world – are relatively constant, one being biologically determined and the other being common property.

The potential space between baby and mother, between child and family, between individual and society or the world, depends on experience which leads to trust. It can be looked upon as sacred to the individual in that it is here that the individual experiences creative living.

By contrast, exploitation of this area leads to a pathological condition in which the individual is cluttered up with persecutory elements of which he has no means of ridding himself.

It may perhaps be seen from this how important it can be for the analyst to recognize the existence of this place, the only place where play can start, a place that is at the continuity-contiguity moment, where transitional phenomena originate.

My hope is that I have begun to answer my own question: where is cultural experience located?

8

THE PLACE WHERE WE LIVE[1]

I wish to examine the place, using the word in an abstract sense, where we most of the time are when we are experiencing life.

By the language we use we show our natural interest in this matter. I may be *in* a muddle, and then I either crawl out of the muddle or else try to put things in order so that I may, at least for a time, know *where* I *am*. Or I may feel I am *at sea*, and I take bearings so that I may come to port (any port in a storm), and then when I am on dry land I look for a house built *on* rock rather than on sand; and *in* my own home, which (as I am English) is my castle, I am *in* a seventh heaven.

Without straining the language of everyday use I may talk of my behaviour in the world of external (or shared) reality, or I may be having an inner or mystical experience, while squatting on the ground contemplating my navel.

It is perhaps a rather modern use of the word 'inner', to use it

[1] This is a restatement of the theme of the previous chapter, written for another, and different, audience.

to refer to psychic reality, to claim that there is an inside where personal wealth builds up (or poverty shows) as we make progress in emotional growth and personality establishment.

Here are two places, then, the inside and the outside of the individual. But is this all?

When considering the lives of human beings there are those who like to think superficially in terms of behaviour, and in terms of conditioned reflexes and conditioning; this leads to what is called behaviour therapy. But most of us get tired of restricting ourselves to behaviour or to the observable extrovert life of persons who, whether they like it or not, are motivated from the unconscious. By contrast, there are those who place emphasis on the 'inner' life, who think that the effects of economics and even of starvation itself have but little importance as compared with mystical experience. Infinity for those in the latter category is at the centre of the self, whereas for the behaviourists who think in terms of external reality infinity is reaching out beyond the moon to the stars and to the beginning and the end of time, time that has neither an end nor a beginning.

I am attempting to get in between these two extremes. If we look at our lives we shall probably find that we spend most of our time neither in behaviour nor in contemplation, but somewhere else. I ask: where? And I try to suggest an answer.

An intermediate zone

In psychoanalytic writings and in the vast literature that has been influenced by Freud there can be found a tendency to dwell *either* on a person's life as it relates to objects *or else* on the inner life of the individual. In the life of the person who is object-relating it is assumed that there is postulated a state of tension driving towards instinct-satisfaction, or else a basking in the leisure of gratification. A complete statement would include the concept of displacement and all the mechanisms of

sublimation. Where excitement has not led to satisfaction the person is caught up in the discomforts that frustration generates, discomforts that include bodily dysfunction and a sense of guilt or the relief that comes from the discovery of a scapegoat or a persecutor.

In regard to mystical experiences, in the literature of psychoanalysis the person we are looking at is asleep dreaming, or if awake is going through a process rather akin to dream-work, but doing this while awake. Every mood is there and the unconscious fantasy of the mood ranges from idealization on the one hand to the awfulness of the destruction of all that is good on the other – bringing the extremes of elation or despair, wellbeing in the body or a sense of being diseased and an urge to suicide.

This is a much simplified and indeed distorted quick review of a vast literature, but I am not attempting to make a comprehensive statement so much as to point out that the written words of psychoanalytic literature do not seem to tell us all that we want to know. What, for instance, are we doing when we are listening to a Beethoven symphony or making a pilgrimage to a picture gallery or reading *Troilus and Cressida* in bed, or playing tennis? What is a child doing when sitting on the floor playing with toys under the aegis of the mother? What is a group of teenagers doing participating in a pop session?

It is not only: what are we doing? The question also needs to be posed: where are we (if anywhere at all)? We have used the concepts of inner and outer, and we want a third concept. Where are we when we are doing what in fact we do a great deal of our time, namely, enjoying ourselves? Does the concept of sublimation really cover the whole pattern? Can we gain some advantage from an examination of this matter of the possible existence of a place for living that is not properly described by either of the terms 'inner' and 'outer'?

Lionel Trilling (1955) in his Freud Anniversary Lecture says:

> 'For [Freud] there is an honorific accent in the use of the word [culture], but at the same time, as we cannot fail to hear, there is in what he says about culture an unfailing note of exasperation and resistance. Freud's relation to culture must be described as an ambivalent one.'

I think that in this lecture Trilling is concerned with the same inadequacy that I refer to here, although very different language is being employed.

It will be observed that I am looking at the highly sophisticated adult's enjoyment of living or of beauty or of abstract human contrivance, and at the same time at the creative gesture of a baby who reaches out for the mother's mouth and feels her teeth, and at the same time looks into her eyes, seeing her creatively. For me, playing leads on naturally to cultural experience and indeed forms its foundation.

Now, if my argument has cogency, we have three instead of two human states to compare with each other. When we look at these three sets of the human state we can see that there is one special feature that distinguishes what I am calling cultural experience (or playing) from the other two.

Looking first at external reality and the individual's contact with external reality in terms of object-relating and object-usage, one sees that external reality itself is fixed; moreover, the instinctual endowment that provides the backing for object-relating and object-use is itself fixed for the individual, though it varies according to phase and age, and the individual's freedom to make use of instinctual drives. Here we are more free or less free according to the laws that have been formulated in considerable detail in the psychoanalytic literature.

Let us look next at inner psychic reality, the personal property of each individual in so far as a degree of mature integration has been reached which includes the establishment of a unit self, with the implied existence of an inside and an outside, and a

limiting membrane. Here again there is to be seen a fixity that belongs to inheritance, to the personality organization, and to environmental factors introjected and to personal factors projected.

By contrast with these, I suggest that the area available for manœuvre in terms of the third way of living (where there is cultural experience or creative playing) is extremely variable as between individuals. This is because this third area is a product of the *experiences of the individual person* (baby, child, adolescent, adult) in the environment that obtains. There is a kind of variability here that is different in quality from the variabilities that belong to the phenomenon of inner personal psychic reality and to external or shared reality. The extent of this third area can be minimal or maximal, according to the summation of actual experiences.

It is this special kind of variability that concerns me here and now and I wish to examine its meaning. I am making this examination in terms of the position, relative to the individual in the world, in which cultural experience (play) can be said to 'take place'.

A potential space

I put forward for discussion of its value as an idea the thesis that for creative playing and for cultural experience, including its most sophisticated developments, the position is *the potential space* between the baby and the mother. I refer to the hypothetical area that exists (but cannot exist) between the baby and the object (mother or part of mother) during the phase of the repudiation of the object as not-me, that is, at the end of being merged in with the object.

From a state of being merged in with the mother the baby is at a stage of separating out the mother from the self, and the mother is lowering the degree of her adaptation to the baby's

needs (both because of her own recovery from a high degree of identification with her baby and because of her perception of the baby's new need, the need for her to be a separate phenomenon).[2]

This is exactly the same as the danger area that is arrived at sooner or later in all psychiatric treatments, the patient having felt secure and viable because of the analyst's reliability, adaptation to need, and willingness to become involved, and now beginning to feel a need to shake free and to achieve autonomy. Like the baby with the mother, the patient cannot become autonomous except in conjunction with the therapist's readiness to let go, and yet any move on the part of the therapist away from a state of being merged in with the patient is under dire suspicion, so that disaster threatens.

It will be remembered that in the example I gave of a boy's use of string (Chapter 1) I referred to two objects as being both *joined and separated* by the string. This is the paradox that I accept and do not attempt to resolve. The baby's separating-out of the world of objects from the self is achieved only through the absence of a space between, the *potential* space being filled in in the way that I am describing.

It could be said that with human beings there can be no separation, only a threat of separation; and the threat is maximally or minimally traumatic according to the experience of the first separatings.

How, one may ask, does separation of subject and object, of baby and mother, seem in fact to happen, and to happen with profit to all concerned, and in the vast majority of cases? And this in spite of the impossibility of separation? (The paradox must be tolerated.)

The answer can be that in the baby's *experience* of life, actually in

[2] I have discussed this thesis at length in my paper 'Primary Maternal Preoccupation' (1956).

relation to the mother or mother-figure, there usually develops a degree of confidence in the mother's reliability; or (in another language belonging to psychotherapy) the patient begins to sense that the therapist's concern arises not out of a need for a dependant, but out of a capacity in the therapist to identify with the patient out of a feeling 'if I were in your shoes . . .'. In other words, the mother's or therapist's love does not only mean meeting dependency needs, but it comes to mean affording the opportunity for this baby or this patient to move from dependence to autonomy.

A baby can be *fed* without love, but loveless or impersonal *management* cannot succeed in producing a new autonomous human child. Here where there is trust and reliability is a potential space, one that can become an infinite area of separation, which the baby, child, adolescent, adult may creatively fill with playing, which in time becomes the enjoyment of the cultural heritage.

The special feature of this place where play and cultural experience have a position is that it *depends for its existence on living experiences*, not on inherited tendencies. One baby is given sensitive management here where the mother is separating out from the baby so that the area for play is immense; and the next baby has so poor an experience at this phase of his or her development that there is but little opportunity for development except in terms of introversion or extroversion. The potential space, in the latter case, has no significance, because there was never a built-up sense of trust matched with reliability, and therefore there was no relaxed self-realization.

In the experience of the more fortunate baby (and small child and adolescent and adult) the question of separation in separating does not arise, because in the potential space between the baby and the mother there appears the creative playing that arises naturally out of the relaxed state; it is here that there develops a use of symbols that stand at one and the same time for

external world phenomena and for phenomena of the individual person who is being looked at.

The other two areas do not lose significance because of this that I am putting forward as a third area. If we are truly examining human beings, then we must be expected to make observations that can be superimposed, the one on the other. Individuals do relate to the world in ways that involve them in instinctual gratification, either direct or in sublimated forms. Also, we do know the paramount importance of sleep and the deep dreaming that is at the core of the personality, and of contemplation and of relaxed undirected mental inconsequence. Nevertheless, playing and cultural experience are things that we do value in a special way; these link the past, the present, and the future; *they take up time and space.* They demand and get our concentrated deliberate attention, deliberate but without too much of the deliberateness of trying.

The mother adapts to the needs of her baby and of her child who is gradually evolving in personality and character, and this adaptation gives her a measure of reliability. The baby's experience of this reliability over a period of time gives rise in the baby and growing child to a feeling of confidence. The baby's confidence in the mother's reliability, and therefore in that of other people and things, makes possible a separating-out of the not-me from the me. At the same time, however, it can be said that separation is avoided by the filling in of the potential space with creative playing, with the use of symbols, and with all that eventually adds up to a cultural life.

There is in many a failure in confidence which cramps the person's play-capacity because of the limitations of the potential space; likewise there is for many a poverty of play and cultural life because, although the person had a place for erudition, there was a relative failure on the part of those who constitute the child's world of persons to introduce cultural elements at the appropriate phases of the person's personality development.

Naturally, limitations arise out of the relative lack of cultural erudition or even the lack of acquaintance with the cultural heritage which may characterize those actually in charge of a child.

The first need, then, in respect of this that is described in this chapter, is for protection of the baby-mother and baby-parent relationship at the early stage of every boy or girl child's development, so that there may come into being the potential space in which, because of trust, the child may creatively play.

The second need is for those who have care of children of all ages to be ready to put each child into touch with appropriate elements of the cultural heritage, according to the individual child's capacity and emotional age and developmental phase.

It is useful, then, to think of a third area of human living, one neither inside the individual nor outside in the world of shared reality. This intermediate living can be thought of as occupying a potential space, negating the idea of space and separation between the baby and the mother, and all developments derived from this phenomenon. This potential space varies greatly from individual to individual, and its foundation is the baby's trust in the mother *experienced* over a long-enough period at the critical stage of the separation of the not-me from the me, when the establishment of an autonomous self is at the initial stage.

9

MIRROR-ROLE OF MOTHER AND FAMILY IN CHILD DEVELOPMENT[1]

In individual emotional development *the precursor of the mirror is the mother's face.* I wish to refer to the normal aspect of this and also to its psychopathology.

Jacques Lacan's paper 'Le Stade du Miroir' (1949) has certainly influenced me. He refers to the use of the mirror in each individual's ego development. However, Lacan does not think of the mirror in terms of the mother's face in the way that I wish to do here.

I refer only to infants who have sight. The wider application of the idea to cover infants with poor sight or no sight must be left over till the main theme is stated. The bare statement is this: in the early stages of the emotional development of the human

[1] Published in P. Lomas (ed), *The Predicament of the Family: A Psycho-analytical Symposium* (1967). London: Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis.

infant a vital part is played by the environment which is in fact not yet separated off from the infant by the infant. Gradually the separating-off of the not-me from the me takes place, and the pace varies according to the infant and according to the environment. The major changes take place in the separating-out of the mother as an objectively perceived environmental feature. If no one person is there to be mother the infant's developmental task is infinitely complicated.

Let me simplify the environmental function and briefly state that it involves:

1. Holding
2. Handling
3. Object-presenting.

The infant may respond to these environmental provisions, but the result in the baby is maximal personal maturation. By the word 'maturation' at this stage I intend to include the various meanings of the word 'integration', as well as psychosomatic interrelating and object-relating.

A baby is held, and handled satisfactorily, and with this taken for granted is presented with an object in such a way that the baby's legitimate experience of omnipotence is not violated. The result can be that the baby is able to use the object, and to feel as if this object is a subjective object, and created by the baby.

All this belongs to the beginning, and out of all this come the immense complexities that comprise the emotional and mental development of the infant and child.[2]

Now, at some point the baby takes a look round. Perhaps a baby at the breast does not look at the breast. Looking at the face is more likely to be a feature (Gough, 1962). What does the baby

[2] For further and detailed discussion of these ideas the reader can consult my paper 'The Theory of the Parent-Infant Relationship' (1960b).

see there? To get to the answer we must draw on our experience with psychoanalytic patients who reach back to very early phenomena and yet who can verbalize (when they feel they can do so) without insulting the delicacy of what is preverbal, unverbalized, and unverbalizable except perhaps in poetry.

What does the baby see when he or she looks at the mother's face? I am suggesting that, ordinarily, what the baby sees is himself or herself. In other words the mother is looking at the baby and *what she looks like is related to what she sees there.* All this is too easily taken for granted. I am asking that this which is naturally done well by mothers who are caring for their babies shall not be taken for granted. I can make my point by going straight over to the case of the baby whose mother reflects her own mood or, worse still, the rigidity of her own defences. In such a case what does the baby see?

Of course nothing can be said about the single occasions on which a mother could not respond. Many babies, however, do have to have a long experience of not getting back what they are giving. They look and they do not see themselves. There are consequences. First, their own creative capacity begins to atrophy, and in some way or other they look around for other ways of getting something of themselves back from the environment. They may succeed by some other method, and blind infants need to get themselves reflected through other senses than that of sight. Indeed, a mother whose face is fixed may be able to respond in some other way. Most mothers can respond when the baby is in trouble or is aggressive, and especially when the baby is ill. Second, the baby gets settled in to the idea that when he or she looks, what is seen is the mother's face. The mother's face is not then a mirror. So perception takes the place of apperception, perception takes the place of that which might have been the beginning of a significant exchange with the world, a two-way process in which self-enrichment alternates with the discovery of meaning in the world of seen things.

Naturally, there are half-way stages in this scheme of things. Some babies do not quite give up hope and they study the object and do all that is possible to see in the object some meaning that ought to be there if only it could be felt. Some babies, tantalized by this type of relative maternal failure, study the variable maternal visage in an attempt to predict the mother's mood, just exactly as we all study the weather. The baby quickly learns to make a forecast: 'Just now it is safe to forget the mother's mood and to be spontaneous, but any minute the mother's face will become fixed or her mood will dominate, and my own personal need must then be withdrawn otherwise my central self may suffer insult.'

Immediately beyond this in the direction of pathology is predictability, which is precarious, and which strains the baby to the limits of his or her capacity to allow for events. This brings a threat of chaos, and the baby will organize withdrawal, or will not look except to perceive, as a defence. A baby so treated will grow up puzzled about mirrors and what the mirror has to offer. If the mother's face is unresponsive, then a mirror is a thing to be looked at but not to be looked into.

To return to the normal progress of events, when the average girl studies her face in the mirror she is reassuring herself that the mother-image is there and that the mother can see her and that the mother is *en rapport* with her. When girls and boys in their secondary narcissism look in order to see beauty and to fall in love, there is already evidence that doubt has crept in about their mother's continued love and care. So the man who falls in love with beauty is quite different from the man who loves a girl and feels she is beautiful and can see what is beautiful about her.

I will not try to press home my idea, but instead I will give some examples so that the idea I am presenting can be worked over by the reader.

Illustration I

I refer first to a woman of my acquaintance who married and brought up three fine male children. She was also a good support to her husband who had a creative and important job. Behind the scenes this woman was always near to depression. She seriously disturbed her marital life by waking every morning in a state of despair. She could do nothing about it. The resolution of the paralysing depression came each day when at last it was time to get up and, at the end of her ablutions and dressing, she could 'put on her face'. Now she felt rehabilitated and could meet the world and take up her family responsibilities. This exceptionally intelligent and responsible person did eventually react to a misfortune by developing a chronic depressive state which in the end became transformed into a chronic and crippling physical disorder.

Here is a recurring pattern, easily matched in the social or clinical experience of everyone. What is illustrated by this case only exaggerates that which is normal. The exaggeration is of the task of getting the mirror to notice and approve. The woman had to be her own mother. If she had had a daughter she would surely have found great relief, but perhaps a daughter would have suffered because of having too much importance in correcting her mother's uncertainty about her own mother's sight of her.

The reader will already be thinking of Francis Bacon. I refer here not to the Bacon who said: 'A beautiful face is a silent commendation' and 'That is the best part of beauty, which a picture cannot express', but to the exasperating and skilful and challenging artist of our time who goes on and on painting the human face distorted significantly. From the standpoint of this chapter this Francis Bacon of today's date is seeing himself in his mother's face, but with some twist in him or her that maddens both him and us. I know nothing of this artist's private life, and I bring him in only because he forces his way into any present-day

discussion of the face and the self. Bacon's faces seem to me to be far removed from perception of the actual; in looking at faces he seems to me to be painfully striving towards being seen, which is at the basis of creative looking.

I see that I am linking apperception with perception by postulating a historical process (in the individual) which depends on being seen:

When I look I am seen, so I exist.
I can now afford to look and see.
I now look creatively and what I apperceive I also perceive.
In fact I take care not to see what is not there to be seen (unless I am tired).

Illustration II

A patient reports: 'I went to a coffee bar last night and I was fascinated to see the various characters there', and she describes some of these characters. Now this patient has a striking appearance, and if she were able to use herself she could be the central figure in any group. I asked: 'Did anyone look at you?' She was able to go over to the idea that she did in fact draw some of the fire, but she had taken along with her a man friend, and she could feel that it was at him that people were looking.

From here the patient and I were together able to make a preliminary survey of the patient's early history and childhood in terms of being seen in a way that would make her feel she existed. Actually the patient had had a deplorable experience in this respect.

This subject then got lost for the time being in other types of material, but in a way this patient's whole analysis revolves round this 'being seen' for what she in fact is, at any one moment; and at times the being actually seen in a subtle way is for her the main thing in her treatment. This patient is

particularly sensitive as a judge of painting and indeed of the visual arts, and lack of beauty disintegrates her personality so that she recognizes lack of beauty by herself feeling awful (disintegrated or depersonalized).

Illustration III

I have a research case, a woman who has had a very long analysis. This patient has come through, late in life, to feeling real, and a cynic might say: to what end? But she feels it has been worth while, and I myself have learned a great deal of what I know of early phenomena through her.

This analysis involved a serious and deep regression to infantile dependence. The environmental history was severely disturbing in many respects, but here I am dealing with the effect on her of her mother's depression. This has been worked over repeatedly and as analyst I have had to displace this mother in a big way in order to enable the patient to get started as a person.[3]

Just now, near the end of my work with her, the patient has sent me a portrait of her nurse. I had already had her mother's portrait and I have got to know the rigidity of the mother's defences very intimately. It became obvious that the mother (as the patient said) had chosen a depressed nurse to act for her so that she might avoid losing touch with the children altogether. A lively nurse would automatically have 'stolen' the children from the depressed mother.

This patient has a marked absence of just that which characterizes so many women, an interest in the face. She certainly had no adolescent phase of self-examination in the mirror, and now she looks in the mirror only to remind herself that she 'looks like an old hag' (patient's own words).

[3] An aspect of this case was reported by me in my paper 'Metapsychological and Clinical Aspects of Regression within the Psycho-Analytical Set-Up' (1954).

This same week this patient found a picture of my face on a book-cover. She wrote to say she needed a bigger version so that she could see the lines and all the features of this 'ancient landscape'. I sent the picture (she lives away and I see her only occasionally now) and at the same time I gave her an interpretation based on what I am trying to say in this chapter.

This patient thought that she was quite simply acquiring the portrait of this man who had done so much for her (and I have). But what she needed to be told was that my lined face had some features that link for her with the rigidity of the faces of her mother and her nurse.

I feel sure that it was important that I knew this about the face, and that I could interpret the patient's search for a face that could reflect herself, and at the same time see that, because of the lines, my face in the picture reproduced some of her mother's rigidity.

Actually this patient has a thoroughly good face, and she is an exceptionally sympathetic person when she feels like it. She can let herself be concerned with other people's affairs and with their troubles for a limited period of time. How often this characteristic has seduced people into thinking of her as someone to be leaned on! The fact is, however, that the moment my patient feels herself being involved, especially in someone's depression, she automatically withdraws and curls up in bed with a hot water bottle, nursing her soul. Just here she is vulnerable.

Illustration IV

After all this had been written a patient brought material in an analytic hour which might have been based on this that I am writing. This woman is very much concerned with the stage of the establishment of herself as an individual. In the course of this particular hour she brought in a reference to 'Mirror mirror on the wall' etc. and then she said: 'Wouldn't

it be awful if the child looked into the mirror and saw nothing!'

The rest of the material concerned the environment provided by her mother when she was a baby, the picture being of a mother talking to someone else unless actively engaged in a positive relating to the baby. The implication here was that the baby would look at the mother and see her talking to someone else. The patient then went on to describe her great interest in the paintings of Francis Bacon and she wondered whether to lend me a book about the artist. She referred to a detail in the book. Francis Bacon 'says that he likes to have glass over his pictures because then when people look at the picture what they see is not just a picture; they might in fact see themselves.'[4]

After this the patient went on to speak of 'Le Stade du Miroir' because she knows of Lacan's work, but she was not able to make the link that I feel I am able to make between the mirror and the mother's face. It was not my job to give this link to my patient in this session because the patient is essentially at a stage of discovering things for herself, and premature interpretation in such circumstances annihilates the creativity of the patient and is traumatic in the sense of being against the

[4] See *Francis Bacon: Catalogue raisonné and documentation* (Alley, 1964). In his Introduction to this book, John Rothenstein writes:

'. . . to look at a painting by Bacon is to look into a mirror, and to see there our own afflictions and our fears of solitude, failure, humiliation, old age, death and of nameless threatened catastrophe.

His avowed preference for having his paintings glazed is also related to his sense of dependence on chance. The preference is due to the fact that glass sets paintings somewhat apart from the environment (just as his daisies and railings set his subjects apart from their pictorial environment), and that glass protects, but what counts more in this case is his belief that the fortuitous play of reflections will enhance his pictures. His dark blue pictures in particular, I heard him observe, gain by enabling the spectator to see his own face in the glass.'

maturational process. This theme continues to be important in this patient's analysis, but it also appears in other guises.

This glimpse of the baby's and child's seeing the self in the mother's face, and afterwards in a mirror, gives a way of looking at analysis and at the psychotherapeutic task. Psychotherapy is not making clever and apt interpretations; by and large it is a long-term giving the patient back what the patient brings. It is a complex derivative of the face that reflects what is there to be seen. I like to think of my work this way, and to think that if I do this well enough the patient will find his or her own self, and will be able to exist and to feel real. Feeling real is more than existing; it is finding a way to exist as oneself, and to relate to objects as oneself, and to have a self into which to retreat for relaxation.

But I would not like to give the impression that I think this task of reflecting what the patient brings is easy. It is not easy, and it is emotionally exhausting. But we get our rewards. Even when our patients do not get cured they are grateful to us for seeing them as they are, and this gives us a satisfaction of a deep kind.

This to which I have referred in terms of the mother's role of giving back to the baby the baby's own self continues to have importance in terms of the child and the family. Naturally, as the child develops and the maturational processes become sophisticated, and identifications multiply, the child becomes less and less dependent on getting back the self from the mother's and the father's face and from the faces of others who are in parental or sibling relationships (Winnicott, 1960a). Nevertheless, when a family is intact and is a going concern over a period of time each child derives benefit from being able to see himself or herself in the attitude of the individual members or in the attitudes of the family as a whole. We can include in all this the actual mirrors that exist in the house and the opportunities the

child gets for seeing the parents and others looking at themselves. It should be understood, however, that the actual mirror has significance mainly in its figurative sense.

This could be one way of stating the contribution that a family can make to the personality growth and enrichment of each one of its individual members.

I. DAS HAUS VOM KELLER ZUM DACHBODEN
DER SINN DER HÜTTE

Wer wird an meine Haustür klopfen?
Tür auf: gegrüßt seist du.
Tür zu: laß mich in Ruh.
Die Welt pulst jenseits meiner Tür.
Pierre-Albert Birot

I

Für eine phänomenologische Studie der Intimitätswerte des inneren Raumes ist das Haus ganz augenscheinlich ein bevorzugtes Wesen, unter der Bedingung wohlgemerkt, daß man das Haus zugleich in seiner Einheit und in seiner Zusammengesetztheit auffaßt und versucht, alle seine Sonderwerte in einen Fundamentalwert einzuordnen. Das Haus wird uns gleichzeitig verstreute Bilder und ein Korpus von Bildern liefern. Im einen wie im andern Fall werden wir beweisen können, daß die Einbildungskraft die Werte der Wirklichkeit vermehrt. Eine Art Anziehungskraft der Bilder konzentriert die Bilder um das Haus herum. Läßt sich durch die Erinnerungen an alle die Häuser hindurch, wo wir Zuflucht gefunden haben, läßt sich über alle die Häuser hinweg, in denen wir zu wohnen geträumt haben, eine intime und konkrete Wesenheit erkennen, die eine Rechtfertigung des einzigartigen Wertes aller unserer Bilder von beschützter Innerlichkeit wäre? Da liegt das Hauptproblem.

Um es zu lösen, genügt es nicht, das Haus als einen »Gegenstand« zu betrachten, auf den wir mit Urteilen und mit Träumereien reagieren könnten. Für einen Phänomenologen, für einen Psychoanalytiker, für einen Psychologen (diese drei Gesichtspunkte nach dem abnehmenden Grade der Prägnanz aufgezählt) handelt es sich nicht darum, Häuser zu beschreiben, ihre malerischen Ansichten auszuführen und ihre Annehmlichkeiten auseinanderzusetzen. Im Gegenteil muß man über die Probleme der Beschreibung hinausgehen — sei diese Beschreibung nun objektiv oder subjektiv, das heißt,

möge sie von Fakten oder von Impressionen berichten – wenn man den primären Kräften gerecht werden will, jenen seelischen Anlagen nämlich, in denen sich eine gewissermaßen angeborene Hingabe an die Urfunktion des Wohnens ausdrückt. Der Geograph, der Ethnograph können uns sehr verschiedene Wohnungstypen beschreiben. Der Phänomenologe bemüht sich, unter dieser Mannigfaltigkeit den Keim des zentralen, sicheren, unmittelbaren Glückes zu erfassen. In jeder Wohnung, sogar im Schloß, die Muschel des Anbeginns zu finden, das ist die erste Aufgabe des Phänomenologen.

Aber wie viele Probleme hängen daran, wenn wir die tiefe Wirklichkeit jeder einzelnen Nuance unserer Anhänglichkeit an einen einmal erwählten Ort bestimmen wollen! Für einen Phänomenologen ist die Nuance ein psychologisches Phänomen erster Ordnung. Die Nuance ist keine zusätzliche Oberflächenfärbung. Es muß also davon gesprochen werden, wie wir unseren Lebensraum in Übereinstimmung mit allen dialektischen Prinzipien des Lebens bewohnen, wie wir uns Tag für Tag in einen »Winkel der Welt« verwurzeln.

Denn das Haus ist unser Winkel der Welt. Es ist – man hat es oft gesagt – unser erstes All. Es ist wirklich ein Kosmos. Ein Kosmos in der vollen Bedeutung des Wortes. Ist nicht, als Intimität gesehen, noch die schlichteste Wohnung schön? Die Schriftsteller, die von der »kleinsten Hütte« reden, berufen sich oft auf dieses Element der Poetik des Raumes. Aber diese Berufung bleibt viel zu eingeschränkt. Da sie wenig zu beschreiben finden in der kleinsten Hütte, halten sie sich nicht lange dort auf. Sie kennzeichnen die kleinste Hütte in ihrer Alltäglichkeit, ohne wirklich ihre Ursprünglichkeit zu erleben, eine Ursprünglichkeit, die allen gehört, den Reichen wie den Armen, wenn sie sich nicht weigern zu träumen.

Aber unsere erwachsene Welt ist so arm an primären Gütern, die anthropokosmischen Bande sind in ihr so locker geworden, daß man ihre ursprüngliche Verknüpfung im All des Hauses nicht mehr spürt. Es fehlt nicht an Philosophen, die in abstrakter Weise Welten erschaffen, die im dialektischen Spiel des Ich und des Nicht-Ich ein All finden. Genau gesagt, kennen sie das Universum früher als das Haus, den Horizont früher

als den Schlupfwinkel. Aber die wirklichen Ursprünge des Bildes, phänomenologisch untersucht, werden uns die Werte des bewohnten Raumes greifbar deutlich machen, wo das Nicht-Ich das Ich beschützt. Hier berühren wir tatsächlich eine Gegenseitigkeit, deren Bilder wir erforschen müssen: jeder wirklich bewohnte Raum trägt in sich schon das Wesen des Hausbegriffes. Überall im Laufe unseres Werkes werden wir sehen, wie die Einbildungskraft in diesem Sinne arbeitet, wenn das Sein die geringste Zuflucht gefunden hat: wir werden sehen, wie die Einbildungskraft »Mauern« aus ungreifbaren Schatten baut, wie sie sich mit Illusionen von Umhegtsein stärkt — oder umgekehrt, wie sie hinter dicken Mauern zittert und die festesten Wälle in Zweifel zieht. Kurz, in der unbeendbarsten aller dialektischen Reihen sensibilisiert das beschützte Sein die Grenzen seines Zufluchtsortes. Es sieht das Haus in seiner Wirklichkeit und in seiner Möglichkeit, im Denken und im Träumen.

Von hier aus haben alle Schlupfwinkel, alle Zimmer mitklingende Traumwerte. Nicht mehr als positiver Tatbestand ist das Haus wirklich »erlebt«, nicht nur in der Stunde, die schlägt, erkennt man seine Annehmlichkeiten. Das wahre Behagen hat eine Vergangenheit. In einem neuen Haus ruft der Traum eine ganze Vergangenheit ins Leben. Die alte Redensart »Man nimmt seine Laren überall mit« hat tausend Varianten. Und die Träumerei vertieft sich soweit, daß ein unvordenkliches Reich sich dem Träumer öffnet, ausgehend vom Herd des Hauses bis hinaus über das älteste Gedächtnis. Wie das Feuer, wie das Wasser, wird uns das Haus ermöglichen, im folgenden jene Lichter der Träumerei heraufzubeschwören, welche die Synthese des Unvordenklichen und der Erinnerung beleuchten. In dieser fernen Region lassen sich Gedächtnis und Einbildungskraft nicht trennen. Das eine wie das andere arbeiten an ihrer gegenseitigen Vertiefung. Das eine wie das andere errichten in der Ordnung der Werte eine Gemeinschaft der Erinnerung und der Bilder. So lebt das Haus nicht nur von einem Tag zum andern, am Faden der Geschichte, in der Erzählung unserer Geschichte. In den Träumen durchdringen einander die verschiedenen Wohnungen unseres Lebens und hüten die Schätze der alten Tage. Wenn im neuen Hause die Erinnerungen der alten

Wohnungen wieder aufleben, reisen wir im Lande der *unbeweglichen Kindheit*, unbeweglich wie das Unvordenkliche. Wir erleben Fixierungen, und es sind Fixierungen des Glükkes [1]. Wir trösten uns, indem wir Erinnerungen an Geborgenheit nacherleben. Irgend etwas Geschlossenes muß die Erinnerungen hüten und ihnen dabei ihre Werte als Bilder bewahren. Die Erinnerungen an die äußere Welt werden niemals die gleiche Tonalität haben wie die Erinnnerungen des Hauses. Wenn wir die Erinnerungen des Hauses heraufbeschwören, fügen wir Traumwerte hinzu; wir sind niemals wirkliche Historiker, wir sind immer ein wenig Dichter, und unsere Emotion drückt vielleicht nichts anderes aus als eine verlorene Poesie.

Wenn wir also die Bilder des Hauses ansprechen, müssen wir darauf bedacht sein, die Solidarität von Gedächtnis und Einbildungskraft nicht zu zerreißen; dann können wir hoffen, die ganze psychologische Elastizität eines Bildes spürbar zu machen, das uns in unvermuteten Tiefengraden bewegt. In den Gedichten, mehr noch vielleicht als in den Erinnerungen, berühren wir den poetischen Grund des häuslichen Raumes.

Wenn man uns unter diesen Voraussetzungen nach der wertvollsten Annehmlichkeit des Hauses fragte, würden wir sagen: das Haus beschützt die Träumerei, das Haus umhegt den Träumer, das Haus erlaubt uns, in Frieden zu träumen. Nicht nur Gedanken und Erfahrungen rechtfertigen die menschlichen Werte. Auch die Träumerei hat Werte, die den Menschen in seiner Tiefe kennzeichnen. Die Träumerei hat sogar ein Privilegium, sich selbst Werte zu geben. Sie genießt unmittelbar ihr eigenes Sein. Die Orte, wo man die Träumerei gelebt hat, erstehen aus sich selbst heraus wieder in einer neuen Träumerei. Und weil die Erinnerungen an frühere Wohnungen wie Träumereien wiedererlebbar sind, darum sind die Wohnungen der Vergangenheit in uns unvergänglich.

Unser Ziel ist jetzt klar: wir müssen zeigen, daß das Haus für die Gedanken, Erinnerungen und Träume des Menschen eine der großen Integrationsmächte ist. In dieser Integration ist die Träumerei das verbindende Prinzip. Die Vergangenheit, die Gegenwart und die Zukunft geben dem Haus verschieden

geartete Dynamismen, oft interferierende, manchmal einander entgegengesetzte, manchmal einander anregende Dynamismen. Im Leben des Menschen schließt das Haus Zufälligkeiten aus, es vermehrt seine Bedachtheit auf Kontinuität. Sonst wäre der Mensch ein verstreutes Wesen. Es hält den Menschen aufrecht, durch alle Gewitter des Himmels und des Lebens hindurch. Es ist Körper und Seele. Es ist die erste Welt des menschlichen Seins. Bevor er »in die Welt geworfen« wird, wie die eiligen Metaphysiker lehren, wird der Mensch in die Wiege des Hauses gelegt. Und immer ist das Haus in unseren Träumen eine große Wiege. Eine konkrete Metaphysik darf diesen Sachverhalt nicht außer acht lassen, um so mehr, als dieser schlichte Sachverhalt ein großer Wert ist, zu dem wir in unseren Träumereien immer wieder zurückkehren. Das Sein ist sofort ein Wert. Das Leben beginnt gut, es beginnt umschlossen, umhegt, ganz warm im Schoße des Hauses.

Von unserem Gesichtspunkt aus, also vom Gesichtspunkt des Phänomenologen, der Ursprünge sieht, ist die bewußte Metaphysik, die mit dem Augenblick einsetzt, wo das Sein »in die Welt geworfen« wird, eine Metaphysik zweiter Position. Sie überspringt die Präliminarien, wo das Sein ein Wohlsein ist, wo das menschliche Wesen in ein Wohlsein hineingelegt wird, in ein Wohlsein, das mit dem Sein ursprünglich verbunden ist. Um die Metaphysik des Bewußtseins zu illustrieren, wird man die Erfahrungen abwarten müssen, in denen das menschliche Sein nach draußen geworfen wird, das heißt in dem Bilderstil, den wir studieren: vor die Tür gesetzt, außerhalb des häuslichen Seins, eine Lage, in der sich die Feindlichkeit der Menschen und die Feindlichkeit des Weltalls zusammenballen. Aber eine vollständige Metaphysik, die das Bewußtsein und das Unbewußte umfaßt, muß dem *Inneren* das Privileg seiner Werte lassen. Drinnen im Sein, im Sein des Drinnen, empfängt und umfängt eine Wärme das menschliche Wesen. Das Sein des Menschen gebietet über ein irdisches Paradies der Materie, entspannt in der Milde einer adäquaten Materie. Es scheint, daß in diesem materiellen Paradies das Sein in der Nahrung schwimmt, daß es überhäuft ist mit allen wesentlichen Gütern.

Wenn man vom Elternhaus träumt, in der tiefsten Tiefe der

Träumerei, dann hat man an dieser ersten Wärme teil, an dieser wohltemperierten Materie des materiellen Paradieses. In dieser Umgebung leben die schützenden Wesen. Wir werden auf die Mütterlichkeit des Hauses näher eingehen müssen. Im Augenblick wollten wir nur die ursprüngliche Fülle des häuslichen Seins andeuten. Unsere Träumereien führen uns dahin zurück. Und der Dichter weiß gut, daß das Haus die unbewegliche Kindheit »umarmt« hält [2]:

»O Haus, o Wiesenhang, o Abendlicht,
auf einmal bringst du's beinah zum Gesicht,
und stehst an uns, umarmend und umarmt.«

II

Wohlgemerkt, dem Haus ist es zu danken, daß eine große Zahl unserer Erinnerungen »untergebracht« sind, und wenn das Haus etwas kompliziertere Gestalt annimmt, wenn es Keller und Speicher, Winkel und Flure hat, dann bekommen unsere Erinnerungen mehr und mehr charakteristische Zufluchtsorte. Ein Psychoanalytiker müßte also seine Aufmerksamkeit dieser einfachen Lokalisierung der Erinnerungen zuwenden. Wie wir in unserer Einführung andeuteten, würden wir gern dieser zusätzlichen Analyse, die zur Psychoanalyse hinzukäme, die Bezeichnung »Topo-Analyse« geben. Die Topo-Analyse wäre also das systematische psychologische Studium der Örtlichkeiten unseres inneren Lebens. In diesem Theater der Vergangenheit, das unser Gedächtnis ist, gibt die Bühnenausstattung den handelnden Personen ihre Stichworte. Manchmal glaubt man sich in der Zeit auszukennen, wenn man doch nur eine Folge von räumlichen Fixierungen des feststehenden Seins kennt, eines Seins, das nicht verfließen will, das sogar in der Vergangenheit, auf der Suche nach der verlorenen Zeit, den Flug der Zeit »aufheben« will. In seinen tausend Honigwaben speichert der Raum verdichtete Zeit. Dazu ist der Raum da.

Und wenn man über die Geschichte hinauskommen will, ja selbst wenn man in der Geschichte bleibt oder unsere eigene Geschichte unterscheiden möchte von der stets zufälligen der

fremden Wesen, mit denen sie überfüllt ist, dann müssen wir uns darüber klar sein, daß der Kalender unseres Lebens sich nur in seiner Bilderwelt aufstellen läßt. Um unser Sein in der Rangordnung einer Ontologie zu analysieren, um unser Unbewußtes, das in primitiven Erdhütten untergebracht ist, zu psychoanalysieren, müssen wir, am Rande der normalen Psychoanalyse, unsere großen Erinnerungen *entgesellschaften* und uns auf die Ebene der Träumereien erheben, denen wir in den Räumen unserer Einsamkeit folgten. Für solche Untersuchungen sind die Träumereien nützlicher als die Träume. Und solche Untersuchungen zeigen, daß die Träumereien sehr verschieden von den Träumen sein können.

Diesen Einsamkeiten gegenübergestellt, fragt dann also der Topo-Analytiker: War das Zimmer groß? War der Speicher überfüllt? War der Winkel heiß? Und woher kam das Licht? Wie verhielt sich in diesen Räumen das menschliche Wesen zur Stille? Wie schmeckten ihm diese verschiedenen, so besonders gearteten Formen der Stille in den verschiedenen Schlupfwinkeln der einsamen Träumereien?

Hier ist der Raum alles, denn die Zeit lebt nicht im Gedächtnis. Das Gedächtnis — seltsam genug! — registriert nicht die konkrete Dauer, die Dauer im Sinne Bergsons. Die aufgehobene Dauer kann man nicht wieder aufleben lassen. Man kann sie nur denken, und zwar auf der Linie einer abstrakten, jeder Stofflichkeit beraubten Zeit. Nur mit Hilfe des Raumes, nur innerhalb des Raumes finden wir die schönen Fossilien der Dauer, konkretisiert durch lange Aufenthalte. Das Unbewußte hält sich auf. Die Erinnerungen sind unbeweglich, und um so feststehender, je besser sie verräumlicht sind. Eine Erinnerung in der Zeit zu lokalisieren, ist ein Geschäft des Biographen und hat eigentlich nur mit einer Art von externer Geschichte zu tun, einer Geschichte zum externen Gebrauch, die den andern mitgeteilt werden soll. Tiefer als die Biographie soll die Hermeneutik die Zentren des Schicksals bestimmen, indem sie die Geschichte aus ihrem verbindenden zeitlichen Gewebe herauslöst, das ohne Wirkung auf unser Schicksal ist. Dringlicher als die Bestimmung der Daten ist hier die Kenntnis der Intimität, jedenfalls die Lokalisierung in den Räumen unserer Intimität.

Die Psychoanalyse versetzt allzu oft die Leidenschaften »in die Welt«, sie säkularisiert sie gleichsam. In Wirklichkeit kochen und brodeln die Leidenschaften in der Einsamkeit. Eingeschlossen in die Einsamkeit bereitet das Wesen der Leidenschaft seine Ausbrüche oder seine Unternehmungen vor.

Und wenn alle Räume unserer Einsamkeit hinter uns zurückgeblieben sind, bleiben doch die Räume, wo wir Einsamkeit erlitten, genossen, herbeigesehnt oder verraten haben, in uns unauslöschlich. Und genaugenommen will das Sein sie gar nicht auslöschen. Es weiß instinktiv, daß diese Räume der Einsamkeit zu seinen Grundlagen gehören. Selbst wenn diese Räume für immer aus der Gegenwart getilgt sind, fremd geworden allen Zukunftsverheißungen, selbst wenn man keinen Speicher mehr besitzt, selbst wenn man die Dachstube verloren hat, immer wird es wahr bleiben, daß man einen Speicher geliebt hat, in einer Dachstube gelebt hat. In den Träumen der Nacht kehrt man dahin zurück. Diese Zufluchtsorte haben den Wert einer Muschel. Und wenn man in den Labyrinthen des Schlafes bis ans Ende geht, wenn man zu den Regionen des Tiefschlafs hinabtaucht, kennt man vielleicht Zustände einer *vormenschlichen* Ruhe. Das Vormenschliche berührt sich hier mit dem Unvordenklichen. Aber sogar in der Träumerei des Tages werden die Erinnerungen an Zustände enger, schlichter, geschlossener Einsamkeit uns zu Erfahrungen eines tröstlichen Raumes, eines Raumes, der sich nicht auszudehnen wünscht, sondern der vor allem immer noch in Besitz genommen werden möchte. Früher konnte man gewiß die Dachstube zu eng finden, im Winter zu kalt, im Sommer zu heiß. Aber jetzt, in der Erinnerung, die in der Träumerei wiedergefunden wird, ist die Dachstube, wer weiß durch welchen Synkretismus, klein und groß, warm und kühl, doch immer tröstend.

III

Hier an der Schwelle der Topo-Analyse müssen wir eine Nuance betonen. Wir gaben zu verstehen, daß das Unbewußte »untergebracht« sei. Es muß hinzugefügt werden, daß das Unbewußte gut und glücklich untergebracht ist. Es ist unterge-

bracht im Raume seines Glückes. Das normale Unbewußte kann sichs überall wohl sein lassen. Die Psychoanalyse kommt dem ausquartierten Unbewußten zu Hilfe, dem brutal oder hinterlistig ausquartierten Unbewußten. Aber die Psychoanalyse bringt das Sein eher in Unruhe als zur Ruhe. Sie veranlaßt das Sein, außerhalb der Schlupfwinkel des Unbewußten zu leben, sich in die Abenteuer des Lebens einzulassen, aus sich selbst herauszugehen. Und natürlich ist das eine heilsame Tat. Denn man muß dem Sein von drinnen auch ein Schicksal im Draußen geben. Um die Psychoanalyse in dieser heilsamen Aktion zu begleiten, müßte man eine Topo-Analyse aller der Räume unternehmen, die uns aus uns selbst nach draußen rufen. Obgleich wir unsere Forschungen auf die Träumereien von der Ruhe konzentrieren, dürfen wir nicht vergessen, daß es eine Träumerei des schreitenden Menschen gibt, eine Träumerei des Weges.

Bringt mich fort, Wege! ...

sagt Marceline Desbordes-Valmore und denkt dabei an ihre flandrische Heimat. Und welch ein schönes dynamisches Objekt ist ein Weg! Wie deutlich sie für das Muskelbewußtsein bleiben, diese vertrauten Wege an den Hügeln! Ein Dichter beschwört diese ganze Dynamik in einem einzigen Vers herauf:

O meine Wege und ihre Kadenz
(Jean Caubère, Déserts)

Wenn ich den Weg, der den Hügel »hinanklomm«, dynamisch wiedersehe, bin ich mir sicher, daß der Weg selbst Muskeln hatte, Gegen-Muskeln. In meinem Pariser Zimmer ist es mir eine gute Übung, mich in dieser Weise an den Weg zu erinnern. Indem ich diese Zeilen schreibe, fühle ich mich von meinem Pflichtspaziergang befreit — ich bin sicher, ausgegangen zu sein.

Und man fände tausend Bindeglieder zwischen der Wirklichkeit und den Symbolen, wenn man den Dingen alle Bewegungen gäbe, die sie in die Vorstellung rufen. George Sand sieht das Leben hinfließen, als sie am Saum eines gelben Sandweges ins Träumen gerät. Sie schreibt: »Was gibt es denn Schöneres

als einen Weg? Er ist das Symbol und das Bild des tätigen, vielfältigen Lebens.« (Consuelo, II., S. 116)

So könnte ein jeder von seinen Wegen, seinen Wegkreuzungen, seinen Bänken sprechen. Thoreau hat, wie er sagt, den Plan der Felder in seiner Seele eingezeichnet. Und Jean Wahl darf schreiben:

Das Wogen der Hecken
Ich hab' es in mir.
(Poèmes)

Wir bedecken derart das All mit den Mustern unseres Erlebens. Diese Muster brauchen nicht genau zu stimmen. Sie müssen nur auf den Ton unseres inneren Raumes abgestimmt sein. Aber was müßte man für ein Buch schreiben, um all diese Probleme zu behandeln! Der Raum ruft die Aktion, und vor der Aktion arbeitet die Einbildungskraft. Sie mäht und pflügt. Man müßte die Nützlichkeit aller imaginären Leistungen hervorheben. Die Psychoanalyse hat ihre Beobachtungen über den Projektionsmechanismus vermehrt, über die extravertierten Charaktere, die immer bereit sind, ihre innersten Eindrücke zu äußern. Eine Topo-Analyse der Äußerungsweise könnte vielleicht dieses projektive Verhalten genauer umreißen, wenn sie die Gegenstandsträumereien definieren würde. Aber im vorliegenden Werk können wir nicht, wie es nötig wäre, die doppelte Geometrie, die doppelte imaginäre Physik der Extraversion und der Introversion aufstellen. Wir glauben übrigens nicht, daß diese beiden Physiken das gleiche seelische Gewicht hätten. Unsere Untersuchungen widmen wir der Region der Intimität, der Region, deren seelisches Gewicht dominiert.

Wir werden uns also der Anziehungskraft aller Intimitätsregionen anvertrauen. Es gibt keine wahre Intimität, die abstieße. Alle Räume der Intimität sind durch eine Anziehung gekennzeichnet. Wiederholen wir nochmals, daß ihr Sein ein Wohlsein ist. Unter diesen Bedingungen hat die Topo-Analyse das Gesicht einer Topo-Philie. Im Sinne dieser Bewertung studieren wir die Schlupfwinkel und Zimmer.

IV

Diese Zufluchtswerte sind so einfach und so tief im Unbewußten verwurzelt, daß man sie eher durch einen einfachen Anruf findet als durch eine minutiöse Beschreibung. Die Nuance gibt dann die Farbe an. Das Wort eines Dichters, weil es die richtige Stelle berührt, erschüttert die tiefen Schichten unseres Seins.

Das übermäßig Pittoreske eines Wohnraumes kann seine Intimität verdecken. Das ist wahr im Leben. Wahrer noch in der Träumerei. Die echten Häuser der Erinnerung, die Häuser, zu denen unsere Träume uns immer wieder zurückführen, die Häuser, die reich sind an getreuen Traumgehalten, widerstreben jeder Beschreibung. Sie beschreiben, hieße sie besuchen. Von der Gegenwart kann man vielleicht alles sagen, aber von der Vergangenheit! Das früheste und für die Traumgehalte entscheidende Haus muß seine Dämmerung behalten. Es untersteht der Literatur der Tiefe, also der Poesie, und nicht der redseligen Literatur, die den Roman der andern braucht, um die Innerlichkeit von außen her zu analysieren. Alles was ich vom Hause meiner Kindheit sagen kann, ist genau dies, was nötig ist, um mich selbst in die Situation des Träumens zu bringen, um mich an die Schwelle einer Träumerei zu versetzen, wo ich mich in meiner Vergangenheit ausruhe. Dann nur kann ich hoffen, daß meine Zeilen einige echte Klänge enthalten, ich meine, eine Stimme, die in mir selbst aus solcher Ferne kommt, daß sie die Stimme sein kann, die alle vernehmen, wenn sie in die Tiefe des Gedächtnisses lauschen, bis zur Grenze des Gedächtnisses, vielleicht über das Gedächtnis hinaus in das Feld des Unvordenklichen. Man teilt den andern nichts weiter mit als eine Weisung auf das Geheimnis hin, ohne das Geheimnis jemals objektiv aussagen zu können. Das Geheimnis hat niemals eine totale Objektivität. Auf diesem Wege gibt man den Traumvorgängen die Richtung, man vollzieht sie nicht [3].

Wem wäre es zum Beispiel dienlich, den Grundriß des Zimmers aufzuzeichnen, das wirklich *mein* Zimmer war, das kleine Zimmer in der Tiefe eines Dachbodens zu beschreiben, zu sa-

gen, daß man durch das Fenster, zwischen den Giebeln hindurch, den Hügel erblickte. Ich allein vermag in meinen Erinnerungen, aus einem anderen Jahrhundert, den tiefen Wandschrank zu öffnen, der für mich allein noch seinen einzigartigen Duft bewahrt hat, den Duft der Trauben, die auf dem Holzrost trocknen. Der Duft der Trauben! Er ist an der Grenze, man muß viel Einbildungskraft haben, um ihn zu empfinden. Aber ich habe schon zuviel davon gesagt. Wenn ich mehr sagen würde, könnte der Leser nicht in seinem eigenen wiedergefundenen Zimmer den einmaligen Schrank öffnen, den Schrank mit dem einmaligen Geruch, der eine Innerlichkeit kennzeichnet. Um die Werte des Intimen, der Innerlichkeit heraufzubeschwören, muß man paradoxerweise den Leser dazu führen, daß er die Lektüre unterbricht. In dem Augenblick, wo die Augen des Lesers das Buch verlassen, kann die Beschwörung meines Zimmers für einen andern zur Schwelle des Traumgeschehens werden. Wenn es aber ein Dichter ist, der spricht, dann hallt die Seele des Lesers wider, sie erfährt jenen Widerhall, der, wie Minkowski darlegt, dem Sein die Energie eines Ursprungs zurückgibt.

Auf der Ebene einer Philosophie der Literatur und der Poesie, auf die wir uns stellen, hat es also einen Sinn zu sagen: man »schreibt ein Zimmer«, man »liest ein Zimmer«, man »liest ein Haus«. Denn sehr bald, nach den ersten Worten, nach der ersten poetischen Eröffnung, unterbricht der Leser, der »ein Zimmer liest«, seine Lektüre und beginnt an irgendeinen früheren Aufenthaltsort zu denken. Ihr möchtet alles sagen über euer Zimmer. Ihr möchtet den Leser für euch selbst interessieren, wo ihr doch der Träumerei eine Tür geöffnet habt. Die Werte des Intimen sind so absorbierend, daß der Leser euer Zimmer nicht mehr liest: er sieht das seinige wieder. Schon ist er ausgezogen, um die Erinnerungen eines Vaters, einer Ahnfrau, einer Mutter, einer Dienerin zu hören, jener »Dienerin mit dem großen Herzen« (Baudelaire), kurz, jenes Wesens, das den Winkel seiner wertvollsten Erinnerungen beherrscht.

Und das Haus der Erinnerung wird psychologisch komplex. Zu den Zufluchtsorten der Einsamkeit gesellen sich das Zimmer, der Saal, wo die dominierenden Wesen regiert haben. Das

Elternhaus ist ein bewohntes Haus. Die Werte der Intimität zerstreuen sich darin, sie stabilisieren sich nicht recht, sie sind dialektischen Gegensätzen unterworfen. Wie viele Kindheitserzählungen – wenn Kindheitserzählungen aufrichtig wären – müßten berichten, wie das Kind, in Ermangelung eines eigenen Zimmers, in seinem Winkel schmollt!

Doch über die Erinnerungen hinaus ist das Elternhaus physisch in uns eingezeichnet. Es besteht aus einer Gruppe von organischen Gewohnheiten. Aus einem Abstand von zwanzig Jahren, allen anonymen späteren Treppen zum Trotz, würden wir noch die Reflexe jener »frühesten Treppe« wiedererkennen, über eine bestimmte, etwas zu hohe Stufe würden wir nicht stolpern. Das ganze Sein des Hauses würde sich entfalten, unserem eigenen Sein treu geblieben. Wir würden die Tür aufstoßen, die noch das gleiche Knarren hat, ohne Licht würden wir in den entlegenen Speicher gehen. Das Gefühl der kleinsten Klinke ist noch in unserer Hand.

Zweifellos haben die Häuser, die wir später eines nach dem andern bewohnten, unsere Gesten banalisiert. Aber wir sind sehr überrascht, wenn wir in das alte Haus zurückkehren, nach den Dekaden einer Odyssee, daß die leisesten Gesten, die frühesten Gesten plötzlich wiederaufleben, vollkommen wie immer. Im ganzen genommen, hat das Elternhaus uns die Hierarchie der verschiedenen Funktionen des Wohnens eingeprägt. Wir sind das Diagramm der Wohnfunktionen, jenes Haus und alle andern Häuser sind nur Variationen eines fundamentalen Themas. Das Wort Gewohnheit wird allzu häufig gebraucht, um diese passionierte Bindung unseres Körpers, der nicht vergißt, an das unvergeßliche Haus zu bezeichnen.

Aber diese Region der wohldetaillierten Erinnerungen, leicht behütet durch die Namen der Dinge und der Wesen, die im Elternhaus gewohnt haben, kann auch von der landläufigen Psychologie studiert werden. Verworrener, weniger gut gezeichnet, sind die Erinnerungen der Träume, die wiederaufzufinden allein die dichterische Meditation uns helfen kann. Die Dichtkunst gibt uns die Situationen des Traumes wieder. Das Elternhaus ist nicht nur ein Wohngebäude, es ist auch ein Traumgebäude. Jeder seiner Winkel war ein Zufluchtsort für die Träu-

merei. Und der Zufluchtsort hat oft der Träumerei ihren besonderen Charakter gegeben. Dort haben wir besondere Gewohnheiten der Träumerei angenommen. Das Haus, das Zimmer, der Speicher, wo man allein gewesen ist, geben den Rahmen ab für eine unbeendbare Träumerei, eine Träumerei, die allein die Dichtkunst in einem Werk beenden, vollenden könnte. Wenn alle diese Verstecke für uns die Bestimmung hatten, Träume zu beherbergen, so kann man sagen, wie ich in einem früheren Buche angedeutet habe, daß für einen jeden von uns ein Traumhaus existiert, ein Haus der Traum-Erinnerung, verloren im Schatten eines Jenseits der wahren Vergangenheit. Dieses Traumhaus, sagte ich, ist die Krypta des Elternhauses. Wir sind hier am Drehpunkt der wechselseitigen Interpretationen des Traumes durch das Denken und des Denkens durch den Traum. Das Wort Interpretation macht diese Kehrtwendungen zu steif. Richtiger ausgedrückt, befinden wir uns hier in der Einheit von Bild und Erinnerung, in der gemischten Funktion von Einbildungskraft und Gedächtnis. Die bloße Tatsachenforschung von psychologischer Geschichte und psychologischer Geographie kann hier nicht als Prüfstein dienen, um das *wahre Sein* unserer Kindheit zu bestimmen. Die Kindheit ist gewiß größer als die Wirklichkeit. Durch alle unsere Lebensalter hindurch unsere Anhänglichkeit an das Elternhaus erfahrbar zu erhalten, dazu ist der Traum fähiger als das Denken. Die Mächte des Unbewußten sind es, welche die entlegensten Erinnerungen fixieren. Gäbe es nicht im Elternhaus ein kompaktes Zentrum für die Träumereien von der Ruhe, dann hätten die so verschiedenartigen Umstände, die das wahre Leben umgeben, die Erinnerungen in Verwirrung gebracht. Außer einigen Medaillen mit den Bildnissen unserer Vorfahren enthält unser Kindergedächtnis nur abgenutzte Münzen. Erst auf der Ebene der Träumerei, und nicht etwa auf der Ebene der Fakten, bleibt die Kindheit in uns lebendig und dichterisch nützlich. Mittels dieser beständigen Kindheit halten wir die Poesie der Vergangenheit fest. Das Elternhaus im Traumvorgang bewohnen ist mehr als es in der Erinnerung bewohnen, es heißt in dem verschwundenen Hause leben, wie wir darin geträumt haben.

Welches Privileg der Tiefe gibt es in den Kinderträumereien! Glücklich das Kind, das seine einsamen Stunden besessen hat, wirklich besessen! Es ist gut, es ist gesund, daß ein Kind manchmal Langeweile hat, daß es die Dialektik des übermütigen Spiels und der grundlosen Langeweile, der reinen Langeweile kennt. In seinen Lebenserinnerungen erzählt Alexander Dumas, daß er sich als Kind oft langweilte, bis zu Tränen langweilte. Wenn seine Mutter ihn so vorfand, weinend vor Langeweile, dann fragte sie ihn:

»Und warum weint Dumas?«

»Dumas weint, weil Dumas Tränen hat«,

antwortete das sechsjährige Kind. Gewiß ist das eine Anekdote, wie man sie in Lebenserinnerungen erzählt. Aber wie gut bezeichnet sie die absolute Langeweile, die Langeweile, die nicht im Fehlen von Spielkameraden begründet ist! Gibt es doch Kinder, die das Spiel verlassen, um sich in einem Winkel des Speichers zu langweilen. Speicher meiner Langeweile, wie oft habe ich mich nach dir zurückgesehnt, wenn das vielfältige Leben mich um den eigentlichen Keim aller Freiheit betrog.

Über alle realen Geborgenheitswerte hinaus entstehen also im Elternhaus die Werte des Traumes, die letzten Werte, die bleiben, wenn das Haus nicht mehr ist. Zentren der Langeweile, Zentren der Einsamkeit, Zentren der Träumereien verbinden sich zu Gruppen, um das Traumhaus zu gründen, das dauerhafter ist als die im Elternhaus verstreuten Erinnerungen. Lange phänomenologische Untersuchungen wären nötig, um alle diese Traumwerte zu bestimmen, um die Tiefe dieses Traumfeldes auszusagen, wo die Erinnerungen wurzeln.

Und vergessen wir nicht, daß es diese Traumwerte sind, die dichterisch von Seele zu Seele weitergegeben werden. Die Lektüre der Dichter ist im wesentlichen Träumerei.

V

Das Haus ist ein Verband von Bildern, die dem Menschen eine Stabilität beweisen oder vortäuschen. Unaufhörlich stellt man sich seine Wirklichkeit vor: alle diese Bilder zu unter-

scheiden, hieße die Seele des Hauses aussagen; es hieße eine wirkliche Psychologie des Hauses entwickeln.

Um Ordnung in diese Bilder zu bringen, muß man, so glauben wir, zwei Hauptmöglichkeiten des Verbandes ins Auge fassen.

1. Das Haus, vorgestellt als ein vertikales Wesen. Es erhebt sich. Es differenziert sich im vertikalen Sinne. Es ist eine der Anregungen für unser Vertikalbewußtsein.

2. Das Haus, vorgestellt als ein konzentriertes Wesen. Es weckt in uns ein Zentralisierungsbewußtsein.

Diese beiden Möglichkeiten sind gewiß recht abstrakt ausgesprochen. Aber es ist nicht schwierig, an Beispielen ihren psychologisch konkreten Charakter zu erkennen.

Die Vertikalrichtung ist gesichert durch die Polarität von Keller und Dachboden. Die Merkmale dieser Polarität sind so einschneidend, daß sie gewissermaßen zwei sehr verschiedene Achsen für eine Phänomenologie der Einbildungskraft bilden. Fast kommentarlos läßt sich die Rationalität des Daches der Irrationalität des Kellers entgegensetzen. Das Dach spricht sofort seinen Daseinszweck aus: es beschirmt den Menschen, der den Regen und die Sonne fürchtet. Die Geographen erinnern immer wieder daran, daß in jedem Lande die Neigung des Daches eines der sichersten Kennzeichen des Klimas ist. Man »versteht« die Schrägstellung des Daches. Sogar der Träumer träumt rational: für ihn durchschneidet das spitze Dach die Wolken. Wenn es sich um das Dach handelt, sind alle Gedanken klar. Im Dachboden sieht man mit Vergnügen das starre Gerippe des Balkenwerks bloßgelegt. Man hat teil an der soliden Geometrie des Zimmermanns.

Und der Keller? Gewiß wird man ihn nützlich finden. Man wird ihn rationalisieren, indem man seine Bequemlichkeiten aufzählt. Zuerst ist er jedoch das dunkle Wesen des Hauses, das Wesen, das an den unterirdischen Mächten teilhat. Wenn man dort ins Träumen gerät, kommt man in Kontakt mit der Irrationalität der Tiefen.

Für diese doppelte vertikale Polarität des Hauses wird man ein Gefühl bekommen, wenn man die Funktion des Wohnens

als imaginäre Wiederholung der Funktion des Bauens auffaßt. Die oberen Stockwerke, vor allem der Dachboden, sind eine »Erbauung« des Träumers, er erbaut sie, im inneren Nachvollzug ihres Bauvorgangs. Mit unseren Träumen in der lichten Höhe befinden wir uns, wie gesagt, in der rationalen Zone intellektualisierter Entwürfe. Aber was den Keller betrifft, so gräbt sich der passionierte Bewohner in ihn ein, gräbt ihn immer wieder nach, schachtet ihn aus, macht seine Tiefe aktiv. Das Faktum genügt nicht, die Träumerei arbeitet. Wenn sie sich in die Tiefe der Erde eingraben, gibt es für die Träume keine Grenze. Im folgenden werden wir Beispiele von Ultrakellerträumen anführen. Zunächst bleiben wir aber in dem zwischen Keller und Speicher polarisierten Raum und sehen zu, wie dieser polarisierte Raum dazu dienen kann, die feinsten psychologischen Nuancen zu illustrieren.

So bedient sich der Psychoanalytiker C. G. Jung des doppelten Bildes von Keller und Speicher, um die Ängste zu analysieren, die das Haus bewohnen. Tatsächlich findet man in einem Buch von Jung einen Vergleich, der die Hoffnung verständlich machen soll, die das bewußte Wesen hegt, »die Autonomie der Komplexe zu vernichten, indem man sie umtauft«. Das Bild sieht wie folgt aus: »Das Bewußtsein benimmt sich wie ein Mensch, der ein verdächtiges Geräusch im Keller gehört hat und zum Dachboden eilt, um dort festzustellen, daß keine Diebe da sind und infolgedessen das Geräusch reine Einbildung war. In Wirklichkeit hat dieser vorsichtige Mann sich nicht in den Keller hinuntergewagt« [4].

Wenn die bildliche Erklärung Jungs uns überzeugt, erleben wir als Leser im phänomenologischen Sinne die beiden Ängste mit: die Angst im Dachboden und die Angst im Keller. Anstatt dem Keller (dem Unbewußten) die Stirn zu bieten, sucht der »vorsichtige Mann« Jungs auf dem Dachboden Alibis für seinen Mut. Im Dachboden können Mäuse und Ratten ihr geräuschvolles Unwesen treiben. Wenn der Hausherr dazukommt, verkriechen sie sich in die Stille ihrer Löcher. Im Keller bewegen sich langsamere Wesen, die nicht so rasch laufen und geheimnisvoller sind. Im Speicher lassen sich die Ängste leicht rationalisieren. Im Keller ist die Rationalisierung, selbst für einen

Mann, der mutiger wäre, als Jung ihn darstellt, weniger rasch und weniger klar; sie ist niemals endgültig. Im Speicher kann die Erfahrung des Tages immer wieder die Ängste der Nacht auslöschen. Im Keller verharren die Dunkelheiten Tag und Nacht. Sogar mit dem Leuchter in der Hand sieht der Mensch im Keller die Schatten über die schwarzen Mauern tanzen.

Wenn man das Beispiel von Jung bis zur vollständigen Erfassung der psychologischen Wirklichkeit weiterverfolgt, so trifft man auf eine Zusammenarbeit der Psychoanalyse und der Phänomenologie, eine Zusammenarbeit, die immer wieder hervorzuheben sein wird, wenn es darauf ankommt, das menschliche Phänomen zu umfassen. Man muß das Bild phänomenologisch verstehen, bevor man ihm eine psychoanalytische Wirksamkeit geben kann. Der Phänomenologe wird hier das Bild des Psychoanalytikers in einer Sympathiebewegung akzeptieren. Er wird die Ursprünglichkeit und Besonderheit der Ängste wiederaufleben lassen. In unserer Zivilisationsepoche, die das gleiche Licht überallhin verbreitet und auch den Keller elektrisch beleuchtet, geht man nicht mehr mit dem Leuchter in den Keller. Das Unbewußte läßt sich aber nicht zivilisieren. Es nimmt den Leuchter, um in den Keller hinabzusteigen. Der Psychoanalytiker kann nicht auf der Oberfläche der Metaphern oder Vergleiche bleiben. Der Phänomenologe aber muß bis zur äußersten Bedeutung der Bilder gehen: weit entfernt von Vereinfachungen und Erklärungen, wird er die Übertreibung noch übertreiben. So werden beim Lesen der Erzählungen von Edgar Poe der Phänomenologe und der Psychoanalytiker in vereinter Arbeit den verborgenen Gehalt verstehen. Die Erzählungen sind Kindheitsängste, die sich erfüllen. Der Leser, der sich ihrer Lektüre »hingibt«, hört die verwunschene Katze, das Zeichen für ungesühnte Schuld, hinter der Mauer miauen [5]. Der Kellerträumer weiß, daß die Mauern des Kellers in der Erde stecken, und die ganze Erde hinter einer einzigen dünnen Scheidewand. Und das Drama wird dadurch gesteigert, und die Angst übertrieben. Aber was ist eine Angst, die aufhört zu übertreiben?

In einer solchen Sympathiebewegung spitzt der Phänomenologe die Ohren »auf gleicher Höhe mit dem Wahnsinn«, wie

der Dichter Thoby Marcelin sagt. Dann ist der Keller vergrabener Wahnsinn, vermauertes Drama. Die Berichte von Verbrecherkellern hinterlassen im Gedächtnis unauslöschliche Spuren, die man nicht gerne vertieft — wer möchte die *Barique* von Amontillado zweimal lesen? Hier ist das Drama zu leicht, aber es macht sich natürliche Ängste zunutze, Ängste, die in der doppelten Natur des Menschen und des Hauses liegen.

Doch ohne eine Akte menschlicher Dramen aufzuschlagen, wollen wir einige Ultra-Keller studieren, die uns auf einfachste Art beweisen, daß der Kellertraum unweigerlich die Wirklichkeit vermehrt.

Wenn das Haus des Träumers in der Stadt liegt, handelt es sich im Traum nicht selten darum, durch die Tiefe die umliegenden Keller zu beherrschen. Er wünscht sich die unterirdischen Räume von Sagenburgen, wo geheimnisvolle Wege unter der ganzen Ringmauer, unter jedem Wall, jedem Graben hindurch, das Zentrum des Schlosses mit dem fernen Wald verbanden. Das Schloß, auf die Spitze eines Hügels gepflanzt, hatte ein reichgebündeltes Wurzelwerk von unterirdischen Räumen und Gängen. Welch eine Macht für ein einfaches Haus, über einem Netz von unterirdischen Räumen erbaut zu sein!

In den Romanen von Henri Bosco, diesem großen Häuserträumer, begegnet man solchen Ultra-Kellern. Unter dem Haus des *Antiquars* (in dem gleichnamigen Roman) befindet sich »eine gewölbte Rotunde mit vier Türen«. Die vier Türen führen zu vier Gängen, die gewissermaßen die vier Himmelsrichtungen eines unterirdischen Horizontes beherrschen. Die östliche Tür öffnet sich, und dann »gehen wir unterirdisch sehr weit, unter den Häusern dieses Stadtviertels . . .« Diese Seiten tragen die Spur von labyrinthischen Träumen. Doch den Labyrinthen der Gänge »mit der dumpfen Luft« verbinden sich Rotunden und Kapellen, die Heiligtümer des Verborgenen. So wird der Keller des Antiquars, wenn man so sagen darf, zu einem komplexen Traumgeschehen. Der Leser soll ihn mit Träumen erforschen, die sich teils auf das Leiden in den Gängen, teils auf das Erstaunen über die unterirdischen Paläste beziehen. Der Leser kann sich darin verlieren (im buchstäblichen

wie im bildlichen Sinne). Zuerst sieht er nicht deutlich die literarische Notwendigkeit einer so komplizierten Geometrie. Hier wird die phänomenologische Untersuchung ihre Tragweite zeigen. Was rät uns die phänomenologische Haltung? Sie verlangt von uns einen Leser-Ehrgeiz, der uns die Illusion gäbe, selbst an der Arbeit des Buchschöpfers teilzunehmen. Eine solche Haltung wird man kaum gleich bei der ersten Lektüre annehmen können. Die erste Lektüre bewahrt zuviel Passivität. Der Leser ist noch ein wenig Kind, ein von der Lektüre zerstreutes Kind. Aber jedes gute Buch soll kurz nach Beendung sofort wiedergelesen werden. Nach der Skizze der ersten Lektüre kommt erst das eigentliche Lesewerk. Man muß dann das *Problem* des Autors erkennen. Nach und nach bringt uns die zweite, dritte Lektüre die Lösung dieses Problems. Unmerklich machen wir uns die Illusion, daß Problem und Lösung die unsrigen seien. Diese psychologische Nuance »Das hätten wir schreiben sollen« macht uns zum Phänomenologen des Lesens. Solange wir nicht zu dieser Nuance gelangen, bleiben wir Psychologe oder Psychoanalytiker.

Welches ist das literarische Problem von Henri Bosco in der Beschreibung des Ultra-Kellers? Es liegt darin, einen ganzen Roman in einem Bilde zu verkörpern, einen Roman, der in seiner Hauptlinie der Roman der unterirdischen Umtriebe ist. Diese geläufige Metapher ist hier durch vielfältige Kellerräume illustriert, durch ein Netz von Stollen, eine Gruppe von Zellen mit oft schwer verschlossenen Türen. Man überdenkt dort Geheimnisse; man bereitet Pläne vor. Und unter der Erde nimmt die Aktion ihren Weg. Wir sind wirklich im intimen Raum von unterirdischen Umtrieben.

In einem solchen Untergeschoß also wollen die Hauptpersonen des Romans, die Antiquare, Schicksale verknüpfen. Der Keller von Henri Bosco mit seinem Netz von Verzweigungen ist ein Stickrahmen für Schicksalsmuster. Der Held, der seine Abenteuer erzählt, hat selbst einen schicksalhaften Ring, einen Ring mit einem von uralten Zeichen gekerbten Stein. Das im eigentlichen Sinne unterirdische, im eigentlichen Sinne höllische Werk der Antiquare wird scheitern. Im gleichen Augenblick, wo zwei große Liebesgeschicke sich knüpfen sollen, stirbt im

Keller des verwunschenen Hauses eine der schönsten Sylphiden des Romandichters, ein Wesen des Gartens und des Turmes, das Wesen, welches das Glück bringen sollte. Ein etwas aufmerksamer Leser, der die unter der psychologischen Erzählung stets wirksam bleibende Begleitmelodie kosmischer Dichtung in den Romanen Boscos nicht überhört, ein solcher Leser wird auf sehr vielen Seiten des Buches Zeugnis für das Drama des Luftigen und des Irdischen finden. Aber um solche Dramen zu erleben, muß man wiederlesen, muß man das Interesse verlagern oder die Lektüre mit dem doppelten Interesse am Menschen und an den Dingen betreiben und nichts von dem anthropokosmischen Gewebe eines Menschenlebens vernachlässigen.

In einer anderen Wohnung, in die uns der Romandichter führt, steht der Ultra-Keller nicht mehr unter dem Zeichen der finsteren Pläne höllischer Männer. Er ist wahrhaft natürlich, in die Natur einer unterirdischen Welt eingelassen. Henri Bosco folgend, erleben wir ein Haus mit kosmischer Wurzel.

Dieses Haus mit kosmischer Wurzel erscheint uns dann wie eine steinerne Pflanze, die aus dem Felsen herauswächst bis zum Himmelsblau eines Turmes.

Der Held des Romans *L'antiquaire* wird bei einem heimlichen Besuch überrascht und muß sich im Untergeschoß eines Hauses verstecken. Aber sofort geht das Interesse vom realen Bericht zum kosmischen Bericht über. Die Realitäten dienen hier nur dazu, Träume vorzubereiten. Zuerst ist man noch in dem Labyrinth der in den Felsen geschnittenen Gänge. Dann plötzlich trifft man auf ein nächtliches Wasser. Damit wird für uns die Romanhandlung unterbrochen. Den Gewinn dieser Zeilen werden wir nur dann aufnehmen, wenn wir mit unseren Träumen in den Raum der Nacht eintreten. Und wirklich wird ein großer Traum, der die Aufrichtigkeit der Elemente hat, in die Erzählung eingeschoben. Lesen wir dieses Gedicht von dem kosmischen Keller [6].

»Gerade zu meinen Füßen trat das Wasser aus der Finsternis.

Wasser! ... Ein unermeßliches Becken! Und was für ein Wasser! ... Ein schwarzes, schlafendes Wasser, so vollkommen glatt, daß kein Wellchen, keine Luftblase die Oberfläche trübte.

Keine Quelle, kein Ursprung. Es war dort seit Jahrtausenden, vom Felsen umschlossen, dehnte sich in einem einzigen regungslosen Spiegel aus und schien in seiner Steinfassung diesem schwarzen Stein ähnlich geworden, unbeweglich, gefangen in der mineralischen Welt. Es hatte die zermalmende Masse, den enormen Druck dieser lastenden Welt erlitten. Unter diesem Gewicht hatte es gleichsam seine Natur verändert, indem es durch die Dichte der Kalkplatten hindurchsickerte, die sein Geheimnis hüteten. So war es zur dichtesten Flüssigkeit des unterirdischen Gebirges geworden. Seine ungewohnte Undurchsichtigkeit und Konsistenz [7] machte etwas wie einen unbekannten Stoff aus ihm, geladen mit Phosphoreszenzen, von denen nur dann und wann ein flüchtiger Widerschein die Oberfläche streifte. Diese elektrischen Farbfunken, Anzeichen der dunklen Mächte, die in den Tiefen ruhen, bekundeten das verborgene Leben und die bedrohliche Macht des noch schlummernden Elements. Ich schauderte.«

Dieses Schaudern ist nicht mehr eine menschliche Furcht, man spürt es gut, sondern eine anthropokosmische Furcht, ein Widerhall der großen Sage vom Menschen, der zu seinen Ursprungssituationen zurückkehrt. Vom Keller, der in den Fels geschnitten ist, zum unterirdischen Reich, vom unterirdischen Reich zum schlafenden Wasser — so sind wir aus der gebauten Welt in die geträumte Welt hinübergeglitten; und vom Roman zur Poesie. Aber das Wirkliche und der Traum bilden jetzt eine Einheit. Das Haus, der Keller, die tiefe Erde erreichen eine Totalität in der Tiefe. Das Haus ist ein Naturwesen geworden. Es ist mit dem Berg und den Wassern, die in der Erde arbeiten, brüderlich verbunden. Die große Pflanze aus Stein, das Haus, würde schlecht wachsen, wenn sie nicht das Wasser der Untergeschosse als Basis hätte. So schreiten die Träume fort, in ihrer Größe ohne Grenze.

Diese Zeilen von Bosco bringen dem Leser durch ihre kosmische Träumerei eine große Ruhe, da sie von ihm verlangen, an jener Ruhe teilzunehmen, die jedes tiefe Traumgeschehen gewährt. Die Erzählung hält sich dann in einer unterbrochenen Zeit auf, die der psychologischen Vertiefung günstig ist. Jetzt kann die Erzählung der wirklichen Ereignisse wieder aufge-

nommen werden: sie hat ihren Anteil an kosmischem Gehalt und an Träumerei empfangen. Tatsächlich: jenseits des unterirdischen Wassers gibt es wieder Treppen im Keller Boscos. Nach der dichterischen Ausrast kann die Wanderung ihren Fortgang nehmen: »Eine Treppe schnitt in den Felsen ein und stieg in Windungen empor. Ich folgte ihr.« Durch diese Schraube windet sich der Träumer aus den Tiefen der Erde heraus und tritt in die Abenteuer der Höhe ein. Am Ausgang so vieler gewundener und enger Wege mündet der Leser in einen Turm. Dieser Turm ist der ideale Turm, der jeden Träumer von alten Häusern entzückt: er ist »vollkommen rund«; er ist umgeben von einem »kurzen Licht«, das »aus einem engen Fenster« fällt. Und die Decke ist gewölbt. Welches große Traumprinzip der Intimität — eine gewölbte Decke! Ohne Ende reflektiert sie die Innerlichkeit in ihrem Zentrum. Man wird nicht erstaunt sein, daß das Turmzimmer die Wohnung eines sanften jungen Mädchens ist und außerdem bewohnt von den Erinnerungen an eine leidenschaftliche Ahnfrau. In seiner Höhe ist das runde, gewölbte Zimmer isoliert. Es hütet die Vergangenheit, wie es den Raum beherrscht.

Auf dem Gebetbuch des jungen Mädchens, diesem Gebetbuch, das einst der fernen Ahnfrau gehört hat, kann man den Wahlspruch lesen:

Die Blume ist immer schon in der Mandel.

Durch diesen wundervollen Spruch ist das Haus, ist das Zimmer von einer unvergeßlichen Innerlichkeit gezeichnet. Gibt es wohl ein Bild von Intimität, zusammengeraffter, seines Zentrums gewisser, als der Zukunftstraum einer Blume, die noch eingeschlossen und zusammengefaltet im Fruchtkern schlummert. Wie man denn meinen möchte, daß nicht das Glück, sondern das Vorgefühl des Glücks in dem runden Zimmer eingeschlossen harrt!

So reicht das von Bosco heraufbeschworene Haus von der Erde bis in den Himmel. Es hat die Vertikalität des Turmes, der sich aus den tiefsten Erd- und Wassertiefen bis zur Wohnung einer himmelsgläubigen Seele erhebt. Ein solches Haus, von einem Dichter errichtet, illustriert die Vertikalität des Mensch-

lichen. Und es ist als Traumvorgang vollständig. Es dramatisiert die beiden Pole der Träume vom Haus. Es macht denen das Geschenk eines Turmes, die vielleicht nicht einmal einen Taubenschlag gekannt haben. Der Turm ist das Werk eines anderen Jahrhunderts. Ohne Vergangenheit ist er nichts. Wie lächerlich ist ein neuer Turm! Aber die Bücher sind dazu da, unserer Träumerei tausend Wohnungen zu schenken. Wer hat nicht romantische Stunden in den Türmen der Bücher verbracht? Diese Stunden kehren wieder. Die Träumerei braucht sie. Auf der Klaviatur einer groß angelegten Lektüre ist die Berufung, einen Turm zu bewohnen, eine Note, die große Träume auslöst. Wie oft, seit ich *L'Antiquaire* gelesen habe, bin ich ausgezogen, den Turm Henri Boscos zu bewohnen!

Der Turm und die Untergeschosse der Ultra-Tiefe dehnen das Haus nach den beiden Richtungen aus, die wir soeben besprochen haben. Dieses Haus ist für uns eine Vergrößerung der Vertikalität bescheidenerer Häuser, die dennoch, um unsere Träumereien zufriedenzustellen, sich in der Höhenrichtung differenzieren müssen. Wären wir Architekt eines Traumhauses, würden wir zwischen einem dreiteiligen und einem vierteiligen Hause zu wählen haben. Das dreiteilige, das einfachste hinsichtlich der notwendigen Höhe, hat einen Keller, ein Erdgeschoß und ein Dachgeschoß. Das vierteilige Haus schiebt ein Stockwerk zwischen Erdgeschoß und Speicher. Ein weiteres Stockwerk, ein zweites Stockwerk, und die Träume verwirren sich. In dem Traumhaus vermag die Topo-Analyse nur bis auf drei oder vier zu zählen.

Von einer bis zu dreien oder vieren bewegen sich die Treppen. Alle differenziert. Die Treppe, die zum Keller führt, steigt man immer *hinab*. Ihr Hinabführen behält man in der Erinnerung, der Abstieg kennzeichnet ihren Traumwert. Die Treppe, die zum Zimmer führt, steigt man hinauf und hinab. Es ist eine banalere Treppe. Sie ist familiär. Das zwölfjährige Kind spielt darauf Tonleitern des Emporsteigens, aber am liebsten nimmt es immer vier Stufen auf einmal, mit großen Sätzen! Eine Treppe vier zu vier Stufen hinaufzuspringen — welches Glück für die Schenkel!

Schließlich die steilere, strengere Treppe zum Dachboden steigt man immer *aufwärts*. Sie steht unter dem Zeichen des Aufstiegs zur stillsten Einsamkeit. Wenn ich träumend in die Dachböden längstvergangener Zeiten zurückkehre, steige ich niemals herab.

Die Psychoanalyse hat den Treppentraum vorgefunden. Doch da sie einen verallgemeinernden Symbolismus braucht, um ihre Interpretation zu fixieren, hat die Psychoanalyse den komplizierten Mischungen von Träumerei und Erinnerung wenig Aufmerksamkeit gewidmet. Deshalb ist die Psychoanalyse, hier wie auch sonst, geeigneter zum Studium der Träume als zum Studium der Träumerei. Die Phänomenologie der Träumerei kann den Komplex von Gedächtnis und Einbildungskraft entwirren. Notwendigerweise gewinnt sie eine Empfindung für die Differenzierungen des Symbols. Die dichterische Träumerei, Schöpferin von Symbolen, gibt unserer Intimität eine polysymbolische Wirksamkeit. Und die Erinnerungen verfeinern sich. Das Traumhaus erreicht in der Träumerei eine äußerste Sensibilität. Manchmal haben einige Stufen dem Gedächtnis eine schwache Bodensenkung des Elternhauses eingeprägt. Ein gewisses Zimmer ist nicht nur eine Tür, sondern eine Tür und drei Stufen. Wenn man sich darauf einläßt, im Detail der Höhe des alten Hauses zu denken, dann beginnt alles, was hinauf- oder hinabsteigt, von neuem ein dynamisches Leben zu führen. Man kann nicht länger ein Mensch auf einer einzigen Etage bleiben, wie Joe Bousquet sagte: »Das ist ein Mensch mit einer einzigen Etage: er hat seinen Keller in seinem Dachboden« [8].

Als Antithese machen wir nun einige Bemerkungen über die im Sinne des Traumes unvollständigen Wohnungen.

In Paris gibt es keine Häuser. Die Bewohner der Großstadt wohnen in übereinandergestellten Schachteln. »Unser Pariser Zimmer«, sagt Paul Claudel [9], »ist zwischen seinen vier Wänden eine Art geometrischer Ort, ein konventionelles Loch, das wir mit Bildern möblieren, mit Trödelkram und mit Schränken in einem Schrank.« Die Hausnummer, die Zahl der Stockwerke fixieren die Lokalisierung unseres »konventionellen Loches«, aber unsere Wohnung hat weder Raum um sich noch Vertikali-

tät in sich. »Am Boden halten sich die Häuser fest mit Asphalt, damit sie nicht durchsinken in die Erde« [10]. Das Haus hat keine Wurzel. Unvorstellbar für einen Hausträumer: die Wolkenkratzer haben keinen Keller. Vom Pflaster bis zum Dach stapeln sich die Räume aufeinander und das Zelt eines Himmels ohne Horizont umschließt die ganze Stadt. Die Gebäude haben in der Stadt nur eine äußere Höhe. Die Fahrstühle zerstören das Heldentum der Treppen. Es liegt kein Verdienst mehr darin, nahe am Himmel zu wohnen. Und das Zuhause hat nur noch eine einfache horizontale Ausdehnung. Es fehlt den verschiedenen Zimmern einer in ein Stockwerk eingekeilten Wohnung eines der fundamentalsten Prinzipien, um die Intimitätswerte zu unterscheiden und zu ordnen.

Dem Fehlen der intimen Werte des Vertikalismus muß das Fehlen des kosmischen Bezugs im Großstadthaus hinzugefügt werden. Die Häuser sind hier nicht mehr in der Natur. Die Beziehungen zwischen Wohnung und Raum werden hier unecht. Alles ist hier Maschine, und das intime Leben verflüchtigt sich überall. »Die Straßen sind wie Röhren, wo die Menschen hineingesogen werden (Max Picard, loc. cit.).«

Und das Haus kennt nicht mehr die Dramen des Alls. Manchmal fegt der Wind einen Dachziegel herab, der einen Passanten tötet. Das Verbrechen des Daches zielt nur auf den verspäteten Passanten. Der Blitz bringt einen Moment lang Feuersglut in die Fensterscheiben. Aber das Haus erzittert nicht unter den Donnerschlägen. Es zittert nicht mit uns und durch uns. In unseren dicht aneinandergedrängten Häusern haben wir weniger Furcht. Das Gewitter über Paris hat gegen den Träumer nicht die gleiche persönliche Angriffslust wie gegen ein einsames Haus. Wir werden es besser verstehen, wenn wir in den späteren Abschnitten *die Situation des Hauses in der Welt* untersucht haben werden, denn diese Situation bietet uns, auf konkrete Weise, eine Variante der so oft metaphysisch zusammengefaßten Situation des Menschen in der Welt.

Aber hier bleibt für den Philosophen ein Problem offen, wenn er an die Heilsamkeit der weitgespannten Träumereien glaubt: wie kann man die kosmische Durchdringung des äußeren Raumes und des Großstadtzimmers fördern? Als Beispiel

geben wir die Lösung eines Träumers für das Problem des Pariser Lärms.

Wenn die Schlaflosigkeit, dieses Leiden der Philosophen, sich durch die nervöse Überreizung verschlimmert, die der Stadtlärm verursacht, wenn spät in der Nacht auf der Place Maubert die Autos knattern, wenn das Rollen der Lastwagen mich mein Städtergeschick verfluchen läßt, dann finde ich eine Beruhigung, indem ich die Metaphorik des Ozeans erlebe. Man weiß ja, daß die Stadt ein rauschendes Meer ist, man hat oft gesagt, daß Paris mitten in der Nacht das unaufhörliche Brausen von Flut und Brandung hören läßt. Aus diesen Klischees mache ich dann ein ehrliches Bild, ein Bild, das mein ist, ebenso mein als hätte ich es selbst erfunden, nach meiner süßen Gewohnheit, mich immer für das Subjekt der Gedanken zu halten, die ich denke. Wenn das Rollen der Wagen schmerzhafter anschwillt, suche ich darin die Stimme des Donners wiederzufinden, eines Donners, der zu mir spricht, der mir grollt. Und ich habe Mitleid mit mir selbst. Da bist du also, armer Philosoph, von neuem im Gewittersturm, in den Stürmen des Lebens! Ich erlebe eine abstrakt-konkrete Träumerei. Mein Diwan ist ein auf den Fluten verlorenes Boot; jenes gräßliche Pfeifen ist der Wind in den Segeln. Die wütende Luft hupt von allen Seiten. Und um mich zu trösten, spreche ich zu mir: Sieh, dein Fahrzeug bleibt fest, du bist in Sicherheit in deinem steinernen Schiff. Schlafe trotz des Sturmes. Schlafe im Sturm. Schlafe in deinem Mut, glücklich, ein Mensch im Ansturm der Fluten zu sein.

Und ich schlafe ein, gewiegt vom Pariser Lärm [11].

Alles bestätigt mir übrigens, daß das Bild der ozeanischen Geräusche der Stadt »in der Natur der Dinge« liegt, daß es ein echtes Bild ist, und daß es heilsam ist, die Geräusche zu naturalisieren, um sie weniger feindlich zu machen. Im Vorübergehen notiere ich diese feine Nüance des wohltuenden Bildes in der jungen Dichtung unserer Zeit. Yvonne Caroutch hört die städtische Morgenfrühe, wenn die Stadt »das Rauschen einer leeren Muschel« hat [12]. Dieses Bild hilft mir, meinem morgendlichen Wesen, sanft und natürlich aufzuwachen. Alle Bilder sind gut, wenn man versteht, sie zu gebrauchen.

Man fände viele andere Bilder vom Stadt-Meer. Halten wir

eines fest, das einem Maler einfiel. Als Courbet in Sainte-Pelagie gefangen war, hatte er die Idee, Paris darzustellen, wie man es von den Dächern des Gefängnisses sieht, sagt uns Pierre Courthion [13]. Courbet schreibt einem Freund: »Ich hätte das in der Art meiner Seestücke gemalt, mit einem Himmel von unermeßlicher Tiefe, mit Bewegungen, Häusern, Kuppeln die aufgeregten Wogen des Ozeans vortäuschend . . .«

Unserer Methode folgend haben wir die große Verbundenheit der Bilder bewahren müssen, die eine rücksichtslose Zergliederung verweigert. Wir mußten den kosmischen Bezug des Hauses kurz aufleuchten lassen. Aber wir werden darauf zurückkommen. Nachdem wir den Vertikalismus des Traumhauses untersucht haben, müssen wir jetzt, wie wir weiter oben angekündigt haben, die Verdichtungszentren der Intimität studieren, wo die Träumerei sich zusammenballt.

VI

Zunächst muß man in dem vielfältigen Haus Zentren der Einfachheit suchen. Wie Baudelaire es ausspricht: »In einem Palast gibt es keinen Winkel für die Intimität.«

Aber die Einfachheit, die oft allzu rational herausgestrichen wird, ist keine Quelle von Traumgeschehen hoher Potenz. Man muß die Primitivität des Schlupfwinkels berühren. Und über die erlebten Situationen hinaus muß man geträumte Situationen entdecken. Über die positiven Erinnerungen hinaus, die Materialien für eine positive Psychologie liefern, muß man das Feld der ursprünglichen Bilder wieder auftun, die vielleicht Fixierungszentren im Gedächtnis verbliebener Erinnerungen gewesen sind.

Die Demonstration der imaginären Ursprünglichkeit läßt sich sogar an jenem scheinbar so unverrückbar im Gedächtnis befestigten Sein vollziehen, aus dem das Elternhaus besteht.

Im Hause selbst zum Beispiel, im Familienwohnraum, träumt ein Schlupfwinkel-Träumer von der Hütte, vom Nest, von jenen Winkeln, wo er sich verkriechen möchte wie ein Tier in seinem Loch. So lebt er in einem Jenseits der menschlichen Bilder. Wenn es dem Phänomenologen gelänge, die Ursprünglichkeit

solcher Bilder nachzuerleben, würde er vielleicht die Probleme anders sehen, die sich auf die Poesie des Hauses beziehen. Ein sehr klares Beispiel dieser Konzentration der Wohnfreude finden wir, wenn wir eine bewundernswerte Seite des Buches lesen, wo Henri Bachelin das Leben seines Vaters erzählt [14].

Das Kindheitshaus von Henri Bachelin ist denkbar einfach. Es ist das ländliche Haus eines Weilers im Morvan. Jedoch ist es, mit seinen bäuerlichen Nebengebäuden und dank der Arbeit und der Sparsamkeit des Vaters, eine Wohnung, wo das Leben der Familie Sicherheit und Glück gefunden hat. In dem von der Lampe erhellten Zimmer, wo der Vater, der Tagelöhner und Küster, abends das Leben der Heiligen liest, in diesem Zimmer spinnt das Kind seine Träumerei vom ursprünglichen Dasein, und diese Träumerei betont die Einsamkeit so sehr, daß sie sich ein Leben in einer verlorenen Hütte mitten in einem großen Wald ausmalt. Für einen Phänomenologen, der die Wurzeln der Wohnfunktion sucht, ist die Seite von Henri Bachelin ein Dokument von großer Reinheit. Hier ist die wesentliche Passage: »Es gab Stunden, wo ich uns gleichsam abgetrennt fühlte von der kleinen Stadt, von Frankreich, von der Welt. Ich hatte Vergnügen daran — doch behielt ich meine Empfindungen für mich —, mir auszumalen, wir lebten inmitten von Wäldern in einer gutgeheizten Köhlerhütte: gern hätte ich gehört, wie die Wölfe ihre Krallen am unabnutzbaren Granit unserer Schwelle schärften. Unser Haus vertrat mir die Stelle der Hütte. Hier sah ich mich beschützt vor Hunger und Kälte. Wenn ich fröstelte, so geschah es vor lauter Wohlsein.« Und wenn er in diesem unaufhörlich in der zweiten Person geschriebenen Roman seinen Vater anruft, so fügt Henri Bachelin hinzu: »Wohlgeborgen auf meinem Stuhl, schwamm ich in dem Gefühl deiner Kraft.«

So ruft uns der Schriftsteller zum Zentrum des Hauses wie zum Zentrum der Kraft, in eine Zone höherer Beschütztheit. Er führt diesen »Hüttentraum« bis ans Ende, den alle diejenigen gut kennen, die die legendären Bilder von primitiven Häusern lieben. Aber in der Mehrzahl unserer Hüttenträume wünschen wir woanders zu leben, weit entfernt von dem überfüllten Haus, fern den städtischen Sorgen. Wir fliehen in Gedan-

ken, um einen wirklichen Zufluchtsort zu suchen. Glücklicher als die Träumer von weiten Fluchten, findet Bachelin im Hause selbst die Wurzel der Träumerei von der Hütte. Er braucht das Schauspiel des Familienzimmers nur ein wenig zu bearbeiten, braucht nur in der Stille seines Wachtraumes den prasselnden Ofen zu hören, während der Wind das Haus bestürmt, um zu wissen, daß er im Zentrum des Hauses, unter dem Lichtkreis der Lampe, in einem runden Hause wohnt, in der ursprünglichen Hütte. Wie viele Wohnungen, ineinander eingeschachtelt, ergäben sich aus den Bildern unserer Intimitätsträumereien, wenn wir sie bewußt in ihren Einzelheiten und in ihrer Rangordnung erleben! Wieviel verstreute Werte vermöchten wir zu verdichten, wenn wir die Bilder unserer Träumereien in aller Aufrichtigkeit erlebten!

Die Hütte in den Zeilen von Bachelin erscheint wirklich als Wurzel und Drehpunkt der Wohnfunktion. Sie ist die einfachste menschliche Pflanze, diejenige, die keiner Verzweigungen bedarf, um zu bestehen. Sie ist so einfach, daß sie nicht mehr zu den manchmal allzu bilderreichen Erinnerungen gehört. Sie gehört zu den Legenden. Sie ist ein Zentrum von Legenden. Wer hat nicht nachts, wenn er in der Ferne ein verlorenes Licht sah, von einem Strohdach geträumt, wer hat nicht, noch mehr in den Legenden befangen, von der Hütte des Eremiten geträumt.

Die Hütte des Eremiten — das ist wirklich eine Gravüre, wie sie im Buche steht! Die wahren Bilder sind *Gravüren*. Die Einbildungskraft graviert sie in unser Gedächtnis ein. Sie vertiefen die erlebten Erinnerungen, machen sie zu imaginierten Erinnerungen. Die Hütte des Eremiten ist ein Thema, das keiner Variationen bedarf. Bei ihrer einfachsten Vorstellung löscht der »phänomenologische Widerhall« die mittelmäßigen Anklänge aus. Die Hütte des Eremiten ist eine Gravüre, der eine Übertreibung des Pittoresken schaden würde. Sie muß ihre Wahrheit aus der Intensität ihrer Wesenheit empfangen, aus der Wesenheit des Wortes Wohnen. Sogleich ist die Hütte konzentrierte Einsamkeit. Im Lande der Legenden gibt es keine gemeinschaftliche Hütte. Mag uns der Geograph von seinen weiten Reisen Photographien von Hüttendörfern mitbringen —

unsere legendäre Vergangenheit übersteigt alles, was gesehen worden ist, alles was wir persönlich erlebt haben. Das Bild führt uns. In die äußerste Einsamkeit gehen wir ein. Der Eremit ist *allein* vor Gott. Die Hütte des Eremiten ist die Antithese zum Kloster. Rings um diese konzentrierte Einsamkeit strahlt ein All aus, welches meditiert und betet, ein All außerhalb des Alls. Die Hütte kann keinen Reichtum »von dieser Welt« empfangen. Sie hat eine glückliche Intensität in der Armut. Die Hütte des Eremiten ist ein Ruhm der Armut. Von Entblößung zu Entblößung gewährt sie uns Zugang zum Absoluten der Zuflucht.

Diese Bewertung eines Einsamkeitszentrums ist so stark, so ursprünglich, so unbestritten, daß das Bild des fernen Lichtes zum Beziehungspunkt wird für weniger deutlich lokalisierbare Lichter. Henry-David Thoreau hört »das Horn in der Tiefe der Wälder«. Dieses »Bild« mit seinem ungenau bestimmten Zentrum, dieses Klangbild, das die nächtliche Natur erfüllt, gibt ihm ein Bild von Ruhe und Zuversicht ein: »Dieser Klang«, sagt er, »ist ebenso freundschaftlich wie die ferne Kerze des Eremiten« [15]. Und wir, erinnern wir uns, aus welchem innersten Tal die Hörner alter Zeiten klingen? Warum akzeptieren wir sofort die gemeinsame Freundschaft der durch das Horn geweckten Klangwelt und der Welt des Eremiten, die das ferne Licht erhellt? Wie kommt es, daß Bilder, die im Leben so selten vorkommen, eine solche Macht auf die Einbildungskraft ausüben?

Die großen Bilder haben zugleich eine Geschichte und eine Vorgeschichte. Sie sind immer zugleich Erinnerung und Sage. Nie erlebt man das Bild in der ersten Instanz. Jedes große Bild hat eine unergründliche Traumtiefe und auf diesem Hintergrund setzt die persönliche Vergangenheit ihre eigentümlichen Farben. Darum geschieht es erst sehr spät im Laufe des Lebens, daß man ein Bild richtig verehrt, indem man seine Wurzeln jenseits der im Gedächtnis fixierten Geschichte entdeckt. Im Reich der absoluten Imagination wird man sehr spät jung. Man muß das irdische Paradies verlieren, um wahrhaft darin zu leben, um in der Wirklichkeit seiner Bilder zu leben, in der absoluten Sublimierung, die jede Leidenschaft transzendiert. In

seiner Meditation über Leben und Werk des großen Dichters Villiers de l'Isle-Adam schreibt der Dichter Victor-Emile Michelet: »Leider muß man erst alt werden, um die Jugend zu erringen, um sie von den Fesseln zu befreien, um gemäß ihrem ursprünglichen Schwung zu leben.«

Die Dichtkunst gibt uns nicht so sehr die Sehnsucht nach der Jugend, das wäre vulgär, aber die Sehnsucht nach den Ausdrucksformen der Jugend. Sie bietet uns Bilder, wie wir sie hätten finden müssen im »ursprünglichen Schwung« der Jugend. Die Musterbilder, die einfachen Gravüren, die Träumereien von der Hütte sind Einladungen, der Einbildungskraft von neuem freien Lauf zu lassen. Sie geben uns nochmals Aufenthalte des Seins, Häuser des Seins, wo sich eine Gewißheit des Seins verdichtet. Es scheint, wenn man solche Bilder bewohnt, so wesensfestigende Bilder, dann müßte man ein anderes Leben beginnen, ein Leben, das unser wäre, unser in den Tiefen des Seins. Wenn man solche Bilder betrachtet, wenn man die Bilder des Buches von Bachelin liest, bekommt man wieder den Geschmack der Ursprünglichkeit. Auf Grund dieser wiederhergestellten Ursprünglichkeit, die man sich wünscht und in einfachen Bildern erlebt, müßte ein Album von Hütten zu einem Handbuch einfacher Übungen für die Phänomenologie der Einbildungskraft werden.

Im Anschluß an das ferne Licht der Eremitenhütte, Sinnbild des Menschen, der wacht, ließe sich eine beträchtliche Sammlung von literarischen Dokumenten zur Poesie des Hauses auswerten, allein unter dem Zeichen der Lampe, die im Fenster leuchtet. Man müßte dieses Bild unter dem Blickwinkel eines der Hauptsätze der Imaginationswelt des Lichtes betrachten: *Alles was leuchtet, sieht.* Rimbaud hat diesen kosmischen Lehrsatz in drei Silben gefaßt: *Nacre voit* (»Perlmutter sieht«) [16]. Die Lampe wacht, also überwacht sie. Je schmaler der Lichtstreifen ist, desto durchdringender die Überwachung.

Die Lampe im Fenster ist das Auge des Hauses. Im Reich der Einbildungskraft wird die Lampe nie draußen angesteckt. Sie ist eingeschlossenes Licht, das nicht anders kann als nach draußen durchsickern. Ein Gedicht mit dem Titel *Eingemauert* beginnt so:

Eine Lampe, angesteckt hinter dem Fenster,
Wacht im verborgenen Herzen der Nacht.

Einige Verse früher spricht der Dichter:

Vom eingekerkerten Blick
zwischen seinen vier steinernen Wänden [17].

Im Roman *Hyacinthe* von Henri Bosco, der, zusammen mit einer anderen Erzählung *Der Garten des Hyazinth*, einer der erstaunlichsten Seelenromane unserer Zeit ist, wartet eine Lampe am Fenster. In ihr wartet das Haus. Die Lampe ist das Zeichen einer großen Erwartung.

Im Lichte des fernen Hauses sieht, wacht, überwacht, wartet das ganze Haus.

Wenn ich mich dem Rausch der Umkehrungen zwischen Träumerei und Wirklichkeit überlasse, kommt mir dieses Bild: das ferne Haus und sein Licht – für mich, vor mir, ist es ein Haus, das nun (seinerseits) durch das Schlüsselloch hinausblickt. Ja, es ist jemand in dem Haus, der wacht, ein Mann arbeitet darin, während ich träume, er führt ein hartnäckiges Dasein, während ich flüchtigen Träumen folge. Einzig durch sein Licht ist das Haus menschlich. Es sieht wie ein Mensch. Es ist ein Auge, geöffnet zur Nacht.

Und andere Bilder entfalten ohne Ende ihre Blüten in der Poesie des nächtlichen Hauses. Manchmal leuchtet es wie ein Glühwurm im Gras, das Wesen mit dem einsamen Licht:

Ich werde unsere Häuser sehen wie Glühwürmchen in den Hügelmulden [18].

Ein anderer Dichter nennt die auf der dunklen Erde leuchtenden Häuser »Grassterne«. Christiané Barucoa sagt von der Lampe im Menschenhaus:

Gefangener Stern, umschlossen vom Frost des Augenblicks.

In solchen Bildern scheinen die Sterne vom Himmel herunterzukommen, um die Erde zu bewohnen. Die Häuser der Menschen bilden Konstellationen auf der Erde.

G.-E. Clancier nagelt mit zehn Dörfern und ihrem Licht eine Konstellation des Leviathan auf die Erde:

Eine Nacht, zehn Dörfer, ein Berg,
Ein schwarzer Leviathan goldgenagelt.
(*G.-E. Clancier, Une Voix*, ed. Gallimard)

Erich Neumann hat den Traum eines Patienten studiert, der, von der Höhe eines Turmes herabblickend, die Sterne auf der Erde aufgehen und leuchten sah. Sie traten aus dem Schoß der Erde hervor; die Erde war in dieser Vision nicht etwa ein einfaches Gleichnis des gestirnten Himmels. Sie war die große produktive Mutter der Welt, Erzeugerin der Nacht und der Sterne [19]. In dem Traum seines Patienten zeigt Neumann die Kraft des Archetypus der Mutter Erde. Natürlich kommt die Dichtkunst aus einer Träumerei, die weniger auf ihrem Recht besteht als der nächtliche Traum. Es handelt sich nur um den »Frost eines Augenblicks«. Aber das dichterische Dokument ist nicht weniger sinnvoll. Ein irdisches Zeichen überlagert ein Wesen des Himmels. Die Archäologie der Bilder wird also durch ein rasches Bild erhellt, durch das Augenblicksbild des Dichters.

Wir haben alle diese Entwicklungsmöglichkeiten eines Bildes verfolgt, das banal erscheinen könnte, um zu zeigen, daß die Bilder sich nicht ruhig verhalten können. Im Gegensatz zur Schlummer-Träumerei schläft die dichterische Träumerei niemals ein. Immer muß sie, vom einfachsten Bilde aus, Imaginationswellen ausstrahlen. Aber so sehr sich das isolierte, vom Stern seiner Lampe erleuchtete Haus auch ins Kosmische erweitert, immer macht es den Eindruck von Einsamkeit: eine letzte Textstelle mag diese Einsamkeit akzentuieren.

In den Fragmenten eines Tagebuchs [20], die einer Briefsammlung Rilkes vorangestellt sind, findet man die folgende Szene: Rilke und zwei seiner Gefährten bemerken in der tiefen Nacht »die Fensterkreuze einer entfernten Hütte ... Übrigens ist es nur eine letzte Hütte, die man von dieser Weinlaube aus sieht, sonst nur Felder und Moorland mit dunkel spiegelnden Kanälen.« Dieses Bild einer Einsamkeit, symbolisiert durch ein einziges Licht, bewegt das Herz des Dichters, es ergreift ihn, so persönlich, daß es ihn von seinen Gefährten isoliert. Von der Gruppe der drei Freunde sprechend, fügt Rilke hinzu: »Wir standen nah beisammen, drei nicht gesellige Menschen,

die einmal eine Nacht sehen und das wie eine Festlichkeit empfinden.« Ein Ausdruck, über den man nie genug nachdenken wird, denn das allералltäglichste Bild, ein Bild, das der Dichter sicherlich hundertmal gesehen hat, empfängt plötzlich das Zeichen des »zum erstenmal« und überträgt dieses Zeichen auf die vertraute Nacht. Kann man nicht sagen, das Licht, das von einem einsam Wachenden kommt, von einem hartnäckig Wachenden, nimmt eine Art hypnotischer Kraft an? Wir werden hypnotisiert von der Einsamkeit, hypnotisiert vom Blick des einsamen Hauses. Von ihm zu uns ist das Band so stark, daß wir von nichts anderem mehr träumen, als von einem einsamen Haus in der Nacht:

O Licht im schlafenden Haus!
(Richard von Schaukal)

Die Hütte, das Licht, das am fernen Horizont wacht, verkörpert die Intimitätsverdichtung der Zuflucht in ihrer einfachsten Form. Am Anfang dieses Kapitels hatten wir im Gegenteil versucht, das Haus im Vertikalsinn zu differenzieren. Jetzt müssen wir dazu übergehen, die Schutzwerte des Hauses gegen die rings anstürmenden Mächte deutlicher zu machen, immer mit Hilfe passender literarischer Dokumente. Nachdem wir diese dynamische Dialektik von Haus und All untersucht haben, werden wir Gedichte betrachten, in denen das Haus selbst eine ganze Welt ist.

IX. DIE DIALEKTIK DES DRAUSSEN UND DES DRINNEN

Die feierlichen Geographien der menschlichen Grenzen . .
Paul Eluard

Denn wir sind oder wir sind nicht
Pierre-Jean Jouve

Eine der praktischen Erziehungsmaximen, die meine Kindheit bestimmt haben: Iß nicht mit offenem Mund.
Colette

I

Draußen und Drinnen bilden eine Zerstückelungsdialektik, und die offenkundige Geometrie dieser Dialektik verblendet uns, wenn wir sie in den metaphorischen Bereichen spielen lassen. Sie hat die scharfe Deutlichkeit der Dialektik des *Ja* und des *Nein*, die alles entscheidet. Ohne daß man es merkt, macht man daraus eine Basis von Bildern, die sämtliche Gedanken des Positiven und des Negativen beherrschen. Die Logiker zeichnen Kreise, die sich überschneiden oder ausschließen, und sofort sind alle ihre Regeln klar. Der Philosoph denkt, wenn er Drinnen und Draußen sagt, an Sein und Nichtsein. Die tiefste Metaphysik hat ihre Wurzel in einer unausgesprochenen Geometrie, und diese Geometrie — ob man es will oder nicht — verräumlicht den Gedanken; würde der Metaphysiker denken, wenn er nicht zeichnete? Das Offene und das Geschlossene sind für ihre Gedanken. Das Offene und das Geschlossene sind Metaphern, die er an alles heftet, sogar an seine Systeme. Jean Hyppolite hat in einem Vortrag die subtile Struktur der »Verleugnung« untersucht, die sehr verschieden ist von der einfachen Struktur der »Verneinung«, und in diesem Vortrag [1] hat er mit Recht von einem »ursprünglichen Mythos des Draußen und des Drinnen« sprechen können. Hyppolite fügt hinzu: »Sie fühlen, welche Tragweite dieser Mythos von der Bildung des Draußen und Drinnen hat: es geht um die Entfremdung, die auf diesen beiden Begriffen beruht. Was sich in ihrer formalen Opposition äußert, wird darüber hinaus Entfremdung und Feindlichkeit

zwischen beiden.« Schon die einfache geometrische Opposition färbt sich also mit Aggressivität. Die formale Opposition kann nicht in einem Ruhezustand bleiben. Der Mythos bearbeitet sie. Aber man soll diese Arbeit des Mythos nicht im falschen Lichte geometrischer Anschauungen betrachten, wenn man sie innerhalb des unermeßlichen Gebietes der Einbildungskraft und des Ausdrucks untersuchen will [2].

Das Diesseits und das Jenseits wiederholen dumpf die Dialektik des Drinnen und des Draußen: alles läßt sich zeichnen, sogar das Unendliche. Man will das Sein fixieren, und indem man es fixiert, will man alle Situationen transzendieren, will es in eine alle Situationen umfassende Situation versetzen. Man konfrontiert dann das Sein des Menschen mit dem Sein der Welt und meint damit an eine ursprüngliche Gegebenheit zu rühren. Man erhebt die Dialektik des *Hier* und des *Dort* in den Rang eines Absolutums. Man verleiht diesen ärmlichen Adverbien der Ortsbestimmung schlecht kontrollierbare ontologische Bedeutungen. Viele Metaphysiker benötigen eine Kartographie. Aber in der Philosophie rächt sich die Bequemlichkeit, und das philosophische Wissen wird nicht auf dem Boden schematisierter Erfahrungen gewonnen.

II

Diese geometrische Krebswucherung des sprachlichen Zellengewebes in der zeitgenössischen Philosophie wollen wir etwas eingehender untersuchen. In der Tat scheint eine künstliche Syntax die Adverbien und die Verben in einer Weise miteinander zu verschweißen, daß sie Auswüchse bilden. Diese Syntax häuft Koppelworte und Bindestriche und gelangt dadurch zu Satz-Worten. Das Wort zieht seine äußeren Umgebungen in sein eigenes Inneres hinein, es verschlingt einen ganzen Satz und setzt sich an dessen Stelle. Die philosophische Sprache wird eine agglutinierende Sprache. Manchmal geschieht es, daß die Worte umgekehrt, anstatt miteinander zu verschmelzen, sich innerlich aufspalten. Vorsilben und Nachsilben — besonders aber die Vorsilben — lösen sich voneinander: sie wollen selbständig denken. So kommt es, daß die Worte manchmal

aus dem Gleichgewicht geraten. Wo ist das Hauptgewicht in Worten wie *être-là*, »Da-Sein«, im Sein oder im Da [3]? Muß in dem besonders betonten »Da« (das genauer »Hier-und-jetzt« heißen müßte) zuallererst mein Sein gesucht werden? Oder finde ich zunächst einmal in meinem Sein die Gewißheit meiner Fixierung in einem *Da*? Jedenfalls wird immer eines der beiden Grundworte das andere schwächen. Oft wird das *Da* mit einer solchen Energie gesagt, daß die geometrische Fixierung der Seinsform die ontologischen Aspekte der Probleme brutal verkürzt. Daraus folgt eine Dogmatisierung des Denkens durch die Rückwirkung des sprachlichen Ausdrucks. Klanglich ist das angeklitterte *là* im Französischen (oder das abgespaltene *Da* im Deutschen) energisch genug, um ein als *être-là* oder *Da-Sein* bezeichnetes Sein mit erhobenem Zeigefinger aus der Innerlichkeit hinaus an einen draußen liegenden Ort zu verweisen.

Doch warum die gegebenen Voraussetzungen so rasch eingrenzen? Man könnte meinen, daß der Metaphysiker sich nicht mehr die nötige Zeit zum Denken nimmt. Für eine Studie des Seins wäre es besser, meinen wir, wenn man alle ontologischen Kreisläufe der verschiedenen Seins-Erfahrungen verfolgen würde. Im Grunde gehören die Seins-Erfahrungen, die eine geometrische Ausdrucksweise rechtfertigen, zu den dürftigsten ... Man muß es sich zweimal überlegen, ehe man im Französischen das Wort *être-là* gebraucht. Wenn man in das Dasein eingeschlossen ist, wird es immer darauf ankommen, hinauszugelangen. Und kaum draußen, wird man wieder zurückkehren müssen. So ist im Sein alles Umlauf, alles Umweg, Wiederkehr, Umschreibung, alles ist ein Rosenkranz von Seinsformen, alles ist Kehrreim endloser Strophen.

Und welche Spirale ist das Sein des Menschen [4]! Wie viele Bewegungsimpulse, die einander umkehren, gibt es in dieser Spirale! Man weiß nicht gleich, ob man sich zum Mittelpunkt hin oder vom Mittelpunkt weg bewegt. Die Dichter kennen dieses Dasein des Zauderns vor dem Dasein. Jean Tardieu schreibt:

> Um vorwärtszukommen, dreh ich mich um mich selbst
> Ein Wirbelsturm vom Unbeweglichen bewohnt.
>
> *(Les témoins invisibles)*

In einem anderen Gedicht hatte Tardieu geschrieben:

Aber drinnen, keine Grenzen mehr!

So wird das spiralförmige Sein, das sich äußerlich so gut um seine Mitte geordnet darstellt, nie seinen Mittelpunkt erreichen. Das Dasein des Menschen läßt sich nicht fixieren. Jeder Ausdruck hebt seine Fixierung auf. Im Reiche der Einbildungskraft gilt, daß das Sein, sobald ein Ausdruck vorgebracht ist, Bedürfnis nach einem andern Ausdruck hat, daß das Sein alsbald zum Sein eines andern Ausdrucks werden muß.

Unserer Ansicht nach sollten die Wortklitterungen vermieden werden. Die Metaphysik gewinnt nicht dadurch, daß sie ihre Gedanken in sprachliche Fossilien gießt. Sie muß aus der äußersten Beweglichkeit der modernen Sprachen Vorteil ziehen und dennoch in der Homogenität einer Muttersprache verharren, genauso wie es auch die echten Dichter zu tun pflegen.

Um aus allen Lehren der modernen Psychologie, allen Erkenntnissen über das Dasein des Menschen, die von der Psychoanalyse errungen wurden, Vorteil zu ziehen, muß die Metaphysik entschlossen diskursiv sein. Sie muß der scheinbaren Evidenz der geometrischen Anschauung mißtrauen. Die Anschauung sagt zuviele Dinge auf einmal. Das Sein sieht sich selbst nicht. Vielleicht hört es sich. Das Sein läßt sich nicht umreißen. Es wird nicht vom Nichts umsäumt. Man ist nie sicher, es als festen Körper zu finden oder wiederzufinden, wenn man sich einem Seinszentrum nähert. Und wenn es das Dasein des Menschen ist, das man bestimmen möchte, dann ist man nie sicher, sich selbst näher zu kommen, wenn man in sich selbst »heimkehrt«, also sich zum Zentrum der Spirale hinbewegt; oft ist das Sein ein Schweifen auch und gerade im Herzen des Seins. Manchmal erfährt das Sein gerade dann Beständigkeit, wenn es außerhalb seiner selbst ist. Oft auch ist es, sozusagen, im Draußen eingeschlossen. In der Folge werden wir einen dichterischen Text geben, für den das Gefängnis draußen liegt.

Man könnte die Bilder vermehren, wenn man sie aus den Bereichen des Lichtes und der Töne, der Wärme und der Kälte nähme. Dann würde man eine langsamere, aber zweifellos besser begründete Ontologie vorbereiten als jene, die auf den geometrischen Bildern beruht.

Wir haben Wert auf diese allgemeinen Bemerkungen gelegt, weil vom Gesichtspunkt der geometrischen Ausdrücke gesehen die Dialektik des Drinnen und Draußen auf eine verhärtete geometrische Vorstellungsweise aufgebaut ist, wo die Grenzen zu Schranken werden. Wir müssen frei bleiben gegenüber jeder definitiven Anschauung — und die Geometrie verzeichnet nur definitive Anschauungen —, wenn wir den Kühnheiten der Dichter folgen wollen, die uns zugespitzte Innerlichkeitserlebnisse, »Fluchten« der Einbildungskraft bieten.

Vor allem muß konstatiert werden, daß die beiden Begriffe Drinnen und Draußen in der metaphysischen Anthropologie Probleme aufwerfen, die nicht symmetrisch sind. Das Drinnen konkret und das Draußen weiträumig zu machen, sind, wie es scheint, Initial-Forderungen, es sind die ersten Probleme einer Anthropologie der Einbildungskraft. Die Opposition zwischen dem Konkreten und dem Weiträumigen ist nicht im Gleichgewicht. Bei der geringsten Berührung erscheint die Asymmetrie. Und so ist es immer: Das Drinnen und das Draußen empfangen die Bewertungen, die unsere Bejahung der Dinge bestimmen, nicht in gleicher Weise. Man kann nicht in der gleichen Weise die Bewertungen erleben, die an das Drinnen und die an das Draußen geknüpft werden. Alles, auch die Größe, ist ein menschlicher Wert, und wir haben gezeigt, daß sogar die Miniatur Größe zu speichern vermag. Sie ist auf ihre Art *weiträumig*.

Jedenfalls können das Drinnen und das Draußen, wenn sie in der Phantasie erlebt sind, nicht mehr einfach als reziprok angesehen werden. Mit Geometrie kommt man nicht weiter, wenn es um den ursprünglichen Wesensausdruck geht; wir brauchen konkretere Ausgangspunkte, genauere im phänomenologischen Sinn, und wir werden uns darüber klar sein müssen, daß die Dialektik des Drinnen und des Draußen sich in unzähligen Nuancen vervielfältigt und abwandelt.

Unserer gewohnten Methode folgend, wollen wir unsere These an einem Beispiel konkreter Poetik nachprüfen; wir forschen bei einem Dichter nach einem Bild, das in seiner *Wesensnüance* neu genug ist, um uns ein Lehrbeispiel ontologischer Übersteigerung zu geben. Durch die Neuheit des Bildes und durch seine Übersteigerung dürfen wir sicher sein, über die ver-

nünftigen Gewißheiten hinaus, oder doch an deren Rande, einen Widerhall in uns zu erleben.

III

In einem Prosagedicht, *L'espace aux ombres*, »Der Raum der Schatten«, schreibt Henri Michaux [5]:

»Der Raum, aber Ihr könnt nicht begreifen, dieses fürchterliche Drinnen-und-Draußen, das der wahre Raum ist.

Manche bäumen sich ein letztes Mal auf, machen eine verzweifelte Anstrengung, um nur in ihrer eigenen Einheit zu sein. Übel bekommt es ihnen. Ich habe so einen getroffen.

Von der Strafe zerstört, war er nur noch ein Lärm, aber ein gewaltiger.

Eine unermeßliche Welt hörte ihn noch, aber er war nicht mehr, er war einzig und allein nur ein Lärm geworden, der vielleicht noch jahrhundertelang hinrollen würde, aber dazu bestimmt war, *vollständig* zu verlöschen, so als wäre er nie gewesen.«

Fassen wir die philosophische Lehre zusammen, die uns der Dichter gibt. Worum handelt es sich in einem solchen Text? Um eine Seele, die ihr »Da-Sein« verloren hat, eine Seele, die sogar noch das *Sein ihres Schattens* verloren hat, und als leeres Geräusch, als unbestimmbares Getöse in die Gerüchte des Seins eingegangen ist. Was war sie? War sie mehr als der Lärm, der sie geworden ist? Besteht ihre Strafe nicht darin, nur noch das Echo des leeren, sinnlosen Geräusches zu sein, das sie war? War sie nicht einst, was sie jetzt ist: ein Schall in den Wölbungen der Hölle? Sie ist dazu verurteilt, das Wort ihrer bösen Absicht zu wiederholen, und dieses Wort ist nun dem Sein eingeprägt und hat das Sein umgestürzt. (Ein anderer Dichter, Pierre Reverdy, sagt: »Bedenke, ein bloßes Wort, ein Name, genügt, um die Scheidewände deiner Kraft zu erschüttern.«) Denn das Sein bei Henri Michaux ist ein schuldiges Sein, schuldig weil es ist. Und wir sind in der Hölle, eingemauert wie wir sind in der Welt der bösen Absichten. Durch welche naive Eingebung lokalisieren wir das Übel, das keine Grenzen hat, in einer Hölle? Diese Seele, diesen Schatten, diesen Lärm eines

Schattens, der, wie der Dichter sagt, seine Einheit will, hört man von außen, ohne die Gewißheit zu haben, daß er irgendwo drinnen ist. In diesem »fürchterlichen Drinnen-und-Draußen« der nichtartikulierten Worte, der unvollendeten Daseinsabsichten, verarbeitet das Wesen in seinem Innern langsam sein Nichts. Seine Nichtswerdung wird »jahrhundertelang« dauern. Das Getöse der Daseinsgerüchte erstreckt sich im Raum und in der Zeit. Vergebens spannt die Seele ihre letzten Kräfte an, sie ist ein Wogengang des endenden Seins geworden. Das Sein ist abwechselnd Verdichtung, die sich zerstreut, indem sie zerplatzt, und Zerstreuung, die wieder zu einem Zentrum zurückfließt. Das Draußen und das Drinnen sind zwei Innerlichkeiten; sie sind immer bereit, umzukippen, ihre Feindlichkeit auszutauschen. Wenn es eine Grenzfläche zwischen einem solchen Drinnen und einem solchen Draußen gibt, so ist diese Grenzfläche auf beiden Seiten schmerzhaft. Die Lektüre des Textes von Henri Michaux erfüllt uns mit einer Mischung von Sein und Nichts. Der zentrale Punkt des »Da-Seins« schwankt und bebt. Der innere Raum verliert jede Klarheit. Der äußere Raum verliert seine Leere, dieser Stoff der Daseinsmöglichkeit —: wir sind aus dem Reich der Möglichkeit verbannt.

Wo soll man wohnen in diesem Drama der inneren Geometrie? Der Rat des Philosophen, in sich selbst zurückzukehren, um seine Existenzform zu finden, verliert seinen Wert, ja sogar seinen Sinn, wenn das geschmeidigste Bild des Da-Seins dem ontologischen Alptraum des Dichters entsprechend erlebt wird. Dieser Alptraum entwickelt sich nicht etwa in dramatischen Handlungen des Schreckens. Die Angst kommt nicht von außen. Sie ist auch nicht aus alten Erinnerungen gemacht. Sie hat keine Vergangenheit. Noch weniger hat sie eine Physiologie. Nichts Gemeinsames mit der »Es-verschlägt-mir-den-Atem«-Philosophie. Die Angst ist hier das Sein selbst. Wohin dann aber fliehen, wo Zuflucht suchen? In welches Draußen könnte man fliehen? In welchem Asyl könnte man sich bergen? Der Raum ist nur ein einziges »fürchterliches Drinnen-und-Draußen«.

Und der Alpdruck ist einfach, weil er radikal ist. Man würde das Erlebnis intellektualisieren, wenn man sagen würde, der

Alpdruck bestehe in einem Zweifel an der Gewißheit des Drinnen und an der Eindeutigkeit des Draußen. Das ganze raumzeitliche Kontinuum des zweideutigen Seins gibt Michaux uns hier als *a priori* des Seins. In diesem zweideutigen Raum hat der Geist seine geometrische Heimat verloren, und die Seele schwimmt.

Gewiß kann man es vermeiden, durch die enge Pforte eines solchen Gedichtes zu gehen. Die Philosophien der Angst sind auf weniger komplizierten Voraussetzungen aufgebaut. Sie widmen ihre Aufmerksamkeit nicht der Aktivität einer flüchtigen Phantasie, denn sie haben die Angst, lange bevor irgendwelche Bilder sie verkörpern, ins Herz des Seins geschrieben. Die Philosophen gönnen sich die Angst und sehen in den Bildern nur Äußerungen ihrer Kausalität. Sie kümmern sich kaum darum, das Sein des Bildes zu erleben. Die Phänomenologie der Einbildungskraft soll die Aufgabe erfüllen, das flüchtige Sein festzuhalten. Denn die Phänomenologie gewinnt ihre Einsichten gerade aus der Kürze des Bildes. Frappierend ist hier, daß der metaphysische Aspekt auf der Ebene des Bildes entsteht, auf der Ebene eines Bildes, das alle Vorstellungen von einer Räumlichkeit durcheinanderbringt, die im allgemeinen für geeignet gehalten werden, die Verwirrungen zu klären und den Geist seiner gleichgültigen Verfassung vor einem Raum zurückzugeben, der für Dramen keinen Platz hat.

Was mich selbst betrifft, so nehme ich das Bild des Dichters als einen kleinen experimentellen Wahnsinn auf, als eine Spur potentiellen Haschischrausches, ohne den wir nicht in das Reich der Imagination gelangen könnten. Und wie anders soll man ein übertriebenes Bild aufnehmen, als indem man es noch ein wenig mehr übertreibt und die Übertreibung ins Persönliche überträgt? Der phänomenologische Gewinn springt sofort in die Augen: wenn man das *Übertriebene* weitertreibt, hat man einige Aussicht, den Gepflogenheiten der *Reduktion* zu entkommen. Im Hinblick auf die Bilder des Raumes befindet man sich genau in einer Region, wo die Reduktion leicht und allgemein wird. Man wird immer jemand finden, sobald von Raum die Rede ist, der jede Komplikation einebnen und uns auf den Gegensatz des Drinnen und des Draußen festlegen

will. Aber wenn die Reduktion leicht ist, so ist die Übertreibung phänomenologisch um so interessanter. Das Problem, das wir behandeln, ist, wie es scheint, sehr geeignet, den Gegensatz zwischen reflektierender Reduktion und reiner Imagination herauszuholen. Die Psychoanalyse – liberaler als die klassische Literaturkritik – folgt jedoch in ihren Deutungen dem Diagramm der Reduktion. Nur die Phänomenologie geht aus Prinzip jeder Reduktion voraus, um das psychologische Sein eines Bildes zu prüfen, zu erproben. Die Dialektik der Dynamismen von Reduktion und Übertreibung kann die Dialektik der Psychoanalyse und der Phänomenologie schärfer hervortreten lassen. Wohlgemerkt ist es die Phänomenologie, die den unmittelbaren psychischen Ausdruckswert des Bildes bejaht. Verwandeln wir also unser Erstaunen in Bewunderung. Beginnen wir mit dem Bewundern. Nachher wird man sehen, ob es nötig sein wird, unsere Enttäuschung durch Kritik, durch Reduktion, zu organisieren. Um aus dieser aktiven Bewunderung, aus dieser unmittelbaren Bewunderung Gewinn zu ziehen, genügt es, dem positiven Impuls der Übertreibung zu folgen. Im Lesen und Wiederlesen akzeptiere ich also den Text von Henri Michaux als eine Angstvorstellung des inneren Raumes, etwa so als wären feindliche Fernen schon in der ganz kleinen Zelle erdrückend, die ein innerer Raum bildet. Mit seinem Gedicht hat Henri Michaux in uns die Klaustrophobie und die Agoraphobie – die Platzangst im geschlossenen und im offenen Raum – aneinanderstoßen lassen. Er hat die Grenzwand zwischen dem Drinnen und dem Draußen erschüttert. Aber damit hat er vom psychologischen Gesichtspunkt aus die faulen Gewißheiten der geometrischen Anschauung zum Einsturz gebracht, durch welche der Psychologe den Raum der Innerlichkeit ordnen wollte. Selbst figürlich gemeint kann man in der Innerlichkeit nichts einschließen; die Tiefe der Erlebnisse, die immer nur *aufgehen*, läßt sich nicht darstellen, indem man die einen in die anderen einschachtelt. Welche schöne phänomenologische Bemerkung liegt in dem schlichten Satz eines symbolistischen Dichters: »Der Gedanke wurde lebendig, indem er wie ein Blütenkelch aufging ...« [6].

Eine Philosophie der Einbildungskraft muß also dem Dichter

bis an die äußerste Grenze seiner Bilder folgen, ohne jemals diesen Extremismus zu reduzieren, der das eigentliche Phänomen des dichterischen Schwunges ist. Rilke schreibt in einem Brief an Clara Rilke [7]: »Kunstdinge sind ja immer Ergebnisse des In-Gefahr-gewesen-Seins, des in einer Erfahrung Bis-ans-Ende-gegangen-Seins, bis wo kein Mensch mehr weiter kann. Je weiter man geht, desto persönlicher, desto einziger wird ja ein Erlebnis ...« Aber ist es nötig, die Gefahr außerhalb der Gefahr des Schreibens, der Gefahr des Ausdrucks, zu suchen? Bringt der Dichter nicht die Sprache in Gefahr? Spricht er nicht das gefährliche Wort aus? Hat die Dichtkunst nicht, indem sie das Echo der inneren Dramen wurde, die reine Stimmung des Dramatischen angenommen? Ein dichterisches Bild erleben, wirklich erleben, heißt in einer seiner feinen Fasern eine Seinsmöglichkeit erkennen, die das Bewußtsein einer *Verwirrung des Seins* ist. Das Dasein ist hier dermaßen empfindlich, daß ein Wort es in Bewegung setzt. Im gleichen Brief sagt Rilke auch: »Wir sind also sicher darauf angewiesen, uns am Äußersten zu prüfen und zu erproben, ... als persönlicher Wahnsinn sozusagen, hat es einzutreten in das Werk.«

Die übertriebenen Bilder sind außerdem so *natürlich*; trotz aller Originalität eines Dichters kommt es nicht selten vor, daß man bei einem andern Dichter den gleichen Impuls findet. Bilder von Jean Supervielle lassen sich etwa mit dem Bilde von Michaux vergleichen. Auch Supervielle bringt die Klaustrophobie und die Agoraphobie miteinander in Berührung, wenn er schreibt [8]:

»Zuviel Raum beengt uns sehr viel mehr als wenn nicht genug Raum da ist.«

Supervielle kennt auch den »äußeren Taumel«. Anderswo spricht er von einer »inneren Unermeßlichkeit«. Und so tauschen die beiden Räume des Draußen und des Drinnen ihren Taumel aus.

In einem andern Text von Supervielle, den Christian Sénéchal in seinem schönen Buch über Supervielle mit Recht hervorhebt, *ist das Gefängnis draußen.* Nach endlosen Ritten in der südamerikanischen Pampa schreibt Supervielle: »Gerade infolge eines exzessiven Auslebens der Freiheit zu Pferde, an-

gesichts dieses bei all unserem verzweifelten Galoppieren unverrückbaren Horizontes, bekam die Pampa für mich den Charakter eines Gefängnisses, das nur größer war als andere Gefängnisse.«

IV

Sobald man die Dichtung als freies Ausdrucksfeld für die Aktivität der Sprache ansieht, wird man genötigt, die Anwendung erstarrter Metaphern, fossiliengewordener Bilder, zu kontrollieren. Wenn z. B. das Offene und das Geschlossene metaphorisch zu spielen beginnen, sollen wir dann die Metapher härter oder weicher machen? Sollen wir im Stil des Logikers wiederholen: »Eine Tür muß entweder offen oder geschlossen sein?« Und werden wir in dieser Sentenz ein Instrument der Analyse finden, das für eine menschliche Leidenschaft wirklich verwendbar wäre? In jedem Falle müssen solche Werkzeuge der Analyse bei jeder Gelegenheit nachgeschliffen werden. Man muß jeder Metapher die lebendige Oberflächlichkeit ihres gegenständlichen Daseins wiedergeben, man muß sie aus der Ausdrucksgewohnheit zurückholen und wieder zur Ausdrucksunmittelbarkeit bringen. Wenn man Ausdrücke finden will, ist es gefährlich, zu tief »an der Wurzel zu arbeiten«.

Die Phänomenologie der dichterischen Einbildungskraft gestattet uns, das Dasein des Menschen als eines Wesens mit einer Oberfläche zu erforschen, Oberfläche, welche die Region des Eigenen von der Region des Fremden trennt. Vergessen wir nicht: in dieser sensibilisierten Oberflächenzone gilt der Satz, daß das Sagen dem Sein vorhergeht. Sagen — wenn nicht zu dem andern, so doch wenigstens zu sich selbst. Und immer weiter voranschreiten. Aus der dichterischen Sprache laufen Wellen von Neuheit über die Oberfläche des Seins. Und die Sprache trägt in sich die Dialektik des Geschlossenen und des Offenen. Durch die sachliche Bedeutung schließt sie sich, durch den dichterischen Ausdruck öffnet sie sich.

Unseren Untersuchungen entspräche es nicht, wenn wir sie in radikalen Formeln zusammenfassen wollten, etwa indem wir das Dasein des Menschen als das Dasein einer Doppeldeu-

tigkeit definieren würden. Wir verstehen uns nur auf eine Philosophie des Details. An der Oberfläche des Daseins, in jener Region, wo das Sein sich bekunden *will* oder sich verstecken *will*, sind die Bewegungen des Öffnens und des Schließens so zahlreich, so oft Umkehrungen unterworfen, so oft mit Zaudern beladen, daß wir mit dieser Formel schließen könnten: Der Mensch ist das halboffenstehende Sein.

V

Wie viele Träumereien müßten im Zusammenhang mit der einfachen Vorstellung der Tür untersucht werden. Die Tür! Sie ist ein ganzer Kosmos des Halboffenen — zum mindesten ist sie darin das Leitbild, der eigentliche Ursprung einer Träumerei, in der sich Wünsche und Versuchungen ansammeln, die Versuchung, das Sein in seinen Untergründen zu erschließen, der Wunsch, alle verschlossenen Wesen zu erobern. Die Tür schematisiert zwei starke Möglichkeiten, die zwei Typen der Träumerei säuberlich voneinander getrennt halten. Manchmal ist sie fest verschlossen, verriegelt, mit Vorhängeschloß versehen. Manchmal ist sie offen, das heißt weit offen.

Aber es kommen Stunden größerer Erlebnisbereitschaft der Phantasie. In Mainächten, wenn so viele Türen verschlossen sind, gibt es eine, die kaum angelehnt ist. Es genügt, ganz leicht anzustoßen! Die Angeln sind gut geölt. Dann zeichnet sich ein Schicksal ab.

Und so viele Türen waren Türen des Zauderns! In *La romance du retour* schrieb der feine, zärtliche Dichter Jean Pellerin [9]:

> Die Türe spürt mich, sie zaudert.

In diesem einen Vers ist soviel seelisches Geschehen auf einen Gegenstand übertragen, daß ein sachlich denkender Leser darin einfach nur ein Spiel des Geistes sehen mag. Wenn ein solches Dokument aus irgendeiner fernen Mythologie käme, würde man ihm leichter zustimmen. Aber warum sollte man den Vers des Dichters nicht als ein kleines Element spontaner

Mythologie nehmen? Warum sollte man nicht empfinden, daß in der Tür ein kleiner Gott der Schwelle inkarniert ist? Muß man denn in eine ferne Vergangenheit hinabtauchen, in eine Vergangenheit, die gar nicht mehr die unsere ist, um der Schwelle eine sakrale Bedeutung zu geben? Der Neuplatoniker Porphyrios hat richtig gesagt: »Eine Schwelle ist etwas Heiliges [10].« Aber wenn wir uns auch nicht auf eine solche Sakralisierung durch die Gelehrsamkeit berufen wollen, warum sollten wir uns nicht durch jene Sakralisierung berührt fühlen, die sich in der Dichtung vollzieht, in einer Dichtung unserer Zeit, die vielleicht die Farbe der Phantasie trägt, aber mit den ursprünglichen Werten in Einklang steht.

Ein anderer Dichter hat nicht an Zeus zu denken brauchen, um in sich selbst die Majestät der Schwelle zu entdecken:

> Ich ertappe mich dabei, die Schwelle
> Als den geometrischen Ort
> Des Kommens und Gehens im Hause
> Des Vaters zu definieren [11].

Und alle die Türen der bloßen Neugier, die das Wesen um eines Nichts willen in Versuchung geführt haben, um des Leeren willen, um eines unbekannten Etwas willen, das nicht einmal in der Einbildung existiert! Wer hat nicht in seinem Gedächtnis die Erinnerung an ein Blaubart-Zimmer, das man nicht hätte aufmachen, einen Spalt weit aufmachen dürfen? Oder — und für eine Philosophie, die sich zum Primat der Einbildungskraft bekennt, ist dies ganz das gleiche — das man sich nicht hätte geöffnet vorstellen dürfen, in der Erwartung, es könnte sich einen Spalt weit öffnen?

Wie wird alles konkret in der Welt einer Seele, wenn ein Objekt, wenn eine schlichte Tür Bilder spendet wie die des Zauderns, der Versuchung, des Verlangens, der Sicherheit, des freien Empfanges, der Ehrfurcht! Man müßte sein ganzes Leben erzählen, wenn man von allen Türen berichten wollte, die man geschlossen öffnen möchte.

Aber ist es das gleiche Wesen, das eine Tür öffnet und das sie wieder schließt? Bis zu welcher Tiefe des Seins können solche Gesten reichen, die das Bewußtsein der Sicherheit oder

der Freiheit geben? Werden sie nicht durch diese »Tiefe« so allgemein symbolisch? René Char macht einen Satz des Albertus Magnus zum Thema eines seiner Gedichte: »Es gab in Deutschland Zwillingskinder, von denen eines die Türen mit dem rechten Arm öffnete, das andere aber sie mit dem linken Arm schloß.« Eine solche Legende ist unter der Feder eines Dichters natürlich kein bloßes Zitat. Sie hilft dem Dichter, die nächste Umwelt zu sensibilisieren, die Symbole des täglichen Lebens zu verfeinern. Diese alte Legende wird ganz neu. Der Dichter macht sie sich zu eigen. Er weiß, daß die Tür zwei »Seinsformen« hat, daß die Tür unsere Träumereien in zwei entgegengesetzten Richtungen anregt, daß sie eine doppelte Symbolik enthält.

Und dann, wohin, wem entgegen öffnen sich die Türen? Öffnen sie sich für die Welt der Menschen oder für die Welt der Einsamkeit? Ramon Gomez de la Serna hat schreiben können: »Die Türen, die sich auf die Landschaft öffnen, scheinen uns hinter dem Rücken der Welt Freiheit zu verschaffen [12].«

VI

Sobald in einer Aussage das Wort *in* vorkommt, faßt man die Realität der Aussage kaum mehr buchstäblich auf. Was man für bildhafte Sprache hält, übersetzt man in vernünftige Sprache. Es fällt uns schwer, es scheint uns müßig, zum Beispiel dem Dichter zu glauben, der sagt, das Haus der Vergangenheit sei in seinem Kopfe lebendig. Sofort übersetzen wir: Der Dichter will ganz einfach sagen, daß er eine alte Erinnerung in seinem Gedächtnis behalten hat. Der Exzeß des Bildes, der das Verhältnis von Inhalt und Behälter umkehren möchte, läßt uns wie vor einem Bilderwahnsinn zurückschrecken. Wir wären eher zur Nachsicht geneigt, wenn wir unsere eigenen Fiebervisionen festhalten könnten. Wir würden dem Fieberlabyrinth folgen, das durch unseren Körper läuft, wir würden die »Häuser des Fiebers« erforschen, die Schmerzen, die einen hohlen Zahn bewohnen, und dann würden wir wissen, daß die Einbildungskraft die Qualen lokalisiert und imaginäre Anatomien bildet und umbildet. Aber wir werden in diesem Buch keinen

Gebrauch von den zahlreichen Dokumenten machen, die wir bei den Psychiatern finden könnten. Wir wollen lieber unseren Bruch mit dem Kausalismus bekräftigen, indem wir jede organische Kausalität aus dem Spiel lassen. Unser Problem ist, Bilder der reinen Imagination zu diskutieren, der befreiten und befreienden Imagination, ohne irgendwelche Bezugnahme auf organische Anregungen.

Solche Dokumente absoluter Poetik existieren. Der Dichter schreckt nicht zurück vor der Umkehrung räumlicher Abhängigkeiten. Ohne auch nur daran zu denken, daß er die Empörung vernünftiger Menschen erregt, bietet er dem gesunden Menschenverstand Trotz, erlebt er die Umkehrung der Dimensionen, das Umstülpen der Perspektiven des Drinnen und des Draußen.

Der abnorme Charakter des Bildes besagt nicht etwa, daß es künstlich hergestellt wäre. Die Einbildungskraft ist das natürlichste Vermögen, das es gibt. Zweifellos könnten die Bilder, die wir beschreiben werden, in einer Psychologie der Planung keinen Platz finden, es sei denn, es handelte sich um eine imaginäre Planung. Jeder Plan ist ein Zusammenhang von Bildern und Gedanken, der einen Eingriff in die Wirklichkeit voraussetzt. In einer Lehre von der reinen Einbildungskraft brauchen wir ihn also nicht zu berücksichtigen. Es ist sogar nutzlos, ein Bild fortzusetzen, nutzlos, es aufrechtzuerhalten. Es genügt uns, daß es ist.

Betrachten wir also mit aller phänomenologischen Einfalt die Dokumente, die uns die Dichter liefern.

In seinem Buch *Wo die Wölfe trinken* schreibt Tristan Tzara:

> Eine langsame Demut dringt in das Zimmer
> Sie wohnt in mir in der hohlen Hand der Ruhe.

Um die Traumwerte eines solchen Bildes wahrzunehmen, muß man sich zweifellos, zunächst einmal selbst »in die hohle Hand der Ruhe« begeben, das heißt, sich um sich selbst versammeln, sich im Sein einer Ruhe verdichten, die eine Annehmlichkeit ist, welche man mühelos »unter der Hand« hat. Die große Quelle schlichter Demut, die in dem schweigenden Zim-

mer ist, sie entspringt dann in uns selbst. Die Intimität des Zimmers wird dann zu unserer Innerlichkeit. Und entsprechend ist der innere Raum so ruhig geworden, so schlicht, daß sich in ihm die ganze Stille des Zimmers lokalisiert und zentralisiert. Das Zimmer ist in der Tiefe unser Zimmer, das Zimmer ist in uns. Wir *sehen* es nicht mehr. Es begrenzt uns nicht, denn wir sind selbst in der Tiefe seiner Ruhe, in der Ruhe, die es uns mitgeteilt hat. Und alle Zimmer von ehemals lassen sich diesem Zimmer einfügen. Wie einfach alles ist!

Aber an einer andern Stelle, rätselhafter noch für den Verstand, aber ebenso klar für jeden, der für die topo-analytische Umkehrung empfänglich ist, schreibt Tristan Tzara:

> Der Markt der Sonne ist ins Zimmer gekommen
> Und das Zimmer in den dröhnenden Kopf.

Um das Bild zu akzeptieren, um das Bild leben zu hören, dazu bedarf es jenes seltsamen Gebrauses, mit dem die Sonne in ein Zimmer eindringt, wo man allein ist, denn es ist eine Tatsache: der erste Strahl *klopft* an die Wände. Solche Laute — über den Sachverhalt hinaus — wird auch hören, wer weiß, daß jeder Sonnenstrahl Bienen mit sich führt. Dann fängt alles zu summen an, und der Kopf ist ein dröhnender Bienenkorb, ein Bienenkorb, in dem die Sonne dröhnt.

Auf den ersten Blick schien das Bild Tzaras von Surrealismus überladen. Doch wenn man es noch weiter überladet, wenn man seine bildhafte Ladung noch weiter verstärkt, wenn man, wohlgemerkt, die von der Kritik, von jeder Kritik, errichteten Schranken überschreitet, dann tritt man wahrhaft in den surrealen Aktionsraum eines reinen Bildes ein. Wenn die extreme Entwicklung des Bildes sich als mitteilbar und wirksam erweist, dann war der Ausgangspunkt gut: das sonnige Zimmer dröhnt im Kopf des Träumers.

Ein Psychologe mag sagen, unsere Analyse bringe nur kühne »Assoziationen«, allzu kühne. Der Psychoanalytiker wird vielleicht einwilligen — denn er ist es gewöhnt —, diese Kühnheit zu analysieren. Beide werden aber, falls sie das Bild symptomatisch finden, Gründe und Ursachen dafür suchen. Der Phänomenologe sieht die Dinge anders an; genauer gesagt, er sieht

das Bild so wie es ist, so wie der Dichter es schafft, und er versucht daraus Gewinn zu ziehen, sich von dieser seltenen Frucht zu nähren; er führt das Bild bis an die Grenze dessen, was er imaginieren kann. So weit er davon entfernt sein mag, selbst ein Dichter zu sein, er versucht doch für sich selbst den Schöpfungsakt zu wiederholen, ja, wenn möglich, die Übertreibung noch weiterzutreiben. Dann ist die Assoziation nicht mehr eine vorgefundene, erlittene; sie ist erstrebt, gewollt. Sie ist eine dichterische, spezifisch dichterische Setzung. Sie ist Sublimierung, völlig befreit von den organischen oder seelischen Lasten, von denen man sich befreien möchte, kurz, sie entspricht dem, was wir in der Einführung reine Sublimierung genannt haben.

Natürlich erlebt man ein solches Bild nicht jeden Tag in derselben Weise. Es ist, psychisch gesehen, nie objektiv. Andere Deutungen könnten ihm ein neues Leben geben. Um es richtig aufzunehmen, bedarf man einer günstigen Stunde der Über-Imagination.

Einmal von der Gnade der Über-Imagination berührt, erfährt man sie auch vor einfacheren Bildern, in denen die äußere Welt dem Hohlraum unseres Seins farbenstarke Gleichnisse bietet. Mit Hilfe eines solchen Bildes gelingt es Pierre Jean Jouve, sein verborgenes Wesen zu *setzen*. Er versetzt es in die innere Zelle:

> Die Zelle meiner selbst erfüllt mit Staunen
> Die weißgetünchte Wand meines Geheimnisses.
>
> *(Les Noces)*

Das Zimmer, in dem der Dichter einen solchen Traum ausspinnt, ist wahrscheinlich nicht »weißgetüncht«. Aber dieses Zimmer, das Zimmer, wo geschrieben wird, ist so ruhig, es verdient so sehr das Beiwort »einsam«. Man bewohnt es durch die Kraft des Bildes, wie man ein Bild bewohnt, das »in der Phantasie existiert«. Hier bewohnt der Dichter der *Noces* das zellenförmige Bild. Dieses Bild übersetzt keine Realität. Es wäre lächerlich, den Träumer nach seinen Ausmaßen zu fragen. Es widerstrebt der geometrischen Anschauung, aber es gibt einen guten Rahmen für das Geheimnis ab. Das verborgene Wesen fühlt sich hier durch die milchweiße Tünche besser be-

hütet als durch dicke Mauern. Die Zelle des Geheimnisses ist weiß. Ein einziger Wert genügt, um viele Träume zusammenzuordnen. Und so ist es immer: das dichterische Bild steht unter der Herrschaft einer besonders hervorgehobenen Eigenschaft. Die Weiße der Wände allein schon beschützt die Zelle des Träumers. Sie ist stärker als jede Geometrie. Sie schreibt sich in die Zelle der Innerlichkeit ein.

Solche Bilder sind unbeständig. Sobald man den Ausdruck verläßt, so wie ihn der Dichter in völliger Spontaneität bietet, läuft man Gefahr, in die platte Eindeutigkeit zurückzufallen und sich bei einer Lektüre zu langweilen, die nicht imstande ist, die Innerlichkeit des Bildes zu verdichten. Wie muß man sich über die eigene Tiefe beugen, um folgenden Text von Blanchot in der Daseins-Stimmung zu lesen, in der er geschrieben ist: »Von diesem in die tiefste Nacht getauchten Zimmer kannte ich alles. Ich hatte es durchdrungen, ich trug es in mir, ich gab ihm Leben, ein Leben, das nicht das Leben ist, aber stärker als das Leben, so daß keine Macht der Welt es besiegen könnte [13].« Fühlt man nicht in diesen Wiederholungen oder in diesen sich wiederholenden Steigerungen eines Bildes, das man durchdrungen hat — nicht etwa eines Zimmers, in das man eingedrungen ist —, eines Zimmers, das der Dichter in sich trägt, das er mit einem Leben außerhalb des Lebens belebt, — ja, sieht man nicht gleich, daß der Dichter nicht einfach sagen will, so sei seine alltägliche Wohnung beschaffen? Das Gedächtnis würde dieses Bild überladen. Es würde es mit gemischten Erinnerungen aus verschiedenen Zeitaltern möblieren. Hier ist alles einfacher, in radikaler Weise einfacher. Das Zimmer von Maurice Blanchot ist eine Wohnung im inneren Raum, es ist sein inneres Zimmer. Wir partizipieren am Bilde des Schriftstellers dank seiner Eigentümlichkeit, die uns wohl berechtigen könnte, von einem *allgemeinen* Bild zu sprechen, wobei die Partizipation uns davor bewahrt, es mit einer *allgemeinen Idee* zu verwechseln. Dieses allgemeine Bild verwandeln wir sogleich in ein einmaliges. Wir bewohnen es, wir durchdringen es, wie Blanchot das seine. Das Wort genügt nicht, die Idee genügt nicht, ein Schriftsteller muß uns dabei helfen, den Raum umzukehren, uns von dem, was man *be-*

schreiben könnte, zu entfernen, um besser die Hierarchie unserer Ruhe zu erleben.

Oft bekommt die Dialektik des Drinnen und des Draußen ihre ganze Kraft erst durch die Konzentration in dem engsten Innenraum. Diese Elastizität wird man empfinden, wenn man über den folgenden Text Rilkes meditiert (*Die Aufzeichnungen des Malte Laurids Brigge*, Ausgewählte Werke, Bd. II, Seite 66): »Und in dir ist beinah kein Raum; und fast stillt es dich, daß in dieser Engheit in dir unmöglich sehr Großes sich aufhalten kann; daß auch das Unerhörte binnen werden muß und sich beschränken den Verhältnissen nach ...« Es liegt eine Tröstung darin, sich in einem kleinen Raum von Stille umgeben zu wissen. Rilke realisiert innerlich — im Raum des Drinnen — diese Enge, wo alles nach dem Maß des inneren Seins gemacht ist. Im nächsten Satz wird dann schon die Dialektik erlebt: »Aber draußen, draußen ist es ohne Absehen; und wenn es da draußen steigt, so füllt es sich auch in dir, nicht in den Gefäßen, die teilweise in deiner Macht sind, oder im Phlegma deiner gleichmütigeren Organe: Im Kapillaren nimmt es zu, röhrig aufwärts gesaugt in die äußersten Verästelungen deines zahlloszweigigen Daseins. Dort hebt es sich, dort übersteigt es dich, kommt höher als dein Atem, auf den du hinaufflüchtest wie auf deine letzte Stelle. Ach, und wohin dann, wohin dann? Dein Herz treibt dich aus dir hinaus, dein Herz ist hinter dir her, und du stehst fast schon außer dir und kannst nicht mehr zurück. Wie ein Käfer, auf den man tritt, so quillst du aus dir hinaus, und dein bißchen obere Härte und Anpassung ist ohne Sinn.

O Nacht ohne Gegenstände. O stumpfes Fenster hinaus, o o sorgsam verschlossene Türen; Einrichtungen von alters her, übernommen, beglaubigt, nie ganz verstanden. O Stille im Stiegenhaus, Stille aus den Nebenzimmern, Stille hoch oben an der Decke. O Mutter: o du Einzige, die alle diese Stille verstellt hat, einst in der Kindheit.«

Wir haben diese Textstelle ohne Unterbrechung in ihrer ganzen Länge hereingenommen, weil sie genau das hat, was wir eine dynamische Kontinuität nennen. Das Drinnen und das Draußen werden nicht ihrer geometrischen Opposition über-

lassen. Aus welcher Überfülle eines »zahlloszweigigen« Innenraums fließt die Substanz des Daseins? Was bedeutet der Anruf der Außenwelt? Ist die Außenwelt nicht nur eine ehemalige Innenwelt, die im Schatten des Gedächtnisses verlorenging? Wie klingt die »Stille im Stiegenhaus?« In dieser Stille: leise Schritte. Die Mutter kommt, ihr Kind zu behüten, wie ehemals. Allen verworrenen und unwirklichen Geräuschen gibt sie ihren konkreten und vertrauten Sinn wieder. Die grenzenlose Nacht hört auf, ein leerer Raum zu sein. Die Sprache Rilkes, die von so vielen Schrecken bebt, findet ihren Frieden. Aber wie lang ist der Umweg! Um in der Wirklichkeit der Bilder erlebt zu werden, müßte er unaufhörlich mit einer Osmose zwischen dem inneren Raum und dem unbestimmten Raum zusammenfallen.

Wir haben so verschiedene Texte wie möglich gegeben, um zu zeigen, daß es Spiele mit Werten gibt, die alles, was mit einfachen räumlichen Bestimmungen zusammenhängt, auf den zweiten Plan verweisen. Die Opposition des Drinnen und des Draußen ist jetzt nicht mehr durch ihre geometrische Evidenz darstellbar.

Um dieses Kapitel zu beschließen, wollen wir noch einen Text von Balzac streifen, wo ein Wille, den als Gegner empfundenen Raum herauszufordern, definiert wird. Der Text ist um so interessanter, weil Balzac gemeint hat ihn verbessern zu müssen.

In einer ersten Fassung von *Louis Lambert* liest man: »Wenn er auf diese Weise alle seine Kräfte gebrauchte, verlor er gewissermaßen das Bewußtsein seines körperlichen Lebens, und existierte nur durch das allmächtige Spiel seiner inneren Organe, die er beständig in seiner Gewalt hatte; so ließ er, nach seinem eigenen bewunderungswürdigen Ausdruck, *den Raum vor sich zurückweichen* [14].«

In der endgültigen Fassung liest man nur: »Er ließ, nach seinem eigenen Ausdruck, den Raum hinter sich.«

Welcher Unterschied zwischen diesen beiden Ausdrucksbewegungen! Welche Abschwächung der Macht des Daseins gegenüber dem Raum, von der ersten zur zweiten Textgestalt! Wie hat Balzac eine solche Korrektur anbringen können? Er ist

damit zum »indifferenten Raum« zurückgekehrt. In einer Meditation über das Dasein klammert man im allgemeinen den Raum aus, anders gesagt, man »läßt den Raum hinter sich«. Als Hinweis auf die verlorene Steigerung der Daseinsstimmung merken wir an, daß die »Bewunderung« weggefallen ist. Die zweite Ausdrucksweise ist nicht mehr, wie der Autor selbst gesteht, »bewunderungswürdig«. Denn sie war effektiv bewunderungswürdig, diese Macht, die *den Raum zurückweichen* läßt, die den Raum nach draußen abdrängt, den ganzen Raum nach draußen, damit das meditierende Wesen in seinem Denken frei sei.

AN ARCHITEKTUR

Material zu: Henri Lefèbvre, Die Produktion des Raums

Zu Henri Lefèbvre kann man sowohl über die Mythen der Situationisten als auch über die Fußnoten in den Texten David Harveys gelangen; von den Ereignissen des Mai 1968 in Paris oder aus dem Umfeld der Surrealisten ebenso wie über die Geschichte der Kommunistischen Partei Frankreichs. Zu ihm führen die Texte von Manuel Castells, Mark Gottdiener, Frederic Jameson und Edward Soja. Die Arbeit von Lefèbvre spielt in Debatten über Architektur und Raum eine zunehmend wichtige Rolle. Seine Texte werden erneut rezipiert und scheinen einen komplexeren Bezug zur Wirklichkeit zu eröffnen. Sie weisen auf Möglichkeiten der Aneignung und einen anderen Zugang zu Fragen räumlicher Gestaltung hin. Darüber hinaus wird Lefèbvre wieder stärker als Vorreiter kritischer Stadtforschung wahrgenommen. Indem er Raum als gesellschaftliches Produkt beschreibt, ermöglicht er ein neues Verständnis der Beziehungen zwischen Raum, Gesellschaft und Produktion. Er benennt Raum als etwas durch die Produktionsverhältnisse und die darin eingebundenen Subjekte Hergestelltes; Gesellschaft, als etwas, das im Raum existiert, diesen formt und von diesem auf unterschiedliche Weise geformt wird; und letztendlich Produktion als Handlung mit Möglichkeiten des Widerstandes oder als affirmative Reproduktion der Verhältnisse. Lefèbvre bietet uns Kategorien der Beschreibung und des Verständnisses von Zusammenhänge in und durch Raum an.

Die Anzahl der deutschen Übersetzungen von Lefèbvres Arbeiten ist gering und komplett vergriffen. Sie beinhaltete vor allem seine frühen Texte zum Marxismus, während eines seiner beiden Hauptwerke über die Produktion des Raumes nur in englischer Übersetzung vorliegt.

1977 erschien in der Zeitschrift Arch+ ein übersetzter Vortrag Lefèbvres zu seiner Arbeit über die Produktion des Raumes. Diesen Text nahmen wir zum Anlass einer weitergehenden Auseinandersetzung mit seinem Werk. Wir ergänzten den Vortrag mit weiterführendem Material aus Lefèbvres Arbeiten und mit begrifflichen Erläuterungen. Mark Gottdiener und Stuart Elden stellten freundlicherweise zwei Texte zur Verfügung, die auf unterschiedliche Weise das Werk Lefèbvres kontextualisieren und in einen größeren theoretischen Zusammenhang stellen. Mark Gottdiener thematisierte kurz nach Erscheinen der englischen Übersetzung und dem Tod Lefèbvres sein Wirken in Relation zu anderen Theoriefeldern, insbesondere hinsichtlich kritischer amerikanischer Stadttheorie. Stuart Elden untersucht Lefèbvres Theorie der Produktion des Raumes als Teil dessen Gesamtwerks und in seiner philosophischen Dimension als Fortführung und Überschreitung marxistischer politischer Ökonomie.

Material zu: ist eine Reihe, die sich mit jeweils einem stadttheoretischen Text, einer architektonischen Position, oder einer AutorIn auseinandersetzen. Die Hefte bauen nicht linear aufeinander auf, sondern versuchen, Cluster von Konzepten und Rezeptionen zwischen den einzelnen Theorien herzustellen. Hier sollen aktuelle und historische Debatten, vergessene AutorInnen, sowie relevante Thesen zu Architektur- und Stadttheorie diskutiert werden.

In deutscher Sprache von Lefèbvre erschienen:

Der dialektische Materialismus. Suhrkamp, Frankfurt/M. 1969
Probleme des Marxismus, heute. Suhrkamp, Frankfurt/M. 1967
Metaphilosophie, Prolegomena. Suhrkamp, Frankfurt/M. 1975
Soziologie nach Marx. Suhrkamp, Frankfurt/M. 1972
Kritik des Alltagslebens. Athenäum, Kronberg/Ts. 1977.
Das Alltagsleben in der modernen Welt. Suhrkamp, Frankfurt/M. 1972.
Die Zukunft des Kapitalismus. Paul List, München 1974.
Einführung in die Modernität. Zwölf Präludien. Suhrkamp, Frankfurt/M. 1978.
mit C. Regulier: *Die Revolution ist auch nicht mehr, was sie mal war.* Hanser Verlag, München/Wien 1979.
Die Revolution der Städte. Philo, Frankfurt/M. 1990.

Lefèbvres wichtigste Titel auf englisch:

Critique of Everyday Life Volume I. London: Verso, 1991.
Everyday Life in the Modern World. Harmondsworth: Allen Lane, 1971.
The Production of Space. Oxford: Blackwell, 1991.
The Survival of Capitalism. London: Allison & Busby, 1976.
Writings on Cities. Oxford: Blackwell, 1996.

Sekundärliteratur:

Rob Shields: *Lefèbvre, Love and Struggle. Spatial Dialectics.* Routledge 1999

Henri Lefèbvre
Die Produktion des städtischen Raums

Die Unterscheidung zwischen Tauschwert und Gebrauchswert ist im marxistischen Denken von zentraler Bedeutung. Im »Kapital« bestimmt Marx in der Tat die Beziehung zwischen diesen beiden Formen des Werts als einen logischen Widerspruch, indem er sie einander gegenüberstellt als die beiden Pole eines in der Sache – der Ware – begründeten Gegensatzes. Noch heute entfaltet sich im Raum der modernen Gesellschaft ein verschärfter und heftiger Konflikt zwischen diesen beiden Formen des Werts – zwischen einem Raum, der immer mehr zum Tauschwert wird, und einem noch bewohnten Raum, der nur noch in dem Maße Gebrauchswert hat, wie ihn der Tauschwert nicht völlig zerstören konnte oder zum Verschwinden bringt. So sind z.B. alle historischen Räume, der Raum der Dörfer und die Räume vorkapitalistisch geprägter Landschaften noch Träger von Gebrauchswerteigenschaften. Der Tourismus bewirkt, dass man sich auf sie stürzt, er unterwirft sie dem Tauschwert und bringt sie dadurch zum Verschwinden. Der Tauschwert selbst entwickelt sich in Richtung einer immer größer werdenden Abstraktion vom Gebrauchswert und führt schließlich zum Austausch bloßer Abstraktionen und Zeichen.

Die durch die Verstädterung hervorgebrachten Probleme stellen sich hier in aller Schärfe, denn sie betreffen Räume, die durch Spekulation und Investition von Kapital unmittelbar der Herrschaft des Tauschwertes unterworfen sind, obgleich der städtische Raum konkreten Gebrauch bedeutet, d.h. den Gebrauch konkreter Zeit. Soweit städtische Räume dem Tauschwert unterworfen werden, wird ihr konkreter Gebrauch erschwert.

Gesellschaftliche Praxis

Im Rahmen dieser ersten Überlegungen lassen sich zwei Entwicklungslinien verfolgen: einerseits eine sich weltweit herausbildende Bewegung der Nutzer, andererseits die Konstitution einer Wissenschaft vom Raum, die nicht mehr länger als neutral oder als jenseits gesellschaftlicher Praxis stehend begriffen werden kann.

Diese Bewegung der Nutzer hat sich nicht nur in Frankreich, sondern insbesondere auch in Italien entfaltet, wo sie – als Bewegung des zivilen Ungehorsams – eine in Frankreich noch unbekannte Stärke und Qualität erreicht hat. Man findet diese Bewegung ebenfalls in Lateinamerika, ja sogar – in beachtlicher Stärke – in den USA oder in Kanada. Trotz dieser weltweiten Entwicklung hat sie in ihren Zielen noch nicht die Präzision der gewerkschaftlich organisierten Betriebskämpfe erreicht, gleichwohl kann sie in ihrer ganzen Vielfalt von gleicher Bedeutung sein.[2]

Die Wissenschaft vom Raum ist die Theorie neben der gesellschaftlichen Praxis und steht ihr gegenüber, einer Praxis, die sich in den Initiativen des Widestands, in der sozialen Bewegung der Nutzer des Raums ausdrückt. Dies sind die zwei Seiten der gleichen Realität und der in ihr enthaltenen Möglichkeiten. Die leitenden Prinzipien einer so verstandenen Wissenschaft können durch einen Vergleich mit dem Ausgangspunkt und der Entwicklungsrichtung des Marxschen Kapitals deutlich gemacht werden. Zu jener Zeit betrachteten die – von Marx als Vulgärökonomen bezeichneten – Ökonomen die Produkte der Industrie allein in ihrer dinglichen Gestalt und versuchten deren Preise zu ermitteln. Marx interessierte sich demgegenüber für ihre Produktion, nämlich ihren gesellschaftlichen Produktionsprozess und schuf derart eine (neue) Wissenschaft. Etwas ähnliches ist heute bezogen auf den Raum zu tun, mit dem sich immerhin die verschiedensten Leute beschäftigen, Schriften über ihn verfassen, ihn analysieren und beschreiben. Es ist eine Wissenschaft des Raums zu entwickeln, eine wis-

Tauschwert und Gebrauchswert

Der Gebrauchswert gibt Auskunft über die objektive oder subjektive Verwendbarkeit eines materiellen Gutes für einen bestimmten Zweck. Der Tauschwert entspricht dem Preis eines Gutes, dem Wert, der im Tausch auf einem Markt realisiert werden kann. Er ist von der stofflichen Gestalt, also auch von seiner Eignung zum Gebrauch unabhängig. Nach Marx wird der Tauschwert der Güter aus dem Wert der zur Produktion eingebrachten Arbeit erklärt. Die eingesetzte Arbeit bildet die Substanz des Wertes.

Verstädterung

Lefèbvre bezeichnet mit dem Konzept der »Verstädterung« den Entstehungsprozess einer völlig verstädterten nachindustriellen Gesellschaft, durch den die alten Stadtformen zerfallen, und der letztlich zur Aufhebung der Unterschiede zwischen Stadt und Land führt. Einer marxistischen Geschichtsauffassung des permanenten gesellschaftlichen Fortschritts entsprechend, ermöglicht erst die Verstädterung ein Verständnis der historischen Phase der Industrialisierung und überwindet schließlich ihr industrielles Ausbeutungsverhältnis.

Lefèbvres Vorstellung des Städtischen beschränkt sich jedoch nicht nur auf die Stadt in ihrer stofflichen Gestalt: »Das Stadtgewebe beginnt zu wuchern, dehnt sich aus und verschlingt die Überbleibsel des ländlichen Daseins. Mit »Stadtgewebe« ist nicht nur, im strengen Sinn, das bebaute Gelände der Stadt gemeint, vielmehr verstehen wir darunter die Gesamtheit der Erscheinungen, welche die Dominanz der Stadt über das Land manifestieren. So verstanden sind ein zweiter Wohnsitz, eine Autobahn, ein Supermarkt auf dem Land Teil des Stadtgewebes.« (Henri Lefèbvre: Die Revolution der Städte. Frankfurt am Main, 1990 (1976), S. 9/10)

dingliche Gestalt

Lefèbvre bezieht sich hier auf Marx' Analyse der Warenwelt, dass bloßes Feststellen und Beschreiben der Existenz der Dinge ihren wahren Charakter verleugnet. Dinge als lediglich quantifizierbare und klassifizierbare Objekte zu betrachten, bedeutet ihren Ursprung, also die gesellschaftliche Arbeit zu verkennen. Lefèbvre konzipiert analog zu Marx' Demaskierung der Dinge eine kritische Analyse von Raum, die diesen in seiner doppelten Beziehung sowohl zu den Dingen als auch zu den gesellschaftlichen Verhältnissen zu erfassen vermag.

»Dinge – für Marx das Produkt gesellschaftlicher Arbeit und zum Tausch bestimmt, und deshalb mit Wert im doppelten Sinn ausgestattet, mit Gebrauchswert und Tauschwert – verkörpern und verbergen gesellschaftliche Verhältnisse. Dinge scheinen demnach diese Verhältnisse zu untermauern. Und dennoch wird aufgrund der marxistischen Analyse deutlich, dass Dinge als Waren aufhören Dinge zu sein. Und, insofern sie Dinge bleiben, werden sie zu »ideologischen Objekten«, die mit Bedeutung überladen sind. Als Waren können Dinge als die Verkörperung gesellschaftlicher Verhältnisse betrachtet werden, ihre Existenz ist dann vollständig abstrakt – so sehr, dass man versucht ist, in ihnen nichts anderes zu sehen, als Zeichen und Zeichen von Zeichen (Geld). Die Frage der Untermauerung ist daher nicht vollständig durch das Postulat einer permanent materiellen Welt beantwortet. Im Kontext unserer gegenwärtigen Diskussion stellt sich diese Frage in erster Linie in Bezug auf den gesellschaftlichen Raum. Dieser Raum hat die Eigenschaften eines »Ding / nicht Ding«, da er weder eine substantielle noch eine gedankliche Realität ist. Er kann nicht auf Abstraktionen reduziert werden und besteht weder in einer Ansammlung von Dingen im Raum noch in einer Anhäufung in Besitz genommener Orte. Er ist weder Raum-als-Zeichen noch ein Ensemble mit Raum verbundener Zeichen und hat damit eine andere Wirklichkeit als die der abstrakten Zeichen und realen Dinge, die er enthält.« (Henri Lefèbvre: The Production of Space. Oxford / Malden, 1991 (1974), S. 402)

senschaftliche Auseinandersetzung über den Raum, die sich eben nicht allein mit seiner dinglichen Gestalt beschäftigt. Die einzige Art und Weise, diese Auseinandersetzung als Wissenschaft derart in Gang zu bringen, dass man den verschiedenen Ideologien entgeht, besteht darin, den Raum im Prozess seiner Produktion zu betrachten.

Grundlegende Vorstellungen

Von den Vorstellungen, die notwendigerweise vorhanden sein müssen, um dieses Vorhaben beginnen zu können, ist die Vorstellung einer symmetrischen Struktur die erste, die wir behandeln müssen. Symmetrische Strukturen finden sich überall in der Natur und auf allen Ebenen der gesellschaftlichen Realität. In sämtlichen Stoffen der physischen Natur kann diese allgemeine Charakteristik aufgewiesen werden (z.B. durch die Kristallographie). In Anlehnung an Heidegger und das berühmte Distichon »la rose et son pourquoi ne sait pas pourquoi elle est rose et ne sait comment elle est rose« wieder aufgreifend, kommen wir dahin, uns nach der symmetrischen Struktur von Blumen zu fragen und uns die Frage zu stellen, warum eine Natur, die die Modelle der Mathematiker, mit deren Hilfe diese sich symmetrische Strukturen – oder deren Metamorphosen – vergegenwärtigen, selbst nicht herstellen kann, mit diesen manchmal hochkomplexen Strukturen überhaupt existiert.

Diese Überlegungen zu unserer Vorstellung der symmetrischen und der asymmetrischen Strukturen zwingen uns, ein noch viel zu gängiges Bild des Raums zu korrigieren, nämlich das Konzept oder die Vorstellung, der Raum sei ein leerer Behälter und seinem materialen Inhalt gegenüber gleichgültig. Es gibt zwischen dem Enthaltenden und dem Enthaltenen, zwischen der Form und ihrem Inhalt, eine viel strengere und tiefere Beziehung als die einer gegenseitigen Gleichgültigkeit.

Es scheint für dieses Vorhaben notwendig zu sein, eine noch weitaus paradoxere und übrigens auch neuere Vorstellung zu entwickeln, nämlich diejenige, die wir als Ort des Zerfalls bezeichnen wollen. Bei der Betrachtung eines Raums ist es erforderlich, den Ort seines Zerfalls zu bestimmen, d.h. die Schwellen, jenseits derer der Raum zerfällt. Ein Ruderer, der langsam sein Boot vorwärtsbewegt, erzeugt auf der Oberfläche des Wassers ellipsenförmige Kurven (eine rund um das Boot sich ausbreitende Wellenbewegung), wenn er aber schneller rudert oder einen Motor verwendet, um vorwärts zu kommen, wird die Ausbreitungsgeschwindigkeit der Wasserwellen überschritten, wodurch hyperbelförmige Kurven erzeugt werden. Plötzlich verwandeln sich in bestimmten Momenten Ellipsen in Hyperbeln, es ist etwas geschehen. Doch vom Boot aus wird man nichts bemerken können. In der Luftfahrt findet sich ein ähnliches Phänomen, nämlich wenn ein Flugzeug die Ausbreitungsgeschwindigkeit der Schallwellen überschreitet. Dieses »etwas« wird »Schallmauer« genannt. Die »Schallmauer« bereitete zunächst allergrößte Schwierigkeiten, denn die Flugzeuge zerbrachen genau in dem Moment, in dem sie diese durchstoßen wollten, so dass alle möglichen Vorsichtsmaßnahmen ergriffen werden mussten. Die »Schallmauer« ist so etwas wie ein Ort des Zerfalls. Jeder Raum hat seinen Ort des Zerfalls, der zu seiner Untersuchung bestimmt werden muss.

Die dritte Vorstellung, die wir in unsere Überlegungen aufnehmen müssen, ist diejenige der hierarchischen Konfiguration als einer in sich geschichteten Struktur der räumlichen Gestalt. Man kann von einer hierarchischen Konfiguration immer dann sprechen, wenn Formen sich gegenseitig enthalten und wenn sie sich hierarchisch schichten lassen. Zum Beispiel lässt sich in der Linguistik die hierarchische Konfiguration im Rahmen der Lautbildung auf die Verquickung von Silbe, Einzellaut, Wort und schließlich Satz anwenden. Ein Wort wird aus Silben und zusammengefügten Lauten gebildet. Ihre Zusammenfügung oder mehrfache Verknüpfung ist die Voraussetzung der übergeordneten Formen. Eine ähnliche hierarchische Konfiguration lässt sich im sozialen Raum aufweisen (das Zimmer,

Raum im Prozess seiner Produktion

Lefèbvres Raumauffassung beinhaltet eine Kritik der vorherrschenden Diskurse des Raumes. Lefèbvre wendet sich sowohl gegen rein gedankliche Konzeptionen von Raum, die ihn entweder mathematisch definieren oder zum Raum philosophischer Theoriebildung erheben, als auch gegen rein ästhetische Auffassungen von Raum, die in ihm einen bloßen Behälter sehen, der seinem Inhalt gegenüber gleichgültig ist, oder die Raum mit den in ihm befindlichen Gegenständen gleichsetzen.

Beide Diskurse, der gedankliche wie der ästhetische sind ideologisch, da sie sich lediglich auf Erdachtes oder Sichtbares beziehen, ohne die Voraussetzungen der Herstellung von Raum zu thematisieren. Zentraler Ausgangspunkt von Lefèbvres Forschungen ist somit die These, dass Raum vor allem gesellschaftlicher Raum und damit ein gesellschaftliches Produkt ist.

Lefèbvre entwickelt analog zu Marx' Analyse der Warenproduktion eine Theorie der Produktion von Raum. Raum besitzt für ihn nicht nur den gleichen Status innerhalb der Produktionsweisen wie Kapital oder Arbeit, eine Erforschung von Raum beinhaltet auch eine Ausweitung und Aktualisierung des marxistischen Projekts.

»Wenn Raum ein Produkt ist, muss von unserem Wissen von Raum erwartet werden, dass es den Prozess der Produktion wiedergibt und erklärt. Der »Gegenstand« des Interesses muss sich somit von den Dingen im Raum auf die tatsächliche Produktion des Raumes verlagern. Aber schon diese Formulierung erfordert umfassende zusätzliche Erklärungen. Beides, die im Raum vorhandenen partiellen Produkte, also die Waren, und der Diskurs über Raum können fortan nicht mehr leisten, als Hinweise auf und Zeugnisse für diesen produktiven Prozess zu liefern, ein Prozess, der signifizierende Prozesse subsumiert, ohne aber auf sie reduzierbar zu sein. Es kann nicht mehr länger von Bedeutung sein, den Raum hiervon oder den Raum davon zu untersuchen: Vielmehr geht es um Raum in seiner Totalität oder in seinem globalen Aspekt. Raum darf nicht nur einer analytischen Forschung unterworfen werden (denn diese Vorgehensweise neigt dazu, lediglich eine unendliche Reihe von Fragmenten und Querschnitten hervorzubringen, die dem eigentlichen analytischen Projekt untergeordnet sind), sondern er muss auch durch und innerhalb eines theoretischen Verständnisses hervorgebracht werden.« (The Production of Space, S. 36/37)

Raum ist für Lefèbvre im Gegensatz zu anderen Waren sowohl selbst Produkt als auch Medium, in dem andere Produkte hergestellt werden. Raum wird gesellschaftlich produziert, gleichzeitig ist er aber das Medium, das gesellschaftliche Verhältnisse strukturiert, konkret werden lässt und dadurch letztlich reproduziert. Raum beinhaltet somit die Möglichkeit, auf den Prozess seiner Herstellung und auf die damit einhergehenden gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse verändernd einzuwirken.

die Hütte, das Wohnhaus, das Dorf oder das Quartier, die Stadt, der Kreis, die Region und schließlich der Staat). Die Vorstellung einer hierarchischen Konfiguration kann der Ausgangspunkt einer Wissenschaft vom Raum unter der Voraussetzung werden, dass in allen Fällen der Ort des Zerfalls präzisiert wird.[3]

Raum und Produktionsweisen

Marx unterscheidet als Epochen ökonomischer Gesellschaftsformation das natürliche Gemeinwesen oder den Urkommunismus, die antike Sklavenhaltergesellschaft, die feudale Produktionsweise, die kapitalistische Produktionsweise und die sozialistische. Es ist möglich und sinnvoll, die Marxsche Klassifikation zu einer allgemeinen Analyse des Raums zu verwenden, obwohl noch viel zu tun bleibt, um eine derartige Klassifikation zu verfeinern.

Der analoge Raum

Die naturwüchsige Stammesgemeinschaft ist bereits ein außerordentlich komplexes Gebilde mit Kombinationen aller Arten sozialer Erscheinungsformen. Sie ist in ihrer Verflechtung von Häuptlingen, Kriegsführern, Sippen, Familien und Stammeszugehörigkeiten wesentlich komplexer, als Marx sie noch gesehen hat. Insgesamt kann man die Besiedlung des Raums oder den durch diese Gemeinschaften besiedelten Raum als einen analogen Raum charakterisieren. Wir verfügen über besonders klare und bemerkenswerte Beispiele für den analogen Raum: ein Dongo-Dorf in Afrika z.B., welches den menschlichen Körper nachzeichnet. Kopf, Glieder, männliche und weibliche Geschlechtsorgane und die Füße werden durch die Anordnung der Hütten nachgebildet: durch die Hütten der Häuptlinge, die Hütten, in denen sich Männer und Frauen versammeln, schließlich durch die Hütten, in denen die Arbeitsinstrumente aufbewahrt werden und dergleichen mehr. Der besiedelte Raum bzw. der gebaute Raum, auch wenn es sich hier nur um einfache Hütten handelt, ist in Analogie zum menschlichen Körper dessen Projektion auf den bzw. in den Raum. Derart lässt sich der analoge Raum definieren.

Der kosmologische Raum

Der kosmische Raum entspricht der antiken Produktionsweise. Die Monumente sind so nebeneinander angeordnet, dass sie den Kosmos verkörpern, wie man ihn sich zu jener Zeit vorstellt. Die Stadt wird zum Abbild der Welt. Häufig hat ein einzelnes Gebäude die Aufgabe, Welt nachzubilden; charakteristisch für diese Art Monument ist das römische Pantheon, dessen Bestimmung es war, die Götter – selbst den unbekannten Gott – zu beherbergen. Das Pantheon ist mit seiner Kuppel die Verkörperung des Firmaments, des kosmischen Raums, wie die Alten ihn sich vorstellten. Die Nachbildung des Kosmos durch das römische Pantheon ist keineswegs einzigartig. Die Stadt der antiken Produktionsweise enthält auch in anderen Fällen Orte, die durch einen Obelisken oder einen Stein beherrscht werden, die als Nabel, Mittelpunkt, als Zentrum der Welt gelten, um welche herum ein Abbild der Welt errichtet wird.

Der symbolische Raum

Die mittelalterliche Stadt enthält eine andere Form von Raum, den symbolischen Raum. Der Raum dieser Städte und der Kathedralen ist selbst Symbol und ein Raum, der von religiösen Symbolen gefüllt wird. Man kann gemäß dieser Auffassung, die in ihrer begrifflichen Konzeption präzisiert und vertieft wird, den Übergang vom symbolischen Raum der romanischen Kirchen zum Raum der gotischen Kathedralen begreifen, der in noch sehr viel weitergehendem Maße Symbolcharakter trägt.

Die letzteren symbolisieren das Emporstreben der Stadt über die Erde hinaus und eine bestimmte Sehnsucht der gesamten Gesellschaft nach der erhofften und erahnten Erleuchtung, jener des Logos, d.h. des Wortes, d.h. nach der Erleuchtung Christi.[4] Es ist ein kryptischer Raum, in welchem die Wahrheit in den Gräbern verborgen liegt, in den Gräbern der Heiligen oder im Grabe Christi. Der

Raum und Produktionsweise

Lefèbvre versucht, den Prozess der Produktion von Raum geschichtlich nachzuvollziehen und in seinen jeweiligen historischen Ausprägungen zu erfassen.

Raum wird hier zum konstitutiven Element unterschiedlicher Gesellschaftsformationen. Lefèbvre macht deutlich, dass jede neue politisch-gesellschaftliche Macht ihren spezifischen Raum erschafft.

»[...] jede Gesellschaft, und damit jede Produktionsweise mit ihren Subvarianten (das heißt, alle jene Gesellschaften, die Ausdruck des generellen Konzepts sind) produziert einen Raum, ihren eigenen Raum. Die Stadt der Antike kann weder als eine Ansammlung von Menschen und Dingen im Raum verstanden werden, noch kann man sich von ihr einzig und allein aufgrund einer Anzahl von Texten und Abhandlungen über den Raum ein Bild machen, obwohl einige von ihnen [...] unverzichtbare Quellen des Wissens sein können. Die antike Stadt hatte demnach ihre eigene räumliche Praxis: Sie brachte ihren eigenen – angeeigneten – Raum hervor. Es bedarf also eines Studiums dieses Raumes, das ihn als solchen zu begreifen vermag, in seiner Genese und in seiner eigenen spezifischen Zeit oder in seinen Zeiten (dem Rhythmus des täglichen Lebens), mit seinen besonderen Zentren und seinem Polyzentrismus (Agora, Tempel, Stadium usw.).

Die griechische Stadt dient hier nur als Beispiel – als ein Schritt auf dem Weg. Jede Gesellschaft bietet, schematisch gedacht, den ihr eigenen Raum als »Gegenstand« der Analyse und allumfassenden theoretischen Erläuterung an. Ich sage jede Gesellschaft, aber es wäre angemessener, jede Produktionsweise zu sagen, einhergehend mit ihren spezifischen Produktionsverhältnissen. Jede dieser Produktionsweisen kann durchaus deutlich unterschiedliche Ausprägungen umfassen, was wiederum zu einer Anzahl theoretischer Schwierigkeiten führt. Wir werden auf diese später in Form von Unstimmigkeiten, Brüchen und Leerstellen zurückkommen.« (The Production of Space, S. 31)

Lefèbvres Konzeption der historischen Epochen von Raum verläuft weitgehend analog zu einer marxistischen Geschichtsperiodisierung. Sie behauptet letztlich die Existenz essentieller Raumformationen jeder historischen Gesellschaftsformation, beziehungsweise Produktionsweise.

Hier wird eine Geschichtsauffassung erkennbar, die im Gegensatz zu Lefèbvres sonstiger Kritik von reduktionistischen Vorgehensweisen steht und die in nebenstehendem Vortrag noch einmal zusätzlich verkürzt erscheint.

Lefèbvres historische Kategorisierung wurde zum Teil stark kritisiert (siehe auch Rob Shields: Lefèbvre, Love and Struggle. New York 1998): Seine Periodisierung von Raum korrespondiert mit einem streng linearen, orthodox-marxistischen Modell geschichtlichen Fortschritts, in dem letztlich die Zeit als ordnende Kategorie der räumlichen Dimension übergeordnet wird. Darüber hinaus weisen insbesondere seine Interpretationen der frühen historischen Epochen eine eurozentristische Sichtweise auf und sind von einem stereotypen Blick auf sogenannte primitive Kulturen und von einer Raumauffassung geprägt, die schematische Muster des Männlich-Aktiven, beziehungsweise des Weiblich-Passiven festschreibt.

Die historische Periodisierung in nebenstehendem Vortrag unterscheidet sich sowohl von der in Production of Space vorgenommenen Periodisierung als auch von den Klassifizierungen der Sekundärliteratur. Wir stellen hier vom Original ausgehend eine ergänzende Interpretation vor, die andere Betonungen setzt und die sich an der begrifflichen Klassifikation von Bo Grönlund anlehnt.

Absoluter Raum (absolute space)

Der absolute Raum ist der Raum der Natur. Lefèbvre setzt ihn mit dem Raum archaischer Kulturen gleich. Absoluter Raum ist analoger Raum, die Projektion des Körpers oder von Sinnbildern des Universums auf räumliche Strukturen. Absoluter Raum ist nicht-fragmentierter Raum, in dem Raum und Zeit, Geistiges und Gesellschaftliches untrennbar miteinander verbunden sind und in dem somit kein Außen existiert.

Sakraler Raum (sacred space / religious space)

Der sakrale Raum ist der Beginn der Abstraktion. Er entfernt sich von der Einheit und Dominanz der Natur des absoluten Raumes durch eine sich von ihr abgrenzende Religion und setzt die Unterscheidungen Mensch-Natur, Stadt-Land als Dualitäten von Aktivität und Passivität. Der sakrale Raum ist der Raum der ersten Stadtstaaten, die beginnen, ihre ländliche Umgebung zu dominieren. Er ist zugleich sakral und politisch. Es entstehen voneinander unterscheidbare Territorien mit gesellschaftlichen Ordnungen, Gesetzen und mit Räumen, die diese repräsentieren.

Historischer Raum (historical space)

Der historische Raum markiert den Übergang einer sakralen zu einer weltlichen Ordnung. Er ist gekennzeichnet durch die Anfänge der Akkumulation, die Trennung der Produktion vom bloßen Überleben. Es entstehen neue städtische Räume des Handels, die Marktplätze des Mittelalters. Die neuen darstellenden Techniken der Renaissance, die Perspektive und exakte Darstellung hingegen schaffen eine neue Dominanz des Visuellen, und damit eine neue Konzeption von Raum. Beide Entwicklungen fördern das Entstehen des abstrakten Raumes, die einhergeht mit der räumlichen Ausbreitung des Kapitalismus.

Abstrakter Raum (abstract space)

Abstrakter Raum ist kapitalistischer Raum. Sein bestimmendes Kennzeichen ist die Gleichzeitigkeit von Homogenisierung und Fragmentierung, beides Tendenzen, die der

Raum ist, insbesondere während der Gotik, ein Raum des Heraufsteigens aus den Grüften, des Aufsteigens gegen das durch die Kathedralen symbolisierte Licht.

Der perspektivische Raum

Obwohl der perspektivische Raum sich nicht unmittelbar in die Klassifikation der Produktionsweisen einfügen lässt, scheint es sinnvoll, sich mit ihm zu beschäftigen, weil wir noch zu häufig seiner Struktur gemäß denken und weil er in unsere Gewohnheiten und in unsere Sprache Eingang gefunden hat, obgleich es mit dem Beginn des modernen Zeitalters, etwa um 1910, zu einer Krise des gesamten Bezugsrahmens kommt. Es ist die Krise einer Gesamtheit von Bezugspunkten, die zur gleichen Zeit gemeinsam ins Wanken geraten: das tonale System in der Musik, das perspektivische System in der Optik, der euklidische dreidimensionale Raum, das alte Geschichtsbild, die Familie und ebensoviele andere Bezugspunkte, die in eine Krise geraten, der wir bis heute noch nicht entkommen sind. Seit etwa 1910 gilt es als Irrtum, in Kategorien des perspektivischen Raums zu denken, seit nämlich die Bilder von Kandinsky und Klee oder diejenigen des analytischen Kubismus uns deutlich gemacht haben, dass wir uns in einer Krise des deskriptiven Raums befinden. Die Linie des Horizontes verschwindet in der Malerei ebenso wie der Schnittpunkt der Parallelen im Unendlichen.

Der perspektivische Raum entwickelt sich mit der Renaissance und dem Quattrocento in der Toskana, in einer Zeit, in der die Städte in ganz Italien, mehr noch aber in der Toskana an Bedeutung gewinnen: Florenz, Siena, Lucca und Pisa. Auf der Basis des Handelskapitalismus lassen sich die Kaufleute, die als Tuchfabrikanten die Wolle von Schafsherden verarbeiten, in den Städten als Bankkapitalisten nieder. Die Bankiers in Florenz, Siena oder Lucca erwerben von den feudalen Grundherren große Ländereien und verändern deren Struktur grundlegend. An die Stelle der Bewirtschaftung der Güter durch Leibeigene setzen sie die Bewirtschaftung durch Pächter, die die Ernte mit den Eigentümern zu teilen haben. Die Pachtwirtschaft ist gewissermaßen ein Fortschritt gegenüber der Leibeigenschaft; insofern er frei ist und seine Ernte »nur« teilen muss, hat der Pächter ein Interesse, soviel wie möglich zu produzieren und entfaltet derart die landwirtschaftliche Produktivität. Die Bankiers der toskanischen Städte benötigen ihrerseits wachsende Ernten, um die städtischen Märkte und die Städte selbst zu versorgen. Infolge ihrer vermittelnden Position sind sie in noch wesentlich größerem Maße Nutznießer dieses Prozesses als die Bauern, wobei sämtliche Böden in der Region bewirtschaftet werden.

Die florentinischen Bankiers, insbesondere die Medicis, errichten auf dem Lande Palais, um die herum Pachthöfe gruppiert sind. Die Wege, die von einem Pachthof zum anderen führen, sind von Zypressen gesäumt, so dass die Landschaft plötzlich eine Tiefe und Weite entwickelt, die sie bis dahin nie gehabt hatte. Die Fluchtlinien zum Horizont werden durch Zypressenalleen gebildet; dort taucht zum ersten Mal die Perspektive auf, die in gewisser Weise das Resultat des wechselseitigen Aufeinanderwirkens von Stadt und Land ist. Freilich, das genügt nicht, denn der Raum lässt sich nicht nur aus den ökonomischen und sozialen Bedingungen heraus erklären. Erst das Werk Albertis verleiht der Perspektive ihre Form. Dennoch bleibt für Alberti der Raum zunächst noch das Symbol des Körpers und des Universums, wobei der Raum bereits ein Maß hat, messbar ist und eine optische Wahrnehmbarkeit besitzt. Diese Übersetzung des Raums in einen Zustand optischer Wahrnehmbarkeit ist ein außerordentlich bedeutsames Phänomen. Nach Alberti muss aus der visuellen Anordnung der Elemente des Raums, der Linien und Kurven, von Licht und Schatten, der männlichen und weiblichen Elemente (d.h. der Winkel und der runden Formen) – muss aus dieser gesamten Anordnung die Schönheit für das Auge entspringen, eine vergeistigte Empfindung, die zugleich Bewunderung und Freude hervorruft. Der Raum bewahrt gewisse Qualitäten der Natur,

kapitalistischen Marktlogik inhärent sind. Abstrakter Raum wird dominiert von einer rationellen, technokratischen Raumauffassung, die diesen quantifiziert und zum Objekt der Planung und des Tausches macht und somit alle nicht-kapitalistischen Produktionsweisen absorbiert.

das Licht und die Reinheit; Kunst, Kultur und Erfindungskraft bringen andere Qualitäten hervor, den Geschmack, würdevolles Verhalten und Formen der Anpassung an die Gesetze der Gesellschaft.

Dieser Raum wird von der Perspektive regiert; er nimmt die Natur in sich auf, indem er sie dem Maß und den Anforderungen der Gesellschaft unterwirft, freilich unter der Herrschaft des Auges und nicht mehr unter der des Körpers. Seit dem Quatrocento trifft man in der Malerei auf die beherrschende Rolle des deskriptiven Raums, der als bildgemäß gilt. Er liefert für den Bau und die Anlage der Städte den Rahmen und die Grundlage einer gemeinsamen Sprache der Bewohner, der Nutzer, der herrschenden Schichten, der Künstler und der Architekten. Seit diesem Zeitpunkt wird die Stadt perspektivisch angelegt. Sie ist der Fassade als dem dominierenden Moment unterworfen, die die Perspektive und die Fluchtlinien der Parallelen, d.h. der Straßen festlegt. Die Kristallisation dieses Zusammenspiels hat Konsequenzen: Unterschiede erscheinen nur noch in der Aufeinanderfolge der Fassaden, sind zurückgenommen auf ihre unterschiedliche Gestaltung. Brüche, Versetzungen und Vorsprünge sind auf ein Minimum reduziert; sie dürfen auf keinen Fall die Kontinuität der Perspektive beeinträchtigen. Und, da nun die Fassade dazu da ist, dass man sie sieht und damit sie gesehen wird, ist sie zentral und beherrschend geworden, ein Tatbestand, der vorher und insbesondere in der Antike nicht existierte. An die Fassaden selbst aber hängt man Balkone, die zugleich dem Sehen wie dem Gesehen-werden dienen. Es ist also ein Gesamt-Raum, der sich entwickelt, indem er das Ensemble der Künste (die Malerei, die Bildhauerei, die Architektur, die Stadtbaukunst) beherrscht, ein Raum, der allen gemein ist. Die Bewohner richten sich in diesem Raum ein und die Architekten und die politisch herrschenden Schichten sind in der Lage, ihm eine Ordnung zu verleihen; wir haben es hier mit einem Code, mit einer verschlüsselten Sprache zu tun. Diese Periode stellt wohl die einzige in der Geschichte des Raums dar, in der eine einheitliche Sprache auf den verschiedenen hierarchisch gegliederten Ebenen existiert, d.h. auf der Ebene des Zimmers, des Wohngebäudes, auf der Ebene einer Folge von Wohngebäuden, auf der Ebene des Quartiers und der Stadt sowie auf der Ebene ihrer Einbettung in den umgebenden Raum. Von daher rührt die harmonische Schönheit der Städte, die diesem Modell gefolgt sind und es umgesetzt haben.

Der kapitalistische Raum

Der kapitalistische Raum ist für den perspektivischen Raum der Ort des Zerfalls. Der eine führt zum Untergang des anderen. Dieses Phänomen wird sichtbar in Picassos analytischem Kubismus oder in der Malerei Kandinskys. Das Ende dieses Untergangs des perspektivischen Raums ist durch den Tatbestand gekennzeichnet, dass nun ein Monument, ein Bau, ein Objekt in einem homogenen und nicht mehr in einem qualifizierten und qualitativen Raum steht. Das Objekt steht in einem visuellen Raum, der es erlaubt, es von allen Seiten einzusehen. Picasso, Klee und die Mitglieder des Bauhauses haben gleichzeitig entdeckt, dass man um die Objekte im Raum herumgehen kann und dass sie keine bevorzugte Ansicht mehr aufweisen. Die Gebäude orientieren sich nicht mehr in die Richtung dessen, der sie betrachtet oder auf den sie blicken. Sie stehen in einem gleichgültigen Raum und sind selbst diesem Raum gegenüber, der sich auf dem Weg zur totalen Quantifizierung befindet, gleichgültig. Das Hochhaus, dessen Prototypen Mies van der Rohe entworfen hat, ist derart in einen Raum gestellt, dass man um es herumgehen kann. Es ist ein Objekt, das kein bevorzugtes Gesicht, keine Fassade mehr hat. Doch ohne Fassade stirbt die Straße. Der perspektivische Raum ist durch einen gänzlich neuen Raum ersetzt worden. Allerdings entspringt dessen Doppeldeutigkeit daraus, daß die Mitglieder des Bauhauses und Le Corbusier an eine Revolution, eine grundlegende Veränderung des Raums glaubten, während der kapitalistische Raum sich durchsetzte. Diese Raumkonzeption hat sich durch den Kapitalismus auf dem Weltmarkt verbreitet.
Dieser kapitalistische Raum ist nicht leicht zu definieren. Um ihn zu bestimmen, reicht die Aussage nicht aus, er sei quantitativ oder er habe den perspektivischen

Raum, d.h. einen in einer besonderen Weise qualifizierten Raum durch einen qualitativ anderen Raum ersetzt. Dieser qualitativ andere Raum ist ein homogener, aber ein in seiner Homogenität zersplitterter Raum. Die bildenden Künste haben in bemerkenswerter Weise zutreffende Modelle davon geliefert, wie ein Raum gleichzeitig homogen und zersplittert sein kann.

Aber wie kann denn nun der Raum gleichzeitig homogen und zersplittert sein? Liegt darin nicht ein logischer Widerspruch? Keineswegs! Dieser Raum ist homogen, weil darin alles äquivalent, weil darin alles austauschbar und auswechselbar ist; weil es ein Raum ist, der dem Verkauf unterliegt und weil es nur einen Verkauf von Äquivalenten, von Austauschbarem gibt. Dieser Raum ist aber ebenso zersplittert, weil er durch Grundstücke oder Parzellen gebildet wird. Und er wird Grundstück für Grundstück oder Parzelle für Parzelle verkauft, er wird also fortwährend zersplittert und fragmentiert, mehr noch: pulverisiert. Aufgebaut auf der Warenwelt, in der alles äquivalent, auswechselbar und – insbesondere durch den Staats- und Polizeiapparat – kontrolliert und kontrollierbar ist, ist dieser Raum homogen, aber auch zersplittert, da er sich auf manchmal winzigen Grundstücken oder Parzellen erhebt – deren Größe nach unten hin ausschließlich durch ihre Eignung zur Bebauung begrenzt ist – auf Grundstücken, die nach den Gesetzen oder den Regeln der Grundrente und der Spekulation so teuer wie möglich verkauft werden. Dass er gleichzeitig homogen und zersplittert sein soll, schien zunächst paradox, dieser Raum ist jedoch ein logischer Raum, wenn auch die Logik des Ganzen dadurch negiert wird, dass sich die Details im Zustand der Fragmentierung befinden.

Die Produktionsweise als Motor der Raumentwicklung

Die von uns vorgeschlagene Klassifikation der Entwicklungsstufen des Raums umfasst also als ältesten und frühesten den analogen Raum, den Raum der naturwüchsigen Stammesgemeinschaft; den kosmischen Raum als den der antiken Gesellschaft, den man ebenso im Orient finden kann; den symbolischen Raum als den Raum des Mittelalters; als Übergangsform dann den perspektivischen Raum, der übrigens den Ort des Zerfalls für den vorausgehenden symbolischen Raum darstellte; schließlich den kapitalistischen Raum, der eine logische Struktur besitzt. Analog, kosmisch, symbolisch und logisch bilden eine gewisse Abfolge, die deutlich zeigt, dass die Produktionsweise die Antriebskraft der Raumentwicklung ist. Jede Produktionsweise impliziert die Produktion eines charakteristischen Raums, aber diese Charakteristika lassen sich umgekehrt nicht vollständig auf die wesentlichen Züge der jeweiligen Produktionsweise zurückführen. Der kosmische Raum war in seinen Strukturen, z.B. in Rom oder Athen, nicht nur durch die Sklavenhaltung bestimmt. Darüber hinaus spielen noch andere Elemente eine bedeutende Rolle, und die offene oder heimliche Reduktion des Ästhetischen auf die Ökonomie wäre ein fataler Fehler, der von einer Reihe von Marxisten immer noch gemacht wird. Die kapitalistische Produktionsweise ist gekennzeichnet durch einen zugleich homogenen und zersplitterten Raum, darüber hinaus jedoch durch einen Raum staatlicher Kontrolle, der zugleich derjenige des kapitalistischen Verkaufs und Austausches ist. Der Staat versucht mittels Kontrolle, den homogenen Charakter des Raums zu verstärken, freilich wird aber eben diese Homogenität beständig zerstört durch den Austausch oder den Verkauf von Parzellen in kleinstem Maßstab. Ein solcher Raum ließe sich ebenso bestimmen als optischer und visueller. Der Körper verliert sich in einem Raum, der bildhaft und flächig geworden ist, d.h. er ist nur noch optisch. Dieser Raum trägt aber ebenso phallischen Charakter; die Hochhaustürme mit ihrer Arroganz bezeugen das in ausreichendem Maße. Phallisch, optisch, visuell, homogen, zersplittert, global und fragmentiert könnten die wesentlichen Eigenschaften des kapitalistischen Raums sein.

Dieser kapitalistische Raum ist von den Mitgliedern des Bauhauses und Le Corbusier idealisiert worden, auch noch dann, als sie ihn verwirklichten. Diese

homogen und zersplittert

Der abstrakte Raum ist durch zwei scheinbar gegenläufige Entwicklungen gekennzeichnet: durch die Gleichzeitigkeit seiner Homogenisierung und Fragmentierung. Lefèbvre beschreibt, wie diese Tendenzen jedoch der Kapitallogik selbst innewohnen und für sie konstitutiv sind.

»Heute ist es einfacher für uns zu verstehen, dass Tauschwert, Ware, Geld und Kapital, da solche Begriffe in die »Kultur« eingegangen sind, konkrete Abstraktionen sind, Formen, die eine gesellschaftliche Existenz haben (genau wie Sprache, die so viel Tinte fließen ließ – und genau wie Raum), die aber erst einen Inhalt benötigen, um gesellschaftlich zu existieren. Kapital unterteilt und zerstreut sich unvermeidlich als individuelle »Kapitale«. Aber das heißt nicht, dass es ihm nicht möglich ist, seine Einheit aufrechtzuerhalten oder dass es aufhört, ein Ganzes zu konstituieren – letzteres ist eine notwendige Bedingung seines Funktionierens (als Kapitalmarkt). Teilaspekte des Kapitals treten miteinander in Konflikt, Wirtschaftskapital, Industriekapital, Investitionskapital, Finanzkapital – dennoch bleibt die formale Einheit des Kapitals bewahrt. Die Form bleibt bestehen und umfasst alle »Bruchstücke«. Und in der Tat ist die gesellschaftlich »wirkliche« Erscheinung, in der es sich präsentiert, die der Einheit, die des Kapitals per se. Seine wahre Heterogenität, seine Konflikte und Widersprüche erscheinen als solche. Dieser Sachverhalt trifft auch auf das Eigentum zu, dass in unbewegliches und bewegliches Eigentum, Grundeigentum und Geld unterteilt ist. Geht es aber um den Markt, so ist dessen Fragmentierung, mit der wir recht gut vertraut sind, Teil seines eigentlichen Konzepts: Es gibt den Warenmarkt (den eine einseitige Interpretation des Marxismus allen anderen Märkten überordnet), den Kapitalmarkt, den Arbeitsmarkt, den Grundstücks- und Immobilienmarkt (Baugewerbe, Wohnungswesen – also Raum) und die Märkte der Kunstwerke, der Zeichen und Symbole, des Wissens und so weiter. (The Production of Space, S. 306/307)

Grundrente

Rente bezeichnet eine Zuwendung, die jemand aufgrund von Rechtsansprüchen erhält. Grundrente meint das auf dem Rechtstitel Eigentum an Grund und Boden beruhende Einkommen.

Nach David Ricardo (Die Grundsätze der politischen Ökonomie und der Besteuerung, 1817) erklärt sich die Grundrente bei Grundstücken, die der Produktion dienen, als »Differentialrente«. Da auf besser verwertbaren Grundstücken oder Böden unterdurchschnittliche Produktionskosten aufgrund ihrer Lagevorteile entstehen, kann bei gleichem Marktpreis der Waren ein »Surplus-Profit« erwirtschaftet werden. Diesen darf ein Grundeigentümer aufgrund seines Rechtsanspruches einziehen und kann so eine höhere Grundrente erwirtschaften als auf vergleichsweise schlechteren Böden. Der ungünstigste Boden ist theoretisch rentenlos.

Auf Grundstücken zum Wohnungsbau, auf denen keine Produktion stattfindet, wird eine sogenannte »Monopolrente« erwirtschaftet.

Der Bodenpreis ist die kapitalisierte Grundrente. Er bildet sich aus der möglichen, nicht aus der tatsächlich erwirtschaftbaren Grundrente und erzwingt so die maximale ökonomische Ausnutzung dieses Raumes. Das ist das von Lefèbvre angesprochene Gesetz der Grundrente.

Idealisierung entwickelte sich ausgehend vom visuellen und optischen Charakter des Raums, der der klassischen Perspektive diametral entgegengesetzt ist. Analysiert man die Werke Le Corbusiers, so begreift man, dass er den kapitalistischen Raum idealisierte, indem er ein Bild produzierte und reproduzierte, welches in der Verherrlichung eines kräftigen, aber müßigen Menschen bestand, der in einem Gefühl der Freude das Licht der Sonne betrachtet, die Natur in den Grünräumen und die in der Helligkeit der Sonne ausgebreiteten Silhouetten anderer Menschen. Dieser Raum enthält jedoch noch andere Elemente, die nicht allein die Alltäglichkeit, das programmierte Alltagsleben, den gelenkten Konsum implizieren, sondern auch eine sorgfältig hierarchisierte Distanz (weil durch den Staat kontrolliert) zwischen vornehmen und gewöhnlichen Räumen, zwischen den Räumen für das Wohnen und allen anderen. Er impliziert zugleich ein Zentrum bürokratischer Herrschaft, ein Zentrum, in dem durch die Träger politischer Macht die Entscheidungen fallen. Dieser Raum ist so organisiert, dass die Benutzer zu Passivität und Schweigen verurteilt sind, wenn sie nicht revoltieren. Diese Revolte aber kann von der Entwicklung alternativer Projekte, der Entwicklung alternativer Räume und zum Teil gewaltsamer Widerstandsaktionen bis hin zu einer massiven Gegenbewegung führen, die die Gesamtheit der austauschbaren, spektakulären kapitalistischen Räume in Frage stellt, jene Räume nämlich, die die Alltäglichkeit, die Zentralisierung der Macht und die räumliche Hierarchisierung mit ihren tiefgreifenden Widersprüchen implizieren.

programmiertes Alltagsleben, bürokratische Herrschaft, Passivität und Schweigen der Benutzer

Lefèbvre konzeptionalisiert in seiner Theorie des Raumes die unterschiedlichen Ebenen, auf denen Raum wirksam wird, in einer dreifachen Beziehung bestehend aus räumlicher Praxis, Repräsentation des Raumes und Räumen der Repräsentation. Diese verschiedenen Aspekte des Raumes durchdringen sich wechselseitig. Sie können sich gegenseitig verstärken oder widersprechen, sind aber immer gleichzeitig wirksam. Diese Triade soll hier zunächst vorgestellt und dann anhand des abstrakten Raumes konkretisiert werden.

Räumliche Praxis (spatial practice)

Räumliche Praxis ist erfahrener Raum (perceived space) und gekennzeichnet durch alle Widersprüchlichkeiten des alltäglichen Lebens. Räumliche Praxis basiert auf einer nicht-reflexiven alltäglichen Praxis, die gesellschaftliche Verhältnisse als gegeben hinnimmt. Sie garantiert somit gesellschaftliche Kontinuität. Anders gesagt produziert und reproduziert dieser Aspekt des Raumes die seiner jeweiligen Gesellschaftsformation entsprechenden räumlichen Praktiken und spezifischen Räume, und damit die ihm zugrunde liegenden gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse. Räumliche Praxis produziert und reproduziert so in zirkulärer Weise ihre eigenen Voraussetzungen.

Räume der Repräsentation (representation of space)

Die Repräsentation des Raumes ist erdachter Raum (conceived space). Dieser Aspekt des Raumes ist gekennzeichnet durch abstrakte Konzeptionen und Darstellungen von Raum. Er ist der Raum der Wissenschaften, Theorien, Planungen und vorherrschenden Diskurse über Raum und wird durch diese hergestellt. Die Repräsentation des Raumes ordnet den gesellschaftlichen und physischen Raum dem gedanklichen Raum unter. Sie steht in enger Verbindung mit vorherrschenden Produktionsweisen und naturalisiert ihre jeweiligen Ordnungen. So wirkt sie nicht zuletzt auch auf die gesellschaftliche Praxis.

Räume der Repräsentation (spaces of representation / representational spaces)

Räume der Repräsentation sind der Diskurs des Raumes im Gegensatz zum Diskurs über den Raum. Sie sind Räume des Ausdrucks, gelebter Raum (lived space), nicht erdachter Raum. Ihre Bedeutungen werden durch den Gebrauch hergestellt. Es ist dieser Aspekt des Raumes, der vorherrschende Ordnungen und Diskurse unterlaufen und dadurch andere Räume imaginieren kann. Räume der Repräsentation sind die Räume möglichen Widerstands und möglicher Kämpfe der Aneignung und bergen eine starke Motivation zu utopischen Veränderungen.

Im abstrakten Raum dominiert der Aspekt der Repräsentation des Raumes, dieser verwirklicht vor allem die Anforderungen und Normen kapitalistischer Produktionsweise. Sein vorherrschender Diskurs ist der einer marktgerechten Verwertbarkeit von Raum, seiner Quantifizierbarkeit und bürokratischen Verwaltung. Die Repräsentation des Raumes legitimiert und stützt so die Funktionsweise von Kapital und Staat. Der abstrakte Raum tendiert zur Reduktion und Homogenisierung gesellschaftlichen Raumes.

Abstrakter Raum ist jedoch nicht das ausschließliche Ergebnis einer Ideologie oder naturalisierender Diskurse, sondern wird hergestellt mittels räumlicher Praxis. Diese kann als eine Art »räumliche Ökonomie« begriffen werden und hat die Existenz eines gesellschaftlichen Konsenses zur Voraussetzung, der die Konventionen des erwarteten Gebrauchs von Räumen vorgibt. Räumliche Praxis bestätigt und reproduziert genau diese Konventionen. Sie ist vor allem durch das Schweigen der Benutzer gekennzeichtnet, durch die Abwesenheit der Räume der Repräsentation. Nach Lefèbvre wäre das der gelebte Raum, der Raum möglicher Widerständigkeit und der Entwicklung alternativer Räume.

Diese Widersprüche verbinden und überlagern sich mit den herkömmlichen Widersprüchen der kapitalistischen Produktionsweise, mit jenen nämlich, die zwischen Kapital und Arbeit und Produktion und Konsumtion bestehen. Einige jener oben genannten Widersprüche sind charakteristische Widersprüche der kapitalistischen Produktionsweise; die Produktion des Raums ist einer davon. Das unmittelbar in die Produktion des Raumes eingebrachte gesellschaftliche Wissen ist in der Lage, den Raum auf der Ebene großer Einheiten zu planen (z.B. der Bau einer Autobahn), zugleich wird aber der Raum fragmentiert und pulverisiert durch Verkauf und Austausch, eben durch das System des privaten Eigentums. Hier erscheint der bereits von Marx bezeichnete und seinem Denken zugrunde liegende Widerspruch zwischen den Produktivkräften und den Produktionsverhältnissen in einer neuen, modernen Form. Die Produktivkräfte, in die das gesellschaftliche Wissen (die Wissenschaft) eingeht, ermöglichen es, den Raum auf der Ebene großer Einheiten zu organisieren, das private Eigentum jedoch (die gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse) hindert die gesellschaftlichen Kenntnisse an dieser Form der Intervention. Die privaten Eigentumsverhältnisse paralysieren die Anstrengungen und Bemühungen der Architekten und Stadtplaner und enden mit der Zerstörung ihrer kritischen und schöpferischen Fähigkeiten. Der Zwang der Produktionsverhältnisse und der gesellschaftlichen Beziehungen (die schließlich auch Eigentumsverhältnisse sind) verstärkt sich und nimmt ungewöhnliche Proportionen an. Dieser Zwang wird letztlich durch die Immobilienhändler und Spekulanten verkörpert.

Der Raum der Gegensätze

Merkwürdig genug – in unserem Teil der Welt sind die kapitalistischen Räume zerfallen oder sind dabei, es zu tun, ob es sich nun um das Wohngebäude, das zusätzliche Ausstattungen erfordert, oder um die Schule, die Krankenhäuser, die psychiatrischen Anstalten handelt; sei es nun die Stadt oder das Quartier, die Region, das Land oder die Nation, alle diese Räume befinden sich im Stadium des Zerfalls. Wir stehen hier vor dem größten oder einem der größten Probleme, die der Sozialismus zu lösen hat. Diejenigen, die sich auf den Sozialismus berufen, scheinen diesen Fragen bislang wenig Bedeutung beigemessen zu haben, sie werden jedoch gezwungen sein, sie mehr und mehr in ihre Überlegungen aufzunehmen und das um so mehr, je mehr sie deren Ausmaß unterschätzen.

Die sozialistische Produktionsweise muss ihren eigenen Raum produzieren, der nicht mehr kapitalistischer Raum sein kann. Jede Transformation der sozialistischen Welt, die die kapitalistische Morphologie reproduziert, wird nur mehr oder weniger verschleiert die kapitalistischen Produktionsverhältnisse reproduzieren. Der kapitalistische Raum befindet sich im Stadium des Zerfalls; hat man begonnen, ihn im Namen des Sozialismus wieder herzustellen? Dies ist ein Problem, was sich in aller Öffentlichkeit stellt. Es ist notwendig, einen neuen Raum zu schaffen, indem man die Tendenzen aufnimmt, die bereits in der kapitalistischen Produktionsweise aufscheinen. Doch wie entsteht, wie entwickelt sich der den kapitalistischen Raum zerstörende Raum, der Ort des Zerfalls des kapitalistischen Raums? Es ist ein Raum der Gegensätze oder ein gegensätzlicher Raum[5], der bereits in der kapitalistischen Produktionsweise als eine beständig bekämpfte Tendenz vorhanden ist. Dieser gegensätzliche Raum manifestiert sich auf allen Ebenen, auf der Ebene der Schule wie auf der des Wohnhauses und seiner Ausstattung, auf den Ebenen des Quartiers und der Stadt. Überall tauchen im Zerfall der Räume Gegensätze auf. Es handelt sich also darum, jenes zusammenzufassen, was bislang getrennt war (z.B. das Öffentliche und das Private), Vermischungen zu antizipieren und die kontinuierliche Weiterentwicklung von Separierungen zu vermeiden wie jene zwischen Zentrum und Vorstädten oder Peripherien.

Widersprüche

Nach Marx ist der Widerspruch die Wechselwirkung zweier in Einheit befindlicher Gegensätze, die einander bedingen, sich aber zugleich ausschließen. Widersprüche treten in Dingen, Prozessen und Systemen auf und werden im Denken widergespiegelt. Der grundlegende Widerspruch der kapitalistischen Gesellschaft - das Ausbeutungsverhältnis zwischen Kapital und Lohnarbeit - erhält in der Ware als Einheit von Gebrauchswert und Tauschwert seine Form. Widersprüche können zu realen Konfrontationen führen und sind so Voraussetzung und Grundprinzip möglicher Veränderungen und möglichen Fortschritts.

In The Production of Space ist die Artikulation der Widersprüche im »Raum der Widersprüche« (contradictory space) die zentrale Vorbedingung der Entstehung anderer Räume. Lefèbvre beschreibt die Widersprüche als der Logik des abstrakten Raumes inhärent, als Widersprüche der Gesellschaft, die im Raum stattfinden, die dort aber aufgehoben und verleugnet werden.

Lefèbvre benennt analog zu Marx diese verdeckten Widersprüche des Raumes, um sie damit produktiv zu machen. Die Widersprüche des abstrakten Raumes sind die zwischen einem global homogenisierenden und einem lokal fragmentierten Raum, zwischen einem quantifizierbaren, auf den Markt und damit den Tauschwert ausgerichteten Raum und einem Raum der Qualität und des Gebrauchswerts.

Lefèbvre betont den dualen, im Gegensatz zu einem bloß binären Charakter der Widersprüche. Die Dualität des Raumes verweist auf eine mögliche Dualität der Macht. Im Raum der Gegensätze liegt eine gewisse Chance der Entstehung alternativer Räume, wenn seine Widersprüche auf eine Weise artikuliert und wirksam werden, die den absorbierenden Tendenzen des dominierenden Raumes entkommt.

»Einer der stärksten, dem Raum immanenten Konflikte ist, dass Raum, wie er gegenwärtig »erfahren« wird, die Äußerung von Konflikten verhindert. Damit Konflikte geäußert werden können, müssen sie zunächst einmal wahrgenommen werden, ohne sich, wie allgemein erdacht, den Repräsentationen des Raumes unterzuordnen. Es bedarf deswegen einer Theorie, die sowohl über die Räume der Repräsentation als auch über die Repräsentationen des Raumes hinausgeht, und die in der Lage ist, Widersprüche angemessen zu artikulieren (an erster Stelle die Widersprüche zwischen diesen beiden Aspekten der Repräsentation). Sozio-politische Widersprüche werden räumlich realisiert. Die Widersprüche des Raumes lassen so die Widersprüche der gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse konkret wirksam werden. Anders gesagt geben räumliche Widersprüche den Konflikten zwischen sozio-politischen Interessen und Kräften »Ausdruck«. Nur im Raum kommen solche Konflikte in wirksamer Weise zum Tragen, und werden so zu Widersprüchen des Raumes.« (The Production of Space, S. 365)

Produktivkräfte und Produktionsverhältnisse

Die Produktionsverhältnisse bezeichnen die Gesamtheit der gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse im Prozess der Herstellung, des Tausches und der Verteilung materieller Güter. Dies sind in erster Linie die Eigentumsverhältnisse an den Produktionsmitteln, sowie die Tausch- und Distributionsverhältnisse, politische Systeme und ihre Rechtsverhältnisse oder soziale Beziehungen.

Die Produktivkraft der Arbeit besteht in dem Zusammenwirken der menschlichen Arbeitskraft und der Produktionsmittel. Die Produktivkräfte sind alle menschlichen und gegenständlichen Faktoren, die im gesellschaftlichen Produktionsprozess den Ablauf und die Intensität der Güterproduktion bestimmen. Dazu gehören neben menschlichen Fähigkeiten und der Art der Arbeitsteilung, auch Naturverhältnisse, die Art der Produktionsmittel sowie der Stand von Wissenschaft und Technik.

Produktionsmittel wiederum umfassen die Arbeitsmittel (Werkzeuge und Maschinen) sowie die Arbeitsgegenstände (Boden, Rohstoffe und Materialien).

Raum der Gegensätze / Differentieller Raum

Der »differentielle Raum« (differential space) eröffnet Möglichkeiten der Produktion alternativer Räume aus den Widersprüchen des gegenwärtigen Raumes heraus. Der abstrakte Raum zielt auf die Einebnung von Differenzen und die Absorption nicht-kapitalistischer Produktionsweisen. Eine Politik der Differenzen kann so als Angriff auf und als Alternative zum vorherrschenden räumlichen System begriffen werden. Raum ist dabei mehr als nur ein Medium dieser Kämpfe. Lefèbvre geht hier über Konzeptionen vorherrschender Theoriebildung hinaus, indem er versucht, abstrakte Konzepte an Gelebtes zu binden und so einen Raumbegriff zu entwerfen.

»Was einer Gesellschaft, die auf dem Tauschwert basiert, zuwiderläuft, ist eine Vorrangstellung des Gebrauchs. Was der Quantität entgegensteht, ist Qualität. Wir wissen, worin Gegen-Projekte oder woraus Gegen-Räume bestehen, weil die Praxis es zeigt. Wenn eine Gemeinde gegen den Bau städtischer Autobahnen oder gegen die Entwicklung neuer Wohngebiete kämpft, wenn sie »Annehmlichkeiten« oder Freiräume für Spiel oder Begegnung fordert, können wir erkennen, wie ein Gegen-Raum in die räumliche Realität eindringt: gegen das Auge und gegen das Starren, gegen die endlose Expansion des »Privaten« und der industriellen Rentabilität und gegen spezialisierte Räume und eine engstirnige Lokalisierung von Funktion. Es passiert natürlich, dass induzierte Differenzen – Differenzen also, die einem Ganzen innewohnen, und von diesem System des Ganzen hervorgebracht wurden, das darauf ausgerichtet ist, sich erst zu begründen und sich dann zu schließen (zum Beispiel die suburbane »Welt der Villen«) – entweder von produzierten Differenzen, die der Herrschaft des Systems entkommen, oder von reduzierten Differenzen, die durch Zwang oder Gewalt in das System zurückgedrängt wurden, schwer

Zur Lösung der städtischen Probleme oder genauer: der Probleme einer denkbaren Gesellschaft (die nicht identisch ist mit der zukünftigen Gesellschaft) lassen sich eine Reihe von Vorschlägen finden, aber keiner dieser Vorschläge ist wirklich geeignet. (...) Es ist erforderlich, was die Produktion eines zukünftigen Raums betrifft, den Raum einer zukünftigen sozialistischen Gesellschaft zu betrachten, den wir uns heute bereits vorstellen bzw. den wir erdenken müssen. Warum verhalten wir uns diesem Problem gegenüber passiv und indifferent? Es ist notwendig, darüber nachzudenken und zu versuchen, Lösungen zu antizipieren, die auch etwas taugen, diese müssen aber noch erfunden werden... Der Vorschlag der gegensätzlichen Räume ist nur ein bescheidener Versuch, solche Räume wahrzunehmen, zu interpretieren oder vorwegzunehmen. (...)

Der Text »Die Produktion des städtischen Raums« wurde 1977 in Arch+ Nr. 34 veröffentlicht. Es ist die Übersetzung (von Übersetzung: Franz Hiss, Hans-Ulrich Wegener) eines Vortrags von Henri Lefèbvre, den er am 30. Mai 1975 unter dem Titel »Introduction à l'espace urbain« auf Einladung der Association Strasbourg 2000 gehalten hat. Er bezieht sich auf Überlegungen aus »La production de l'espace«, Edition Anthropos, Paris 1974. Mit freundlicher Genehmigung von Arch+ wird dieser Vortrag hier leicht gekürzt wieder abgedruckt.

1 vgl. Karl Marx, *Das Kapital*. Bd. I

2 vgl. *Strasbourg 2000*, um ein Beispiel zu nennen .

3 Der mathematische Ausdruck der Vorstellung, die dem »Ort des Zerfalls« entspricht, findet sich in dem Buch von René Thom, *Modèles mathématiques de la morphogenèse*. Eine wörtliche Übersetzung von »espace de catastrophe« schien uns unangemessen und sinnentstellend. Die von Lefèbvre genannten Beispiele sprechen für den von uns gewählten deutschen Ausdruck. (Anm. d. Übers.)

4 Das Werk von Panovski hat deutlich bestimmte Formen der Wirklichkeit dieses Raums gezeigt, ohne freilich ausreichend auf seinen symbolischen Charakter hinzuweisen, sowie auf sein Auftauchen aus den vorhergehenden Raumformen.

5 »espace des différences, espace différentiel«; bislang sind diese Begriffe unserer Meinung nach zu wörtlich übersetzt worden, nämlich mit »der differentielle Raum« (vgl. *Die Revolution der Städte*, München 1972). Wir schlagen hier die inhaltlich treffendere Übersetzung »Raum der Gegensätze, gegensätzlicher Raum« vor. (Anm. d. Übers.)

zu unterscheiden sind. Natürlich passiert es auch, dass ein Gegen-Raum oder ein Gegen-Projekt bereits existierenden Raum simulieren, diesen parodieren und seine Grenzen aufzeigen, ohne trotz alledem seinen Klauen zu entkommen.

Die einzige Möglichkeit mithilfe des Einbringens (oder Wiedereinbringens) eines gewissen Pluralismus auf das Funktionieren des zentralisierten Staates einzuwirken, liegt in der Herausforderung der zentralisierten Macht durch »lokale Mächte«, in der Fähigkeit kommunaler oder regionaler Kräfte zu Handlungen, die in direktem Zusammenhang mit dem jeweiligen Gebieten stehen. So ein Widerstand oder solche Gegen-Aktion tendieren zwangsläufig dazu unabhängige territoriale Einheiten zu stärken und zu schaffen, Einheiten, die sich bis zu einem gewissen Grad selbst verwalten können.« (The Production of Space, S. 381/382)

»Wir beginnen langsam, die volle Tragweite der Differenz zu erkennen, die letztlich den Widerspruch zwischen wahrem Raum (true space) und Wahrheit des Raumes (truth of space) hervorbringt. Wahrer Raum, der Raum der Philosophie und seiner erkenntnistheoretischen Ableger, nahtlos vor allem im abstrakten Sinn, eingehüllt in den Umhang der Wissenschaft, nimmt im Kopf eines Denkers Gestalt an, und wird dort gestaltet, bevor er auf die gesellschaftliche und sogar auf die physische »Wirklichkeit« projiziert wird. [...] Wahrer Raum ist ein gedanklicher Raum, dessen duale Funktion darin besteht, den »wirklichen« Raum auf die Abstraktion zu reduzieren und minimale Differenzen zu induzieren. Dogmatismus dieser Art dient den schändlichsten Strategien ökonomischer und politischer Macht. [...] Der Raum der Repräsentation verschwindet in der Repräsentation des Raumes – die letzte schluckt den vorherigen. Räumliche Praxis, mit gesellschaftlicher Praxis zu einem Ganzen zusammengefasst, hat nur Bestand als der nichtgedachte Aspekt des Gedankens, der sich nun selbst zum souveränen Herrscher ernennt. Im Gegensatz dazu bezieht sich die Wahrheit des Raumes - den dominierenden offiziellen Absichten entgegenlaufend - einerseits auf die gesellschaftliche Praxis und andererseits auf Konzepte die, obwohl philosophisch ausgearbeitet und theorethisch untereinander verknüpft, die Philosophie als solche transzendieren, gerade weil sie mit der Praxis verbunden sind. Gesellschaftlicher Raum erfordert eine Theorie der Produktion und es ist diese Theorie, die seine Wahrheit bestätigt.« (The Production of Space, S. 397/398)

Produktion eines zukünftigen Raumes

»Es gibt nicht widersprüchlicheres als das Urbane. Einerseits ermöglicht es zu einem gewissem Grad, Klassenkämpfen in andere Richtungen zu lenken. Die Stadt und die urbane Wirklichkeit können dazu beitragen, gefährliche »Elemente« zu verstreuen und sie erleichtern auch das Aufstellen relativ harmloser »Zielsetzungen«, beispielsweise die Verbesserung des Transportwesens oder ähnliche »Annehmlichkeiten«. Andererseits werden die Stadt und ihre Peripherie allmählich zu einer Arena möglicher Handlungen, die nicht mehr länger auf die traditionellen Orte der Fabrik oder des Büros beschränkt werden können. Die Stadt und der urbane Bereich sind somit die Schauplätze des Kampfes; sie sind jedoch auch die Gegenstände dieses Kampfes. Wie kann man nach Macht streben, ohne nach den Orten zu greifen, an denen die Macht sich befindet, ohne diesen Raum besetzen und so eine neue politische Landschaft schaffen zu wollen – etwas, das eine Kritik der Handlungen der alten politischen Struktur beinhaltet und somit auch des Zustandes der politischen Sphäre selbst (sowie spezifischer politischer Ausrichtungen)? [...] Die Aneignung politisch dominierten Raumes wirft ein enormes politisches Problem auf, eines, das so lange unlösbar bleiben muss, wie keine Kritik des politischen Gebietes, spezifischer Politiken und des Staates in Sicht ist – in der Tat so lange kein Dahinwelken des Staates eintritt, ganz gleich, auf welchem Wege und aufgrund welcher Vorgänge.« (The Production of Space, S. 386/387)

»Es existiert keine »kommunistische Gesellschaft«, und das eigentliche Konzept des Kommunismus ist unklar geworden, insofern als der Begriff hauptsächlich dazu dient, zwei gegensätzliche, aber komplementäre Mythen aufrechtzuerhalten, den Mythos des Antikommunismus einerseits und den Mythos, dass irgendwo eine kommunistische Revolution stattgefunden hat. Um diese Frage nochmals anders zu stellen: Hat der Staatssozialismus einen eigenen Raum produziert?

Diese Frage ist wesentlich. Eine Revolution, die keinen neuen Raum produziert, hat nicht ihr volles Potential entfaltet. Sie ist in der Tat gescheitert, indem sie nicht das Leben selbst, sondern lediglich den ideologischen Überbau, die Institutionen oder politischen Apparate verändert hat. Eine gesellschaftliche Transformation muss, um wahrhaft revolutionären Charakter zu haben, in ihren Auswirkungen auf das tägliche Leben, auf die Sprache und auf den Raum eine kreative Kapazität unter Beweis stellen, obwohl ihre Wucht nicht im selben Grad oder mit gleicher Kraft in jedem dieser Bereiche auftreten muss.« (The Production of Space, S. 53/54)

Mark Gottdiener

Ein Marx für unsere Zeit: Henri Lefèbvre und Die Produktion des Raumes

Henri Lefèbvre, der letztes Jahr im Alter zwischen 86 und 89 starb (die Aufzeichnungen sind hier unklar), war vielleicht der größte marxistische Denker seit Marx und er war sicherlich einer der größten Philosophen unserer Zeit. Soziologen können seine Bedeutung erst richtig schätzen, wenn sie sich vergegenwärtigen, dass das, was sie über Marx' Werk selbst wissen, recht begrenzt ist. Letzterer ist von Generationen der Lehrbuchschreiber und Traditionen irreführender Wissenschaftlichkeit homogenisiert und vereinfacht worden.[1] Um Marx zu verstehen, ist es erst einmal notwendig zu wissen, wie er dachte und wie er gesellschaftliche Zustände analysierte, als genau das zu kennen, was er sagte. Damit meine ich ein Verständnis des überzeugenden dialektischen Schemas, das Marx in seiner Kritik von Fichte und Hegel entwickelt hat.[2] Lefèbvre war einer der sehr wenigen Analysten der Gesellschaft, der *wirklich* wusste, wie Marx dachte, und es ist bezeichnend, dass eines seiner ersten Bücher marxistische Dialektik behandelte war (Lefèbvre 1939).[3] Dieses Werk enthält viele der Themen, die Lefèbvre später weiterentwickeln sollte.

1974 veröffentlichte Lefèbvre ein monumentales Buch, *La production de l'espace*, das gerade als englische Übersetzung erschien (1991)[4] und das der Verleger als »sein philosophisches Hauptwerk« bezeichnet. Ich würde eher ein anderes Werk, sein dreiteiliges Buch *Critique de la vie qoutidienne*[5], (das erst jetzt übersetzt wird), als sein bedeutsamstes einstufen. Aber das Buch über den Raum muss ganz knapp dahinter eingeordnet werden. Außerdem hat Lefèbvre auch wichtige Beiträge zur Theorie des Staates (ein 4-bändiges Meisterwerk), zur Soziologie der Kunst, zum Poststrukturalismus, zum Existentialismus, zur wissenschaftlichen Forschung über Descartes, Pascal, Nietzsche (schon 1939), Lukacs und anderen Denkern und zur Theorie der Moderne/Postmoderne verfasst.[6] Was ich jedoch am meisten an Lefèbvre schätze, ist, die Art wie er seine Zeit verbrachte. Er schrieb nicht in der Isolation, sondern lebte das Leben eines Pariser Intellektuellen und nahm an lebendigen Debatten mit anderen über die das Wesen des Marxismus, über politische Aktion, die intellektuellen Grundlagen des Strukturalismus, Poststrukturalismus, der Postmoderne und (rückblickend) des Existenzialismus teil. Konsequenterweise nahm er auch die Mühe auf sich, die Bücher anderer zu lesen und einen Dialog in seinen Arbeiten anzustreben – eine Seltenheit unter amerikanischen Akademikern. Wenn man Lefèbvre liest, kann man alle Arten teilweise verborgener, manchmal expliziter Bezüge zu gegenwärtigen Ideen und Büchern im Pariser Milieu finden, die dem uninformierten Leser entgehen könnten.[7]

Ich begrüße das Erscheinen der Übersetzung von *La production de l'espace*[8], aber es ist nicht klar, wie es aufgenommen werden wird von den neuen Stadtgeographen und den Soziologen, die einen weniger ausdifferenzierten Anspruch haben, wie z.B. die Humanökologie oder die Ideen in dem vielveröffentlichten Buch von Logan und Molotch (1987). Sowohl Manuel Castells als auch David Harvey, die oft von Stadttheoretikern als die Vordenker des neuen Urbanismus bezeichnet wurden, stehen bei Lefèbvre in einer großen verkannten Schuld. Der Letztere verdient, indem er seit 1968 eine Serie von sechs Bücher zum Urbanismus geschrieben hat, den Titel eines Vorläufern. Am wichtigsten ist aber, dass sowohl Castells als auch Harvey einige Ideen Lefèbvres weiterentwickelt haben, die vor dem gipfelnden Werk über Raum von 1974 erschienen, und die so noch keinen Nutzen aus den verfeinerten und vervollständigten Argumenten ziehen konnten.[9]

In *Le matérialisme dialectique* (1939)[10] analysierte Lefèbvre marxistische politische Ökonomie zu einem Zeitpunkt, als er mit dem Stalinismus und der Kommunistischen Partei brach. Zweifellos reagierte er auf Dogmatismus und Orthodoxie (eben so wie auf Stalins Politik) und seine Reaktion spiegelte sich in einer kritischen Lesart von Marx' *Das Kapital* wieder. Lefèbvre merkte an, dass dieses Werk im wesentlichen von der Zeit handelte – das Erzielen und die Zirkulation des Mehrwerts. Lefèbvre glaubte, dass die marxistische politische Ökonomie den materiellen Aspekt der Produktion vernachlässigte: Die Welt der Waren existierte im Raum ebenso wie in der Zeit. 1939 verkündete er, dass die Dialektik ebenso räumlich wie zeitlich wäre und dass diese Erkenntnis Marx' System in ein neues Licht setze. Lefèbvre stieß buchstäblich in die materielle Dimension der Dialektiken vor. Seiner Ansicht nach resultierte die Produktionstätigkeit des Kapitalismus in einem Raum – also in einer Materialität. Darüber hinaus besitzt dieser »Raum« sein eigenes dialektisches Moment. Wie andere Kategorien marxistischer Denkweise – Geld, Arbeitskraft – war er eine *konkrete Abstraktion*. Das bedeutet, der Raum war sowohl ein materielles Produkt der gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse (das Konkrete) als auch eine Manifestation der Verhältnisse, selbst ein Verhältnis (das Abstrakte). Er war somit ebenso Teil der gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse, wie es die Zeit war. Kurz gesagt, indem er marxistisches Denken auf Marx anwandte, gelangte Lefèbvre zu Einsichten, die die marxistische politische Ökonomie überschritten und die von den Dogmen weg führten. Er brauchte die nächsten 30 Jahre, um die Folgerungen aus diesen frühen Entdeckungen auszuarbeiten.

La production de l'espace ist ein komplexes Werk, zugleich historisch, philosophisch, semiotisch und marxi-

stisch. Es wurde zu einer Zeit geschrieben, als Althusserianismus sowie Dekonstruktivismus vorherrschend waren und es finden sich dort viele Anmerkungen zu Theoretikern, die diesen Überzeugungen anhingen. Es ist ebenso ein ausgereiftes Werk, in dem Lefèbvres Beherrschung seines dialektischen Denkens geradezu meisterhaft ist. In der Dialektik Fichtes und in vielen dekonstruktivistischen oder strukturalistischen Denkansätzen werden analytische Kategorien als Oppositionen oder Antinome wahrgenommen. Lefèbvre will mit dieser Manischeischen Sicht nichts zu tun haben, denn sie endet üblicherweise in statischen Gegensätzen. Marx' dialektische Momente waren fließend, vielfältig und komplex, besonders in Hinblick auf »die Negation«, ein Konzept, von dem ich glaube, dass es nur Adorno und Lefèbvre wirklich verstanden haben. Nach Lefèbvre werden dialektische Momente als »Triplizität« – mit drei Begriffen und nicht mit zwei – ausgedrückt. Der dritte Begriff dekonstruiert unmittelbar statische Gegensätze oder Dualismen und fügt dem gesellschaftlichen Prozess eine fließende Dimension hinzu.[11]

Das wichtigste »Triple« bezieht sich darauf, die Wichtigkeit des Raumes gemäß seiner Manifestationen als *erfahrenen, erdacht* und *gelebt* (perceived, conceived and lived) zu erfassen. Seit seinem frühen Bruch mit dem orthodoxem Marxismus war Lefèbvre stets bemüht, jeden reduktionistischen Ökonomismus zu vermeiden. Diese »Dreiheit« soll vermitteln, dass Raum einen komplexen Charakter hat und in die gesellschaftlichen Beziehungen auf allen Ebenen eindringt. Er ist zugleich eine physische Umgebung, die wahrgenommen werden kann; eine semiotische Abstraktion, die sowohl darüber Auskunft gibt, wie gewöhnliche Leute den Raum bewältigen (die von den Geographen studierten mental maps), als auch über den Raum der Konzerne, Planer, Politiker und dergleichen und schließlich ein Medium, durch welches der Körper in Interaktion mit anderen Körpern sein Leben (aus-)lebt. Soziale Beziehungen sind ebenso räumliche Beziehungen; wir können nicht über das eine ohne das andere sprechen.[12]

Indem er mit dieser dreifachen Relation arbeitet, versucht Lefèbvre Reduktionismus zu vermeiden, sei er ökonomischer (marxistischer) oder idealistischer (dekontruktivistischer) Art. Er schlägt eine umfassende Theorie des Raumes vor, die das Physische, das Mentale und das Soziale zusammenbindet. Indem er diesen verallgemeinerten Zugang zum Raum noch weiter entwickelt, führt Lefèbvre ein zweites »Triple« ein, das das erste verstärkt. Raum ist gleichzeitig eine räumliche Praxis (eine externalisierte, materielle Umwelt), eine Repräsentation des Raumes (ein konzeptuelles Modell, das eingesetzt wird, um Handlungen zu steuern) und ein Raum der Repräsentation (die gelebte soziale Beziehung der Benutzer zu ihrer Umwelt.)

Am Anfang des Buches wendet Lefèbvre hauptsächlich seine dreifache Unterscheidung auf die Analyse unterschiedlicher Lebensräume an. Seine Herangehensweise verbindet geographische, historische und semiotische Analyse und vermeidet so Reduktionismus. Er konzentriert sich darauf, wie verschiedene Gesellschaften über die Zeit dem Raum sowohl Form als auch Bedeutung gegeben haben. Lefèbvre vollendet diese Aufgabe, indem er den Unterschied zwischen abstraktem Raum und sozialem Raum berücksichtigt. Abstrakter Raum wird durch die Überschneidung von Wissen und Macht konstituiert. Er ist der hierarchische Raum, der denen dient, die die Organisation der Gesellschaft kontrollieren wollen, wie den politischen Herrschern, den ökonomischen Interessen und den Planern. Gesellschaftlicher Raum entsteht im Gegensatz dazu aus der Praxis – die alltäglich gelebte Erfahrung, die sich durch Handlungen aller Mitglieder der Gesellschaft, sogar der Herrschenden, veräußerlicht und materialisiert. Personen, die vom Modell des abstrakten Raumes ausgehen, versuchen fortwährend über den sozialen Raum des alltäglichen Lebens mit seinen beständigen Veränderungen zu herrschen und ihn zu kontrollieren, während sozialer Raum jedoch immer erdachte Grenzen und geregelte Formen überschreitet.

Letztlich beinhalten abstrakter und gesellschaftlicher Raum beide die Dreiheit: Wahrnehmung gebauter Formen, gedankliche Vorstellung und gesellschaftliche Praxis. Im besonderen geht die Vorstellung von Raum immer der räumlichen Praxis der Menschen voraus; das bedeutet, dass gedanklicher Entwurf oder das semiotisches Modell des Raumes und die physische Beschaffenheit oder Veräußerlichung miteinander in Beziehung stehen. Lefèbvre führt den Leser unter Einsatz dieser Konzepte durch die westeuropäische Geschichte und versucht zu zeigen, wie bestimmte isolierte Veränderungen im dreifachen Zusammentreffen des Raumes tatsächlich qualitative historische Bewegungen mit sich brachten. Der griechische Raum beispielsweise wird von einer kosmischen, abstrakten Auffassung von Religion und Geometrie bestimmt. Rom hingegen wird befleckt von der Ausübung der Macht; der Raum wird von den Menschen selbst errichtet. Somit, sagt Lefèbvre, ist die griechische Agora (ein abstrakter Raum) leer und einheitlich nach dem goldenen Schnitt proportioniert, so dass sich die Griechen dort treffen und in der Einheit mit dem Kosmos tun können, was sie wollen. »Das römische Forum andererseits ist voll von Objekten« (1991, Seite 275).

Diesem Teil der Textes, in dem Lefèbvre seine Vorgehensweise auf Geschichte anwendet, fehlt das strenge vergleichende Verständnis von Max Weber oder Ferdinand Braundel; noch reicht er an die Art und Weise heran, in der einige zeitgenössische Geographen eine historische Analyse des Raums vornehmen würden. Und er scheint etwas diffus und unsystematisch als semiotische Analyse, verglichen mit den jüngeren Ansätzen, einen semiotischen Zugang zu Raum zu definieren.[13] Zu seinen Gunsten deutet Lefèbvre nie an, dass es so etwas wie ein »evolutionäres« Prinzip gäbe, das die Beziehung

des Menschen zum Raum verändere, sondern nur, dass diese Beziehung sich gemäß den Unterschieden gesellschaftlicher Organisation verändert. Insgesamt liegt daher sein Beitrag in der ausgeglichenen, integrierten Analyse, die Semiotik, politische Verhältnisse und ökonomische Verhältnisse miteinander verbindet, als vielmehr einzig und allein, die Tiefe der historischen Analyse auszuloten.

Im späteren Teil des Buches, beginnend mit Kapitel 5, wendet sich Lefèbvre dem Kapitalismus und der fortentwickelten industriellen Gesellschaft zu. Und hier brilliert seine Arbeit. Er führt in sein zentrales theoretisches Konzept »Die Produktion des Raumes« ein. Jede Art der gesellschaftlichen Organisation produziert eine Umwelt, die eine Folge der gesellschaftlichen Verhältnisse ist, die ihr eigen sind. Zusätzlich materialisiert sich eine Gesellschaft nicht nur in distinkten baulichen Formen, indem sie einen Raum gemäß ihrer eigenen Natur produziert, sondern reproduziert sich auf diese Weise auch selbst. Das Konzept der »Produktion des Raumes« meint das, was Giddens die »Dualität der Struktur« nennt.[14] Das heißt, Raum ist zugleich Medium gesellschaftlicher Verhältnisse und materielles Produkt, das gesellschaftliche Verhältnisse beeinflussen kann. Diese dialektische Vorstellung ist ein Grundsatz der »New Urban Sociology«

Im Kapitalismus schließt die Produktion des Raumes die Fragmentierung und Homogenisierung des Raumes mit ein, so wie es bei anderen Waren »unter dem Gesetz des Reproduzierbarkeit und der Wiederholung« (1991, S. 375) der Fall ist. Kein Wunder, dass die neuen Vorstädte überall gleich aussehen. Lefèbvre wendet seinen Ansatz auf die marxistische politische Ökonomie an und erreicht an diesem Punkt den Kern seiner Theorie. »Alle marxistischen Konzepte werden auf ein höheres Niveau gebracht, ohne dass eine einzige Ebene der Theorie dabei verloren geht.« (S. 342) Indem wir Raum Wert beimessen, ihn explizit in Betracht ziehen, überschreiten wir die marxistische politische Ökonomie ohne den kritischen Zugang zum Kapitalismus, wie ihn Marx einführte, aufzugeben.

Lefèbvre beispielsweise geht zurück zu dem Marx des *Kapitals* und erinnert uns an einen entscheidenden Punkt: Dieses Buch war nur ein Teil eines größeren Projekts (vgl. *Grundrisse*).[15] Marx Analyse des Kapitalismus gründete rein theoretisch auf dem Gegensatz von abstrakter Arbeit und Kapital, gemäß eines »binären« dialektischen Schemas, das solche Oppositionen wie Lohn-Profit, Arbeiter-Kapitalist und so weiter beinhaltete. Trotzdem war in den historischen Bedingungen der Entfaltung des Kapitalismus ein drittes Element, der Boden, genauso vorhanden und unterstützte eine eigene Klasse in den *frühen* Phasen des Wachstums. Marx führt letztendlich diesen dritten Begriff am Ende von *Das Kapital* ein und nennt seine Beziehung zu den anderen Grundeinheiten der Gesellschaft die »Trinitarische Formel«. Lefèbvre schätzt diese Bezeichnung der Trinität, weil sie mit seiner Dialektik in Einklang steht und er bemächtigt sich ihrer als Möglichkeit Marx' politische Ökonomie aufzuwerten.

Nach Lefèbvre bilden Boden und seine fortgeschritten kapitalistischen Produktionsverhältnisse, die er »Grundeigentum« nennt, einen zweiten Kapitalkreislauf, und das obwohl eine eigene Klasse von Grundbesitzern nicht länger existiert. Das bedeutet, die Kapitalflüsse, der Wohnungsbau, die Raumentwicklung, die Finanzierung und die Bodenspekulation bilden eine zweite Möglichkeit Reichtum zu erreichen, die relativ unabhängig von dem »ersten« Kreislauf, der industriellen Produktion, ist. Darüber hinaus zeigt Lefèbvre in einer ausgedehnten Erörterung, dass dieser zweite Kreislauf eine der fundamentalen Kräfte der Gesellschaft und eine Quelle der Mehrwertschaffung ist. Schließlich argumentiert er überzeugend, dass dieser eine eigene Logik hat, obwohl er auf den ersten Kreislauf bezogen ist. Kurz, die marxistische Analyse des Kapitalismus wird durch das Einbeziehen des Raumes nie wieder dieselbe sein.[16] Darüber hinaus wurden diese Konzepte von Lefèbvre die Basis für die »New Urban Sociology«, die ihren Einfluss in diesem Bereich immer weiter ausdehnt.

Immer, wenn ich Lefèbvre lese, erinnere ich mich an Barthes' Ausdruck »Vergnügen des Texts«, denn es ist eine Freude, ihn zu lesen. In einer virtuosen Entfaltung des dialektischen Denkens zum Beispiel erörtert er, wie der Vormarsch der kapitalistischen Industrialisierung sich überall über den abstrakten Raum, den *quantifizierten* Raum, legt. Der *qualitative* Aspekt des Raumes jedoch kann in diese Bewegung nicht vollständig integriert werden. »Er taucht wieder auf, wenn die 'Räume des Konsums' zum 'Konsum von Raum' werden.«(1991 S. 352) Wann findet das statt? Im Tourismus zum Beispiel »wenn Menschen qualitativen Raum – Sonne, Schnee, das Meer – suchen. (1991 , S. 352); wenn der Kapitalismus den Kreislauf der Waren für Menschen in einen Kreislauf der Menschen durch warenförmige Orte transformiert.

An anderer Stelle in diesem Text trifft Lefèbvres Dialektik den Kern einer wichtigen Angelegenheit und zeigt Erkenntnisse auf, die den engen Blickwinkel der politischen Ökonomie überschreiten. In der Vergangenheit, so stellt er dar, waren die Waren selbst knapp, aber die Ressourcen reichlich vorhanden. Die Politische Ökonomie gründete auf Askese – auf der Notwendigkeit, unter Bedingungen der Knappheit eine Auswahl zu treffen. Im Gegensatz dazu gibt es heute einen Überfluss an Waren, aber unsere natürlichen Ressourcen werden langsam knapp. »Diese dialektische Bewegung wurde nie als solche analysiert – das Augenmerk auf Verschmutzung, Umwelt, Lärm und Erschöpfung der Ressourcen verbirgt sie.« (1991, S. 376) Durch diese Erkenntnis wird das Buch zu einem bedeutsamen Werk für die Umweltbewegung. Nach Lefèbvre sind die individuellen Aspekte des Verfalls der Umwelt, wie rassistische, ökonomische oder

chemische Aspekte, nicht von zentraler Bedeutung. Wir müssen uns eher auf die Produktion des Raumes konzentrieren. In diesem Fall hat die kapitalistische Industrialisierung die Natur zerstört und ersetzt diese mit einer »zweiten Natur«. Das Gleichgewicht zwischen organischer und menschlicher Umwelt verschwindet auf dem ganzen Globus aufgrund der Produktion und Ausweitung einer zweiten Natur – die konkrete, materielle Welt der organisierten Gesellschaft. (1991, S. 343-45) Das ist der Kern des Problems.

Zum Schluss leistet Lefèbvre einen brillanten Beitrag zum Verständnis des Staates. Seine Denkweise ist besonders brauchbar, wenn er die Beziehungen zwischen Macht und Raum analysiert, eine Eigenschaft, die unter anderem von den »New Urban Geographers« völlig übersehen wird. Der Raum ist nicht nur homogenisiert und fragmentiert sondern auch hierarchisch und Grundlage der Macht. Lefèbvres Erörterung der Beziehung zwischen Staat und Raum ist inspirierend. Jetzt, da die Arbeit in der Übersetzung vorliegt, frage ich mich, ob, oder wie bald, es die Studien über Staat, speziell die historische Rolle staatlicher Regulierung mit räumlichen Mitteln beeinflussen wird.

Lefèbvre wäre kein kritischer Theoretiker, wenn er uns nicht mit einer befreienden Position zurücklassen würde, die wir uns nach seiner weitgreifenden philosophischen Diskussion zu eigen machen können. Gesellschaftliche Veränderung kann nach Lefèbvre nicht auf organisierte Weise stattfinden, ohne die Produktion eines veränderten Raumes. Wie er darstellt, scheiterte die russische Revolution genau dann, als das Vorhaben einen neuen revolutionären Raum zu schaffen, wie es in der Arbeit der russischen Konstruktivisten angelegt war, ebenfalls scheiterte. Das Leben zu verändern bedeutet genauso den Raum zu verändern. Vor dem Erscheinen dieses Buches drückte Lefèbvre diesen Gedanken als »Recht auf Stadt« aus; zusammen mit andern Aspekten seines Denkens hatte es einen großen Einfluss auf die Studenten in Frankreich während der Ereignisse im Mai 1968. Lefèbvre glaubt, dass die Transformation gesellschaftlicher Verhältnisse eine Veränderung sozialräumlicher Verhältnisse und die Produktion eines neuen, befreienden Raumes bedeutet.

Zum Abschluss möchte ich noch einige Anmerkungen zu der Übersetzung von Daniel Nicholson-Smith machen. Insgesamt hat er eine meisterhafte Leistung erbracht. Stellenweise hat er sogar die Zitate deutlicher gemacht. Der Übersetzer war sehr bedacht, die Intention von Lefèbvres Ideen zu bewahren. Wenn er zum Beispiel die Veränderungen der römischen Gesellschaft beschreibt, verwendet Lefèbvre eine Opposition – »crypt/decrypt« – um bestimmte Entwicklungen in der Beziehung zum Raum zu erläutern. Es gibt kein englisches Wort »decrypt«; dennoch hat es der Übersetzer bewahrt, um der wörtlichen Bedeutung von Lefèbvres Analyse zu folgen.

Wie in allen Übersetzungen gehen jedoch einige Aspekte des Originals verloren. Nicholson-Smith neigt zu komplizierten Synonymen. Eines der Vergnügen Lefèbvre zu lesen liegt jedoch in der Anerkennung seines exquisiten Gebrauchs der Sprache; er sagt die Dinge direkt und klar, aber nicht vereinfachend. Etwas von seinem wundervollen Gebrauch der Worte ist verloren. Außerdem hat Lefèbvre eine Neigung für Wortspiele und ich fürchte, der Übersetzer übersah diese. Schließlich enthält die Ausgabe von Blackwell Publishers ein Nachwort von David Harvey. Wenn man bedenkt, wie wenig der Einfluss Lefèbvres in der Vergangenheit anerkannt wurde, finde ich diese Einbindung von Harvey in das Projekt zugleich ironisch und ganz einfach ein weiteres Beispiel der Aneignung.

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The Social Production of Urban Space. Austin University of Texas Press, 1985.
The New Urban Sociology. New York: McGraw-Hill, 1994.
The Theming of America. Boulder Westview Press, 2001.
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Karl Marx: *The Grundrisse*, New York, Vintage, (1939) 1973

1 Hier meine ich nicht nur die schlichten Einführungstexte, die sich fast ausschließlich auf das Konzept der Klasse und auf Marx' »evolutionäre« Theorie der Geschichte konzentrieren, sondern auch die irreführenden und recht begrenzten Variationen über »conflict theory«, die Konflikt, ein nicht näher bestimmtes, natürlich stattfindendes Phänomen, in der marxistischen Geschichtsanalyse als den phänomenologische Kern positionieren.

2 Einige Soziologen glauben, dass die Dialektik These, Antithese und Synthese umfasst. Tatsächlich bezieht sich dieses Denken auf Fichte und hat nichts mit der marxistischen Dialektik zu tun. Marx' Anspruch stammt von Hegels Vorstellung des Phänomens, der Negation und der Negation der Negation, aber er versteht diese Bewegung in bezug auf beides: die ontologische Position, dass alle Phänomene eine Basis in der materiellen Welt haben und die epistemologische Position, dass Bewegung quer durch das dialektische Moment durch die Beziehung zwischen der Tiefenstruktur und der Oberfläche verstanden wird; diese Position wird auch von realistischen Theoretikern übernommen. (Bhaskar 1979)

3 Lefèbvre veröffentlichte 66 Bücher. Er begann im Alter von 30 und veröffentlichte einige seiner allerbesten Schriften, 25 Bücher, nach dem Erreichen des Alters von 65!

4 Henri Lefèbvre, *The Production of Space,* Oxford & Cambridge, 1991 (A.d.Ü)

5 Henri Lefébvre, *Critique de la vie qoutidienne I: Introduction.* Paris 1947, *Critique de la vie qoutidienne II: Fondement d'une sociologie de la quotidienneté.* Paris 1962, *Critique de la vie qoutidienne III: De la meodernité aua modernisme.* Paris 1985 (A.d.Ü.)

6 Eine komplette Bibliographie erscheint am Ende von *Production of Space* ([1974] 1991)

7 Meine Lieblings-Anmerkung erschien in *The Survival of Capitalism* ([1973] 1974), wo Lefèbvre seine Antwort auf Althussers gewichtiges Schema wie folgt zusammenfasste: »Wenn Du es verstehen kannst – herzlichen Glückwunsch«

8 Mein Buch *The Social Production of Urban Space* (1985) war direkt von Lefèbvre inspiriert. Es ist in dessem Geiste ein kritischer Kommentar zu den Schriften anderer, wie Castells and Harvey, hinsichtlich ihres Reduktionismus und ihrer Leugnung des Konzeptes »Raum«, das gleichzeitig semiotisch, politisch und ökonomisch ist.

9 Ich möchte die Positionen im Folgenden knapp zusammenfassen: Harvey benutzte die Schriften Lefèbvres, die in den späten 1960er Jahren erschienen, bevor Lefèbvre einen ausdifferenzierteren Begriff des »Raums« entwickelte, und leistete einen Beitrag, indem er systematisch die Kategorien der politischen Ökonomie auf urbane Phänomene anwandte. Aber darin liegt eben auch Harveys ökonomischer Reduktionismus. Castells schrieb eine Kritik von Lefèbvres Schriften der 60er Jahre, unter Verwendung Althusserianischem Strukturalismus und stellte eine Annäherung an städtische soziale Bewegungen vor, die verständlicher war als die von Lefèbvre. Seit damals jedoch hatte keine Arbeit Castells mehr viel mit »Raum« zu tun und kürzlich verfiel er in einen technologischen Reduktionismus. Um zusammenzufassen: Nur indem wir Lefèbvres Projekt gerecht werden, vermeiden wir, wie im Buch über Raum umrissen, alle Formen des Reduktionismus in der Analyse städtischer Phänomene. (siehe Gottdiener 1985; Gottdiener und Lagopoulos 1986)

10 *Dialectical Materialism*. London 1968 / *Der dialektische Materialismus*, Frankfurt 1970 (A.d.Ü.)

11 Vor einigen Jahren beispielsweise diskutierten einige Theoretiker die »micro/macro« Spaltung in der Gesellschaftsanalyse. Dieses einfache Schema kann durch die Hinzufügung eines dritten Begriffes, wie die »meso« Ebene der Gesellschaft unmittelbar dekonstruiert werden und so eine größere Komplexität erreichen.

12 Diese Einsicht wurde neben anderen auch von Giddens und Jameson übernommen.

13 Lefèbvres Buch ist erfüllt von einer Semiotik des Urbanen. Er erwähnt beispielsweise nebenbei die Arbeit von Lagopoulos (vgl. Gottdiener und Lagopoulos 1986)

14 Giddens benutzt dieses Konzept in seinen Schriften, aber scheint sich nicht bewusst zu sein, dass Lefèbvre es entwickelt hat.

15 Wie marxistische Gelehrte wissen, sind *Grundrisse* (Marx 1939) und nicht *Das Kapital*, das umfassende Werk. Es ist ebenso der beste Text, um Marx' Beherrschung der Dialektik zu beobachten.

16 Diese Ideen sind bereits in die Praxis umgesetzt. Harvey benutzte das Kreislaufmodell des Kapitalismus mit starkem Einfluss auf Geographen, obwohl er es zusammengesetzt und verändert hat. Einige Stadttheoretiker, wie Logon und Molotch (1987) schlagen irreführend vor, dass eine eigene Klasse der Grundeigentümer immer noch existiert, und folglich leidet darunter auch ihre Analyse. Gottdiener (1985, 1987) hat Lefèbvres politische Ökonomie des Raums ausgearbeitet. Viele andere Urbanisten und in jüngerer Zeit postmoderne Gelehrte, haben die Anwesenheit einer relativ autonomen räumlichen Ebene in ihre Analyse aufgenommen. Jameson beispielsweise, der sehr viel über den Raum und dessen Wichtigkeit für das postmoderne Denken spricht, war stark von Lefèbvre beeinflusst. Feagin (1988) hat eine brillante Analyse über Houston verfasst, indem er diese Perspektive verwendete. Ein neues Lehrbuch über die Soziologie des Urbanen wird demnächst veröffentlicht werden. (Gottdiener, erscheint demächst) (The New Urban Sociology. New York: McGraw-Hill,1994A.d.Ü.)

Stuart Elden
»Es gibt eine Politik des Raumes, weil Raum politisch ist.«
Henri Lefèbvre und die Produktion des Raumes

Einleitung

Der marxistische französische Philosoph Henri Lefèbvre (1901-1991) wurde in den 1930er Jahren durch die erste Übersetzung von Marx' *Ökonomisch-philosophischen Manuskripten* von 1844 bekannt. Seine ersten bedeutenden Arbeiten, wie *La conscience mystifiée* und *Le matérialisme dialectique* wurden bereits in den 1930er Jahren veröffentlicht. Er setzte seine Arbeit bis zu seinem Tode fort und schrieb fast siebzig Bücher. Im Vergleich zu anderen marxistischen Theoretikern, Zeitgenossen Lefèbvres wie Sartre und Althusser, ist er verhältnismäßig unbekannt. Eine seiner bedeutendsten Arbeiten ist die Studie *La production de l'espace* von 1974, die vor kurzem in Frankreich wiederaufgelegt wurde[1]. Verständlicherweise findet ein Großteil der Lefèbvre-Rezeption in Bereichen wie Geographie und Urban Studies statt, während die Rezeption im Bereich der Politikwissenschaft und Philosophie eher ausgeblieben ist. Lefèbvres Arbeiten können jedoch auch den politischen Theoretiker mit brauchbaren konzeptuellen Werkzeugen ausstatten, um die Räumlichkeit von Politik und Geschichte zu kartieren, anstatt einfach die Politik und Geschichte von Raum zu erklären.

Eine genaue Einordnung von Lefèbvres Arbeit ist aufgrund der begrenzten Länge dieses Artikel ausgeschlossen, einige wichtige Punkte sollten jedoch bedacht werden. Zum einen war Lefèbvre immer an der Beziehung zwischen Hegel und Marx interessiert und dadurch an Idealismus und Materialismus. Anstatt Materie als die Verkörperung gedanklicher Konstrukte zu verstehen oder Geist als die Reaktion auf Materie, betrachtet Lefèbvre Geistiges und Materielles im Zusammenhang. Diese Verschmelzung der Ideen des Idealismus und des Materialismus ermöglicht eine *idealistische und materialistische* Betrachtungsweise von Leben und gelebter Erfahrung[2]. Zum anderen verstand Lefèbvre Marx' Werk als bedeutsam, genauer gesagt als wesentlich für ein Verständnis unserer Zeit, aber nicht als etwas, das für sich stehen kann. Aus diesem Grund - und weil er die Bedeutung Hegels erkannte - integrierte er die Einsichten anderer Denker, vor allem Heidegger und Nietzsche, in seine Schriften. Dieser Einfluss wird in seinen Arbeiten über Raum deutlich und in dem, was Lefèbvre seine bekannteste Konzeption nannte, die Kritik des Alltagslebens[3]. Lefèbvre war einer der Ersten, der Marx als einen Theoretiker der Entfremdung begriff, und der *im Gegensatz zu* Althusser die Kontinuität von dessen Früh- zu Spätwerk betonte. Lefèbvres Konzept des Alltagslebens greift eindeutig Marx' Gedanken der Entfremdung auf. Allerdings geht es über das Ökonomische hinaus und wird in Bezug zu Heideggers Verständnis von *Alltäglichkeit* gesetzt[4].

Das Ländliche, das Städtische und das Globale

Lefèbvres Theorie des Alltagslebens wurde sinnvollerweise zwischen den beiden Hauptströmungen der französischen Nachkriegstheorie eingeordnet[5]: Im Gegensatz zu der Umklammerung der Phänomenologie, oder der Verleugnung von Erfahrung, die sich im Strukturalismus offenbart, möchte Lefèbvre zeigen, wie die Strukturen, die Zeichen und Codes des Alltags mit dem Leben des Einzelnen verbunden sind. Lefèbvre verwendet diesen Gedanken in seinen Arbeiten zur Soziologie des Städtischen und des Ländlichen, welche er in unzähligen Studien entwickelte[6]. Sein Verständnis von Raum hat Lefèbvre in *La survie du capitalisme* weiterentwickelt, wo er darlegt, dass die Umgestaltung der globalen räumlichen Ökonomie eine entscheidende historische Entwicklung darstellt. In seinen ersten Überlegungen über das praktische Verständnis von Raum durchspielt Lefèbvre Themen, die später ihre theoretische Ausarbeitung in La production de l'espace finden werden.

Die Beziehung zwischen Stadt und Land ist für Lefèbvre ein historisches Verhältnis, in dem Industrialisierung und technischer Fortschritt die vermittelnde Rolle spielen. Die industrielle Gesellschaft, so Lefèbvre, ist von der verstädterten Gesellschaft verdrängt worden. Diese Entwicklung stand zu Marx' Zeit in ihren Anfängen und so ist es verständlich, dass dieser noch nicht wahrnehmen konnte, »dass die Produktion der Stadt das Ende, das Ziel und die Bedeutung der *industriellen Produktion* war«[7]. 1968 schreibt Lefèbvre dagegen: »Das große Ereignis der letzten paar Jahre ist, dass die Auswirkungen der Industrialisierung auf eine oberflächlich umgewandelte kapitalistische Gesellschaft der Produktion und des Eigentums nun ihre Ergebnisse hervorgebracht haben: ein programmiertes *Alltagsleben* an den entsprechenden *urbanen Schauplätzen*. Solch ein Prozess wurde durch die Auflösung der traditionellen Stadt und durch die Ausbreitung des Urbanen begünstigt«[8]. Was auf diese Weise hergestellt wird und demnach untersucht werden muss, ist eine urbane Umwelt. Lefèbvre schlägt vor, dass dieser Ausdruck besser geeignet ist als »technologische Umwelt«, »da Technologie nur in der Stadt und durch die Stadt eine 'Umwelt' herstellt; Technologie außerhalb der Stadt allerdings ausschließlich isolierte Objekte produziert: eine Rakete, eine Radarstation«[9]. Diese Annahme kann in Frage gestellt werden, da es selbstverständlich erscheint, dass der Fortschritt der Technik, zum Beispiel im Bereich der Landwirtschaft, das »Ländliche« ebenso geformt hat, wie parallele Ent-

wicklungen das Urbane. Außerdem sollte nicht vergessen werden, dass die Umwelt offensichtlich durch staatliche Planungen direkt beeinflusst wird. Dies ist eine weitere Entwicklung der jüngsten Zeit. Der Staat, so Lefèbvres Kommentar, »ist aktiv in Wohnungsbau, Stadtplanung und Urbanisierung involviert. 'Urbanismus' ist gleichzeitig Teil der Ideologie und Teil der möchte-gern vernünftigen Vorgehensweise des Staats«[10].

Diese Auffassung der Verschiebung vom Ländlichen zum Urbanen - sowohl in seiner eigenen Arbeit als auch in historischer Sicht - ermöglicht es Lefèbvre, den nahe liegenden Vorwürfen zu entkommen, dass es in der kontinentalen Theorie insgesamt ein starken Hang zum Urbanen gibt. Margaret Fitzsimmons kritisiert Marx und Weber scharf in diesem Punkt, und sieht diese Tendenz in jüngeren Arbeiten von Althusser, Foucault, Derrida und Lacan fortgesetzt. Nur Lefèbvre entgeht ihrem vernichtenden Urteil von »dieser fixen Idee *des urbanen Lebens / la vie urbaine, des Pariser Leben / la vie parisienne* als der einzigen zivilisierten Äußerung *des Alltagslebens / la vie quotidienne*«[11]. Lefèbvres Ansatz, das Ländliche und das Städtische zusammen statt isoliert zu denken, ist eines seiner Schlüsselkonzepte: Die Überbetonung des Urbanen ist einer seiner Kritikpunkte an den Situationisten[12], während er andererseits die Vernachlässigung von Problemen der Urbanisierung bei Marcuse als einen Fehler betrachtet.[13]

Wichtige Leseweisen urbaner und ländlicher Landschaften können in Lefèbvres gesamtem Werk gefunden werden. Der ersten Band von *Critique de la vie quotidienne* enthält zum Beispiel das Kapitel »Notizen, geschrieben eines Sonntags auf dem Land in Frankreich«, in dem Lefèbvre ein gewöhnliches französisches Dorf beispielhaft analysiert. Besonders seine Auseinandersetzung mit der Dorfkirche zeigt deutliche Parallelen zu Nietzsches Beobachtungen zu diesem Thema[14]. Lefèbvre erkennt zweifellos die Macht der Symbole in der Kirche - »Für mich kann dieser Raum niemals wie ein anderer Raum sein.« - und es ist bereits in diesem ersten Entwurf ersichtlich, dass er sich Nietzsches Verständnis von der Macht des Raumes angeeignet hat: »Schlösser, Paläste, Kathedralen, Burgen, alle sprechen auf unterschiedliche Art von der Größe und Stärke der Menschen, die sie gebaut haben und gegen die sie gebaut wurden.«[15] Gleichermaßen überzeugend ist diese Lesart des Raumes in einer 15 Jahre später geschriebenen Studie, in welcher er das Dorf, in dem er lebt, mit einer neuen Stadt, die ein paar Kilometer entfernt liegt, vergleicht. Für Lefèbvre stellt die Stadt in vieler Hinsicht eine *geplante*, keine natürliche Entwicklung dar.[16] Lefèbvres Begriff des Alltagslebens legt nahe, dass Kapitalismus, der schon immer das Arbeitsleben strukturiert hat, diese Kontrolle nun auch in großem Maße über das private Leben, die Freizeit ausgeweitet hat. Häufig geschieht dies durch die Organisation des Raums.

»Die *neuen Vorstädte* sind das sichtbare und bezeichnende Phänomen in der und anhand derer diese Strukturierung *gelesen* werden kann, denn hier ist sie auch *geschrieben* worden. Was wurde, abgesehen von Eigenschaften wie der Negation traditioneller Städte, der Segregation und verstärkter polizeilicher Überwachung, in diesen gesellschaftlichen Text eingeschrieben, um von denen entziffert zu werden, die den Code kennen. Was also wurde auf diese Fläche projiziert? Alltagsleben - organisiert, sorgfältig unterteilt und so programmiert, dass es in einen kontrollierten genauen Stundenplan passt.«[17]

Die Produktion des Raumes

In den letzten Jahren hat sich eine deutliche Verschiebung von Aspekten der Zeitlichkeit hin zu solchen der Räumlichkeit abgezeichnet. So stellte Frederic Jameson die Frage, »warum Landschaft in irgendeiner Weise weniger dramatisch sein soll als das Ereignis?«[18] Lefèbvre legt in seinen Schriften nahe, dass ebenso wie das Alltagsleben auch dessen Ort - der soziale Raum - der kapitalistischen Ordnung unterworfen wurde.[19] Es ist deshalb wichtig, Analysen des Raumes zu erarbeiten, und zu verstehen, wie dieser gesellschaftlich geschaffen und genutzt wird. Vergegenwärtigt man sich, dass der Raum in der Moderne an Bedeutung gewonnen hat, so erscheint dies in besonderem Maße notwendig. Lefèbvre weist darauf hin, dass es früher einen Mangel an Brot, jedoch nie einen Mangel an Raum gab, während es nun (zumindest in den entwickelten Ländern) genügend Getreide gibt, aber das Angebot an Raum knapp ist: »Die Überbevölkerung von hoch entwickelter Industriestaaten drückt sich besonders deutlich in den größeren Städten aus.«[20] Gesellschaftlicher Raum wird je nach Klasse zugeteilt und die gesellschaftliche Planung reproduziert die Klassenstruktur. Dies spielt sich entweder auf der Basis von zu viel Raum für die Reichen und zu wenig für die Armen ab, oder aufgrund der ungleichen Entwicklung der Qualität von Orten, oder tatsächlich in beider Hinsicht. Die politische Ökonomie des Raumes basiert, wie jede Ökonomie, auf der Strategie der Verknappung.[21] »Heute ist der Klassenkampf mehr denn je in den Raum eingeschrieben.«[22]

Ebenfalls von zentraler Bedeutung sind die Konzepte der Marginalisierung und Regionalisierung. Diese sind Ausgangspunkte in Lefèbvres Aufruf für das Recht auf Stadt / Le droît à la Ville. Segregation und Diskriminierung darf die Menschen nicht aus dem urbanen Raum ausschließen.[23] Auch sind Raum und die Politik des Raumes nicht auf die Stadt begrenzt. Das Verhältnis von Zentrum und Peripherie ist auch anderenorts feststellbar: in unterentwickelten Ländern, auf dem Land und in marginalisierten Gebieten kapitalistischer Länder - Sizilien, Schottland, Baskenland - in Vorstädten und Ghettos, und an der gesellschaftlichen und politischen Peripherie, den Gegenden der »Verrückten«, Homosexuellen, Frauen, Jugendlichen, und DrogenbenutzerInnen. Verschiedene dieser ausgegrenzten Gruppen wurden von Foucault thematisiert, Lefèbvre kritisiert jedoch dessen Ansatz als »eine Ansammlung punktueller Betrachtungen, die räumlich und zeitlich von einander getrennt sind: Zentrum und Zentralität werden vernachlässigt, das Globale wird vernach-

lässigt.«[24] Lokale Analysen sind wichtig, jedoch darf das Gesamtbild nicht aus dem Auge verloren werden. Harvey beschreibt dies folgendermaßen: »Die gesamte Geschichte territorialer Organisation, des Kolonialismus und Imperialismus, der ungleichen Entwicklung und des Widerspruchs zwischen Stadt und Land, sowie geopolitische Konflikte bezeugen die Wichtigkeit dieser Kämpfe in der Geschichte des Kapitalismus.«[25] Einer der Gründe, warum es der Kapitalismus geschafft hat, bis ins zwanzigste Jahrhundert zu überleben, ist dessen Flexibilität in der Strukturierung und Restrukturierung von räumliche Beziehungen und der globalen Ökonomie des Raumes; also in der Konstituierung des Weltmarktes.[26] Lefèbvre vertritt die Meinung, dass Raum der grundlegende Ort und Vermittler dieser Kämpfe und als solcher ein entscheidendes politisches Thema ist: »Es gibt eine Politik des Raums, weil Raum politisch ist.«[27]

Viele Kommentatoren Lefèbvres haben darauf hingewiesen, dass Marxismus nicht gerade durch seine Aufmerksamkeit für Fragen des Raumes hervortritt. Edward Soja führt die Ansicht, dass Geschichte wichtig und Geographie eine »unnötige Verkomplizierung«[28] ist, auf Marx zurück, und Richard Peet weist darauf hin, dass »Marxismus wenig über das Verhältnis zur Natur zu sagen hat, und Ereignisse eher auf einer Nadelspitze stattfinden sieht als in einem räumlichen Zusammenhang.«[29] Die Fairness dieser Vorwürfe kann man anzweifeln, obwohl es sicherlich richtig ist, dass diese Untersuchungen bei Marx niemals höchste Aufmerksamkeit erlangten. Es sollte auch festgehalten werden, dass einige Marxisten, die es versäumt haben, eine Analyse von Raum durchzuführen, dennoch ausgiebigen Gebrauch von räumlichen Metaphern gemacht haben. Ein klassischer Fall ist Althusser, der Begriffe wie Feld, Terrain, Raum, Stelle, Situation oder Position benutzt, sich dabei aber auf Sprache allein zu verlassen scheint.[30] Räumliche Begriffe als Metaphern zu verwenden, sollte nicht verworfen werden, doch sollte vielleicht hinzugefügt werden *warum* diese Sprache so nützlich sein kann. Räumliche Beschreibungen handeln oft von Disputen, Kämpfen und von Produktivität, da sie den konkreten Gebrauch des Raumes und räumliche Erfahrungen widerspiegeln. Wird zum Beispiel der Raum des Stadtplaners als wissenschaftliches Objekt angesehen, als unschuldig und apolitisch, argumentiert dagegen Lefèbvre, dass dieser Raum durch historische und natürliche Faktoren, durch einen politischen Prozess geformt und gestaltet wurde.[31] Raum ist ein gesellschaftliches und politisches Produkt. Genau dies ist der Grund, warum Lefèbvres Hauptwerk über Raum mit *La production de l'espace* betitelt ist. Dieser Titel beinhaltet zwei Begriffe, beide verlangen eine kritische Betrachtung.

Obwohl Lefèbvre vorgeworfen wird, Marx' frühes Konzept der Entfremdung den späteren Ausarbeitungen zum Begriff der Produktion vorzuziehen, wird in seinen Arbeiten über Raum (und auch an anderen Stellen) deutlich, dass die Produktionsweise ausschlaggebend für seine Untersuchung ist. Die Auswirkungen menschlichen Handelns werden zwar sorgfältig in Betracht gezogen, dominieren jedoch nicht. Lefèbvre konstatiert unzweifelhaft: »(gesellschaftlicher) Raum ist ein (gesellschaftliches) Produkt«[32]. Gemeint ist hier, dass »jede Gesellschaft - und damit jede Produktionsweise in all ihren Spielarten...einen Raum herstellt, ihren eigenen Raum.«[33] Das Unausgearbeitete des Vorwortes von 1859 (Zur Kritik der politischen Ökonomie) über Basis und Überbau wird nicht wiederholt, vielmehr erkennt Lefèbvre nun die kausale Wirksamkeit der Produktionsverhältnisse und -kräfte. Er hält fest, dass es keine völlige Übereinstimmung gibt und dass Räume manchmal durch Widersprüche in der Produktionsweise entstehen. Hier nennt er als Beispiel eine mittelalterliche Stadt, die aus dem Feudalismus heraus entstand, aber letztendlich aus diesem siegreich hervortrat.[34] »Ein sozialer Raum ist kein *sozialisierter* Raum«[35], betont Lefèbvre nachdrücklich: Er existierte nicht vorher als nicht-gesellschaftlicher, natürlicher Raum, sondern wird durch gesellschaftliche Kräfte hergestellt.

Eine Analyse der Produktionsweise in der modernen Welt zeigt, das »wir von der *Produktion der Dinge im Raum zur Produktion des Raums selbst* übergegangen sind«.[36] Einer der Schlüsselfaktoren für diese Entwicklung ist Technologie. Scott Kirsch hat darauf hingewiesen, dass dies in der Auseinandersetzung mit Lefèbvres Werk manchmal übersehen wird: »Zusätzlich zu ihrer Bedeutung für die Produktion *im* Raum, spielt Technologie ebenfalls eine vermittelnde Rolle in der Produktion des Raumes.« Kirsch warnt auch davor »Zuflucht in der eher cartoon-artig schrumpfenden Welt der Metaphern zu suchen«, und dabei zu riskieren, die komplexen Beziehungen zwischen Kapital, Technologie und Raum aus dem Blick zu verlieren. Raum »schrumpft« nicht, sondern muss vielmehr unabänderlich verändert werden.[37] Es bietet sich an, den letzten Satz umzuformulieren und näher zu bestimmen: Raum schrumpft nicht, er wird fortwährend verändert, aber wir *nehmen* ihn als schrumpfend *wahr*.

Dies betont einen wichtigen Aspekt. Lefèbvre hat nicht nur das modernistische Ungleichgewicht von Zeit über Raum korrigiert, sondern betont darüber hinaus, *im Gegensatz zu Kant*, die Historizität ihrer Erfahrung. Es geht nicht mehr um Kants leere formale Behälter, nicht mehr um Kategorien der Erfahrungen - Zeit und Raum können nun vielmehr *als solche* erlebt werden und ihre Wahrnehmung steht in direkter Beziehung zu den historischen Bedingungen, innerhalb derer sie erfahren werden.[38] Für Lefèbvre stehen diese geschichtlichen Bedingungen natürlich in einer direkten Verbindung zur Produktionsweise und - damit zur *Produktion* des Raumes. Aus diesem Grund sieht er zwei Hauptargumentationsstränge für seine Arbeit vor: Erstens den Raum der Zeit gleichzustellen unter Berücksichtigung sozialer Theorie und dadurch die Verengungen des Kantschen Begriffs der Behälter der Erfahrung zu korrigieren. Räumlichkeit ist genauso wichtig wie Zeitlichkeit und Geschichte,

deren Berücksichtigung dennoch nicht verhindert werden darf: »Raum und Zeit erscheinen und erweisen sich als unterschiedlich, doch zugleich untrennbar.«[39] Zweitens wollte er dieses neue kritische Verständnis nutzen, um die (moderne) Welt, innerhalb der seine Thesen entstanden sind, einer kritischen Untersuchung zu unterziehen. Dies wird durch eine Analyse, wie Raum produziert und wie er erlebt wird, erreicht. Raum wird auf zwei Arten produziert: als gesellschaftliche Formation (Produktionsweise) und als gedankliche Konstruktion (Vorstellung).

Was ist mit Raum gemeint? Massey hat darauf aufmerksam gemacht, dass die Begriffe »Raum« und »räumlich« in der Regel benutzt werden, als wäre ihre Bedeutung klar, dass aber im allgemeinen nicht bemerkt wird, dass es viele verschiedene Interpretationen dafür gibt. Sie sieht, dass Lefèbvre dies erkannte, und dass sein Gebrauch und Verständnis dieser problematischen Worte ziemlich genau ist.[40] Zieht man in Betracht, dass das französische Wort *espace* ein breiteres Spektrum von Bedeutungen hat als »space«, wird die Situation noch komplizierter. Im Englischen können einige der Bedeutungen als Gebiet (area), Zone (zone), Ort (locus) oder Territorium (territory) übersetzt werden. Lefèbvre beginnt *La production de l'espace* mit der Feststellung, dass es bis zu jenem Zeitpunkt eine bestimmte Vorstellung von Raum dominierte. Diese Vorstellung basierte auf der von Descartes eingeführten Unterscheidung zwischen *res cognitas* und *res extensa*.[41] Raum wurde aus der Vorstellung der Ausdehnung heraus konzeptualisiert und in Begriffen wie Koordinaten, Linien und Flächen - als euklidische Geometrie also - gedacht. Kant hat diese Anschauung im weiteren verkompliziert, indem er sich Zeit und Raum als *a priori* gesetzte, absolute Kategorien vorstellte, die jegliche Erfahrung strukturieren. Wir haben bereits gesehen, wie Lefèbvres Betonung der Produktion von Raum diese Erfahrung historisiert; die Kritik an der kartesianischen Formulierung muss immer noch erbracht werden.

Bereits 1939 hatte Lefèbvre geometrischen Raum als abstrahierend beschrieben und mit der Uhrzeit und ihrer Abstraktion des Konkreten verglichen.[42] Der Bezug auf die Kritik des geometrischen Raums in Heideggers *Sein und Zeit* und dessen späteren Schriften ist deutlich. Genauso wie wir einen Hammer nur als Hammer wahrnehmen, wenn es ein Problem mit ihm gibt, fassen wir Raum nur geometrisch auf, wenn wir innehalten, um über ihn nachzudenken, das heißt wenn wir ihn konzeptualisieren.[43] Nicht die Art und Weise, in der wir auf Raum reagieren ist geometrisch, die Art und Weise, in der wir abstrahieren, hingegen schon. Hier wurde eine Gegenüberstellung eingeführt zwischen unserer Vorstellung von Raum - abstrakt, gedanklich und geometrisch - und unserer Wahrnehmung von Raum - konkret, materiell und körperlich. Letztgenanntes nimmt als Ausgangspunkt den Körper, welchen Lefèbvre innerhalb des Diskurses über die Macht des Raumes als Ort des Widerstands ansieht.[44] Abstrakter, entkörperlichter Raum ist, so Lefèbvre, ein weiterer Aspekt der Entfremdung.

Um in unserem Verständnis von Raum voranzukommen, müssen wir das Konkrete und das Abstrakte im Zusammenhang begreifen. In *Le matérialisme dialectique* wurde argumentiert, dass, wenn nur ein Aspekt aufgegriffen und für absolut genommen wird, diese partielle Wahrheit einen Trugschluss darstellt: »Die Verstreuung der Elemente des Realen wird gebilligt und verstärkt, wenn man einen Teil des Inhalts zurückweist.«[45] Genauso wie Lefèbvre den Staat als »realisierte Abstraktion«[46] beschrieben hat, so ist auch Raum eine realisierte (in beiden Bedeutungen des Wortes) Abstraktion. Hier wird offenkundig, wie Idealismus und Materialismus im Zusammenhang gebracht werden. Raum ist ein gedankliches und ein materielles Konstrukt. Zwischen den Polen von Vorstellung und Wahrnehmung stattet uns dies mit einem dritten Begriff aus, dem Gedanken des Gelebten. Lefèbvre argumentiert, dass menschlicher Raum und menschliche Zeit jeweils zur Hälfte in der Natur und in der Abstraktion begründet sind. Sein Beispiel für Zeit ist aufschlussreich: »Es ist offensichtlich... dass die menschlichen Rhythmen (biologisch, psychologisch und gesellschaftliche Zeiteinteilungen - die Zeiteinteilung unseres eigenen Organismus und die der Uhr) bestimmen, in welcher Weise wir die Welt wahrnehmen, sie uns vorstellen, und sogar welche Gesetze wir in ihr entdecken.[47] Raum und Zeit, gesellschaftlich gelebter und gesellschaftlich produzierte, sind abhängig von physischen und gedanklichen Konstrukten.

Daraus ergibt sich eine konzeptuelle Triade: räumliche Praxis (spatial practice), Repräsentationen des Raumes (representations of space) und Räume der Repräsentation (spaces of representation).[48] Raum wird auf drei Arten verstanden, als erfahren (perceived), erdacht (conceived) und gelebt (lived): l'espace percu, concu, vecu. Lefèbvres Schema versteht physischen, gedanklichen und sozialen Raum als eine Einheit:

Räumliche Praxis	l'espace percu	erfahren (wahrgenommen, gebraucht)	Physisch	Materialismus
Repräsentation des Raumes	l'espace concu	erdacht (geplant, vorgestellt)	Gedanklich	Idealismus
Räume der Repräsentation	l'espace vecu	Gelebt	gesellschaftlich	Materialismus & Idealismus

Die erste dieser Zeilen geht von Raum als physischer Form aus, dem realen Raum, der erzeugt und benutzt wird. Die zweite umfasst den Raum des Wissens (savoir) und der Logik, den Raum der Karten und Mathematik, den Raum als instrumentellen Raum der Technokraten und Stadtplaner. Raum als gedankliches Konstrukt, imaginierter Raum. Die dritte betrachtet Raum als produziert und im Verlauf der Zeit und durch seinen Gebrauch verändert, als Raum, der mit Symbolen und Bedeutungen ausgestattet sind, den Raum der

connaissance (weniger formale eher lokalere Formen des Wissens), Raum als *real-und-imaginiert*.

Die Konzeption des gelebten Raumes ist einer von Lefèbvres zentralen Beiträgen, obwohl er in Bezug auf seine Verwendung zurückdatiert werden muss. Heideggers Einfluss zeigt sich deutlich an vielen Stellen in *La production de l'espace* und in anderen Arbeiten aus dieser Zeit. Lefèbvres Herangehensweise scheint darin zu bestehen, viele von Heideggers Schriften mit denen von Marx zu kombinieren. Heidegger konnte durch seine Beschäftigung mit Nietzsche und Hölderlin ein Verständnis des Poetischen in seine Arbeiten integrieren. Dies war entscheidend für die verräumlichte Vorstellung des poetischen Wohnens, eine Vorstellung der *gelebten Erfahrung des Alltagslebens*.[49] Lefèbvres Gebrauch von habiter ist eine direkte Übersetzung von Heideggers Begriff *wohnen*.[50] Tatsächlich zitiert Lefèbvre aus Hölderlins Gedicht *In Lieblicher Bläue* die Zeile »dichterisch wohnet der Mensch« und bezieht sich dabei mit Sicherheit auf Heideggers Erörterung dieses Phänomens bei Hölderlin.[51] Lefèbvres Anmerkung, dass [be]wohnen (habiter) auf den Ausdruck Wohnraum (habitat) reduziert wurde, gleicht Heideggers Ausführungen zu einer Krise des Wohnens.[52]

Lefèbvre folgt explizit Heidegger, wenn er schreibt, dass diese Krise »einer merkwürdigen Art von Exzess entspringt: der Sucht nach Messungen und Kalkulationen.«[53] Harvey hat festgehalten, dass nach dieser Anschauung des gelebten Raumes die kartesianisch-kantischen Vorstellungen von Raum nicht notwendigerweise falsch sind - es können völlig angemessene Annäherungen sein - aber es bleiben Annäherungen.[54] Zur Wiederholung: Es handelt sich um Annäherungen, die auf der Ebene der Abstraktion beginnen, genau eine entscheidende Ebene entfernt von der gelebten Reaktion.

Aus diesem Grund schuldet die Konstruktion, beziehungsweise die Produktion des Raumes der Konzeption genauso viel wie den materiellen Aktivitäten. Ein Beispiel für einen Raum, der sowohl gedankliche als auch materielle Vorstellungen verkörpert, ist ein Kloster, wo »der gestische Raum es geschafft hat, den gedanklichen Raum - einen Raum der Kontemplation und theologischen Abstraktion - fest in der Erde zu verankern, und es ihm dabei ermöglicht, sich symbolisch auszudrücken und Teil einer Praxis zu werden.«[55] Ein anderes Beispiel zeigt, wie bauliche Konstrukte in einer modernen Stadt erfahren werden. Ein Park wurde erdacht, entworfen und hergestellt durch Arbeit, Technologien und Institutionen, aber die Bedeutung des Raumes und der Raum selbst wird dadurch adaptiert und transformiert, dass er von gesellschaftlichen Akteuren und Gruppen *erfahren* und *gelebt* wird.[56] Doch diese Vorstellung des Raumes als »gelebt« ist allein nicht ausreichend. Lefèbvre kritisiert an Heidegger, dass dieser es verfehlt hat, den Gedanken der Produktion ausreichend detailliert zu betrachten. Heideggers Konzeption von Produktion sieht er als »restriktiv und eingeschränkt« an, da er sie für ein »zur-Erscheinung-bringen, ein Aufsteigen (un surgissement) hält, welches ein Ding hervorbringt, wie ein Ding, das da ist, zwischen anderen Dingen, die schon vorhanden sind.«[57] Was deshalb eine Rolle spielt, ist die gesellschaftliche wie auch politische Produktion des Raums.

Wie sollte dann eine Analyse des Raumes vorgehen? So wie das Gesellschaftliche historisch geformt ist, so ist es auch räumlich geformt. Genauso ist das Räumliche historisch und gesellschaftlich konstruiert. Die drei Elemente des Gesellschaftlichen, des Räumlichen und des Zeitlichen formen sich gegenseitig und werden voneinander geformt. »Gesellschaftliche Beziehungen, die konkrete Abstraktionen sind, haben keine Existenz an sich, sondern nur im Raum und durch Raum. Ihre Grundlage ist räumlich«[58]. Und, sollte man hinzufügen, zeitlich. Und dennoch ist Raum auch nicht einfach »der passive Ort [lieu] gesellschaftlicher Beziehungen«[59]. Auf der Suche nach einer Bezeichnung für diese neue Betrachtungsweise spielt Lefèbvre mit den Begriffen »spatioanalysis« und »spatiology«, sieht aber auch das Problem der Verwendung dieser Begriffe, da es einer Analyse der *Produktion des Raumes* bedarf.[60] Als Marxist vereinigt Lefèbvre dies mit einer Überarbeitung des historischen Materialismus. In seiner »Critique de la raison dialectique« lobt Sartre Lefèbvre dafür, Soziologie und Geschichte in den historischen Materialismus zu integrieren.[61] Wenn man aber den weiteren Verlauf von Lefèbvres Arbeit betrachtet, sollte man auch »spatiology (Wissenschaft vom Raum)« zu dieser Kombination hinzufügen. Tatsächlich vertrat Lefèbvre 1989 in einem Interview die Ansicht, dass die Lehre in Soziologie und Geschichte, die die Fragen des Urbanen (des Raums) außer acht lassen, lächerlich seien, da ihnen dann ihre eigentliche Substanz fehlt.[62]

Kritische Rezeption: Entwicklung hin zu einer Geschichte des Raums oder einer räumlichen Geschichte?

Ich habe dargelegt, dass Lefèbvre zwei wichtige Argumentationsstränge in seiner Arbeit vollzieht. Eine Feststellung der Bedeutung von Raum in Beziehung zur Zeit und eine Analyse der Räume der Moderne. Während in Lefèbvres subtiler und nuancierter Arbeit diese Unterscheidung klar und sinnvoll ist, wird sie von weniger geschickten Autoren allzu oft auf eine schwer zu handhabende Betrachtung der Postmodernisierung reduziert, etwa der Stadtlandschaft von Los Angeles[63] (das ist mit einer traurigen Regelmäßigkeit das einzige Beispiel). In dieser kurzen Darlegung der kritischen Lesart von Lefèbvre wird im folgenden nur die erste seiner zwei Argumentationen untersucht, die methodische.

Erste Aufmerksamkeit erfuhr Lefèbvres Arbeit im englischsprachigen Raum durch die Arbeit von Manuel Castells. Castells war von der anti-hegelianischen / althusserischen Betrachtungsweise des Marxismus beeinflusst und stand Lefèbvres Arbeit deshalb kritisch gegenüber,

insbesondere der Problematisierung des Raumes. Es wurde bereits betont, dass er seine Betrachtungsweise dazu schon größtenteils dargelegt hatte, bevor Lefèbvre explizit diese Themen behandelte, und dass er Lefèbvres Arbeit über das Alltagsleben ignorierte, in der diese schon angesprochen wurden.[64] Castells verstand die Arbeit von Lefèbvre anfangs als eine Art Fetischismus des Raumes. Er verstand, dass die Betonung des Raumes bei Lefèbvre eine Infragestellung des historischen Materialismus war, der natürlich selbst Raum vernachlässigt und Zeit und Geschichte in den Vordergrund stellte. Es wurde bereits überzeugend dargelegt, das dies eine Fehlinterpretation von Lefèbvres Ansatz ist.[65] Lefèbvre mag eine Grenzposition innerhalb des westlichen Marxismus und historischem Materialismus eingenommen haben, aber er versuchte dennoch eine explizit marxistische Analyse voranzutreiben. Vor dem Hintergrund der vorhandenen Unausgewogenheit des historischen Materialismus war es vielleicht zu erwarten, dass Lefèbvre durch eine Überbewertung des Raumes versuchte, wieder ein Gleichgewicht herzustellen. Wenn Raum von ihm nicht so stark in den Vordergrund gestellt worden wäre, so wäre dieses Thema wahrscheinlich ignoriert worden.

Dies ist einer der Ansprüche von Edward Soja, der Lefèbvre als »den ersten und besten historischen und geographischen Materialisten«[66] feiert. Man muss es Soja anrechnen, Lefèbvres Arbeit im englischsprachigen Raum verbreitet zu haben. Sein Buch *Postmodern Geographies* wurde zu Recht als eines der herausforderndsten und anregendsten Bücher gehandelt, die jemals über den gesellschaftlichen Gebrauch von Raum geschrieben wurden. Das Problem an Sojas Arbeit ist, dass er sich so stark auf die Postmoderne und auf Los Angeles bezieht, dass er genau für diesen Zweck ein spezielles Programm aus der Arbeit von Lefèbvre und anderen entwickelt, anstatt ein theoretisches Gerüst zu skizzieren, dass auf andere Zeiten und Orte angewendet werden kann. Während Soja anführt, dass Kritik, wie zum Beispiel. in »What about Huddersfield?« den Punkt verfehlt, weil seine konzeptionellen Werkzeuge auch auf andere Gebiete angewandt werden können, fokussiert er in seiner eigenen Arbeit jedoch nur auf diesen einen Ort, mit einem oberflächlichem Blick auf dessen historische Hintergründe.[67] Dies schwächt seinen kritischen Anspruch, Raum wieder stärker in der kritischen Gesellschaftstheorie zu verankern.

»Die (Re-) Etablierung von Raum in der kritischen Gesellschaftstheorie - und in der kritischen politischen Praxis - wird von einer weitergeführten Dekonstruktion eines immer noch ausschließenden Historizismus abhängen und viele zusätzliche Forschungsreisen in die Heterotopien der zeitgenössischen postmodernen Geographien erfordern.«[68]

Von dieser (Re-) Etablierung erhofft sich Soja, Geschichte zu verräumlichen und Zeit zu verorten (put time »in its place«), aber er scheint sich nicht richtig bewusst zu sein, dass Lefèbvres Arbeit selbst so etwas wie ein Historizismus ist.[69] Das ist die Kernfrage: Verräumlicht Lefèbvre Geschichte, historisiert er Raum, oder verräumlicht er einfach die Soziologie? Während ich glaube, dass Lefèbvre, indem er mit den drei dauernd in Bezug stehenden Begriffen arbeitete, dies alles und mehr beabsichtigte, kann es so erscheinen, als ob er eine *Geschichte des Raums* und nicht eine *räumliche Geschichte* schreibt.[70] Viele seiner Kommentatoren folgten dieser Argumentation, indem sie Raum geschichtlich betrachteten, ohne auf die Umkehrung zu achten. Der springende Punkt scheint die Radikalisierung des Verständnisses der Geschichte zu sein, so dass diese verräumlicht wird. Da nur ein kleiner Teil von Lefèbvres Arbeit zu Geschichte und Zeit auf englisch erhältlich ist, wird dieses Problem nicht leicht zu lösen sein. Es besteht die Gefahr, den Raum auf Kosten eines reduzierten geschichtlichen Verständnisses auf einen Thron zu heben. Genauso wenig glaube ich, dass das bloße Hinzufügen eines zweiten Adjektivs zu dem Begriff »historischer Materialismus« angebracht wäre. Gemeinsam mit Lefèbvre könnten wir uns auf das Werk von Michel Foucault beziehen, der, indem er auf Nietzsche und Heidegger zurückgreift, einen alternativen Zugang zu Raum und Zeit entwickelt, welcher entscheidend *von Beginn an räumlich und zeitlich* konzipiert ist. Obwohl Soja Foucaults Werk berücksichtigt, versäumt er es, sich mit vielen seiner wichtigen Einsichten zu beschäftigen. Foucault verräumlicht historische Studien äußerst erfolgreich, indem er aufzeigt, wie wichtig Raum in vielen Zeitaltern ist, allerdings natürlich jeweils auf sehr unterschiedliche Weise.[71]

Ebenso würde ein lediglich räumlicher Ansatz Gefahr laufen, die Bedeutung einer Analyse von Rhythmen, eine Rhythmusanalyse, , »die die Darstellung der Produktion des Raumes vervollständigen würde«[72], zu verkennen. Eine Analyse der Produktion des Raumes, gesetzt den Fall, dass sie auf Lefèbvres Aufarbeitung der Dialektik und des historischen Materialismus ausdrücklich Bezug nehmen würde, wäre ein sinnvoller Schritt, Lefèbvres Arbeit voranzutreiben. Lefèbvre versteht die Analyse des Raumes gerade nicht als einen Ersatz für andere Analysen, und er erkennt, dass auch die Produktion von Bevölkerung und Klassenstrukturen bedacht werden muss. Auch wenn er manchmal anders verstanden wurde, muss diese Analyse auch historische Aspekte mit einbeziehen - sie ist nichts Statisches[73]. Sie muss Rhythmus in Betracht ziehen, indem sie auf den menschlichen Körper eingeht[74]. Raum und Zeit sind miteinander verknüpft und hängen voneinander ab.[75]

Es wäre streng, aber nicht unbedingt unfair, zu behaupten, dass Lefèbvres Arbeit dadurch Schaden genommen hat, dass sie von einem bestimmten Wissenschaftlertypus gelesen wurde. Genau wie der theoretische Unterbau Foucaults von Kulturwissenschaftlern außer Acht gelassen wurde, die nur erpicht darauf waren, dessen Werkzeug in die Hände zu bekommen, so wurden auch die

Geographen und Stadttheoretiker, die Lefèbvres philosophischen Hintergrund nur in Marx suchen, seiner Arbeit nicht gerecht. Lefèbvre macht nur Sinn, wenn die Argumente von Nietzsche und Heidegger zusammen mit denen von Marx bedacht werden. Sein Marxismus war offen für viele Möglichkeiten, denn er verstand Marx` Denken als »einen Kern, einen überschäumenden Samen, ein Grundgerüst für eine Konzeption der Welt, die sich entwickelt, ohne jedoch die Konfrontation mit völlig anderen Arbeiten vermeiden zu können.«[76]

Hegel, Marx, Nietzsche und Heidegger können dazu benutzt werden, uns zu helfen, die moderne Welt zu verstehen. Das Verstehen funktioniert, indem man einige von Marx` Konzepten beibehält, aber auch neue hinzufügt: »Den Alltag, das Städtische sowie gesellschaftliche Zeit und Raum.«[77] Der übrig gebliebene hegelianische Idealismus, Heideggers Verständnis des Alltags und der Erfahrung des Raumes, Nietzsches Anmerkungen über den Willen zur Macht und zum Gebauten, und »die Betonung des Körpers, der Sexualität, der Gewalt und des Tragischen und die Produktion von unterschiedlichen Räumen und verschiedenen Zeiten«[78] finden sich in Lefèbvres Arbeit wieder. Marxistische Wissenschaftler haben aus genau diesen Gründen Schwierigkeiten gehabt, Lefèbvres intellektuelle Hinterlassenschaft nachzuvollziehen, Raumwissenschaftler begreifen oft seine Aufarbeitung des Marxismus nicht.

In seinen eigenen Worten bietet uns Lefèbvres Arbeit eine »Orientierung« in Bezug auf Raum:

»Ich spreche mit Bedacht von einer Orientierung. Es geht um nichts mehr und nichts weniger als das. Wir befassen uns mit etwas, das »Sinn« genannt werden könnte: ein Organ, das wahrnimmt (perceives), eine Richtung, die erdacht werden könnte (conceived) und eine unmittelbar gelebte Bewegung, die bis an den Horizont führt. Und wir beschäftigen uns mit nichts, was auch nur im Entferntesten einem System ähnelt.«[79]

Dieser Text ist eine vom Autor für »An Architektur« überarbeitete und aktualisierte Fassung eines Vortrages, den er 1998 auf einer Konferenz zur Postmoderne in Erlangen unter dem Titel »There is a Politics of Space because Space is Political« gehalten hat.

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Demnächst erscheinen von ihm folgende Bücher zu Lefèbvre:
Henri Lefebvre: Key Writings. herausgegeben von Stuart Elden und Elizabeth Lebas, London/New York, Athlone/Continuum, erscheint 2003.
Henri Lefebvre: A Critical Introduction. London/ New York, Continuum, erscheint 2004.

1 *La production de l'espace*. Paris, Anthropos, 4. Ausgabe, 2000 (1974)

2 vgl. *Le matérialisme dialectique*. Paris, Presses Universitaires de France PUF, 1974 (1939)

3 »Towards a Leftist Cultural Politics: Remarks Occasioned by the Centenary of Marx's Death«, in: Cary Nelson & Lawrence Grossberg (Hrsg.): *Marxism and the Interpretation of Culture*. London, Macmillan, 1988, S.78

4 Lefèbvres wichtige Überlegung zum Marxismus beinhalten *Le Marxisme*. Paris, PUF, 1948, und *Sociologie de Marx*. Paris, PUF, 1966; zu einer hervorragenden Lefèbvre Biographie, vgl. Rémi Hess: *Henri Lefèbvre et l'aventure du siècle*. Paris, A.M. Métailié, 1988.; über sein Verhältnis zum Marxismus und zur zeitgenössischen Theorie, vgl. bes. Michael Kelly: *Modern French Marxism*. Oxford, Blackwell, 1982; Mark Poster: *Existential Marxism in Postwar France: From Sartre to Althusser*. Princeton, Princeton University Press, 1975; über das Alltagsleben, vgl. Alice Kaplan & Kristin Ross: *Everyday Life: Yale French Studies*, 73, Herbst 1987; A. Hirsch: *The French New Left*. Boston, South End Press, 1981; über Heideggers Diskussion von Alltäglichkeit, vgl. Martin Heidegger: *Sein und Zeit*. Tübingen, Max Niemeyer, 1967

5 Alice Kaplan & Kristin Ross: »Introduction«, in: *Everyday Life: Yale French Studies*, S. 3

6 vgl. z.B. *La vallée de Campan: Étude de sociologie rurale*. Paris, PUF, 1963; *Du rural à l'urbain*. Paris, Anthropos, 1970; *La Révolution urbaine*. Paris, Gallimard, 1970; *Espace et politique*. Paris, Anthropos, 1973

7 *Everyday Life in the Modern World*. übersetzt von Sacha Rabinovitch, Harmondsworth, Allen Lane, 1971, S. 195; vgl. auch *Writings on Cities*, übersetzt und herausgegeben von Eleonore Kofman & Elizabeth Lebas, Oxford, Blackwell, 1996, S. 65ff. & 130; und *La pensée marxiste et la ville*. Paris, Casterman, 1972

8 *Everyday Life in the Modern World*, S. 65

9 *Everyday Life in the Modern World*, S. 65

10 *The Explosion: Marxism and the French Upheaval*. übersetzt von Alfred Ehrenfeld, New York, Modern Reader, 1969, S. 46; vgl. *La Révolution urbaine*

11 vgl. Margaret Fitzsimmons: »The Matter of Nature«, in: Trevor Barnes & Derek Gregory (Hrsg.): *Reading Human Geography: The Politics and Poetics of Inquiry*. London, Arnold, 1997, bes. S. 188; Lefèbvres grundlegender Text über diese Verschiebung ist *Du rural à l'urbain*.

12 *Introduction to Modernity: Twelve Preludes*. übersetzt von John Moore, London, Verso, 1995 [1962], S. 345-6

13 *The Explosion*, S. 33

14 *Critique de la vie quotidienne I: Introduction*. Paris, L'Arche, 22. Ausgabe, 1958 [1947], S. 228-37; vgl z. B. Friedrich Nietzsche: *Also sprach Zarathustra*. Teil II, §4; *Menschliches Allzumenschliches* §130; Generell zu Macht und Raum, vgl. *Götterdämmerung* Teil 9, §11; alle in: *Sämtliche Werke: Kritische Studienausgabe*. Giorgio Colli & Mazzino Montinari (Hrsg.), Berlin und München, de Gruyter und Deutscher Taschenbuch Verlag, 15 Bände, 1980

15 *Critique de la vie quotidienne I*. S. 228 & 247; für eine spätere und genauere Ausarbeitung, vgl. *The Survival of Capitalism*. London, Allison & Busby, 1976, S.86-88: »Konstruierter Raum – eine Transparenz aus Metall und Glas – spricht laut vom Willen zur Macht und all seinen Tricks. Es ist kaum nötig hinzuzufügen, dass auch das 'Habitat' diese räumliche Verteilung der Dominierung teilt«

16 *Introduction to Modernity*. S. 116ff.

17 *Everyday Life in the Modern World*. S. 59

18 Frederic Jameson: *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*. London, Verso, 1991, S. 364

19 Kristin Ross: *The Emergence of Social Space: Rimbaud and the Paris Commune*. Houndmills, Macmillan, 1988, S. 8-9; sie geht so weit zu sagen, dass sozialer Raum ein Synonym für das Alltagsleben, und dass das Alltagsleben hauptsächlich, jedoch nicht vollständig, als räumliches Konzept zu verstehen sei

20 *Everyday Life in the Modern World*. S. 52; *Espace et politique*. S. 57-58

21 diese und andere Aspekte zu Lefèbvre und Raum, vgl. Mario Rui Martins: »The Theory of Social Space in the Work of Henri Lefèbvre«, in: Ray Forrest, Jeff Henderson & Peter Williams (Hrsg.): *Urban Political Economy and Social Theory: Critical Essays in Urban Studies*. Aldershot, Gower, 1982

22 *La production de l'espace*. S. 68

23 *Espace et politique*. S. 22f.; *The Survival of Capitalism*. S. 17ff.

24 *The Survival of Capitalism*. S. 116; dieses Thema ist vorherrschend in Foucaults Schriften; vgl. jedoch bes. *Histoire de la folie à l'âge classique*. Paris, Gallimard, 1976 [1961], und *Surveiller et punir: Naissance de la prison*. Paris, Gallimard, 1975; zur Diskussion, vgl. Stuart Elden: *Mapping the Present: Heidegger, Foucault and the Project of a Spatial History*. London & New York, Continuum, 2001, bes. Kapitel 5

25 David Harvey: *The Condition of Postmodernity*. Oxford, Blackwell, 1989, S. 237

26 *The Survival of Capitalism*. S. 21, 106

27 *Espace et politique*. S. 59

28 zitiert (ohne Referenz) in: Edward Soja: *Postmodern Geographies*. London, Verso, 1989, S. 32; es scheint möglich, dass sich Soja auf David Harvey bezieht: *The Urbanization of Capital: Studies in the History and Theory of Capitalist Urbanization II*. Oxford, Blackwell, 1985, S. xii; in einem persönlichen Gespräch bemerkte Harvey, dass es sich wahrscheinlich um (blinde/indirekte) Zitate handelt

29 Richard Peet: *Global Capitalism: Theories of Societal Development*. London & New York, Routledge, 1991, S. 178-179; Lefèbvre vertritt die Meinung, dass »bestimmte Konzepte wie Tausch- und Gebrauchswert heutzutage auf den Raum angewendet werden können, obwohl der Raum in *Das Kapital* nicht analysiert wird«; vgl.. »Space: Social Product and Use Value«, in: J.W. Freiburg (Hrsg.): *Critical Sociology: European Perspectives*. New York, Irvington Publishers, 1979, S. 292

30 vgl. bes. Louis Althusser, Jacques Rancière & Pierre Macherey: *Lire le Capital Tome I*. Paris, François Maspero, 1965, S.28-31; um Althusser in diesem Kontext zu diskutieren, vgl. Neil Smith & Cindy Katz: »Grounding Metaphor: Towards a Spatialised Politics«, in: Michael Keith & Steve Pile (Hrsg.): *Place and the Politics of Identity*. London, Routledge, 1993

31 *Espace et politique*. S. 50-1

32 *La production de l'espace*. S. 35

33 *La production de l'espace*. S. 35

34 »An Interview with Henri Lefèbvre«, in: *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space*, übersetzt von Eleonore Kofman, 5, 1987, S. 31

35 *La production de l'espace*. S. 220

36 »Space: Social Product and Use Value«. S. 285

37 Scott Kirsch: »The Incredible Shrinking World? Technology and the Production of Space«, in: *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space,* 13, 1995, S. 533 & 544; die Kritik an der Metapher der schrumpfenden Welt ist direkt an die Arbeit von David Harvey gerichtet; Kirsch behauptet, dass der metaphorische Raum der schrumpfenden Welt, den materiellen Raum aus der Geographie vertreibt, was einer Fetischisierung von Raum sehr nahe kommt; es ist darauf hingewiesen worden, das in Lefèbvres Vorstellung von Raum, als konkrete Abstraktion, dieser nicht von seiner Materialität getrennt werden kann.

38 vgl. Immanuel Kant: *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. Hamburg, Felix Meiner, 1956; oder *Prolegomena zu einer jeden künftigen Metaphysik*. in: Ernst Cassirer (Hrsg.): *Immanuel Kants Werke*. Berlin, Bruno Cassirer, 1922, Band IV

39 *La production de l'espace*. S. 204

40 Doreen Massey: »Politics and Space/Time«, in: *New Left Review*, 192, November/Dezember 1992, S. 66; vgl. *La production de l'espace*. S. 9-10

41 René Descartes: *Meditationes de Prima Philosophia in Œuvres Philosophiques: Tome II (1638-1642)*. Paris, Garnier Frères, 1967

42 *Le matérialisme dialectique*. S. 118, 130

43 Martin Heidegger: *Sein und Zeit*. S. 109, 361-2; *Die Grundprobleme der Phänomenologie*. Gesamtausgabe Band 24, Frankfurt am Main, Vittorio Klostermann, 1975, S. 231ff.

44 *The Survival of Capitalism*. S. 89

45 *Le matérialisme dialectique*. S. 165; vgl. Norbert Guterman & Henri Lefèbvre: *La conscience mystifiée*. Paris, Éditions Syllepse, 1999 [1936], S. 210

46 *Critique de la vie quotidienne I*. S. 223

47 *La matérialisme dialectique*. S. 139

48 *La production de l'espace*. S. 42-3

49 vgl. Martin Heidegger: *Nietzsche*. Pfullingen, Günther Neske, 2 Bände, 1961; *Hölderlins Hymne 'Der Ister'*, Gesamtausgabe Band 53, Frankfurt am

Main, Vittorio Klostermann, 1984; *Vorträge und Aufsätze*, Pfullingen, Günther Neske, 1978; für einen Kommentar, vgl. Stuart Elden, »Heidegger's Hölderlin and the Importance of Place«, in: *Journal of the British Society for Phenomenology*. 30, 3, Oktober 1999, S. 258-74

50 *La révolution urbaine*. S. 240; *La production de l'espace*. S. 143-4

51 *Du rural à l'urbain*. S. 160; *La révolution urbaine*. S. 111; *La production de l'espace*. S. 362

52 *Writings on Cities*. S. 79; *La production de l'espace*. S. 362

53 *Du rural à l'urbain*. S. 161

54 David Harvey: *Justice, Nature and the Geography of Difference*. Oxford, Blackwell, 1996, S. 267

55 *La production de l'espace*. S. 250

56 Kirsch, »The Incredible Shrinking World?«. S. 548

57 *La production de l'espace*. S. 144

58 *La production de l'espace*. S. 465

59 *La production de l'espace*. S. 18

60 *La production de l'espace*. S. 465

61 Jean-Paul Sartre: *Critique de la raison dialectique précédé de Questions de méthode, Tome I: Théorie des ensembles pratiques*. Paris, Gallimard, 1960, S. 50; David Caute: *Communism and the French Intellectuals 1914-1960*. London, Andre Deutsch, 1964, S. 298

62 *Writings on Cities*. S. 215

63 ich beziehe mich hier besonders auf Edward Sojas *Thirdspace: Journeys to Los Angeles and Other Real-and-Imagined Places*. Oxford. Blackwell, 1996, welches ich kritisch rezensiert habe, in: »What about Huddersfield?«, in: *Radical Philosophy*, 84, Juli/August 1997, und weiterführend dikutiert habe, in: »Politics, Philosophy, Geography: Henri Lefèbvre in Anglo-American Scholarship«, in: *Antipode: A Radical Journal of Geography*, 33, 5, November 2001, S. 809-825

64 vgl. Manuel Castells: *La question urbaine*. Paris, Maspero, 1972; um Castells' Arbeit kritisch zu diskutieren, vgl. Peter Newman: »Urban Political Economy and Planning Theory«, in: Forrest, Henderson & Williams (Hrsg.): *Urban Political Economy and Social Theory*. vgl. Peter Saunders: *Social Theory and the Urban Question*. London, Hutchinson, 2. Ausgabe, 1986; es sollte erwähnt werden, dass Castells seine Meinung in späteren Arbeiten über Lefèbvre änderte und abmilderte; wichtig ist auch David Harveys Arbeit *Social Justice and the City*. Oxford, Blackwell, 1973

65 Kristin Ross: *The Emergence of Social Space*. S. 9; Edward Soja: *Postmodern Geographies*, London, Verso 1989, S.69-70, 76ff.

66 Edward Soja: *Postmodern Geographies*. S. 42.

67 Soja diskutiert diese Kritikpunkte in dem »Postmodern Spaces« genannten Papier, veröffentlicht im Juli 1995: *Signs of the Times Conference. Postmodern Times*, City University, London

68 Edward Soja: *Postmodern Geographies*. S. 248

69 Lynn Stewart, »Bodies, Visions and Spatial Politics: a Review Essay of Henri Lefèbvre's The Production of Space«, in: *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space*, 13, 1995, S. 617

70 *La production de l'espace*. S.57, 130-131, 144; wichtige Anstöße in *The Explosion,* ein kurzer Text, in dem er die Ereignisse vom Mai 1968 betrachtet, und den speziellen Status von »urbanen Phänomenen« heraushebt, und seine Analyse von Paris 1781 in *La proclamation de la commune*. Paris, Gallimard, 1965; es sollte Lefèbvres Kritik am Strukturalismus in Bezug auf den Raum hervorgehoben werden, mit Blick darauf, dass der Strukturalismus der Zeit keinen angemessenen Status einräumt; vgl. *The Survival of Capitalism*. S.65-66, vgl. Stuart Elden, *Mapping the Present*

71 es ist bezeichnend, dass Soja und andere sich stark auf Foucaults 1967 gehaltene Vorlesung »Des Espaces Autres«, in: *Dits et écrits*. Paris, Gallimard, 1994, Band IV beziehen, der Foucaults expliziteste Veranschaulichung der Geschichte des Raumes ist, ohne dabei auf die räumliche Geschichte in seinem gesamten Werk zu achten; vgl. Stuart Elden: *Mapping the Present*. Kapitel 4 & 5

72 *La production de l'espace*. S. 465

73 *Le temps des méprises*. Paris, Stock, 1975, S. 238

74 *La production de l'espace*. S. 465, S.236-238; *Hegel, Marx, Nietzsche ou le royaume des ombres*. Paris, Casterman, 1975, S.191-192, 195-196; *Éléments de rythmanalyse: Introduction à la connaissance de rythmes*. Paris, Éditions Syllepse, 1992

75 *Le temps des méprise.*, S. 240

76 »Toward a Leftist Cultural Politics«, S. 76; darüber, und auch als nützliche Zusammenfassung einiger seiner Ideen, vgl. die Diskussion zwischen Lefèbvre und Leskek Kolakowski, »Evolution or Revolution«, in: Fons Elders (Hrsg.): *Reflexive Water: The Basic Concerns of Mankind*. London, Souvenir Press, 1974

77 »Toward a Leftist Cultural Politics«. S. 77

78 Eleonore Kofman & Elizabeth Lebas: »Lost in Transposition – Time, Space and the City«, in: *Writings on Cities*. S. 5

79 *La production de l'espace*. S. 485

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I. Einführung

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Natur im Diskurs

Wenn im Titel dieses Buches *Leib* als die Natur, die wir selbst sind, bezeichnet wird, so mag dies anstößig wirken. In jedem Fall enthält es ein Paradox: Es wird hier zusammengebracht, was eigentlich auf die zwei Seiten einer Dichotomie zu verteilen ist, nämlich der Dichotomie zwischen dem Aktiven und dem Pathischen. Wir sind uns selbst als Natur gegeben, *Natursein* geschieht uns. Der Begriff des Selbstseins dagegen suggeriert eine Aktivität, unterstellt, dass, worum es dabei geht, von einem Selbst gestaltet, wenn nicht gar zu verantworten ist. Dieses Paradox besteht darin, dass wir in unser bewusstes Verhalten zu uns selbst unser Natursein aufnehmen, also etwas, über das wir nicht verfügen können. Dieses Paradox beschreibt aber sehr gut unsere Situation, die *existentielle* Seinweise. Sie ist als solche in der philosophischen Anthropologie durchaus anerkannt. Etwa bei Helmuth Plessner mit der Exzentrizität unseres Daseins; bei Sartre mit der Formel, dass wir sind, was wir nicht sind, und nicht sind, was wir sind; bei mir in meiner ersten Arbeit zur Anthropologie[1] mit dem Begriff des *Risses im Sein.* Man könnte sogar sagen, dass in der uralten, auf Aristoteles zurückgehenden Definition des Menschen als *zoon logon echon* oder lateinisch als *animal rationale* ebenfalls eine paradoxe Definition des Menschseins gegeben wurde. Ich stelle mich mit meiner Definition des Leibes durchaus in diese Tradition. Es liegt mir nur daran herauszuarbeiten, dass wir, indem wir uns selbst gegeben sind, mit uns qua Natur zu tun haben – um damit in gewisser Weise die bisher existierende Leibphilosophie zu korrigieren oder wenigstens doch zu ergänzen. Ebenso gilt es, den heute aktuellen Diskurs über *Natur* zu korrigieren beziehungsweise zu ergänzen – nämlich dahingehend, dass wir in unserer Leiberfahrung mit uns selbst qua Natur zu tun haben, und das heißt für den Naturdiskurs: dass wir *Natur* keineswegs bloß als etwas Äußerliches kennen, sondern sie vielmehr auch quasi von innen, nämlich in unserer Selbsterfahrung, kennenlernen.

1 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Anthropologie in pragmatischer Hinsicht. Darmstädter Vorlesungen* [1985], aktualisierte und erweiterte Neuausgabe mit Nachwort, Bielefeld, Basel 2010.

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Durch die Formulierung *kennenlernen* deute ich bereits an, dass durch die Definition *Leib: die Natur, die wir selbst sind* sehr wohl *Leib* bestimmt ist, aber keineswegs als Faktum, sondern vielmehr als Aufgabe. Sowohl das *Natur-selbst-Sein* versteht sich nicht von selbst, ebenso nicht, *Natur* quasi von innen beziehungsweise in Selbsterfahrung kennenzulernen. Zwar sind wir von gewissen leiblichen Regungen wie dem Schmerz unausweichlich betroffen, und wir erfahren diese Regungen als aus einem Grunde stammend, den wir zunächst und zumeist nicht selbst sind, und doch sind wir eben *unausweichlich* betroffen, weil solche Regungen, insbesondere der Schmerz, uns gerade anzeigen, dass, was uns da trifft – so fremd und lästig es gerade sein mag, eben zu uns gehört, uns *zu eigen* ist.

Es geht also im Folgenden einerseits um den Leib als Naturerfahrung und andererseits um die Einführung des Leibbegriffs in den Diskurs über die Natur. Zunächst zu Ersterem.

Es ist erstaunlich, dass in der mittlerweile ausgearbeiteten und wirkungsvollen Phänomenologie menschlicher Leiblichkeit das Natursein des Menschen nicht thematisiert wurde. Das mag, wie bei Hermann Schmitz, ein bewusstes Ausweichen sein – er wollte nicht, dass seine Anthropologie in die Dichotomie von Natur und Geist zurückfiele. Es mag aber auch daran liegen, dass die Phänomenologie sich generell im Gegenzug zur Naturwissenschaft versteht und damit einer Thematisierung des menschlichen Leibes als Natur misstraut, weil damit die Gefahr gegeben wäre, ihn doch wieder als Gegenstand der Naturwissenschaft, nämlich als Organismus, zu behandeln. Folge dieser Vermeidung des Naturbegriffs in der Leibphilosophie ist die erstaunliche Tatsache, dass die Geschlechtlichkeit in dieser Philosophie praktisch keine Rolle spielt. Insofern ist die Arbeit von Ute Gahlings über die *Phänomenologie weiblicher Leiberfahrungen*[2] ein ganz wesentliches Korrektiv.

Wenn ich sagte *praktisch keine Rolle spielt*, so weil es in Merleau-Pontys Buch *Phänomenologie der Wahrnehmung* das Kapitel V »Der Leib als geschlechtliches Sein« gibt und es ja gerade als eine der wesentlichen Errungenschaften Merleau-Pontys gilt, von der *Inkarnation* des Ich beziehungsweise des Subjekts Kenntnis zu neh-

2 Siehe Ute Gahlings, *Phänomenologie der weiblichen Leiberfahrungen*, Freiburg ^{2}2016.

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men.[3] Diese Inkarnation hat unter dem Titel *embodiment* geradezu einen Siegeszug um die ganze Welt vollbracht und vertritt oder besser gesagt: verdrängt dadurch die Thematisierung des Leibes als solchen.[4] Der Grund dafür, dass Merleau-Ponty den Leib in der einseitigen und damit unzureichenden Weise der Inkarnation des Ich entdeckt, liegt in der – für einen französischen Philosophen typischen – vorausgesetzten Selbstsicherheit des Ich, des Ich-denke, das heißt in seinem Kartesianismus – oder allgemeiner gesehen: in dem Vorrang, den man dem Handeln bis dato – oder sagen wir besser bis zu Hermann Schmitz:[5] in der philosophischen Anthropologie zuschrieb. Geschlechtlichkeit wird deshalb von Merleau-Ponty vom Bewusstsein her verstanden, und Bewusstsein ist für ihn mit Edmund Husserl immer Bewusstsein von etwas, also intentional. *Embodiment* ist damit eine Weise, wie Bewusstsein sich sinnlich in die Welt der Gegenständlichkeit ausstreckt. Das ist die Inkarnation: »Der Begierde aber eignet ein Verstehen, das ›blindlings‹ Körper mit Körper verbindet. So ist selbst die Geschlechtlichkeit, die man doch lange genug als typisches Beispiel einer bloßen Körperfunktion betrachtet hat, keineswegs ein peripherer Automatismus, sondern Intentionalität, die der Bewegung der Existenz selbst folgt […].«[6] Geschlechtlichkeit wird also von Merleau-Ponty durchweg von der Begierde her verstanden, das heißt einem aktiven Zugriff auf den Anderen. Es entgeht ihm dabei die Selbsterfahrung im leiblichen Spüren, also das Pathische. Der Leib als solcher taucht dabei gar nicht auf, allenfalls noch bei der Behandlung der *Exhibition,* in der man quasi seine eigene Subjekthaftigkeit zurückstellt, um den anderen Menschen zu faszinieren. Auch hier geht es ihm um eine Strategie, also noch um verdecktes Handeln, bei dem man durch Verführung sich »dem anderen Menschen widerstandslos ausliefern [will], so daß es der Andere sein wird, der ihm zum Sklaven verfällt«.[7]

3 Siehe Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phänomenologie der Wahrnehmung*, Berlin 1966, S. 251 bzw. S. 185.

4 Siehe dazu auch das Kapitel »*Embodiment*, Leib und der mündige Patient« in diesem Band.

5 Siehe Gernot Böhme, »Leibsein als Aufgabe«, Rez. von Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*, Bd. II.1, in: *Hippokrates* 40 (1969), 186-191.

6 Ebd., S. 188.

7 Merleau-Ponty, *Phänomenologie der Wahrnehmung*, S. 199.

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Wie Sartre in *Das Sein und das Nichts*[8] interpretiert er die Situation hegelsch als Herr/Knecht-Dialektik, als Auseinandersetzung zweier Subjekte.

Man entgeht dieser Dialektik und damit der Verdeckung der Leiblichkeit durch die Strategie der Inkarnation nur, wenn man in der Analyse nicht das Subjekt, das Ich, den Willen schlicht voraussetzt, sondern vielmehr umgekehrt, die Etablierung einer Ich-Instanz als Ausdifferenzierung aus einer ursprünglichen Selbstgegebenheit, nämlich der Selbstgegebenheit qua Leib herleitet.[9] Der Leib ist die Natur, die uns im leiblichen Spüren gegeben ist. Dieses Spüren ist die Erfahrung von Natur, nämlich von etwas, das mir gegeben ist und das als etwas, was von selbst da ist (die Griechen kannten das *automaton* als Kennzeichen der Natur), das aber – wie das Beispiel *Schmerz* zeigt – trotz seines fremden und befremdlichen Charakters seine Mir-Zugehörigkeit signalisiert. Die eigene Natur wird also in *betroffener Selbstgegebenheit* erfahren. Und allerdings, *was* da erfahren wird, ist durchaus mein Organismus, aber nicht, wie ich ihn in gegenständlicher Kenntnis konstatieren kann, sondern wie er sich mir in leiblichen Regungen aufdrängt.

Auch bei Hermann Schmitz, dessen Leibphänomenologie wohl im weltweiten Vergleich ausgeführt ist wie keine andere, hat zwar die Analyse von Vorgängen, die eindeutig zu uns als Lebewesen gehören, ihren Platz. Gleichwohl wird sie keineswegs so geführt, dass sie als Erfahrung der Natur, die wir selbst sind, deutlich würden, geschweige denn als Lebensvollzüge, die zu uns in unserem Sein in der äußeren Natur und mit der äußeren Natur gehören. So etwa beim Thema Atmen. Für Schmitz ist das Atmen – in Erinnerung an Goethe als *systole* und *diastole* analysiert – ein Phänomen der Dynamik leiblicher Ökonomie.[10] Das heißt also: das Atmen wird beschrieben als ein Spiel innerhalb der Polarität von Enge und Weite, nämlich als jeweiliges Verhältnis von Spannung und Schwellung. So ist das Ausatmen beispielsweise ein »gerichtetes Vermitteln

8 Jean-Paul Sartre, *Das Sein und das Nichts. Versuch einer phänomenologischen Ontologie*, Hamburg: 1966, S. 498-500.

9 Siehe dazu das Kapitel »Eingedenken der Natur im Subjekt«, in*:* Gernot Böhme, *Ethik leiblicher Existenz,* Frankfurt/M. 2008, S. 136-149.

10 Siehe dazu Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*. Bd II.1: *Der Leib*, Bonn 1964 f., § 49 f.

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von Enge an Weite«.[11] Kein Wort dazu, dass man im Atmen das eigene Natursein erfährt. So kann man beispielsweise nach langem Ausatmen gewissermaßen am Tiefpunkt der Atmung erfahren, wie das Atmen *von selbst* wieder einsetzt. Die Erfahrung dieses *von selbst* ist, um es noch einmal mit den Griechen zu sagen, die Erfahrung des *automaton*, und das heißt also die Erfahrung, dass unser Sein qua Leben von selbst immer wieder einsetzt und dass wir so von der Natur *getragen* sind. Kein Wort auch bei Schmitz, dass das Atmen eine ständige Auseinandersetzung mit der Natur, die wir nicht sind, nämlich der uns umgebenden Luft ist. Nach Paracelsus sind wir bekanntlich *Luftwesen*, nämlich Lebewesen, die im Medium der Luft leben. Allerdings wird im alltäglichen Leben dieses Leben mit der Luft und die Angewiesenheit auf die Luft nicht spürbar. Sie ist – wie Heidegger sagen würde – immer unauffällig *zu handen.* Das kann sich aber durchaus ändern, und die Luft, die wir einatmen, kann erfrischend oder stickig wirken und uns etwa in Smoglagen das Atmen wirklich schwer machen. In der Regel bedarf es bewusster Atemübungen, um sich im Atmen des In- und Mitseins mit der Luft zu versichern. Das kann beispielsweise geschehen, indem man die Lippen anfeuchtet und so den Luftstrom im Atmen spürt. Es kann aber auch geschehen, indem man explizit darauf achtet, wie die Luft, die wir atmen, in affektiver Betroffenheit wahrgenommen wird – ich erwähnte schon die frische und die stickige Luft –, insbesondere ist aber hier an das Riechen zu denken. Riechend können wir uns geradezu im *Dunstkreis*, der uns umgibt, wie in einer Wolke verlieren.[12] Schließlich ist das Atmen als Erfahrung des Leibes als Ergänzung zu Hermann Schmitz' Analyse, der mit seinem Leibinselkonzept den Leib grundsätzlich als opakes Volumen behandelt, zu ergänzen, dass im Atmen der Leib auch als Hohlraum oder als Mannigfaltigkeit von Hohlräumen erfahren werden kann.[13]

11 Ebd., S. 100.

12 Siehe dazu Mephistopheles' Bemerkung gegenüber Faust, während sie sich in Gretchens Stube einschleichen: Er könne sich »in ihrem Dunstkreis satt weiden«, *Faust I*, 2671, siehe Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Sämtliche Werke, Briefe, Tagebücher und Gespräche*, Frankfurter Ausgabe [FA] in 40 Bd., hg. v. Friedmar Apel u. a., Frankfurt/M., Berlin 1987-2013, I. Abt., Bd. 7.1: *Faust. Texte*, hg. v. Albrecht Schöne, Frankfurt/M. 1994, S. 114.

13 Zu diesen Erfahrungen siehe explizit Gahlings, *Phänomenologie weiblicher Leiberfahrungen.*

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In Analogie zu der Erfahrung der Luft im Atmen dürfte es sich lohnen, phänomenologische Untersuchungen dazu zu machen, wie wir in der Erfahrung unseres Leibes als der Natur, die wir selbst sind, zugleich auch das Wasser oder allgemeiner das Flüssige, das wir nicht selbst sind, erfahren. Es würde dabei um die mannigfaltigen Erfahrungen des Trinkens gehen, aber eben auch um das Schwimmen als spürbares Sein in einem natürlichen Medium.

So weit also zu der Forderung, in der Leibphänomenologie die Natur, die wir selbst sind, zu berücksichtigen. Und nun zu der Verortung des vorliegenden Buches im aktuellen Naturdiskurs.

Der Naturdiskurs, wie er uns gegenwärtig beschäftigt – und mit *uns* sind keineswegs bloß die Philosophinnen und Philosophen und die Gemeinde der Wissenschaftlerinnen und Wissenschaftler gemeint, sondern durchaus auch die Öffentlichkeit von Politik und Jurisprudenz –, nahm seinen Ausgang mit und in der Zeit von Jean-Jacques Rousseau und hatte seinen Grund in einem, mit Sigmund Freud gesprochen, *Unbehagen in der Kultur*.[14] Kunsthistoriker wie Matthias Eberle[15] gehen zeitlich noch ein Stück weiter zurück, wenn sie behaupten, dass *Landschaft* eine ästhetische Entdeckung des Stadtbürgers war, der, beengt nicht bloß durch die Mauern, sondern beengt durch die Menge sozialer Regelungen – von den rechtlichen über die Marktregeln, die ständischen Regeln, die Kleiderordnung, die strengen Zunftregeln –, Natur *da draußen,* vor den Mauern suchte. In jedem Fall kann man sagen, dass der Naturdiskurs, der uns beschäftigt, ein *moderner* Diskurs ist, nämlich wenn man als Moderne die Neuzeit bezeichnet. Dieser Diskurs verschärfte sich allerdings mit der industriellen Revolution, also etwa seit 1800, als nämlich Natur nicht mehr einfach als Reich der Freiheit im Gegensatz zum Bereich der Zivilisation verstanden werden konnte, sondern als menschliche Lebensgrundlage ins Bewusstsein trat. Es war die Hüttenrauch-Diskussion im 19. Jahrhundert, die zur Naturschutzbewegung, es war das Sterben der Wälder durch industriebedingte Versauerung der Luft und das Dahinschwinden der Ozonschicht durch FCKW-Emissionen

14 Sigmund Freud, *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur*, in: Ders., *Gesammelte Werke*, Bd. XIV: Werke aus den Jahren 1925-1931, Frankfurt/M. ^{5}1976, S. 419-513.

15 Matthias Eberle, *Individuum und Landschaft*, Gießen 1980.

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(ab 1974) und die Erderwärmung durch CO_2 (ab 1985),[16] was zur Klimadiskussion führte. Diese Diskussion führte zu der Einsicht, dass *die Natur* keineswegs ein unendliches Reservoir, insbesondere nicht ein sich selbst stabilisierendes System war, dem gegenüber die Einwirkungen des Menschen als ein durch Produktions- und Konsumformen organisiertes Kollektiv irrelevant waren. War mit Rousseau – aber auch, freilich im anderen Sinne, mit Hobbes – Natur im Gegensatz zu Zivilisation als ein hypothetisch angenommener Urzustand friedlichen Zusammenlebens beziehungsweise als ein Krieg aller gegen alle verstanden worden, so trat mit der neueren Phase des Diskurses etwa in der Mitte des 19. Jahrhundert die Natur als menschlicher Lebensraum in den Blick mit dem Resultat: dass es diesen Lebensraum zu schützen galt.

Man kann diese Phase auch als Phase des Diskurses über das *Schwinden* der Natur bezeichnen, und zwar nicht nur der faktischen Natur da draußen, sondern auch des Dahinschwindens des Naturbegriffs als einer kulturellen, nämlich normativen Ressource. Beides hängt zusammen, weil nämlich – freilich kurzsichtig – in der Kritik des menschlichen, des zivilisatorischen Verhaltens, dann aber der industriellen Ausbeutung von Natur *die Natur da draußen* als der Bereich galt, der von sich aus da ist und als solcher gut.[17] Angesichts dieser Diskurslage hat Rolf Peter Sieferle von der Krise der menschlichen Natur[18] geschrieben, hat Michel Serres einen *Naturvertrag* gefordert,[19] hat Klaus Michael Meyer-Abich an einen *vergessenen Traum* erinnert,[20] hat mein Bruder Hartmut Böhme von *Aussichten der Natur* gesprochen,[21] indem er dem Naturkonzept – jedenfalls in diesem Buch – nur als ästhetischem eine Chance gibt.

16 Zum Zusammenhang der beiden letztgenannten Umweltprobleme siehe Hans-Jochen Luhmann, »Was wäre wenn… – Die klimapolitische Bedeutung der Warnung von Rowland und Molina vor den ozonschichtzerstörenden Substanzen«, in: *diskutabel* 03 (2008), S. 12-15.

17 Siehe dazu Gernot Böhme, *Natürlich Natur. Über Natur im Zeitalter ihrer technischen Reproduzierbarkeit*, Frankfurt/M. ^{3}1997.

18 Rolf Peter Sieferle, *Die Krise der menschlichen Natur. Zur Geschichte eines Konzepts*, Frankfurt/M. 1989.

19 Michel Serres, *Der Naturvertrag*, Frankfurt/M. 1994.

20 Klaus Michael Meyer-Abich, *Praktische Naturphilosophie. Erinnerung an einen vergessenen Traum*, München 1997.

21 Hartmut Böhme, *Aussichten der Natur. Naturästhetik in Wechselwirkung von Natur und Kultur*, Berlin 2016.

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Ich selbst habe mit dem Buch *Die Natur vor uns*[22] im Einklang mit Ernst Ulrich von Weizsäcker[23] mit einer Kehrtwende gegen Rousseau behauptet, dass Natur sowohl als menschlicher Lebensraum wie auch als Bestandteil menschlichen Selbstverständnisses als Aufgabe *vor* uns liegt. In jüngster Zeit haben nun wortgewaltige Autoren wie Bruno Latour und Philippe Descola versucht, den soeben geschilderten neuzeitlichen Naturdiskurs überhaupt zu kippen. Beiden ist gemeinsam, dass sie philosophierende Autoren sind, die aus der Ethnologie beziehungsweise der soziologisch orientierten Anthropologie stammen und deshalb – wohl methodisch der strukturalen Anthropologie eines Lévi-Strauss folgend – den Naturbegriff nicht für sich, sondern als Pol im Doppelbegriff Natur/Kultur behandeln. Freilich impliziert das – zumindest bei Bruno Latour, dessen historische Bildung bis zu Descartes, allenfalls noch bis zu Galilei zurückreicht – eine historische Kurzsichtigkeit. Denn wenn zwar auch ursprünglich – das heißt bei den Vorsokratikern – Natur qua *Physis* das Ganze des Seienden bezeichnete, so war doch seit dem Sophisten Antiphon – oder literarisch belegt seit Aristoteles – mit *Natur* ein Gegenbegriff zu Technik, Gesetzgebung, zu *nomos* als gesellschaftlicher Ordnung konzipiert. Das von Natur Seiende ist nach Aristoteles, was von selbst da ist und das Prinzip seiner Bewegung und Veränderung, also auch das Prinzip seiner Reproduktion, in sich trägt.[24] Das, was durch Technik da ist, dagegen bedarf des Menschen, nämlich insbesondere des Handwerkers oder des *Techniten* zu seiner Herstellung beziehungsweise Wiederherstellung. Latour war oder ist nun besonders stolz darauf, dass er meint, in Natur/Kultur das Prinzip der Moderne gefunden zu haben, um von daher uns, den Menschen der Moderne, vorzuwerfen, wir seien nie modern gewesen – nämlich weil wir immer schon Mischwesen oder Hybride zwischen Natur und Kultur hergestellt hätten, um sie aber gleichzeitig ideologisch als solche zu verschleiern.[25] Dabei übersieht er gänzlich, dass bereits die antike Unterscheidung von *physe on*, dem, was von Natur aus da ist,

22 Gernot Böhme, *Die Natur vor uns. Naturphilosophie in pragmatischer Hinsicht*, Zug 2002.

23 Ernst Ulrich von Weizsäcker, *Erdpolitik. Ökologische Realpolitik an der Schwelle zum Jahrhundert der Umwelt*, Darmstadt ^{2}1990.

24 Aristoteles, *Physik*, 192b20-193a28.

25 Bruno Latour, *Wir sind nie modern gewesen. Versuch einer symmetrischen Anthropologie*, Frankfurt/M. 1998.

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und *techne on*, dem, was durch menschliches Verhalten da ist, mitten durch den Menschen selbst hindurchgeht. Der Mensch ist sich selbst qua Natur gegeben, bildet sich aber in seinem Charakter und Verhalten als Kulturwesen aus.[26] Latour entgeht entsprechend auch gänzlich, dass es in dem Naturdiskurs der Moderne, insbesondere im Naturschutz nicht um den Schutz der Natur an sich ging, sondern vielmehr um Natur als menschlichem Lebensraum, das heißt die immer schon kulturell gestaltete Natur, nämlich die durch Forstwirtschaft und Ackerbau gestaltete Natur. Allenfalls in den USA, die ja in der Frühphase immer noch Natur als Wildnis vor Augen hatten, konnte etwa in der Naturphilosophie eines Emerson[27] Natur geschätzt werden als Bereich des von Menschenhand Unberührten.

Philippe Descola versucht nun, in seinem Buch aus der Perspektive der Ethnologie die Dichotomie Natur/Kultur als eine, im Weltmaßstab gesehen, Besonderheit der europäischen Zivilisation zu relativieren. Dabei übersieht er gänzlich, dass diese Zivilisation als technische Zivilisation quasi imperialistisch ist, das heißt heute den ganzen Globus überzieht und allenfalls regional beziehungsweise für die Feiertage der Mannigfaltigkeit der Kulturen noch Raum lässt.[28] Das Unglück ist nur, dass diese anderen, nichteuropäischen Kulturen gerade wegen des Mangels der Entgegensetzung von Natur und Kultur auch nicht die kritischen Ressourcen gegen die invasive Technisierung[29] entwickelt haben, die deren Siegeszug seit dem 18.,[30] spätestens seit dem 19. Jahrhundert begleitet haben.

Bruno Latour nun glaubt in seinem Buch *Kampf um Gaia*,[31]

26 Interessant, dass Kant im guten Gespür für diese Differenz eine *Anthropologie in pragmatischer Hinsicht* – in der er nämlich zeigt, was der Mensch im Wissen um sich aus sich machen kann – und eine *Anthropologie in physiologischer Hinsicht* – also das, was der Mensch als Naturwesen ist – in seinen Vorlesungen unterschieden hat.

27 Ralph Waldo Emerson, *Natur*, Schaffhausen 1981.

28 Philippe Descola, *Jenseits von Natur und Kultur*, Berlin 2011.

29 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Invasive Technisierung. Technikphilosophie und Technikkritik*, Kusterdingen, 2008.

30 Bei dieser sehr früh sich regenden Technikkritik bzw. Industrialisierungskritik ist an Goethes besorgte Beobachtung der Modernisierung zu erinnern. Siehe Gernot Böhme, »Goethe und die moderne Zivilisation«, in: *Goethe Yearbook* XXII (2015), S. 133-141.

31 Bruno Latour, *Kampf um Gaia. Acht Vorträge über das neue Klimaregime*, Berlin 2017.

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die Instabilität des Verhältnisses Natur/Kultur, die Aussichtslosigkeit des Ökologie-Diskurses, die »uns schier verrückt macht«,[32] im Blick auf das Gaia-Konzept von James Lovelock überschreiten zu können.[33] Gaia ist seit der griechischen Antike ein mythologischer Name für die Erde im Ganzen. So gesehen ist Latours Buch das Plädoyer dafür, sich nicht auf eine diffus unendliche Natur zu beziehen, sondern vielmehr auf den Teil der Natur, aus dem wir konkret leben, nämlich die Erde. Das klingt ganz vernünftig, ist aber verblüffend, weil er glaubt, dadurch den Naturbegriff überhaupt hinter sich lassen zu können. Insbesondere aber ist die vielleicht fruchtbare und empfehlenswerte Einschränkung des Interesses auf Natur qua Erde kurzsichtig, weil die Erde als Körper des Sonnensystems – und deshalb insbesondere in Bezug auf ihren Energiehaushalt von der Sonne abhängig – ein Teil des Kosmos ist und ihre kosmische Natur im Innern auch weiterhin birgt: Die Natur als menschlicher Lebensraum sind ja nur die ganz dünne Oberflächenschicht der Erde und die unteren Ebenen der Atmosphäre. Was die Erde als kosmisches Objekt darstellt, bekommen die Menschen immer wieder durch das zu spüren, was sie *Naturkatastrophen* nennen. Wenn Latour also quasi mit moralischer Geste eine Konzentration auf Erdpolitik fordert, so nimmt es doch wunder, dass er kein Wort darüber verliert, dass der Mensch längst durch Weltraumtechnologie in den Kosmos ausgreift und dass – zumindest in der Science-Fiction – Lebensräume auch außerhalb der Erde konzipiert werden.

Wenn Latour auch die Arbeit von Lovelock sehr ausführlich würdigt, so folgt er ihm doch gerade in dem entscheidenden Punkt nicht, nämlich dass die Erde eine Art Großlebewesen ist, eine sich selbst regulierende Ganzheit, deren Soll gerade darin besteht, den schmalen Spielraum im Spektrum der vielen Zustandsparameter (Durchschnittstemperatur, Zusammensetzung der Atmosphäre etc.) offenzuhalten, der auf der Erde – und das heißt hier: von der Tiefe des Meeres bis zu den niederen Schichten der Atmosphäre – Leben ermöglicht. Für Latour ist Gaia gerade kein Ganzes, sondern eine Mannigfaltigkeit von Rückkopplungsschleifen, die von *Agenten* in Gang gehalten werden und in ihrer Auseinandersetzung

32 Ebd., S. 72.

33 Von den zahlreichen Büchern Lovelocks sei hier nur hingewiesen auf *Gaia. Die Erde ist ein Lebewesen. Anatomie und Physiologie des Organismus Erde*, Bern u. a. 1992.

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eine Evolution von Gaia vorantreiben. Dabei sind nach Latours *Agency*-Theorie Steine, Lebewesen, Menschen etc. in gleicher Weise Agenten und die Menschen nicht als Einzelne, sondern als technisch und wirtschaftlich organisiertes Kollektiv eine Wirkmacht, die sich als Gaia-gestaltende Rückkopplungsschleife auswirkt. Die Auseinandersetzung der verschiedenen Rückkopplungsschleifen beziehungsweise der sie vorantreibenden Wirkmächte sieht Latour nun im Anschluss an Carl Schmitt und dessen Definition des Politischen durch die Freund-Feind-Dichotomie nicht als Entgegensetzungen, sondern als Feindschaften. Deshalb läuft sein Buch, das in der deutschen Übersetzung noch relativ harmlos mit *Kampf um Gaia* betitelt ist, schließlich auf Krieg hinaus.[34] Freilich, sosehr sich Latour als Materialist gibt und sich explizit vom Idealisten Hegel absetzt,[35] ist der Kampf um Gaia, von dem er redet, letzten Endes ein ideologischer Krieg: Das Volk der »Erdverbundenen«,[36] deren Territorium nicht geographisch festzumachen ist, sondern aus *Netzwerken* besteht,[37] diese Kriegspartei der »Gaianer« also, zu der sich Latour selbst rechnet, sieht ihren Feind in den »Menschen«,[38] die sich halbmodern noch für die Natur und ihre Erhaltung einsetzen. Der Kampf um Gaia wird also als literarischer Krieg ausgefochten, und Bruno Latours Buch ist ganz selbstreflexiv ein Instrument in diesem Krieg.

Um mit dieser Einleitung zum Schluss zu kommen: Was hat nun die Durchsicht der Leibphänomenologie und des modernen Naturdiskurses mit der Frage, ob darin jeweils Leib als die Natur, die wir selbst sind, eine Rolle spielt, erbracht, und was könnte die Zusammenführung beider Diskurse, die in diesem Buch versucht wird, für Folgen haben?

In dem ökologisch motivierten modernen Naturdiskurs kommt die Natur des Menschen, insofern wir sie qua Leib selbst sind, nicht vor. Wenn es um den Menschen geht, der in der Natur ist, so wird

34 Terminologisch auch im Französischen, siehe Bruno Latour, *Face à Gaïa. Huit conférences sur le nouveau régime climatique*, Paris 2015; siehe darin besonders den siebten Vortrag: »Die Staaten (der Natur) zwischen Krieg und Frieden«, S. 373-429.

35 Siehe Latour, *Kampf um Gaia*, S. 73.

36 Ebd., S. 418.

37 Ebd., S. 425.

38 Ebd., S. 418.

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er als Organismus unter anderen behandelt, der allerdings, ökonomisch und technisch organisiert, eine bedeutende Wirkmacht darstellt. Dies führt, insofern diese Wirkmacht die menschliche Lebensgrundlage Natur zu zerstören droht beziehungsweise die Rückkopplungsschleifen, die im Ganzen Gaia ausmachen, aus dem Gleichgewicht zu bringen drohen, jedoch lediglich zum politisch-juristischen und ökonomisch schonenden Umgang mit der Natur qua Erde. Das geht über den traditionellen Naturschutz, über die Definition von Reservaten und Grenzwerten, nicht hinaus. Auch die neuesten Berichte an den Club of Rome sind hier keine Ausnahme.[39] Eine wirkliche Alternative innerhalb des modernen Naturdiskurses stellt das schon genannte Buch von Klaus Michael Meyer-Abich dar. Darin findet sich auch eine Anerkennung meiner Vorschläge, »auf menschliche Weise Natur zu sein«.[40] Freilich überzieht er seine eigene Kategorie des *Mitseins*, wenn er meine Rede von der außermenschlichen Natur als der Natur, die wir nicht selbst sind, kritisiert: »Tier und Blume, Baum und Stein sind nicht die Natur, die wir nicht sind, sondern wir sind auch Tiere, Pflanzen und Elemente.«[41]

Im Leibdiskurs – so nenne ich hier einmal die Phänomenologie der menschlichen Leiblichkeit – kommt die Natur und damit das menschliche Natursein überhaupt nicht vor. Die Phänomenologie hat die Behandlung der menschlichen Natur faktisch der Naturwissenschaft überlassen, von der sie sich aber gerade qua Phänomenologie entschieden absetzt. Dabei begibt sie sich nicht nur der Chance, die Regung, die im leiblichen Spüren aufsteigt, als Erfahrung der eigenen Natur zu verstehen, sondern darüber hinaus der Entwicklung einer allgemeinen Phänomenologie der Natur, wie sie mit Goethes Naturwissenschaft ihren Anfang nahm.[42]

39 Siehe Jørgen Randers, *2052. Der neue Bericht an den Club of Rome. Eine globale Prognose für die nächsten 40 Jahre*, München ²2014; Ernst Ulrich von Weizsäcker, Anders Wijkman u. a., *Wir sind dran. Club of Rome: Der große Bericht: Was wir ändern müssen, wenn wir bleiben wollen. Eine neue Aufklärung für eine volle Welt*, Gütersloh 2018. Letzteres Buch enthält aber über die klassische Forderung des schonenden Umgangs mit der Natur in Teil 3 auch eine ganze Reihe von Alternativen, also z. B. alternatives Wirtschaften, alternative Wirtschaftstheorien, alternative Energie-Technologien etc.

40 Meyer-Abich, *Praktische Naturphilosophie*, S. 75.

41 Ebd.

42 Siehe dazu Gernot Böhme, »Goethes Naturwissenschaft als Phänomenologie der

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Die Folgen einer Zusammenführung beider Diskurse liegen jedoch nicht nur vornehmlich auf der kognitiven Ebene, sondern betreffen die Praxis des Umgangs sowohl mit uns selbst als auch mit der äußeren Natur. Natur ist in beiden Bereichen kein Faktum, das sich konstatieren und beschreiben ließe, sondern vielmehr eine Aufgabe, die zunächst entwickelt werden und dann in der Praxis eingeübt werden muss.

Zunächst zur Natur im menschlichen Selbstverständnis: Seit der klassischen Definition des Menschen als *animal rationale*, also als ein Lebewesen, das Verstand hat, gehört ja das Natursein des Menschen eigentlich zu seinem Selbstverständnis. Doch eben nur *eigentlich*, denn nicht wirklich explizit und vor allem nicht praktiziert. Schon die Definition selbst in der klassischen Form des *genus proximum* und der *differentia specifica* nennt die Rationalität als dasjenige, was den Menschen qua Menschen ausmacht und ihn von allen anderen Lebewesen unterscheidet. Das kann in der Praxis bedeuten und hat bis weit in die Pädagogik hinein in der Praxis auch wirklich bedeutet: die Disziplinierung dessen, was am Menschen Natur ist, seine Verdrängung und die mögliche Emanzipation von der Natur. Die Leibphänomenologie und insbesondere das Verständnis des Leibes als die Natur, die wir selbst sind, verlangt dagegen eine Praxis, in der dieses Natursein des Menschen bewusst übernommen und eingeübt wird. Dadurch erhalten Lebensvollzüge wie Atmen, Sich-Ernähren, Gehen oder Schwimmen ein ganz anderes Gewicht: In ihnen vollzieht sich, was es heißt, ein Mensch zu sein. Doch was bedeutet das für die Beziehung des Menschen zur äußeren Natur? Handelt es sich bei der expliziten Übernahme des eigenen Naturseins etwa bloß um Selbstbildung und den Versuch, *gut Mensch zu sein*?[43] Die Konsequenzen in der Beziehung zur äußeren Natur zeichnen sich in Meyer-Abichs Kategorie des *Mitseins* schon – wenn vielleicht auch in *zu netter* Weise – ab. Tatsächlich geht es darum, eine neue Kultur des Umgangs mit der äußeren Natur und den anderen Lebewesen, die wir nicht sind, zu entwickeln. Doch wichtiger scheint mir dagegen die Kategorie des *Inseins.* Der Naturdiskurs, insofern er ökologisch motiviert ist, ver-

Natur«, in: Ders., (Hg.), *Über Goethes Naturwissenschaft. Schriften der Darmstädter Goethegesellschaft*, Bielefeld 2017, S. 7-16.

43 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Gut Mensch sein. Anthropologie als Proto-Ethik*, Zug 2016.

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langt ja gerade danach ernst zu nehmen, dass der Mensch in seiner Natürlichkeit *in* der Natur ist. Das heißt, es geht nicht um Natur oder Umwelt überhaupt, sondern um die menschliche Umwelt. Das bedeutet aber, dass unter ökologischen Gesichtspunkten die Natur keineswegs einfach hingenommen und gar geschont werden muss als das, was sie von sich aus ist. Vielmehr geht es um ihre Gestaltung als ein menschlicher Lebensraum. Das heißt aber nicht nur, dass die Natur als Umgebung des Menschen von der Art sein muss, dass er sein Leben darin vollziehen und reproduzieren kann, sondern auch, dass er sich darin wohl befindet. Daraus folgen zwei Maximen für den Umgang mit Natur als menschlichem Lebensraum: Erstens muss der Mensch in diesem Lebensraum seine eigene Reproduktion so einrichten, dass er zugleich mit ihr die umgebende Natur als menschlichen Lebensraum reproduziert. Man nennt das heute auch das Prinzip der Nachhaltigkeit, obgleich es seinen Ursprung im traditionell agrikulturellen und forstwirtschaftlichen Umgang mit der Natur hat.[44] Das zweite Prinzip ist das der ökologischen Naturästhetik. Hier wird ernst genommen, dass wir in der Erfahrung der Natur, die wir selbst sind, uns zugleich in bestimmter Weise als in einer Umgebung anwesend erfahren – oder unter Verwendung des Begriffs der Befindlichkeit: In unserem Befinden erfahren wir, in welcher Umgebung wir uns befinden.[45] Die Einführung des Begriffs *Leib* in den Naturdiskurs verlangt also eine Humanisierung der Natur als Umwelt.

44 Die Modernisierung dieses Begriffs als *sustainability* impliziert, dass Wirtschaftswachstum zur Nachhaltigkeit gehören sollte, so dass man von daher den paradoxen und unhaltbaren Begriff des nachhaltigen Wirtschaftswachstums bilden konnte.

45 Siehe dazu auch das Kapitel »Umweltästhetik« in diesem Band.

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Der Begriff des Leibes

1. Wozu ein Begriff des Leibes?

Obgleich die Forderung nach einem Begriff eine klassische Forderung der Philosophie ist, nämlich durch eine Definition anzugeben, was man unter einem Terminus verstehen will, beziehungsweise für eine Sache, worin sie eigentlich besteht, ist sie in der Regel kaum zu erfüllen, und es gibt auch gute Gründe dagegen, sie erfüllen zu wollen. Denn eine Definition ist immer eine Festlegung und ein Begriff ein Zugriff auf die Mannigfaltigkeit der Dinge und Erscheinungen, unter dem sie erstarren. Die Verteidigung der Vielfalt des Besonderen und, mit Adorno zu sprechen, des Nichtidentischen ist gerade etwas, was auch Ziel der Phänomenologie ist. So scheinen die Forderung nach einem Begriff und die Bewahrung der Phänomene miteinander im Streit zu liegen.

Im besonderen Maße scheint es der genetischen Phänomenologie zu widerstreiten, einen Begriff des Leibes zu formulieren. Denn ihre methodologische Grundüberzeugung besteht ja darin, dass es eine Mannigfaltigkeit von Erscheinungsweisen des Leibes beziehungsweise des Körpers gibt – in Abhängigkeit von unterschiedlichen Zugangsarten zum Leibkörper beziehungsweise in Abhängigkeit von den Verhaltensweisen des Menschen zu sich selbst. Daraus folgt, dass es zumindest nicht *einen* Begriff des Leibes geben kann, so dass sich die Frage nach dem Begriff des Leibes verwandelt in die nach der jeweiligen Berechtigung unterschiedlicher Leibbegriffe. Soweit solche Begriffe vorhanden sind, sei es im durchschnittlichen Alltagsverständnis, sei es in der Philosophie, ginge es darum nachzuweisen, in Bezug auf welche Zugangsart oder welches Selbstverhältnis des Menschen sie ihren Sinn erfahren. Das zu leisten, könnte vielleicht wenigstens unnütze Diskussionen und theoretische Auseinandersetzungen beenden und die Einsicht stärken, dass es eigentlich auf ebendieses Selbstverhältnis ankommt. Darüber hinaus allerdings wäre es wünschenswert, einen Leibbegriff zu bilden, der nicht nur die Prädikate einer bestimmten Art von Leibphänomenen bestimmt – also im Kognitiven bleibt –, sondern gerade dieses Selbstverhältnis mit in den Begriff des Leibes aufnimmt. Das wäre dann im Sinne von Kierkegaard ein Existenzbegriff des Leibes.

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Beginnen wir aber mit Descartes. Für Descartes ist der Körper *res extensa*, das heißt, das Wesentliche des Körpers ist eigentlich sein Volumen. Der Körper tritt also vor allem dadurch in Erscheinung, dass er einen Platz einnimmt und gegebenenfalls andere Körper verdrängt. Nun hat allerdings bereits Newton darauf hingewiesen, dass man mit einem solchen Körperbegriff nicht einmal eine vernünftige Mechanik zustande bringt, und er hat deshalb den Körpern auch Kräfte zugeschrieben, einerseits die Trägheit beziehungsweise die Masse als eine *vis insita* und andererseits die Schwere, also die wechselseitige Anziehung der Körper. Ich habe schon andernorts darauf hingewiesen, dass historisch gesehen dieser kartesische Begriff des Körpers, auf den Körper des Menschen angewandt, dessen radikale, das heißt vor allem entzaubernde Vergegenständlichung ermöglicht hat und damit die moderne Medizin. Jetzt allerdings müssen wir fragen: Unter welchen Bedingungen erfahren wir uns so, dass der kartesische Körperbegriff adäquat ist?

Eine Antwort auf diese Frage haben wir eben bereits gegeben: Der kartesische Körperbegriff macht Sinn, insofern wir menschliche Körper objektivieren wie anderes auch und sie naturwissenschaftlichen Methoden unterwerfen. Aber das ist offenbar nicht die ganze Antwort, denn wir rechnen damit, dass wir dieses so thematisierte Körperding sind und sein müssen. Wie andere Leute uns sehen, kann uns nicht gleichgültig sein, und wir versuchen ja auch, sei es mit Spiegeln oder ohne, uns so zu sehen, wie andere Leute uns sehen. Der entfremdende Blick entfremdet uns unserem Körper doch nicht gänzlich, weil es letztlich eben doch unser Leib ist, der so vergegenständlicht wird. Hinzu kommt, dass wir nicht nur mit dem Blick der anderen, sondern auch mit den anderen Gegenständen rechnen müssen. Denn auch für sie sind wir – wenn man das so sagen darf – nur Gegenstände, das heißt mechanische Körper, und damit müssen wir rechnen. Das heißt, dass auch für uns gilt, dass nicht zwei Körper an demselben Platz sein können und dass wir in unserer Bewegung durch den Raum sehr wohl den Gesetzen der Mechanik unterworfen sind. Diese Einsicht, dass wir bei uns selbst damit rechnen müssen, dass wir auch Körper sind, hat zum sogenannten »Körperschema«, dann später »Körperbild«, geführt, wie es ursprünglich von Paul Schilder als Begriff eingeführt und dann von Karl Conrad weiterentwickelt wurde. Thomas Fuchs, der diese Tradition aufgearbeitet hat, definiert:

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Hingegen verstehe ich unter dem *Körperschema* eine zentrale Repräsentanz des Körpers, die uns eine unwillkürliche, implizierte Orientierung bezüglich der Haltung, Lage und Bewegung unseres Leibes und seiner Glieder ermöglicht. Dieses unsichtbare Netz räumlicher Orientierung ist allerdings nicht auf den Leib begrenzt, sondern bezieht immer auch sein Verhältnis zur Umgebung und seinen Umgang mit den Dingen mit ein […]. Der Begriff des *Körperbilds* (*body image*) schließlich entspricht der habituellen visuell-räumlichen Vorstellung vom eigenen Körper, seinem Aussehen und seinen Eigenschaften, also dem Körper aus der Sicht von außen […].[1]

Dieser Begriff vom Körper im Sinne von Körperschema hat offenbar bereits seinen Sinn darin, dass er den Körper nicht einfach bloß als Gegenstand bestimmt, sondern in der Perspektive, dass wir diesen Gegenstand auch sein müssen – mit Michel Henry gesprochen: Wir müssen unseren Körper *existieren*. Aber gerade deshalb müssen wir darauf hinweisen, dass unser Körper aus der Perspektive, dass wir ihn leben und leben müssen, gerade keinem festem Schema genügt. Dem hat man nach jüdischer Tradition dadurch entsprochen, dass es verboten war, lebendige Menschen zu messen – nur der Tote habe ein festes Maß. Weniger tiefsinnig dürfte die Tatsache sein, dass wir, gerade um uns in der Körperwelt zu bewegen, unseren Leib eben nicht nur zum faktischen Körper machen dürfen beziehungsweise uns umso kompetenter bewegen, je mehr wir unseren Körper variabel gestalten. Charakteristisch dafür ist das Turnen: Es gelingt umso besser, je mehr man davon Gebrauch macht, dass wir als lebendige Körper keinen festen Schwerpunkt haben. Die Möglichkeit der Selbstbewegung hängt – abgesehen davon, dass wir als Organismen in unserem Körper auch mechanische Energie freisetzen können – davon ab, dass wir, uns bewegend, in unserem Körper unseren Schwerpunkt ständig verlagern.

Wir müssen aber noch in einem weiteren Sinne damit rechnen, dass wir Körper sind, insofern wir nämlich das, was uns aus naturwissenschaftlich-medizinischer Perspektive über uns selbst gesagt wird, nicht einem fremden Körperding, sondern uns selbst zuschreiben müssen. Natürlich ist dieses Wissen gerade immer insofern effektiv, als wir uns dann in distanzierender Haltung auch selbst als ein Körperding behandeln oder behandeln lassen. Aber auch das ist nicht die ganze Wahrheit, denn auch hier spielt ja eine

1 Thomas Fuchs, *Leib, Raum, Person. Entwurf einer phänomenologischen Anthropologie*, Stuttgart 2000, S. 41.

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Rolle, dass wir dieses Körperding eben qua Leib doch sind und wir nur allein deshalb auch an einer Behandlung interessiert sind; ferner, dass wir es eben auch nicht schlechthin sind und sich uns deshalb auch Möglichkeiten eröffnen, gegebenenfalls auf andere Weise mit den Problemen fertig zu werden – in der Regel sind das Krankheiten –, die eine Objektivierung unter dem ärztlichen Blick notwendig machten.

Bei Husserl finden wir den Begriff des *fungierenden Leibes*. Es geht dabei, wie Waldenfels sagt, um die Frage »Was tut der Leib, was leistet der Leib, wie funktioniert er?«[2] In dieser Formulierung könnte man allerdings noch glauben, es handele sich eigentlich um den Körper qua Organismus, das heißt um die funktionalen Betrachtungen, die die Biologie als objektivistische Wissenschaft durchaus leisten kann. Aber das ist schon bei Husserl wohl nicht so gemeint, vielmehr entspricht sein Konzept vom fungierenden Körper einer Wiederaufnahme von Schopenhauers Sicht des Leibes als Korrelat des Willens. Es geht also um unseren Leib, insofern wir ihn als Medium unserer Selbstbewegung erfahren. Husserl spricht hier von *Motionen* als leiblichen Bewegungstendenzen im Unterschied zu den Intentionen als den Gerichtetheiten des Bewusstseins.

Dieser Begriff des fungierenden Leibes ist nun in der Tat unterschieden von anderen, sowohl von dem Körperbegriff, der auf Descartes zurückgeht, als auch von dem pathischen Leibbegriff, den wir mit Schmitz vorstellen werden. Sartre hatte ja den Leib überhaupt erst auf der Rückseite des Handelns erscheinen lassen oder besser gesagt: als Störfaktor im Handeln. Dies ist aber nur die *eine* Weise der Leiberfahrung, die man in aktiver Weltzuwendung machen kann, es gibt eben auch die andere, die des aufmerksamen, kompetenten und manchmal auch lustvollen Sich-Auslebens. Husserl hat deshalb den kinästhetischen Erfahrungen, das heißt dem Wechselspiel von Wahrnehmung und Bewegung, besondere Aufmerksamkeit geschenkt, wie auch nach ihm Merleau-Ponty. Dessen Begriff des inkarnierten Ich ist denn auch als eine andere Version von Husserls Begriff des fungierenden Leibes anzusehen.

Hermann Schmitz hat eine Definition von Leiblichkeit gegeben,

2 Bernhard Waldenfels, *Das leibliche Selbst: Vorlesungen zur Phänomenologie des Leibes*, Frankfurt/M. 2000, S. 42.

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die durch ihre Klarheit und leichte Handhabbarkeit besticht. Zugleich hat man aber den Eindruck, dass sie eigentlich nur gemacht ist, um leibliche Phänomene von anderen zu unterscheiden, ohne den Anspruch zu erheben, das Wesen des Leiblichen zu erfassen. Dies wäre im Rahmen der Tradition des Definierens auch durchaus legitim.[3] Nur auf Umwegen erkennt man, dass in Schmitz' Definition, die nur ein Abgrenzungskriterium für das Leibliche anzugeben scheint, doch ein *essential*, um nicht zu sagen der entscheidende Wesenszug des Leibes enthalten ist. Ich gebe zunächst die Definition selbst an, die leibliche Phänomene von körperlichen und diese wiederum von seelischen unterscheidet:

Leiblich ist das, dessen Örtlichkeit absolut ist.
Körperlich ist das, dessen Örtlichkeit relativ ist.
Seelisch ist, was ortlos ist.[4]

Schmitz' Leibphilosophie kann man als eine Ausarbeitung der Husserl'schen Entdeckung leiblichen Spürens ansehen, die in seinem Zwei-Hände-Experiment enthalten ist. Das Experiment besteht darin, dass man mit der rechten Hand die linke anfasst. Die rechte hat dann Empfindungen – nämlich von der linken Hand –, die linke jedoch nach Husserls Terminologie »Empfindnisse«,[5] nämlich: sie spürt sich selbst. Man kann auf der Basis dieses Experiments noch eine zweite Husserl'sche Definition des Leibes – neben der eben angegebenen als *fungierender Körper* – geben, nämlich als *Feld der Empfindnisse*. Für Schmitz ist der Leib, was im leiblichen Spüren gegeben ist. Und da das Spüren ein *Sich-Spüren* ist, kann man ebenso sagen, dass der Leib das räumlich ausgedehnte Spüren selbst ist: Meine gespürte Hand ist nichts anderes als das ausgedehnte Spüren in der Gegend der Hand selbst. Schmitz verwendet für diese mehr oder weniger abgegrenzten, mehr oder weniger

3 Ein solches *pragmatisches* Definieren habe ich bereits bei Platon nachgewiesen. Siehe dazu Gernot Böhme, *Platons theoretische Philosophie*, Stuttgart 2000, hier: Abschnitt II.7.3. Bei Schmitz scheint bezüglich der Differenz von Wesensdefinition und pragmatischer Definition eine leichte Unsicherheit zu bestehen, wenn er das entsprechende Kapitel mit »Der Begriff des Leibes« überschreibt, dann aber in § 43 eine »Definition des Leiblichen« gibt. Siehe Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*, Bd. II.1: *Der Leib*, Bonn 1965.

4 Schmitz, *Der Leib*, S. 6.

5 Edmund Husserl, *Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und phänomenologischen Philosophie II*, Den Haag 1952, S. 145 f.

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stabilen, mehr oder weniger ineinander übergehenden Felder des Spürens den Ausdruck *Leibesinseln*. Er zeigt dann, dass das leibliche Spüren zwei Grundtendenzen hat, nämlich Engung und Weitung, dass diese Tendenzen miteinander in einen dynamischen Antagonismus treten als Spannung und Schwellung, dass es dann ferner in diesem leiblichen Spüren auch Richtungen gibt usw. Zusammengenommen werden diese Strukturen leiblichen Spürens als *leibliches Alphabet* bezeichnet. Es enthält quasi leibliche Elementarphänomene, auf deren Basis Schmitz in Anspruch nimmt, komplexere leibliche Erfahrungen durchbuchstabieren zu können.

Gemessen an den Definitionen von Descartes und Husserl (der ersten) muss man Schmitz' Definition als eine pathische Definition des Leiblichen bezeichnen: Es sind Erfahrungen der Selbstgegebenheit, durch die Leiblichkeit charakterisiert wird, oder im Sinne der genetischen Phänomenologie gesprochen: Der Leib zeigt sich im Sinne der von Schmitz charakterisierten Phänomenalität, wenn man sich auf ihn einlässt als etwas, das einem widerfährt.

Was hat aber der Leib als Korrelat leiblichen Spürens oder besser gesagt als Strukturzusammenhang leiblichen Spürens mit der Schmitz'schen Definition von Leiblichkeit zu tun? Wenn man diese Frage stellt, kommt man darauf, dass Schmitz' Definition keineswegs so rein pragmatisch ist, wie sie aussieht. Das liegt vor allem an dem Terminus *absolut* in der Formulierung »leiblich ist das, dessen Örtlichkeit absolut ist«. Absolute Örtlichkeiten, würde man denken, gibt es nämlich eigentlich gar nicht, denn jeder Ort ist doch in seiner Lage relativ zu anderen bestimmt. Dieses Vorurteil ist auch berechtigt, allerdings eben gerade nur für den Bereich des Körperlichen. Der Ort eines Körpers ist durch seine Lage zu anderen Körpern bestimmt. Im leiblichen Spüren dagegen ist ein absolutes *Hier* gegeben. Das gilt sowohl für das Spüren meines Leibes im Ganzen als auch für das Spüren einzelner Leibesinseln. Auch wenn ich meine Hand spüre, ist in diesem Spüren ein absolutes Hier impliziert.[6] Dieses absolute Hier, das im leiblichen Spüren impliziert ist, ist ein *Hier-bin-ich* oder genauer: Es ist die primitive Gegenwart, die Schmitz zu seinem Prinzip der Philosophie gemacht hat.

6 Schmitz setzt sich ausführlich mit dem Problem auseinander, dass im leiblichen Spüren durch die unterschiedlichen Leibesinseln eine Mannigfaltigkeit von absoluten *Hiers* gegeben ist, die aber gleichwohl nicht strikt voneinander unterschieden sind.

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Die primitive Gegenwart ist das unentfaltete *Ich*, *Hier*, *Jetzt*, *Dieses*, *Dasein*. »Unentfaltet« bedeutet dabei, dass in dem Spüren der Kern zur Ausdifferenzierung dieser Elemente gegeben ist.

Blicken wir von der Ausdifferenzierung des *Ich*, *Hier*, *Jetzt*, *Dieses*, *Dasein* zurück, dann kann man sagen, dass im absoluten Hier des leiblichen Spürens die Betroffenheit der leiblichen Existenz des Menschen begründet ist: Qua Leib ist der Mensch je in einer bestimmten Zeit, an einem bestimmten Ort, und er ist von der Unausweichlichkeit seines Daseins, das er in radikaler Besonderung als diesen Leib erfährt, unausweichlich betroffen. Wir sehen also, dass im Terminus *absolut* in der Schmitz'schen Definition der Leiblichkeit das Wesen des Leiblichen als betroffenes Sich-Spüren durchaus enthalten ist.

Schmitz' Definition des Leiblichen ist also über den Terminus des absoluten Ortes an sein Prinzip der Philosophie zurückgebunden. Das hat nun weitreichende Konsequenzen, von denen ein Licht auf den Sinn der Schmitz'schen Definition der Leiblichkeit fällt. Nach Schmitz ist ja Philosophie überhaupt das »Sichbesinnen des Menschen auf sein Sichfinden in seiner Umgebung«.[7] Es geht in einem radikaleren Sinne noch als bei Descartes um Gewissheit angesichts oder besser unter der Bedingung radikaler Erschütterungen. Diese Erschütterungen des durchschnittlichen Welt- und Selbstvertrauens sind insofern radikaler als der kartesische Zweifel, als sie nicht bloß intellektuell sind, sondern an die Seinsgewissheit selbst rühren. Es handelt sich um die Erfahrungen von Angst und Schmerz. Und ähnlich wie Descartes im Zweifel findet auch Schmitz den Grund der Gewissheit in der Erschütterung selbst. In Angst und Schmerz ist die primitive Gegenwart als das unausweichliche *Ich*, *Hier*, *Jetzt*, *Dieses*, *Dasein* gegeben. Auf dem Grunde der primitiven Gegenwart erkennt Schmitz als Phänomen im Sinne seiner Phänomenologie nun genau das an, was sich übermächtig und unleugbar aufdrängt. Das sind primär natürlich solche Phänomene, die in irgendeiner Weise die Erfahrung der primitiven Gegenwart implizieren wie alle Phänomene leiblichen Spürens. Sie implizieren eine Gewissheit, die man traditionell auch in der *aisthesis*, das heißt der Wahrnehmung im strengen Sinne, gefunden hat: Wenn ich Rot sehe, kann ich nicht sinnvoll daran zweifeln, Rot

7 Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*, Bd. I: *Die Gegenwart*, Bonn 1964, S. 5.

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zu sehen. Diese sinnliche Gewissheit hat übrigens Wittgenstein – darin Moore folgend – auch gerade in der Erfahrung des eigenen Leibes gefunden: »Ich *weiß*, ich vermute nicht nur, dass hier meine Hand ist.«[8]

Damit zeigt sich der Sinn des Schmitz'schen Leibkonzeptes: Der Leib erschließt sich, insofern man sich auf ihn einlässt, als etwas, das einem widerfährt, das heißt also in pathischen Existenzweisen. Diese erweisen sich aber als mehr denn als bloße Erkenntniswege: Es geht um das Aufsuchen von Erfahrungen der Selbstvergewisserung.

2. Leib: die Natur, die wir selbst sind

Die drei besprochenen Definitionen haben je ihre Berechtigung und charakterisieren den Leib in einer je spezifischen Zugangsweise beziehungsweise in einem je spezifischen Selbstverhältnis des Menschen. Auffällig ist bei allen dreien die Orientierung auf Erkenntnis. Die kartesische Definition ist geradezu grundlegend für eine spezifische Erkenntnisweise des Leibes, nämlich als naturwissenschaftlicher Gegenstand. Bei Husserl geht es durchaus um den gelebten Leib, aber die Orientierung ist doch auf das gerichtet, *was* dieser Leib ist. Und bei Schmitz, bei dem sich in der Tiefe seines Leibbegriffs sehr wohl das existentielle Verhältnis zeigte, ist doch in der ausdefinierten Form des Begriffs nichts davon zu spüren. Die Funktion des Begriffs ist lediglich kognitiver Art. Hier dagegen muss es um eine Leibdefinition gehen, durch die die Probleme, die wir mit dem Leib haben, sichtbar werden, und zugleich sollte die Definition eine Weise, Leib zu sein, anzeigen, in der man Aussicht hat, diese Probleme zu bewältigen, wenn nicht gar zu lösen. Die Definition sollte eine kognitive, das heißt erkenntnistheoretische Funktion ausüben können, aber zugleich auch eine praktische, eine solche, die in Richtung einer Ethik leiblicher Existenz weist. Diese Definition ist:

Der Leib ist die Natur, die wir selbst sind.

8 Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Über Gewissheit*, in: Ders.: *Werkausgabe*, Bd. 8, hg. v. G. H. v. Wright u. G. E. M. Anscombe, Frankfurt/M. 1984, § 57, S. 131.

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Damit diese Definition ihre Funktion entfalten kann, ist es notwendig, sie nicht nur in den Termini, sondern auch in ihrem Bau zu erläutern.

Zunächst zum Terminus *Natur*: Der Naturbegriff ist ein Begriff, den man seit der griechischen Sophistik aus Gegensätzen versteht. Davor benutzten die vorsokratischen Naturphilosophen den Ausdruck »Natur«, griechisch *physis*, für das Seiende im Ganzen. Seit der Sophistik ist Natur dagegen ein Bereichsbegriff beziehungsweise bezeichnet dieser Begriff eine bestimmte Seinsweise. Natur wird verstanden im Gegensatz zu Satzung, Technik, Kultur, Zivilisation. Natur ist also dasjenige, was von selbst da ist, dasjenige, was uns Menschen gegeben ist; Natur wird verstanden im Gegensatz zu dem, was vom Menschen gemacht wird. Am schönsten ist diese Differenz bei Aristoteles in seiner *Physikvorlesung* formuliert. Er greift dabei auf ein Beispiel des Sophisten Antiphon zurück. Man vergrabe ein Bett, das aus Holz gefertigt ist – für dieses Experiment eignet sich wohl am besten Weidenholz –, dann wird bei entsprechender Feuchtigkeit daraus ein Schössling treiben, also wiederum ein Weidenbaum entstehen – nicht ein Bett. Von Natur aus, sagt Aristoteles, ist der genannte Gegenstand Holz, durch Technik ist er ein Bett.[9] Er definiert dann Seiendes, das von Natur aus ist, als solches, das das Prinzip seiner Bewegung in sich habe, während durch Technik Seiendes von der Art ist, dass es das Prinzip seiner Bewegung (das heißt seiner Entstehung, Wandlung und Reproduktion) im Menschen habe.

Wenn wir den Leib als Natur definieren, so stellen wir uns explizit in diesen von Antiphon und Aristoteles hergeleiteten Traditionszusammenhang. Der Leib wird apostrophiert als etwas, das uns gegeben ist. Man könnte vermuten, dass damit Leib qua Natur von vornherein als eine Invariante, als etwas Kulturunabhängiges wie auch historisch Invariantes, also als eine Art anthropologische Konstante eingeführt wäre. Das ist aber nicht der Fall. Schon allein deshalb, weil man Weisen der Gegebenheit unterscheiden kann, vor allem aber deshalb – und das ist das aktuelle Problem –, weil man ja auch Gegebenes in Gemachtes verwandeln kann. Genau das zu tun, war ja auf breiter Linie das Projekt der Moderne.[10] Schon

9 Aristoteles, *Physik*, II 193a.

10 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Einführung in die Philosophie. Weltweisheit – Lebensform – Wissenschaft*, Frankfurt/M. 1994, S. 3-7.

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die neuzeitliche Naturwissenschaft ist so angelegt: Die Natur soll durch Rekonstruktion erkannt werden. Aber auch der menschliche Bereich, soweit er als Gegebenes erfahren wurde, also beispielsweise die menschlichen Institutionen, sollte nach einem bewussten, und das heißt: nach einem vernünftigen Plan entworfen werden. Und auch der Mensch selbst sah sich als privates wie als gesellschaftliches Wesen als etwas, das sich überhaupt erst zu dem machen muss, was es ist und sein soll. Der Mensch wird nur Mensch durch Erziehung, resümiert Kant. Dieses Projekt der Selbstbildung des Menschen, ein Projekt, das zunächst nur ein pädagogisches und politisches war, ist im 20. Jahrhundert zu einem naturwissenschaftlich-technischen geworden, das heißt zu einem, das auch die menschliche Natur zur Disposition stellt und einem Plan unterwirft. Hierin liegt eines der Hauptmotive dafür, überhaupt eine Naturphilosophie in praktischer Hinsicht zu entwickeln. Deshalb wird auch der Leib als Natur definiert, denn er ist uns zunächst gegeben, selbst dann, wenn wir die Bestände des Gegebenen nicht akzeptieren und verändern. Darüber hinaus wird man wohl davon ausgehen müssen, dass auch Menschen, die aus Prozessen gentechnischer Produktion und des Klonens hervorgegangen sind, zunächst sich selbst in ihrem Bestand als gegeben und damit als Natur erfahren werden.

Nun gibt es unterschiedliche Arten von Gegebenheit, eine davon ist die naturwissenschaftliche. Unser Leib ist uns auch als naturwissenschaftliche Tatsache gegeben, allerdings indirekt und auf dem Umweg über Apparate und den ärztlichen Blick. Wir nennen den so gegebenen Leib *Körper*. Dass der Körper Natur ist, dürfte unproblematisch sein, denn Natur wird ja gegenwärtig normalerweise als dasjenige verstanden, was Gegenstand der Naturwissenschaft ist.

Man kann die Rechtfertigung dafür, den Leib Natur zu nennen, gerade aus dieser Tatsache herleiten, dass der Leib eben auch als Gegenstand der Naturwissenschaft gegeben sein kann. Für unsere Definition ist aber nun entscheidend, dass der Leib uns auch nicht vermittelt über den Anderen oder über Apparate gegeben ist, sondern in der Selbsterfahrung. Dass man den Leib als Natur bezeichnet, kann man auch hier damit begründen, dass er einem gegeben ist. Nur ist der Sinn von ›Natur‹ hier ein anderer, weil die Gegebenheitsweise eine andere ist: Es handelt sich nicht um Fremderfahrung, sondern um Selbsterfahrung. Die Bedeutung dagegen ist

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dieselbe, das heißt also, was da gegeben ist, ist dasselbe, wenngleich auch in radikal unterschiedlicher Gegebenheitsweise und daraus folgend in unterschiedlicher Phänomenalität.[11]

Diese formale Kennzeichnung von Leib als Natur, weil er uns in Selbsterfahrung *gegeben* ist, reicht aber noch nicht aus, um ihn sinnvoll als Natur zu bezeichnen. Dass er nämlich *uns* gegeben ist, setzt voraus, dass wir ihn in gewisser Weise oder gar zunächst und zumeist nicht selbst sind. Wäre das anders, wäre die leibliche Selbsterfahrung nur so etwas wie Selbstaffektion. Von Selbstaffektion redet Kant dort, wo es darum geht, dass das Subjekt seine eigene Tätigkeit erfährt: Es affiziert sich selbst durch seine Tätigkeit. Schon hier also gilt es, darauf zu achten, dass die Leiberfahrung nicht zum einfachen Bewusstseinsphänomen wird. Das Sich-Spüren, das ja in der Tat als ein Hinspüren praktiziert werden kann und damit eine Art Selbstaffektion ist, darf generell gerade nicht dieser Art sein: Das Sich-Spüren muss uns überfallen können, uns fremdartig berühren, wenn wir es sinnvoll als *Naturerfahrung* bezeichnen wollen.

Wir müssen also im Kontrast zur Definition davon ausgehen, dass wir unseren Leib als Natur zunächst und zumeist gerade nicht selbst sind. Wir, das heißt erwachsene Menschen, späte Produkte der europäischen Zivilisation und zudem Leute, die Bücher über den Leib lesen, gehen von einer Situation aus, in der ein Ich längst ausdifferenziert ist. Nichts fällt uns leichter, als von uns selbst als ›Ich‹ zu sprechen, und in der Tat sind wir auch ein Ich im Sinne einer auf Dauer gestellten und biographisch wie durch soziale Netze abgesicherten Person. Der Leib als Natur ist mir daher allerdings gegeben, aber als etwas Fremdes, manchmal durchaus Befremdliches. Dabei ist, dass dieses Fremde mein Fremdes ist, nie zu leugnen. Gewiss, es gibt auch solche massiven Selbstentfremdungen, bei denen Menschen Teile von sich schlechthin als Dinge ansehen.[12] Dann würde man von Krankheit reden. Im normalen

11 Für diese Weise, an der Identität eines Gegebenen trotz radikal unterschiedener Gegebenheitsweisen festzuhalten, siehe Gottlob Freges Aufsatz über »Sinn und Bedeutung«, in: Ders., *Funktion, Begriff, Bedeutung. Fünf logische Studien*, hg. v. Günter Patzig, Göttingen ^{2}1966, S. 40-65. Freges klassisches Beispiel ist die unterschiedliche Gegebenheitsweise der Venus qua Morgenstern und qua Abendstern.

12 Siehe dazu die Fälle bei Oliver Sacks, *Der Mann, der seine Frau mit einem Hut verwechselte*, Reinbek bei Hamburg 1997, bspw. S. 85.

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Zustand dagegen ist die Beziehung zu der Natur, die mein Leib ist, als zu etwas, das zu mir gehört, durch die affektive Betroffenheit sichergestellt. Das Spüren des Leibes bleibt ein *Sich*-Spüren.

Die Fremdheit des Leibes qua Natur ist zunächst darin begründet, dass er mir gegeben ist, das heißt, ich finde mich immer schon mit diesem bestimmten Leib begabt vor. Die *Selbst*gegebenheit ist deshalb zunächst eine *Vor*gegebenheit. Es ist der Leib als Faktum, als vorgefundene Konstitution, als sedimentierte Vorgeschichte meines gegenwärtigen Daseins. Soweit hierin die Fremdheit des eigenen Leibes besteht, handelt es sich um nichts anderes als das, was Heidegger *Geworfenheit* nennt, beziehungsweise das Faktum, dass man seines eigenen Grundes nicht mächtig ist. Heidegger formuliert diese Einsicht aber zugleich so, dass darin eine Aufgabe des Selbstseins erkennbar wird:

> Das Selbst, das als solches den Grund seiner selbst zu legen hat, kann dessen *nie* mächtig werden und hat doch existierend das Grundsein zu übernehmen. […] Das Dasein ist nicht insofern selbst der Grund seines Seins, als dieser aus eigenem Entwurf erst entspringt, wohl aber ist es als Selbstsein das *Sein* des Grundes.[13]

Die Fremdheit des eigenen Leibes, durch die er uns gerade als *Natur* entgegentritt, ist aber nicht bloß in seiner Faktizität begründet, sondern vielmehr noch in seiner Selbsttätigkeit. Der Leib tritt dem Ich als eine andere, als eine befremdende Spontaneität entgegen. Diese Erfahrung kann nicht besser ausgedrückt werden als mit Freuds Satz, das Ich sei nicht Herr im eigenen Hause.[14] Dass der Leib als Natur erfahren wird, meint geradezu so viel, dass er als etwas erfahren wird, das nicht vollständig der Herrschaft des Ich zu unterwerfen ist, sondern sich ihm gegenüber widerständig und träge verhält beziehungsweise umgekehrt: sich selbsttätig äußert. Der Leib kann lästig, kann auffällig, kann quälend, der Leib kann fordernd, überraschend und unheimlich sein. Schlagend ist diese Erfahrung von Georg Büchner in seinem Stück *Woyzeck* in der achten

13 Martin Heidegger, *Sein und Zeit*, Tübingen 1976, S. 284 f.

14 Obgleich Waldenfels sich auf diesen Satz Freuds bezieht, kann er doch die Fremdheit des *eigenen* Leibes nicht würdigen. Er bringt vielmehr den Begriff der Fremdheit in die Leibphilosophie, um deutlich zu machen, dass der eigene Leib erst aufgrund der Beziehung zum Anderen, dem fremden Leib, als eigener erfahren wird. Siehe Waldenfels, *Das leibliche Selbst*, S. 284.

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Szene formuliert worden. Auf die Vorwürfe des Doktors: »Er hat auf die Straß gepißt, an die Wand gepißt wie ein Hund« antwortet Woyzeck: »Aber Herr Doktor, wenn einem die Natur kommt.«[15]

Der Leib qua Natur ist uns also nicht bloß gegeben, sondern er drängt sich geradezu auf. Dass ich dieser Leib selbst bin, ist keineswegs selbstverständlich, wohl aber wird in der Betroffenheit durch den Leib erfahren, dass ich ihn zu sein habe.

So viel zum Terminus *Natur*. Ich wende mich damit dem zweiten Teil der Definition von Leib als der Natur, die wir selbst sind, zu. Obgleich ich betont habe, dass im zivilisierten Erwachsenendasein der Leib zunächst als das erfahren wird, das wir *nicht* selbst sind, tauchte doch das *Selbst* bereits auf: Die Erfahrung des Leibes, auch wenn sie befremdend war, blieb doch immer Selbsterfahrung. In diesem Terminus schillert das *Selbst* zwischen zwei Bedeutungen. *Selbsterfahrung* kann heißen: die Erfahrung, die man selbst macht; es kann aber auch heißen: die Erfahrung des Selbst. Tatsächlich trifft in der Leiberfahrung beides zu. Der Leib wurde im Vorbegriff ja bereits eingeführt als etwas, das im Gegensatz zum Körper Gegenstand der Selbsterfahrung ist. Und ferner zeigte sich, dass in der Betroffenheit leiblicher Erfahrung immer spürbar blieb, dass dieser Leib mein Leib ist, dass im gewissen Sinne ich selbst es bin, was ich da erfahre. Das leibliche Spüren ist immer ein *Sich*-Spüren.

Aber was heißt es, dass man in der Leiberfahrung eigentlich sich selbst erfährt? Ist dieses Selbst ein anderes oder gar tieferes Ich? So redet Nietzsche in seinem Kapitel »Von den Verächtern des Leibes« im *Zarathustra*. Der Leib ist das Selbst, der große Gebieter: »In deinem Leibe wohnt er, dein Leib ist er.«[16] Ist das Ich nur so eine Art Marionette oder eine Fingerpuppe an der Hand des großen Selbst? Das hieße nun allerdings, das Ich in seiner Selbständigkeit und Selbsttätigkeit zu unterschätzen. Es hat – selbst in seinen Bestrebungen – auch ganz andere Quellen als den Leib, und es ist von ihm unterschieden und gegen ihn stabilisiert durch biographische Identifikationsprozesse und soziale Vernetzung. Und das Ich so zu unterschätzen, hieße auch, nachträglich die Fremdheit des Leibes zu leugnen. Fremd ist der Leib ja überhaupt nur gegenüber einem relativ unabhängigen Ich, das sich zu seinem Leib in ein Verhältnis

15 Georg Büchner, *Woyzeck*, 8. Szene »Beim Doktor«.

16 Friedrich Nietzsche, *Also sprach Zarathustra*, in: Ders., *Werke in drei Bänden*, Bd. 2, hg. v. Karl Schlechta, München 1994, S. 300.

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des Habens setzen kann (Plessner). Es könnte also sein, dass *den Leib selbst sein* verlangen würde, die Selbständigkeit des Ich aufzugeben oder zumindest teilweise oder vorübergehend zu suspendieren. Allgemein stellt sich *den Leib als Natur selbst zu sein* als prekäre Aufgabe. Es gilt, was wir selbst als Faktum oder in affektiver Betroffenheit sind, explizit in den eigenen Selbstentwurf aufzunehmen. Es geht damit um die Frage, in welcher Weise zu sein wir unseren Leib sind. Dabei wird das »sein« als transitives Verb genommen, so wie Michel Henry sagt, *on existe son corps*.

Dieses *den Leib existieren* vollzieht sich im betroffenen und im emphatischen Lebensvollzug. Ich will für beides je ein Beispiel geben, wobei beide noch sehr vorläufig und vorbereitend sind. Zunächst ein Beispiel dafür, wie man im betroffenen Sich-Spüren sich selbst zugleich als Natur erfährt. Mein Beispiel ist das schwere Atmen in Smoglagen. Der Vorgang des Atmens ist eines der wichtigsten Phänomene leiblicher Existenz überhaupt, und zwar weil es diese leibliche Existenz als Vorgang, als Vollzug erfahrbar macht. Fast alle Übungen, durch die man lernen soll, sich auf sein leibliches Dasein einzulassen und sich dem Leib zu öffnen, beginnen mit Atemübungen. Das Atembewusstsein ist in gewisser Weise das Leibbewusstsein überhaupt. Hier soll es aber zunächst nicht um diese allgemeinere Bedeutung des Atmens gehen, sondern um die spezielle Erfahrung, die man macht, wenn beispielsweise in Smoglagen das Atmen schwer wird. Diese Erfahrung ist, insbesondere im Kontrast zu der Leichtigkeit und Unauffälligkeit des Atmens sonst, eine Erfahrung der Last des Daseins: Man spürt, dass das Dasein qua leiblicher Existenz *vollzogen* werden muss, um überhaupt zu sein. Diese Erfahrung hat zwei Seiten. Hier ist zunächst besonders wichtig, dass sie explizit eine Naturerfahrung ist: Man erfährt im schweren Atmen seine Angewiesenheit auf Luft. Das schwere Atmen ist eine Leiberfahrung, die den Leib selbst als etwas erfahren lässt, das auf den Austausch mit der übrigen Natur angewiesen ist. Das muss man im Rückblick auf die bisherige Phänomenologie betonen. Das Atmen ist zwar in der Phänomenologie ausführlich behandelt worden, als Wechsel von Spannung und Schwellung, als rhythmische Dynamik der leiblichen Ökonomie.[17] Aber als Erfahrung der eigenen Natürlichkeit oder besser gesagt: sogar der Kreatürlichkeit war

17 Schmitz, *Der Leib*, § 49b u. § 50b u. passim.

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es nicht Thema, weil der Atem nicht zur Luft in Beziehung gesetzt wurde. Im Atmen erfahren wir uns gewissermaßen als Luftwesen – als solche bezeichnet jedenfalls Paracelsus, wie oben bereits angeführt, die Menschen, weil ja ihr Lebensmedium die Luft sei.

Die andere Seite dieser Erfahrung ist das darin implizierte Selbstsein. Das Natursein trifft uns im schweren Atmen nicht einfach bloß als ein Faktum, sondern zugleich als eine Aufgabe. Im schweren Atmen erfahren wir das Atmen selbst als ein Atmen-Müssen, das heißt in der Betroffenheit durch dieses Phänomen ist zugleich das Übernehmen mit angelegt: Das Müssen ist fast zwangsläufig ein Wollen, und das Schwer-Atmen geht in ein explizites Um-Atem-Ringen über. Das Beispiel zeigt also, was Selbst-Natur-Sein heißen kann, nämlich sich aktiv auf das einzulassen, was einem von der eigenen Natur her widerfährt. Dass das so ist, sieht man am deutlichsten dort, wo der Betroffene von seiner Natur am Ende überwältigt wird: Gerade wo die Atemnot überwältigend wird – etwa im schweren asthmatischen Anfall –, ist die Identifikation des Betroffenen mit dieser Not im Ringen um Atem am größten.

Dieses Beispiel verweist zugleich auf die allgemeinere Wahrheit, nämlich dass das Selbstsein in der Regel aus negativen Erfahrungen entspringt. Ich könnte mir denken, dass vielen Leserinnen und Lesern dieser Gedanke unbehaglich ist. Aber wie sollte sonst das implizite Selbstverhältnis, das im Sich-Spüren liegt, explizit werden, wie sollte das Natursein zu einem Selbst-Natur-Sein führen, wenn das Leben einfach ein müheloses Dahingleiten wäre? Umso wichtiger ist es, Beispiele anzuführen, in denen gerade der positive und ungehemmte Lebensvollzug zum Selbst-Natur-Sein wird. Es sind Beispiele der Emphase, die davon zeugen. Die Emphase ist das freudige Mitgehen mit dem, was von selbst geschieht. Ein Beispiel dafür ist das Losstürmen eines Kindes am Strand. Die Beschleunigung dabei ist nur die unbewusste Emphase, nicht der Wunsch, etwas schneller zu erreichen, denn das Kind ist ja eigentlich schon da, wo es sein will. Es sind Lebensvollzüge, die mit einer Steigerungstendenz erfahren werden, die Anlass geben, sie explizit zu übernehmen, sich quasi auf die Welle zu schwingen, die einen überrollt. Die eindrücklichsten Beispiele wären wohl hier aus dem Bereich der leiblichen Liebe zu nehmen. Emphase ist damit eine Weise, in der wir selbst Natur sind, bei Gelegenheiten, in denen uns Natur zu sein nicht als Last, sondern als Lust widerfährt.

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Nachdem durch diese Beispiele – mit Kant zu sprechen – auch die objektive Realität der Definition des Leibes gezeigt wurde, möchte ich zum Schluss dieses Kapitels noch auf die Struktur der Definition eingehen. Diese Definition hat sicherlich im Unterschied zur großen Tradition des Definierens nicht einfach ein Was-Sein zum Inhalt. Die Forderung nach einer Definition war ja von Sokrates in der Form: *was ist X?* in die Welt gebracht worden und als Antwort wurde die Angabe der wesentlichen Bestimmtheiten des fraglichen X erwartet – sein Was-Sein, seine Essenz. Würde man die Definition »Leib ist die Natur, die wir selbst sind« im Lichte dieser Tradition lesen, dann ist das Mindeste, was man feststellt, eine Spannung, die zwischen den beiden definierenden Termini, nämlich Natursein und Selbstsein, besteht. Leserinnen und Leser, die in der Philosophie der Leiblichkeit weniger erfahren sind, können hier sogar einen Widerspruch vermuten. Die Dichotomie von Natur als dem Gegebenen auf der einen Seite, Satzung, Kultur, Technik, Zivilisation als dem Gemachten auf der anderen Seite scheint die Zusammenstellung von Natursein und Selbstsein unmöglich zu machen: »Selbst und Gegebenheit verhalten sich wie Feuer und Wasser.«[18] Die Spannung zwischen Natursein und Selbstsein ist nicht zu leugnen. Sie bezeichnet aber nicht einen Widerspruch, sondern eine Aufgabe. Leibsein ist uns zugleich gegeben und aufgegeben. Die Definition des Leibes ist in Analogie zu Kierkegaards Existenzbegriffen[19] eine *Existenzdefinition* zu nennen. Es geht nicht bloß um ein Was-Sein, sondern es geht um einen Vollzug, eine Weise des Existierens. Die Spannung zwischen Natur und Selbst, in der die leibliche Existenz spielt, lässt dabei im Prinzip zwei Möglichkeiten zu: Die eine ist die gängige, nämlich dass das handelnde Subjekt nach Möglichkeit die Natur beherrscht beziehungsweise wegarbeitet oder verdrängt. Das wäre – mit Heidegger zu sprechen – der defiziente Modus des Leibseins. Im eigentlichen Modus des Leibseins ginge es darum, das Selbstsein derart zu entfalten, dass darin das eigene Natursein zugelassen wird.

18 Gerhard Gamm, »›Aus der Mitte denken‹. Die ›Natur des Menschen‹ im Spiegel der Bio- und Informationstechnologien«, in: *Zeitschrift für kritische Theorie* 12 (2001), S. 29-51, hier: S. 39.

19 Siehe dazu Böhme, *Einführung in die Philosophie*, Teil III, Kap. 3: »Existenzphilosophie«, S. 246-258.

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Leib und Körper – erläutert am Beispiel der *Liebe*

1. Das Staunen über die Liebe

Natürlich könnte man denken, dass Liebe das Selbstverständlichste von der Welt ist – sie gehört einfach als Grundzug zum menschlichen Dasein. Nur leben wir in einer Zeit, in der das Zusammenkommen von zwei Menschen in Liebe doch höchst erstaunlich ist und im Weiteren dann auch meist prekär verläuft. Eigentlich ist es nur noch die Mutterliebe, oder sagen wir besser: die Liebesbeziehung zwischen Mutter und Kind in der frühen Phase, die noch selbstverständlich ist. Bei erwachsenen Menschen dagegen ist es doch höchst erstaunlich, dass sich die Individuen immer wieder zu Paaren zusammenfinden und zusammentun. Erstaunlich ist es, weil die Grundtendenz unserer gegenwärtigen Zivilisation verlangt, dass jeder Mensch ein Individuum ist und seine Besonderheit ausbildet und pflegt – man nennt das Selbstverwirklichung –, und weil die durchschnittliche Lebensform des erwachsenen Menschen schon zu mehr als 40 Prozent das Singletum ist.[1] Und doch suchen sich diese vereinzelten Menschen immer wieder, als sehnten sie sich nach ihrer anderen Hälfte, wie es früh vom Komödiendichter Aristophanes beschrieben wurde:[2] Ursprünglich seien die Menschen Kugelwesen gewesen, doch der Gott zerschnitt sie, als sie zu übermütig und mächtig wurden – und nun liefen die Hälften herum, sich danach sehnend, mit einer anderen Hälfte wieder ein ganzer Mensch zu werden. Ja, auch das trifft auf unsere Gegenwart zu: Die Liebe richtet sich vornehmlich auf den Anderen. Nach dem Verfall von Klassen und Ständen wird die Partnersuche schrankenlos und freilich damit auch orientierungslos. Und es ist vornehmlich das Andere, das einen anzieht, natürlich, wie traditionell, das andere Geschlecht, aber eben auch die andere Kultur, die andere Ethnie, die andere Sprache, die andere Hautfarbe. Liebe ist Liebe zum Anderen.

Wie kommt es dazu? Warum ist das so? Darauf sind in der An-

1 2017 waren laut Statistischem Bundesamt 41 % der deutschen Haushalte Single-Haushalte, siehe ⟨https://www.destatis.de/DE/PresseService/Presse/Pressemitteilungen/zdw/2017/PD17_31_p002.html⟩, letzter Zugriff 10. 8. 2018.

2 Platon, *Symposion*, 189d-193d.

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tike und in der Moderne sehr unterschiedliche Antworten gegeben worden. Nach den antiken Vorstellungen ist Liebe etwas, das einen überfällt, das einen von außen ergreift – sei es nun die Atmosphäre der Venus, die einen umweht, oder der Pfeil des Amor, der einen trifft und in Verwirrung bringt. In der Moderne, insbesondere seit Sigmund Freud, sieht man das anders. Man sieht die Liebe in der Natur begründet und weist ihr einen Zweck zu, nämlich die Reproduktion der Gattung. Die Liebe steckt in einem, sie beruht auf einem Trieb, der Libido, und diese sucht sich einen Ort, besser gesagt einen Partner für eine *Besetzung*.

Diese beiden Sichtweisen unterscheiden sich charakteristisch danach, wie sie die Liebe in der physischen Existenz des Menschen verorten:

– Die Liebe als etwas, das einen überkommt und das einen ergreift, verweist auf den *Leib* als Ort der Gefühle. Die Liebe ist etwas Pathisches.

– Die Liebe als Trieb hat ihren Ort im Organismus, im *Körper*, und wird von ihrer Funktion zur Reproduktion der Gattung her verstanden. Sie ist etwas Aktives.

Aus dieser Vorüberlegung folgt, dass es nötig ist, um uns über die Lage der Liebe in unserer Zeit zu verständigen, zunächst den Unterschied zwischen Leib und Körper zu klären.

2. Leib und Körper

Der Körper ist in Diskursen, in denen es heute um die Natur des Menschen und seine Physis geht, der dominante Terminus. Das liegt an der Vorherrschaft naturwissenschaftlichen und medizinischen Denkens. Die Rede von der menschlichen Natur qua Körper leitet sich von Descartes her, der ja bekanntlich den Menschen als eine Verbindung zweier Substanzen, der *res extensa* und der *res cogitans*, verstand, also als eine Verbindung von Materie und Geist. Das wurde von La Mettrie in seinem Buch *L'homme machine*[3] auf die Spitze getrieben, indem die menschliche Natur als eine organische Maschine konzipiert wurde. Der Begriff von menschlicher

3 Julien Offray de La Mettrie, *Die Maschine Mensch*. Französisch-deutsch, übers. u. hg. von Claudia Becker, Hamburg 2009.

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Natur als Leib ist im Grunde älter und bezeichnete den Menschen in seiner lebendigen Existenz. Wir haben im Deutschen das Glück, dass wir hier zwei Termini haben, mit denen wir die angedeutete unterschiedliche Sicht und Erfahrungsweise artikulieren können. In vielen europäischen Sprachen ist die kartesische Sichtweise mit dem Terminus *corps* oder *body* so sehr festgeschrieben, dass man nur mit Mühe einen Terminus findet, der dem deutschen *Leib* entspricht. Im Französischen empfiehlt sich *corps vécu*, im Englischen *felt body.* In dem gegenwärtigen anglophilen Diskurs dominiert allerdings *embodiment,* ein Terminus, der sich von Maurice Merleau-Ponty herleitet. Bei ihm heißt es *incarnation,* ein Terminus, der seinen eingefleischten Kartesianismus verrät und letzten Endes auf die Bibel (»und das Wort ward Fleisch«, Johannes I, 14) zurückweist: Es wird also primär ein Ich oder ein Geist vorausgesetzt, der dann sich auch noch – meist durch Handeln – inkarniert. Nach dieser Vorbereitung können wir den Unterschied von Körper und Leib folgendermaßen definieren:

Körper ist die Natur des Menschen in Fremderfahrung.
Leib ist die Natur des Menschen in Selbsterfahrung.

Mit *Natur* wird in dieser Definition sehr wohl die physische Existenz des Menschen bezeichnet, nicht aber speziell der Mensch als Organismus oder Gegenstand der Naturwissenschaft. Allgemein wird hier das als *Natur* bezeichnet, als was sich der Mensch *gegeben* ist, also was er ist vor jeder Reflexion.

Für den Unterschied von Körper und Leib kommt es nun auf die *Gegebenheitsweise* an. Als Körper bezeichnen wir die menschliche Natur, insofern sie in Fremderfahrung, und das heißt vornehmlich in naturwissenschaftlicher Erfahrung, in Anatomie und Physiologie und im Blick der medizinischen Wissenschaft uns gegeben ist. Es ist also primär der Blick des Anderen auf die eigene physische Existenz, durch die sie als Körper erscheint. Dagegen bezeichnen wir die physische Existenz als Leib, insofern sie in Selbsterfahrung gegeben ist. Diese Gegebenheitsweise kommt durch das leibliche Spüren zustande: Wir spüren uns selbst. Diese unterschiedliche Gegebenheitsweise kann man auch durchaus als den Unterschied ›von außen‹ und ›von innen‹ beschreiben. Man sollte sich aber hüten, sie als *Aspekte* zu bezeichnen, weil diese Redeweise

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ein an sich vorliegendes Ding, das man dann noch aus verschiedener Perspektive betrachten kann, voraussetzt. Das leibliche Spüren erfasst jedoch keinen besonderen Aspekt einer *an sich* vorliegenden menschlichen Natur.

In unserer Zeit ist unser Selbstverständnis bezüglich der eigenen physischen Existenz wesentlich als Körperbewusstsein geprägt. Das liegt nicht nur an der Dominanz von Naturwissenschaft und Medizin, sondern auch an der extravertierten Einstellung, in der der Blick des Anderen, der Spiegel, das eigene Aussehen und die Fitness das Interesse an der eigenen Natur bestimmen. Dem gegenüber muss das Leibbewusstsein – so dumpf und unterschwellig es immer vorhanden sein mag – überhaupt erst entdeckt und entwickelt werden.[4]

In der Lebenspraxis müssen die Erfahrungen der eigenen Natur qua Leib und qua Körper jedoch beständig vermittelt werden. Es ist auch keineswegs so, wie noch Helmuth Plessner meinte, dass wir den Leib *sind* und den Körper bloß *haben*. Vielmehr sind wir auch der eigene Körper, insofern wir betroffen sind, wenn ihm etwas geschieht: Der eigene Körper ist nie ganz fremd. Vielmehr ist und bleibt er der *eigene*. Und natürlich müssen wir, sosehr unsere Bewegungen von ›innen‹, also durch leibliches Spüren initiiert und geleitet sind, uns doch in unserer Umgebung *korrekt* qua Körper verhalten: Unsere Bewegungen selbst, auch wenn sie tänzerisch oder gar nur gestisch sind, müssen den Naturgesetzen entsprechen, denen unser Körper unterliegt, also durchaus mechanischen Gesetzen, und, noch elementarer, sie müssen beachten: dass nie zwei verschiedene Körper an demselben Ort sein können. Wenn man das nicht beachten würde, würde man gegen die Wand laufen oder sich stoßen.

So strikt also Körper und Leib epistemologisch unterschieden sind, weil sie in unterschiedlichen Erfahrungsweisen gegeben sind, so müssen doch in der Lebenspraxis beide Erfahrungsweisen beständig miteinander vermittelt werden.

4 Siehe dazu Gernot Böhme, *Leibsein als Aufgabe. Leibphilosophie in pragmatischer Hinsicht*, Zug ²2017.

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3. Liebe

Kehren wir zurück zum Thema *Liebe*. Der Unterschied von Körper und Leib spiegelt sich in der unterschiedlichen Auffassung von Liebe als Sexualität und als leiblicher Liebe und auch im Unterschied der zugeordneten Praxis, also der Weise, wie die Liebe gelebt wird. Wenn wir diesem Unterschied nun nachgehen, müssen wir erwarten, dass auch hier in der Praxis immer auch eine Vermittlung beider Weisen zu lieben stattfindet, wobei aber dem dominanten Selbstverständnis der eigenen Natur qua Körper entsprechend auch eine Dominanz der Sexualität zu erwarten ist: Wie bei der Erfahrung der eigenen Natur als Leib, so muss heute auch ein Verständnis von Liebe als leiblicher erst eingeübt werden.

(a) Sexualität

Liebe als Sexualität wird verstanden als Drang oder Trieb, der auf Befriedigung aus ist. Dieses Verständnis von Liebe ist eine unheilige Allianz mit dem auf die Griechen zurückgehenden Verständnis von Liebe als Eros eingegangen. Es ist Platon, der im *Symposion* durch den Mund des Sokrates den Eros als arm und bedürftig darstellt, nämlich als *Begehren, das Schöne zu haben*.[5] Daraus folgt einerseits eine asymmetrische Beziehung zwischen dem Liebenden und dem oder der Geliebten, wie sie für die klassische Knabenliebe charakteristisch war, und andererseits die Tatsache, dass die Liebe qua Eros zum Erliegen kommt, wenn das Bedürfnis, das darin liegt, erfüllt wird. Ich will die daraus folgende Kritik des Eros hier nicht fortsetzen,[6] sondern den Gedanken wiederaufnehmen, dass Liebe als Sexualität auf einem physischen Drang beruht.

Zunächst: Dieser Drang ist zwar auf die Abreaktion eines inneren Potentials gerichtet, aber das bedeutet nicht, dass er dazu des Anderen oder der Anderen nicht bedarf. Man kennt zwar beim männlichen Geschlecht die nächtliche Pollution und bei beiden Geschlechtern auch die Masturbation. Gleichwohl wird in der Regel der oder die Andere gesucht, wodurch – mit Freud zu spre-

5 Platon, *Symposion*, 205a, b.

6 Siehe aber das entsprechende Kapitel »Liebe« in Gernot Böhme, *Anthropologie in pragmatischer Hinsicht. Darmstädter Vorlesungen* [1985], aktualisierte und erweiterte Neuausgabe mit Nachwort, Bielefeld, Basel 2010, hier bes. S. 94-98.

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chen – eine *Besetzung* stattfindet oder – mit Foucault – das Bedürfnis (*besoin*) in Begehren (*désire*) gewandelt wird.

Selbst wenn es sich nur um mechanische Reizung handelt, was aufgrund des organischen Charakters des Triebes möglich ist, so wird sie als *besser* empfunden, wenn sie der oder die Andere vornimmt. Dafür gibt es ein deutliches Beispiel in Fassbinders Film *Berlin Alexanderplatz.* Noch wichtiger aber ist, dass der sexuelle Trieb, obgleich er ein physischer Drang ist, doch häufig des Anderen bedarf, an dem sich dieser Drang *entflammt*. Das sieht man etwa an der Rolle, die Pinup-Bilder oder auch bloße Phantasiebilder in der Masturbation spielen. Erfahrene Denker und Autoren wie Sokrates in Platons Dialog *Symposion* oder Adam Bernd in seiner eigenen Lebensbeschreibung[7] weisen auf die *Wirklichkeit der Bilder* (Ludwig Klages) hin, nämlich, dass Bilder die Körper zu einer bestimmten Disposition organisieren. Natürlich ist das auch durch Gerüche möglich oder allgemeiner durch die Atmosphäre – durch die Atmosphäre, die ein Mensch ausstrahlt, oder durch die kommunikative Atmosphäre,[8] die sich zwischen Personen aufbaut. Wir haben damit einen Übergang von der Sexualität zur leiblichen Liebe: Bereits in der Körperpraxis, die wir Sexualität nennen, gibt es Ansätze zu einem leiblichen Spüren und damit zu einem Liebesvollzug, in dem die leibliche Anwesenheit des Anderen oder der Anderen eine wesentliche Rolle spielt.

(b) Leibliche Liebe

Wenn wir damit angedeutet haben, dass Sexualität und leibliche Liebe im Konkreten häufig zusammenspielen, so ist es doch nötig, wie die Sexualität auch die leibliche Liebe für sich zu betrachten und als einen besonderen Typ von Liebe herauszuarbeiten. Das Hauptmerkmal im Unterschied zu einer erotisch geprägten Sexualität besteht darin, dass leibliche Liebe nicht eine Liebe der *Annäherung*, sondern der *Nähe* ist. Leibliche Liebe ist der Vollzug und die Steigerung gemeinsamen Daseins der Partner. Daraus folgt bereits, dass sie eine Liebesform ist, die zu pflegen sich besonders für Part-

7 Adam Bernd, *Eigene Lebens-Beschreibung* [1738], München 1973.

8 Siehe das entsprechende Kapitel in Gernot Böhme, *Architektur und Atmosphäre*, Paderborn ²2013.

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ner, die sich schon gefunden haben, also etwa für Eheleute,[9] empfiehlt oder aber auch für ältere Leute, bei denen der sexuelle Drang nachlässt oder keine Rolle mehr spielt. Das heißt aber keineswegs, dass sich diese Liebesform von selbst einstellt, zumal sie als besondere Liebesform in unserer sexualitätsbesessenen Zivilisation kaum bekannt ist und eines eigenen Namens ermangelt. Deshalb beobachten wir in den beiden genannten Situationen, in denen leibliche Liebe eigentlich die richtige Form der Liebe wäre, nämlich in der Ehe und in der Altersbeziehung, ein krampfhaftes Bemühen, die Sexualität *am Laufen* zu halten. Dabei sind Verfremdungs- und Distanzierungsstrategien üblich – bis hin zum Seitensprung, um den Eros in der ehelichen Beziehung wiederzuerwecken, oder Potenzmitteln, um im Alter den *Drang* zu verlebendigen. Bei der leiblichen Liebe dagegen ist Fremdheit nicht ein Anreiz, sondern eher ein Hindernis, denn wir befinden uns alle als zivilisierte erwachsene Menschen durch Umgangsformen, Kleidersitten, ja auch durch den notwendigen personalen Respekt, den wir uns gegenseitig zollen, zueinander in einer habituellen Distanz. Um leibliche Liebe zu ermöglichen, ist es deshalb nötig, mit achtsamem Umgang eine Vertrautheit miteinander zu schaffen und eine Kultur geteilter Intimität zu entwickeln. Dabei kann nun umgekehrt die Libido, kann der sexuelle Eros hilfreich sein. Gerade weil dieser Liebestyp im Drang zur Annäherung besteht, kann er in die Nähe führen. Nur ist die erreichte Nähe nicht wie beim Eros das Erlöschen der Liebe, sondern die Chance der Entwicklung eines ganz anderen Typs von Liebe, nämlich der von mir so genannten *leiblichen Liebe*.

Zärtlichkeit ist das Medium der leiblichen Liebe: Letztere vollzieht sich in der Zärtlichkeit – oder man kann geradezu sagen, sie *ist* Zärtlichkeit. Um das zu verstehen, ist daran zu erinnern, dass das, was wir Leib nennen, uns im leiblichen Spüren gegeben ist. Der Leib ist nichts anderes als das ausgedehnte leibliche Spüren. Deshalb kann man auch mit Hermann Schmitz[10] sagen, dass der Leib

9 Hermann Schmitz hat in seinem Buch *Die Liebe*, Bonn 1993, für die Römer einen gegenüber dem griechischen Eros anderen Liebestyp herausgearbeitet (siehe S. 21-28), der besonderes durch Vertrautheit und durch *fides* gekennzeichnet ist. Das wird freilich anhand von lyrischen Texten demonstriert; die Wirklichkeit mag anders ausgesehen haben. Siehe dazu Philippe Ariès, Georges Duby (Hg.), *Geschichte des privaten Lebens*, Bd. I, Augsburg 1999.

10 Siehe Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*, Bd. I.II: *Der Leib*, Bonn 1967 ff.

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primär als eine Mannigfaltigkeit von Leibesinseln erfahren wird, nämlich der Gegenden, in denen man sich selbst spürt. Es hat sich eingebürgert, diese Gegenden nach dem relativen Ort, an dem sie sich im körperlichen Leib befinden, zu benennen, also etwa nach der Herzgegend, dem Solarplexus, der Brust oder dem Unterbauch usw. (Es gibt hier aber auch eine Beziehung zu den Chakras, nach denen in östlichen Kulturen solche Gegenden benannt werden.)

Durch den zärtlichen Umgang miteinander werden nun Leibesinseln angeregt, das heißt Bereiche, an denen man *sich* spürt. Das betrifft beide Partner, die miteinander zärtlich umgehen. Das heißt, die Zärtlichkeit regt sowohl bei mir, dem Zärtlichen, wie auch beim Partner oder der Partnerin, der oder die zärtlich berührt wird, leibliches Spüren an. Genauer gesagt ist dieses Spüren – zumindest im glücklichen Fall – gar nicht als solches zu unterscheiden, denn nach der Theorie der Leiblichkeit ist ja der Leib selbst nichts anderes als das ausgedehnte Spüren. Und so ist im Vollzug der Zärtlichkeit das Sich-Spüren von dem den-Anderen- oder die-Andere-Spüren gar nicht mehr zu unterscheiden. Es vollzieht sich eine *unio mystica*. Sie besteht für die Partner der Zärtlichkeit in der Erfahrung geteilter leiblicher Präsenz: Ich erfahre mein leibliches Da-sein in und mit der gespürten Präsenz des Anderen.

Es lohnt sich, diese mystische Erfahrung in der Liebe von derjenigen zu unterscheiden, die Georges Bataille als *kleinen Tod* im Orgasmus bezeichnet.[11] Diese Form von mystischer Steigerung wird mit Recht als kleiner Tod bezeichnet, insofern sie nämlich das Hinschwinden des Ego, nämlich der bewussten, durch Autonomie und Verantwortlichkeit bestimmten Ich-Instanz bedeutet.[12] Diese Art von Mystik ist ein Loswerden, ein Sich-Erheben über die menschliche Welt als gesellschaftliche verstanden. Die andere Person, auf die sich der Eros richtete, der zu einer solchen Steigerung führt, spielt dabei keine Rolle. Sie wird auch vergessen oder kommt von Anfang an nicht vor, wenn es sich um einen Orgasmus handelt, der durch Masturbation herbeigeführt wird. Ganz anders bei der leiblichen Liebe: Hier ist die *unio mystica* tatsächlich eine Vereinigung mit dem Anderen im leiblichen Spüren. Sie ist deshalb auch kein Sich-Erheben über das Menschliche, sondern vielmehr ein Herabsteigen

11 Siehe Georges Bataille, *Der Heilige Eros*, Frankfurt/M. 1979.

12 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Ich-Selbst. Über die Formation des Subjekts*, Paderborn 2012.

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und Sich-Einlassen auf das Menschliche, nämlich auf die leibliche Existenz: Wir sind uns im leiblichen Spüren selbst gegeben.

Hier ist wohl der Ort, an dem an die Liebe von Mutter und Kind als einer ursprünglichen Liebesform zu erinnern ist. Wenn wir von der Liebe zwischen Erwachsenen reden, so ist die wechselseitige personale Fremdheit immer die Voraussetzung, von der wir ausgehen müssen. Auch die Praxis der leiblichen Liebe setzt diese Fremdheit voraus. Dabei dürfen wir aber nicht vergessen, dass die Einheitserfahrung, die im leiblichen Umgang durch Zärtlichkeit erreicht werden kann, auch eine Art Erinnerung ist, nämlich an die primordiale Erfahrung der Einheit mit der Mutter, die in der Tiefe des eigenen leiblichen Spürens noch dämmert. Man hat deshalb nicht zu Unrecht in der Liebe auch immer wieder die Sehnsucht nach der Rückkehr zu dieser ursprünglichen Einheit gesehen. Freilich trifft diese Deutung nur auf die leibliche Liebe zu, nicht auf die erotische, die ja nach Platons klarer Definition ein *Habenwollen*[13] ist. Einsseinwollen und Habenwollen sind nicht dasselbe.

Wenn wir vom zärtlichen Umgang miteinander geredet haben, der zum geteilten leiblichen Spüren führt, so wird sich dabei der Gedanke an die Zärtlichkeit der Hand nahegelegt haben. Doch das Gesagte trifft vielmehr auf zärtliche Berührungen zu, etwa durch die Brust, den Bauch, die Beine. Denn das Spüren mit der Hand hat, wie der Sinn des Auges, eine Tendenz zur Objektivierung. Das liegt natürlich daran, dass wir unsere Hände vornehmlich als Organe des Entdeckens und der Arbeit benutzen und also auch in diese Funktionen eingeübt haben. Das Spüren mit der Hand ist deshalb in der Regel auch intentional, das heißt, es hat einen Gegenstand. Deshalb konnte auch Husserl in seinem berühmten, oben bereits erwähnten Zwei-Hände-Experiment[14] den Unterschied zwischen Empfindungen und Empfindnissen einführen: Wenn die rechte Hand die linke berührt, dann hat die rechte Hand Empfindungen – nämlich von der linken Hand, während die linke Hand als berührte *sich* spürt, und dieses Sich-Spüren nannte Husserl seinerzeit *Empfindnis*.

Diese Besonderheit des Spürens mit der Hand gibt mir nun Anlass, noch eine zweite Form der Erfüllung in leiblicher Liebe durch

13 Platon, *Symposion*, hier besonders 206a.

14 Edmund Husserl, *Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und phänomenologischen Philosophie II*, Den Haag 1952, S. 145 f.

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Zärtlichkeit zu benennen, die zu der Möglichkeit der *unio mystica* hinzutritt oder manchmal auch in ihr enthalten ist, nämlich die *Entzückung*. Die spürende Hand ist so etwas wie das entdeckende Auge. Aber ihr Spüren ist eben gerade doch kein Sehen, das Sichtbares in seiner Sichtbarkeit aktualisiert, sondern eben ein Spüren, das dem oder der Anderen in seiner oder ihrer leiblichen Existenz nachspürt. Dabei wird die Samtigkeit der Haut, das Blühen und das Schwellen des oder der Anderen in ihrer leiblichen Existenz ent-deckt. Der Dichter Gottfried Benn, der als Arzt für Haut- und Geschlechtskrankheiten natürlich einer Sicht der Liebe als Sexualität besonders nahestand, bezeichnete diese einmal als »Anpeilung von Schwellkörpern«.[15] Das ist ganz böse gesagt. Doch was die spürende Hand im zärtlichen Mitgehen mit den Formen des Anderen entdeckt, ist dessen drängende, quasi knospende Lebendigkeit – oder seine Natur. Hier ist es aber besser, den griechischen Ausdruck *Physis* zu nehmen, weil dieser ja eher Aufgehen und Aufblühen benennt. Und dieses Spüren des oder der Anderen in ihrer Lebendigkeit, das ist das *Entzücken*. Es ist eine tiefe, aber auch leichte und jubelnde Teilnahme am leiblichen Dasein des Anderen. Immanuel Kant hat *Lust*[16] als die Ursache, in dem Zustand, in dem man sich befindet, verweilen zu wollen, definiert.[17] In diesem Sinne kann man die Freude am Dasein des Anderen, die im zärtlichen Zusammensein gespürt werden kann, auch als Lust bezeichnen. Ob aber Lust als befriedetes Verweilen in einem Zustand angesehen werden kann, dürfte zweifelhaft sein, wenn man an die quasi nietzscheanische Erfahrung denkt: Lust will mehr Lust. Aus diesem Grunde wollen wir den Ausdruck Lust mehr für die sexuelle beziehungsweise die erotische Liebe reservieren, die ja, solange sie währt, auf Steigerung aus ist – und dann mit der Erfüllung in sich zusammenbricht. Auch das Einander-Spüren in der leiblichen Liebe ist ein

15 Gottfried Benn, »Pallas«, in Ders., *Gesammelte Werke in vier Bänden*, hg. v. Dieter Wellershoff, Bd. 1, Wiesbaden 1965, S. 365.

16 Siehe Immanuel Kant, *Kritik der Urteilskraft*, in: Ders., *Werke in sechs Bänden*, hg. v. Wilhelm Weischedel, Darmstadt 1957, Bd. V, § 10, S. 299.

17 Siehe dazu auch Fausts berühmte Formel, mit der er sich dem Teufel verschreibt: »Werd' ich zum Augenblicke sagen: / Verweile doch! du bist so schön!« (1699 f.); Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Sämtliche Werke, Briefe, Tagebücher und Gespräche*, Frankfurter Ausgabe [FA] in 40 Bd., hg. v. Friedmar Apel u. a., Frankfurt/M., Berlin 1987-2013, I. Abt., Bd. 7.1: *Faust. Texte*, hg. v. Albrecht Schöne, Frankfurt/M. 1994, S. 76.

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Zustand gesteigerter Existenz, die aber nicht über sich hinauslangt, sondern selbst die Erfüllung ist. Deshalb möchte ich hier lieber von Freude sprechen. Es ist die Freude am eigenen leiblichen Dasein wie dem leiblichen Dasein des oder der Anderen, die Freude an der geteilten leiblichen Existenz. Tatsächlich ist diese Freude auch als solche spürbar, und zwar gerade nicht wie die sexuelle Lust an oder in den Genitalien, sondern im Herzen. Das Herz ist ja von Aristoteles erstaunlicherweise als das Organ des Spürens, nämlich der ἁφή (*haphé*), bezeichnet worden.[18] Und so wird die Erfüllung der leiblichen Liebe auch letztlich im Herzen empfunden.

18 Aristoteles, *De vita et morte*, 469a 18-23.

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Der leibliche Raum

Das Raumdenken ist in der europäischen Philosophie wesentlich durch zwei Paradigma bestimmt, nämlich einerseits durch den Begriff des *topos* bei Aristoteles – also des Ortes – und andererseits durch den Begriff des *spatium* bei Descartes – also des Abstandes. Dem kartesischen Raumbegriff entspricht mathematisch die euklidische Geometrie, die nach Descartes durch Einführung des Koordinatensystems zur analytischen Geometrie fortentwickelt wurde. Dagegen ist die mathematische Disziplin der Topologie nicht eigentlich als eine Entfaltung des aristotelischen Begriffs des *topos* anzusehen, denn nach Aristoteles ist der Ort definiert durch die Oberfläche der umgebenden Körper.[1] Freilich wird bei Aristoteles die Definition von etwas durch Angabe der Form, die eine Materie bestimmt, angegeben. Die Materie des Ortes nach Aristoteles wäre das *Dazwischen* beziehungsweise das Kontiniuum (*syneches*[2]). So gesehen ist der Ausdruck *topos* als Raumbegriff also doch ein Vorläufer der mathematischen Disziplin der Topologie, denn als Topologie kann man die Ordnung in einer Mannigfaltigkeit bezeichnen, die nur Nachbarschaftsbeziehungen, also zum Beispiel A liegt zwischen B und C, und Beziehungen von innen und außen kennt, wie etwa A liegt innerhalb oder außerhalb der Punktmannigfaltigkeit b. Entscheidend als Hintergrund für den gleich einzuführenden Begriff des leiblichen Raums ist, dass beide Traditionen des Raumbegriffs, also *topos* und *spatium*, den Raum als etwas Objektives behandeln, also als etwas, das quasi *außerhalb* oder zumindest unabhängig vom menschlichen Erleben da ist.

Freilich wird vielfach auch der objektive Raum vom Erlebnis des Darinnen-Seins her verstanden. Charakteristisch dafür ist eine Formulierung in Kants *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, und zwar bei der metaphysischen Erörterung des Raumbegriffs. Dort lesen wir: »Denn damit gewisse Empfindungen auf etwas außer mich bezogen werden (d. i. auf etwas in einem anderen Orte des Raumes,

1 Aristoteles, *Physik*, 2012a6.

2 Siehe Gernot Böhme, »Kontinuität als Phänomen in der Philosophie des Aristoteles«, in: Jan Beaufort, Peter Prechtl (Hg.), *Rationalität und Prärationalität. Festschrift für Alfred Schöpf*, Würzburg 1998, S. 77-45.

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als darinnen ich mich befinde), imgleichen damit ich sie als außer *und neben* einander, mithin nicht bloß verschieden, sondern als in verschiedenen Orten vorstellen könne, dazu muß die Vorstellung des Raumes schon zum Grunde liegen.«[3] Obgleich Kant den Raum als *Form der Anschauung* darlegen will, rekurriert er hier auf das lebensweltliche Vorverständnis von *Darinnen-Sein.* Um hier eine begriffliche Ordnung zu schaffen, gilt es, zwischen dem Raum als Medium von Darstellungen und dem Raum als Form lebendiger Existenz zu unterscheiden.[4] Der Unterschied ist einer zwischen Vorstellen und Sein: Der Raum als *Vorstellung* beziehungsweise Form unserer Vorstellungen besteht darin, dass wir – nach Kant – uns gegebenes Mannigfaltiges als nebeneinander vorstellen. Davon ist zu unterscheiden: der Raum als *Seinsmodus*, als Weise des Inseins – wie Heidegger sagen würde –, eben als Form lebendiger Existenz. In diesem letzteren Sinne ist der Raum als eine Form der *Befindlichkeit* gegeben, also als Form, in der wir unser Da-sein spüren: Dies ist der leibliche Raum.

Der Begriff des leiblichen Raums ist in der Neuen Phänomenologie, das heißt im Wesentlichen in der Phänomenologie von Hermann Schmitz, entwickelt worden.[5] Als seine Vorläufer sind Graf Dürckheim, Otto Friedrich Bollnow und Elisabeth Ströker zu nennen.[6] Dabei zeichnet sich Schmitz' Einführung des Begriffs *leiblicher Raum* dadurch aus, dass er im Unterschied zu seinen Vorläufern eine diffuse Vermengung dieses Phänomens mit Vorstellungen vom objektiven beziehungsweise mathematischen Raum vermeidet. Denn wenn man statt vom leiblichen Raum vom erlebten oder gelebten Raum (Graf Dürckheim, Bollnow) spricht

3 Immanuel Kant, *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, in: Ders., *Werke in sechs Bänden*, hg. v. Wilhelm Weischedel, Darmstadt 1956, Bd. II, § 10, A 23/B 38, S. 72.

4 Siehe Gernot Böhme, »Der Raum leiblicher Anwesenheit und der Raum als Medium von Darstellung«, in: Sybille Krämer (Hg.), *Performativität und Medialität*, München 2004, S. 129-140.

5 Siehe Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*, Bd. III.1: *Der leibliche Raum*, Bonn 1967.

6 Siehe Graf Karlfried von Dürckheim, »Untersuchungen zum gelebten Raum. Erlebniswirklichkeit und ihr Verständnis«, in: Felix Krüger (Hg.), *Neue psychologische Studien*, Bd. 6, 4. Heft, München 1932, S. 383-480; Otto Friedrich Bollnow, *Mensch und Raum*, Stuttgart ^{9}2000; Elisabeth Ströker, *Philosophische Untersuchungen zum Raum*, Frankfurt/M. ^{2}1977.

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oder wie Minkowski vom *espace vécu*,[7] so wird dabei der objektive Raum vorausgesetzt – wie beispielsweise Bollnow mit dem Begriff des *erlebten Raumes*: Wenn etwas erlebt wird, ist das, was erlebt wird, schon vorausgesetzt. Andererseits versuchen merkwürdigerweise die genannten Autoren umgekehrt – quasi in Husserl'scher Manier – den Begriff des objektiven Raums in dem des leiblichen Raums fundiert zu sehen. Dieser Fundierungsabsicht folgt schließlich auch Schmitz.

Der leibliche Raum ist nach Hermann Schmitz quasi ein Produkt der sogenannten leiblichen Ökonomie. Diese besteht in den gespürten Tonusverhältnissen im Leib, nämlich der Beziehung von Engung und Weitung. Diese Beziehung kann sich je nach dem einen oder nach dem anderen Pol hin entwickeln, nämlich in Richtung Enge als Spannung und in Richtung Weite als Schwellung. Der Raum ist zunächst die Weite, in der der eigene Leib gespürt wird. Dabei kann das leibliche Spüren qua Weitung die Grenzen des körperlichen Leibes – also die Haut – überschreiten und als *privative Weitung* – also bei Schwinden der Engungstendenz – quasi ins Unendliche ausgreifen. Auf diesem Wege entsteht unter anderem das schon bei Descartes bekannte Phänomen, dass etwas ins leibliche Spüren einbezogen werden kann – der Blinde spürt den Kiesel, nach dem er tastet, am Ende des Stockes, nicht an seinen Fingern –, was man *embodiment* nennen könnte, aber bei Schmitz eine Form der leiblichen Kommunikation ist.

Der leibliche Raum ist danach nicht der objektive Raum, der subjektiv erlebt wird. Vielmehr wird der leibliche Raum von der Weitungstendenz leiblichen Spürens *aufgespannt*. Das festzuhalten, ist äußerst wichtig, weil nicht-dingliche und nicht-metrische Räume wie etwa der akustische Raum sich dann als Modifikationen leiblichen Spürens in die Weite verstehen lassen.

Nach dieser Einführung des leiblichen Raums können strukturelle Merkmale festgehalten werden, durch die sich der leibliche Raum deutlich vom objektiven beziehungsweise mathematischen Raum der Geometrie unterscheidet:

– Der geometrische Raum ist homogen, das heißt, alle Punkte in diesem Raum sind gleichberechtigt. Dagegen gibt es im Raum

7 Siehe Eugène Minkowski, *Le Temps vécu, etudes phénoménologiques et psychopathologiques*, Paris 1933.

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leiblichen Spürens einen ausgezeichneten Ort, nämlich das Zentrum des *hier bin ich.* Er ist – im Gegensatz zur Weitung – durch die radikale Engung wie beispielsweise in Angst und Schmerz gegeben. Das *Hier* ist – wie Hermann Schmitz sagt – ein absoluter Ort. Während sonst Orte durch Abstände von Gegenständen angegeben werden beziehungsweise allgemeiner durch Koordinaten, wird im *Hier* ein Ort durch leibliches Spüren absolut gegeben.

– Der mathematische Raum der Geometrie ist isotrop, das heißt, keine Richtung in diesem Raum ist ausgezeichnet. Dagegen ist der leibliche Raum anisotrop, das heißt, im leiblichen Spüren in die Weite kennen wir den Unterschied von Oben und Unten, von Vorne und Hinten und Rechts und Links. Diese Richtungen sind im leiblichen Spüren gegebene Bewegungstendenzen.

– Schließlich ist im objektiven oder metrischen Raum die Beziehung einer Mannigfaltigkeit im Raum durch das Nebeneinander gegeben. Der leibliche Raum dagegen ist meine Form des Inseins und damit die Ausdehnung meiner leiblichen Anwesenheit. Soweit in der Sphäre meiner leiblichen Anwesenheit auch andere Menschen oder Dinge auftauchen, so ist deren Erfahrung nicht die Erfahrung eines Nebeneinanders, sondern eines Seins-bei… beziehungsweise ein geteiltes Miteinander, ein Zusammensein.

Damit haben wir, obgleich die genannten Charakteristika zur Unterscheidung des leiblichen Raums vom objektiven oder mathematischen Raum möglichst formal gehalten waren, doch zugleich angedeutet, dass der leibliche Raum jeweils *mein* Raum ist, dass ich in diesen Raum *involviert* bin. Wie oben bereits erwähnt, ist der Begriff *leiblicher Raum* deshalb im Sinne von Søren Kierkegaard ein Existenzbegriff, das heißt ein Begriff von etwas, das mich angeht. In diesem Sinne ist der leibliche Raum von der Art, dass jede Modifikation in affektiver Betroffenheit gespürt wird. Im leiblichen Spüren kann beispielsweise der Raum als bedrückend oder erhebend, als heiter oder als melancholisch, als hell oder dunkel erlebt werden – wir betreten das Feld der *Atmosphäre.*[8] Aus diesem Grunde kann über den Charakter des gespürten Raums beziehungsweise die Sachverhalte im leiblichen Raum nur derjenige Auskunft geben, der davon betroffen ist. Die Philosophy of Mind stellt deshalb fest, dass hier nur Aussagen in der ers-

8 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Atmosphäre. Essays zur Neuen Ästhetik*, Berlin ⁷2013.

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ten Person möglich sind; Hermann Schmitz redet von *subjektiven Sachverhalten*.

Entsprechend den drei Charakteristika des leiblichen Raums, nämlich dass er:

– ein Richtungsraum ist, der sich als gefühlter Raum nach meinen Bewegungstendenzen richtet,

– ein anisotroper Raum ist, durch meine leibliche Gegenwart zentriert,

– ein Raum des Zusammen- oder Beieinanderseins ist, der Raum der leiblichen Kommunikation meines Seins-bei …, ist er

– die *sphaera activitatis*, der *Handlungsraum*,

– der *Raum meiner leiblichen Anwesenheit*,

– der *Wahrnehmungsraum*.

Der leibliche Raum ist also erstens meine *sphaera activitatis,* das heißt der Spielraum für meine Handlungen und Bewegungsmöglichkeiten. Dabei wird dieser Raum durch das Ausgreifen meiner selbst auf Bewegungsziele hin, auf zu behandelnde Objekte oder Personen hin, nach Richtungen und Intentionen artikuliert. Dieses Ausgreifen stößt aber an Grenzen, an Wände und Gegenstände. Dadurch wird das leibliche Spüren des Raums durch die Gegebenheiten im objektiven Raum, insbesondere durch die Dinge determiniert. Auf diese Konfrontation ist weiter unten zurückzukommen.

Der Raum meiner leiblichen Anwesenheit wird zweitens durch das *Wie* meiner Befindlichkeit gespürt, beziehungsweise er ist die Ausdehnung meiner Befindlichkeiten selbst. Das kann sehr wohl bedeuten, dass eine innere Stimmung meine Erfahrung des Raums, in dem ich mich befinde, quasi einfärbt, also mir etwa die Welt als trüb oder heiter erscheinen lässt. Man spricht deshalb hier auch vom *gestimmten Raum* oder allgemeiner von der Atmosphäre, die ich spüre. Das heißt aber keineswegs, dass diese affektive Tönung des leiblichen Raums immer eine *projizierte* sein muss. Vielmehr wird sie sogar in der Regel erfahren als etwas, das mir entgegenkommt, das mich *anweht.* Das leibliche Hinausspüren ins Offene wird in der Regel durch die Gegebenheiten modifiziert, auf die dieses Hinausspüren trifft. Man spricht hier von den Erzeugern von Atmosphären. Das sind objektive Gegebenheiten, die dem gespürten Raum, dann Atmosphäre genannt, einen bestimmten Charakter verleihen, wie bedrückend oder erhebend, trüb oder heiter,

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gemütlich oder unbehaglich. Insofern kann man sagen, dass wir in unserer Befindlichkeit spüren, in welcher Art Raum (hier ist der objektive Raum gemeint) wir uns befinden.[9]

Der leibliche Raum ist schließlich der Raum des Seins-bei…, etwa des Seins bei den Dingen und den anderen Menschen. Da die Wahrnehmung die primäre Weise des Seins bei etwas ist, können wir den leiblichen Raum in dieser Hinsicht auch als den Wahrnehmungsraum bezeichnen. Wenn wir Wahrnehmung als Sein-bei… bestimmen, so ist wiederum das bereits von Descartes bekannte Beispiel des Blinden, der mit einem Stock nach einem Stein tastet, heranzuziehen. Dieses Beispiel verallgemeinernd kann man sagen, dass wir *bei* den Dingen sind, die wir sehen. Unser leibliches Spüren ihrer Anwesenheit vollzieht sich nicht im Auge, sondern dort, wo die Dinge sind. Sehen als Spüren der leiblichen Anwesenheit von Dingen (oder auch von anderen Menschen) – das klingt zunächst überraschend. Tatsächlich hat aber Hermann Schmitz mit guten Gründen das Sehen auch als eine leibliche Kommunikation – eben mit dem Gesehenen – bestimmt.[10] Das Sehen eines Dinges ist eben nicht einfach das konstatierende Gewahren eines Dinges an einem Ort. Vielmehr greift das Gesehene in meine leibliche Ökonomie ein. Das ist natürlich mehr oder weniger der Fall, aber das Verfolgen eines fliegenden Tennisballs oder das Bemerken eines heranfahrenden Autos bringt in mein Hinausspüren einen Konzentrationspunkt *da draußen*, der mich in meinem Hinblicken *fesselt.*

Es ist der leibliche Raum, um den es geht, wenn man nach der Räumlichkeit von Musik, von Tönen, von Schall und Geräuschen im Allgemeinen fragt. Man kann sogar behaupten, der akustische Raum *ist* der leibliche Raum.

Freilich gibt es auch eine Beziehung von akustischen Phänomenen und dem physischen Raum. Es geht hier um das, was man landläufig und im engeren Sinne *Akustik* nennt als einer architektonischen und bautechnischen Disziplin der Gestaltung von Innenräumen, um eine hohe Tonqualität zu erreichen. Darum geht es auch bei der Gestaltung von Studios zum Zweck von Tonaufnahmen: Es geht um die Echoqualität der Räume und um die

9 Siehe Gernot Böhme, *Für eine ökologische Naturästhetik*, Frankfurt/M. ^{3}1999. Siehe auch das Kapitel »Umweltästhetik« in diesem Band.

10 Siehe Hermann Schmitz, *System der Philosophie*, Bd. V.3: *Die Wahrnehmung*, Bonn 1978.

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Nachhalldauer von Ton in diesen Räumen. Durch die physische Gestaltung der Wände bleiben akustische Phänomene als Schwingungsvorgänge der Luft für eine mehr oder weniger lange Weile *im Raum* erhalten. Dieses Phänomen kann man in den sogenannten echolosen Räumen zum Zweck von Tonaufnahmen oder zu experimentellen Zwecken praktisch auf null herunterdrücken. Man bezeichnet in diesem Zusammenhang also als *Akustik* die Kunst, durch Gestaltung der Oberflächen eines Raums die Aufführung von Musik in diesem Raum in bester Qualität vollziehen zu können. Das kann so weit gehen, dass diese Oberflächen, wie etwa im Kultur und Kongresszentrum Luzern, je nach Musikstück verändert werden können. Das Umgekehrte dagegen ist selten: nämlich dass ein Komponist ein Stück für einen bestimmten existierenden Raum eigens gestaltet.[11] Das alles betrifft die Beziehung von physischem Raum und akustischen Phänomenen als Schwingungszuständen in diesem Raum. Ein anderes Thema ist dagegen die Beziehung von Raum und *gehörtem* Ton: Der Raum, um den es in diesem Zusammenhang geht, ist der leibliche Raum.

Das Grundphänomen, das man als den Beweis für diesen Unterschied anführen muss, ist die Tatsache, dass man, mit Kopfhörern hörend, das jeweilige Geräusch *räumlich* hört, obgleich es ja im physischen Raum nicht stattfindet. Vielleicht würde man oder wird man erst durch diese Tatsache darauf aufmerksam, dass Töne als solche eine räumliche Qualität haben, nämlich als Strukturierung des leiblichen Raums. Dem wollen wir uns jetzt zuwenden. Ein Geräusch oder ein Ton *füllt* den Raum, in dem man sich befindet, und gibt ihm eine gewisse emotionale Qualität, man kann auch sagen, er *tingiert* den Raum. Es handelt sich hier in jedem Fall um den Raum, in dem man sich befindet, den gefühlten Raum. Ein Ton oder Geräusche in diesem Raum machen diesen mehr oder weniger dicht oder, wenn es sich um eine Geräuschmannigfaltigkeit handelt, *löchrig* oder gebrochen. Wenn diese Töne oder Geräusche von einer erzeugenden Quelle ausgehen, so macht sich diese Quelle durch die akustische Füllung des Raums bemerkbar. Diese spürbare Anwesenheit im Raum kann man auch selbst als Quelle erzeugen, indem man etwa singt oder spricht. Der Philo-

11 Siehe Gernot Böhme, »Atmosphären: die Beziehung von Musik und Architektur jenseits physikalischer Vorstellungen«, in: Christoph Metzger (Hg.), *Musik und Architektur*, Saarbrücken 2003, S. 98-103.

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soph Jakob Böhme hat deshalb Ton neben Geruch als eine Weise aufgeführt, durch die etwas anwesend ist.

Als weiteres Phänomen räumlicher Qualität von Tönen und Geräuschen hatte ich bereits erwähnt, dass sie den Raum *tingieren*. Damit erweist sich die Räumlichkeit von akustischen Phänomenen als ein Beispiel der Erzeugung von Atmosphären.[12] Atmosphären sind Räume mit einer Stimmung, und Töne und Geräusche sind eine Gattung der Erzeugenden von Atmosphären – neben etwa Licht und den Bewegungssuggestionen, die von Dingen ausgehen. Man setzt deshalb auch Töne und Geräusche neben Licht, Gegenständen und Symbolen in der Kunst des Bühnenbildes ein, um auf der Bühne eine bestimmte Atmosphäre zu inszenieren. Das Besondere der Gestaltung von Atmosphären durch Musik und Geräusche ist, dass sie den gefühlten Raum unmittelbar artikulieren. Das dürfte auch die Grundlage sein, von der her man die emotionale Bedeutung von Musik verstehen kann.

Neben der Formierung des leiblichen Raums im Ganzen haben nun aber auch gehörte Töne und Geräusche selbst räumliche Qualitäten. So können sie beispielsweise durch den Raum wandern, oder aber sie haben selbst räumliche Gestalt. Beispielsweise sind sie etwa spitz und scharf oder breit lagernd. Die alten Griechen haben in ihrer Musiktheorie diese räumlichen Qualitäten von Tönen auch benutzt, um Unterschiede, die wir als *hoch* und *tief* bezeichnen, zu artikulieren: Sie nannten die hohen Töne *oxys*, das heißt scharf, und die tiefen Töne *barys*, das heißt breit gelagert. Für uns dagegen sind die räumlichen Qualitäten von akustischen Phänomenen eigentlich erst wieder durch die modernen elektronischen Aufnahme- und Wiedergabetechniken deutlich geworden. Das hat zur Folge gehabt, dass man in der neuen Musik, und speziell in dem Bereich der *sound art*, sich eigens um diese räumlichen Qualitäten von Tönen kümmert. Diese Musik besteht also nicht mehr nur wie die große klassische Musik in der Gestaltung von Harmonien und zeitlichen Sequenzen, sondern auch oder vielleicht sogar besonders in der Gestaltung der Räumlichkeit von akustischen Phänomenen.

Einen starken Impuls hat diese Entwicklung erhalten durch die sogenannte *Soundscape*-Bewegung. Es war Murray Schafer, der in den 1970er Jahren anfing, durch Tonaufnahmen akustische Land-

12 Siehe Böhme, *Atmosphäre*.

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schaften wie etwa das Hafengebiet von Vancouver zu dokumentieren. Das war in gewisser Weise die Entdeckung einer eigenen Welt, freilich der Welt, in der wir schon immer gelebt haben. Genauer gesagt ging es um die Entdeckung, dass unser leiblicher Raum, der gefühlte Raum, durch die akustischen Phänomene der Umwelt, in der wir uns befinden, immer schon geprägt ist.[13] Da die akustische Landschaft, in der wir uns befinden, sich historisch relativ stark verändert, haben die Produkte der Recherchen von Murray Schafer und seinen Mitarbeitern einerseits inzwischen den Charakter eines Archivs angenommen. Andererseits haben die Mitarbeiter des *Soundscape*-Projekts relativ bald angefangen, mit ihrem aufgenommenen Material zu komponieren, schon allein deshalb, weil sich für die Wiedergabe der dokumentierten akustischen Umwelt die 1:1-Reproduktion von Aufnahmen, sagen wir von 24 Stunden, nicht eignete. Um das Charakteristische einer akustischen Landschaft mitzuteilen, kam es darauf an, aus der sogenannten Tonalität, also den bleibenden Grundgeräuschen einer Gegend und den besonderen akustischen Ereignissen, so etwas wie ein Musikstück zu machen.

Das ist eine Quelle, wenn auch nicht die einzige, für die besondere musikalische Disziplin der *sound art*. In ihr geht es explizit um die akustische Gestalt von Räumen – freilich, das muss wieder betont werden, von Räumen, in denen wir uns als hörende Teilnehmer befinden. In gewisser Weise hat Musik in ihren Aufführungen immer schon Räume gestaltet, nur ist dabei die akustische Gestaltung des gefühlten Raums eher ein Nebenprodukt gewesen. Die musikalische Disziplin der *sound art* macht das dagegen eigens zu ihrem Thema. Sie gestaltet durch Installationen Räume und Orte so, dass sie als Räume gespürter Anwesenheit in bestimmter Weise wahrgenommen werden. Das kann durchaus so geschehen, dass akustische Phänomene, die ohnehin in den jeweiligen Umgebungen vorhanden sind, für die Besucher – etwa durch Resonanzrohre – eigens hervorgehoben werden und damit erst explizit hörbar werden, oder aber auch durch Erzeugung von akustischen Phänomenen mit besonderen Bewegungen und figürlicher Qualität durch im Raum verteilte Tonquellen. Schließlich kann – und das ist vielleicht sogar das älteste Beispiel von *sound art* – physisches Geschehen in der Um-

13 Siehe dazu meinen Aufsatz zu *Soundscape*: »Atmosphären. Ein Beitrag zur ökologischen Ästhetik«, in: Institut für neue Musik, Darmstadt (Hg.), *Klang und Wahrnehmung. Komponist – Interpret – Hörer*, Mainz 2001, S. 38-48.

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gebung durch bestimmte Installationen überhaupt erst hörbar werden. Dazu gehören etwa die Äolsharfen und die Windpfeifen. Aber auch strömendes Wasser kann man zum *Klingen* bringen.[14] Zusammenfassend kann man sagen, dass die junge Disziplin der *sound art* sich durch akustische Modifikation und Artikulation des gefühlten Raums zu einer selbständigen Gattung der Musik entwickelt hat.

Zum Schluss dieses Kapitels ist noch einmal auf die Versuche zurückzukommen, die die Mehrzahl der Philosophen unternehmen, die sich mit dem leiblichen Raum beschäftigen, nämlich den leiblichen Raum und den Raum der Geometrie in ein Fundierungsverhältnis zu bringen: Man versucht zu zeigen, dass man durch eine bestimmte Modifikation des leiblichen Raums zum metrischen Raum übergeht. Ich verfolge hier nicht diese Linie, weil der leibliche Raum und der geometrische Raum auf verschiedenen kategorialen Ebenen liegen: nämlich auf der Ebene des Seins und der Ebene des Vorstellens. Gleichwohl sind diese Versuche interessant und zumindest in einigen Schritten plausibel.

So charakterisiert zum Beispiel Hermann Schmitz den leiblichen Raum im Unterschied zum metrischen Raum als einen Raum, der *flächenlos*[15] ist. Diese Beobachtung ist zwar richtig und trifft bei vielen Beispielen für leiblichen Raum zu, zum Beispiel dem akustischen Raum oder auch schon dem einfachen Weiteraum. Schmitz führt den Begriff der Flächenlosigkeit auch keineswegs als Charakterisierung des leiblichen Raums ein, sondern lediglich als ersten Schritt des Übergangs vom leiblichen Raum zum metrischen Raum. Nun muss zunächst festgehalten werden, dass auch der leibliche Raum nicht generell flächenlos ist. Nach Schmitz wird der Leib im leiblichen Spüren als Mannigfaltigkeit von Leibesinseln gegeben. Leibesinseln sind opake Volumina, die durch die jeweiligen Verhältnisse von Spannung und Schwellung spürbar gegeben sind. Nur, und das ist einer der wesentlichen Beiträge, die durch die geschlechtsbezogene Leibphänomenologie von Ute Gahlings[16]

14 Als ein Beispiel sei hier aus dem Werk von Sam Auinger die Strömungsharfe im Rhein bei Bonn genannt, siehe ⟨http://rheinau.hearingview.info/video.html⟩, letzter Zugriff 9. 8. 2018.

15 Siehe Hermann Schmitz, *Jenseits des Naturalismus*, Freiburg 2010, S. 139-144; Ders., *Gibt es die Welt?*, Freiburg 2014, S. 80-82.

16 Siehe Ute Gahlings, *Phänomenologie der weiblichen Leiberfahrungen*, Freiburg

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eingeführt wurde, ist der Leib auch durchaus durch eine Mannigfaltigkeit von Hohlräumen gegeben. Es mag kein Zufall sein, dass diese Entdeckung spürbarer Leibeshöhlungen von einer Frau gemacht wurde. Denn die Erfahrung des Leibes als Hohlraum ist in der weiblichen Sexualität wie in der Schwangerschaft selbstverständlich. Aber auch der Mann wird entsprechende Erfahrungen von seinem Leib als Mannigfaltigkeit von Hohlräumen, etwa in Bezug auf Mund und Rachenraum, machen. Entscheidend ist nun, dass das Spüren leiblicher Hohlräume durch das Spüren der sie umgebenden Oberflächen gegeben ist – geradezu im Sinne des aristotelischen Toposbegriffs. Das Spüren dieser inneren Oberflächen mag durch etwas Berührendes, zum Beispiel durch die Luft beim Atmen, angeregt werden. Es kann auch sein, dass das Spüren leiblicher Hohlräume als Hohlräume für etwas erfahren wird. Entscheidend ist aber, dass man – gegen Schmitz – konstatieren muss: Es gibt ein leibliches Spüren von Flächen.

Für Schmitz nun ist die Erfahrung von Flächen im leiblichen Raum etwas Überraschendes, geradezu ein Geschenk,[17] das nicht dem leiblichen Spüren entstammt. Von da aus will er dann durch das Sich-Schneiden von Flächen zur Linie kommen und dann von der geraden Linie zum Abstand. Das ist ein plausibler Weg – er kehrt gewissermaßen den euklidischen Aufbau der Geometrie um: Dieser geht vom Punkt aus zur Linie, zur Fläche, zum Körper. Es muss jedoch festgestellt werden, dass das leibliche Spüren auch anderweitig auf Nichtleibliches stößt, nämlich auf die Dinge. Von dieser Erfahrung her kann man dann ebenfalls durch Bewegung eines starren Dinges – dann als Maßstab genommen – in den leiblich gespürten Raum eine Metrik einziehen. Was man da *draußen* spürt, erhält dadurch einen Ort, der durch die Abstände zu anderen Dingen und in seiner Entfernung von mir, dem Wahrnehmenden qua Körperding, bestimmt ist. Man sieht daraus, dass der metrische Ort von etwas durch Abstand von mir qua Ding bestimmt werden kann.

[2]2016, S. 182, 190, 226. Siehe dazu auch das Kapitel »Der Begriff des Leibes« in diesem Band.

17 Siehe Hermann Schmitz, *Phänomenologie der Zeit*, Freiburg 2014, S. 81: »Das Geschenk der leibfremden Fläche ist ein großer Gewinn für die personale Emanzipation […] des Menschen.«